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Effective Business Communications

7TH EDITION

HERTA A. MURPHY

HERBERT W. HILDEBRANDT

JANE P. THOMAS

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WITHDRAWN

Effective Business Communications

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7TH EDITION

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To my husband, Gene,
with love and remembrance
—H. M.

To my wife, Dee
—H. H.

To my husband, Hugh
—J. T.

Preface

Pick up any newspaper, read scholarly research studies, look at personnel want ads; invariably the term *communication* is used. Thus this seventh edition continues the main thrust of the past six editions: Managers and executives—indeed, all employees of organizations—must possess excellence in written and oral communication. Our term for communication in the business world is *business communication;* that is, we are concerned with the movement of ideas via either the written or oral word, in both for-profit or nonprofit organizations.

This book seeks to develop communication skills needed by those preparing for, or who are already in, a business or management position. The seventh edition strengthens the research orientation and solid academic base of the previous editions. This fact, along with the authors' combined total of more than 75 years of teaching undergraduate, graduate, and executive students at major American and foreign universities, means that extensive pragmatic teaching in the classroom adds to the academic base.

We maintained flexibility in the text; it can be adapted to either a one- or two-semester or a quarter-length course at both two- and four-year colleges and universities. Additionally, we have used the book in many continuing education and executive programs in the United States and abroad. Finally, *Effective Business Communications* has proved valuable as a handy reference guide long after the course has been completed.

NEW MATERIALS AND CHANGES

- **This textbook is more than 200 pages shorter than previous editions.** Accomplishing that task was not easy because both authors and readers become quite comfortable with familiar examples and topics. Regardless, we omitted repetitious explanations but retained and added new examples; decreased theoretical underpinnings but kept pragmatic advice; combined related topics and replaced long illustrations with shorter examples; omitted involved research discussions and inserted concise Communication Probes.
- **We omitted the obvious, shortened the familiar.** All the core business topics of the past six editions are there; they are simply in brief form, along with concise research probes and more checklists, the latter to verify that students have adequately covered the topic. Even long-used exercises have been omitted from the text, but these tested and true exercises are folded into the *Instructor's Manual.*

- **We are in paperback.** When the three authors were in school, they too had to purchase textbooks for classroom use while on a limited budget. This edition is less expensive than a hardcover book.
- **Communication Probes.** To acknowledge the source of related information, numerous research Communication Probes are included in each chapter, rather than an inordinate number of footnotes. These probes are succinct summaries of research statements relating to communication issues discussed within the chapter. Scholarly journals are the dominate source of these statements, but pragmatic and popular business-related journals are also cited.

  We underpin many pragmatic suggestions with research-oriented statements. Perceptive readers will quickly see that the 1960s and 1970s were the heyday for much communication research; we recognize that fact, but we also added recent communication studies that are new or are built upon previously completed efforts.
- **New Chapters.** *Chapter 4, "Business Communication and the Ethical Context."* One cannot avoid the term *ethics* in the business world: Newspapers report daily on unethical activity; at annual meetings stockholders raise questions that challenge company policies; and foreign governments scrutinize the behavior of nondomestic firms. Thus one chapter is devoted to ethical concerns, focusing on backgrounds to ethical contexts, influences on personal ethics, and communication and ethical issues.

  Chapter 5, "Business Communication and the Technology Context." Three-year-olds play games on their computers. High school students—and students even younger—surf the Internet. Dual telephone lines (fax and phone) are hooked to many American homes. Instant worldwide communication is common. Interviews are conducted via computer. CD-ROMs make data instantly available. Communicating via satelite is the norm. All these tools recognize that students, and the world of business, increasingly depend on linking technology with central business communication principles. Thus Chapter 5 merges technology with both internal and external communication. We touch the future but do not omit the past.
- **New Appendix.** *Appendix A, "Visual Aids in Business Communication."* Visuals are so dominant in both written and oral communication that an entire appendix is devoted to their discussion. Increasingly, boards of directors demand consistency in all visuals; managers demand that reports avoid drab black and white visuals that contain no color; instructors demand that the familiar three visual categories of pie charts, bar graphs, and line graphs no longer be options in business communication but mandatory. Long columns and rows of figures can be made more vivid. Appendix A suggests ways in which to add vividness to either oral or written business communication.
- **International Examples.** Business is no longer insular. It is not limited to the continental United States, nor are employees or you as a potential executive confined to domestic concerns. Thus, about a third of our examples are from outside the United States. Because one of the authors lived nearly 20 summers in Asia and because that part of the world is turning eagerly to capitalism, many foreign examples are from Asia. But those examples are not relevant to Asia alone; they are applicable to other sections of the world as well.

- **Sidenotes.** Whereas the Communication Probes are research-oriented statements embedded in the text, the sidenotes in the margins are brief summary statements that isolate significant points in the text that should not be ignored. Occasionally we draw an inference or offer an opinion: to reinforce the statements in the text, and possibly show our bias.
- **Exercises and Problems.** Every chapter's exercises begin with two questions demanding an international awareness. As businesses become more global, students—and instructors—must become familiar with differences and similarities in culture and global business communication. We often link the frequent in-class foreign students (with their own communication perceptions) with native class members. Both groups learn from the assignments; both learn about each other's culture; both improve their current and future communication skills as they begin jobs in global corporations. All the exercises are based on the instructors' involvement in or awareness of the international business environment.

  Long-time users of previous editions are adamant that we retain "old chestnut" exercises. We did remove some from this edition, but those we moved—along with our suggested responses—to our new *Instructor's Manual.* This compromise allowed us to add many new examples and exercises yet keep popular questions from previous editions.
- **Streamlined Prose.** Each chapter that was retained from the sixth edition was rewritten for the seventh. As stated earlier, this book is 200-plus pages shorter than previous editions, yet it includes the core of business communication principles. The authors, and other instructors, often supplement those central ideas by turning to innumerable other articles and research studies that relate to the topics in this text. That is the intent behind our more concise writing: to lay the foundation for effective business communication. Then through Communication Probes, new examples and illustrations, new topics, and an increased emphasis on international issues, students and instructors can supplement the information provided here.

SPECIAL LEARNING FEATURES AND BENEFITS

Principles of the Seven C's

No one knows the original source of the seven Cs; emphasis on these principles of completeness, conciseness, consideration, concreteness, clearness, courteousness, and correctness is present in the works of Greek and Roman writers and affirmed in the Renaissance. We simply—as in the previous six editions—continue to give the principles luster, in mnemonic form, to guide readers in choosing the content and style of presentation adapted to the purpose and recipient of each message.

Examples

Exemplary pedagogy moves on the wheels of good examples. As we mentioned, at least a third of the examples are international in nature. More than 400 examples are directly from actual business and professional organizations. Classroom-

tested, the examples have benefited from comments received from thousands of students and instructors over the years.

Checklists

Previous editions were known for their usable and workable checklists. In this seventh edition, Chapters 8, 9, and 10 have detailed capsule checklists; Chapter 7 is an entire chapter of examples acting as visual checklist; and all other chapters have checklists embedded within. In fact, each checklist lets readers review their progress, their homework, or even their understanding of the text. More than 100 checklists are now part of the text.

Cases

Most chapters include minicases—some people call them incidents—and problems that quickly lend themselves to in-class analysis and impromptu evaluations via either written or oral assignments. We continue the tradition of including as many real instances as possible, omitting of course any reference to identifiable companies or individuals.

Visuals

With today's PC software for graphics, it is a simple task to include illustrations, graphs, charts, and tables to enhance prose and text discussion of a report or oral presentation. Whenever we could visually enhance our prose, we did so, even including an entire appendix devoted to visuals.

References and Explanatory Notes

Previous editions included numerous source citations as further support for the text discussion. We omitted many of these citations in this edition, except in Chapter 4, "Business Communication and the Ethical Context," which depends heavily on outside examples and citations. Only when necessary is a citation included to which either the student or the instructor can turn for additional reading. We used a modified version of the American Psychological Association (APA) citation format.

Outlines and Summaries

We live in a visual world. Thus, each chapter opens with an outline of the main topics followed by our traditional **PAL:** Porch (*brief opening remarks*), Aim (*core purpose of the chapter*), and Layout (*major topic divisions of the chapter*). A summary of the most important concepts discussed ends each chapter.

Databases

Technology's footprint is obvious in this seventh edition. No longer can anyone avoid the increasing use of databases in law, the social sciences, business, and a host of other areas. References to CD-ROMs and the proliferating visual world

of information are included where appropriate. Our intent is to awaken students and encourage them to pursue the increasing numbers of electronic sources—as supplements to this text—useful for well-documented written or oral forms of business communication.

Appendixes

Positioning the following topics in the appendixes does not diminish their importance; it stresses their centrality in business communication:

- Appendix A, "Visual Aids in Business Communication," focuses on six common forms of visual support: outline charts, tables, bar graphs, pie charts, line graphs, and area graphs, along with examples of each.
- Appendix B, "Grammar, Punctuation, and Style," includes more than 60 examples that illustrate the common mechanical problems facing communicators.
- Appendix C, "Business Communication and Legal Issues," looks at five areas each businessperson will face in the future: defamation; invasion of privacy; misrepresentation and fraud; laws regarding employment, credit, and collections; and copyrights and computer data security.

SUPPLEMENTS

Instructor's Manual

To help fellow teachers do a better job of instructing, the *Instructor's Manual* includes our suggestions, comments, and assistance for each chapter:

- Background information, including possible course content and organization; suggestions for conducting various courses using this textbook; longer, unique cases with simulation exercises.
- Possible answers and suggestions for each of the exercises, problems, and cases in the text chapters.
- Transparency masters. Some illustrate significant text concepts; others extend the textual material; several display possible answers to chapter exercises and problems.

Microsoft PowerPoint™ for Checklists

Each of the shorter checklists (all those but the longer capsule checklists in Chapters 8, 9, and 10) is available on a disk for instructors to project via computer. We found in our classes that each checklist is a superior discussion starter.

Test Bank

A test bank is available, prepared by Betty Pritchett of Kennesaw State University. Each chapter contains a variety of questions, with answers.

Computerized Test Bank

The test bank is also available in Microtest III™, a computerized test-preparation system in DOS, Windows, and Macintosh platforms.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

No one writes alone. Over many years unnamed students and fellow instructors have given advice—often with firmness—about many issues covered in the book. To these people we are grateful.

Foremost, the two senior authors—Herta Murphy and Herb Hildebrandt—welcome Jane Thomas, our junior coauthor. Her long hours and dedication and justifiable demands for rewrites and amendments are obvious throughout the book. Jane is a distinguished teacher and Director of the BBA writing program at the University of Michigan Business School.

Initial reviewers were exceptionally thorough, and we tried to meet all their expectations and demands. Our appreciation is extended to each of the following reviewers:

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Three secretaries especially deserve our thanks. Joanne Ripple of the University of Michigan Business School has for many years made sense out of poorly formatted disks and visuals for Herb Hildebrandt; Margaret Oberle and Marilyn Bernhardt, also of the Business School, exerted efforts for Jane Thomas far beyond the usual. Michelle Chiu and Carla LaPointe of the Business School also offered additional help. To all, we are sincerely grateful.

McGraw-Hill has been our publisher since 1972, which is a lengthy relationship. We would like to acknowledge the efforts of Bonnie Binkert, former senior editor, as our motivator and inspiration who got us going on this seventh edition. Her insights over the years are not overlooked. Our new editor, Karen Westover, continues the tradition of able adviser. To her, and the many other staff members of McGraw-Hill, we are grateful.

To Mary Farrell, a not-behind the scenes copyeditor, we also owe much appreciation. Her semantic and grammatical hoe forced us to cultivate the words we planted in the text. We may not be entirely weed-free, but if there are any unwelcome plants, the fault is with the original gardeners, the authors.

With consummate sincerity we continue to affectionately dedicate this book to three persons who endured out of love our affairs with modern office technol-

ogy, and the seemingly endless hours staring into a computer screen. Sadly, Gene Murphy recently died, and so we honor him in remembrance.

Our public dedication is to our students: They—you—are the future. We give you our support, our affection, our wish for you to be successful in written and oral communication.

Herta A. Murphy
Herbert W. Hildebrandt
Jane P. Thomas

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Chapter 1

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If you can communicate effectively in speaking and writing, you have a highly valued skill. In numerous surveys, business executives rank the ability to communicate first among the personal factors necessary for promotion.

Communicating effectively in speaking and writing extends across all areas of business, including management, technical, clerical, and social positions. And now in the nineties, the phenomenal growth of internal trade creates the need for you to also understand intercultural communication—the ability to speak and write in ways that are sensitive to and cognizant of the factors in different cultural contexts.

This chapter discusses the importance and benefits of effective communication to you and to your organization. It also reviews the basic components of a message, including concepts and problems in communicating and facets of nonverbal communication. The need for greater cultural sensitivity and knowledge of international issues is also stressed.

IMPORTANCE AND BENEFITS OF EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

The ability to communicate well has always provided advantages to those who possess it. Communication has a rich history, and its traditions can still be seen in modern-day communication concepts.

Ancient Heritage for Communication Principles

Western principles of communication developed in ancient Greece and Rome, with an emphasis on oral rhetorical traditions.

The ancient world, both the East and the West, depended heavily on oral communication. For example, in ancient Greece and Rome, it was necessary to communicate well on one's feet when dealing with matters in government assemblies and the law courts. During the Medieval and Renaissance periods, the oral tradition continued. As writing became more important as a permanent record of communication, authors and books on written communication principles appeared.

Communication principles originating in the East, particularly China, are based on and connected with the importance of bureaucratic traditions. For centuries, Chinese political theorists were concerned with the problems of communicating within the vast government bureaucracy as well as between the government and the people. As early as the fourth century, these theorists were advising rulers and government officials. Their advice stated that information should flow smoothly upward and downward. The theorists also encouraged rulers and officials to minimize bias and falsification of sources and to resist the influence of cliques and opportunists.[1]

Hence, some of today's principles of writing are founded on a mixture of ancient oral and written traditions. Business communication is one offshoot from an earlier world where communicating well was a foundation of learning.

"Lifeblood" of Every Organization

Organizations cannot function without open and effective communication.

An *organization* is a group of people associated for business, political, professional, religious, athletic, social, or other purposes. Its activities require human beings to interact and react, that is, to communicate. They exchange informa-

Communication Probe

Many language historians believe that writing developed as a means of communicating business matters. Archaeological evidence shows numerals and letters written on products and goods traded by ancient tribes, and for centuries, writing appears to be limited to commercial and administrative concerns. Wills from England and Europe during the Middle Ages list few books of literature. Even Bibles, psalters, and religious books are rare. Business accounts from that period, however, are common and are the basis of much of our historical knowledge. Although some researchers believe that priests first developed writing, many others think that merchants were the first to use written symbols because of the necessities of trade and keeping accounts. Historical studies of literacy have often ignored the role played by merchants and others involved in the development of commerce.

Gorlach, M. (1991). *Introduction to Early Modern English.* Cambridge and New York: Cambridge University Press. Pyles, T. (1982). *The origins and development of the English language* (3rd ed). New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich; Thomas, J. (1994). *The language of the Celys* (pp. 175–200). Dissertation, University of Michigan; Ann Arbor.

tion, ideas, plans; order needed supplies; make decisions, rules, proposals, contracts, and agreements. Communication is the "lifeblood" of every organization.

Because this book is concerned primarily with effective *business* communication, the discussions and illustrations you will read focus mainly on business messages. However, you can apply these principles to other organizations, to the professions, and to your personal communications.

Internal Communication

A vital means of attending to company concerns is through effective internal communication—*downward, upward,* and *horizontal.* It helps increase job satisfaction, safety, productivity, and profits and decreases absenteeism, grievances, and turnover.

When employees receive appropriate *downward* communication from management, they can be better motivated and more efficient. They need not only clear job directions and safety rules but also facts about organizational strategy, products, and viewpoints on important controversial issues. They are concerned about employee benefits—health care, insurance, promotions, pensions, training, work environment, retirement. In all, the many pressures from employees force employers to be accountable for their decisions through effective downward communication. Employers who communicate effectively have more productive employees.

Likewise, *upward* internal communication has become increasingly more significant. Many executives sincerely seek frank comments from employees, in addition to the usual periodic reports. Successful managers listen closely to opin-

ions, complaints, problems, and suggestions, especially when these are clearly and effectively stated. As a response to increasing global competition, some companies are developing new management styles, which make input from employees an integral part of important decisions affecting the company.

Effective *horizontal* communication between peers is also essential in organizations in order to solve problems, perform job duties, prepare for meetings, and cooperate on important projects. For example, if you think about the time spent listening to and making requests, writing notes and memos, and discussing and writing about projects, you soon realize that communication is the medium through which an organization accomplishes its goals.

Among various ways of communicating within companies are memos, reports, meetings, face-to-face discussions, teleconferences, video conferences, and electronic mail. This book includes suggestions that may be applied to these communications.

External Communication

Effective communication to people outside the organization can help create a good reputation and have a positive impact on its ultimate success.

Messages to persons outside the company can have a far-reaching effect on its reputation and ultimate success. The right letter, proposal, report, telephone call, or personal conversation can win back a disgruntled customer, create a desire for a firm's product or service, help negotiate a profitable sale, encourage collections, motivate performance, and in general, create goodwill.

Furthermore, communications to the *public* regarding social accountability have become significantly more important during the past two decades. Because of demands by many special interest groups (labor unions, environmental groups, government agencies, political action committees, and others), the media, business organizations, and political groups are seriously concerned about enhancing their public image. Important are well-planned public speeches, tactful replies to comments and criticisms, free informative pamphlets, annual reports, 10-K reports, and image-building interviews with the news media. All these messages should be transmitted with an emphasis on honesty, openness, and concern for the public.[2]

Overall Communication Costs

Time is a major factor in overall communciation costs.

In multinational corporations, thousands of hours are devoted daily to interviews, conferences, memos, reports, employee manuals, letters, advertising, new articles, bulletins, newsletters, and other messages. Time is the chief element in the overall cost of written and oral communications. For example, the time spent just in written tasks can occupy much of the working day. In a survey of four professional areas, a substantial number of respondents, none of whom was employed as a writer, indicated that they spent from 29 to more than 50 percent of their time writing.[3]

Managers	Technical Workers	Clerical Staff	Social Service Workers
49.4%	40.7%	29.1%	51.6%

Among other costs of communication in organizations are materials (stationery, office supplies, postage, computer disks, software), equipment, and fixed

charges, such as heat, rent, light, and depreciation. Important developments and adaptations of office technology, such as computers, electronic mail, and video conferences can help in various ways to reduce the time and costs of communicating efficiently.

Poor communication can cost an organization time and money.

Consider also the wasteful cost of unclear, incomplete, inaccurate, inconsiderate, and unduly long or late communications. Ineffective messages that alienate customers are more expensive than effective ones because they destroy goodwill. Poor messages often require several additional messages. Furthermore, in fields such as aviation, construction, medicine, mining, oil drilling, and others, poor instructions can result in loss of life and loss of money.

Benefits of Effective Comunication in Your Career

Your job, promotion, and professional reputation often depend on doing well in written and oral communication. Also, your ability to communicate effectively is a valuable asset for many activities in your personal life.

A Valuable Job Requirement

If your career requires mainly mental rather than manual labor, your progress will be strongly influenced by how effectively you communicate your knowledge, proposals, and ideas to others who need or should receive them.

Strong communication skills were found in the job descriptions listed by numerous companies advertising positions. For example, Francis W. Weeks, executive director emeritus of the Association for Business Communication,[4] found in a 6-year study of job listings at the University of Illinois Coordinating Placement Office that 340 jobs in 30 fields required communication ability. In addition, Vanessa Dean Arnold's analysis of communication requirements listed in the job descriptions of only one issue of the *National Business Employment Weekly,* a publication of the *Wall Street Journal,* found that of 120 listings, 85 emphasized communication skills and described the specific skills needed.[5] Among the job descriptions found in this study were requirements like the following:

Job Title	Communication Skills
Finance Associate	Must be able to communicate clearly to clients and other finance professionals
Fiscal Officer	Superior writing and presentation skills
Product Manager	Develop and communicate product objectives and strategies
Senior Sales Representative	Excellent communication and follow-up skills; ability to write proposals and quotations
Contracts Administrator	General knowledge of proposal preparation: good oral/written communication skills

Communication is a primary responsibility in many careers, such as customer relations, labor relations, marketing, personnel, public relations, sales, and

teaching. Also, technical and scientific fields need editors, producers, researchers, and writers. Advancement can be made to management, research, training, and consulting positions.

Communication is a major responsibility in many areas, including government and nonprofit organizations.

Communication skills play a major role in congressional and senatorial offices at the state and national level. For instance, some senators in Washington, from their chiefs of staff on down, have in excess of 60 people handling correspondence, preparing speeches, meeting with constituents, assisting with fundraising, helping write legislation, communicating with business. Other governmental departments are equally full-staffed to handle communication issues, each department seeking to communicate clearly internally and externally. Searching for competent communication people to decrease fuzzy double-talk from government offices is ongoing. As you know, government is the country's biggest business.

Even if your work is mainly with figures, as in the accounting profession, the ability to communicate to those who read your financial reports is essential. The *Journal of Accountancy,* in a study cited in *Horizons for a Profession,* emphasized the importance of writing. A group of accountants who were considered the "most knowledgeable and forward-looking segment of the accounting profession" ranked 53 subjects that a beginning CPA should be familiar with. First place went indisputably to written and oral English—even over accounting theory and practice![6] In addition, a study done by Hiemstra, Schmidt, and Madison in the December 1990 *Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication* showed that the Certified Management Accountants surveyed believe that the importance of communication skills has increased significantly since they first began their accounting careers.[7] The federal government's Defense Contract Audit Agency (DCAA) has a two-volume manual that accountants must follow in auditing government contracts. While instructions are detailed as to which material should be audited, one chapter is devoted entirely to writing.[8]

An Essential for Promotion

The prime requisite of a promotable executive is "ability to communicate." Notice that it is at the top of the mountain in Figure 1.1. Too often those who cannot communicate effectively in either oral or written communications remain "buried" in lower, dead-end jobs. Members of management spend 60 to 90 percent of their working days communicating—speaking, writing, and listening.

Many people rate communication as one of the most important aspects of business leadership.

Over the past 40 years, many surveys and articles have confirmed the idea that effective communication is essential for success and promotion in business. They have included responses from thousands of top-level executives, middle managers, and university business graduates across the United States and in foreign countries. When the respondents were asked to answer the question "What has been the most valuable subject you studied in college?", such titles as Business Communications, Business Letter and Report Writing, and Written and Oral Expresion were consistently among the top three responses. Respondents, including top, middle, and operations managers, have repeatedly asserted that business communication skills significantly influenced their advancement to executive positions.[9]

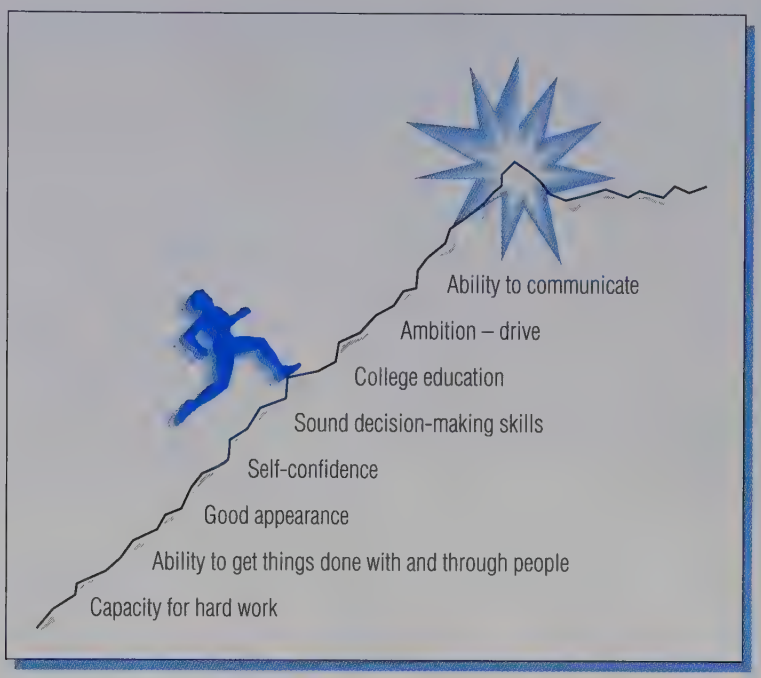

Figure 1.1 Requisites for a promotable executive.

Challenge of Communication in the Global Market

The way you communicate both within and outside your own country will affect everything you accomplish. Your ability to speak and write effectively will also make a difference to your organization. Developing the right attitude and

Communication Probe

Although many business students believe that a secretary will write most of their day-to-day documents for them, studies show that this is not the case. In a study of types of writing done by managers, respondents indicated that they wrote letters, memos, and short reports most frequently and that they, not their secretaries, did the actual writing.

In the same study, the managers indicated that they spent little time on the more formal, long reports. Information on how to prepare a formal, documented report is necessary, but this study suggests that instruction should focus on the more common, shorter documents. Many business schools now offer courses on memo and letter writing, emphasizing strategies for efficiency and effectiveness.

Kirtz, M. K., Reep, D. C. (1990). A survey of the frequency, types, and importance of writing tasks in four career areas. *Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication*, 8(4), 3.

preparing adequately are crucial to effective communication in the international marketplace. These qualities will help you to be effective in dealing with international business people outside your organization. In addition, becoming flexible in attitude and methods of communicating will help you to be effective in dealing with issues within your organization.

Developing the Right Attitude

"To the customer, you are the company." This good advice comes from public relations experts. Your attitude when dealing with customers, clients, and the public reflect on the company you represent. When you deal with international business people, your attitude will reflect your country and your culture.

Your ability to communicate orally and in writing affects your company's public image.

You may realize that special and important communications can make millions of dollars of difference to your company. But you should also be aware that the daily routine messages are just as important. Each message communicates the essential quality and culture of your company and can either build goodwill or destroy it.

Doing an honest job enthusiastically and competently helps both the doer and the receiver. Answering even routine inquiries should and can be an interesting challenge. For example, an insurance company correspondent may often receive similar questions from policyholders who have lost their insurance policies. Though lost-policy cases are familiar to the insurance staff member, they certainly are not routine to the reader. Thus a good approach is to send a personalized, helpful message, sensitive to the reader's viewpoint.

Messages written to international clients, customers, suppliers, and other business contacts must be especially sensitive to audience concerns. Goodwill toward your organization is at stake as well as goodwill toward you as a representative of your country.

Preparing Adequately

Most people can learn to communicate effectively for business if they are willing to devote whatever effort is necessary to prepare themselves adequately. In addition to the proper goodwill-building attitude, the following qualities are desirable:

- Careful, sound judgment when choosing ideas and facts for each message
- Patience and understanding, even with unjustly insulting persons
- Integrity, backed up by a valid code of ethics
- Reasonable facility with the English language
- Applied knowledge of the communication process and principles and of successful methods for sending and receiving messages
- Knowledge of the cultural conventions of your audience

Becoming Flexible

Today's workplace is increasingly diverse in age, gender, and national origin. Diversity has brought problems to organizations, but it has also brought strengths. Changing demographics have contributed to changes in management styles,

making effective communication central to success in carrying out the organization's business.

Many companies now offer seminars or other kinds of classes in handling diversity issues in the workplace. Today's managers and workers need to be flexible in the way they deal with others; problems can be avoided by keeping an open mind and being willing to make extra efforts in communication.

One of the most sensitive issues is language. Although English currently appears to be the international language of business, many workers in U.S. companies do not speak English as their first language. Effective communication in organizations with a multinational workforce takes flexibility and an awareness of the important components of language use. These components involve the major issues of communication, including how to effectively address various audiences and how to choose effective communication channels and information. To focus on errors in speaking or writing standard English is to risk failure of your communication objectives.

COMPONENTS OF COMMUNICATION

Communication is a process of transmitting and receiving verbal and nonverbal messages. Communication is considered effective when it achieves the desired reaction or response from the receiver. Simply stated, communication is a two-way process of exchanging ideas or information.

Communication includes six components: context, sender-encoder, message, medium, receiver-decoder, and feedback. Figure 1.2 illustrates in part how these factors interact in the communication processes, affected by various contextual conditions and decisions.

Context

Every message, whether oral or written, begins with context. Context is a broad field that includes country, culture, organization, and external and internal stim-

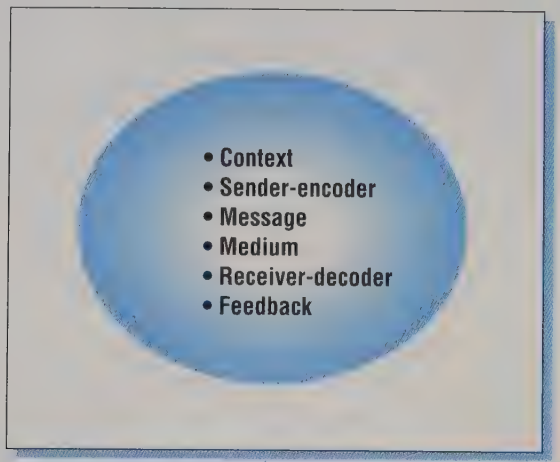

Figure 1.2 The components of communication.

uli. Every country, every culture, and every company or organization has its own conventions for processing and communicating information. This aspect of context is the playing field on which you must plan, design, and communicate your message successfully.

Another aspect of context is the external stimulus that prompts you to send a message. The source of this prompt may be a letter, memo, note, electronic mail, fax, telex, telephone call, a meeting, or even a casual conversation. Your response to this prompt may be oral or written.

Next, internal stimuli have a complex influence on how you translate ideas into a message. When you encode, your own view of the world affects the choices you make in language. Your attitudes, opinions, emotions, past experiences, likes and dislikes, education, job status, and confidence in your communication skills all influence the way you communicate your ideas. Especially important is your ability to analyze your receiver's culture, viewpoint, needs, skills, status, mental ability, experience, and expectations. You must consider all these aspects of context in order to communicate a message effectively.

Sender-Encoder

As a sender-encoder, you use symbols that express your message and create the desired response.

When you send a message, you are the "encoder," the writer or speaker, depending on whether your message is written or oral. You try to choose symbols—usually words (and sometimes also graphics or pictures)—that express your message so that the receiver(s) will understand it and react with the response you desire. After considering all the factors mentioned above, you decide which symbols best convey your message and which message channel will be most effective among the oral and written media.

Message

You must first decide what the main point of your message is and what other information to include.

The message is the core idea you wish to communicate; it consists of both *verbal* (written or spoken) symbols and *nonverbal* (unspoken) symbols. Examples are discussed later in this chapter and others.

Your first task is to decide exactly *what* your message is and what content to include. You must consider your context and especially the receiver of your message—how the receiver will interpret it and how it may affect your relationship. A simple answer to a request for information may be relatively easy. In contrast, a message explaining why a company is moving some of its manufacturing to Mexico or a proposal to build a new headquarters for a governmental agency will require more complex, carefully planned communication strategies.

Medium

Your medium can be the printed word, electronic mail, or sound.

Your message channel depends on all the contextual factors discussed above and the nature of the message itself. Your choices include electronic mail, the printed word, or sound. Briefly, should you write or speak?

Like message content, the choice of medium is influenced by the relationship between the sender and the receiver. Some research suggests that the urgency of a message is a primary factor in whether to use the written or spoken medium. You may also consider factors such as importance, number of receivers, costs, and amount of information. If the message goes to an international audience, you must also consider which medium is preferred in the receiver's culture.

Based on research, the following describe some of the characteristics found in oral and written media:

Oral	Written
Immediate feedback	Delayed feedback
Shorter sentences; shorter words	Longer sentences; longer words
Conversational	More formal
Focus on interpersonal relations	Focus on content
Prompt action	Delayed action
Less detailed technical information	More detailed technical information
More personal pronouns	Fewer personal pronouns
More colloquial language	More complex constructions
Simpler constructions	Useful for permanent record; detailed documentation
More imperative, interrogative, and exclamatory sentences	Possibility of review

The written channel is often preferred when the message is long, technical, or formal in nature, and when the message must be documented. The oral channel is effective when the message is urgent or personal or when immediate feedback is important. These guidelines can change when your receiver is from another country. For example, in many countries in Europe and Asia, complex messages are often dealt with orally, with written documents provided only later, if necessary.

Inside Your Organization

Internal communication consists of sending messages inside your organization; external communication consists of sending messages outside your organization.

For internal communication, written media may be memos, reports, bulletins, job descriptions, posters, notes, employee manuals, electronic bulletin boards, even internal faxes. Oral communication may take the form of staff meeting reports, face-to-face discussions, presentations, audio tapes, telephone chats, teleconferences, or videotapes. Another oral channel, usually unplanned by the sender, is the "grapevine," through which news and rumors travel quickly—often quite accurately.

Outside Your Organization

External written communication media may be letters, reports, proposals, telegrams, cablegrams, mailgrams, faxes, telexes, postcards, contracts, ads, brochures, catalogs, news releases, and a host of other things. You may also communicate orally in face-to-face discussions, by telephone, or by presentations in solo or panel situations. You may speak to groups in live presentations or through teleconferences, video conferences, or television.

Receiver-Decoder

The message receiver is your reader or listener, also known as the *decoder.* Many of your messages may have more than one decoder.

The receiver-decoder is influenced by context and by his or her mental filter.

As Figure 1.3 indicates, the receiver as well as the sender are influenced by the context and by the external and internal stimuli. Both receive messages through the eyes and ears but are also influenced by nonverbal factors such as

touch, taste, and smell. All factors of a message are filtered through the receiver(s) view of and experiences in the world.

But one problem is that we do not all undergo identical experiences with the subject or the symbols that the sender has chosen. Even within the United States, attitudes, abilities, opinions, communication skills, and cultural customs vary. Add another country into the communication process and the problems increase. Therefore, miscommunication can occur when personal biases and individual values cause the receiver to misinterpret the sender's intended message.

Feedback

Feedback can be an oral or a written message, an action, or simply silence.

Ultimately the receiver reacts with either the desired response based on a clear understanding of the symbols or with an undesired response because of miscommunication. Feedback can be oral or written. It can also be an action, such as receiving in the mail an item you ordered. Sometimes silence is used as feedback, though it is almost always ineffective. Senders need feedback in order to determine the success or failure of the communication.

The components described above represent what happens in communication. A context exists in which a sender chooses a message to communicate; the sender must also choose the medium for the message; a receiver decodes the message and provides feedback. Although this linear description seems relatively simple, problems can occur at any point on the continuum.

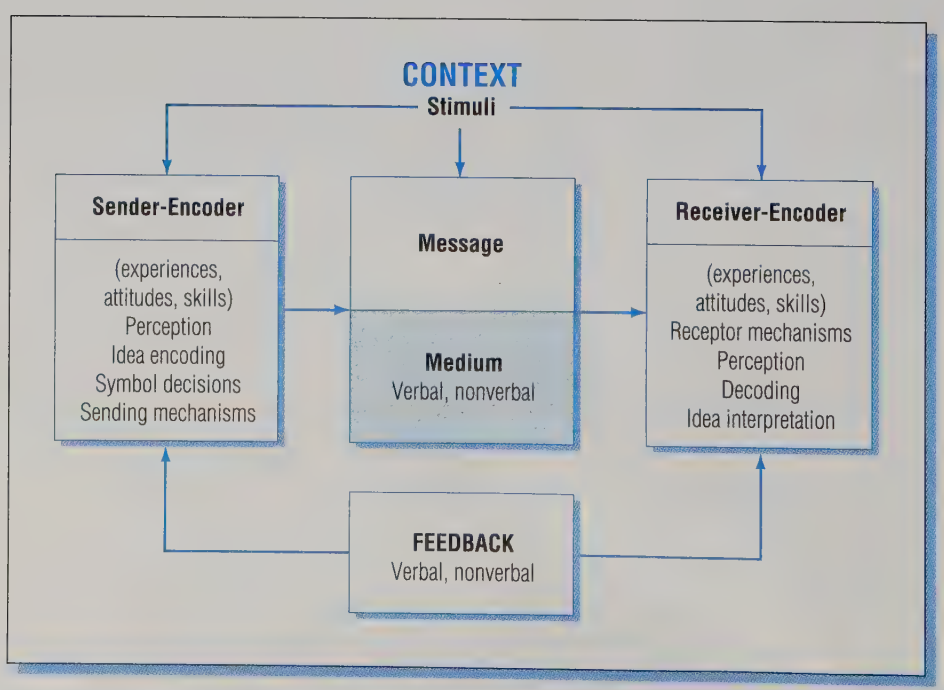

Figure 1.3 A communication model.

Checklist 1.1 Components of Communication

1. Context
   - **a.** Have you considered the cultural and organizational convention concerning the environment of your message?
   - **b.** Have you thought about the specific reasons for and objectives of your message?

2. Sender-encoder
   - **a.** Recognize that internal attitudes can influence your message
   - **b.** Realize that the words you are using reveal something about you

3. Message
   - **a.** Is central purpose clear?
   - **b.** Is thought given to both verbal and nonverbal elements of communication?

4. Medium
   - **a.** Ask yourself: Which medium should I use? The more urgent suggests oral; the less urgent suggests written
   - **b.** Ask yourself: Are the symbols clear in the medium I have chosen?

5. Receiver-decoder
   - **a.** Are you, as the sender, aware of the attitudes and perceptions of your receiver?
   - **b.** Are there physical, emotional, mental, or cultural factors in the receiver that could affect your message?

6. Feedback
   - **a.** Have you allowed for feedback to your message?
   - **b.** Have you been precise about when you desire the feedback?

CONCEPTS AND PROBLEMS OF COMMUNICATION

No two people in the world are exactly alike, and no two cultures or countries are the same. For example, decision making in Japan is inordinately slow by western standards. Americans also wonder why Germans are so thorough in their reports, why the French are so polite in letter writing, and why middle eastern business people are less concerned with time. The reason is that in those cultures, these different attitudes are acceptable and appropriate. All these differences, however, can cause problems in conveying intended meanings.

Each person's mind is a unique filter. Problems with communication are more likely to occur when the communicators' filters are sharply different. The

message sender's meanings and the receiver's response are affected by numerous factors, such as individual

- Conventions of meaning
- Perceptions of reality
- Values, attitudes, and opinions

Conventions of Meaning

A fundamental principle of communication is that the symbols the sender uses to communicate messages must have essentially the same meaning in both the sender's and receiver's minds. You can never assume that the message in your mind will be perfectly transmitted to your receiver. The world is littered with errors, sometimes humorous, often costly, as a result of differences in semantic understanding.

A way of clarifying semantic problems is to view the semantic triangle (Figure 1.4). In this view, a symbol is a sign for something that exists in reality. Thus your name—really a symbol or word—represents you. Only through common experience is a connection made between the symbol or word attached to you and the person you are in reality. The closer the common experiences surrounding the symbols and their things (referents) in the minds of the sender and receiver, the closer the level of understanding.

For example, many acronyms have become accepted into Standard English and are generally understood by most people, such as *laser* (*l*ight *a*mplification by *s*timulated *e*mission of *r*adiation) and *sonar* (*s*ound *n*avigation *r*anging). Others, however, are particular to certain fields, such as FIFO (first in, first out) and LIFO (last in, first out) in accounting. Such acronyms are not understood by people who are not accountants.

Communication Problems in Conventions of Meaning

Symbols are signs for things that exist. Connections between signs and their referents are unique to each individual.

The meanings of words (semantics) are constructed within each person's experience of reality. The knowledge we each have about a subject or word affects the meanings we attach to it. Different word interpretations are especially notable in *miscommunicated instructions* and in reactions to *denotations, connotations,* and *euphemisms.*

Miscommunication occurs when the sender and receiver have different meanings for the symbols used.

Miscommunicated Instructions. When the message sender and receiver attribute different meanings to the same words or use different words though intending the same meanings, miscommunication occurs. Many English and foreign words have several dictionary definitions; a few have over 100. In one abridged dictionary, the word *run* has 71 meanings as a verb, another 35 as a noun, and 4 more as an adjective. Moreover, for certain words many people have their own unique meanings, based on their experiences, and such personal meanings are not in a dictionary. Thus, confusion sometimes arises, as these "listening" incidents illustrate:

1. A legislator hired a new office manager with the instructions to turn in a bimonthly report on all the activities that occurred in the previous pe-

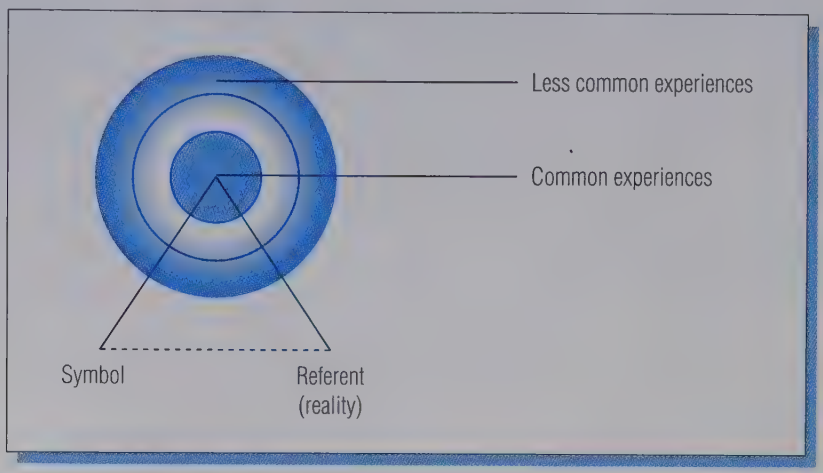

Figure 1.4 Communication triangle.

riod. After a month went by with no report, the legislator asked the office manager why he had not turned in the report as requested. The office manager replied that he thought the legislator wanted the report only every 2 months. After a short discussion on the definition of bimonthly, the two looked the word up in the dictionary. They discovered that *bimonthly* means both "twice a month" and "every two months."

2. A woman sold a piece of property and asked her attorney to draw up a contract of sale. When she received the document for her signature, she read that "the party of the first part agrees to sell to the party of the second part the tenement located at the southeast corner First Ave. and Drysdale Blvd." She quickly telephoned her attorney to point out that the land she was selling had no "tenement" on it and, in fact, had no building at all. Her attorney had to point out that the word *tenement* in the law means only "a holding of land."

3. A British manager of a large retail conglomerate was working in the United States for the first time. In order to bring himself up to date on his department's activities, he looked over the minutes from the last staff meeting, which he had not attended. He saw with satisfaction that the group had tabled his proposal to decrease allowable travel expenses. He was upset later, however, when he found that his staff had put the proposal off until the next meeting. In Britain, *to table a proposal* means to act on it.

Miscommunication occurs not only in business and industrial offices but also among government officials, military leaders, professionals, and all of us in our everyday contacts. To avoid communication errors when you give instructions or discuss issues, be sure your words convey the intended meaning to the recipient. When you are the recipient of unclear instructions, before acting on them, ask questions to determine the sender's intended meaning.

Reactions to Denotations, Connotations, and Euphemisms. On occasion many of us have been surprised that a remark intended as a compliment, a matter-of-fact statement, or a joke was interpreted as an insult. Because words have both denotative and connotative meanings and because the sender has not considered the receiver's probable interpretations and reactions, miscommunication can occur.

A denotation is usually the dictionary definition of a word.

1. *Denotations.* Most people agree on denotative meanings. It often is the dictionary definition. Denotative meanings inform the receiver, naming objects, people, or events without indicating positive or negative qualities. Such words as *car, desk, book, house,* and *water* convey denotative meanings, provided, of course, that the communicators are using the same language and provided that the receiver has a similar understanding of the context in which the word is used.

A connotation is an implication of a word or a suggestion separate from the usual definition.

2. *Connotations.* In addition to the more literal denotative meanings, some words have connotative meanings that arouse qualitative judgments and personal reactions. The term *house* is denotative. *Mansion, villa, home, cottage, firetrap, shack*—though they all denote a place of residence—also have connotative meanings. The word *student* is denotative; *bookworm, scholar, dropout, gunner* are connotative. They reveal how the sender evaluates the subject. Some words, such as *efficient, gentle, prompt,* usually have favorable connotations. Others, such as *lazy, cowardly, rotten, delinquent,* usually have unfavorable connotations. Some words have positive connotations in some contexts and negative meanings in others. Compare, for example, *fat check* and *fat girl; free enterprise* and *free* (rude, bold) *manners; sucker* (customer) and *sucker* (candy); *cheap product* and *cheap price.* In common usage, words that usually have opposite meanings can sometimes have the same meaning, as in the two expressions *slim chance* and *fat chance.* One word that can now mean its opposite in colloquial language is the term *bad,* such as "Woodstock '94 was *bad*!"

   The connotative meanings for words are also affected by the communicators' different backgrounds and interests. Words such as *amnesty, speed, grass, crack, coke, gay, feminist* may arouse mixed feelings and arguments, depending on people's associations with them.

To communicate effectively, you must be aware of the connotative meanings of your words, and you must realize that some people have their own idiosyncratic meanings because of their experiences and background. Thus, choose your language carefully and consider both its denotations and its connotations to convey the exact idea you want and to achieve your desired results.

Perceptions of Reality

Complex, infinite, and continuously changing, the material world provides a special reality to each individual. Also, human beings' sensory perceptions—touch, sight, hearing, smell, taste—are limited, and each person's mental filter is

unique. We make various *abstractions, inferences,* and *evaluations* of the world around us.

Communication Problems in Perceptions of Reality

When you select some facts and omit others, you are abstracting.

Abstracting. Focusing on some details and omitting others is a process called *abstracting.* In countless instances, abstracting is necessary. However, you should be cautious about "slanted" statements.

1. *Necessary, desirable abstracts.* Whether you write or speak, you are usually limited by time, expense, space, or purpose. You need to select facts that are pertinent to accomplish your purpose and to omit the rest (as you do, for example, in a one-page application letter about yourself).

   The chapter you are now reading is also necessarily an abstract; it condenses into a few pages highlights of numerous studies relating to communication and miscommunication. You must anticipate the likelihood that others may not be abstracting as you are. Their points may be as important as yours, though they select differently from the infinite number of details in reality. Differences in abstracting occur not only when persons describe events but also when they describe people, equipment, projects, animals, objects.

2. *Slanted statements.* Conscientious communicators, both senders and receivers of messages, should try to determine whether the facts they are acquainted with are truly representative of the whole. Slanting is unfair in factual reporting. For example, the news reporter is taught to include quoted statements in context and to avoid expressions of personal approval or disapproval of the persons, objects, or occurrences being described.

A reputable news reporter would not write, "A small crowd of suckers came to hear the Governor's plan for 1997 yesterday noon in that rundown hotel that disfigures Hong Kong central." Instead, the write-up might state that "between 200 and 350 people heard an address yesterday noon by Governor Patton in the auditorium at the Conrad Hotel at Pacific Place."

Not only the language you use but also the type of information you include and exclude can result in slanting, revealing your own biases. Although total objectivity is not possible, you should try to not let personal preferences influence your factual reporting of information.

Inferences are conclusions drawn from evidence.

Inferring. Conclusions made by reasoning from evidence or premises are called *inferences.* Every day most of us find it necessary to act on some inferences. We make assumptions and draw conclusions even though we are not able to immediately verify the evidence. Some inferences are both necessary and desirable; others are risky, even dangerous.

Necessary, Desirable Inferences. For business and professional people, inferences are essential in analyzing materials, solving problems, and planning procedures. Systems analysts, marketing specialists, advertisers, architects, engineers, designers, and numerous others all must work on various premises and make inferences after they have gathered as much factual data as possible. Even our legal procedures allow inferences from experts as acceptable evidence. In our everyday activities, we make inferences that are necessary and usually fairly reliable.

- When we land at a foreign airport, we assume we will be treated hospitably.
- When we send a fax to Frankfurt, Germany, we assume it will reach the intended receiver.
- When we drop a letter into the mailbox, we infer that it will be delivered to our intended reader.
- When we enter an elevator in our building, we hope it will take us to the desired floor.

When we base our inferences on direct observation or on reasonable evidence, they are likely to be quite dependable; but even so, there are disappointing exceptions. Conclusions we make about things we have not observed directly can often be untrue.

Risks of Inferences. As intelligent communicators, we must realize that inferences may be incorrect or unreliable and anticipate the risks before acting on them.

> *Suppose a personnel manager notices that John Edwards, a new management trainee, has been staggering into his office every day for the past week. The manager might infer that the trainee has a drinking problem. But if the reason for the unsteady movement is the presence of Ménière's Syndrome (a disease of the inner ear), the manager would be wrong to assume a drinking problem. Always get the facts before taking action!*

Tell those who may be acting on your inferences which portions of your statements are mere assumptions. If you are presenting a report on which an important executive decision may rest, be careful to distinguish clearly among verifiable facts, inferences based on facts, and mere "guesstimates."

Values, Attitudes, and Opinions

A receiver's attitude toward a message can determine whether it is accepted, rejected, distorted, or avoided.

Communication effectiveness is influenced also by the values, attitudes, and opinions the communicators have in their mental filters. People react favorably when the message they receive agrees with their views toward the information, the facts, and the sender.

Communication Problems Involving Values, Attitudes, Opinions

Receivers' views of the information presented will affect their response, which could be what the sender desires or just the opposite.

Favorable or Unfavorable Information. The effective communicator considers the receivers, and whenever possible, emphasizes the points the receivers will regard as favorable or beneficial. Receivers often react to unfavorable information by rejecting, distorting, or avoiding it.

Inadequate or Incorrect Information. Occasionally people react according to their attitudes toward a situation rather than to the facts. For instance, a customer may be happy over an adjustment that a company extended, but angry when learning that someone else received a better deal for what the customer assumed (perhaps wrongly) to be the same circumstances. This customer may have incomplete or incorrect information.

Closed Minds. Some people hold rigid views on certain subjects. These people do not consider facts or additional information and maintain their rigid views regardless of the circumstances. Such a closed-minded person is very difficult to comunicate with, and often you can't communicate with that person at all. Dealing with such a person, you may have to resort to a mediator or a court of law to resolve disputes.

Credibility in the sender is important in getting a favorable reaction.

Sender's Credibility. Often people react more according to their attitude toward the *source* of information than to the information itself. A strong Democrat will more likely accept an idea from another Democrat than the same idea from a Republican; a Whig (Great Britain) would do the same with a Tory. In general, people react more favorably to a communicator who has credibility—someone whom they trust and respect. An effective communicator builds credibility by writing and speaking in a fair and just manner and by considering receivers' points of view.

Other Circumstances Affecting Attitudes, Opinions, Responses. When personal, business, or environmental stresses occur, attitudes toward messages may be affected. On a day when personal problems seem overwhelming, a communicator's messages may seem gruff, gloomy, or uncooperative. Life's stresses affect our ability to send effective messages and color our responses when we receive them. Sensitivity to your own state of mind as well as to that of your receiver helps you communicate your messages in a positive way.

NONVERBAL COMMUNICATION

Nonverbal messages often contradict the verbal.

The preceding sections about the communication process focused on *verbal* communication—written or spoken syllables, usually *words*. As Figure 1.3 indicates, we also communicate *nonverbally—without words*. Sometimes nonverbal messages contradict the verbal; often they express feelings more accurately than the spoken or written language.

Checklist 1.2 Aids in Overcoming Communication Problems

1. Meanings
   a. Choose, if possible, the denotative word over the connotative word.
   b. Through audience analysis, select the term with which the audience has had the most experience and understanding.

2. Perceptions of reality
   a. Be sure to provide sufficient information.
   b. Be careful with *allness* terms; not all people will agree.
   c. Choose wisely when *inferring*; enough data must be used to draw a valid conclusion.

3. Values and opinions
   a. Realize that some audiences do not desire information at odds with their own biases and limited information.
   b. Spend sufficient time collecting information that is valid and credible.

Numerous articles and books have been written on the importance of nonverbal messages. Some studies suggest that from 60 to 90 percent of a message's effect comes from nonverbal cues. This section presents a brief overview of nonverbal communication:

- Appearance
- Body language
- Silence, time, and space

How Appearance Communicates

Appearance conveys nonverbal impressions that affect receivers' attitudes toward the verbal message even before they read or hear them.

Effect on Written Messages

The format, neatness, and language of a written message sends a nonverbal message to the reader.

An envelope's appearance—size, color, weight, postage—may impress the receiver as "important," "routine," or "junk" mail. Telegrams, Mailgrams, Express Mail, and private courier mail also have distinctive envelopes that signal urgency and importance. Next, the letter, report, or title page communicates nonverbally before its contents are read by the kind of paper used, its length, format, and neatness. Finally, the language itself, aside from its content, communicates something about the sender. Is it carefully worded and generally correct in mechanics such as spelling, grammar, and punctuation?

Communication Probe

Deborah Tannen, a prominent researcher in the differences in communication styles of men and women, suggests that the two sexes use language in entirely different ways, creating miscommunication on a regular basis. For women, language is the glue that holds relationships together; for men, activities hold relationships together, and language is used to negotiate their position. According to Tannen's research, women suggest and men command. Women react to commands with feelings of being bullied; men perceive women's indirect requests as manipulative. An additional finding is that American men in business settings like to discuss business and not waste time on personal talk. Women, like business people in certain other cultures, feel that personal talk establishes a comfortable relationship that can provide the basis for working together. These differences in style cause confusion and resentment in many cases.

Tannen, D. (1994). *Talking from 9 to 5: How women's and men's conversation styles affect who gets heard, who gets credit, and what's done at work.* New York: Morrow.

One company's "ding" or rejection letter consists of a postcard with various categories listed on the back, such as "insufficient experience," "inferior credentials," and "wouldn't be a good fit in the company." Checks are placed before each relevant category; the postcard is then mailed to the recipient. What does this rejection format suggest about this company?

Effect on Oral Messages

Whether you are speaking to one person face to face or to a group in a meeting, personal appearance and the appearance of your surroundings convey nonverbal stimuli that affect attitudes toward your spoken words. Chapters 14 and 15 discuss nonverbal stimuli in more detail.

Personal Appearance. Clothing, hairstyles, neatness, jewelry, cosmetics, posture, stature are part of personal appearance. They convey impressions regarding occupation, age, nationality, social and economic level, job status, and good or poor judgment, depending on circumstances.

Appearance of Surroundings. Aspects of surroundings include room size, location, furnishings, machines, architecture, wall decorations, floor (carpeted or bare?), lighting, windows, view, and other related features wherever people communicate orally. Surroundings will vary according to status and according to country and culture.

How Body Language Communicates

Included under body language are facial expressions, gestures, posture and movement, smell and touch, and voice and sounds. Chapter 14 has a more developed discussion.

Facial Expressions

Conventions of eye contact are specific to each culture. Eye contact and facial expression can help or hinder your verbal message.

The eyes and face are especially helpful means of communicating nonverbally. They can reveal hidden emotions, including anger, confusion, enthusiasm, fear, joy, surprise, uncertainty, and others. They can also contradict verbal statements.

> *Because he was embarrassed, a new employee answered "yes" when asked by his supervisor if he understood his instructions. Yet, the supervisor should have noticed the employee's bewildered expression and hesitant voice and restated the instructions more clearly.*

In the United States, direct eye contact (but not staring) is considered desirable when two people converse. The person whose eyes droop or shift away from the listener is thought to be either shy or dishonest and untrustworthy. But because people differ, we must be careful not to make a false inference about eye contact.

> *A Puerto Rican student in a New York City High School was thought to be guilty of stealing a backpack because when she was questioned by the principal, she kept her eyes lowered. The truth, however, was that the student was innocent and was merely showing respect to an elder by not looking directly at her questioner.*

Always get additional facts before judging a person's facial expressions conclusively.

Gestures, Posture, and Movement

Posture, gestures, and body movement convey a message and add to or subtract from your oral message.

In some occupations, actions speak louder than words. Employees who direct traffic in crowded streets or in noisy stadiums or who guide trucks when backing up in narrow places effectively communicate by pointing arms or fingers or by tapping on the side of the vehicle to indicate the desired direction. Deaf people communicate with a language primarily composed of hand, finger, and eye movements.

Gestures and movements are culture-specific. The meaning of a gesture in the United States may be completely different in Europe or Asia. In the United States, a clenched fist pounding on the table can indicate either anger or emphasis. Such a display in Asia would be unacceptable. Continual gestures and movement such as pacing back and forth may signal nervousness and may be distracting to listeners. Handshakes reveal attitudes (and sometimes handicaps) by their firmness or limpness.

Legs, too, communicate nonverbal messages. Consider, for example, a man sitting with his legs stretched out on top of his desk during an interview; a person shifting from one leg to the other in rhythmic motion; a woman pacing back and forth while speaking. Posture and movement can convey self-confidence, status, or interest. A confident executive may have a relaxed posture, and yet may stand more erect than a timid subordinate. An interested listener may lean forward toward the speaker; one who is bored may lean away, slump, or glance at the clock.

Smell and Touch

Various odors and fragrances sometimes convey the emotions of the sender and sometimes affect the reactions of the receiver, especially if the receiver is sensitive to scents. Also, touching people can communicate friendship, love, approval, hatred, anger, or other feelings. A kiss on the cheek, pat on the shoulder, or slap on the back is prompted by various emotions. On the other hand, touching in a crowded Japanese train or being pushed at the Tsimshatsui MTR (mass transit railway) in which passengers are squeezed together may be offensive to many North Americans.

Voice and Sounds

Your voice quality and the extra sounds you make while speaking are also a part of nonverbal communication called *paralanguage.* Paralanguage includes voice volume, rate, articulation, pitch, and the other sounds you may make, such as throat clearing and sighing.

> *The words "You did a great job on this project!" could be a compliment. But if the tone of voice is sarcastic and said in the context of criticism, the true meaning is anger.*

A loud voice often communicates urgency while a soft one is sometimes calming. Speaking fast may suggest nervousness or haste. A lazy articulation, slurring sounds or skipping over syllables or words, may reduce credibility. A lack of pitch variation becomes a monotone, while too much variation can sound artificial or overly dramatic. Throat clearing can distract from the spoken words. Emphasizing certain words in a sentence can purposely indicate your feelings about what is important.

Communication Probe

Many writers on business communication emphasize the increasing importance of nonverbal communication in dealing with business people in the international marketplace. One writer's research suggests that, in spoken communication, the words alone are less than 10 percent of the message another person receives. Inflection, tone, emphasis, and other voice qualities account for 28 percent, and the remaining 62 percent is visual. In presentations, rather than using slides with words (often little more than cue cards for the presenter), he advocates replacing words with pictures, charts, and graphs. In international settings, the fewer words a message contains, the less there is to translate and the faster a receiver can respond to information.

Dibble, J. A. (1990, Spring). Communication skills: what they really are, why they matter. *Careers and the MBA* (pp. 47–50). Holbrook, MA: Bob Adams.

How Silence, Time, and Space Communicate

Silence, time, and space can communicate more than you may think, even causing hard feelings, loss of business, and profits. It pays to know these differences across cultures, as you will see in Chapter 3.

Silence

Consider how you feel when you make an oral request that is met with silence. Or think about the confusion you feel when your written message generates no response.

> *Suppose you wrote a request to your supervisor for additional funds for a project you are developing. If you receive no answer for several weeks, what is your reaction? Do you assume that the answer is negative? Do you wonder if your supervisor is merely very busy at the moment and hasn't been able to answer your request? Do you think your supervisor is rude or considers your request unworthy of an answer?*

Time

Concepts of time and space are culture-specific. Effective communicators adapt to senders' and receivers' expectations.

Waiting when an important request is ignored causes problems and attitude changes. In the preceding example, after the long silence, should you ask again? Time is important in many ways. How do you feel when you are kept waiting two hours after the scheduled time for an interview? In U.S. culture, being on time for appointments, for work each day, and for deadlines communicates favorable nonverbal messages.

Concepts of time, however, vary across cultures and even in the United States. Americans and Germans, for example, are quite punctual. Middle eastern business people think little of arriving after an agreed-upon time, not out of discourtesy, but rather a feeling that the task will be accomplished regardless of time. If you arrived on time for a meeting in Portugal, your host might wonder why you came so early. Cultural differences are noted in more detail in Chapter 3.

Space

If you step into an empty elevator, where do you stand? If the elevator then fills up with people, where do you move? The need for personal space decreases as the number of people increases. In the United States, the need for personal space in a two-person conversation is about 18 inches. The need for space is less in many middle eastern countries and more in most Scandinavian countries.

> *Consider the common "dance of the diplomats" in which an American and a Saudi Arabian fall into conversation. The Saudi takes a step forward; the American edges backward; the Saudi advances; the American retreats. By the end of the conversation, the American feels bullied, and the Saudi feels insulted.*

Effective communicators must learn to adapt to both senders' and receivers' expectations regarding space. The key to success is to be aware of the differences.

SUMMARY

Effective business communication is the lifeblood of every organization, a key to success in your career and help in your personal life. The volume and costs of business communication are great; so are challenges and opportunities for those with the right attitude and preparation. When you combine the principles of effective business communication with common sense, you excel in your dealings with others.

Effective communication depends to a large extent on insights into human nature and on the ability to get desirable responses by meeting expectations. It is a complex process that involves context, sender-encoder, message, medium, receiver-decoder, and feedback. This chapter is merely an introduction to the process of communication; it gives you helpful ideas as to why miscommunication problems occur.

To be an effective communicator, realize that human beings' mental filters and experiences differ. Each brings different attitudes, abilities, skills, and cultural customs to the meanings of the words we use. Your message may not always be understood. You may have problems of miscommunicated instructions, with denotations, connotations, and euphemisms, which all interfere with messages between sender and receiver.

Remember also the importance of nonverbal communication—appearance, body language, silence, time, and space. Above all, try to understand your audience, the receiver of your message, and keep an open mind in order to get as many accurate facts as possible. Your ability to do these things will help you communicate effectively.

In the following chapters and appendixes, you will study various principles and strategies. You will find examples and cautions in dealing with typical business situations. You will be asked to think, analyze, solve problems, gather facts, plan, and organize messages according to acceptable procedures for effective business communication

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Deciding on the Medium: Oral or Written?*** Symbols such as flags, songs, religious artifacts, and school insignia stand for something else. How important are symbols to you in your daily life? How far should we go to protect them or to control them? What exactly do they communicate? Discuss the following incident from a communication perspective and answer the above questions.

   You are the American manager for a division of an American company that produces medical products. Your division is located in a small town in southern Germany. The supervisor of the day shift has been with the company for 6 years and is respected and liked by the management of the company. However, he is known to have strong opinions, some of which are unpopular in Germany. One day he brought in an old Nazi flag and tacked it

on the bulletin board. Most of his coworkers were incensed. Some demanded his immediate dismissal. What would you do?

2. ***A Short Informative Report on the Nonverbal Customs of an Asian Country.*** You are the assistant to an architect for an American firm that has been contracted to build a new hospital in Bangkok. Your boss will be spending 2 months in Bangkok supervising the project until it gets under way. He has asked you to prepare a short report outlining the nonverbal customs of Thailand and specifically of Bangkok. Include in your report Thai conventions of time and space, gestures and body language, dress, eating customs, and any other pertinent information.

3. ***Miscommunicating in Translations.*** See if you can interpret the following letter sent from a Japanese supplier to an American company:

```
We are glad to inform you that hand-made samples.
My apology for this belated hand-made samples.
Trial hand-made sample the point at issue.
1. The pump sample is no good. Thickness no equal-
   ity.  By reason of machine is out of order. But
   directly be mended of machine, it is no trouble.
2. This is plate sample no clear and stained with
   grain of good.  But no trouble in case of mass
   production.
You may be well assured we shall exert ourselves to
the utmost to prove ourselves deserving of your
recommendation.

Yours sincerely,
```

Exercises of a General Nature

4. ***Investigation.*** Pick up a copy of a recent *Wall Street Journal* and look at the classified ad section. Conduct a mini-investigation as to how many job positions require communication abilities.

5. ***Handling a Personnel Problem.*** You are the manager of the accounting department in a medium-sized company. One of your accountants has missed 2 weeks of work in the past 2 months, and her work is not being done on a timely basis. How would you handle the situation? Would you speak to her or write a memo? Would you do both: speak and write? If you would speak and write, which would you do first and why?

6. ***Denotative Versus Connotative Words.*** Choose an editorial from the opinion page of a daily newspaper. Underline the words that are denotative; circle the words that are connotative. Discuss the impact of the connotative words and whether the combination of denotative and connotative words is effective.

7. ***Communication Principles.*** What general communication principles do the following statements and incidents illustrate? Discuss each briefly.

a. A friend states: "I'll never buy groceries from Tiptop Market. Haven't been there since the first week they opened 4 years ago. Their produce department is a mess, and prices are too high."

b. A colleague wants more money for a project. He states: "I know our manager is strongly opposed to this project, but I'm just going to barrage him with my reasons until he agrees!"

c. An article in the newspaper states that negotiations in the baseball strike are not making any progress. But the chief negotiator for the owners said he couldn't imagine "how what we offered them was a provocation to continue the strike."

8. ***Inferences Versus Facts.*** Discuss whether each of the following statements is an inference or a verifiable fact based on observation:

a. The boss is a "swinger."

b. Employees over 65 are inefficient.

c. The union requested double pay for each hour of overtime.

d. The union requested too much money.

e. XYZ skis are no good.

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Chapter 2

The Seven C's of Effective Communication

I. Completeness
   A. Provide All Necessary Information
   B. Answer All Questions Asked
   C. Give Something Extra, When Desirable

II. Conciseness
   A. Eliminate Wordy Expressions
   B. Include Only Relevant Material
   C. Avoid Unnecessary Repetition

III. Consideration
   A. Focus on "You" Instead of "I" or "We"
   B. Show Audience Benefit or Interest in the Receiver
   C. Emphasize Positive, Pleasant Facts

IV. Concreteness
   A. Use Specific Facts and Figures
   B. Put Action in Your Verbs
   C. Choose Vivid, Image-Building Words

V. Clarity
   A. Choose Precise, Concrete, and Familiar Words
   B. Construct Effective Sentences and Paragraphs

VI. Courtesy
   A. Be Sincerely Tactful, Thoughtful, and Appreciative
   B. Use Expressions That Show Respect
   C. Choose Nondiscriminatory Expressions

VII. Correctness
   A. Use the Right Level of Language
   B. Check Accuracy of Figures, Facts, and Words
   C. Maintain Acceptable Writing Mechanics

VIII. Summary

IX. Exercises and Problems

To compose effective written or oral messages, you must apply certain communication principles. These principles provide guidelines for choice of content and style of presentation, adapted to the purpose and receiver of your message. Called the "seven C's," they are *completeness, conciseness, consideration, concreteness, clarity, courtesy,* and *correctness,* discussed in that order in this chapter.

All seven C's can apply to both oral and written communication.

Although we deal here with these principles on the sentence level, they are applicable to all forms of communication, from mere utterances and sentences to complete documents or presentations. To some extent the principles overlap because they are based on a common concern for the audience, whether that audience consists of listeners or readers.

COMPLETENESS

Message receivers—either listeners or readers—desire complete information to their questions.

Your business message is *complete* when it contains all facts the reader or listener needs for the reaction you desire. Remember that communicators—senders and receivers—differ in their mental filters; they are influenced by their backgrounds, viewpoints, needs, experiences, attitudes, status, and emotions. Because of these differences, communication senders need to assess their messages through the eyes of receivers to be sure they have included all relevant information.

Completeness offers numerous benefits. First, complete messages are more likely to bring the desired results without the expense of additional messages. Second, they can do a better job of building goodwill. Messages that contain information the receiver needs show concern for others. Third, complete messages can help avert costly lawsuits that may result if important information is missing. Last, communications that seem inconsequential can be surprisingly important if the information they contain is complete and effective.

As you strive for completeness, keep the following guideliness in mind:

- Provide all necessary information.
- Answer all questions asked.
- Give something extra, when desirable.

Provide All Necessary Information

Answering the five W's helps make messages clear: who, what, when, where, and why.

When you initiate a message, check to make sure you have provided all the information the reader needs for thorough, accurate understanding. One way to help make your message complete is to answer the five W questions—*who, what, when, where, why*—and any other essentials, such as *how.* The five-question method is especially useful when you write requests, announcements, or other informative messages. For instance, to order (request) merchandise, make clear *what* you want, *when* you need it, to *whom* and *where* it is to be sent, and *how* payment will be made. To reserve a hotel banquet room, specify the accommodations needed (*what*), location (*where*), sponsoring organization (*who*), date and time (*when*), event (*why*), and other necessary details (*how*).

Answer All Questions Asked

Whenever you reply to an inquiry, try to answer all questions—stated and implied. A colleague or prospective customer's reaction to an incomplete reply is likely to be unfavorable. The customer may think the respondent is careless or is purposely trying to conceal a weak spot. In general, "omissions cast suspicions," whether you are answering an inquiry about your product or recommending a former employee for a new job. If you have no information on a particular question, say so clearly. If you have unfavorable information in answer to certain questions, handle your reply with both tact and honesty.

Look for questions: some may even appear buried within a paragraph. Locate them and then answer precisely.

In one example, a software distributor, when replying to a dealer's letter, answered only four of seven questions. Because the original questions were unnumbered and somewhat buried in five long paragraphs, the respondent apparently overlooked or disregarded three of them. The reply, incomplete and unfriendly, caused the distributor to lose the business and goodwill of a potential customer.

Sometimes before you can answer an inquiry, you need certain specific information from the inquirer. If so it is a good idea to list the needed details on a reply form that the inquirer can fill out and return to you. In this way both your answer and that of your respondent will be complete.

Give Something Extra, When Desirable

The words "when desirable," in the above heading, are essential. Sometimes you must do more than answer the customers' specific questions. They may not

Communication Probe

Credibility of the communicator has been systematically analyzed over the years, often as relating to the speaker. Several classic, but still relevant, studies suggest that five decisions are made regarding a communication source:

- Competence: Does the sender of the message know his or her message?
- Character: Does the audience perceive the message sender as communicating honestly?
- Composure: Does the sender give the impression of being calm and collected, particularly in a stressful situation?
- Sociability: Does the sender come across as a likable individual?
- Extroversion: Does the source exhibit outgoing tendencies rather than timidity?

McCroskey, J. C., Holridge, W. & Toomb, J. K. (1974). An instrument for measuring the source credibility of basic speech communication instructors. *Speech Teacher,* 23, 26–33; McCroskey, H. C., Jensen, T. & Todd, C. (1972). The generalizability of source credibility scales for public figures. *Paper, Speech Communication Association,* Chicago; McCroskey, J. C., Jensen, T., Todd, C. & Toomb, J. K. (1972), and many others.

know what they need, or their questions may be inadequate. For example, suppose you are president of your local Rotary Club and receive the following inquiry from an out-of-town member:

> I'm new to the city and would like to consider joining your club. As I will be visiting your club within the month, will you please tell me where the next meeting will be held?

Use your good judgment in offering additional material if the sender's message was incomplete.

If you answered only this one question, your letter would be incomplete. Realizing that your reader is a newcomer to your city and to your Rotary Club, you should include in your reply a welcome plus such needed details as directions for reaching the building; parking facilities; day, date, and time of meeting; and perhaps also the program for the next meeting. Your message will then have the "something extra" that a reader really needs and appreciates. In most cases the reason the communicator includes something extra will be obvious; whenever it is not completely clear, explain why you are including the additional information.

Here are some additional examples of incomplete questions in faxes and one letter.

FAX 1 *Incomplete question.*

> Please fax me in return the departures from Singapore to Hong Kong on the 8th.

In responding to the above you would have to "give something extra" as to times of day, airlines flying that route, costs, and departure and arrival times.

FAX 2 *Incomplete question.*

> How come my request for an interview letter did not receive a response?

When was letter sent? Who sent it? To whom was it sent? In other words, to answer fax 2 would require a return letter or fax seeking answers to the above questions.

LETTER 1 *Incomplete letter to a new savings depositor.*

> Thank you for the confidence you have shown us by the account you recently opened.
>
> All our facilities are at your disposal, and anytime we can be of service, please call on us. Our appreciation is best expressed by our being of service to you.

LETTER 1 *Revised, complete letter to the new savings depositor.*

Thank you for the confidence you have shown in First Federal by the savings account you recently opened. Our goal is to make all our services to you both pleasant and helpful.

Among the conveniences and services available to you at First Federal, you may be especially interested in these:

YOUR PASSBOOK DEPOSITS earn 6½% interest compounded monthly.

BETTER-THAN-CHECKING service helps you pay bills by phone, earns interest on your money, and permits using our 24-hour cash machines.

MORTGAGE LOANS help you to buy, build, or refinance a home or to borrow for property repairs and improvements.

With our MONEY MARKET CERTIFICATES you can earn interest at various current high rates, depending on time and amount of your investment. The enclosed leaflet gives you more details about these and other services available to you at First Federal.

FREE CUSTOMER PARKING is provided in the lot north of our office. The teller stamps your parking slip, entitling you to free parking while doing business here. Office hours are 9:30 A.M. to 4:30 P.M. weekdays except for Friday, when the doors remain open until 6:00 P.M.

You are most welcome to come in whenever we can assist you. Please consider this association your financial headquarters for your savings and borrowing needs.

Checklist 2.1 Completeness

1. Remember the five W's:
   Who? What? When? Where? Why?
2. Answer all questions:
   a. Stated questions from questioner.
   b. Implied questions from questioner.
3. Give extra information, when desirable.

Communication Probe

Completeness means that you tell your reader what he or she wants to know about your service or product. It involves laying out the benefits of what you are selling; it means imagining every reader to have a "show me" attitude. Readers must be convinced; they have to be shown results from simple reading. Therefore writers must be thorough. Informative selling will give the buyer confidence and increase later satisfaction with the purchased product or service. Such completeness will also reduce the number of goods returned to the firm.

On writing a sales letter. (ND). *Royal Bank of Canada, 43,* 3.

CONCISENESS

Conciseness is saying what you have to say in the fewest possible words without sacrificing the other C qualities. A concise message is complete without being wordy.

Conciseness is a prerequisite to effective business communication. A concise message saves time and expense for both sender and receiver. Conciseness contributes to emphasis; by eliminating unnecessary words, you let important ideas stand out. When combined with a "you-view," concise messages are inherently more interesting to recipients. Finally, concise messages show respect for recipients by not cluttering their professional lives with unnecessary information.

To achieve conciseness, observe the following suggestions:

- Eliminate wordy expressions.
- Include only relevant material.
- Avoid unnecessary repetition.

Eliminate Wordy Expressions

The following are some concrete suggestions you can use to reduce wordiness in your communication.

1. Use single-word substitutes instead of phrases whenever possible without changing meanings.

Use single words in place of phrases. Even Winston Churchill made extensive use of simple, one syllable words.

Wordy: At this time
Concise: Now

Wordy: Due to the fact that
Concise: Because

Wordy: Have need for
Concise: Need

Wordy: In due course
Concise: Soon

2. Omit trite, unnecessary expressions.

Wordy: Please be advised that your admission statement was received.
Concise: Your admission statement has been received.

Wordy: Allow me to say how helpful your response was.
Concise: Your last response was helpful.

3. Replace wordy conventional statements with concise versions.

Wordy: Please find attached the list you requested.
Concise: The list you requested is attached.

Wordy: Such refreshing comments are few and far between.
Concise: Such refreshing comments are scarce.

4. Avoid overusing empty phrases.

Wordy: It was known by Mr. Smith that we must reduce inventory.
Concise: Mr. Smith knew we must reduce inventory.

Wordy: There are four rules that should be observed.
Concise: Four rules should be observed.

5. Omit "which" and "that" clauses whenever possible.

Wordy: She bought desks that are of the executive type.
Concise: She bought executive-type desks.

Wordy: The receipt that is enclosed documents your purchase.
Concise: The enclosed recipt documents your purchase.

Use your computer grammar check or let someone else check whether you have overused certain words; dullness may result from the same word or idea being repeated too often.

6. Eliminate unnecessary prepositional phrases.

Wordy: The issue of most relevance is teamwork.
Concise: The most relevant issue is teamwork.

Wordy: In most cases the date of the policy is indicated in the upper right corner.
Concise: The policy date is in the upper right corner.

7. Limit use of the passive voice.

Wordy: The total balance due will be found on page 2 of this report.
Concise: The balance due is on page 2 of this report.

Wordy: The reports are to be submitted by employees prior to 5:00, at which time they will be received by Mr. Jones.
Concise: Please submit your reports to Mr. Jones by 5:00.

In all attempts to reduce wordiness, you must be careful to not distort meaning. Conciseness reflects the thoughtful elimination of unnecessary words.

Include Only Relevant Material

The effective, concise message should omit not only unnecessarily wordy expressions but also irrelevant statements. To be sure you include only relevant facts, observe the following suggestions.

1. Stick to the purpose of the message.
2. Delete irrelevant words and rambling sentences.

Communication Probe

Wordiness has been the bane of writers—and speakers—since humans began to communicate. The word used to describe such circumlocution is *tautology,* or using two or more words to express a simple and single thought. Often we have implied that business communciation can be dull: it tends to lack modifiers, it avoids excessive use of superfluous—or should—words. Yet, writers of reports or other forms of communication should follow the maxim, "once is often enough."

Alexander, D. & Rivett, A. (1995, Spring). Once is often enough. *Journal of Management Consulting, 8,* 32.

3. Omit information obvious to the receiver; do not repeat at length what that person has already told you. If you feel it is important to remind the audience of known information, subordinate the familiar information.
4. Avoid long introductions, unnecessary explanations, excessive adjectives and prepositions, pompous words, gushy politeness.
5. Get to the important point tactfully and concisely.

Wordy: We hereby wish to let you know that our company is pleased with the confidence you have reposed in us.
Concise: We appreciate your confidence.

Wordy: At this time I am writing to you to enclose an interview card, which has been post-paid, for the purpose of arranging a convenient time when we might get together for a personal interview.
Concise: Please return the enclosed interview card to set up a convenient time for an interview.

Avoid Unnecessary Repetition

Unnecessary repetition leads to dullness.

Sometimes repetition is necessary for emphasis. But when the same thing is said two or three times without reason, the message becomes wordy and boring. Here are three ways to eliminate unnecessary repetition:

1. Use a shorter name after you have mentioned the long one once. Instead of the "North Central Company," use "North Central."
2. Use pronouns or initials rather than repeat long names. Instead of citing "American Association of Technical Analysts" again and again, use "it" or "they" or AATA. When using well-known initials or acronyms, give the full reference first with the initials in parentheses: The North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA) is being debated in Congress.
3. Cut out all needless repetition of phrases and sentences. Sometimes it is possible to combine two or even more sentences by using subordinate clauses or phrases.

The following letter from a business executive to a firm the company had dealt with for 5 years shows unnecessary repetition at its worst.

Wordy: Will you ship us sometime, anytime during the month of October would be fine, or even November if you are rushed (November would suit us just as well, in fact a little bit better) 300 of the regular 3- by 15-inch blue felt armbands with white sewn letters in the center.

Checklist 2.2 Conciseness

1. Use one word in place of phrases; one sentence in place of two. Read out loud to "listen" for wordiness.
2. Omit outdated trite expressions.
3. Ask yourself: What material is really relevant?
4. Look for unnecessary repetition: Does the same word or idea appear too often?

Thank you in advance for sending these along to us by parcel post, and not express, as express is too expensive.

Concise: Please ship parcel post, before the end of November, 300 regular 3- by 15-inch blue felt armbands with white sewn letters in the center.

CONSIDERATION

Consideration means preparing every message with the message receivers in mind; try to put yourself in their place: You are considerate, you do not lose your temper, you do not accuse, you do not charge them without facts. You are, foremost, aware of their desires, problems, circumstances, emotions, and probable reactions to your request. Then handle the matter from their point of view. This thoughtful consideration is also called "you-attitude," empathy, the human touch, and understanding of human nature.

In a broad but true sense, consideration underlies the other six C's of good business communication. You adapt your language and message content to your receiver's needs when you make your message complete. Three specific ways to indicate consideration are:

- Focus on "you" instead of "I" and "we."
- Show audience benefit or interest in the receiver.
- Emphasize positive, pleasant facts.

Focus on "You" Instead of "I" or "We"

Using "you" does help project a you-attitude. But overuse can lead to a negative reaction.

To create considerate, audience-oriented messages, focus on how message receivers will benefit, what they will receive, and what they want or need to know. In some cases, this can be accomplished by emphasis; you might downplay your own feelings and emphasize a point, make an explicit reference, or use a direct quotation in responding to the request of another individual. Creating a you-attitude may require avoiding telling others how they feel, assuming you know their needs.

We-Attitude: I am delighted to announce that we will be extending our hours to make shopping more convenient.

You-Attitude: You will be able to shop evenings with the extended hours.

We-Attitude: We're sure you must be frustrated by the length of time it has taken to ship your order for Polish gargoyles.

You-Attitude: The Polish gargoyles you ordered will reach you within a week.

Showing consideration for the audience involves more than just using "you" instead of "I" or "we." Messages that use "we" can be receiver-oriented if "we" includes the recipient of the message. Messages that use "you" can be insensitive in negative situations. In fact, sometimes avoiding "you" can reduce potential defensiveness or allow the recipient to save face. An extreme example of a negative situation is the collection letter with "you" or "your" in almost every sentence; if those sentences are insulting, sarcastic, tactless, or untrue accusations and threats against the debtor, the letter surely lacks a you-attitude. The use of "you" in negative situations can be avoided by employing the passive voice, making the receiver part of a group, or depersonalizing the situation.

Insensitive: You failed to enclose your check in the envelope.
Considerate: The check was not enclosed. [*passive voice*]
Considerate: The envelope we received did not have a check in it. [*depersonalized*]

Insensitive: Your contract tells you plainly that . . .
Considerate: I'm always happy to discuss the contract terms with new employees. [*receiver as part of group*]

Insensitive: You are completely off base in your proposal.
Considerate: We have differing interpretations of the utility of the proposal. [*sender-oriented with acceptance of responsibility*]
Considerate: The proposed plan has three aspects that need clarification. [*depersonalized*]

Show Audience Benefit or Interest in the Receiver

Readers may react positively when benefits are shown them.

Whenever possible and true, show how your receivers will benefit from whatever the message asks or announces. Benefits must meet recipients' needs, address their concerns, or offer them rewards. Most important, they must be perceived as benefits by the receivers. This means that you must identify the

legitimate benefits of your position, policy, or product and then put yourself in the place of the receivers to assess their perspectives.

Receivers will be more likely to react favorably and do what you suggest if you show that benefits are worth the effort and cost you ask of them. In situations where actual direct benefit is impossible or irrelevant to the subject matter, the message should at least show interest in and concern for the recipient's needs or viewpoints.

Merely inserting the word "you" does not ensure you-attitude, as shown in this sentence: "You will be glad to know that we now have a walk-up window open 7–9 A.M. and 3–8 P.M. every weekday." Some readers wonder, "So what?" The following revised sentence includes reader benefit: "You can now take care of your banking needs at our new Walk-Up Window. It is open with a capable teller to serve you 7–9 A.M. and 3–8 P.M. Monday through Friday."

Reader-benefit appeals help collect payments on bills, soften the blow in a turndown, and sell products. Such appeals are desirable also in job applications, favor requests, and announcements to your customers, prospective buyers, stockholders, and employees. Whether you are writing to one person or to large numbers, try to personalize the reader benefits instead of stating them in a general way. Benefits that are realistic, inherent, and tailored to individuals help communicators achieve goals in effective, ethical ways.

Emphasize Positive, Pleasant Facts

A third way to show consideration for your receivers is to accent the positive. This means stressing what can be done instead of what cannot be done, and focusing on words your recipient can consider favorably.

Negative—Unpleasant	Positive—Pleasant
It is impossible to open an account for you today.	As soon as your signature card reaches us, we will gladly open an . . .
We don't refund if the returned item is soiled and unsalable.	We refund when the returned item is clean and resalable.
When you travel on company expense, you will not receive approval for first-class fare.	When you travel on company expense, your approved fare is for tourist class.

Because of past connections with words, readers will react positively or negatively to certain words.

Among the *positive* words to which people react *favorably* are *benefit, cordial, happy, help, generous, loyal, pleasure, thanks, thoughtful.* Words with *negative* connotations that often arouse *unfavorable* reactions include *blame, complaint, failed, fault, negligence, regret, reject, trouble, unfair,* and many others. For example, in the following opening of a letter the negative words (underlined) focus on ideas you'd rather not have the reader think about.

> We regret that, since you closed your account, your name will be missing from our long list of satis-

Checklist 2.3 Consideration

1. See your material from your reader's point of view.
2. "You" is more desirable than "I" or "we" in most instances.
3. Readers like to see benefits. Be sure benefits are a prominent part of the message.
4. Consciously use positive words; readers will react more favorably.

fied customers. We sincerely hope that, despite the best effors of our fine staff, there were no occasions on which you felt we failed to serve you properly.

As a final note, true consideration is a result of integrity and ethics in communication. Because the topic of ethics and communication is so important, we treat it in a separate chapter.

CONCRETENESS

Misunderstandings of words have produced tragedies in both war and peace, in business and nonbusiness situations.

Communicating *concretely* means being specific, definite, and vivid rather than vague and general. Often it means using denotative (direct, explicit, often dictionary-based) rather than connotative words (ideas or notions suggested by or associated with a word or phrase). Thus the term *female* may appear in a personnel folder as a part of a job description, yet widely different connotations may occur when using terms as *wife, mother, spinster, widow, maiden, matron,* or *dowager.* Each of these latter terms also refers to *female* but with wide-ranging associations.

Communication Probe

Some letter writers are completely absorbed in the things about which they are writing, about quantities and qualities, about dollars and delivery. To become intelligible and effective, they need to enrich their thoughts by spreading them out to include people. At the core of good writing is audience analysis, audience adaptation.

Some persons will say that business is objective, mechanical, dealing with commodities and services rather than with people. How absurd it is to say so when every businessperson knows that every sale, every purchase, every contact, every financial deal, depends upon the word "yes" or "no" from some human being.

On Writing Clearly. (ND). *Royal Bank of Canada Letter, 38,* 7.

The benefits to business professionals of using concrete facts and figures are obvious: your receivers know exactly what is required or desired. Using concrete language has some additional, less obvious advantages. When you supply specifics for the reader or listener, you increase the likelihood that your message will be interpreted the way you intended. Moreover, concrete messages are more richly textured than general or vague messages; thus, they tend to be more vivid, dynamic, and interesting. The following guidelines should help you compose concrete, convincing messages.

- Use specific facts and figures.
- Put action in your verbs.
- Choose vivid, image-building words.

Use Specific Facts and Figures

It is desirable to be precise and concrete in both written and oral business communication.

Whenever possible, use an exact, precise statement or a figure in place of a general word to make your message more concrete.

Vague, General, Indefinite	Concrete, Precise
Student GMAT scores are higher.	In 1996 the GMAT scores averaged 600; by 1997 they had risen to 610.
Eastern Europe is making progress in obtaining investments.	In 1990 investments in Eastern Europe were about US $30 million; today that figure has increased by 12%.
She's a brain.	Her grade-point average in 1996 was 3.9 on a four-point scale.

Note in the above examples that some of the vague words are opinion words. What is *higher*? What do we mean by *progress*? What does being a *brain* mean?

For example, the following words can also lead to uncertainty, confusion:

slightly	small	soon	early	high	about
most	a few	slow	very	almost	several

Of course it is permissible—even desirable—to use general expressions. But note some exceptions to the "facts and figures" rule:

1. When it is not possible to be specific: "You may not have the precise figures or facts."
2. When you wish to be diplomatic (considerate): "You have missed three invitations to my office" is harsh; you may be more tactful by saying "I've sent you several reminders to see me in my office."
3. When exact figures are unimportant, as in "more than half the committee was present."

Put Action in Your Verbs

Verbs can activate other words and help make your sentences alive, more vigorous. That is, to have dynamic sentences (1) use active rather than passive verbs and (2) put action in your verbs rather than in nouns and infinitives.

Use the Active Voice

When the subject performs the action described by the verb, the verb is said to be in the active voice. Usually the active voice puts the verb up front. "The financial officer *reported* to the Board." Here the subject (the financial officer) reported; the verb "reported" is active, is up front in the sentence.

Conversely, when the subject receives the action of the verb, the verb is in the passive voice: ("The report by the financial officer was heard by the Board.") A passive verb has three characteristics:

- The subject does not do the acting in a sentence.
- The verb consists of two or more words, one of which is in some form of "to be" (is, is being, am, are, was, were, will be, has, or have been, had been, or will have been).
- The word "by" is expressed or implied (by whom or what).

Passive (Subject Receives the Action)	Active (Subject Performs the Action)
The tests were administered by the professors.	Professors administered the tests.
Grades of students will be sent to you by the school.	The school will send students their grades.

When the subject acts there is more life, vividness.

Active verbs help make your sentences more

1. *Specific.* "The dean decided" is more explicit than "A decision has been made."
2. *Personal.* "You will note" is both personal and specific; "It will be noted" is impersonal."
3. *Concise.* The passive requires more words and thus slows both writing and reading. Compare "Figures show" with "It is shown by figures."
4. *Emphatic.* Passive verbs dull action. Compare "The students held a contest" with "A contest was held by the students."

Sometimes, however, you may prefer the passive voice instead of the active, as in the following situations:

1. *When you want to avoid personal, blunt accusations or comments.* "The October check was not included" is more tactful than "You failed to include. . . ." "Attendance at the meeting is required" is less harsh than "You must attend. . . ."

2. *When you want to stress the object of the action.* In "Your savings account is insured up to $100,000," you have intentionally stressed "your account"—not the firm that does the insuring. Also, "You are invited" is better than "We invite you."
3. *When the doer isn't important in the sentence.* In "Three announcements were made before the meeting started," the emphasis is on the announcements, not on who gave them.

Put Action in Verbs, Not in Nouns

Verbs propel thought; they move ideas in place of slower-moving nouns.

Seven verbs—*be, give, have, hold, make, put,* and *take*—(in any tense) might be designated as "deadly" when the action they introduce is hidden in a "quiet noun." The examples below show how each deadly verb with the noun and preposition (all underlined) can be changed to an action verb that shortens the sentence.

Action Hiding in a "Quiet" Noun	Action in the Verb
The function of this office is the collection of payments and the compilation of statements.	This office collects payments and compiles statements.
Professor H. will give consideration to the report.	Professor H. will consider the report.
The proposal has a requirement for . . .	The proposal requires that . . .
Students held the meeting in the office.	Students met in the office.

Put Action in Verbs, Not in Infinitives

Action Hiding in Infinitive	Action in the Verb
The duty of a secretary is to check all incoming mail and to record it. In addition, it is his or her responsibility to keep the assignment book up to date.	A secretary checks and records all incoming mail mail and keeps the assignment book up to date.

Choose Vivid, Image-Building Words

Business writing uses less figurative language than does the world of fiction.

Among the devices you can use to make your messages forceful, vivid, and specific are sensory appeals, comparisons, figurative language, concrete nouns, and well-chosen adjectives and adverbs. But use these devices with caution: business writing uses fewer descriptors than does a magazine article or fictional writing.

Checklist 2.4 Concreteness

1. Were you precise in using facts and figures wherever possible?
2. Did you use the active voice more than the passive?
3. Is there action in verbs rather than in nouns or infinitives?
4. Did you try to occasionally use vivid, image-building words? But in business writing, use them sparingly.

Sensory Appeal

Concrete language often evokes a sensory response in people; it appeals to one or more of the five senses. Such language tends to be more descriptive than conventional business language. For example, instead of saying "It was hot in the factory," you might appeal to both sight and touch by saying "Sweat trickled down the arms of the line workers"; or "The secretary's face was wrinkled after squinting into the computer the entire day." Although sensory appeals are used primarily in marketing products, they also have a limited place in providing color and specificity in other forms of business communication.

Comparisons

Analogies (either figurative or literal) or comparisons can make an unclear idea clear or make an idea more vivid. Compare the bland images in the left column with those in the right column:

Bland Image	More Vivid Image
Proposals submitted this quarter were uninteresting.	Too many simple sentences, too many simplistic ideas gave the impression of the writing of a first-year student.
This is a long letter.	This letter is three times as long as you said it would be.

Figurative Language

Use figures of speech with caution. When used sparingly they do make an idea more vivid. Consider the following three examples.

Literal (and Dull)	More Vivid, Figurative
Her work in groups was exemplary.	She could be called "the spark plug of the group."
Some women were stopped in their promotions.	Many women faced the "glass ceiling" in their company.

Communication Probe

In the ancient world, rhetoricians (teachers of oral communication) suggested that ornateness in language was a significant part of communication. Indeed, there were communication practitioners and theorists who argued that ornateness in words and their use within a sentence were core to effective communication.

Such heavy emphasis on ornate communication slowly disappeared in communication texts in the Renaissance and later. Organization of ideas, support for those ideas replaced the micro divisions and subdivisions of how to be more ornate in communication. Today ornateness in communication is more characteristic of honorary degree citations or keynote speeches at political conventions. Metaphors (implied comparisons between two things) are modern day uses of figures of speech thoroughly discussed in ancient communication texts. Business communication today uses few forms of ornateness.

Hildebrandt, H. W. (1988). Some influences of Greek and Roman rhetoric on early letter writing. *The Journal of Business Communication, 25*(3), 7–26.

Literal (and Dull)	More Vivid, Figurative
Our budget analysis will begin soon.	This is the first shot across your bow as we begin to review your budget for next year.

CLARITY

Getting the meaning from your head into the head of your reader—*accurately*—is the purpose of *clarity*. Of course, you know this is not simple. We all carry around our own unique interpretations, ideas, experiences associated with words.

- Choose precise, concrete and familiar words.
- Construct effective sentences and paragraphs.

Choose Precise, Concrete, and Familiar Words

Clarity is achieved in part through a balance between precise language and familiar language. When you use precise or concrete language, you select exactly the right word to convey your meaning. Precise words need not be pretentious. When you use familiar language, you select a word that is part of your personal repertoire, familiar to the audience, and appropriate for the situation. Familiar words, as between two good friends, for example, are often conversational, and occasionally may be part of a speech or written communication.

When you have a choice between a long word and a short one, use the short, familiar word that your reader or listener will quickly understand. Also, use synonyms instead of Latin terms (L) if they, though short, may be unfamiliar to your audience.

When in doubt, use more familiar words; audiences will understand them better.

Familiar	Pretentious
about	circa (L)
after	subsequent
home	domicile
for example	e.g. (L)
pay	remuneration
invoice	statement for payment

Notice how the following statement with unfamiliar words is expressed clearly in the revision using familiar words.

Unfamiliar: After our perusal of pertinent data, the conclusion is that a lucrative market exists for the subject property.

Familiar: The data we studied show that your property is profitable and in high demand.

Although it is appropriate to use technical terms and business jargon in some professional situations, avoid it when you communicate with a person who is not acquainted with the terminology. If you must use such terms, define them briefly and clearly. If you don't, you'll confuse, embarrass, or irritate the reader. You may even be forced to explain later, as in the following classic story:

A plumber wrote the National Bureau of Standards to tell them hydrochloric acid is good for cleaning out clogged drains. (Before you go any further into the story, visualize the plumber. Assume you don't know him and have never exchanged correspondence. It is a pretty good guess he isn't a college graduate—maybe he didn't finish high school. But he probably is a good plumber—at least conscientious—because he's writing to the bureau to tell them something he thinks will help other people.)

In reply to the plumber's message, a technical specialist of the bureau wrote:

The efficacy of hydrochloric acid is indisputable, but the corrosive residue is incompatible with metallic permanence.

The plumber then wrote to thank the bureau for agreeing with him—when, of course, the bureau was actually disagreeing with him. Sensing the plumber didn't understand, another member tried to set the man straight by writing:

We cannot assume responsibility for the production of toxic and noxious residue with hydrochloric acid, and suggest you use an alternative procedure.

Again the plumber thanked the bureau. Then, in desperation, the department manager wrote:

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Don't use hydrochloric acid.  It eats hell out of
the pipes.
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As we have said and will say throughout the book, understanding the audience helps writers choose familiar words: those known by the speaker and the listener. Here are just a few examples.

Possibly Unfamiliar	Familiar to the Layperson
assessed valuation	property value for tax purposes
charge to your principal	increase the balance of your loan
easement for ingress and egress	allows passage in and out
buyouts	purchased by another company
scribbler's compacts	letters passed along to which readers added comments

With the increased use of E-mail there is the tendency to be concise. The danger is that you must know the meaning of the E-mail acronyms which aid conciseness. For instance how many of the following abbreviations do you know? IMO, FAQ, LOL, MOTOS. Respectively: in my opinion, frequently asked question, laughing out loud, member of the opposite sex.

Construct Effective Sentences and Paragraphs

At the core of clarity is the sentence. This grammatical statement, when clearly expressed, moves thoughts within a paragraph. Important characteristics to consider are length, unity, coherence, and emphasis.

Length

Try for an average sentence length of between 17 and 20 words.

Generally, short sentences are preferred. The suggested average sentence length should be about 17 to 20 words. Because variety in sentence length adds interest to writing, adopt a range of from 3 to 30 or more words. But when a sentence exceeds 40 words, try to rewrite it into more than one sentence. Also, if all sentences are short (under 10 words), the result is primerlike language—choppy and overly simple.

Unity

In a sentence—whether simple, compound, or complex—unity means that you have one main idea, and any other ideas in the sentence must be closely related to it. "I like Jim, and the Eiffel Tower is in Paris" obviously is not a unified sentence.

Coherence

In a coherent sentence the words are correctly arranged so that the ideas clearly express the intended meaning. Place the correct modifier as close as possible to the word it is supposed to modify. In the following examples notice why each "unclear" sentence conveys a wrong meaning, and how it is corrected in the "clear" sentence.

Communication Probe

A former assistant managing editor of the *New York Times,* Theodore Bernstein, summarized a series of studies in his classic book—*Watch Your Language*—concerned with one question: Why were some newspaper writers considered more understandable than their colleagues? On review of the newspaper stories, one fact stood out: The more understandable writer used more short sentences. One study compared a journal article with few sentences with the same story with many sentences.

	Longer Sentence Version	Shorter Sentence Version
Number of words	271	265
Total sentences	5	21
Average words per sentence	54	12

After two groups of students took comprehension tests on what they had read, the shorter sentence version resulted in a comprehension level of 64 percent as against 9 percent in the longer sentence version.

Bernstein, T. (1958). *Watch your language* (p. 112). New York: Channel Press.

Unclear: Being an excellent lawyer, I am sure you can help us.
Clear: Being an excellent lawyer, you can surely help us.
Clear: As you are an excellent lawyer, I am sure you . . .

Unclear: His report was about managers, broken down by age and gender.
Clear: His report focused on age and gender of managers.
Clear: His report about managers focused on . . .

Unclear: After planting 10,000 berry plants, the deer came into our botanist's farm and crushed them.
Clear: After our botanist had planted 10,0000 berry plants, the deer came into his farm and crushed them.

Emphasis

Most often, put main ideas up front within a sentence.

The quality that gives force to important parts of sentences and paragraphs is emphasis. Writers must decide what needs emphasis, and then choose correct sentence structure. In a complex sentence the main idea should be placed in the

Checklist 2.5 Clarity

1. Choose as precise or as concrete a word as possible.
2. Select words that have a high sense of appropriateness for the reader.
3. Opt for the familiar word, the one that is not pretentious.
4. Limit average sentence length to 17 to 20 words.
5. Insert no more than one main idea into a sentence.
6. Arrange words so that the main idea occurs early in a sentence.

main clause; the less important points are in subordinate (dependent) clauses or phrases.

For instance, in the first sentence below, the two ideas appear to be of equal value. In contrast, if the important idea is that the "airplane was difficult to control," the second sentence would be more meaningful and emphatic; its main idea is in the main clause.

Little emphasis: The airplane finally approached the speed of sound, and it became very difficult to control.

Better emphasis: As it finally approached the speed of sound, the airplane became very difficult to control.

Little emphasis: Candidates should be motivated and have interest in static and dynamic testing of material, and have those prerequisites and others.

Better emphasis: Prerequisites in candidates should include expertise in static and dynamic testing of material.

In addition to using the above methods for emphasis, the PCs of today—and related software—allow innumerable ways to visually add emphasis to words. Though it is impossible to list all of them, some visual procedures include: headings, tabulations, itemizations, graphs, line charts, pie charts, underlinings, italics, indentations, colored capitals or italics, or even wide or short margins. The visual innovations are endless.

COURTESY

Knowing your audience allows you to use statements of courtesy; be aware of your message receiver.

True *courtesy* involves being aware not only of the perspective of others, but also their feelings. Courtesy stems from a sincere you-attitude. It is not merely politeness with mechanical insertions of "please" and "thank you," although applying socially accepted manners is a form of courtesy. Rather, it is politeness that grows out of respect and concern for others.

In addition to following the guidelines discussed under "Consideration," courteous communicators generate a special tone in their writing and speaking. The following are suggestions for generating a courteous tone:

- Be sincerely tactful, thoughtful, and appreciative.
- Use expressions that show respect.
- Choose nondiscriminatory expressions.

Be Sincerely Tactful, Thoughtful, and Appreciative

Tact

Though few people are intentionally abrupt or blunt, these negative traits are a common cause of discourtesy. Sometimes they stem from a mistaken idea of conciseness, sometimes from negative personal attitudes, sometimes from not knowing the culture of a country or even groups of people. Avoid expressions like those in the left-hand column below; rephrase them as shown in the right-hand column.

Tactless, Blunt	More Tactful
Stupid letter; I can't understand any of it.	It's my understanding . . .
Clearly, you did not read my latest fax.	Sometimes my wording is not precise; let me try again.
I rewrote that letter three times; the point was clear.	I'm sorry the point was not clear; here is another version.

E-mail messages are short and often informal.

Writing a letter to a customer outside the company requires more "niceties" than writing an E-mail within your company. A one-sentence internal E-mail to a colleague could be this short:

> Phil, give me a call at #41279 and give me the number of the report you're sending along to the VP.

A fax or letter to a foreign company would not be as short, or blunt; instead, add a few more tactful words:

> It was kind of you to write and extend holiday greetings. Here in the States the Christmas season is a high point of the year. Thank you for your regards.
>
> Because our company receives many reports from China and your company, we need the number of the report you sent us in October. We need this in order that our electronic files can easily find it

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in the system.  We then wish to send the report
along to our Vice President of Marketing.
```

Thoughtfulness and Appreciation

Writers who send cordial, courteous messages of deserved congratulations and appreciation (to persons both inside and outside the firm) help build goodwill. The value of goodwill or public esteem for the firm may be worth thousands (or millions) of dollars. Be especially thoughtful and courteous when communicating with Asian cultures: they like the soft, more polite approach in both oral and written communication.

Use Expressions That Show Respect

No reader wants to receive messages that offend. Such expressions are discussed in two groups: irritating expressions and questionable humor.

Omit Irritating Expressions

Following is a consensus list; that is, it includes a list of expressions many people find irritating. Avoid these expressions, particularly used with "you" or "your":

contrary to your inference
delinquency (delinquent)
I do not agree with you
if you care
I'm sure you must realize
inexcusable
irresponsible
obnoxious
obviously you overlooked
owing to your questionable credit we are unable to
simply nonsense
surely you don't expect
we are amazed you can't
we don't believe
we expect you to
we find it difficult to believe that
we must insist
we take issue
why have you ignored
you are delinquent
you are probably ignorant of the fact that
you claim that
you did not tell us
you failed to
you forgot to
you have to
you leave us no choice
you neglected to (overlooked)
you say
you should know
you surely don't expect
your apparent disregard of our previous request leaves us no alternative
your complaint
your failure to
your insinuation
your neglect
your stubborn silence

Omit Questionable Humor

When in doubt as to the relevance of humor, leave it out.

Laughter to one person is disgust for another; each of us has a different sense of humor. A flippant attitude can be in poor taste, as seen in the following note. When in doubt be more formal. The second note is also informal, but courteous.

NOTE: 1 *Offensive*

Hey man, what's this I hear about the good news? You sure pulled a fast one this past weekend-and then didn't tell any of us about it.

Give my regards to the little lady. And wish her the best; she'll need it.

NOTE 2 *More courteous*

Warm congratulations on your wedding!

Well, you certainly took us by surprise. In fact, just a few of us even suspected you were taking off to get married. But even though we didn't hear about it until later, we-my wife and I-wish you the best.

Give our warm regards to your new partner.

Choose Nondiscriminatory Expressions

Another requirement for courtesy is the use of nondiscriminatory language that reflects equal treatment of people regardless of gender, race, ethnic origin, and physical features. The suggestions selected here can be particularly useful for your written and oral busines communiation.

Sexist Terms: "Man" Words

In western culture there is more concern than in other cultures about using the term *man* as part of a compound noun.

For a long period of time *man* was accepted to denote not only a male person but, generically, humanity at large. Today many people in the United States connect *man* with a "male human being." Thus the English language—more so than other languages—uses alternative expressions for *man* that are neuter in form. Some examples are:

Questionable	More Desirable
freshman	entering students; first-year students
manpower	workers; employees; work force; personnel
man-made	manufactured; constructed; built
the best man for the position	the best person; the best candidate for the position

Singular Pronouns

English lacks a neuter singular pronoun signifying "he" or "she." Previously we accepted—and some persons still do—masculine pronouns in expressions as "anyone . . . he" or "each customer . . . his bill." The trend today is to avoid using *he, him,* and *his* when referring to the hypothetical person or humanity in general.

Questionable	More Desirable
Anyone who comes to class late will get his grade reduced.	Students who come late to class will have their grade reduced. [*Reworded to omit unnecessary pronouns.*]
Each customer will have the new changes noted on his bill.	Customers will have the new changes noted on their bills. [*Reworded into the plural.*]
"Our criteria are firm: he is to be a scholar; he is to be a good teacher."	Our criteria suggest he or she is to be a good scholar and a good teacher. [*Reworded to include both genders.*]
"You guys should all be concerned about the issue."	Both men and women, all of you should be concerned about the issue. [*Reworded to include both genders.*]
The executives may benefit from the stock options. He will . . .	The executives may benefit from the stock options. Each executive may . . . [*Reworded to repeat the noun or a similar noun if a few words intervene.*]
Each manager has an assigned parking place. He should park his car . . .	Every manager has been assigned a parking place. Each car should be parked in . . . [*Reworded into the passive.*]

In sum, use good judgment. Some companies use the masculine *he* quite freely; know the culture of the company before making a final decision when writing.

Recognize that the emphasis on gender neutrality is more common in the United States than in other countries.

Names

When using names, treat each gender with respect: use names in parallel form.

Undesirable	More Desirable
Ted Aprill and Ruth Mrs. Aprill and Ted	Ted and Ruth Aprill Ms. Aprill [*she desires this*] and Mr. Aprill

Checklist 2.6 Courtesy

1. Ask yourself: Does the communciation have a sincere you-attitude?
2. Have someone else look at your statement if you have doubts about whether it is tactful. Another opinion may cause you to reconsider making a statement.
3. Be cautious in using humor in communication. Here too it pays to have someone else review your words.
4. Be careful in using discriminatory language; this means being aware of gender, race, age, color, creed, sexual preferences, or ethnic origins.

CORRECTNESS

At the core of *correctness* is proper grammar, punctuation, and spelling. Major principles relating to each of these qualities are in Appendix A.

However, a message may be perfect grammatically and mechnically but still insult or lose a customer. The term *correctness*, as applied to business messages, also means the following three characteristics:

- Use the right level of language.
- Check accuracy of figures, facts, and words.
- Maintain acceptable writing mechanics.

Use the Right Level of Language

We suggest that there are three levels of language: formal, informal, and substandard. Take a quick guess: What kind of writing is associated with each level? What is the style of each?

Formal writing is often associated with scholarly writing: doctoral dissertations, scholarly articles, legal documents, top-level government agreements, and other materials where formality in style is demanded. The style is unconversational, usually impersonal, and often contains long and involved sentences.

Informal writing is more characteristic of business writing—even more so if that writing occurs in an E-mail message.

Informal writing is more characteristic of business writing. Here you use words that are short, well-known, and conversational, as in this comparison list:

More Formal	Less Formal
participate	join
procure	get
endeavor	try
ascertain	find out
deem	think (believe)
edifice	building
utilize	use
interrogate	question

In the following poem, Enid C. Stickel offers a humorous example of how people try to formalize their language.

Readability Gap

Colleges aren't schools,
They are learning institutions;
Problems don't have answers,
They have viable solutions.
People don't spend money,
They re-allocate resources.
Newsmen don't use tipsters,
They rely on informed sources.

Speakers don't make speeches,
They give oral presentations.
Bosses don't set quotas,
They just indicate objectives.
Workers don't take orders,
Though they implement directives.

Machinery can't break down,
But components can malfunction.
A court does not command
It just issues an injunction.
Programs don't have failures,
They have qualified successes.
And jargon doesn't hurt you—
It just constantly distresses!

Avoid *substandard* language. Using incorrect words, incorrect grammar, faulty pronunciation all suggest an inability to use good English. Some examples follow:

Substandard	More Acceptable
ain't	isn't, aren't
can't hardly	can hardly
aim at proving	aim to prove
desirous to	desirous of
irregardless	regardless
stoled	stolen
brung	brought
should of	should have

Check Accuracy of Figures, Facts, and Words

It is impossible to convey meaning precisely, through words, from the head of the sender to a receiver. Our goal is to be as precise as possible, which means checking and double-checking to ensure that the figures, facts, and words you use are correct.

Figures and Facts

A good check of your data is to have another person read and comment on the validity of the material.

- Verify your statistical data.
- Double-check your totals.
- Avoid guessing at laws that have an impact on you, the sender, and your message receiver.

- Have someone else read your message if the topic involves data.
- Determine whether a "fact" has changed over time.

In other words, there are accepted measures for statistical analysis just as there are rules for good grammar. At the bottom of all our suggestions, however, is this prescription: Be alert to accuracy because of changing rates, regulations, laws, and conditions locally and even internationally.

Words That Confuse

Our English language is constantly changing. In fact, even dictionaries cannot keep up with the rapid change in our language. But the dictionary is still a major source for locating correct words and their intended meanings. The following list includes only a sample of the many words often confused in usage:

a, an	Use *a* before consonants and consonant sounds or a long "u" sound. Use *an* before vowels or a silent "h."
accept, except	*Accept* is a verb and means to receive. *Except* is a verb or a preposition and relates to omitting or leaving out.
anxious, eager	*Anxious* implies worry; *eager* conveys keen desire.
between, among	*Between* involves two people or two groups; *among*, three or more.
biannually, biennially	*Biannually* means "two times a year" or "every 2 years"; *biennially*, "every 2 years."
continual, continuous	*Continual* means "recurring regularly" (like lapping ocean waves). *Continuous* means "without stopping."
counsel, council	*Counsel* means (as a verb) "to advise" and (as a noun) "lawyer," "advice." *Council* (noun) is an advisory or governing group.
effect, affect	In business usage only, *effect* is a noun; it means "result," "condition," or "influence." Both words are verbs—to *effect* is "to bring about"; to *affect* is "to influence."
eminent, imminent	*Eminent* means "high in station, merit, esteem," "prominent." *Imminent* means "about to happen," "threatening" (said especially of a danger or catastrophe).
farther, further	*Farther* is more used to express distance in space; *further* for distance in time, quality, or degree.

Checklist 2.7 Correctness

1. Select the right level of language for your communication: either formal or informal.
2. Realize that informal language is most often used in business communication.
3. Check—often by letting another person read your material—for correct figures, facts, and words.
4. Apply the principles of accepted mechanics to your writing.

imply, infer	*Imply* means "to insinuate" or "suggest"; *infer* means "to conclude." A writer *implies*; the reader *infers*.
lay, laid, laid lie, lay, lain	A person or a sheet *lies* (rests) on the bed, but a person *lays* the book on the table or *lays* himself or herself on the bed. If you can substitute *place(s)* and answer *what?* use the proper tense of *lay*.
principal, principle	*Principal*, as an adjective, means "chief," "main"; as a noun, it means "sum of money" or "head of a school." *Principle* means "rule" or "basic truth."
which, that, who	*That* refers to persons or things; *who*, to people; *which*, only to things.
who, whom	Use *who* as the subject of a verb—"*Who* will win?" Use *whom* as the object of a verb or a preposition—"*Whom* can you trust?" (You can trust *him* or *her*, not *he* or *she*.) "For *whom* will you vote?"

Maintain Acceptable Writing Mechanics

All the material discussed in Appendix A relating to mechanics, word processing, and appearance of business messages is relevant here. With the various packages available for computers, both grammar-checks and spell-checks have made your editing tasks easier. Yet we recommend careful attention to the mechanical part of every well-written document.

SUMMARY

Knowing the seven C's, and using them, will help you become a better communicator; the principles for these seven criteria for good communication are core

to this book, and we hope will be your criteria for good communication in the future.

Be *complete* in giving your message receiver all necessary information. One way to remember this suggestion is to think of the five W's: *who, what, when, where,* and *why.*

Apply the second C, *conciseness,* through eliminating wordy expressions, including only relevant material, and avoiding unnecessary repetition. Consistently ask this question: Which word, sentence, or paragraph may be eliminated without omitting relevant material?

Prepare your messages with the audience in mind. *Consideration* means putting yourself in their place. Focus on "you" in place of "I" or "we." Stress the positive in your messages.

Insert specific, definite, and vivid words to make your messages *concrete,* the fourth C principle. Use specific facts and figures; put action in your verbs; and choose vivid, image-building words.

Think of *clarity* as using words that are familiar to the message receiver. Additionally, use sentences that average 17 to 20 words, contain one main idea, are coherent, and give emphasis to ideas more often in the beginning of a sentence.

Respect your message receiver. The sixth C principle, *courtesy,* means being tactful, thoughtful, and appreciative. Such writing also implies using expressions that show respect and use nondiscriminatory language.

Review all your communication for *correctness.* This last of the seven C's focuses on correctness in grammar, punctuation, and spelling. Additionally, give thought to the right level of language and the checking of figures, facts, and words.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Understanding a Foreign Country Through Viewing Its Newspapers.*** One of the better ways of understanding a foreign country is to spend time viewing one of their newspapers, written in English of course. Foreign students in class may wish to read a paper in their native language. Your task is this: Set up a list of criteria for good English writing and then apply those criteria to the foreign paper. Some criteria you may wish to consider are these:

   a. Use of headings to the stories

   b. Tendency to overuse certain words, such as the article *the*

   c. Control over prepositions

   d. Difficulty with using tenses

2. ***Analysis of Foreign Form of Written Communication.*** Here is an interesting assignment for the foreign students in class: Have each of them analyze a form of writing (letter, memorandum, report, E-mail, or other) as completed in their native language. Their task is to write an analysis of dif-

ferences between their native format and those practiced in their native country. Each student should feel free to select his or her own criteria for the comparative statement.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Comparative Report on a Current Periodical.*** Apply two or three of the Seven C's discussed in this chapter as criteria for evaluating several different kinds of publications. (1) Do your analysis of one of the following documents. (2) Have another member of the class analyze the same document. (3) Compare results before reporting to the class on where you agree and where you disagree. You may select your analysis document from the following list or select one on your own:

   a. The *Wall Street Journal,* the *New York Times,* the *Washington Post,* or a local newspaper in your area

   b. An annual report

   c. Periodicals such as the *Economist, Business Week, Readers Digest, Fortune,* or a journal of your choice

   d. A story from a popular magazine

   e. The letter from the chairperson in a company's annual report

   f. This textbook, or another textbook selected from your major

4. ***Restatement of Long Thoughts into Shorter Thoughts.*** Translate the following gobbledygook into the original proverbs. Then compare sentence length (total words) in each concise proverb with the total words in the gobbledygook counterpart.

   a. All's well that is finalized effectively.

   b. Be it a minimal dwelling in a depressed socioeconomic area, there is no place like home.

   c. All programmed activity and nonutilization of recreational outlets make Jack a less than fully realized personality.

   d. Do not attempt statistical estimates of your chickens before it is feasible to correlate volume variances with projected expectations.

   e. The utilization of a superfluity of culinary personnel maximizes disorganization and has a deleterious effect on the broth.

5. ***Assignment to Move a Thought from Formal to Informal Writing.*** Rewrite the following example of formal writing into a more informal business style:

   On behalf of the committee investigating the issue of sex discrimination in the hallowed halls of academia, we respectfully request, indeed implore, that we earnestly seek your recommendation for cri-

teria to remove such discrimination. Furthermore, it is the intent of the committee that you use all means available to you, including via our approval additional measures, to submit no later than the 6th of October 199- those criteria to us. Finally, be it known that your information be made available to the committee in both hard-copy form and computer disk, the latter compatible with MS-DOS machines.

6. ***Exercises on Choice of Words.*** Choose the correct word or words that should be used in each sentence listed below.

   a. This act will not (effect, affect) my confidence in you.

   b. I am (anxious, eager) to (tell, advise) you that you are right.

   c. (Continuous, continual) rains are drenching the fields.

   d. We assure you (its, it's) a pleasure to do as you suggest.

   e. Enclosed (please find, is) my check for ($100.00, $100).

   f. RXZ College employs 10 (imminent, eminent) scholars.

   g. The dissension (between, among) the five departments has been settled by a (well known, well-known) authority.

   h. The man (who, which, that) was crossing the street was struck by a car (who, which, that) Mr. Smith was driving.

   i. (A, An) university regent held (a, an) one-hour meeting with (a, an) honor society (council, counsel).

   j. We sold (fewer, less) fans last month.

   k. We had (already, all ready) received the suit when your letter arrived. I am (already, all ready) to write this customer.

   l. Your rug should (lie, lay) (smooth, smoothly) on the floor.

   m. The (principal, principle) of honesty should be evident here.

   n. Be courteous to (whomever, whoever) comes to your desk.

   o. A large number of bills (is, are) outstanding.

   p. Do you know (who, whom) the manager promoted yesterday?

   q. The decision is a secret between Ron and (I, me).

   r. We have a large (quantity, amount, number) of suits here.

   s. Either Ellen or (myself, I, me) will call you Monday.

7. ***Substitution of Simpler for More Complex Word.*** Assume that you are writing to the average citizen who has contacted your company. Offer appropriate synonyms for the following words in order to improve understanding:

accelerate	allegation	default
aggregating	contingent	discrepancy
rescind	accord	cunning
validity	censure	hoi polloi
modus operandi	de facto	de jure
circumvent	paucity	archaic

8. ***Suggestions for Gender-Neutral Terms.*** Suggest some gender-neutral alternatives for the following terms:

freshman	man-hours	workmanship
repairman	layman	showmanship
manmade	chairlady	checkroom girl
girl	womankind	man the desk

9. ***Rewriting a Document into Nongender Terms.*** For the following interdepartmental memo, (a) number the paragraphs (1 to 4), (b) under every paragraph number, list all nongender, neutral statements—each on a separate line—and (c) opposite each statement write an appropriate nonsexist version.

TO: Mrs. Erica Cosmos DATE: May 10, 199-
FROM: Tom Grant
SUBJECT: CPC Staffing Requirements

I would like your support along with that of Charles to serve as cochairman of our Staffing Requirements Committee for the Communications Planning Centers. As you know, the CPCs are a most important sales tool, and we need highly qualified manpower with top salesmen.

The other committeemen I have appointed to work with you are Scott Durke, Fred Picker, Miss Helen Jaynes, and Mrs. Thoms.

One of the important jobs at the centers is that of professional sales demonstrator, which requires many man-hours of work. This man will be an entry-level group manager, responsible for all equipment sales demonstrations. He must of course be extremely knowledgeable about all our products and services. Currently this assignment is being handled by Miss Carolyn Mayer at our II Center and by Kermit Smith at ABC Center. Both are doing a superior job.

We would like this task to be a one-year rotational assignment and be filled with the best available candidate-man or lady. This job experience can greatly benefit the assigned individual

and make him more valuable to our company on future reassignments. Please get your committee together this week to begin an extensive search for good people who are available for these assignments. If you need help typing announcements or other materials, I've asked the gals in the typing pool to be available.

Business Communication in Context

Chapter 3 Business Communication and the Global Context

Chapter 4 Business Communication and the Ethical Context

Chapter 5 Business Communication and the Technology Context

Chapter 3

Business Communication and the Global Context

I. Background to Intercultural Communication
- A. A Concept of Culture
- B. An Intercultural Communication Model

II. National Cultural Variables
- A. Education
- B. Law and Regulations
- C. Economics
- D. Politics
- E. Religion
- F. Social Norms
- G. Language

III. Individual Cultural Variables
- A. Time (Chronemics)
- B. Space (Proxemics)
- C. Food
- D. Acceptable Dress
- E. Manners
- F. Decision Making
- G. Verbal and Nonverbal Communication

IV. Summary

V. Exercises and Problems

VI. References

Throughout the business world the term *globalization* is well-known. Globalization means that for a company to survive, it must establish markets not only in its own country but also in many foreign countries. Thus employees—and you as a potential international communicator—must understand others' cultures and variables. Additionally, you must be aware of your own country's ethnic diversity in order to communciate effectively with global companies.

This chapter introduces you to three fundamental topics as a basis for communicating effectively with people from other countries.

- Background to intercultural communication
- National cultural variables
- Individual cultural variables

BACKGROUND TO INTERCULTURAL COMMUNICATION

Communicating with persons from other countries is not easy, as suggested in the following examples:

Many personal and national variables affect both senders and receivers of messages.

You've got a choice: either you're on the plane with me this evening or I return home alone. [*Actual statement from a spouse after one day visiting a foreign country.*]

I get to work at 9:00 and leave at 8:00 in the evening. [*Actual statement from Hong Kong worker.*]

A few American companies have attempted to take their uniquely American approach to management and transplant it to Japan. Without exception, every attempt has been a complete and total disaster.[1]

What the above statements imply is that throughout the world there is a large mix of nationalities and people. And central to improving and understanding one another is communication training, captured in a statement made by a scholar in South Africa: "Stress is placed upon the concept of background which we believe is necessary to an understanding of the total communication process. By background we mean those aspects that can either impede or aid effective communication: language, culture, status, education, and age."[2]

Thus each person, each country has its own written and unwritten rules of behavior, including instruction in communication. Surely it is more comfortable to work with persons of your own culture, your own language, your own communication norms. But international communication demands work with many foreign countries and people. Let us begin by looking at culture.

A Concept of Culture

As the term *communication* is difficult to define, so too is the term *culture*. Two authors' research suggests that at least 164 definitions exist, with at least 6 cate-

Cultural generalizations applicable to an entire nation are impossible. Knowing core characteristics of a country are basic to better international communication

gories predominating.[3] For our purposes, *culture* refers to the behavioral characteristics typical of a group. This definition implies that communications, oral and nonverbal, within a group also are typical of that group and are often unique. Thus, to assume that all the suggestions for improving your written and oral communication as noted in this book are valid throughout the world is incorrect.

Another term you should know is *ethnocentrism*, that is, judging other groups or countries by the cultural standards of your group. While the focus in this chapter is primarily on communication, you must understand the many other factors that make up a culture, discussed later in this chapter. Try to guess in which countries the following communication and cultural habits exist.

1. What do you think of a culture in which people sign their last names first?
2. What is your reaction when two signatures appear at the bottom of a business letter?
3. Why don't people put the month first, then the day, rather than day first, then the month?
4. What is your impression of a foreign letter that is intentionally not concise?
5. Some salutations are overly formal; so are endings. Is that a concern when your letters have been more casual?
6. How do you react to long sentences in letters when you were taught to write shorter sentences?
7. What's your reaction when a letter ends without a clear statement of purpose or action?
8. What is your feeling toward a meeting in which there is little discussion and little comment until the senior and usually older person speaks and recommends an answer?
9. How do you react when writing problems such as errors in choice of verb tense, prepositions, and articles frequently occur in writing?

All the above are, respectively, dominant characteristics of communication for the following nationalities: (1) Chinese, (2) German, (3) Europeans and others, (4) French and German, (5) French and German, (6) French and German, (7) Chinese, (8) Chinese, and (9) many Asian countries. If you reacted negatively toward any of the different communication styles in the above questions, you tended to judge them in light of your own cultural standards.

Each time you hold up your standards of what is good when judging written or oral communication from another culture, you must be careful. To say, as did one American manager, "German reports begin with Adam and Eve" misses the point: Germans are usually more thorough in submitting reports than are writers in the United States. Withhold evaluative statements on foreign communication styles until you recognize that different cultures use different communication methods.

Communication Probe

Innumerable articles and studies confirm that as companies expand internationally, they will face cultural issues that could lead to unintended hostility. Cultural errors abound; business deals are lost worldwide because of unintended slights. Two international experts suggest the following:

- Get as close as possible to all stakeholders.
- Focus on social protocol as much as business protocol.
- Remain calm in the face of unrelenting frustration.
- Develop multifaceted communication with all levels of government in addition to company contacts.
- Identify, early, opinion leaders and acquire their support.
- Avoid arrogance; practice humility.

These suggestions apply worldwide. Central is this underlying inference: One must be aware of both business communication practices and cultural protocols.

Kohut, J. (1995, January 7). The art of wooing Chinese officials. *The South China Morning Post,* 19; Ward, S. (1993). Managing hostile local interests. *Business Asia, 25* (19), 12.

An Intercultural Communication Model

Studies have long determined that all of us are more comfortable with persons we know and who hold similar beliefs.

We assert that all of us are more comfortable with familiar people and surroundings. That makes sense. As a basis for understanding that assertion, look at Figures 3.1 and 3.2 on pp. 74 and 75.

Examine *carefully* the exact center of the daisy wheel petals: Directly in the middle are located basic human characteristics common to all of us. Thus a doctor in Stockholm, Sweden, understands the workings of the human body of an American, a fellow Swede, a Malaysian, or a Russian. In other words, certain physical, anatomical traits are common to humankind, regardless of race or cultural differences. So are the acts of walking, or love of family, or shaking hands in most cultures.

A core cultural value comes close to being fixed in stone. Know the basic ethical and moral concepts to which different ethnic and cultural groups subscribe.

Note that in Figure 3.1 countries I and II have a major cultural overlap. That is, people of those two countries might speak English, dress in a similar fashion, and use common forms of address—all in addition to basic core areas of agreement. Countries III and IV have the same core values but have less commonality with the other two countries.

Thus at the international level you probably would be more comfortable working in countries I and II than in countries III and IV.

Look at the end of each petal. All four cultures in Figure 3.1 would have major differences: Religions might be different, as could be values, beliefs, attitudes, and verbal and nonverbal means of communication.

Consider your own country. Within the United States, or within the former Soviet Union, for example, one finds diverse cultures. Ethnic groups within those countries still maintain an allegiance to core principles, and yet they hold on to traditions and habits peculiar to their own ethnic group. In other words, within

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Europe has for years included English as the second language requirement in its schools; younger persons recognize the importance of English as a world business language. But that fluency varies—as does that fluency in the rapidly growing region of Asia. Americans feel the world speaks English; perhaps, but with varying degrees of competence.

Thus a study of English fluency, particularly for English-language television, was conducted in the following countries: China, Indonesia, Japan, the Philippines, Thailand, South Korea, Taiwan, Malaysia, Hong Kong, and Singapore. Of the 10 countries, the Philippines have more people who speak English, or 49 percent. Based on a percentage of the population, 47 percent of the population is fluent in English. Singapore is second in percentage of their people speaking English, at 47 percent. So concerned are the other countries that both in national newspapers and journals a consistent series of statements seeking to improve daily and business English appear.

Nation, J. (1995, January 6). Mind your language—tempus fugit and other Latin traps. *Asia Magazine,* 33, k-7, 23; Lehner, U. (1994, March 20). Fewer Asians speak English than thought, study says. *Asian Wall Street Journal,* 6.

each country many individuals belong to different ethnic groups. Thus, while Americans accept certain underlying principles, attitudes, ideals, and values of their own culture, there exists diversity between persons of the same country.

Political parties, for instance, support democracy, yet wish to improve the system from different points of view. So do Hispanics and Europeans and Asians and a host of other ethnic groups within the United States. Each group supports core values, yet retains its basic diversity. Recognize that speech patterns will be different, nonverbal behaviors will vary, dress will be different, foods will taste different, holidays will assume varying degrees of importance, and even language usage will vary. Understanding the diversity of your own country is as necessary as understanding the cultural differences of foreign countries.

Note in Figure 3.2 that countries I, II, and IV are highly similar; each to a high degree overlaps the other. Thus it may be that Christianity is the dominant religion, the language is the same, letter sizes are identical, formality in dress dominates, cars drive on the same side of the road—even first names are used often.

Ask the foreign students in your class if they see additional differences between their native countries and the United States. In the past some foreign students have made the following responses:

United States	Other Cultures
Concern with diversity	Less tolerance for diversity
Tendency to be obsessed with time	Time is flexible

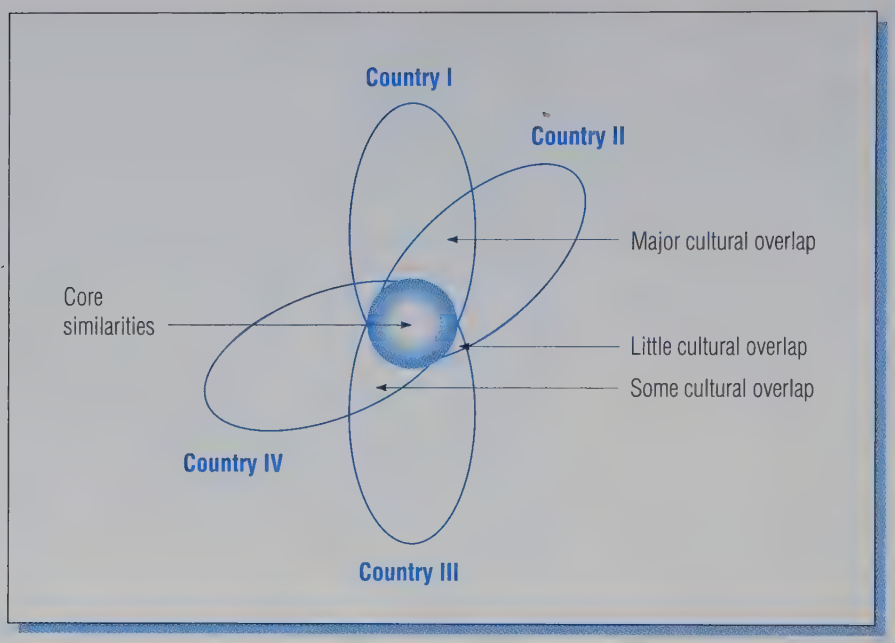

Figure 3.1 Cultural overlap.

United States	Other Cultures
Expect answers quickly to faxes, letters, or E-mail	Faxes and E-mail slowly increasing in developing countries
Few vacation periods	Many vacation days (about 17 in some countries)
Legalistic letters	More informal; a handshake is as good as a letter
Early starting time for work	Start working later in the day
Much use of slang	Less use of slang
Prefer deductive: It gets to the point more quickly	Prefer inductive: It is less arrogant
Prefer paragraph headings and visual divisions	Prefer bullets or numbers
Rank is less important	Rank is important

These comparisons lay the foundation for basic discussion of international or intercultural communication, but there are more specific variables that should be recognized in order to communicate effectively. This means understanding the seven national cultural factors.

Some of the thorny issues countries face politically are direct results of not communicating or of not knowing their own country's ethnic diversity.

Look at Figure 3.2: What does the configuration of Country III suggest? A quick inference is that the country has little in common with the other three. As one moves outward from a core sameness, each culture represented by the petals begins to change—some more than others. Why? Ethnic diversity within a country plays a part. So do such factors as habit, attitudes, and tradition.

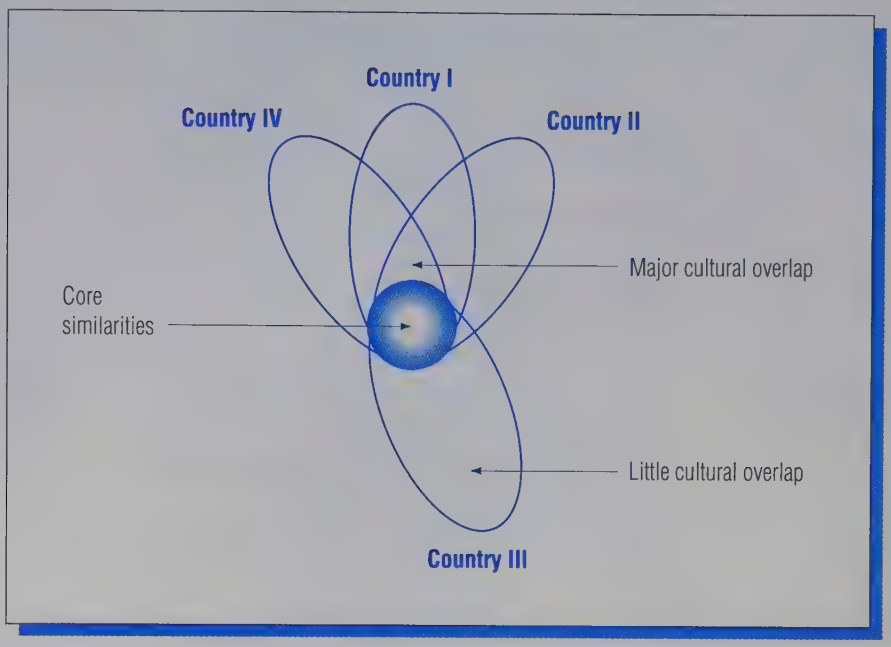

Figure 3.2 Cultural similarity and dissimilarity.

Notice that at some points the petals overlap where certain traditions (eating with chopsticks, celebrating the lunar new year, wearing the chador) are commonalities while others are not.

Assume you are in Country III. Although you possess the core attributes of other cultures, it is difficult for you to accept their differences. The following brief list cites some typical traits of American culture and compares them with possible alternatives you might find abroad.[4]

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There is support for the assertion that adaptation of foreigners to a host culture is related to length of time spent in that culture. Also relevant is the issue of communication over time between the host and foreigner. Thus adaptation—or the lack of it—of the two sides can lead to alienation. Conclusion: When Americans were perceived as hostile, the higher the social isolation of foreign students in the United States. Additionally, when Americans were perceived as avoiding interaction, the greater the social isolation. Conversely, when Americans showed a liking of foreign students, there was less social isolation.

McDermott, S. (1992). Communication factors in alienation among foreign students. *World Communication, 21,* 41–49.

Traits of U.S. Culture	Possible Alternatives Abroad
Individuals can influence the future.	Life's path is preordained.
Diversity days recognized on campuses.	Diversity days infrequently observed.
First names should come first.	Last names are used first.
Punctuality is important.	There is much time available; we'll get there.
Get to the point quickly.	Get to know the individual first; then conduct business.
Slow to offer business cards.	Quick to offer business cards.
Write from left to right.	Write from right to left.
Day is divided into two 12-hour segments.	Day is continuous; hours numbered from 1 to 24.
Consensus makes the decision.	The senior member makes the decision.

NATIONAL CULTURAL VARIABLES

An entire country may have a series of cultural norms; individual ethnic groups within that country may accept most of those norms as well as adding their own.

As the communication model in Chapter 1 shows, the message sender and the receiver are both affected by external and internal stimuli. When communicating with business people in a foreign country, you must realize that overall national and individual cultural differences within the cultures further affect those stimuli. Figure 3.3 suggests the macro, or global, constraints and variables that communicators must face when working with foreign receivers of their messages. The items in the left-hand column are mainly national cultural variables. You should understand them, know they exist; we begin our discussion there.

Education

Management education—including training in business communication—is more prevalent in the United States than in other countries. Some countries have no academic courses in communication training.

One of the conclusions students draw from visiting companies in other countries is that many managers in foreign factories are not very well educated. For example, if your future work takes you to Asia, you will find that most Asian and Chinese managers have had a less formal education than you.[5]

EDUCATION LEVELS OF CHINESE, ASIAN, AND U.S. MANAGERS

Highest Level of Eduation	Chinese, %	Asian, %	U.S., %
Less than high school	5.4	2.5	0.1
High school graduate	31.8	12.4	3.2
Some college	34.6	19.4	16.9
Undergraduate degree	27.6	65.4	79.8
Postgraduate degree	0.7	25.0	30.0

Because this book focuses on business communication, it is interesting to note the high importance of communication courses as preparation for a career

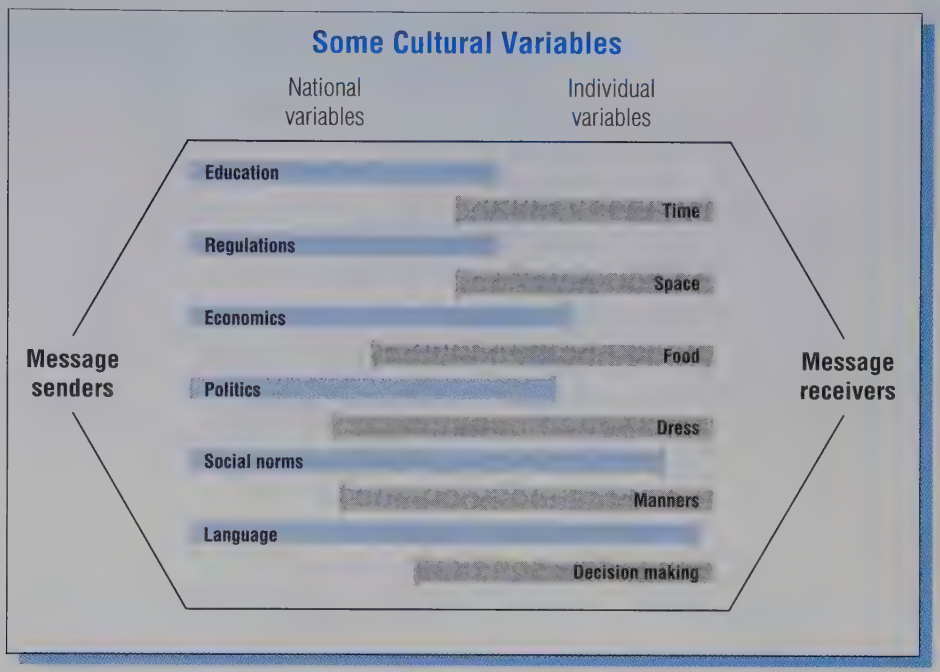

Figure 3.3 Overlapping cultural variables.

in general management. In the table on the next page, data are included for middle managers in the United States, Asia in general, and China.[6]

A quick assumption might be that Asians, particularly the Chinese, are less interested in education, that the nation is ill-equipped to hold its own with other

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As Eastern Europe opens itself to western capitalistic influences, it is beginning to search for contacts with Western universities and academic programs. Such contacts seek ways of linking both student and professorial interchanges: Both Eastern Europe—read "former Communist countries"—and Asian students suggest that when pursuing an M.B.A. degree they are introduced, in their mind, to some of the most radical and innovative business ideas they have experienced.

Bridging cultural gaps to the mind of the eastern European and Asian is half the battle; the other half is understanding the business protocols—and western forms of business communication. Thus, regardless of changes in current political thought, eastern European and Asian M.B.A. candidates and current degree holders are eager to combine and understand western management strategies with their own cultures.

Retaining managers. (1993, October 4). *Business China,* 5–6.

PERCENT OF MANAGERS RECOMMENDING SPECIFIC COURSES AS "VERY IMPORTANT" PREPARATION FOR GENERAL MANAGEMENT

Course	U.S.	Asia	China
Oral Communication	79.5%	71.8%	8.6%
Written Communication	78.0	69.7	8.0
Computer/Information Systems	53.4	27.0	21.1
Business Policy/Planning	47.5	48.2	14.1
Finance	39.9	38.5	30.9
Accounting	37.4	30.2	45.9
Personnel/Industrial Relations	36.0	36.1	37.7
Marketing	36.9	40.2	20.2
Business Economics/Public Policy	31.9	34.2	14.2
Business Law	26.0	19.1	8.5
Production/Operations	25.3	11.7	30.7
Statistics	18.1	10.8	16.9
Advertising/Sales	14.5	10.3	22.4
International Business	10.3	21.5	10.5

Before drawing conclusions from cultural data, it is necessary to consider many factors: A single cause rarely produces a valid conclusion.

parts of the world. If you made such an assumption, you would be wrong. You must go beyond your initial inference and assess the reasons that Chinese managers lack extensive education. You must go beyond surface conclusions:

1. In relation to its size, China does not have many institutions of higher education—in contrast to the United States. In 1980 there were only 675 institutions of higher education, increasing to 902 in 1984, and by 1985—the latest figures—the number had reached 1,016.
2. China is an agrarian economy. Over 800 million people still live in the countryside; 69 percent of the labor force is agricultural. Education, some early Chinese leaders felt, was not needed in such an environment.

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One should not get the idea that education means that all business courses receive the same emphasis throughout the world. Consequently, as our business schools and junior colleges offer basic business courses, including business communication, this latter course infrequently appears in college curriculums in Europe, for instance.

In a major study of German universities and junior colleges, the term *Kommunikation* as a criterion for excellence referred to the kind of communication between the universities and business managers outside the school. Few major schools in Germany offer classes in business or managerial communication—as we view the term in the United States. Often *Kommunikation* training occurs outside the university, in private and public seminars frequently taught by nonacademics.

Novizen aus der Provinz (Novices in [business education] located in the provinces). (1995). *Manager Magazine, 1,* 126–144.

3. Most universities were closed during the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976).
4. Self-study and private tutoring occurred during the Cultural Revolution, but for most young, college-aged people, education was not available.
5. A less educated Chinese manager—except between 1977–1980—faced an age maximum (age 25) for taking a college entrance examination.

Interpreting the above list demands an understanding of the political structure of China before concluding that communication is less important to the Chinese. In short, in a country rapidly opening its borders to capitalistic enterprises, communication continues to increase in importance: People today have more of an opportunity to express themselves than formerly.

Law and Regulations

Making mistakes in communication is easy in a foreign country. You or your legal department must be aware of strictness to the law or simply meeting the letter of the law.

In both the developed and developing nations, various government regulations affect business communications and the sale of products. For example, advertising directed at children is restricted in the United States, Canada, and Scandinavia. The type of product to be advertised—for instance, cigarettes—is restricted in Europe; also, money spent on advertising is limited. Other countries, such as France, Mexico, and the Province of Quebec, also have a restriction on the use of foreign languages in advertisements. In Iran it was difficult to show the World Cup tournaments held in the United States because American women who participated in the games exposed more of their bodies than is permitted in Iran; moreover, the sale of western publications showing unveiled women is forbidden. No fashion magazines are allowed into the country, and cosmetic makeup—including perfume—is prohibited. Women must wear either a *chador* (a head-to-toe veil) or a manteau (a loose smock worn over pants) with a scarf on the head. Men cannot wear short sleeves or T-shirts.

Economics

Availability of capital and transportation and the standard of living per capita vary from nation to nation. The opportunity to borrow money, the rate of inflation, and the exchange rates influence business and a country's ability to communicate concerning that business.

Under the U.S. free-enterprise system, competitors usually set their own prices. In contrast, OPEC (Organization of Petroleum Exporting Countries), as a cartel, sets oil prices. Israeli agricultural competitors mutually agree on a price. Some Japanese businesses check with the government before initiating major production and trading changes. And only recently have freedoms associated with capitalism made inroads in Eastern Europe and the southern part of China.

Politics

Even concepts of democracy will vary as interpreted in Korea, the Philippines, or Great Britain. Indeed, the sweeping political changes in Eastern Europe and its altered concepts of government will affect future business relations. Even the

Checklist 3.1 National Cultural Variables Between Your Country and Your Host Country

1. Attitudes toward education
   - **a.** What is the level of education of middle managers?
   - **b.** To what degree is education of women supported in the country?
   - **c.** Does education constitute a significant portion of the national budget?

2. Laws and regulations: Degree of formality
   - **a.** To what extent are the laws of the country codified?
   - **b.** Is there uniform enforcement for the laws and regulations of the country?
   - **c.** Are the laws and regulations of your country accepted and enforced?

3. Economics: Past history and projections
   - **a.** Which economic changes have occurred within the past 5 years that will affect the future?
   - **b.** Is the government supportive of the economic changes occurring?
   - **c.** How welcome are outside investors in your host country?
   - **d.** May funds be removed easily from your host country?

4. Politics: Past history and projections for the future
   - **a.** Which political changes have occurred within the past 5 years?
   - **b.** How supportive is the government of outside investors? of joint ventures?
   - **c.** What are the protocols, the conventions individuals must respect in the host country?

5. Religion: Homogeneity and diversity of belief structure
   - **a.** Are you aware of the major religious beliefs that could affect your business relationships?
   - **b.** Will the religious holidays affect your rhythm of conducting business?
   - **c.** What personal behavior is acceptable and nonacceptable?

6. Social norms: Importance of family, influence of past colonial influences
   - **a.** Are you aware of the social hierarchies of the country?
   - **b.** Is there a rank order of importance for participants at meetings?
   - **c.** Who will really make the business decision?
   - **d.** Which country's influence is still evident after previous colonial control?

7. Languages: Use of English and other languages used in business relationships
   - **a.** Is it necessary to have an interpreter at business sessions?
   - **b.** Is English understood at the oral or written level?
   - **c.** Is there a protocol to follow for formal and informal communication?

events in Tiananmen Square affected individual and business contacts with China; more changes will certainly occur in the future.

All such events affect communication, understanding of a country, and a company's willingness to do business in an unclear political environment.

For the measurement of potential political instability, there are classic indices and research studies[7] that monitor events—such as antigovernment demonstrations, arrests, assassinations, elections, exile, general strikes, guerrilla warfare, government crises, purges, revolutions, and riots—in determining the stability of a country.

Religion

Be especially careful of religious beliefs within foreign countries. Although some basic beliefs overlap, there are major differences that, if not understood, can result even in personal harm.

In the United States we accept religious diversity; we are tolerant of Protestant, Catholic, Jewish, Buddhist, Hindu, Moslem, and many other personal beliefs. Other foreign countries are less tolerant—Iran, for instance—of diversity in religion.

In connection with religion there is great need for tolerance. Buddhism, Hinduism, and Moslem religions are found in many parts of the world, affecting the values (and attire) of people professing these faiths. For instance, these three religions forbid consumption of alcohol; thus no liquor is served at business affairs.

Religious holidays affect international communication, interrupting work schedules or delaying responses to requests. The *International Herald Tribune* is the excellent international newspaper that lists the current and upcoming holidays around the world.

Be aware too that religion can affect the status of women: their positions within an economy and even their buying patterns and habits of dress. Fortunately, many of the above middle eastern, European, South American, and Asian ethnic groups are present in the United States. To communicate well internationally, it also pays to understand the diversity patterns within one's own country.

Social Norms

In various ways any national environmental constraints—education, law and regulations, economics, politics, religion—affect a nation's social norms. In many countries a male line of the family profoundly influences some business decisions. Then the family and how its members relate to one another—decisions, buying patterns, pooling of resources, special interests—affect behavior and business communication.

Beyond the immediate family a bond may exist between persons, based on caste, class, age, or even special interests. Be aware of a nation's social norms.

Language

All agree: Knowing the language of your host country is the most significant contributor to improved communication, on a personal and a business level.

An important constraint that undergirds all the preceding variables is language. Obviously, unless both sender and receiver understand a common language, the opportunities for successful business communication are significantly limited.

English is a world language—and to a major extent the language of business. But, you will do a better job overseas if you know some basic vocabulary of

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Government decrees banning television receiving disks and even intended legislation against English words and programs are not uncommon. Underlying such prohibitions against English is the fear that a nation or ethnic group will diminish its cultural heritage. A further argument is that through learning another nation's language or being exposed to others' customs, literature, and people, nationalities will weaken their own identity.

Few countries question that English is the language of international communication. Knowing English is to master the political and economic realities for the future. However, in learning English and being exposed to western ideas, there is little doubt in this admonition outside the United States: Learn English for modern living and modern business, but do not replace core cultural qualities.

Bond, M. (1991). *Beyond the Chinese face.* Hong Kong: Oxford University Press.

your host country. Your informal contacts and your off-the-road visits and travels will take you to places where "no speak the English" will be heard. Younger people overseas often know English; fewer older people do. Yet interpersonal bonds are forged between you and your hosts by your trying to learn the language—with all your errors. Each language has its own sentence patterns and vocabulary. Thus, writing and speaking in a second language are more prone to errors.

It is an easy task to find support for this assertion: Language problems are often core to communication misunderstandings. Published support—in a study of international business communication—appears for the countries of England, Belgium, Germany, France, Poland, India, Japan, Hong Kong, Canada, Brazil, Peru, and South Africa. Undoubtedly businesspersons and scholars from other countries would also agree.[8]

INDIVIDUAL CULTURAL VARIABLES

All people value their individual freedom. Often this freedom is expressed in one's own ethnic diversity.

Think of the preceding discussion as noting the macro national characteristics affecting communication—both intranational and international. These are the overriding sections of the cultural petals discussed earlier. Yet living within that overall cultural petal is the individual person; he or she exhibits a unique lifestyle of personal habits and ethnic diversity. Thus, within each culture, on the micro and more personal level, are differences in verbal and nonverbal cues expressed through varying concepts of time, indivdual speech, food, acceptable dress, manners at home and at work, decision-making patterns, and other nonverbal variations.

Time (Chronemics)

Persons in Latin America and the Middle East treat time more casually than do Americans, who usually prefer promptness. Germans are time-precise; rarely do

you wait for an appointment in Germany. In Latin America—and in Buddhist cultures—you may wait an hour; your host is not showing disrespect thereby, just reflecting a different concept of time; arriving late is a socially accepted custom.

In some cultures business people take afternoon naps, close shops, and postpone times for business meetings and dinner. German law specifies definite opening and closing hours for business and dictates which evening(s) retail stores may be open.

Even when referring to seasons of a year, countries differ. Some speak of the rainy and the dry season; Americans and Europeans think of spring, summer, fall, and winter.

Briefly, people in the United States think of time as linear: Journeys begin, journeys end; days begin, days end; seasons start, seasons stop. Others think of time as circular: "all in good time" for some cultures is precise enough.

Culture I	Culture II
"Let's get on with it."	"Mañana" (*tomorrow*)
"Time-saving devices"	"Efficient devices"
"In how many minutes can you get here?"	"What will be will be."
"Let's set a phone appointment for 8:15."	"We'll give you a call."
"The future is now."	"The old way is a good way."
"Live for today."	"Traditions should be honored."
"8:15"	"Some time tomorrow"
"You're late."	"Oh? Didn't know I was."
"Dinner at eight."	"See you when we get there."

In addition to different concepts of time, other factors—such as space restraints, lack of individual computers, and electric current interruptions—affect prompt communication.

It should not take you long to recognize which is the time-conscious culture and which is the one less concerned with precision in time. Knowing cultural perceptions of time helps you understand why some responses are slow—by your standards.

Space (Proxemics)

How close may strangers stand to you? What does it feel like when you are in a crowded elevator? Most Americans feel uncomfortable if a stranger comes closer than 18 inches.

- How do you react in Saudi Arabia when someone's breath intentionally brushes you in conversation?
- How do you like being literally pushed into a train in Tokyo?
- How would you react hanging onto the outside of a bus in India?
- How do you react to the cold stare of a German as your eyes invade the privacy of his or her yard?

Americans demand more room—buffer space—between themselves and others when speaking. To some cultures (Arabs, Latin Americans), Americans who do not stand close seem cold and aloof. Conversely, some cultures consider those who stand close to you as intrusive, rude, pushy, overbearing.

Concepts of office space differ. In third-world countries, several people occupy the same office, even the same desk. Furniture is arranged according to alleged mystic powers. In Germany one's door is often closed; you knock before entering the room. You cannot assume that a western concept of space is accepted and understood throughout the world.

Food

It may be a good idea prior to visiting your host country to visit various ethnic restaurants in your home country. Then you'll have an initial idea as to the kinds of foods available: how they are served, fixed, or eaten.

It used to be that only the tourists in London or Tokyo would rush off to the ubiquitous McDonald's or that those in Beijing would order a Domino's pizza or a meal at Kentucky Fried Chicken. But now the natives in those countries also frequent such places. When we get off the beaten path, however, food—and its preparation—will vary. Pork is forbidden in middle eastern countries but is a part of the Asian diet and that of many other countries; beef is hard to find in India; veal is plentiful in Europe; rice is ever-present in Hong Kong and China.

In Asia, dark and light tea are national drinks—they also have good beer. In Europe, French workers enjoy a glass of wine with lunch, often a stated codicil in a labor contract. Alcohol, as stated in the preceding section under "Religion," is forbidden for Buddhists, Moslems, and Hindus. You can get into trouble by carrying liquor into some countries.

Cheese may be dessert in France, part of a sandwich in Denmark, or an hors d'oeuvre in Germany. Your palate must adapt as well as your view of time and space.

Or how do you react to how food is served, or what is served? Do you like to have food offered you from a rolling cart, as in eating *dim sum* in Hong Kong? Do you like eating with your fingers, as in an Ethiopian restaurant? How about soup so hot in taste that cold water is a necessary and efficient chaser in Thailand? Or, how proficient are you with chopsticks in picking up a peanut, as natives in many Asian countries can do? Not all the world eats the same, and that's what makes international travel and business so interesting.

Acceptable Dress

It is better to ask about the mode of dress for an occasion in your host country than to risk making an embarrassing mistake.

In most American businesses males wear the business suit whereas women wear dresses or tailored suits. And in great measure that "uniform" is common throughout the world, even in Eastern Europe as it adopts more capitalistic methods. Some of our British friends might still wear the bowler along with a dark suit and carry an umbrella; in India a Nehru jacket; in Singapore a long-sleeved shirt with a tie.

In the Middle East long cotton coats are acceptable. In some situations you may see the Hawaiian muumu, the Polynesian sarong, the Japanese kimono, the Iranian chador, or the Mao dark-blue jacket and pants.

Manners

Some cultural anthropologists suggest that you observe children in foreign cultures because by watching them you learn the behavioral habits of elders. Children shake your hand in Germany, hug you in Italy, and often stay in the background in India. In fact, the ritual of the greeting and the farewell is more formal

overseas with children and adults. You bring a gift when visiting most homes in Europe. If you bring flowers, you avoid gifts of red roses in Germany or white chrysanthemums in France, Belgium, and Japan. Adopting the manners of a country may mean a 2- to 3-hour lunch in Europe is acceptable, if you can call up your patience. Be prepared to sit close together in Asia: 12 people at a rather small round table, eating with chopsticks, is not unusual.

In Saudi Arabia, you will learn that sons defer to their fathers, that age is paramount, that a junior prince is silent when a senior enters. At the heart of their system is the family, the House of Saud. To know even these few cultural manners is to begin understanding this country in the Middle East.

Decision Making

Americans are accused of being brusk; we wish to get to the point—fast. "Getting down to business" is a trait of our western culture. The Germans, Singaporeans, Swiss, Dutch, and Scandinavians are similar, quickly getting to the issue. In contrast, the Chinese, Italians, French, and British prefer more leisuring social amenities.

Patience—above all—is needed in intercultural communication, in doing business with other countries. Americans are typecast as moving too quickly in asking for a decision. Give more thought to inductive communication.

When one reaches Japan, decision time is held back as group consensus moves toward a decision. Participation, by many people, is the touchstone. As you can imagine, much time is spent in reaching an answer. That is what frustrates Americans; that is where we throw up our hands. Unhappily, we do not try to understand that for the Japanese the system of participative decision making works, that the *ringi* process (stamps of approval by many people on a proposal) means that underlying agreement is obtained in advance of beginning an action.

One of your authors lectured, visited, consulted, and entertained in an Asian country for 8 years before his hosts felt comfortable enough to offer assistance with some research projects. At the end of a dinner in the eighth year, a senior member declared: *We now know you!* We're ready to help with your research projects." Eight years—*8 years*—to gain approval of the projects and interpersonal acceptance by the hosts.

Thus patience—and your understanding of the decision process—add to your success in dealing with a foreign environment.

Verbal and Nonverbal Communication

Although verbal and nonverbal forms of communication occur throughout this book, a separate section is required to point up additional differences across cultures.

Verbal

We judge people to a great extent by their voice. Some native languages demand many tonal variations, giving the impression to a nonnative of loudness, even arrogance.

Regardless of culture, a kind of verbal sparring occurs when strangers meet, each seeking to determine which topics are acceptable and noncontroversial. Additionally, the tone of voice of one's initial words can influence your initial perception of whether the meeting is positive or negative.

Even the oral phrase "how would you like to" can have either a direct or an indirect meaning; it could be a command or a question. In Australia it is taken as a request and not a question; in the United States it is a question. "See you later" can mean the same day to some Asian workers or some indefinite time in the fu-

Checklist 3.2 Individual Cultural Variables Between Your Country and Your Host Country

1. Perceptions of time
   a. Is the concept of time considered linear or circular?
   b. What impact will time have upon business decisions?
   c. Is time considered valuable or an intangible asset?

2. Perceptions of space—What is the average acceptable personal space between natives of the host country?

3. Perceptions of food
   a. Are you aware of the eating habits of your hosts?
   b. Are there table conventions you should be aware of?
   c. Are there foods you might find disagreeable?

4. Perception of dress
   a. How much skin may be exposed in both an informal and in a formal situation?
   b. Are certain colors disturbing?
   c. Will western attire be accepted?

5. Perceptions of manners
   a. What is the protocol regarding the introduction of persons in a business situation?
   b. What are the "rules" of gift giving?

6. Perceptions of decision making
   a. Is the pattern for making decisions consistent from one company to another?
   b. Is placement of the major decision maker consistent in a meeting situation?
   c. Is an inductive or a deductive pattern of decision making preferred?

ture to Americans. A response of "Yes" from an Asian may mean "yes" or "no." "Anytime" to a Greek means he or she would welcome you with no time limit. In China you may utter the Chinese expression "*she-she*" ("thank you") for your tea, or tap your fingers on the tablecloth, nonverbally indicating gratitude.

If you traveled abroad or flew on foreign airlines, you may have been surprised at the volume level of some person's speech. What to us is loud and raucous, perhaps sounding like a fight, is considered normal and accepted by Arabs. Some Japanese use little volume, again accepted and part of a cultural heritage. Tonal languages, such as Cantonese, demand more volume to suggest changes in word meanings, English less so.

Communication Probe

When people communicate, their verbal and nonverbal signals are influenced by their experiences and by their cultural backgrounds.

Obviously, people from the same culture—who, by definition, are more likely to have similar backgrounds and experiences—are more likely to interpret one another's words and actions accurately. However, even under ideal conditions, the message the receiver decodes is never identical to the message the sender transmits. And cultural differences greatly increase the chances that the message received will differ from the message sent.

Hulbert, J. (1994, March). Overcoming intercultural communication barriers. *The Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication,* 57(1) 41–44.

Nonverbal

A handshake is a traditional form of greeting in the West. In Polynesia, the traditional greeting is embracing and rubbing each other's back. Eskimos rub noses as a form of greeting; a kiss on the cheek or lips signifies the same thing in many western cultures. In China and Japan public kissing is frowned on, an action reserved for one's private life. Touch as a form of behavior varies and is limited to certain persons.

A myriad of nonverbal symbols exist for every culture, even in subcultures. Knowing the major desirable and undesirable cues helps knowing both intended and unintended communication errors.

Facial expressions vary across cultures. You could get the wrong impression when some Filipinos smile and laugh, when underneath this behavior they are angry. Or, the inscrutable facial expression of the Japanese does not suggest disinterest, rather an unwillingness to make public one's inner thoughts.

Checklist 3.3 Verbal Communication: Differences Between Your Country and Your Host Country

1. Volume of the voice
   a. Are you aware if the language is tonal; i.e., does the language require variations in volume and pitch in order for the word to be understood?
   b. Is meaning dependent upon major tonal variations?

2. Pitch of the voice
   a. Are you aware of the need for pitch variation for meaning to occur between two people?
   b. Are emotional states communicated via variations in pitch?

3. Rate of the voice—Is the culture known for speech delivered rapidly?

Checklist 3.4 Nonverbal Communication: Differences Between Your Country and Your Host Country

1. Gestures in communicating
   a. Are you aware of any undesirable gestures that may affront?
   b. To what extent should the hands be used in communicating?
   c. What is a desirable posture when sitting at a meeting?
   d. Is it desirable to bow, or should that be left to the host country persons?

2. Eye contact in communicating
   a. Is it desirable to maintain direct eye contact during conversations?
   b. Are you aware of the visual cues that suggest the conversation is ended or that it is your turn to speak?

The meaning of gestures varies. What we think is an innocent gesture (the "O.K." sign with thumb and forefinger together) may be obscene in parts of Italy; a thumbs up is a positive sign in the United States; in Greece it is negative, suggesting "sit on this." This is not the place to review the hundreds of gestures and body motions used in different cultures; several good books are devoted solely to this topic.[9]

You can see that it is not safe to assume that gestures used in all innocence in the United States are accepted in the same manner throughout the world. Be aware; be cautious; know the variations that could cause failures in communication or complete distrust of you as a communicator.

SUMMARY

It is difficult to assert that definite behaviors will consistently be used throughout a country by *all* persons. Times change. Cultures change. Ethnic diversities change. Yet, consider the following maxims on intercultural communication:

- Recognize that one's own country is a mixture of various ethnic groups; understanding the diversity of one's own country is fundamental before looking abroad.
- Avoid drawing conclusions for an entire cultural group based on only a few examples.
- Understand that communication breakdowns are more the result of misunderstandings in culture than grammatical or stylistic issues.
- Avoid judging others on the basis of your own culture; each country has

its long-established traditions. The United States does not have a monopoly on preferred business communication principles or procedures.

With those four maxims as background, this chapter suggested that each culture, each ethnic group within a culture, has a generally accepted, recognizable behavior. If most of that behavior is familiar to us, we are comfortable. If there are major differences, we feel uncomfortable. Time is needed to adapt to and understand another culture.

Basic to any country are certain national variables—those mega principles that indirectly affect its population. Thus we learn something about a country's culture by knowing the educational levels of the population, the legal and regulatory restraints affecting business, the economic philosophies or national and foreign trade practices, the political attitudes, the religion as practiced by the state or the individual, the social norms of the state, and the language. Each of the above affects international communication.

Within each country are individual people—all with their own personal behaviors involving how they handle time, what a comfortable distance for interpersonal communication is, what foods are wholly acceptable, what is considered appropriate dress, what the unwritten personal manners within a home or office are, what procedures and speed are followed in arriving at personal and business decisions. Finally, cultures have both verbal and nonverbal communication characteristics; what is acceptable in one culture may be entirely unacceptable in another.

Your effectiveness in communicating well and succeeding overseas requires adapting to many factors. Knowing even the polite forms of a foreign language is helpful, as is knowing some differences in writing and speaking. Do some research into various organizations and journals interested in international business and communication. Finally, ask questions, in both personal and business areas. Then you are on the way to successful intercultural communication.

Communication Probe

Japan, as a major force in Asia, is no different from other Asian countries: All—just like the European nations—face similar communication problems. "Being misunderstood" is a loud complaint—around the world. And as this chapter notes, historical, political, economic, social, cultural, and psychological differences between Americans and Japanese impede effective communication. Fukushima notes five communication problems, to which your authors add, these problems are common with other countries as well: Unintentional misunderstandings, use of intentionally ambiguous statements, lack of an English or a Japanese equivalent word, meaning errors when translating material, and Japanese desire for pretense rather than observed reality.

Fukushima. G. (1995, March). "Misunderstanding" Japan. *Tokyo Business Today, 63,* 48.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

All Exercises and Questions for This Chapter Are International in Nature

1. ***Significant and Representative Issues of a Country's Culture.*** Choose any country you wish. Then complete a brief memorandom that summarizes major cultural issues that you feel could affect business and communication with that country. You may wish to select headings from the following list:

   - Basic principles for doing business
   - Forms of address
   - Courtesies in formal and informal settings
   - Language
   - Religion
   - Entertainment
   - Nonverbal and verbal behaviors
   - Principles of negotiation, decision-making patterns.

2. ***Oral Team Reports on a Country's Variables That May Affect Business and Communication.*** Appoint several teams within the class. Each team is responsible for selecting a single country and then orally reporting to the class some of that country's national environmental variables and individual environmental variables that may affect business and communication. A possible outline might include the following points:

   The Country
   Land and climate
   History and government
   Economy
   Education
   Transportation
   Health

   Lifestyles of the Country
   Position of the family
   Social and economic levels
   Business hours
   Food

   The People of the Country
   Population
   Language
   Religion
   Holidays
   Attitudes

   Cultural Customs
   Methods of greeting one another
   Nonverbal behavior

   Words and Phrases

3. ***Comparison of U.S. and Chinese Idioms.*** While numerous differences exist between cultures, there are also high degrees of commonality. One sees this commonness when comparing idioms or sayings between two cultures. We in the United States are familiar with the idioms in the left col-

umn. Match them with their Chinese counterparts in the right column. (Answers are in the Instructor's Manual.)

Familiar to Americans	Familiar to Chinese
a. It's the bad apple that spoils the barrel.	____ The head of the cow does not fit the mouth of the horse.
b. It takes two to tango.	____ It's impossible to clap with only one hand.
c. Speak of the devil.	____ Paper cannot wrap up fire.
d. It's like building castles in the air.	____ One hair from nine oxen.
e. Don't bite off more than you can chew	____ The wood has already been used in making the boat.
f. A drop in the bucket.	____ You ride a tiger and find it hard to get off.
g. As ye sow, so shall ye reap.	____ To dig a well only after one is thirsty.
h. To lock the barn door after the horse is gone.	____ Like ants on top of hot cooking pot.
i. It's water over the dam.	____ If one plants melons, one gets melons.
j. Where there's smoke, there's fire.	____ Like climbing a tree to catch a fish.
k. Like comparing apples and oranges.	____ The horse that leads the herd astray.
l. On pins and needles.	____ Blow on the hair and search for tiny sores.
m. Picky, picky, picky.	____ When you speak of Ts'ao Ts'ao, Ts'ao Ts'ao arrives.
n. The truth will out.	____ There are no waves if there is no wind.

4. ***Written Memo Report and Oral Presentation on a Foreign Country Investment.*** Combine both an oral and a written assignment according to the following structure.

Subject:	Present an Individual Research Memorandum and Oral Presentation on a Foreign Country Investment
Action requested:	Recommend whether a company—of your choice—should expand, establish a subsidiary, permit franchising, or locate an overseas office in a named foreign country.
Goal of assignment:	1. To bring together (a) original work and (b) secondary information in a memorandum that includes a clear recommendation on whether a company—selected by you—should or should not invest resources in that country. 2. To present the results of your research in an oral briefing, attempting to persuade the class on a course of action.

Procedure:

1. Each class member may select from the list at the end of this exercise a foreign country for analysis, setting his or her own criteria as to whether investing resources in that country is desirable or undesirable.
2. Your instructor should receive two copies of your memorandum on the day of your oral presentation. All class members will on the day of your presentation also receive copies of your memorandum. Example of headings you may wish to include:

   TO: International Review Committee (your class)

   FROM: Your name and the group or division you represent.

   SUBJECT: Include a clear, definite statement of purpose. Include a verb to give a sense of direction.

   DATE:

   Introduction:
   (1) Opening paragraph important. Here restate what is being recommended or will be discussed. Why is topic important? What is previous to discussion? What are criteria?
   (2) Supply definitions if needed.
   (3) Layout of position you wish accepted or will discuss; *divisio* (agenda) of how material will be developed.

   Body:
   (1) Entire body of memorandum includes (a) background discussion and (b) rationale for your recommended action.
   (2) Evidence for your recommendation should including findings, examples, statistics, analogies, quotations, charts. (An appendix may be added for visual supports or other related material.)
   (3) Usually use one paragraph for each major issue or conclusion.
   (4) Transitions may be used to clearly move ideas along.

   Conclusion:
   (1) Restate recommendation you wish accepted.
   (2) Look into the future—visualize what will occur if proposal or conclusions are or are not accepted.

3. Class procedure:
   a. Proper grammatical form, proper footnote and bibliographic form should be used throughout.
   b. Distribute your memorandum to each member of the class.
   c. The class will challenge or question you *during* your oral presentation.
   d. You will receive a written critique of your memo and presentation from your instructor.

Possible macro sources for background research include the following:

The Economist Intelligence Unit (EIU), Country Profile (country reports on over 180 countries).

Area Handbook Series, Foreign Area Studies, The American University (country reports on over 100 countries).

United States Department of State, *Background Notes,* Washington, D.C. (country reports on about 180 countries).

5. ***Foreign Student Perceptions of Differences or Similarities Between Their Native Language and Native English Speakers.*** The major sections of this assignment depend on the individual foreign student: He or she should report on at least two or three areas of difference between their native language and English. For example:

Spanish:	Complexity of Spanish grammar, particularly tenses
	How Spanish vowels differ from English vowels
	Accents and their use in Spanish
Portuguese:	Spoken Portuguese: differences in sounds
	Written Portuguese: use of the inductive method
German:	Problems of positioning the verb
	Problems connected with gender
Japanese:	Differences between Japanese vowels and English vowels
	Vowel sound differences between Japanese and English

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Chapter 4

Business Communication and the Ethical Context*

I. Background to Ethical Contexts
   A. Ethical Situations
   B. Ethics As a Communication Issue
   C. Ethics in Corporations—An Historical View

II. Influences on Personal Ethics
   A. People
   B. Culture
   C. Philosophy
   D. Law
   E. Religion

III. Communication and Ethical Issues
   A. Legal Issues
   B. Key Areas for Ethical Communication
   C. Ethics and Organizational Responsibility

IV. Summary

V. Exercises and Problems

VI. References

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On Nov. 1, 1993, the U.S. Department of Transportation fined Continental Airlines $20,000 for not selling enough seats at the advertised discount fare. Continental had advertised an attractive fare from Newark, N.J., to Europe and sold about 8 percent of the seats at the advertised price. The Department of Transportation argued that at least 10 percent of the seats had to be sold at the discount fare. "We felt there were a sufficient number of seats available and the DOT felt otherwise," replied a Contental spokesperson. "In order to avoid costly litigation, we chose to pay the fine."[1]

A Chinese manager of a luxury hotel in Beijing could not find his watch and an expensive pen that had been given to him as gifts. He went through the desk drawers of his subordinates looking for the missing items. A lower-level manager observed this behavior and called it unethical.[2]

Did Continental Airlines mislead the public with its advertising? Is offering 8 percent of a product at the advertised price sufficient? Did Continental behave unethically? Was the Chinese manager's behavior unethical? These questions are not easily answered; ethical issues are complex and challenging areas of decision making.

This chapter views ethical issues arising in communication contexts. Specifically, we focus on some ethical contexts affecting communication, consider how your own personal ethics were formed and continue to be influenced, and examine ethical motives in your personal, cross-cultural, and advertising messages. Finally, we consider ethics in organizations and look at how organizations institutionalize and communicate ethical values.

BACKGROUND TO ETHICAL CONTEXTS

Making ethical decisions is relatively easy when all the facts of a situation are known.

Making ethical decisions is easy when you know the facts, the events are unambiguous, and the choices are clear. But it is different when evidence is missing, and multiple points of view conflict. How should one handle ambiguities and make the right ethical decisions when the issues are unclear? Ethics is about making right and wrong decisions. Ethical principles, the focus of this chapter, assist in making those decisions. These principles center around fairness, service, quality, integrity, excellence, compassion, honesty, and dignity.

Ethical Situations

You make ethical decisions every day; you build on a concept of right and wrong; you establish certain ethical principles. Consider the following situations. How would you react?

1. During an on-campus interview, a recruiter asks you why he should hire you over another candidate (a classmate of yours). You have some negative information about this person. Do you share it with the recruiter?
2. You witness another student cheating during an important accounting exam. Do you confront the student? Do you tell other students or a professor about the incident?

3. A firm invites you for a second interview at its corporate office. You are not especially interested in this company, but you are considering taking the trip because you have a good friend you would like to visit in a distant city and you could use the frequent-flyer mileage. Do you accept the interview?

A quick response to the above three incidents is that you would always make the right and moral decision: Friendship should take precedence over personal gain. Cheating is wrong and should not go unchallenged. If a job does not interest you, do not pretend that it does and accept the plane ticket and hotel room.

But *are* these the right and moral decisions? Are there circumstances when you would act differently? Why not tell the recruiter damaging information about the other candidate? After all, it's a competitive world. Perhaps you would ask the person cheating why he or she had done it. The answer may put the unethical act into a different context. Should you take the recruiting trip even though you are not interested? Why not give the company a chance to change your mind? Putting ethical events into different contexts changes the way we perceive the event. The *right* answer is not always clear.

Context of a situation influences the ethicality of a decision.

As a manager you will face similar ethical dilemmas; you will be tested as to what is right and wrong. Consider two scenarios, part of a study in which 1,500 club, accounting, and hotel managers gave their responses.[3] How would you react in each situation?

1. A hotel food and beverage manager recently purchased 20 cases of wine from a new beverage purveyor. Without the manager's advance knowledge, the purveyor delivers a free case to the manager's residence. The manager decides to keep the free case for his personal use since the free case did not influence his purchase of the 20 cases for the hotel.
2. A restaurant manager contracts with Spotters, Inc., to provide "customers" to spy on the bartenders to determine whether they are preparing drinks according to the standard recipe and whether they are charging customers properly for all drinks served.

Do you agree with the hospitality manager in incident 1? Would you accept the wine under certain conditions? Would you hire professionals to spy on your employees, as in incident 2?

Study results indicated that most managers believed it was wrong to accept the wine; however, they had no problem with spying on employees and even indicated that this was an accepted practice. This same group of managers also did not object to testing a cashier's integrity by slipping $50 into the cash drawer to see if it was reported as an overage at the end of the shift. The practices of spying and testing honesty are common in the hospitality industry.

Ethics As a Communication Issue

"We are not human beings having a spiritual experience. We are spiritual beings having a human experience." Pierre Teilhard de Chardin.

We communicate our values and beliefs to others via verbal and nonverbal behavior. We are defined in the eyes of others according to the way we behave. It follows, then, that we have a responsibility to act in ways that promote honesty and fairness to maximize the personal worth of each person in the organization.

We also need to communicate to others the importance and necessity of good ethics.

Foremost, corporate leaders and managers set a corporations's ethical tone. Leaders' actions demonstrate corporate values, whether the organization is corrosive, manipulative, and prone to deviousness or whether it is honest, open, and willing to admit possible failures.

In 1987 the Chrysler Corporation was indicted for mail and wire fraud and conspiracy after it was learned that Chrysler had disconnected the odometers on new cars so that assembly plant managers could take them home for test drives. Managers were to keep them only one night, but some drove the cars for a few weeks; some even had minor accidents. Later, the cars were sold as new. In both print and television, Lee Iacocca said, "America, we apologize. Testing cars is a good idea. Disconnecting odometers is a lousy idea. That's a mistake we won't make again at Chrysler. Period."[4]

Although some say that Chrysler attorneys dragged their feet in identifying and compensating people who had purchased these cars, Lee Iacocca nevertheless made the right ethical decision regarding corporate wrongdoing.

A major conclusion is this: Ethical leaders speak out when something is wrong; ethical people influence others by acting in line with their personal values. Often we know what is right, but we lack the impetus or collective feeling that reinforces our acting ethically in the face of other choices. Observing other people making the right choices inspires us and supports others to do the same.

Ethics in Corporations—An Historical View

The American public, historically, has not viewed business favorably. Nineteenth century "robber barons" were ruthless in driving out competition to build monopolies. They often exploited immigrant laborers, children, and minority workers as cheap labor. So it is not surprising that the integrity of corporate America has been questioned repeatedly over the years.

- The 1960s—In 1966, Lewis Harris conducted a poll indicating that 42 percent of Americans agreed with the statement "Most businessmen will do anything—honest or not—for a buck."[5]
- The 1970s—Many perceived business as profiting from the Vietnam War and the defense budget. Protests occurred on college campuses when the CIA and corporations linked to the defense industry tried to recruit on campus.
- The 1980s—One poll showed that 55 percent of the public thought most executives were dishonest. Another mutually conducted poll by the *New York Times* and *CBS* found that 56 percent of the respondents rated businesses "fair" or "poor" in terms of their contributions to the well-being of the communities where their plants were located.[6]

Rightly or wrongly, the public has doubts about the ethics of corporate America.

A 1992 Gallup Poll indicated that only about 20 percent of the respondents rated the honesty and ethical standards of businesspeople "high" or "very high."[7] And in 1993, from a list of 25 professions, the ethical standards of businesspeople were rated thirteenth—lower than journalists, reporters, and lawyers but higher than U.S. senators, representatives, and used-car salesmen.[8]

Ethics is a concern for American business. When crises occur, such as Exxon's Alaskan oil spill or Union Carbide's chemical leak in Bhopal, India, the press, the public, and the stakeholders scrutinize an organization's actions. Considerable damage was done to Exxon's reputation; eventually the firm was assessed a considerable fine.[9]

Publicity via the news media often alerts the public to corporate ethical crises.

However, corporations are only as good as the people working within them. Stephen R. Covey, author of *The Seven Habits of Highly Effective People,* notes that "organizational behavior is individual behavior collectivized."[10] In other words, the ethics of an organization are only as good as the integrity of the people who belong to it.

We are constantly faced with ethical issues. You will find it difficult to study, work, or live in an environment free of ethical decisions. How you handle each ethical issue reflects your values and communicates critical messages to others. Our organizations, both profit and nonprofit, need individuals with strong ethical values to lead us into the twenty-first century.

INFLUENCES ON PERSONAL ETHICS

Everyone—young students, older teachers—makes ethical decisions. Have you returned everything you found? Have you kept information from someone who would also benefit from the knowledge? Were you quiet when you were aware that facts were omitted? Reflect for a moment: How did you react to the above questions; what influenced your final decision?

Your personal ethics are shaped by five major influences: (1) influential people in your life (family, close friends, or a role model); (2) cultural norms; (3) philosophical positions; (4) local, state, and federal laws that govern individual behavior; and (5) your personal religious views. Figure 4.1 illustrates how these five areas influence your personal ethics.

People

Your family played a large part in shaping your personal ethics.

Your family members and friends exert strong influence on your ethics; Your parents and other family members shaped your ethical value system early on.

Communication Probe

Do shareholders want their companies to act ethically, or are they primarily interested in profits?

One study revealed that 42 percent of shareholders do not expect a high level of ethical behavior from either corporate leaders or employees. But 58 percent said they would be willing to sacrifice corporate for ethical behavior. Although this is not a strong mandate for ethics over profits, it is clear that the majority of shareholders place ethics first. Further, over 70 percent of the shareholders surveyed said they would like to see disclosure about ethics in the annual report.

Damatitio, S., & Schmidgall, R. (1993). Hospitality professionals' responses to ethical situations. *The Cornell HRA Quarterly, 34*(4), 40–43.

Communication Probe

Research indicates that we perceive ourselves to be more ethical than other people with whom we compare ourselves. This means that most of us think we are more ethical than everyone else. One study examined both college students' and practicing accountants' perceptions of their personal ethics and found that both groups saw themselves as acting more ethically than other people. Are we really as ethical as we think we are?

Tyson, T. (1992). Does believing that everyone else is less ethical have an impact on work behavior? *Journal of Business Ethics, 11,* 707–717.

Teachers, especially when you were younger, may have laid the foundation for ethical decisions.

Conditioning has shaped your conscience; your parents have left an imprint on you as to what is right and wrong. Values we gleaned from family members and influential people tend to stay with us throughout our lives.

Teachers are also influential. You were likely taught a number of values in school that reinforced your parents' teaching. Later, you may have admired a close friend, relative, or teacher; you may have made a deliberate choice to emulate this person's behavior, modeling your own actions after him or her. Your peers also influence your ethics. And you, in turn, choose people to be close to you who share your same value system.

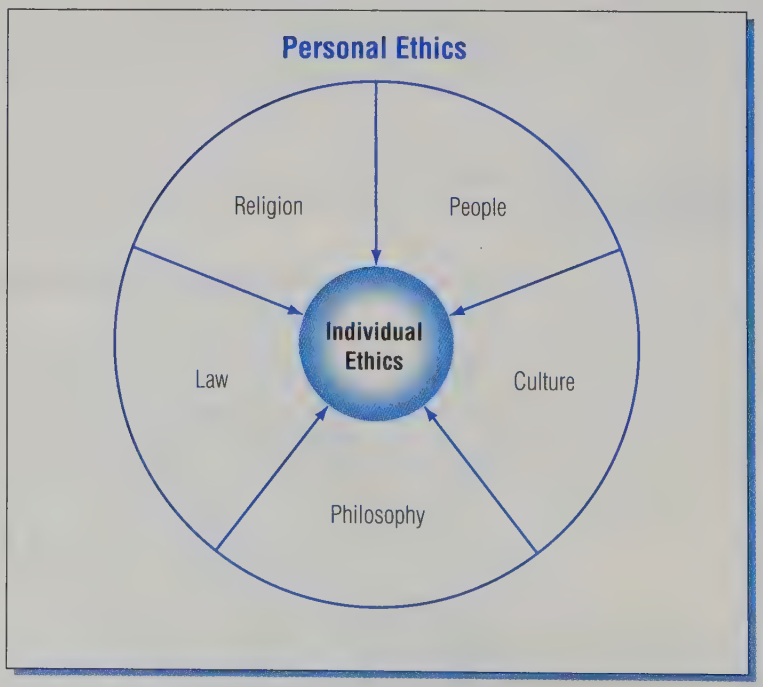

Figure 4.1 Influences on personal ethics.

Culture

Your culture taught you certain ethical values. If you grew up in a city, you may have different values from someone who was raised in a small town. Similarly, those of you not raised in the United States have values determined by your own country and culture. Americans have been influenced primarily by Judeo-Christian ethics along with myths, stories, and legends that explain our past. Children growing up in the United States learned, for example, that George Washington chopped down his father's cherry tree; young Washington then confessed, saying he could not tell a lie. We also learned that Abraham Lincoln, as a young man clerking in a store, walked several miles to return a penny that he had overcharged a customer. Expected cultural behaviors are taught in these stories.

Each culture, over time, acquires its own set of values.

Children growing up in China learn a song about a child who finds a penny on the street, turns it in to an officer, and then is praised by the officer for performing a good act. The symbolism is transparent. In America, if we find a penny, our culture says we can keep it for "good luck"; in China, it belongs to the government. But if you find more than a penny, what are you supposed to do? If you find something of considerable value, what does the culture in which you live expect of you?

Philosophy

Theories of philosophy have long been concerned with ethical and moral issues.

Descriptive ethics and normative ethics are names for two major types of philosophical inquiry. Descriptive ethics reflect facts about the moral judgments or beliefs of a person or group of people. Normative ethics, on the other hand, involve discovering, formulating, and defining fundamental moral principles. This latter concept asks what actions are good and right, and thus which should be performed. With business ethics, we are primarily concerned with normative ethics and with what is moral and right, and contributes positively to the human experience. A number of these normative philosophical perspectives exist, but four important ones that can affect business and personal decisions are cited here:

1. *Theologism:* A moral perspective that attempts to pattern actions according to God's will. The theologist asks "What would God have me do in this situation?"
2. *Deontology:* The study of moral obligations or duty. The deontologist considers moral obligations to be knowable by intuition and without reference to the concept of good. Deontologists evaluate acts regardless of their consequences. The pure deontologist, for example, believes that you should always tell the truth.
3. *Teleology:* The study of evidence of design in nature. Events can be explained by final causes. Teleologists morally evaluate actions by examining consequences. The pure teleologist for example, believes that the singular duty is to maximize good consequences.
4. *Utilitarianism:* A form of teleology that argues that an act is morally right if it maximizes utility—that is, if the number of people helped is

greater than the number of people harmed. Utilitarians believe in the greatest good for the greatest number.

Your actions in a situation depend on which philosophical perspective or perspectives reflect your personal beliefs. Suppose a deranged gunman is holding five people hostage at gunpoint in the lobby of a bank. He asks if any other customers or employees are in the bank. You know that three customers escaped to the backroom along with a teller. Do you tell him the truth? The theologist would consider what God would want and whether a lie in this circumstance would be God's will. An extreme deontologist would tell the gunman about the other people, for he or she would believe that a lie is never justified. The teleologist, to maximize good consequences, and the utilitarian, for the good of the majority, probably would not tell. The utilitarian would also be the least troubled if a police sniper killed the gunman. One life would be sacrificed for a group of innocent hostages; thus a greater good would be achieved as a number of innocent lives would be saved.

These philosophical views are by no means a full representation of viewpoints; rather they help us identify some of the important questions. Do the ends justify the means? Should individuals always tell the truth? What does it mean to maximize good consequences? What is "good"? The answers to these and other important questions depend on your philosophical perspective.

Law

Laws, some argue, represent the minimum standard of behavior.

Some individuals view ethics from a legal perspective: Acting ethically means following the law. Is a legal definition of ethics too simplistic? Perhaps the law represents a minimum standard of behavior. Codes of ethics for various professions, such as accounting, law, and medicine, require standards of behavior that exceed the law.

But what if you consider a law to be wrong—unethical or unjust? Henry David Thoreau addressed this viewpoint in his essay "Civil Disobedience," as did Martin Luther King in his "Letter from the Birmingham Jail." Thoreau did not want to pay taxes to support war, and King argued that because segregation laws were unjust, no one had a moral obligation to follow them.

Religion

Religions throughout the world are major foundations for ethical behavior among followers.

Using religion as the grounding for your ethical behavior means you act according to what you believe God wants you to do. Christians take advice from the Bible and the teachings of Jesus Christ; Muslims follow the teaching of Mohammed, the Arab prophet and founder of Islam; Buddhists adhere to the writings of Gautama Buddha; Confucianists follow the teachings of the ancient Chinese philosopher, Confucius. Many other religions and sects of these mainstream religions provide moral guidance as to one's duty to God, other human beings, and all the living things on the earth. Underlying nearly all the major religions is the concept of a supreme being and respect for the sanctity of life.

Sanctity of life is a predominant characteristic of the major religions of the world.

Different ethical decisions usually require input from multiple perspectives. When doctors face a difficult ethical dilemma regarding a seriously ill patient,

they may convene the medical ethics committee: Other physicians, a rabbi or priest or minister, a hospital administrator, a psychologist or social worker, and a person with specialized training in medical ethics. A manager looking at a serious dilemma would also consult experts.

In sum, your approach to ethical problem solving is shaped by other people, culture, philosophy, laws, and religion. These perspectives create tensions between themselves and between you and other people. Values frequently conflict and compete with one another. Arriving at the right decision involves examining your beliefs in each area, deciding where your values lie, and acting accordingly.

COMMUNICATION AND ETHICAL ISSUES

Communicating ethically in the business arena challenges you on several levels. Legal issues have an impact on you personally and on the organization to which you belong. Organizational challenges include constructing a productive company culture with employees who have diverse backgrounds, values, and beliefs. In all these challenges, your personal system of values will influence yours and others' behavior in business.

Legal Issues

Legal considerations such as defamation and privacy are concerns in all organizations (see Appendix C). Statements that damage a person's name or reputation, are communicated to others, and involve false and malicious statements that may be defamatory. Written defamation is libel; oral defamation is slander. Individuals or companies can be sued for defamation of character. Although these are legal issues, they are also ethical issues because slander and libel violated basic principles of honesty, respect, and human dignity.

Databases, unless carefully controlled, can become vast resources of information on your private matters.

Our laws protect individual privacy. Of major concern are the large databases credit, marketing research firms, and medical companies collect (see Chapter 5). The proliferation of computerized data has greatly increased the chances that our private information can become public. For example, confidential medical data collected by health care institutions and HMOs must be protected. When organizations or individuals violate the privacy of a person by passing information to a third party, they can be found guilty of invasion of privacy.

You may wonder why a recruiting firm or potential employer asks you to sign a release so they can obtain a copy of your college transcript. Educational institutions may not disclose information about your performance or activities without your permission. They may, however, reveal to a third party the number of semesters you attended and whether you received a degree.

Other issues with both ethical and legal implications are discrimination and harassment. Discrimination involves deliberate actions to exclude certain groups of people. Legislation has been passed to prevent this from occurring in housing, education, and employment. Discrimination is unethical because it seeks to segregate individuals on the basis of race, sex, ethnic group, or national origin.

Harassment and stalking laws are increasingly appearing on the books of various states.

Harassment involves irritating or tormenting another person on a repeated basis. It can occur between coworkers, between supervisor and subordinate, between persons of different cultures, or between people who have grown up together. In 1986, the Supreme Court ruled that sexual harassment is a form of

Communication Probe

Is there equal opportunity for all people? Evidence of continuing racial and gender bias surfaced recently in a 1993 *Industry Week* survey of 1,300 middle managers from medium-sized companies in the United States. Ten percent said they preferred to hire a white male, and 92 percent reported a preference of working for a man rather than a woman. Acting on these preferences through discriminatory hiring is both illegal and unethical.

Altany, D. R. (1993). Torn between halo & horns. *Industry Week, 242*(6), 10–14.

sexual discrimination, and thus employees are granted legal protection from it. Harassment is both illegal and unethical. Harassing another person is also a poor way of communicating feelings and violates the principles of fairness, dignity, and respect for other people.

Plagiarism is also an ethical issue. It involves taking the ideas or written material of another person and using it as one's own. When you quote material from a source without acknowledging that source or when you copy material directly, you cause the reader to believe that the thoughts and ideas are your own. Such behavior is unethical because it involves misrepresentation and denies the original author proper acknowledgment. Students engaging in plagiarism may suffer academic integrity penalties and face possible expulsion from school. Worse, you could be sued for monetary and other damages.

When in doubt, check with a legal representative regarding the latest copyright laws.

Copyrighting affords legal protection for one's creative efforts. A copyright is granted to an author, publisher, or distributor for the exclusive publication, sale, and distribution of an original work. Violating copyrights is both unethical and illegal; originators of work may sue to reclaim any losses caused by copyright violations. However, not all countries share the same attitudes and respect for a copyright. The Russian computer market is growing very rapidly—an estimated 30 to 50 percent annually, but software companies say that more than 90 percent of the programs used are pirated; a similar situation exists in some Asian countries.

Key Areas for Ethical Communication

Ethical treatment of a subject takes time, thought, and preparation. As a manager, it is important for you to focus on ethical communication in three key areas:

Communication Probe

Pirated software has been a problem for American, Japanese, and European computer companies. The software industry estimates that Russian counterfeiting alone cost it $75 million in 1993. Wherever the concept of private ownership is not developed, copyright issues can be viewed as unimportant.

Krantz, P. (1994). Taking on the "Superpower of Privacy." *Business Week, 340*(4), 166b.

Your personal written and spoken messages, cross-cultural messages, and the advertising your company creates. The latter area is important because our work is becoming increasingly international, and sensitivity to diversity is now an important managerial skill.

Personal Written and Spoken Messages

Your messages, both written and spoken, demonstrate not only the message you intend but also a message regarding your values and integrity. Use the guidelines in Checklist 4.1 to evaluate your purpose and motives in each situation.

Checklist 4.1 Guidelines for Ethical Spoken and Written Messages[11]

1. *Message purpose.* If my purpose is accomplished, will it be in the best interests of my listeners? Will a small group benefit, or will the larger organization/society be served? Do I have any hidden agendas that affect my purpose and/or thesis?

2. *Research methods.* Are my sources recent, reliable, and unbiased? Was my research thorough? Have I explored all avenues in gathering information pertinent to my subject and purpose?

3. *Selection of material.* Have I chosen information that will communicate my ideas fairly and accurately? Are my sources representative of the information available on my topic? Have I avoided the propaganda technique of card stacking (omitting relevant opposing information)?

4. *Development of ideas.* Have I relied too heavily on emotional appeals? Is my logic and reasoning sound? Have I avoided propaganda techniques that omit, exaggerate, or otherwise distort information? Is my information accurate and relevant?

5. *Use of language.* Am I easily understood by my listeners? Is my language appropriately concrete and specific, or have I relied on ambiguities, abstractions, and loaded words? Does my language show respect for my listeners?

6. *Ethical context.* Have I considered my listener's values, feelings, and attitudes in designing my presentation? Have I avoided using communication strategies that would take advantage of their role, status, or background?

7. *Self-analysis.* Do I feel comfortable with the purpose and development of my presentation? Do I sincerely believe that what I have to communicate is important and true? Have I done everything possible to prepare a message that is within my ethical comfort zone?

Cross-Cultural Messages

Never before have so many people from different cultures lived and worked together. Our world has become a global village, and our work force reflects that diversity. Because we have such different customs and ways of communicating, it is natural that misunderstandings occur in the workplace.

Ethical communicators anticipate and avoid cross-cultural miscommunication whenever possible and avoid gaining an advantage based on misunderstanding. The cross-cultural ethical outline in Checklist 4.2 will help you assess your ethicality in multicultural situations.

Advertising Messages

Gaining customers through false advertising is both unlawful and unethical.

It is ethically wrong to advertise products in ways that confuse. Whether promoting a college jazz event, a getaway weekend, or a line of products for a multimillion dollar company, the rule for ethical advertising is consistent: *Tell the truth, don't misrepresent, and don't manipulate language to create a false impression.* The small gain realized by misrepresentation is not worth the loss of company reputation and customer trust. A recent issue of "Consumer Reports" noted an advertisement from Travel Consulting Inc. offering an 8-day "White Christmas in Russia" package for $599. But you could not go at Christmas time. Small print

Checklist 4.2 Cross-Cultural Ethical Guidelines

1. *Cultural context.* Have I considered the other individual's values, feelings, and attitudes from his or her cultural point of view? Have I attempted to understand the context of the transaction from the other person's position? Do I believe that all the other people involved fully understand the context of the transaction and all its implications?

2. *Misunderstandings.* Have I anticipated and tried to correct any possible misunderstandings that might occur? Have I attempted to gain an understanding of the other party's culture and what their expectations might be?

3. *Language.* Have I used language that can be clearly understood by others? Am I taking care not to use language and expressions that might be offensive to another culture? Am I aware of the nonverbal aspects of my message and the ways they might change the message in a different culture?

4. *Accountability.* Have I completely fulfilled my own standard for cross-cultural ethics? How would I feel if my family and friends knew all the details of the transaction? Am I being fair to all involved? How would I feel if the events were published on the front page of the newspaper?

explained that the price was good to December 16 or after January 10. If you wanted to be in Russia during Christmas, it would cost $200 more.[12]

Recently, consumers have complained about confusing food label advertising. Claims about "healthy," "low fat," "reduced fat," and "fat-free" (yet often with considerable cholesterol) products have befuddled consumers trying to eat sensibly. When Veryfine Company prints the phrase "100% natural juice drink" on the side of a juice can, does that mean the majority of the product is juice or sweetened water? In this case, the product is 25 percent juice.

Minute Maid, a division of Coca Cola, also prints "100% natural" on cans of its "juice drink." If we don't read the smaller print on the side of the can, or we don't understand that the insertion of the word *drink* after the word *juice* means sweetened water was added, we might think we are buying pure "natural" juice. "Consumer Reports" chastised Minute Maid for printing "New Easy-to Mix Instructions" on newly designed cans of raspberry lemonade.[13] In reality, the older cans called for 4½ cans of water, yielding 64 ounces of lemonade, while the newer can called for only 3 cans of water, resulting of course in less lemonade (48 ounces, or 25 percent less).

Advertisers should also consider the moral consequences of impressions created by advertising. The media, particularly television, plays a major role in shaping our ideas and opinions of events. Is it ethical to depict stereotypes or to portray a group of people in a negative light? Consider the results of the study in the Communication Probe.

Questions you should ask yourself regarding ethical advertising are cited in Checklist 4.3.

Ethics and Organizational Responsibility

Workplaces are mixes of many ethical values; each person brings a personal view of what is ethical.

Organizations dominate our life and workplace. These organizations typically attempt to create a corporate culture. But the task is difficult: Our individual ethical beliefs are extremely complex and diverse. How can an organization with employees from different ethnic backgrounds, religious perspectives, and family values have a common set of beliefs? Think of the organizations in which you have worked. Did you share the same beliefs about work and personal commitment as others in the organization? What about values such as honesty, commit-

Communication Probe

Social learning theory tells us that children learn appropriate social behavior by imitating modeled behavior. Advertising in magazines and television offers children many such models. Should we be concerned about the content of advertising? One study of magazine advertising revealed that children are primarily depicted in nonscholarly roles (such as athletics). When children were shown in school-related roles, they were frequently portrayed as "eggheads" or "nerds."

Peterson, R. T. (1994). Depiction of idealized youth lifetyles in magazine advertisements: A content analysis. *Journal of Business Ethics, 13,* 259–269.

Checklist 4.3 Ethical Guidelines for Advertising

1. *Language.* Have I represented the product or event using clear, straightforward language, taking care not to make exaggerated claims? Is the language truthful? Can the product be taken at face value?

2. *Graphics/print.* Do the graphics used in the advertising depict the product accurately? Is any of the significant information in small print, or is it placed in an unobtrusive spot? If so, does this slant the customer's perception of the product?

3. *Omission.* Have I omitted any key details that may affect the way the customer views the advertised product? Is significant information unstated? Would it change the customer's perception of the product if this information were included?

4. *Truth.* Does the product or event live up to the claims made in the advertising? Is it a quality product that can fulfill all the expectations of the customer?

5. *Accountability.* Would I be comfortable if my advertising techniques were scrutinized by a customer products magazine and the results printed for the public to read? Would I want to have a face-to-face meeting with a group of consumers who purchased my product?

ment, and concern for others? Were your views different from others? Did you fully accept the values and standards of the organization as you came to understand them?

Organizations are stronger than individuals; organizations have access to money, which gives them the power to influence others. Money purchases both power and influence: One need only look at the hundreds of lobby groups in Washington, D.C., to understand the scope of their influence. Corporations must think carefully about the extent to which they use money to purchase influence.

Formal Versus Informal Ways of Communicating Ethics

Companies must determine whether it is better to suggest ethical values from the top down or the bottom up.

Should managers decide the values of an organization—much like strategic policy—and communicate them downward to individual members? Or should ethical statements and values emerge from the ranks of employees themselves? Are ethics more effective when members are *told* what to do? Or are organizational values stronger if created from the middle and lower ranks of organizations, thus reflecting what the majority of workers believe? How do people in an organization come to know and understand the beliefs others hold? These are questions

companies must answer as they seek to define and make ethics part of the organization's culture.

Formal. An example of using ethics formally, as strategic policy, can be found in the Ben and Jerry's ice cream company, a leader among socially responsible companies. A percentage of their company profits is channeled into charitable organizations that support environmental concerns and the homeless. Even though other companies do this to some extent, Ben and Jerry's has made social responsibility and ethics a part of its corporate culture. To ensure salary equity between employees and managers, the company has a salary ratio formula in which the highest-paid employee makes no more than seven times the salary of the lowest-paid employee.[14] When organizations use a top-down approach to communicate ethical standards, they typically express ethical values in the following three ways:

1. *Public messages.* Formal statements of organizational values and ethics appear in speeches by CEOs and in public statements such as press releases and annual reports. Speeches and press releases frequently follow an organizational crisis, and when the crisis calls the organization's values into question, high-level executives usually attempt to explain the company's position. Ethical statements are also found in the body of the annual report or the chairperson's letter preceding the report. Executives use these channels to formally communicate the ethics and values of the organization to employees, stockholders, and other constituencies.

Inherent in any public statement from a company is an ethical message.

2. *Employee manuals and policy statements.* Ethical statements appear in employee policy books and manuals, which typically contain the rules and regulations of the organization. Many courts view the employee manual as a contract between the employee and employer; language used in these manuals must be carefully constructed. Organizations publishing their ethical statements in manuals need to make sure the statements are communicated in other ways in addition to the manual. Many employees do not read the employee manual or merely consult sections on a need-to-know basis. The organization's ethical statements may not receive much attention unless they are reinforced and communicated through other channels in the organization.

Ethical codes are becoming more prominent in written documents of organizations.

3. *Mission statements and ethical codes.* Mission statements attempt to address fundamental strategic issues that distinguish the business from others. Product and market are often core to identifying the business. Although they differ from corporate ethical codes by more directly addressing strategic planning and bottom-line issues, mission statements may contain statements of values and ideals. To avoid confusion, however, it is better to keep strategy in the mission statement and place value statements in the ethical code.

   Ethical codes are written documents that state the ethics and values of an organization. Firms frequently attempt to manage ethics through these codes, often intending the code for both internal and external au-

diences. A code may be part of a personnel policy manual, or it may be a separately issued document. Some have affidavits of understanding that require the employee's signature. Most important, they are messages by which organizations shape employee behavior and effect change through explicit statements of desired behavior.

If ethics are not part of a formal strategic policy and communicated as such, values and ethics will generally emerge from day-to-day expectations and will be communicated informally throughout the organization. Here are three ways in which that might happen.

Over time, through workers and managers or through the organization itself, a corporation creates its ethical structure.

Informal. First, culture and values are imported into organizations through membership; that is, individual organizational members bring their attitudes and values into the organization. Second, organizations themselves are social instruments producing their own value systems. Besides creating values systems, organizations frequently produce symbols of these values, such as rituals, customs, and legends, that reinforce their meaning. Awards for safety, outstanding customer service, or honesty may symbolize organizational ethics. Third, symbolic acts of managers can create culture and corporate values. When managers act in organizations, others in the organization observe and model their behavior, and their actions are interpreted symbolically. Thus, managers, as seen in their behavior, shape and influence the direction of organizational values.

Organizations that want to manage their ethics better should explore both formal and informal ways of establishing and communicating ethics. Both ways are useful in creating an ethical culture, and managers may want to use both paths simultaneously.

SUMMARY

As a manager, some of your ethical dilemmas will be an easy call: The ethical concerns will be obvious; you can quickly make the right decision. Others will be more difficult. Ethics is often a communication issue. Your employees and coworkers learn about your ethics and values by observing your actions. Modeling ethical behavior is an important managerial tool.

Communication Probe

Corporate ethical codes address many different subjects, ranging from what type of gift may be accepted to respecting the rights and opinions of those with whom you work. A study in the *Journal of Business Ethics* showed that the five most common subjects found in corporate ethical codes are (1) conflict of interest, (2) gifts, bribery, and kickbacks, (3) misuse of confidential information, (4) violation of laws, and (5) personal character issues.

Stevens, B. (1994). An analysis of corporate ethical code studies: Where do we go from here? *Journal of Business Ethics, 13,* 63–69.

Your family and peers influence your personal ethics, as well as your culture, philosophy, local, state, and federal laws, and even your religious perspective. Managers need to be aware of these influences, especially monitoring their ethics in written and spoken messages, in cross-cultural communication, and in advertising. Three checklists in this chapter help you focus on key ethical areas.

Finally, this chapter examined how ethics are communicated in organizations using downward communication and how ethical values and statements also emerge from the lower and middle echelons of the organization. Both are viable ways by which organizations create ethical values.

As we move into the twenty-first century, most of us will be producing and analyzing information rather than manufacturing goods. Because the quality and integrity of this information permeate the entire product, ethics plays an increasingly important role in these new organizations. Defects in durable goods are more easily spotted than defects in the culture of an organization. Our dependence on accurate, uncompromised, quality information increases daily as does our need for a stronger, unwavering sense of ethics in the workplace.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Teams of 3 to 5 Assess a Current Ethical Situation.*** In March 1995, Nicholas Leeson, a 28-year-old trader in Singapore, allegedly helped precipitate bankruptcy of the 232-year-old British merchant banking firm of Barings P.L.C. While it was not one of the prime players of the British financial scene, Barings was a venerable banking firm, perhaps best known for overseeing the financial aspects of the Louisiana Purchase. Leeson got involved in mortgage derivatives and purchased an extraordinary number of futures contracts on the Nikkei stock exchange resulting in losses of over $1 billion. In December 1995, a Singapore court sentenced Leeson to 6 years and 6 months.

   Activity: Teams research different aspects of the Barings P.L.C. bankruptcy and report the results of their research orally to the class.

   Team 1—The background of the problem: Present facts about Barings and Leeson.

   Team 2—The event: Describe the event that allegedly bankrupted the firm.

   Team 3—The ethical dilemma: Identify the ethical issues in this case.

   Team 4—The future: Explore ways of preventing a recurrence of this type of event.

   Team 5—(in collaboration with Team 4) The decision: Choose one of the team's suggestions and defend why it would be effective.

2. ***Panel Discussion.*** Business transactions with other countries are sometimes difficult because of the different cultural expectations. However, since the passage of NAFTA and markets in China and Russia opening up, the

volume of worldwide business has increased dramatically, but not without new problems. Foreign banks have recently learned that doing business in China is far more complex than originally thought. A credit crunch in 1989 caused loan defaults on several shaky hotel projects, and foreign banks learned that Beijing does not always honor the commitments provincial governments or state-owned banks made. Forty-five percent of China's state-owned enterprises lose money, so not paying on loans is a way of life.[15]

Are the Chinese being unethical? Research this situation in more depth and discuss the pros and cons of investing. What ethical issues impact on this scenario?

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***An Ethical Dilemma for Discussion.*** Most American hotel companies will *not* contact you if you leave a valuable item behind in one of their rooms. This is done not out of a desire to keep the item (assuming the person who found it turned it in) but to protect your privacy in case you were not where you were supposed to be or in case you were with someone who was not your spouse or family member. Is it ethical for a hotel to act in this manner? Is the hotel engaging in complicity for clandestine meetings?

4. ***Teams of Two Debate Ethical Issues.*** Argue the affirmative side of one of the following issues and find an opponent to take the opposite side of the issue. The first speaker defends the statement with an 8-minute presentation and then is followed by the negative speaker, who also speaks for 8 minutes. The affirmative side then gives a 4-minute rebuttal, followed by the negative speaker.

   a. Americans should place greater trust in corporate America.

   b. U.S. firms should not advertise products on the television show *Beavis and Butthead.*

   c. Employees should be allowed to keep the frequent-flyer miles they earn during corporate travel.

   d. Business ethics should be a required course in the M.B.A. curriculum.

   e. Business should be primarily concerned with making a profit and less with social responsibility.

   f. Sexually explicit uniforms are acceptable in certain occupations.

   g. Affirmative action laws have accomplished their purpose and should be abolished.

   h. Copying/sharing software programs is an acceptable practice for college students.

   i. Americans have become too concerned about being "politically correct."

j. It is unethical for colleges and universities to draft legislation limiting free speech even if it involves hate language and racism.

k. A businessperson should refuse all gifts valued over $25 from clients or customers.

l. Food labels confuse the consumers and should be further legislated.

m. Every company should have a policy on AIDS in the workplace.

n. All organizations should allow opportunities for indoor smoking on their premises.

o. The public has a right to know if their doctor or dentist has tested HIV-positive.

p. Mandatory retirement at age 70 should be abolished.

5. ***Case Discussion: Sexual Harassment.*** Read the case "Incident on the Cruise Ship *Princess Maria.*" Discuss the questions at the end of the case.

Incident on the Cruise Ship *Princess Maria*

The S.S. *Princess Maria* is a 65,000-ton cruise ship, offering first-class and luxury accommodations to 1,525 passengers. The ship is 700 feet long, with a beam of 110 feet and a cruising speed of 19 knots. The ship features a deck of suites, a number of cabins with verandas, two show lounges, three dining rooms, and two outdoor swimming pools in addition to a number of other excellent features. You feel fortunate to have landed a position on this ship and have been enjoying the sights of Acapulco, Puerto Vallarta, the Islas Marias, and Mazatlán during your time off.

As assistant director of human resources, you are responsible, along with the director, for the policies and procedures aboard the ship, administering benefits, and processing requests for leave for the 800 crew members. You report to the director of human resources, Ron Adams, who is not aboard for this 6-day cruise because of an illness in his family. Ron is planning to return next week.

Employee relations aboard ship are fairly good. This is an affable crew with seemingly few problems. You've made several good friends during your 6-month tenure and are enjoying working with the rest of the people. A "hot spot," however, seems to be the ship's galley. A few minor incidents have occurred—mostly people shouting at one another—since you have been aboard. Ron filled you in on the details but generally expressed no real concerns.

"You know how galleys are—they're like a lot of restaurant kitchens—a free-wheeling atmosphere and some "blue" language. It goes with the pressure of producing volumes of high-quality food under pressure," Ron exclaimed, in a discussion you had before he left. Ron also expressed the opinion that most of the individuals involved were just "blowing off steam." Estebán Phillipe, a first cook, and one of the pot washers, Tomás, seemed to get into it more than others.

This morning, however, one of the salad makers, Miranda, and a desserts-preparation woman, Carlina, came to your office to register a complaint. "I've been sexually harassed," claimed Miranda." "Tomás has been coming on to me." When you asked what he said, Miranda replied, "Last week he patted me on the fanny when I walked by, and this week he asked me to have a drink with him after work." You look at Mi-

randa, an obviously attractive woman with long dark hair. Miranda's issued uniform is unusually short. She has apparently shortened the hem so that the skirt is about 5 inches above her knees. Someone else in the gallery had mentioned this fact to you earlier in the week.

Then Carlina, a married woman who lives with her husband in Puerta Vallarta during her times off, chimed in. "Yes, Tomás is a problem. He winked at me last week when I walked by. But the real problem is Estebán Phillipe. Do you know what he said to me last week?" Carlina's face was flushed with anger. "He said, 'I hope your husband appreciates what he's getting at home,' I am highly offended by that remark." Carlina looked even more upset.

The phone rings. Your secretary reminds you of an executive meeting in 5 minutes on the Texas Deck. You express your concerns to Miranda and Carlina, telling them you will look into the matter *and* talk with them both at greater length.

After the women leave, you have just a few minutes, but it is enough time to quickly scan the policies and procedures manual. Your company's sexual harassment policy warns that such behavior will not be tolerated. It also cautions against creating a "hostile climate" in the workplace. The policy regarding uniforms states that employees must wear their issued uniforms while on duty but says nothing about a prescribed skirt length or altering a uniform.

At this point you need to decide whether sexual harassment has occurred and whether the policies of the organization have been violated. You also want to identify and analyze the communication problems that your galley employees are experiencing.

Activity: Role-play the events in this case, adding any nonverbal communication that the actors think is appropriate. Next, role-play an informational interview between you and Tómas, in which your purpose is to listen to his side of the story. Do the same thing with Estebán Phillipe.

Policy Book of the Princess Cruise Lines, Inc.

Sexual harrassment will not be tolerated by any employee of the Princess Maria.

Definition
Sexual harassment includes unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, and other verbal or physical conduct or communication of a sexual nature when:

1. Submission to such conduct or communication is made a term or condition either explicitly or implicitly to obtain employment.

2. Submission to or rejection of such conduct or communication by an individual is used as a factor in decisions affecting such individual's employment.

3. Such conduct or communication has the purpose or effect of substantially interfering with an individual's employment.

4. Such conduct is repeated and creates a hostile climate for the employee.

Management of the Princess Maria expressly forbids all employees from harassing any other employee. A violation of this policy will result in appropriate disciplinary action, up to and including termination.

Any employee who believes (s)he is being sexually harassed should report the incident or situation to the Director of Human Resources. As an employer, the management cannot remedy situations in which harassment is alleged unless it has prompt notice of it. All complaints of sexual harassment from any individual will be investigated thoroughly and prompt remedial action will be taken. Sometimes, however, the perceived harassment may simply result from misunderstanding. An off-hand remark or off-color joke may be offensive to some but not to others. If the situation is reported promptly, appropriate corrective action can be taken.

Dress Code Policy

Personal appearance and dress are especially important on board the Princess Maria, as most employees are in constant contact with our guests. All employees, even those in nonpublic areas, are expected to dress in a professional manner.

Employees must wear their issued uniforms while on duty and are expected to be neat, clean, and tidy at all times.

Questions for discussion:

1. Identify the problems you need to address.
2. What should be your next step?
3. Have Tomás and Estebán Phillipe behaved offensively toward these women?
4. Does Miranda's short skirt justify Tomás' actions?
5. What cross-cultural problems may exist here?
6. What actions, if any, do you plan to take?

6. Business intelligence has become a booming business. Spying on other companies is on the increase as firms try to become more competitive. American and foreign firms appear to be adopting the military model of intelligence gathering. Increasingly, firms specializing in espionage are using military intelligence tactics to gather information from competing firms. They generate $500 million in revenue annually.[16]

Write a short (1- or 2-page) position paper on the ethics of company espionage.

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Chapter 5

Business Communication and the Technology Context

I. Managing Information Within Organizations
- A. History of Technological Developments
- B. Challenges to the Organization Made by New Technologies

II. E-Mail
- A. Defining E-Mail
- B. Using E-Mail
- C. Understanding How E-Mail Works
- D. Understanding the Internet
- E. Establishing Security

III. Other Communication Technologies
- A. Voice Mail
- B. Groupware
- C. CD-ROM Databases
- D. Teleconferences
- E. Faxes

IV. Managing Information Outside Organizations
- A. Managing the News Media
- B. Managing Corporate News
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You are sitting at your computer when you hear the familiar musical chord that announces an incoming message. You activate your interview line, and the communication manager of your company appears in the corner of your screen. "Thought you would be interested in this memo from headquarters," she says, "regarding the new communication system we're installing. Soon we'll be completely wireless, and you'll be able to receive and transmit images that can fill your screen rather than sit in the corner of it." She chuckles. "That's assuming you *want* a larger image of whoever you're talking to!" You chat for a few minutes while the copy of the memo is being sent. Within a minute or two, your printer gives you a copy of the memo. You say goodbye and deactivate your interview line.

The growth of information technology over the past 30 years has transformed the way business is transacted throughout the world. Obvious effects of the new technologies include a marked increase in the amount and availability of information and greater speed in sending and receiving it. Other, less obvious effects are changes in organizational structure from the diminishing importance of physical location in running a business. Additional changes involve requirements in computer literacy even for entry-level positions and changes in individuals' work demand and expectations. All these factors may generate more stress as the amount and speed of available information eliminates the time for reflection that older, slower systems allowed. Information technology is also changing the conventions of written communication, favoring more direct and informal styles and promoting more collaborative types of communication.

Internationally, the instantaneous availability of information has communicated and influenced social, political, and economic events, such as the detailed coverage of the Persian Gulf War and the earthquake in Kobe, Japan. Information technology has generated a new international economy. Each day throughout the world, more than $1 trillion is transferred electronically, and more than $300 billion by foreign exchange transactions. To put these numbers in perspective, the total world trade in physical goods is about $4 trillion *a year.*[1]

This chapter presents information on managing information within organizations, using the new and developing technologies with special emphasis on E-mail—its systems, uses, etiquette, costs and benefits, and security. Other communication technologies, such as groupware, faxes, and telexes, are also briefly described. We also include material on managing information outside your organization, such as how to deal with the news media, how to be a good company spokesperson, and how to prevent and control corporate crises.

MANAGING INFORMATION WITHIN ORGANIZATIONS

Because of rapidly changing technological developments, you, as business managers, now have to know something about information technology in order to manage it as effectively as you manage people and products. In the beginning of the information explosion, this was not true; technical specialists and consultants handled all the necessary details and problems. But with the changes brought about by personal computers and individual access to information anywhere in the world, information technology is now everyone's business.

History of Technological Developments

Nineteenth century developments such as the telegraph and telephone marked the beginning of the rapid growth in information technology.

All methods of communication beginning with the development of language itself can be considered technological developments. However, the inventions toward the end of the nineteenth century and the beginning of the twentieth, such as the telegraph and the telephone, marked the beginning of the rapid growth leading to today's ever-changing information technology. Telex machines, the direct ancestor of E-mail, are not used much anymore. Faxes are widely used, and their use increases daily. Faxes are also precursors of today's E-mail and networking systems.

In the 1960s, some companies became attracted to computer technology to handle data processing. The computers used by these progressive companies were huge mainframes, with tubes and reels of storage tape; they were so big that they often filled a large room. Terminals—video screens with keyboards—were hooked up to the mainframe. Programming had to be done from scratch because there was no packaged software, and computer programmers, often people with no expertise in business or management, owned the technology.

Developments in information technology that led to more powerful and less expensive personal computers have facilitated the growth of electronic information in today's businesses.

By the 1970s, more people had computer terminals that had access to central information on large mainframes. Some packaged software was developed so that certain tasks did not have to be programmed from scratch. However, computers were expensive, and costs rose as companies without clear needs for them were persuaded to invest in information technology.

The transformation of telecommunications in the 1980s, with the development of fiber optics, local area networks, and satellite technology, along with the new, more powerful personal computers, facilitated the growth of information technology in organizations. Organizations now have laptop computers, desktop publishing capabilities, electronic spreadsheets, and word processing programs to gather, store, and communicate information. Turmoil and change are the norm for information technology, and they reflect and influence the concurrent changes in business organizations on structure, profits, people, and society.

Communication Probe

In the 1960s, E-mail was called computer-based messaging system (CBMS). Western Union first registered the trademark "Electronic Mail" in 1974. It was also during the sixties that most of the stereotypes of computers and computer people developed. Computer "nerds" were thought to be antisocial, interested only in bits and bytes. Many of these early information systems professionals were, however, resistant to the development of personal computers. Not only did they not want amateurs playing around with information systems, but they also had justifiable worries regarding the security of confidential information.

Keen, P. G. (1995). *Every manager's guide to information technology* (p. 17). Boston: Harvard Business School Press; Gibbons, D., Fox, D., Westenbroek, A., Cravens, D., & Shafran, A. (1994). *Using e-mail* (p. 9). Indianapolis, IN: Ewing.

Challenges to the Organization Made by New Technologies

As future business leaders, you will need to understand and manage the transitions facing you in business operations. According to some researchers, the problem is not so much technical since the technology itself has become increasingly easier to use, but rather organizational because new structures must be set up to manage information in a world forever changed by it.[2] Those of you who can enter the global marketplace with a knowledge of information technology and an ability to manage change will be the successful business leaders of the twenty-first century.

Additionally, there is the question of control over content. During the time of carbon copies, it was relatively easy to oversee who received what and when. Those days are gone. With computer hackers invading electronic databases, and even employers eavesdropping, control over that data is becoming increasingly difficult. What we thought was secure is, sadly, now easier to access. All these issues affect both the form and the content of messages.

E-MAIL

Although E-mail used to be limited to major universities with computing resources, it is now growing in use in companies throughout the world. With the development of PCs that can be networked worldwide, software programs that make communicating easy, and less expensive hardware and software, E-mail is beginning to dominate day-to-day communications in business organizations.

Defining E-Mail

E-mail refers to messages sent over computers and includes everything from casual notes to friends to multimedia presentations sent across the world.

Electronic mail (E-mail) lets you send a message to a person without your making direct contact or knowing where that person is located. Subscribers to electronic mail services are called *users,* and as a user, you can access messages on your system from your home, office, hotel, or anywhere you happen to be.

Several basic components make up E-mail systems, including users, messages, senders' and recipients' addresses, protocols, messaging transports, gateways, value-added networks, and directory systems. Users are often people, but users can also be other computer application programs. A message is the actual information sent by one user to another. Part of the E-mail information included in a message is the addresses of both sender and receiver, which include their unique identification codes along with another identifier such as the E-mail system, the mailbox number, or the organization. Each E-mail system uses a protocol that describes the structure of the message, generally with a header of TO:, FROM:, and SUBJECT:, followed by the body, which may include text, images, graphics, video, and audio.

The software that moves the message from one system to another is called the transport. If the message sent from one system must get to a user on another system, it must pass through a gateway to be delivered. A gateway is an application program that translates between two protocols of different E-mail systems. Value-added networks (VANs) are public telecommunication companies, such as AT&T or MCI, that handle E-mail services to users for a fee. As a user, you can

Communication Probe

In 1994, an estimated 30 million people were users of E-mail in the United States alone, with growth averaging 30 percent a year. For comparison, the number of users in 1983 was only about 1 million. Much of the interest in E-mail has come from academic communities, whose researchers have seen the possibilities of the Internet for information access. As software companies continue to make this complex exchange of information increasingly user-friendly, more business organizations and individuals are jumping on the E-mail bandwagon.

Keen, P. G. (1995). *Every manager's guide to information technology* (p. 134). Boston: Harvard Business School Press.

access a directory that contains names, addresses, and sometimes other information about each user to find the E-mail address you need to send a message.

Using E-Mail

With E-mail, you can reach individuals, groups, or other computers anywhere in the world to share information, files of data, spreadsheets, videos, music, and anything else that can be stored on a computer.

E-mail combines some of the characteristics of writing and speaking. As a user, you have the immediacy of communicating directly to your receiver along with the advantages of being able to compose and revise a written message. E-mail can save you time in printing, copying, and distributing your messages. You can use E-mail to send and receive faxes and telexes. You can reach groups as well as individuals and share files of data, spreadsheets, videos, music, and anything else you can store on a computer. Computer programs themselves can use E-mail to monitor such things as inventory levels and communicate to a person or another computer the information. For example, a computer at Hughes Aircraft Company in Los Angeles recently sent a short memo to a computer several hundred miles away at the Boeing Company. With only the press of a button, the message left a Hughes IBM computer, was picked up by MCI Mail, transferred to Telemail, and finally deposited in a Digital Equipment computer at Boeing.[3]

E-mail is also useful in your personal communications. You can communicate with friends and family anywhere in the world. And because many universities give free E-mail accounts to their students, you can keep in touch with your college-age children without having to make an appointment for a telephone call.

E-mail writing conventions tend to be less rather than more formal.

Writing conventions for E-mail are still developing, but one characteristic appears to be a more informal approach. Most business people handle their own E-mail, and because most of their messages are read only and not printed on paper, they tend to drop the formalities of traditional correspondence. Punctuation and capitalization can vary from one E-mail user to another, with some people omitting *all* punctuation and capitalization except for periods at the ends of sentences. The immediacy and perceived informality of E-mail tempts many people into composing rambling messages. Effective communicators, however, will analyze the situation to determine the degree of formality needed in the message and will often put the important information "up front."

Understanding How E-Mail Works

To send an E-mail message, you do the following:

- Log on. This means connecting to a computer, network, or E-mail program. It requires the user's name and a password.
- Choose the receivers of your message. For this step, you need to know the E-mail addresses of your recipients.
- Compose the message.
- Instruct the program to send the message.

To read your E-mail messages, you do the following:

- Log on.
- Look at a list of your new mail.
- Choose the message you want to read.
- Handle the current message by deleting, storing, printing, forwarding, or replying.
- Continue to read your messages.

What you see and the commands you use in sending and receiving messages is the front end of your E-mail system. The back end of the system consists of the message store, where received messages are kept before they are read, the transport agent, which determines how mail is moved from one mailbox to another, and the directory agent, which contains the names of users and allows mail to be routed to the proper person.

In the beginning, each E-mail user had an individual mailbox. All messages were saved in that mailbox. However, the private mailbox system wasted a lot of space, and so new ways were developed to handle messages. A modern E-mail package stores one copy of each message and sets up pointers that show to whom the message was sent. When a person has new mail, the pointer is active. Most E-mail programs do not store messages in individual files; they hold them in large data packages, which saves room and makes locating messages easier.

Understanding the Internet

Internet is a large group of computer networks connecting individuals and groups to services and information throughout the world.

Called the "Net" by many people, the Internet is a wide-ranging group of computer networks that connect government, the military, educational institutions, companies, and individuals to services and information throughout the world. E-mail on the Net can be either person to person or person to group. You may have access to the Internet through school, your workplace, a commercial provider, or a freenet. Commercial providers include CompuServe and America Online; a freenet is a publicly available Internet access site provided by some communities and usually free to residents.

CompuServe and America Online are two commercial services that offer access to Internet information as well as other services, such as shopping services, ticket services for sports and other events, and many others.

CompuServe, or the CompuServe Information Service (CIS) is the largest commercial on-line service, with millions of subscribers throughout the world.[4] With CompuServe, you can get tickets to shows and sports events, shop for clothes and jewelry, hire a financial analyst or a computer consultant, subscribe to magazines, watch an all-news television channel, get current stock prices, and review the weather anywhere in the world. America Online, although smaller

Communication Probe

E-Mail Addresses of Interest

president@whitehouse.gov (Gets you to the President)
vice-president@whitehouse.gov (Gets you to the Vice President)
congress@hr.house.gov (U.S. House of Representatives. Many representatives have E-mail services; this address can tell you which ones.)
abcnews@class.org (ABC News research center)
cnnglobal@aol.com (CNN Global News)
cspanguest@aol.com (C-SPAN call in)
nightly@news.nbc.com (NBC Nightly News)
foxnet@delphi.com (Fox Television Network)
voa-europe@voa.gov (Voice of America, Europe)
iac@bbc-ibar.deamon.co.uk (BBC World Service)
lateshow@pipeline.com (*The Late Show with David Letterman*)
herb_hildebrandt@umich.edu (one of the authors of this book)
thomasej@umich.edu (one of the authors of this book)

Thousands of additional E-mail addresses are listed in almost all reference books on electronic mail.

Gibbons, D., Fox, D. Westenbroek, A., Cravens, D., & Shafran, A. (1994). *Using e-mail* (pp. 354–365). Indianapolis, IN: Ewing.

than CompuServe, is one of the fastest-growing companies in the country. It offers subscribers a wide range of information and services as well as ease of use and affordability.

The Internet originally grew out of a network funded by the Defense Department in the 1960s for use in civilian research. Later the National Science Foundation funded a new, high-speed network to provide communication between supercomputers. Most users have traditionally been academics, researchers, and engineers, although with the growth in the types of information and services available, more and more businesses are getting on the "information superhighway." Among the almost limitless Internet services available on E-mail are such resources as File Transfer Protocol (FTP), a way of transferring files and software to your computer; Archie, a way of locating files on the Internet; Gopher, a way of accessing archives of documents and information; and an online dictionary. As a base for an Information Superhighway in the United States, the Internet will provide a national public data network for all subscribers.

E-Mail Etiquette

Be clear, concise, and polite when you send an E-mail message; the same general guidelines for good business writing should always apply.

Because E-mail is fairly immediate and generally less formal than other forms of written communication, you may be tempted to relax the tone, organization, and content of your message. However, most of the advice applicable to your printed messages is relevant to your electronic messages. Remember the following:

- Watch your tone. Because of the conversational aspect of E-mail and the fact that you are sitting in privacy, you may be tempted to be too casual. Your formality will depend on your relationship with your receiver.
- Be concise. Long, rambling messages are just as ineffective on E-mail as they are in print.
- Send a message only if you have something important to say. It can be daunting to come back to your office from lunch and see 75 messages waiting for you on E-mail.
- Forward the mail to the appropriate address if you receive a message that was not meant for you. You may want to alert the sender that the message was sent to the wrong address.
- Be polite. Even when you are communicating with a group of users you have never met, you should not get involved in a "flame" war. "Flaming" is an E-mail term meaning to insult, provoke, or comment too much about something that is irrelevant or tasteless.

E-Mail Signs and Symbols

Because of the limitations of language in E-mail systems, users have developed some interesting conventions to show emotion. For example, consider the following message:

```
WHEN DID YOU SAY YOU WERE DOING THAT JOB?

I CAN'T BELIEVE IT'S TAKING SO LONG!
```

This message is the E-mail equivalent of shouting. The following addition puts it in perspective:

```
Just kidding. :-)
```

Checklist 5.1 lists some common acronyms and abbreviations that you may find in electronic messages.

E-mail messages may also contain *emoticons*, or representations of emotions using keyboard characters. To interpret an emoticon, you must look at the symbol from the side because the expression is "lying down." For example, the common expression for a smiley face is :-), which you can see if you turn your head 90 degrees to the left. Checklist 5.2 lists a few of the more common emoticons.

Establishing Security

Security is one major problem of E-mail due to conflicts between access and control.

Lack of security of information on computer networks is one of the major problems facing business today. Most of today's systems are about as secure as a house with simple locks; they can stop amateurs but are easy for professionals to break into. On-line services are especially vulnerable to credit card and telephone card fraud. And automatic teller machine (ATM) thefts are now costing billions of dollars a year.[5]

Conflicts between access and control are at the bottom of the security prob-

Checklist 5.1 E-Mail Acronyms and Abbreviations

BBL	Be back later
BFN	Bye for now
BRB	Be right back
BTW	By the way
FYI	For your information
<g>	Grin
<G>	Big grin
HSIK	How should I know?
IAE	In any event
IMO	In my opinion
IOW	In other words
LOL	Laughing out loud
NBD	No big deal
ROFL	Rolling on floor laughing
TIA	Thanks in advance
TIC	Tongue in cheek
TTFN	Ta ta for now
TTYL	Talk to you later
WYSIWYG	What you see is what you get

lem. Making network services easy and convenient to use also makes control of the information difficult. The most common method of restricting access is by the use of passwords, which let only authorized users into the system. However, hackers can generally break into passwords quickly and easily. Encryption, a technique that scrambles information to make it unintelligible during transmission, is another level of security. A third strategy some large financial services and telecommunications companies use scans for patterns of activity that suggest misuse.[5]

The problem of security has not yet received the attention it deserves. One reason is that the managers of many companies do not realize how vulnerable their information is and how much damage and loss their company can incur. So far there seems to be little willingness to spend money on this kind of protection. However, as electronic communication develops, so will ways to protect the system and increase security.

Checklist 5.2 Emoticons

:-(	Sad
:-|	Indifferent
;-)	Winking
;-(	Crying
;-D	Laughing
:-\	Undecided
:-P	Tongue hanging out
:-o	Surprised
:-@	Screaming
:-X	Big kiss
:::-)	Wearing glasses
8-)	Wearing sunglasses
:-C	Really sad
:-&	Tongue-tied

OTHER COMMUNICATION TECHNOLOGIES

E-mail developments and the popularity of E-mail use have led to additional communication technologies, including *voice mail, groupware, CD-Rom databases,* and *teleconferencing. Faxes,* which have been around for several decades, are also still common in business communication.

Voice Mail

Voice mail has become popular in many offices because it eliminates "telephone tag."

Voice mail records messages on a computer disk for later retrieval by the receiver. When an incoming call is not answered, the system responds by telling the caller how to leave a message or how to reach someone else. The receiver of the call can then either listen to the machine upon returning to the office or access the message via telephone. This process eliminates the problem of telephone tag, which can be so frustrating.

Groupware

Groupware allows a supervisor to manage the workflow of a department via computer.

Groupware allows several people to use software at the same time to create documents, keep track of projects, route messages, and manage deadlines. Groupware enables a supervisor to manage work flow via individual computers instead of physically moving people from place to place or having face-to-face meetings.

Groupware is a primary force in the growth of the global marketplace. It is central to the current theories of team-based organizations in which hierarchies are breaking down, allowing teams to work interactively from their individual locations. Groupware represents a basic shift in business culture and can be threatening to those brought up with the norms of privacy, hierarchy, face-to-face meetings, reports, and memos.[6]

Lotus Notes is the leading product in the groupware market, although Microsoft and Novell are also working on software of this type. Lotus Notes allows users to work together as if they were in the same room, creating transactions, schedules, and reports. Although it may take many companies a few more years to become comfortable with this new development, companies that remain viable and continue to grow will make the effort. By 1944, there were nearly 750,000 users of Lotus Notes in 3,000 organizations; but that figure represents only 3 percent of networked personal computers.[7]

CD-ROM Databases

Because of their massive storage ability, CD-ROM disks offer multimedia applications, directories, encyclopedias, and other useful information.

Compact Disk–Read Only Memory (CD-ROM) has been available for several years and is becoming more popular. It is a powerful tool for putting masses of information in a form that is easy to digest. Some kinds of information typically found on CD-ROMs are encyclopedias, dictionaries, telephone directories, and articles and abstracts on various subjects.

Storage ability for only one CD-ROM disk far surpasses the 60 to 100 megabytes of disk space on a PC. A CD-ROM disk can store more than 100,000 pages of text as well as high-resolution photos and other graphics. Multimedia applications, including video, audio, graphics, and text, are making CD-ROM storage of information essential; CD-ROMs will continue to grow in popularity.

Communication Probe

Hackers are people who bypass security controls, guess passwords, and enter databases that often contain valuable data. Although many people think of hackers as brilliant renegades, hackers are often thieves who can do a lot of damage to company data and personal information. Hackers can get your credit card number from several company files and make purchases using it. Your social security number is also at risk.

So much of the American economy is now on computer files that the possibilities for quick money are attracting big-time criminals. Balancing the need for easy access of information with security needs is a continuing problem.

Keen, P. G. (1995). *Every manager's guide to information technology* (p. 156). Boston: Harvard Business School Press.

Teleconferences

Telecommunications is the electronic exchange of information. This term used to refer to telephones, telexes, and faxes, but now it comprises a rapidly developing technology that will soon allow high-quality video images and personal conferencing systems that operate on individual PCs.

Teleconferencing is a rapidly developing technology that will eventually change the way companies do business.

Currently, video conferencing has problems, including a high price tag and poor-quality video images on the computer screen. However, some companies are making strides in solving the problems. For example, Intel plans an overhaul of PCs that will make videoconferencing and other multimedia an integral part of the machine.[8] With the aid of special software, the new approach will allow powerful microprocessors to handle data compression instead of the added circuit boards now needed.

Faxes

A facsimile machine scans a printed page, converts it to a signal, and transmits the signal over a telephone line to a receiving fax machine. Although faxes have been available for many years, until recently they were slow and expensive.

Faxes have been available for many years and are popular in business offices; newer fax machines are digital, allowing communication via computer, and are much faster than the old ones.

The oldest type of fax machine had to be connected to a machine of the same type, and the transmission took several minutes. Today's fax machines do not require the same kind of machine at the receiving end, and they can transmit a page in less than 1 minute. The newest fax machines use digital transmission, which makes it possible to use a computer program as a receiver. These new faxes are also much faster.

E-mail and the technologies it has generated are changing the landscape of business communication. Our discussion is only an overview of a complex subject. Several problems need to be addressed as we continue to explore these new technologies. In addition to the problems of expense and quality of electronic messages, there are problems of security, of the transformation of culture the technology requires, and of the very nature of information itself. Certainly the

day is over when only information systems specialists know about and can operate electronic communication systems. Communication technology is something we all need to be comfortable with.

MANAGING INFORMATION OUTSIDE ORGANIZATIONS

In 1982, Johnson and Johnson's Tylenol brand of analgesics outsold the next four leading analgesics combined and contributed about 7 percent of 1981 sales and 15 to 20 percent of profits. Johnson and Johnson executives expected Tylenol to take 50 percent of the market by 1986.[9] However, sometime in the fall of 1982, someone replaced some of the Tylenol Extra-Strength capsules with cyanide-laced capsules, resealed the packages, and put them back on the shelves of at least a half dozen pharmacies and grocery stores in the Chicago area. On September 29, the first of seven people died of cyanide poisoning after taking an Extra-Strength Tylenol capsule. With no warning, McNeil Consumer Products Company, which makes Tylenol, and its parent company, Johnson and Johnson, were plunged into a crisis that could have destroyed not only the product but the company as well.

McNeil and Johnson and Johnson executives took aggressive steps to handle the crisis, and as a result, the ensuing damage did not destroy either product or company. However, the easy access and transmission of information by the news media put Johnson and Johnson executives in a spotlight in which almost every step they took was known and scrutinized by the public. In fact, it was a reporter from the *Chicago Tribune* who first alerted company officials of the problem.

This discussion focuses on how to manage information outside the organization, how to deal with the news media, how to create tools for managing corporate news, what to do if you're a company spokesperson, and how to control a public company crisis. Managing corporate news involves not only knowing how to deal with crises but more often involves handling the day-to-day information that is disseminated to the public through interviews, press releases, conferences, and other channels of communication.

Managing the News Media

News organizations are responsible for most of our knowledge of what goes on in the world.

What we refer to as "the media" are simply channels of information, everything from newspapers, radio, television, magazines, journals, and newsletters. Almost everything we know about what goes on in the world comes from the news media. To professional media people, news is generally categorized into two types: hard news versus soft news. Hard news is out of the ordinary, is timely, and is most often something the public needs to know. Plane crashes and fires are hard news. The Tylenol crisis was hard news. Soft news often includes "feel-good" stories about the kindness of a stranger, the opening of a new art gallery, or a company's new program to help children. Soft news stories are timeless; that is, they can be used within a wider framework of time, and most often they have a positive rather than a negative slant.

Within business organizations, hard news includes such things as annual meetings results, quarterly earnings, or announcement of a new product. Soft news includes material that can inform or educate readers or viewers about the

company, its vision in the world, and its community activities. Often a company manager in charge of media relations will ignore the soft news of the organization, believing that the dedication of a new park sponsored by the company or a piece on its child care facility is not newsworthy. However, soft news can present a company's message effectively and build a foundation of goodwill for its customers.

Managing Corporate News

Several useful tools for communicating to the media are available to you as a company media manager. The most commonly used tools are press releases, interviews, conferences, op-ed pieces, letters to the editor, and talk shows.

Press Releases

A press release is an informational memo from your organization to the news media to get your message to the public.

A press release is simply an information statement made available to any number of sources. So important are the statements that even universities and other nonprofit organizations have public relations departments to distribute newsworthy statements. Some organizations—witness the large number of releases from the White House alone—do so daily. Your problem is often how to get editors, journalists, ad agencies, TV and radio stations to consider your information newsworthy. Checklist 5.3 suggests which questions you should ask when deciding whether your story is newsworthy. If the answers to these questions are "yes," your story is probably a good example of soft news.

When getting your message to the media, personal contacts are mandatory, as are short, clearly written statements. When writing your press release, be sure to do the following:

- Include precise organizational information: contact person, name of the organization, phone number.
- Suggest a subject line; if well done, such a statement could be part of the headline for a newspaper story.
- Be precise about when the information may be released.

Releases directed toward TV stations may also include film footage, or for radio, segments of interviews. Central, however, is the written statement that summarizes the major point you want to get across.

Checklist 5.3 Questions to Determine Whether Your Story Is Newsworthy

1. Does the story have a local aspect to it, making it interesting to a local audience?
2. Is your story unusual or unique in any way?
3. Is the story timely?
4. Does the story concern people? Create human interest?

Interviews

The pitfalls of interviewing can be avoided by careful preparation and knowledge.

Weekends are noted for national TV interviews. Major political figures often appear on these shows as do, on occasion, people closely related to business or related fields. Your selected spokesperson for these occasions must be briefed and prepared for a multitude of possible questions. Dry-run the interview; take time to rehearse major themes you can bring into the conversation. Rarely, for example, does any political candidate not have a dress rehearsal prior to a major interview. Businesspeople should do no less. Be precise, be accurate, be timely.

Conferences

Press conferences are often the result of a crisis; however, you handle them the same way you handle other forms of communication: with careful preparation.

Press conferences offer good opportunities for you and your company to communicate your message. Unfortunately, most often in business, press conferences are the result of some kind of crisis. Preparation is key to running a good press conference, and you should begin as much in advance as possible. Formats for press conferences are generally (1) a few minutes for an opening statement, (2) distribution of the spokesperson's opening statement, and (3) questions from persons present. You can end your conference yourself by announcing that you will take one more question, or you may have someone else in your organization end it for you. Remember that everything you say during the conference and afterward in chats with reporters is considered "on the record." So be careful.

When you hold a press conference or host any kind of special news event for your company, you are expected to give the news media a package of materials called a *press kit*. What goes into a press kit can vary according to the type of news event; however, certain basic information should always be included in your packet of materials. Checklist 5.4 recommends what should be included.

Op-Ed Pieces

Opinion articles by private organizations can often be found opposite the editorial page in a newspaper.

Some newspapers or TV stations alert company public relations departments in advance that they will be making an editorial statement on a controversial company-related issue. Such a contact often asks for an op-ed statement, that is, a statement contrary (possibly opposite) to the one that will appear on the editorial page or during the editorial portion of a TV newscast. Thus your company can prepare a response—thoughtfully, carefully, truthfully.

Checklist 5.4 Press Kits

1. Main press release
2. Related feature stories, if applicable
3. Photos, films, or videotapes of relevant information
4. List of names, titles, and affiliations of people involved in the event
5. Photos and biographies of main people
6. Fact sheet on your organization
7. Annual report or other information about your organization
8. Name and phone number of a contact person for additional information

If you have no advance notice of an unflattering editorial, you can respond later with an op-ed piece, stating your position and interpretating the events surrounding the controversial issue. Above all: Be truthful, concise, straightforward. It is usual to have such statements read by your legal counsel before releasing them to the media.

Letters to the Editor

Letters to the Editor must always be short, clearly written, and signed.

Pick up the *Wall Street Journal,* the *New York Times,* national magazines, or your local paper. Several columns are devoted to letters submitted by interested readers. Many letters try to clarify an issue, refute a charge, correct a mistake, point out a needed change, offer an opinion, or react to a situation. You, as a business manager or the manager's representative, can use a letter to the editor as an opportunity to comment and even correct a statement made in the publication. Sign the letter. Surely the higher in the organization the signer of the letter, the more seriously the letter will be considered for publication. Use a method similar to the op-ed piece: State the situation, provide a short background, and offer a solution.

Talk Shows

Call-in talk shows, whether on radio or television, can offer your organization a positive channel for communicating your message to the public. Radio and TV producers are always looking for interesting programming, and they are required to provide some public service programs to keep their licenses.

General guidelines for talk shows are similar to those for press conferences. Preparation is the key to a good presentation. Talk shows, however, are less predictable than any other kind of media, and your spokesperson should be someone who is comfortable in dealing with potentially hostile questioners. You should watch or listen to several segments of the talk show in order to know the format and the kind of people who make up its audience.

Managing Information Through Company Spokespersons

A company spokesperson must be knowledgeable, comfortable with oral communication, and well-prepared to discuss all aspects of the issue under consideration.

Companies (and universities for that matter), often select one person to be the main spokesperson. This strategy allows for a consistent answer, a single contact, and a decrease in response variances. Certainly the CEO or president is the obvious choice. However, he or she may not be verbally articulate or comfortable in the rough give and take of the media world. Whoever is chosen to be the contact between the organization and the media should be

- Knowledgeable about the company's overall objectives and strategies
- Well-prepared to speak on the issue under consideration
- Comfortable speaking in public and to groups and fielding questions deftly
- Assured of the full confidence of the company's management

Preparation is the most important factor in being a succesful spokesperson. If you are a company spokesperson, you must know before every interview (1) the date, time, place, and length of the interview; (2) the issue under discussion;

(3) what kinds of questions the reporter may ask; and (4) what message the company wants you to deliver. If possible, it is also helpful to know the background of the reporter doing the interview, the kinds of stories he or she usually writes, and the general slant of the newspaper or radio/TV program where your interview will appear. You should also provide background information materials so that the reporter knows what has already been said on the issue and can expand on it. (See Checklist 5.5.)

Managing Crisis Communication

When emergency situations occur in business, the worst thing you can do is take a closed, "no comment" attitude toward the media. Bad news will not go away, and in fact, the worse it is, the more sensational the coverage in the media. Environmental issues, nuclear energy, falling profits, employee layoffs, and disasters and other catastrophes can cause problems for your company. How your company manages the crisis can have a long-term effect on profits.

Although Johnson and Johnson had no formal crisis contingency plan when the Tylenol incident occurred, the general opinion is that company management did a good job of handling the situation. The strategy of openness to the press helped the company get its message across and portray itself as willing to do what was right regardless of cost. After the immediate shock was over, the *Washington Post* wrote: "Johnson and Johnson has effectively demonstrated how a major business ought to handle a disaster.[10]

As the result of the Tylenol crisis and other disasters that have marked the past 15 to 20 years, many organizations have developed permanent crisis contin-

Checklist 5.5 Guidelines for a Company Spokesperson

1. Know what message your company wants to deliver.
2. Know as much about the issue under discussion as possible.
3. Prepare desirable statements and practice them before the interview.
4. Anticipate questions and prepare answers for them.
5. Tape-record your interview.
6. Realize that your interview will be edited; in some cases, for radio and television, a live interview can be better than one that is taped.
7. Do not worry if you do not know the answer to a question. Simply state that you will get the answer as soon as possible.
8. Do not let a reporter put words in your mouth. Be wary when you hear the words "Aren't you really saying that . . . ?" or "Do you mean that . . . ?" Simply restate the message the way you want it; do not repeat the reporter's words.
9. Avoid jargon.
10. Avoid using negatives.
11. Do not speak "off the record."
12. Know your real audience—not the reporter but rather the people who read the publication or watch the program.

gency plans. These plans vary according to the organization, but each group generally has a permanent, recognized crisis team designated to handle the public and the media in the event of a crisis as well as a set of procedures in place to handle negative news. Part of this strategy may be to cultivate relationships with the media during ordinary periods so that if a crisis occurs, the company has a point of contact. It takes time to position yourself as a credible person in the eyes of the media, but this credibility is necessary when a crisis strikes. As in all other forms of communication, being prepared is the key to success.

SUMMARY

Managing information inside and outside organizations has become one of the major concerns of business. Technological developments are, to a large extent, responsible for the transformation of today's world into a global village with all its accompanying problems. Effective communication has never been more important on a national, organizational, and personal level.

This chapter was an overview of the challenges that businesses face in handling new technologies, in managing their information for greatest productivity inside the organization, and in communicating with the media outside. E-mail will continue to grow in use and in utility as new ways of exchanging information become accessible. The Internet will continue to grow, and although the information superhighway is so far only an idea, it will soon be a reality. Each person who joins a company in the next few years will find himself or herself in a world of groupware communication, teleconferencing, and information gathering and sharing via computer. The person who is comfortable with these new technologies will have an advantage.

Organizations will always have to deal with the public, and when the news is bad, it will always be underlined by the news media. But this channel of information goes both ways: You can deliver your message while responding to public concerns. Careful preparation is imperative when your company is facing a crisis. Choosing your company spokesperson and preparing that person to communicate your message can help your company deal with crises. Your organization may want to implement a crisis contingency plan in order to be prepared should a negative event occur.

All companies must take into consideration the current access of information and realize that nothing will go unnoticed. Because of the growth in information and in the media interest in organizations, companies must be concerned not only with how things are but also how they will appear. Effective communication is your key to dealing with these issues.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***International Communication Styles.*** Working in teams, conduct an in-depth interview of a student or professor in your school who is from another country. Find out what information technology is used and how written and

oral communication styles differ from U.S. business styles. Write an informational memo relating your findings.

2. ***Library Research.*** Do a search of information in your school library on the Internet as it is used in one of the following areas: Southeast Asia, Central Europe, Eastern Europe, South America, Scandinavia. Write a short report on your findings.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Uses for the Internet.*** Write a memo to your instructor arguing for or against your school's hooking up to the Internet. Be sure to take a position either for or against, and provide support for each of your points.

4. ***Discussion/Debate.*** Consider the proposition, or one similar to it, arising out of this statement: "When I write memos or letters, I'm careful to use correct grammar; I edit and proofread carefully as I prepare the final copy. But when I write a message on E-mail, I don't think it's necessary to be so careful." Select persons who agree with this statement and those who disagree. Then have those persons go before the group using this pro and con procedure: pro speakers 2 minutes each; con speakers 2 minutes each; one pro speaker 2-minute final statement; one con speaker 2-minute final statement; questions from the audience to any of the speakers.

5. ***Persuasive Memo.*** You are a copywriter in the public relations department of a large medical supply company. Your company is moving its headquarters from the city, where you live, to the suburbs. You do not want to move, and you do not want the long commute that will be necessary when the company move is completed. Write a memo to your department manager asking to work in your home, linked to the company by way of computer, fax, and modem. Include the advantages to the company of this arrangement, but do not ignore reader concerns. Be explicit about what equipment you will need, and how it will be used.

6. ***Voice Mail Discussion.*** You have just called your bank to speak to your loan officer, and you get the following message: "You have just reached International Bank 2000. Hours are 9:30 A.M. to 3:30 P.M. Monday through Friday; 9:30 A.M. to 1 P.M. Saturday. If you want information, press 1; if you want to speak to the credit department, press 2; if you want to speak to the mortgage department, press 3" and so on for 16 additional numbers. As a customer, how do you like this system? What are its advantages to you? What are its disadvantages?

7. ***Press Release.*** Your company has organized a huge charity event to benefit underprivileged children in the city. Write a press release to the local newspaper, explaining the event and its objectives. Make the information interesting and relevant to the community. How would you change your press release if it were for the local radio or TV station?

8. ***Dealing with a Crisis.*** Your college or university recently has been cited by the Environmental Protection Agency for groundwater pollution, and you are beginning to receive negative press on the issue. In teams, prepare a press kit of information for the local news media. Decide what information you will include, and write up the information. Make up details to make your press kit realistic.

9. ***Crisis Prevention.*** If you were the president of your university, what would you do to prepare for dealing with a crisis? In teams, create a crisis contingency plan, naming people who should be on the crisis team and what roles they should play. What will be your overall approach to the news media in the crisis? Include procedures for dealing with the emergency.

10. ***Response to an Upcoming Disturbing Announcement.*** You are the public relations manager of a medium-sized company that manufactures cleaning fluid used for fabrics in clothing and other materials. Your company moved its primary manufacturing plant to Monterrey, Mexico, 10 years ago to save on labor costs. Up to now, there have never been any problems with either the manufacturing process or the product. However, today you have received a disturbing E-mail message on your computer from the assistant manager of the Monterrey plant. He says that the Mexican government has discovered massive pollution in the groundwater around the plant and is planning to make the discovery public. He wants advice immediately on how to handle the situation. You now must decide what to do. Think about who you should tell this information to and what steps you should take to control the damage. You should draft the following messages:

    a. An E-mail response to the assistant manager's message telling him to wait until he hears from headquarters before talking to the government or the media

    b. A message to the president of your company describing the problem

    When you have drafted those messages, create a plan to deal with the crisis that will control the damage, show goodwill to the area residents, and save your company from a public relations disaster.

11. ***Discussion of Privacy.*** Because the laws concerning electronic information are still developing, there are no clear guidelines for privacy in E-mail messages. Some companies monitor employees' E-mail messages. Discuss the pros and cons of this issue, analyzing what company needs are served by monitoring E-mail and whether monitoring E-mail is an invasion of privacy.

12. ***To Censor or Not to Censor.*** Your school has hooked up to the Internet and is eagerly exploring the many uses found there. One popular innovation has been the setting up of a schoolwide public bulletin board on which anyone in the school can post messages. You have been chosen administrator of this bulletin board. It is your responsibility to review all the messages and alert school administrators of any potential problems. Early this morning when you looked at the new messages, you saw one that was clearly racist in

content and language. As administrator, you have the authority to delete this message, but if you do, will you be breaking a First Amendment right? Or will you be protecting the school from scandal? Should the sender of the message be identified and/or punished in some way? Discuss the issues in this situation and how you would handle the problem.

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Message Design

Chapter 6 The Process of Preparing Effective Business Messages

Chapter 7 The Appearance and Design of Business Messages

Chapter 8 Good-News and Neutral Messages

Chapter 6

The Process of Preparing Effective Business Messages

I. Five Planning Steps
- A. Identify Your Purpose
- B. Analyze Your Audience
- C. Choose Your Ideas
- D. Collect Your Data
- E. Organize Your Message

II. Basic Organizational Plans
- A. Direct (Deductive) Approach
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III. Beginnings and Endings
- A. Opening Paragraphs
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IV. Composing the Message
- A. Drafting Your Message
- B. Revising Your Message
- C. Editing and Proofreading Your Message

V. Summary

VI. Exercises and Problems

Whether you are preparing a written or an oral business message, to be effective you need to plan, organize, draft, revise, edit, and proofread. Essential also is thoughtful adherence to communication principles—the seven C qualities discussed in Chapter 2—and awareness of legal and ethical aspects.

Even with the most advanced office technology, the need for careful preparation of either written or oral messages demands effort. Add to this precept the idea that companies are becoming more global and international, and the argument for thoughtful preparation receives even more emphasis.

This chapter presents planning steps, basic organizational patterns, suggestions for openings and closings, and composing procedures. Letters, domestic and international, are the focus of the discussion and exercises. Later chapters include details about specific kinds of letters and memos and suggestions for preparing proposals and reports.

FIVE PLANNING STEPS

To communicate effectively, consider the following steps before you write your message:

- Identify your purpose.
- Analyze your audience.
- Choose your ideas.
- Collect data to support your ideas.
- Organize your message.

Identify Your Purpose

The objective of your message is almost always twofold: the reason for the message itself and the creation of goodwill.

Your first step when planning your communication is to determine your specific purpose. Is your message mainly informational, such as annnouncing your firm's new location? Is it mainly persuasive, such as asking customers to buy your product? Are you trying to negotiate a contract with a parts supplier in South America? Or must you explain why you are not granting a customer's request for credit?

All messages have an underlying "relational" purpose—to create goodwill. For example, in a credit refusal letter, your purpose is twofold: to refuse the request while encouraging the customer's continued business. Creating goodwill is especially important when communicating with foreign companies, including the governments of those companies. Courtesy and patience in waiting for a response are especially necessary.

Analyze Your Audience

See your message from your receivers' point of view: their needs, interests, attitudes, even their culture.

After reading about the communication process and principles in both national and international contexts in Chapter 3, you realize how important it is to adapt your messages to your receivers' *views, mental filters, needs, and culture.* If you are acquainted with your readers or listeners, you can actually visualize individuals. Much of your writing, however, will be directed to people you have never met. Additionally, when communicating for the first time with a foreign com-

pany or government, you cannot be too cautious. Take care even with the salutation of the letter, paying attention to the proper placement of first and last names and correct titles. Take time to become knowledgeable about the basic communication principles of the country to which you are writing.

If you are sending a message to one person, try to see that person as a member of a group, such as business or professional person or laborer; superior, colleague, or subordinate; woman or man; new or longtime customer; young, middle-aged, or elderly. Consider also the person's educational level, attitudes, and probable values (often culture-specific). Finally, consider your message and decide whether your readers or listeners are informed or uninformed on the subject and whether they will react positively or negatively, with interest or disinterest.

Choose Your Ideas

The ideas you include depend on the type of message you are sending, the situation, and the cultural context.

With your purpose and receiver in mind, the next step is to choose the ideas for your message. If you are answering a letter, underline the main points to discuss and jot your ideas in the margin. If you are writing an unsolicited or a complex message, begin by listing ideas as they come to you—brainstorming—and then choosing the best ideas for your receiver.

The ideas you include depend on the type of message you are sending and the background and location of your receiver (national or international). For example, in a response from a large resort hotel to a person who has asked about rates, you might send a brief list of in- and out-of-season prices. But if you limited your response to this list, you would miss an opportunity to sell the other services you have to offer. In this kind of response, the following ideas should be included:

- Thank the reader for the letter asking about rates.
- Mention the services the hotel provides.

Communication Probe

Analyzing your audience is important for more reasons than simply determining the content and approach of your message. In a study of communication channel choice, Sitkin, Sutcliffe, and Barrio-Choplin found that the recipient of your message should influence even the medium you choose for delivering it. "Effective media choice depends significantly on a variety of factors that influence recipient response, including educational level, physical capabilities, media familiarity and comfort, interaction history with the communicator, and knowledge of the communication context." As an example, this study suggests that sometimes holding a meeting with line employees can be more effective than trying to persuade them to read instruction manuals.

Sitkin, S. B., Sutcliffe, K. M., & Barrio-Choplin, J. R. (1992, June). A dual-capacity model of communication media choice in organizations. *Human Communication Research, 18*(4), 563–598.

- Include information regarding the place where the hotel is located.
- Describe the facilities.
- List the rates.

You might also include a brochure of your hotel along with small brochures of popular sights in your area.

Collect Your Data

Be sure to collect enough data to support your ideas; check names, dates, addresses, and statistics for precision.

After you have decided what ideas to include, you must determine whether you need specific facts, figures, quotations, or other forms of evidence to support your points. Be sure you know your company policies, procedures, and product details if your message requires them. Always check your data on names of individuals, dates, addresses, and statistics. Sometimes, you may need to enclose a brochure, table, picture, or product sample.

Organize Your Message

Organizing your material before writing your first draft can prevent rambling and unclear messages.

Before you write your first draft, outline your message (mentally or on paper). The order in which you present your ideas is as important as the ideas themselves. Disorganized, rambling messages often seem careless, confusing, and unimportant. However, different approaches are necessary for different cultures. While the direct style is often preferred by U.S. businesspeople, the indirect plan is often more effective in South American, middle eastern, and Asian countries. Europeans most often prefer the direct approach. Choose your organizational plan after you have worked through your initial planning steps.

BASIC ORGANIZATIONAL PLANS

Your choice of organizational plan depends on a number of factors: how you expect your reader or listener to react to your message, how much this person knows about the topic or situation, and what his or her cultural conventions are.

For letters and memos, you can choose one of four basic organizational plans: the *direct-request, good-news, bad-news,* or *persuasive-request plan.* The first two plans use the direct approach, which begins with the main idea; the last two plans use the indirect approach, which states the main idea later.

All these plans are flexible guides only, not rigid rules. Your own judgment must help you decide the best organization and content of your message, taking into consideration your audience's views, conventions, knowledge, and culture. Other chapters discuss and illustrate various ways you can use these four basic plans.

Direct (Deductive) Approach

Use the direct approach when the audience is receptive to your message.

When you think your reader or listener will have a favorable or neutral reaction to your message, you can use the direct approach. You *begin with the main idea*

or best news. After the opening, you include all necessary explanatory details in one or several paragraphs and end with an appropriate, friendly closing.

Use the direct-request plan when the main purpose of your message is to make a request that requires less persuasion; use the good-news plan to grant requests, announce favorable or neutral information, and exchange routine information within or between companies. The direct-request and good-news plans have three basic parts. Notice their similarities as you compare the brief outlines side by side in Checklist 6.1.

Indirect (Inductive) Approach

When you expect resistance to your message, choose the indirect approach, such as in a bad-news message or a persuasive request.

If you think your readers or listeners might react negatively to your message, generally you should not present the main idea in the first paragraph. Instead consider beginning with a buffer—a relevant pleasant, neutral, or receiver-benefit statement; then give an explanation *before* you introduce your idea. Chapter 15 calls this pleasant and neutral opening the "Porch," or the initial remarks to an audience.

Checklist 6.1 Direct (Deductive) Organizational Plans

Direct-Request Plan

1. Main idea
   - **a.** Request, main statement, assertion, recommendation, question
   - **b.** Reasons, if desirable
2. Explanation
   - **a.** All necessary and desirable details and data
   - **b.** Numbered questions, if helpful
   - **c.** Easy reading devices
3. Courteous close, with motivation to action
   - **a.** Clear statement of action desired
   - **b.** Easy action, dated when desirable
   - **c.** Appreciation and goodwill

Good-News Plan

1. Best news or main idea
2. Explanation
   - **a.** All necessary and desirable details and data
   - **b.** Resale material*
   - **c.** Educational material
   - **d.** Sales promotion material
3. Positive, friendly close, including, if appropriate:
   - **a.** Appreciation
   - **b.** Clear statement of action
   - **c.** Appreciation and desired, if any
   - **c.** Easy action, dated when desirable
   - **d.** Offer of further help, reader benefits

**Resale material* is usually favorable information about a product or service that the reader (customer) has already bought or is planning to buy. The customer made the selection. *Sales promotion material* usually includes the vendor's suggestions for additional products or services.

Many bad-news and persuasive-request plans use the indirect approach. Notice in Checklist 6.2 that each plan has four instead of three parts. Bad news and persuasion take a little longer to present.

The bad-news message is one of the most difficult to prepare because your reader may react negatively. Likewise, in the persuasive request you may face resistance. Even in good-news and neutral messages, some cultural communication conventions require an indirect approach. Goodwill and reader benefits are essential to these messages.

BEGINNINGS AND ENDINGS

Two of the most important positions in any business message are the opening and closing paragraphs. You have probably heard the old sayings "First impressions are lasting" and "We remember best what we read last." Whenever possi-

Checklist 6.2 Indirect (Inductive) Organizational Plans

Bad-News Plan

1. Buffer (pleasant or neutral statements, reader-oriented)
2. Explanation
   - **a.** Necessary data, tactfully stated
   - **b.** Pertinent favorable, then unfavorable acts
   - **c.** Reader benefit reasons
3. Decision (implied or expressed) along with offer of additional help or suggestions
4. Positive, friendly close
   - **a.** Appreciation
   - **b.** Invitation to future action desired
   - **c.** Easy action, dated when desirable
   - **d.** Willingness to help further
   - **e.** Reader benefit and goodwill

Persuasive Request Plan

1. Attention
   - **a.** Reader benefit
   - **b.** Reader-interest theme
2. Interest
   - **a.** Descriptive details and data
   - **b.** Psychological appeals
   - **c.** Reader benefits
3. Desire
   - **a.** Statement of request
   - **b.** Supporting data to help create reader's desire to grant request
4. Action
   - **a.** Clear statement of action
   - **b.** Easy action, dated when desirable
   - **c.** Special inducement
   - **d.** Reader benefit

Communication Probe

In an article exploring expository writing in Japanese, Korean, Chinese, and Thai, John Hinds describes an alternate organizational pattern that sometimes confuses western readers. This pattern is not deductive nor completely inductive, but rather what Hinds calls "quasi-inductive." It follows a more circular progression of points rather than the linear progression common in western writing. The purpose of this organizational pattern is often to persuade readers to think for themselves, to reflect and come to their own conclusions. Persuasive writing in the West always has the purpose of offering conclusions to readers and persuading them to act. Recognizing these different expectations and purposes can help the western reader to correctly interpret many written messages from other cultures.

Hinds, J. (1990). Inductive, deductive, quasi-inductive: Expository writing in Japanese, Korean, Chinese, and Thai. In U. Connor & A. Johns (eds.), *Coherence in writing: Research and pedagogical perspectives* (pp. 80–100). Alexandria, VA: Teachers of English to Speakers of Other Langauges, Inc.

ble, place the main favorable ideas at the beginning and ending of a message. This advice also applies to paragraphs.

Opening Paragraphs

The opening of a message determines whether the reader continues reading, puts the message aside, or discards it.

Often the opening of a written message determines whether the reader continues reading, puts the message aside for later, or discards it. Checklist 6.3 and the following examples offer suggestions for good openings that help make favorable impressions:

1. Choose Openings Appropriate for Message Purpose and Reader

Main Idea or Good-News Subject First. Begin with the main idea or good-news subject when you are sure the reader will consider the information favorable or neutral. It is also easier for the reader to understand the main idea if it is in the first paragraph. These openings are desirable in direct-request, neutral, and good-news messages.

Request: So that your CD funds, which have matured, can be transferred to your IRA account as you have requested, please return to us the following:

Good news: Enclosed is a cash refund for the defective wristwatch that you sent to us recently.

Checklist 6.3 Opening Paragraphs

1. Choose an opening appropriate for the message purpose and for the reader.
   a. Main idea or good-news first for direct-request, neutral, and good-news messages.
   b. Buffer first for bad-news messages.
   c. Attention-getting statements first for persuasive requests.

2. Make the opening considerate, courteous, concise, clear.
   a. Get reader into opening.
   b. Keep first paragraph relatively short.
   c. Focus on the positive.
   d. Use courteous, conversational language.
   e. Avoid unnecessary repetition.

3. Check for completeness regarding:
   a. Sentence structure.
   b. Date of letter you are answering.

Announcement: (who, what, when, where, why)

As a representative of [*company name*], you are invited to attend a free seminar on Negotiating Environmental Issues in the International Marketplace to be held in the Richelieu ballroom, Opera Hotel, 8 rue de Sèvres, Paris, on May 1. The purpose of this seminar is to explain the new national environmental laws affecting international business.

Advertising writing seeks to get reader attention immediately; such writing often breaks the rules of proper grammar.

Buffer First. When you have bad news for the reader, begin with a buffer—a statement that you can agree on which sets a neutral tone. (Chapter 9 discusses buffers in greater detail.)

Poor:

Your application to the [*name*] Executive Skills Program has been rejected due to the following reasons:

Good:

Because of the large number of applications we received for our [*name*] Executive Skills Program, we have had to turn away many persons. We obviously underestimated the interest in our current subject. A new program is already being planned, and we will send you information as soon as it's available.

Attention-Getting Statements First. When you write a persuasive request (sales letter), begin with relevant statements that will induce the recipient to read further, as in this opening:

> Did you know that up to half of all lower back pain is caused by sleeping on a too-soft mattress? In addition, back pain due to other causes can be made worse by sleeping on a poor mattress. We remedy that. Our company has developed a new mattress and foundation that provides the kind of support your back needs!
>
> So we blew it! That happens. But our wish is to meet your concerns immediately. Like within the next two weeks. Please read the enclosed flyer; we hope it responds to all your questions.

In both examples above, the sentences are varied. Some are even incomplete. Attention-getting marketing statements seek first to get attention of the reader and then worry about the precision of the language.

2. Make the Opening Considerate, Courteous, Concise, Clear

Immediately get your reader into the opening thought whether your message is good or bad news, a direct or a persuasive request. Emphasize the reader, and focus on the positive aspects of your message. Use courteous language, and avoid anything that might anger the reader.

Keep the first paragraph relatively short—five typewritten lines or less. As in all the paragraphs, use conversational language in clear and concise sentences. Avoid unnecessary repetition of what the reader has told you.

3. Check for Completeness

Avoid opening with an incomplete sentence like:

> Reference your letter [*or* per your letter] of May 9, concerning Helen Smith's request for a transfer of funds.

Usually you should subordinate the date of the letter you are answering unless including it is beneficial to the reader or to you or unless you need it for record keeping.

Poor: As per your recent letter, we have shipped your order today by Federal Express.

Good: Three bolts of Thai silk, which you ordered on July 6, were shipped to you today by DHL.

Closing Paragraphs

Your closing is more likely to motivate the reader to act as requested if it is appropriately strong, clear, and polite. Here you have the opportunity to bring final

Closings should be strong, clear, and polite; they should leave a sense of closure and goodwill with the receiver.

focus on the desired action and leave a sense of goodwill with the reader. What you say in the closing should reinforce the central purpose of your message.

Checklist 6.4 and the following examples focus on ways to apply the seven C qualities in closings for various letter and memo situations.

1. Make Action Request Clear and Complete with the Five W's and the H

Whenever you are requesting action by your reader or by someone else, your closing paragraph will usually be more effective if you make clear *what, who, how, where, when,* and if appropriate, *why.*

What and Who? *Clear statement of the action you desire your reader (or someone else) to take.* Should the reader phone your office for an appointment? Sign a card or a document? Return it? If so, to whom? Come to your office in person? Send you certain information or payment?

How and Where? *Easy action.*

- Include your phone number and extension if you want the reader to phone you.
- Enclose a form (card, order, blank, or questionnaire) and an addressed reply envelope (perhaps with postage paid) if you want the reader to furnish something.
- Give complete instructions regarding *how* and *where* if you do not include a form and envelope.
- State your office hours and location if you want the reader to come to you in person. Do you have a free parking lot? Where?

Be careful when setting precise deadlines with foreign companies; some will consider a deadline only after extensive discussion.

When and Why? *Dated action; special inducement to act by a specified time.* Name the date (and the exact hour, if pertinent) whenever you need the reply by

Communication Probe

"Practice precedes theory" is a supportable axiom; it means that businesses often accept a communication procedure far in advance of its appearance in textbooks or articles. For example, for years Great Britain, with its extensive empire, influenced business communication throughout the world. The memorandum, in various formats on all continents, was accepted and used. Today E-mail is used as part of the technological revolution; this media channel preceded theories about it, theories that are only now developing. Textbooks and scholars seek to keep up with the accelerated changes occurring in the business world as firms grow and become more global.

Yates, J. (1989, May). The emergence of the memo as a managerial genre. *Management Communication Quarterly, 2*(4), 485–510.

Checklist 6.4 Closing Paragraphs

1. Make your action request clear and complete with the five W's and the H (how) if you want your reader to do something.
   a. *What and who:* Clearly state what action you desire and who should do it.
   b. *How and where:* Make action easy.
   c. *When:* Date the action, if desirable.
   d. *Why:* Show reader benefit, if possible.

2. End on a positive, courteous thought.
   a. Include any apologies and negatives before the last paragraph.
   b. Be friendly.
   c. Show appreciation.
   d. Occasionally add a personal note.

3. Keep the last paragraph concise and correct.
   a. Avoid trite expressions.
   b. Omit discussion of trivial details.
   c. Use relatively short and complete sentences.

a certain time. Tactfully state the reason you need it then—perhaps to meet a report or printer's deadline or to use in a speech you are giving at a certain meeting.

When appropriate, mention some benefits the reader will gain by prompt action. In the following example, notice how the vague action request is improved by inserting some or all of the W's and the H:

Vague: I look forward to hearing from you regarding this matter.

Better: So that we can make appropriate arrangements for your visit, please call me at 555-4567, ext. 11, before Friday, November 16, anytime between 9 A.M. and 5 P.M.

2. End on a Positive, Courteous Thought

Include Any Apologies and Negatives Before Last Paragraph. Study these examples:

Negative: I'm sorry we can't be more encouraging at this time.

Positive: We wish you success in your search for a position.

Be Friendly. Offer to help the reader further, if that is appropriate. Words like *please* or *will you* help soften commands.

Good: If there is any further way we can assist you, please call (222) 555-4567 Monday through Friday between 9 A.M. and 5 P.M.

Poor: Send us your check today.

Good: To keep your credit in good standing, please send us your check for $595.95 today.

Show Appreciation. Everyone likes sincere praise when earned. But do not thank people for doing something before they have agreed to do it.

Avoid: Thank you in advance for distributing these questionnaires to your employees.

Say: I will appreciate your distributing these questionnaires to your employees.

Occasionally Add a Personal Note. When unrelated to the subject discussed in the message, a personal note is appropriate, sometimes added as a last paragraph, often handwritten.

Give my regards to your lovely family. I enjoyed meeting them during the October conference.

3. Keep Last Paragraph Concise and Correct

Trim your last paragraph to five or fewer lines of complete sentences. Avoid trite expressions and unnecessary repetition.

Poor: Again, we thank you for your inquiry. Enclosed you will find a self-addressed, stamped envelope. Hoping to hear from you soon about your preference, I remain . . .

Better: Please fill out this form and return it in the enclosed envelope by [*date*]. Then you can soon begin to enjoy the comfort at . . .

COMPOSING THE MESSAGE

Drafting Your Message

Your first draft is often the most difficult to write. The important thing is to get the most important information in your message on paper early.

When you have completed the five planning steps and considered your openings and closings, you are ready for your first draft.

No two people prepare their first drafts the same way. Some people write first drafts in a linear style, following their mental or written outline and moving from one point to the next. Others use a more circular style, putting their ideas down with a less fixed progression of points, data, and organization. Regardless of your style, the important thing is to get on paper (or cassette recorder or word processor) the information you want included in your message. The next step is to polish the document. Some of the world's best writers believe their strength lies in revising and editing, the next two steps in writing.

Revising Your Message

Revision means adding necessary and deleting unnecessary information, making sure your points are adequately supported, checking your organizational approach, and reviewing your language in terms of the seven C's.

After you finish the first draft of a message, you must evaluate its content, organization, and style. The following are suggestions for revising:

- Does your message accomplish its purpose?
- Have you chosen the most effective organizational plan?
- Are your points supported by adequate material?
- Is your language complete, concise, considerate, concrete, clear, courteous, and correct?
- Have you used variety in sentence structure?

If you included unnecessary material, delete it. If you need additional information, get it. Change, move, add, and delete as much information as you need to create an effective message. The best writers confirm again and again that revision is the key to good writing. Tolstoy revised *War and Peace* 5 times; James Thurber rewrote his stories as many as 15 times; Franklin D. Roosevelt's speeches often went to 18 drafts; James Mitchener feels that his strength is in rewriting.

Editing and Proofreading Your Message

Editing and proofreading are important to ensure that your document has no mistakes in grammar, spelling, punctuation, or word choice.

Editing your message involves checking all paragraphs for good topic sentences, examining sentences for sound structure, and watching language for correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation. When you have edited your message and found it to be effective, you are ready for final proofreading. Sometimes you will proofread your document several times to be sure that you have not missed any errors. Even minor mistakes, such as typographical errors, can reduce the effectiveness of your message and undermine your credibility.

Persons writing in a second language will find it helpful to read their written material aloud.

Those writing in a second language can take one more step in proofreading material. Read your written material aloud. Most people who speak a second language are more competent in oral communication in their second language than in written, which is why an American writing in German will more easily sense through *Sprachgefühl* (feel of the language) which of the 12 German

Communication Probe

Drafting and revising is important in business writing not only to produce the best, most effective product but also to increase a writer's understanding of issues. Many researchers suggest that writing is itself a tool for learning, that the process of putting thoughts on paper or on a word processor helps develop a writer's understanding of complex issues, which can then be incorporated into subsequent drafts. Some writers say "I don't know what I think about the topic until I've written it down." Writing can be a legitimate method of discovery.

Schwom, B. L., & Hirsch, P. L. (1994, June). Managing the drafting process: Creating a new model for the workplace. *The Bulletin for the Association for Business Communication*, 1–10. Gere, A. R. (1988). *Writing and learning*. New York: Macmillan.

prepositions is most correct if he or she reads the document aloud, and a native Spaniard who writes in English can better sense which tense, which article, and which preposition is best when reading aloud. In fact, pronouncing written material out loud is a good idea for everyone.

SUMMARY

Five planning steps are basic to effective writing: (1) identify your purpose, (2) analyze your audience, (3) choose your ideas, (4) collect your data, and (5) organize your message. Although this chapter discusses these steps in sequence, several steps may occur simultaneously.

Western countries prefer the direct (deductive) approach; they like to state the main idea, the main purpose early. It is the preferred organizational approach in business. Yet, be conscious of your message receiver and know whether he or she will be receptive to your message.

Other countries, such as those in South America, Asia, or the Middle East, prefer the indirect (inductive) approach, in which more prefatory material is provided before arriving at the conclusion, recommendation, or action step.

Certainly opening paragraphs and closing paragraphs are singularly important. Opening statements attempt to gain reader attention; ending statements provide easy action or precise steps to take.

Revising and editing are central to good writing. Here you verify the existence of the seven C's; here you read for sentence structure, language clarity, and correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation. Second language writers should read their material aloud, because a person's oral language recognition is often better than written language recognition.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Evaluations of Openings.*** Following are the first sentences of three messages to a Japanese business executive. What are their differences, and which would be effective or ineffective. Why?

   a. Per our conversation on March 4, we would like to negotiate a contract with you to distribute your products in the Chicago area.

   b. Would you like to sell your products in a totally new market?

   c. We respect our relationship with you.

2. ***Request for Support.*** Discuss the features of the following letter from a Japanese MBA student to his company, which is paying for his graduate program.

Dear Sir and Madam:

I am delighted to hear that you are continuing to prosper.

By the way, I have been chosen to study for an M.B.A. degree at [*university name*] in the United States.

The care and help that you provided me while I was working in the Osaka branch of the Mitsui Trust and Banking Company has been appreciated.

During my stay abroad, I will do my very best and study hard. I ask for your continued support in the future.

Sincerely,

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Evaluations of Closings.*** Rewrite the following closings to show a more reader-oriented approach and a friendlier tone.

   a. I wish to thank you very much for opening an account with our store. We will do our best to serve you well, and we hope that you will use your account as soon as possible.

   b. Fill out the enclosed questionnaire and mail it to us right away so that we can send your prize.

   c. You must send your payment by October 15 or risk your account being turned over to a credit agency.

   d. Payment is due on delivery.

4. ***Revision of a Wordy and Inappropriate Memo.*** Revise the following memo from the manager of a small office to salaried employees regarding donations for holiday gifts for the office secretaries.

Once again, the time of year has rolled around that we have to think about giving something to the gals that slave for us. Trying to think of things to give that really show our appreciation (and don't break the bank!) gets harder and harder each year. You all know how difficult this is because we go through it every year, and every year we have the same problem, which is trying to please 7 women. And you all know how impossible that is! If any of you have some good ideas-or even bad ideas, come to think of it-I'm all ears. I'd like for us all to go in together and get something they can all use, although I haven't been able to come up with anything yet. We could get a big tin of popcorn

for the office or maybe a plant. I'm not sure how much money we should each give-maybe a buck apiece would cover it. At any rate, let me know any ideas you come up with, and give me the buck as soon as you can.

5. ***Evaluation of Three Replies.*** The sales manager of Right Fit Hanger, Inc., recently wrote to three television stations asking if they would handle her product on a commission basis. She had heard that some stations occasionally used their open time in this manner. Which of the three replies below do you think best adheres to business communication principles? Why?

REPLY A

I don't know where you got your information as stated in the opening sentence of your letter: "I have been informed that your station occasionally promotes items on a commission basis." We don't appreciate your assumption. If you want to do business with us, buy; if you don't, don't write us.

REPLY B

This will acknowledge your recent letter offering your all-plastic clothes hanger on a commission basis.

I am quite sure that you did not run your advertisement in the Sunday newspaper supplement on a commission basis. By the same token, we will not accept business on a percentage or per inquiry basis.

For your information, I am attaching our rate card.

REPLY C

Your information must have been somewhat misleading inasmuch as NUTZ has never promoted items on a commission basis.

We would be delighted to handle the Right Fit hanger, and I personally think it is an item in great demand.

Enclosed is our rate card so that you can choose the time, frequency, and length of message that will promote your product as you wish it. As soon as your reply to these points reaches us, we will be glad to put all our resources at your disposal.

6. ***Revision of a Memo.*** Revise the following memo announcement so that it has a better you-attitude and more active than passive verbs. Correct any other errors and problems.

```
TO:       Customer Service Personnel
FROM:     Tom S. Powers
SUBJECT:  Deposit and Cash Receipt Books
DATE:     March 1, 199-

Effective March 1, 199-, the following changes will
be made in the use and care of deposit and cash re-
ceipt books by our salesmen:

1. The deposit and/or cash receipt book(s) issued
   to a salesman will be used only by the client to
   whom the book is issued.

2. Whenever a deposit or other monies are col-
   lected, the salesman will remove from the re-
   ceipt book(s) the customer's copy(s) and give
   this to the customer as is now done.  In addi-
   tion, at the end of his shift, each salesman
   will no longer turn in the receipt book(s) with
   the money and tickets for those transactions.

3. Deposit and receipt books are not to be left
   laying around in a vehicle or other places.
   They are to be under the strict control of the
   individual the book(s) is issued to.

Normally a salesman will have one deposit book and
one cash receipt book.  Additional books may be is-
sued by a service supervisor.  All used up books
are to be returned to the supervisor for forwarding
to the accounting department.
```

7. ***Searching for Overall Organizational Pattern.*** This exercise requires you to determine whether a piece of writing is inductive (indirect) or deductive (direct). Remember the admonition of this chapter: When the purpose or aim is up-front or immediate, the structure is deductive; when the purpose, aim, or main conclusion comes later or last, the movement is inductive. Certainly, some forms of communication will be unclear as to purpose or aim. Apply those principles to the following kinds of communication:

   - An article in the *Wall Street Journal* or other national newspaper
   - An abstract of a business article or a lengthy report
   - A research article in a business communication journal
   - A television commercial
   - A poem
   - A song
   - An advertisement sent through the mail

Chapter 7

The Appearance and Design of Business Messages

I. Business Letters
- A. Stationery and Envelopes
- B. Standard Parts of the Letter
- C. Optional Parts of the Letter
- D. Letter Layout

II. Memorandums
- A. Stationery
- B. Parts of the Memorandum
- C. Layout of the Memorandum Body
- D. Envelopes and Electronic Mail

III. Special Timesaving Message Media
- A. Electronic Mail
- B. Facsimiles (Faxes)
- C. Telegrams, Mailgrams, Telexes
- D. Teleconferencing

IV. Summary

V. Exercises and Problems

In the workplace of the future, you may send and receive dozens of messages, interview a candidate for a position in your company through a videoconference, write a report to your manager regarding a new initiative, and download several company files for analysis—all from a PC in your home office or from your laptop if you are not at home. The electronic revolution is changing the way we communicate, and these changes include formats and conventions of written communication.

In the more traditional forms of written communication, your receiver will form an impression of you based on the overall appearance and format of the message. Your cover letter enclosed with your resume when you apply for a job will communicate something about you even before your receiver reads a word of it. This chapter is a brief overview of both the traditional formats of written communication, such as letters and memos, and the newer communication styles developing as a result of the exploding technology.

BUSINESS LETTERS

The medium used most often for written messages to persons outside your organization is the business letter. Your letter's appearance conveys nonverbal impressions that affect a reader's attitude even before that person reads the letter. The many type styles and formats of modern word processing systems and printers can enhance the appearance of your message and create a positive impression.

Elements of appearance that help produce favorable reactions are appropriate stationery and correct letter parts and layouts.

Stationery and Envelopes

Keep the following guidelines in mind if you have an opportunity to suggest or change your organization's stationery.

Quality, Size, Color

Good company stationery is most often at least 25 percent cotton content, 20-pound weight, and white, cream, or light gray in color.

To help build an image of quality, the paper for general business correspondence should have at least 25 percent cotton content; cotton does not turn yellow in time as does wood pulp. Paper quality is usually 20-pound weight, based on the actual weight of 4 reams (2,000 sheets) of standard-sized paper. Other types of paper used are 16- and 24-pound weight. Most letters are the standard size 8½ by 11 inches, with some legal firms using 8½ by 14 inches. White is the most common color, although cream and light gray are also popular. With the new possibilities generated by computer graphics, some messages are written on dark or bright-colored paper. These colors should be used only in special circumstances, however, as when the design of the message is as important as the substance.

Letterhead

Modern letterheads (see Figure 7.1) usually occupy no more than 2 inches at the top of the page. The firm's name, address, ZIP code, and sometimes telephone number, cable address, fax number, Internet address, nature of business, and

Letterhead information should include the name, address, ZIP, and telephone number. Sometimes fax numbers, nature of business, and name of department are also included.

name of the department or branch office sending the correspondence are printed, embossed, or engraved.

Optional details are names of officers and directors, trademark, slogan, and the firm's starting date. Many firms include the extended ZIP code—four figures beyond the ZIP. Benefits of including the extended ZIP are high-speed sorting of your outgoing mail and improved delivery services.

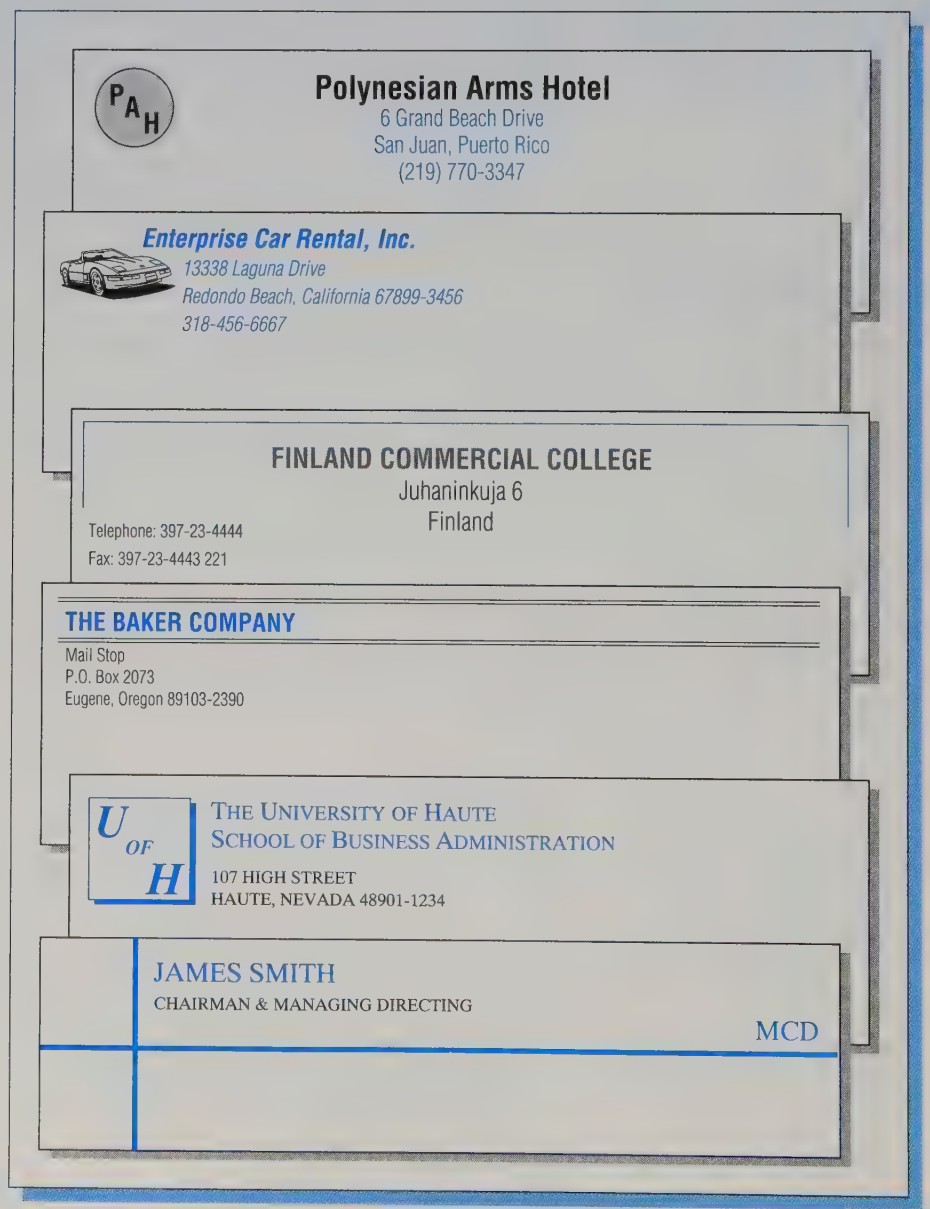


Figure 7.1 Illustration of letterheads. (MCD's address, fax, and telephone numbers are printed on two lines at the bottom of the page.)

Envelopes

Return addresses of the senders, often printed like the letterhead or, if necessary, typewritten, should be in the upper left corner of the envelope. The addressee's address, which is the inside address of the letter, should be placed on the envelope according to U.S. Postal Service published guidelines for location, legibility, abbreviations, and format. Addresses should always be typed in block form, with all lines aligned on the left (see Figure 7.2). Information in the address should be listed in the following order:

1. Name and title of receiver
2. Name of department
3. Name of organization
4. Name of building (if relevant)
5. Street address and suite number or post office box number
6. City, state, and ZIP code (U.S.) or city, province, and postal code (Canada)
7. Country (if letter is being sent out of the country)

Mail notations such as REGISTERED or SPECIAL DELIVERY should be typed in all capitals below the postal area. Any on-arrival instructions, such as CONFIDENTAL, PLEASE FORWARD, or ACCOUNT NUMBER, should be

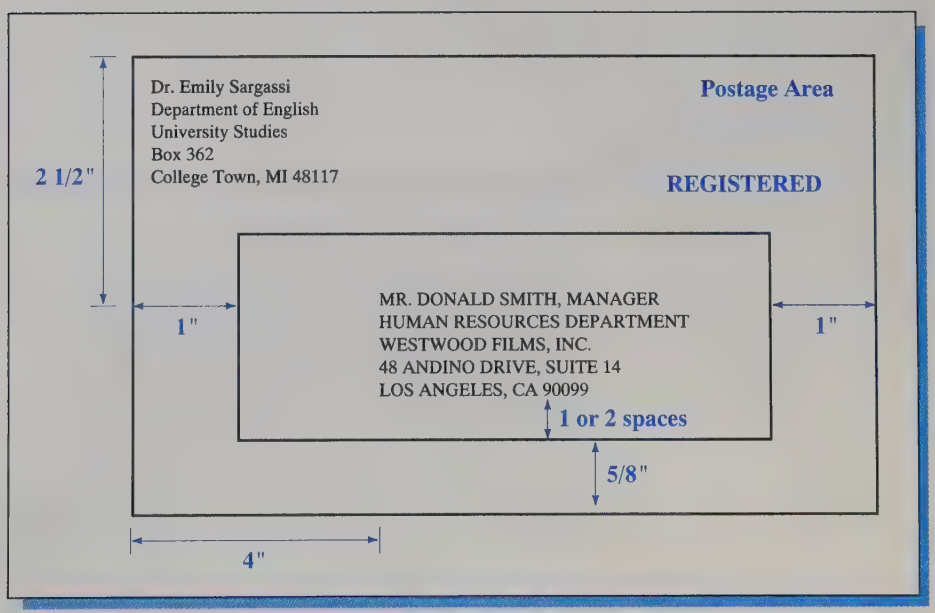


Figure 7.2 Large business envelope (no. 10 size—$9\frac{1}{2}$ by $4\frac{1}{8}$ inches) properly addressed for optical character recognition.

typed in all capitals below the return address near the left upper edge of the envelope, as shown in Figure 7.2. Business correspondence should follow the prescribed guidelines because the Postal Service uses scanners to speed operations. The U.S. Postal Service extended ZIP codes can identify a floor in a large building or even a department in an organization.

To speed machine sorting and processing while holding down postal operating costs and postage fees, the Postal Service continues to make minor changes in published preferences wherever possible and desirable. They also have, in every large city, a joint Mailer/Postal Service organization that deals with mailer problems and suggestions. A free monthly pamphlet and various guidelines for successful envelope addressing are available from your local post office.

Standard Parts of the Letter

Most business letters have the following parts: (1) heading: letterhead and date, (2) inside address, (3) salutation, (4) body, (5) complimentary close, (6) signature area, and (7) reference section, as shown in Figure 7.3.

1. Heading—Letterhead and Date

A heading shows where the letter comes from, and if it is letterhead stationery, it is usually at the top center of the letter. If you are not using letterhead stationery, your return address, but not your name, is typed directly above the date about 2 inches from the top, as in Figure 7.4, p. 165.

Headings—either letterhead or your own address—should be at the top of the letter before the date and before the name and address of the receiver of your message.

Usually the date is typewritten two to six lines below the last line of the letterhead—at the left margin, centered, begun at the center, or placed so it ends with the right margin. Date sequence preferred in American business is month, day, year—March 5, 1997—with the month spelled out. If you use the figures 3/5/97, the meaning in Europe, Latin America, and Asia would be day, month,

Communication Probe

The kind of stationery a company chooses, its quality, and any graphic designs or letterhead formats it chooses can communicate a strong message to clients and consumers. If a company has no consistent graphics, letterheads, or quality of stationery, the message can be one of visual chaos, suggesting an absence of attention, organization, and effective management. A lack of quality and consistency can also be costly, with each division and department designing and funding its own stationery, letterheads, and images. Although a reader usually does not study the kind of stationery used by a company or the effectiveness of its graphics, the physical characteristics nevertheless do communicate a strong impression that can help or hinder the substance of the message.

Spaeth, T. (1991, Winter). Diagnosing corporate identities. *Design Management Journal*, 47–51.

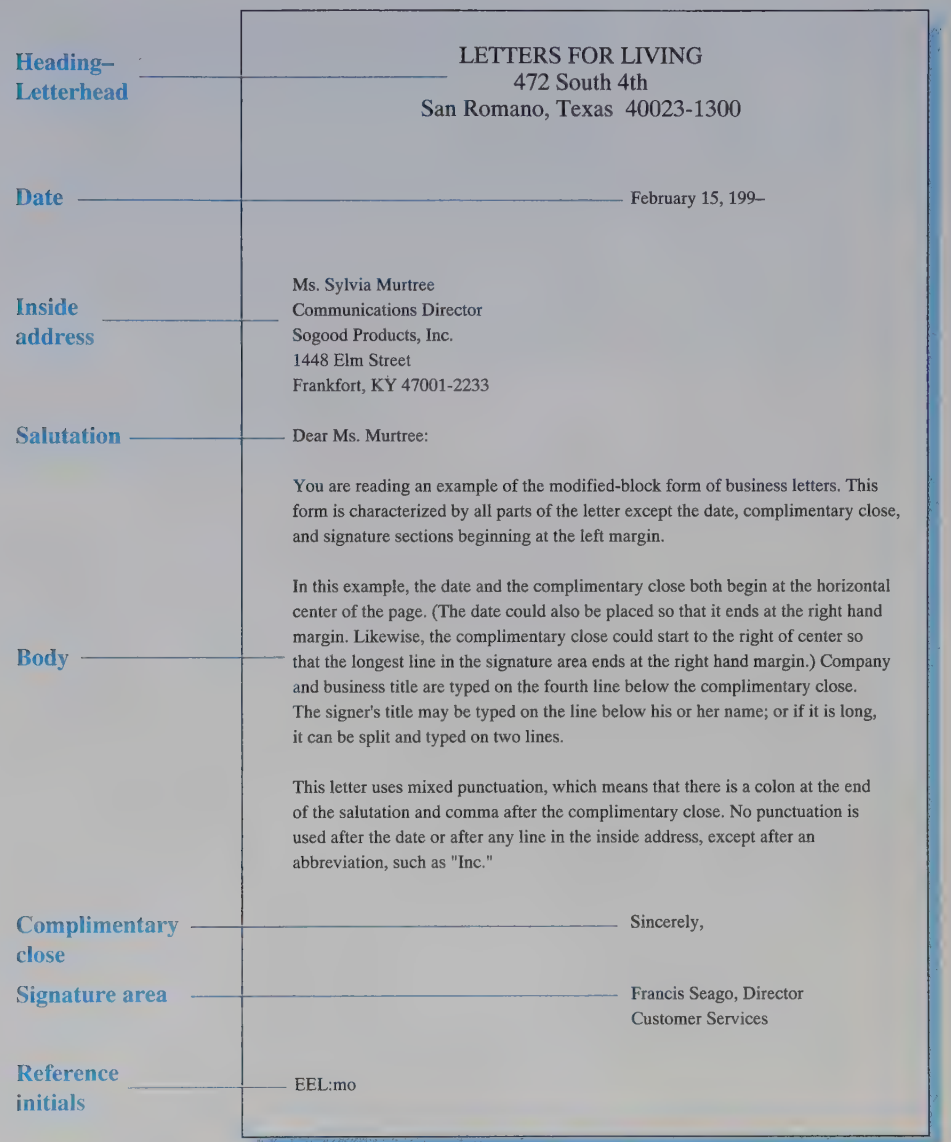


Figure 7.3 Modified-block letter style with mixed punctuation. Length: medium; total blank line spaces below the last line of a letterhead to the date and to the inside address vary, depending on the length of the letter.

year—3 May, 1997. As companies globalize, more people write out the month to avoid confusion.

The inside address should begin with the addressee's name preceded by a courtesy and/or professional title.

2. Inside Address

Always blocked at the left-hand margin, the inside address includes the name and address of the individual, group, or organization to whom you are writing.

Order of items is (1) courtesy title, (2) name, and (3) executive or professional title, if any. All parts are typed single-spaced.

Courtesy Title and Name. If the addressee has no professional title, such as Doctor, Reverend, or Professor, the traditional courtesy titles are Mr., Mrs., Miss, or Ms. When in doubt about a woman's preference, use Ms. plus her own first name and surname. Current trends suggest Ms. as the courtesy title for all business and professional women regardless of their marital status unless they have a professional title that takes precedence. For guidelines on abbreviations of titles and other items, such as names of streets and states, see "Abbreviations" in Appendix B.

After the courtesy title, include your addressee's full first names or two initials and surname. When you do not know whether the initials are for a man or a woman, you can use Mr. or Ms. for the courtesy title or omit the courtesy title altogether.

Executive or Professional Title. Depending on the length of lines, the executive or professional title may be typed on (a) the same line as the addressee's name, (b) the second line preceding the company's name, or (c) a line or two by itself, as in the following examples:

a.
```
Mr. John Trimmer, President
General Construction Company
Larson Building
1380 Adams Street NW
Chicago IL 60623-1122
```

b.
```
Ms. Marietta K. Worthington
Treasurer, XYZ Corporation
P.O. Box 91467
Augusta GA 30915-1234
```

c.
```
Dr. Marlotte Lim, Sr.
Human Resources Officer
Esso Singapore Private Limited
1 Raffles Place
Singapore 0104
```

3. Salutation

Salutations are typed on the second line below the inside address and two lines above the body of the letter.

The salutation is typed on the second line below the inside address, two lines above the body, and even with the left margin. Both traditional and comparatively recent salutations are included in the following list, all of which much be appropriate for the first line of the inside address.

a. Dear Mr. [or Ms., Mrs., Miss] Doe—When the first line of an inside address is the name of an individual.

b. Dear John [or Mary or nickname]—When you'd address the individual this way in person and when it is appropriate for you to do so in your letter.

c. Dear Koo Hong Chuan,—Most often used in Asia; family name first, then given name, then comma.

d. Dear Manager [or Executive, Human Resources Director, Admissions Director, or an appropriate variation]—When the first line is a position within an organization and you have no name.

e. Dear Ladies and Gentlemen [or Members of . . . , Committee Members, Professional Women, XYZ Fraternity, Admissions Office]—When you are addressing a company, a group, or a department and you don't know a specific person to contact.

f. Dear Customer [or Homeowner, Executive, Student, Occupant, Member of . . .]—For messages that omit the inside address such as sales letters or announcements.

4. Body

Most letters are typed single-spaced, with two spaces between paragraphs, before and after the salutation, and before the complimentary close.

Generally, the body of all letters should be typed single-spaced, with double spacing between paragraphs, before and after the salutation, and before the complimentary close. Figure 7.3 indicates where all blank line spaces are in that letter. A short letter could be double-spaced with additional blank line spaces before and after the date and within the signature area.

When the body of a letter is two or more pages, each page beyond the first is headed by the addressee's name, page number, and date. This information is typed at the top of the sheet with the same margins as the first page.

5. Complimentary Close

The most popular complimentary closes in American letters are the following (notice that only the first word is capitalized).

```
Sincerely, [most popular]
Sincerely yours, Yours sincerely
Very truly yours, Yours very truly
Cordially,
```

When the letter is informal, additional complimentary closes are often used, such as Warm regards, Best regards, and Best wishes. Do not be surprised to see letters from the U.K. or Asia closing with Faithfully yours, or Faithfully; tradition influences their use of that closing.

6. Signature Area

You can include in the signature area several identifications: name of your company, your signature, your typewritten name, and your business title. If printed on the letterhead, your company name need not be typed after the complimentary close. However, if you wish to include it, type it in capital letters a double space under the complimentary close, as in the Westwood company example below.

Your signature is pen-written above your typed name, which appears three to five lines below the company name (if included) and the complimentary close. The typed business title usually follows the typed name.

```
Very truly yours,          Sincerely,                 Cordially,

                           WESTWOOD FILMS, INC.

Jennifer Wenthe            Stuart Stanton             Steven

Jennifer Wenthe            Stuart Stanton             Steven Grant
Marketing Manager          Human Resources            President
                           Director
```

Usually the signature is the same as the typed name. An exception occurs when you use your reader's first name for the salutation, in which case you will usually sign only your first name above your typed name, as Steven Grant did in the example above.

7. Reference Section

The reference section may include information about the message composer, the typist, and sometimes word processing data.

Your initials as the composer of the message along with those of your typist usually appear at the left margin on the same line with the last line of the signature area (your name or title) or one or two lines below that, as in Figures 7.3 and 7.5. Common forms are

```
MLO/mb        MLO/MB        MLO:mb        MLO:MB
```

Use of word processing systems adds another dimension. Disk information is often included as in the following:

```
HWH<3>:jr      [HWH is composer; disk 3; jr is typist]
jcCJNT V1<6>   [jc is composer; title on disk; disk 6]
```

If someone other than the signer of the letter composes the letter, practice varies regarding reference initials. Many firms show on the file copy the initials of the signer, writer, and typist (KLM:JC:tr). The original to the addressee may omit all or only the writer's initials to avoid showing that the signer did not compose the letter. At present, there is no universally recommended way to include references.

Optional Parts of the Letter

When appropriate, any of these optional parts can be included: (1) attention line, (2) subject line, (3) enclosure(s), (4) copy notation, (5) file or account number and mailing notation, and (6) postscript.

An attention line is useful when you want your message to go to a certain department or when someone other than the addressee will take care of your message.

1. Attention Line

When you want to direct a letter to a particular person or title or department in an organization, you can use an attention line. It is useful in the following contexts:

- When the writer does not know an individual's name but wants the message to go to a particular title (sales or adjustment manager) or department (personnel)
- When the writer knows only the person's surname and therefore does not want to use that name in the salutation
- When the writer expects that the addressee travels often and wants the letter to be attended to promptly by whoever takes care of the addressee's business

Placement of the attention line is usually between the inside address and salutation, with a blank line before and after it. It may be flush with the left margin, indented with the paragraphs, or centered. See Figure 7.5. for an example of flush with the left margin.

2. Subject Line

Considered part of the body of the letter, the subject line helps tell your reader at a glance what your letter is about. It also helps in filing. The subject line may include or omit the word *subject*. It is usually placed on the second line below the salutation and centered (Figure 7.4), or it may be placed flush with left margin (Figure 7.7). The typing may be capitals and lowercase and underlined (Figure 7.4) or all capitals (Figure 7.7).

3. Enclosure Notation

An enclosure or attachment notation is included to remind your reader to check for additional pages of information.

To remind whoever prepares your envelope for mailing that something is to be enclosed, the enclosure notation is usually typed a single or double space under

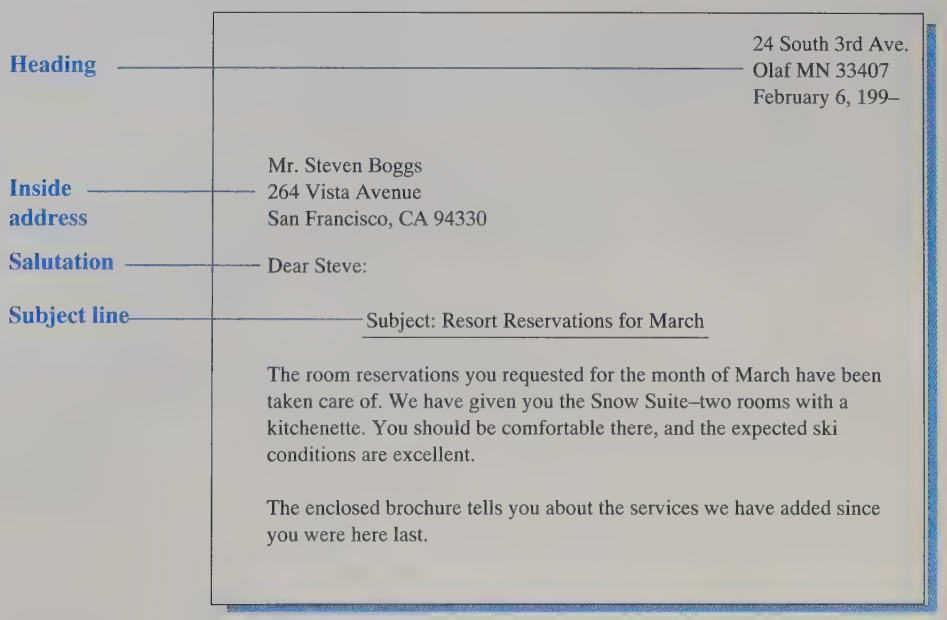


Figure 7.4 Illustration of heading with typed return address on plain stationery; also, inside address, nickname in salutation, and centered subject line.

DIGIGRAPHICS, INC.
222 49th St.
City, NY 10012-0000

May 2, 199–

REGISTERED MAIL

Mr. Kevin George, Consultant
Office Supply Corp.
111 Computer Notices Building
460 River Street
Chicago, IL 60045-6677

Dear Mr. George:

DIGIGRAPHICS, Inc. can supply you with forms for all kinds of business letters. This full-block letter is typed single-spaced with a blank line between paragraphs. Every line begins at the left margin. "REGISTERED MAIL" is a double space from the date.

Many firms prefer this format because of its simplicity and ease in setting up on computers or word processors. The writer's company name may be typed under the complimentary close, as here, or omitted.

Other accepted forms of reference initials could be used with this letter style. Also, the "REGISTERED MAIL" notation could be typed at the bottom, a double space after the reference initials. The postscript, handwritten or typewritten, would then be placed a double space under "REGISTERED MAIL."

Sincerely yours,

DIGIGRAPHICS, INC.

Andrea Forman, Manager
Customer Service Department

MB/mo

Figure 7.5 Full-block letter style, with mixed punctuation. Length: short.

the reference initials. This notation also alerts the addressee to check for enclosures. One enclosure is a unit that can consist of one or more pages. For example, a cover letter with a two-page resume enclosed is only one enclosure. When more than one item is enclosed, you should indicate the number: `"Enclosures 3"` (See Figure 7.6). For an attachment, that word may be typed in place of "enclosure."

When the enclosures are especially important (checks, legal documents, or blueprints), it is desirable to list in the enclosure notation exactly what the enclosures are (Enclosures 2-Policy #9595 and #32805).

4. Copy Notation

When persons other than the addressee will receive a copy of your message, you note by writing "c," "pc," "copy," or "cc" followed by the names of these persons just below the reference initials or the enclosure notation.

When you want persons other than the addressee to receive a copy of your letter, the names of these persons should be typed just below the reference initials or the enclosure notation, whichever is last. Type "cc" before the copy notation names if you are sending them a carbon copy. Type "c," "pc," or "copy" if it is a photocopy. Recipients' addresses may be included after their names.

When you do not want the addressee to know that other persons are getting a copy of the letter, type "bc" (blind copy) or "bpc" (blind photocopy) and the recipients' names *on the copies only.*

5. File or Account Number and Mailing Notation

To aid in filing and quick retrieval for both the sender's and reader's company, some firms require that file, loan, or account numbers be typed above the body of the letter.

Mailing notation words such as Special Delivery, Certified, or Registered Mail, when applicable, may be typed a double space below the date line and at least a double space before the inside address, as in Figure 7.5. An alternative placement is below the last notation. For instance, the Registered Mail notation could be placed a double space under the reference initials and a double space above the postscript.

6. Postscript

To emphasize a point already in your letter or to include a brief personal message unrelated to the letter, a postscript, typed or handwritten (with or without "P.S.," "PS," or "PS:") may be added below everything else typed on the page. (See Figure 7.5.) But with today's rapid word processors, the postscript is falling into disuse.

If you have occasion to use several notations after the signature area, the initials RECMP may help you remember the proper order for arranging them vertically at the left margin: reference initials, enclosures, copy notation, mailing notation, postscript.

Letter Layout

Most American business letters use mixed punctuation, with a colon following the salutation and a comma after the complimentary close.

Although layout or format of the letter is primarily the typist's responsibility, it is covered briefly here to give you a basis for choosing the styles you prefer. Some companies have adopted a common word processing softward package (that even includes punctuation) so that all their letters are uniform regardless of dictator, department, or secretary.

Punctuation Styles

Open and *mixed* punctuation are the two forms most used in American business letters. In open punctuation, no line of any letter part (except the body) has any

punctuation at the end unless an abbreviation requires a period. In mixed punctuation, a colon follows the salutation; a comma follows the complimentary close.

Foreign writers, especially those in Asia and Great Britain, use a comma in place of a colon after the salutation. They argue that colons are too formal. Tradition in the United States suggests a comma in personal letters even though colons are used in business letters.

Letter Styles

Business letters are usually arranged in one of the letter styles described briefly below and in Figures 7.3 to 7.7.

1. *Full-block* (Figure 7.5). Every line begins at the left margin. This is a common format because it is quick and easy to set up.
2. *Modified-block* (Figure 7.3). The date, complimentary close, and signature sections begin at the horizontal center of the page or are placed so that they end near the right-hand margin. Attention and subject lines may be indented, centered, or begin at the left margin, where all other parts begin. This letter style is used often and is attractive on the page.
3. *Modified-block with paragraphs indented* (Figure 7.6).
4. *AMS (Administrative Management Society) simplified style* (Figure 7.7). AMS has been in use since the 1950s, but is not widely used.

Tips for Letter Placement

Software packages permit instant formatting (indents, spacing, margin width, type style, for example) of material according to the length of the letter or the size of the paper. The following suggestions are helpful for setting up your message on 8½ by 11-inch paper.

Letter Length	Words in Body	Side Margins, Inches	Line Length, Inches	Lines Between Date and Inside Address	Examples
Short	Under 100	2	4½	4–10	Figure 7.4
Medium	100–200	1½	5½	3–8	Figures 7.3 and 7.5
Long	200–300	1	6½	2–6	Figure 7.6

In summary, some software packages for word processing systems have removed most of the guesswork in laying out or formatting a letter. Additional nonverbal cues of the letter's appearance are its stationery, placement of the standard parts on the page, and envelope. When these are all desirable, the combination will help you send a visually appealing letter.

MEMORANDUMS

In contrast to the letter, which is directed outside your organization, the memorandum goes within your organization. It is the most common form of written

LETTERHEAD

February 6, 199–

Research & Development Department
Futura Graphics Company
114 Fourth Avenue, NE
San Obispo, CA 55577-0000

Attention: Ms. Fenottus

Research Development Team:

Among other formats available for your business letters is this modified-block style with paragraph indentations. The date may be centered or placed to the right of center, so long as it does not extend into the right margin. In this example, the date begins to the right of center.

The attention line here is at the left margin, two lines below the inside address, and underlined. It could also have been centered and typed in all capital letters without underscoring. If you wanted Ms. Fenottus' name in the salutation, you would type her first name or two initials and her surname above "Research & Development Department." Then you would omit the attention line and use "Dear Ms. Fenottus" in the salutation.

Like the date, the complimentary close begins at the center of the page. The company name is omitted, but it could have been included. Also, the signer's name, instead of being at the left, could have been typed in the usual place–or just move above "Creative Director," and reference initials could then have been used at the left margin.

The term "enclosures 3" in the reference section shows that three additional items are being enclosed in the envelope. Each different item is counted as one regardless of the number of pages it has. The notation "c" indicates that a copy is being sent to Mr. Solomon. If you have more than one name, you can list them alphabetically or by rank.

The right-hand margins are not "justified" (even) in this letter, but that is an option you have for this and all other letter styles.

Very truly yours,

George Wells Creative Director

Enclosures 3
c: Mr. James Solomon

Figure 7.6 Modified-block letter style, with paragraph indentations and mixed punctuation. Length: long.

LETTERHEAD

May 1, 199–

Mr. Louis St. John
P.O. Box 992
Boston, MA 00000-1234

FORMAT FOR SIMPLIFIED LETTER

This letter form, Mr. St. John, has been recommended by the Administrative Management Society as a timesaver when typing business letters. Here are its features:

- It uses full-block form and open punctuation.
- It omits the salutation and complimentary close but–to personalize–may, if possible, use the reader's name in the first and last sentences.
- The subject line is all capitals, omits "Subject," and is typed where the salutation is usually placed.
- The signer's name and business title are typed in all capitals, starting at the left margin at least four lines below the last line of the letter body.
- The typist initials are at the left margin two lines below the signer's name. Enclosures and names of persons receiving copies are on separate lines below the initials.

Mr. St. John, the simplified letter not only saves time but also avoids the risk of selecting an inappropriate saluation–or using "Dear (name)" when the reader is in no way "dear." It is also helpful when you are writing a department and don't know anyone's name or whether its members include men, women, or both.

For most business letters, correspondents prefer to use the traditional forms with salutations and complimentary closes.

JANICE C. PETINA–PUBLIC RELATIONS DIRECTOR

mo
Enclosure
CC: Jon Sanchez, Jennifer Waits

Figure 7.7 AMS simplified style; full-block; open punctuation. Length: medium; side margins: $1\frac{1}{2}$ inches; line length: $5\frac{1}{2}$ inches.

communication between people or departments. The stationery, parts, layout, and envelopes are somewhat different from those of the letters described in the preceding section.

Stationery

Managers using electronic mail (E-mail) send their message from a computer to that of a colleague, eliminating the need for stationery. Or the receiver may print out the message on computer paper. For more permanency, a copy of the E-mail memo is often reproduced on higher-quality stationery. Formal memorandum reports, composed on word processing systems and reproduced on laser printers, may also use higher quality paper. Preprinted memo stationery may include MEMORANDUM and the company's name (but not address). Also, words naming the various memo parts may be included, as in Figure 7.8. Many companies decide on their own format.

Parts of the Memorandum

Standard memos consist of a heading with TO, FROM, SUBJECT, and DATE. On preprinted office forms, the word MESSAGE may also appear. These parts can be programmed to appear automatically with just a keystroke in a word processing system. Optional parts are such items as reference initials, enclosures, file number, routing information, and the sender's department and telephone

MEMORANDUM (Company name)

DATE: _____ FROM: _____

TO: _____ TELEPHONE: _____

DEPT: _____

SUBJECT: _____

Message, Comment, or Reply

For your

☐ APPROVAL ☐ INFORMATION ☐ COMMENT

WRITE IT • DATE IT • SIGN IT

Oral messages waste time, cause annoying interruptions, and are likely to be misunderstood or forgotten.

Figure 7.8 Office interdepartmental memorandum.

number. Unlike the letter, the memo requires no inside address, salutation, complimentary close, or full signature. It is not unusual to sign the memorandum at the end along with a personal, handwritten note. That is more the case with British-influenced writing, in which even a complimentary close is added. Some companies have combination message-reply forms that provide lines for both the writer's and the reader's signatures.

Using the combination *message-and-reply memorandum* form is an especially good time and expense saver for both sender and receiver. A packet of three or more perforated sheets plus carbons (unless special carbonless paper is used) makes up a message-reply packet. Printed instructions at the top or bottom tell the sender and the reader how to use the sheets. Each sheet is divided into two sections, MESSAGE and REPLY. These two sections may be side by side or one above the other, as in Figure 7.9.

Headings

Whether to include a courtesy title after your "TO" heading depends on your relationship with your receiver; you omit your title before your own name.

What you write after the TO, FROM, and DATE will vary with the situation and your organization's practices. A courtesy title such as Mr., Mrs., Miss, Ms. before your reader's name may be used, depending on your relationship with the reader (superior or subordinate) and the degree of formality within your organization. You omit the title before your name. Also, if the message is a temporary message, not to be filed, and if you and the writer work together regularly, you may merely use initials, first name, or nickname after TO and FROM, and use all figures or abbreviations for the date.

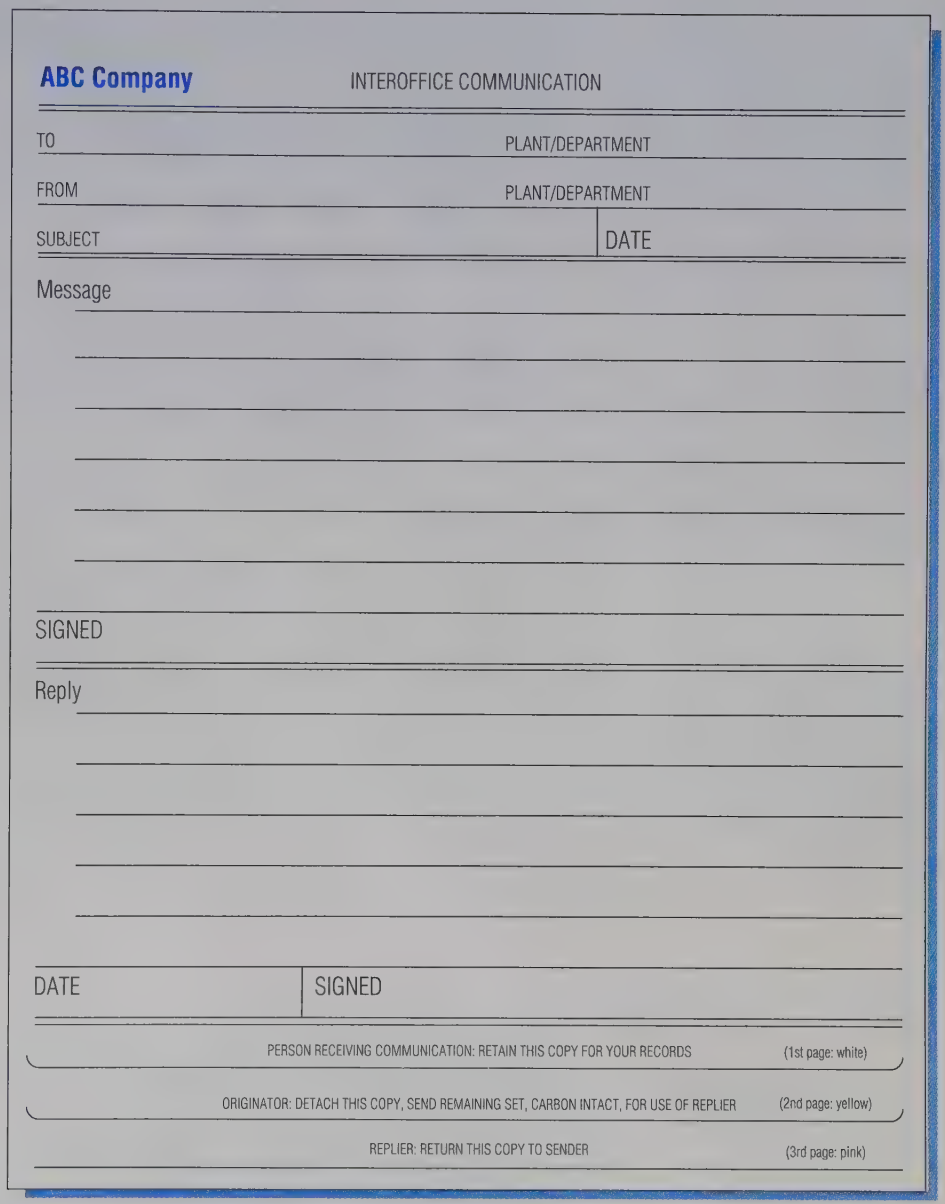
Whether you use initials, first names, or whole names, you must sign or initial your memo. Usually your signature is written above or to the right of your printed name. Occasionally, the signature is put at the bottom of the memo.

If the memo will be filed, the names of the sender and receiver should be completely spelled out. If you are sending the same message to several persons, their names or titles, or both, should be typed after TO. If you write to the same persons often, you may have a form called a *routing slip* prepared with their names printed after the TO. When you have only one copy of a document, book, or other important papers that you want everyone in a certain group to read and comment on, circulate a cover memo as in the following:

```
DATE:     April 1, 199-   Please read and initial the
TO:       John Evans      attached:  then send it to
          Jane Brown      the next reader.  Last
          Toshi Umeda     reader please return memo
          Susan Kalray    and attachment to sender.
FROM:     Steve Westberg, Human Resources
SUBJECT:  Request your Suggestions on Attached
          Policy Manual
```

Subject Line

A subject line must make the content of the memorandum instantly clear. One-word subject lines communicate little. The reader does not know whether he or she will be informed or persuaded, asked to do something, or simply to read for information. Busy executives who receive many memos daily desire an up-front,


ABC Company INTEROFFICE COMMUNICATION

TO PLANT/DEPARTMENT

FROM PLANT/DEPARTMENT

SUBJECT DATE

Message

SIGNED

Reply

DATE SIGNED

PERSON RECEIVING COMMUNICATION: RETAIN THIS COPY FOR YOUR RECORDS (1st page: white)

ORIGINATOR: DETACH THIS COPY, SEND REMAINING SET, CARBON INTACT, FOR USE OF REPLIER (2nd page: yellow)

REPLIER: RETURN THIS COPY TO SENDER (3rd page: pink)

Figure 7.9 Interoffice memorandum packet containing either carbons under sheets of paper or carbon-treated paper with sections for both message and reply.

clear direction to the memo. Thus the deductive, early statement of intent, often including a verb, gives early understanding of later contents, as in the following two approaches.

Informative Subject Lines—note use of qualifiers

```
Changes in Vacation Schedules
Requesting Leaves of Absence
```

```
Family Events During the Coming Year
Announcement of Newly Promoted Colleague
```

Persuasive Subject Lines—note use of verbs

```
Employees Must Determine Vacation Schedule by
  March 1
Vice-Presidents Should Submit Material for Annual
  Report
Leave of Absence Needed
```

In brief, the subject line should give immediate direction to the memorandum. Later, of course, the specific aim of the memo will appear. But having clarity immediately increases the chance of a reader's understanding.

Layout of the Memorandum Body

The body of the memo is its most important part because it contains your message. In general, you can use the same guidelines, principles, and organizational plans for the memo as for the letter.

The memo body is not centered on the page and is lined up evenly on the left, with a triple space between the last of the memo headings and the first line of the body.

Unlike that of a letter, the memo body is not centered on the page. First lines usually begin a triple space under the last of the memo headings regardless of message length. Left margins are usually lined up evenly below the headings. Single spacing with double spacing between paragraphs is conventional. For memo pages beyond the first, headings are the same as those for the business letter: reader's name, page number, and date. Reference initials are typed a double space below the body at the left margin. Copy notations may be placed after the reference initials or near the top of the memo between the `TO` and `FROM`. If only your business title appears in the `FROM` line, or if the `FROM` line is omitted, you should sign your name a few spaces below the memo body.

Communication Probe

It is impossible to completely separate formats of messages from their substance. A business message generally looks different from other kinds of documents because of the nature of the information involved, the purpose of the message, and the identity of the receiver. Shorter paragraphs, headings and other kinds of advance organizers, and an appropriate amount of white space are hallmarks of business documents. Reasons for these kinds of format conventions are twofold: Most business readers want to understand the message quickly, and most business documents are problem-solution–related rather than philosophical. One of the biggest differences between business writing and other kinds of writing is the importance of visual impact.

Munter, M. (1992). *Guide to managerial communication* (3rd ed.). Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall.

Envelopes and Electronic Mail

How your memo is sent to the addressee depends on where you and the reader are located and the degree of high technology in the office. Firms generally have messengers, preprinted company envelopes, or electronic mail. The envelope address contains your name and department in the upper left corner and the reader's name, department, and address according to your organization's procedures.

SPECIAL TIMESAVING MESSAGE MEDIA

Included in this section are various message media that save both the sender and the recipient time. Media that merit discussion here are the newer electronic forms of communication, such as electronic mail (E-mail) and facsimiles (faxes), as well as a few of the older forms, such as telexes, telegrams, and mailgrams. Teleconferencing adds another dimension to electronic communication, enabling a person to attend a meeting in another city without leaving his or her desk.

Electronic Mail

E-mail formats have similarities to both memo and letter formats, with conventions that are still developing as the use of electronic mail expands.

Writing conventions for electronic mail are still emerging, but generally, E-mail is marked by informality and speed. Formats can vary considerably from one sender to another. Receivers have varying comfort levels with messages sent electronically; some receivers always print out the message in hard copy in order to give it their best reading. Over time, the users of E-mail will determine which kinds of formats are effective. At present, E-mail formats are generally a less formal combination of letter and memo conventions, with memo headings for internal and external communications, but often with salutations and closings more like letters. A complete discussion of electronic mail, including ways to use it effectively, is in Chapter 5.

Communication Probe

Some researchers have suggested that a writer's relation to electronic communication seems different from a writer's relation to a hard copy of a letter or memorandum. Some writers lose the sense of audience when composing on a computer and thus, lose the inhibitions or constraints that a hard copy provides. So far, there is little censorship in electronic mail, and writers sensing this freedom express ideas that they would not write on a hard copy. Writers need to be aware that even though writing on E-mail seems relatively anonymous and impermanent, there is not only a receiver of the message but also a record of each message that remains on the system for a period of time. E-mail messages can be read by system operators, can be transcribed on command, and can be subpoenaed in a court of law.

Hawisher, G., & Moran, C. (1993, October). Electronic mail and the writing instructor. *College English, 55*(6), 627–643; Ahrens, E. (1992, Winter). The perils of imprudent writing. *ACCA Docket*, 34–37.

Facsimiles (Faxes)

For immediate communication, many organizations use a fax, which is a fast-growing means of sending and receiving messages.

Where there was one fax machine, there are now three, five, or ten. For years, this instrument languished, only to burst forth as one of the preeminent instruments for communicating information—worldwide or down the hall. Basically, the system transmits identical images electronically from the sender's machine to the receiver's. That machine may be a fax machine or a computer with software capable of sending a fax directly from your computer to another computer. All one needs is the telephone and fax number of the receiving party.

Noteworthy also is the Western Union Instant Mail Manager for the Macintosh computer. It is usable for message creation, transmission, and receipt. "Fax for Macs" are delivered worldwide. From your Macintosh you can send messages to multiple fax machines as well as telex subscribers simultaneously by using EasyLink's multiple address feature. You receive immediate information that your fax message has been delivered.

Telegrams, Mailgrams, Telexes

Older forms of electronic communication that operate on the same wires and satellites set up for the telephone system are telegrams, mailgrams, and telexes. These communication media are still used by companies not set up with computer systems, although their use is diminishing as computer-driven technology becomes easier and less expensive to access.

Telegrams, mailgrams, and telexes are older forms of electronic communication, but they are still used by companies that are not hooked into computer networks.

You can still send a telegram within the continental United States and Canada or a cablegram overseas by contacting a Western Union toll-free number listed in any telephone directory. Since charges are based on number of words, conciseness is important. Mailgrams are used when you need to reach a number of people simultaneously in writing on the next business day. They may be sent by various means, but the most convenient is to telephone a Western Union toll-free number. In general, telegrams and mailgrams are less expensive than phone calls, especially if the message must be transmitted a long distance.

Telexes are also electronic messages that use telegraph lines for transmission. A telex message is keyboarded on a word processing system and then sent over telegraph lines to compatible receivers. Many companies, hotel chains, airlines, and other groups communicate directly with their own branch offices by telex.

Teleconferencing

It is often less expensive to bring together people located at distant geographical sites by arranging a teleconference rather than have them physically come together. There are three ways you can make this kind of arrangement:

1. *Audio*—Audioconferencing uses telephone lines to set up a group conference. Everyone in the group is able to speak to everyone else.
2. *Video*—Videoconferencing uses closed-circuit television, in which every participant can see, hear, and talk to others. This form of communication is gaining popularity because of improvement in technology and decreasing costs.

3. *Computer*—Computer conferencing uses computer terminals to link participants. People can send and receive messages in real time (while they are actually sitting at their computer terminal) from other members of the group.

SUMMARY

Forms of your message, as contrasted to its substance, are important for two reasons: (1) You want your receiver to get your points without being distracted by the message's format, and (2) you want your message's format to make your points as easy to understand as possible. Even with your message's format, you need to be aware of your receiver's expectations.

This chapter is your guide to formats of business letters, memos, and the various forms of electronic communication media. The appearance of your business messages gives a strong nonverbal impression to your reader. Stationery, parts, format, and envelopes for business letters (external communication) should follow certain guidelines. For memorandums (internal communication) the stationery, parts, layout, and envelopes are different from those of letters.

Format conventions for the new and developing electronic media are continually changing. E-mail tends to take less formal shapes and to be based on quickness of delivery. Faxes are also immediate and, at this writing, easier to use than E-mail. Older forms of electronic media—telegrams, mailgrams, and telexes—are still used by many companies not yet hooked up to the growing computer networks. Teleconferencing is growing in popularity for companies whose interests are increasingly global.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***International Telecommunications.*** Although the technology exists to link the world through electronic networks, there are problems because of the varying ways countries regulate electronic access and the disparate electronic systems. AT&T and MCI are forging ahead with several proposed global alliances. Do library research on what AT&T and MCI have proposed, what problems the proposals could solve, and what problems they could generate. Report to the class on your findings.

2. ***Format Variations Abroad.*** Various kinds of standard message formats are different from country to country. For example, resumes in Germany look much different from those in the United States. In pairs, find an example of a message format that is different from the conventional format in the United States. Give an oral report outlining the differences.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Condensing Word Counts.*** Condense the following 25-word telegram to 10 words or less:

PLEASE MEET ME AT THE PLAZA HOTEL AT 1 P.M. ON JUNE 6, 199- TO DISCUSS OUR PLANS FOR THE UPCOMING CONVENTION OF ENVIRONMENTAL NEGOTIATORS

4. ***Investigating Teleconferencing.*** Find out from a technology expert in your school what it would cost to set up audio- and video-conferencing equipment. What equipment is needed? What are the costs? What would be the advantages and disadvantages? Write a brief proposal in favor of or against your school's investing in these facilities. If your school already has this technology available, write a report on whether it is a wise or an unwise investment.

5. ***Discovering New Technology.*** Find an article on electronic mail, networking, the Internet, faxes, or other technological media of communication and review it for the class.

6. ***Correcting Format Errors.*** Discuss the errors in each of the following letter parts. Each example has one or more faults.

   In the heading (of stationery that does not have a letterhead):

   a. 6 February 199-
   13128 Van Doren st
   Petosky, Mich. 48990

   b. Ms. Louise Masters
   99 Vernon Ave.
   Billings, Mon. 80841
   Jan 13, 199-

   In the inside address:

   a. Mr. Jonathon Wills,
   4317 N.E. (ave.)
   Chicago,
   Illinois

   b. Doctor William Sorenson
   School of Business Administration
   University of the Palisades
   LOS ANGELES 99460

   Salutations and complimentary closes (mixed punctuation):

   a. Dear Miss Lois Trane
   Yours truly

   b. Dear George,
   Sincerely yours

c.
```
Dear Sir:
        With regards
```

d.
```
Dear Prof. Charles Cowan
        Very truly yours,
```

In the signature and reference section:

a. [*open punctuation*]

```
                    Very Truly Yours,
                    Michigan Environmental Assn.
R.M.F./M.O.B.       Ms. Sylvia West
INCLOSURE           President
```

b. [*mixed punctuation*]

```
                    With warm regards
                    WESTLAND PRODUCTS GROUP
M0B/R0              Cecil Walker
cc: John Jones      Rs. & Dev.
```

Chapter 8

Good-News and Neutral Messages

I. Organizational Plan

II. Favorable Replies
- A. Answering Inquiries
- B. Granting Requests for Adjustment
- C. Approving Credit
- D. Acknowledging Orders
- E. Granting Favors and Other Requests
- F. Job Acceptance Letters
- G. Goodwill Messages

III. Neutral Messages
- A. Announcements
- B. Transmittals

IV. Summary

V. Exercises and Problems

VI. Capsule Checklists for Good-News and Neutral Messages

A message that will receive a favorable or neutral reaction from your reader is usually easy to write because such a message tells your reader something pleasant or offers useful information. These messages are generally organized by the direct approach—also known as the good-news plan.

This chapter suggests an effective organizational plan for favorable replies and neutral messages and discusses the following kinds of letters and memoranda you can organize with this plan:

Favorable Replies

- Answering inquiries
- Granting requests for adjustment
- Approving credit
- Acknowledging orders
- Granting favors and other requests
- Job acceptance letters
- Goodwill messages: appreciation, congratulation, and condolence letters

Neutral Messages

- Announcements about:
  - Sales and events
  - Procedures, policies, and responsibilities
  - Honors and activities of people
- Transmittals

ORGANIZATIONAL PLAN

You can use the direct-approach, good-news plan whenever your message is favorable or neutral to your reader. The plan has three parts:

1. **First:** Best news or main idea
2. **Middle:** Explanation, with one or more of the following, when appropriate: all necessary details, educational information, resale, sales promotion
3. **Last:** Positive, friendly ending, with a clear statement of action desired, motivation to action, willingness to help further, appreciation

You can use the good-news plan if your message is mainly good news or favorable information but also has unpleasant facts. Because the items in the following explanation form the basic core of your message, use your own judgment in deciding which items to include:

1. *All necessary details.* Include all facts, terms, reasons, and other explanations that pertain to the best news or the main idea. Consider, for instance, whether the reader needs specific details on the why, what, when, who, where, and how of the news or main idea.

2. *Educational information.* Include instructions for use and other educational facts about a product or service the customer has bought. Decide how much information is necessary to help the customer get the most benefit from your product or from the relationship with your firm. If you enclose an instruction booklet, a short paragraph in the letter may call attention to certain pages in that booklet.
3. *Resale material.* Include appropriate favorable information about a product or service the reader has already bought or is planning to buy or about your organization. This kind of information emphasizes reader benefits.
4. *Sales promotion.* Include suggestions about other products or services related to those the customer has bought or is considering buying. Including this kind of information will let you be of further service to the customer and provide reader benefits.

FAVORABLE REPLIES

Most persons like good news first in a communication; favorable replies allow you to begin in such a positive manner.

To help build goodwill, a progressive organization replies to all reasonable requests courteously, helpfully, and promptly. If you know there will be a delay, a brief acknowledgment should state the reason and then tell the inquirer approximately when to expect a complete answer. In such a message, you begin with the best news first—information that is useful to the reader or shows you are doing something.

In every good-news reply, your compliance with the reader's request is more important than an expression of gratitude, pleasure, or apology for not being able to deal with the request immediately. Depending on circumstances, you can begin by saying that you have done what the customer asked (the preferred beginning), that you are in the process of doing it, or that you will do it. The material you select for the explanation and ending varies with the circumstances.

The discussion in this section includes guidelines for and examples of favorable replies to requests for information about individuals and products and to requests for adjustment, credit, orders, and favors. It also gives suggestions for writing job acceptance letters and letters of congratulations, appreciation, and condolence.

Answering Inquiries

It is advisable, if possible, to write a recommendation to a specific person.

Among the most frequent non-sales-related inquiries are requests for information about personnel and credit applicants. The following section focuses on letters of recommendation about personnel for jobs and replies to inquiries about applicants who are considered for reasons other than jobs.

When you furnish information about an applicant's qualifications, character, and general conduct, the message should preferably be addressed to the specific person interested rather than "To whom it may concern."

You have a fourfold responsibility when you write recommendations. You must be fair to (1) *the applicants,* so they can get what they are best qualified for; (2) *the inquirers* (prospective employer, creditor, landlord, or whomever),

Communication Probe

Although the direct approach for good-news and neutral messages is a major guideline for American and British writing, other countries favor a more indirect, or inductive, approach to messages. In a study of expository writing in Japanese, Korean, Chinese, and Thai, John Hinds discovered that a "quasi-inductive" organization was favored. This kind of approach incorporated not only a buffer at the beginning but also a less linear progression of points, allowing the reader to contemplate the issues and draw his or her own conclusions.

In a separate study of Finnish, British, and American requests, Hilkka Yli Jokipii found that even the British and American conventions differed in that the British prefer implicit, less direct strategies, whereas the Americans aim for explicitness and directness.

Hinds, J. (1990). Inductive, deductive, quasi-inductive expository writing in Japanese, Korean, Chinese, and Thai. In U. Conner & A. Johns (eds.), *Coherence in writing: Research and pedagogical perspectives* (pp. 79–100). Alexandria, VA: Teachers of English to Speakers of Other Languages; Jokipii, H. (1994). *Requests in professional discourse: A cross-cultural study of British, American and Finnish business writing.* Helsinki, Finland: Suomalainen Tiedeakatemia.

because they are depending on your frank comments; (3) *your own conscience and reputation,* for integrity; and (4) *the civil rights laws and legal statutes* that cover hiring practices. Discussed now are the expanded good-news outline, recommendations on outstanding candidates, and appraisals on candidates with shortcomings.

Expanded Good-News Plan for Recommendations

The following suggestions are a basis for confidential recommendation letters (or phone conversations) when facts are mainly favorable or neutral:

1. Main idea
   - **a.** State the applicant's full name and what his or her relationship is to you—employee, customer, friend, tenant, club member. Mention dates, length of time, and type of job, credit, tenancy, or whatever is pertinent.
   - **b.** Include an expression of pleasure, if sincere, in your statement of purpose for the letter, *replying confidentially to a request.* A subject line can cover part of item b with such words as "Confidential report by request on Gail E. Smith as a prospective field representative."
2. Explanation
   - **a.** Answer all questions, direct or implied, unless doing so would be legally risky.

b. Support your statements of evaluation (excellent, outstanding, etc.) with specific facts about performance record. For a job applicant: (1) Tell specific job duties that applicant performed. (2) Discuss those duties relevant to the position for which the applicant is a candidate, if known. (3) Mention, when desirable, work habits that show personality characteristics.

c. If there is negative material, consider the suggestions in the section "Recommendations for Candidates with Shortcomings" below.

3. Ending

a. Include, if possible, a candid statement of your personal opinion about the applicant's probable fitness for the position or for the lease, credit, or membership in a club.

b. Be sure to correlate your opinion with documented facts.

Recommendations for Outstanding Candidates

When everything you want to say is favorable, the requested recommendation can be stated easily and in a straightforward manner, as in the example below:

LETTER 1 *An international marketing director's sincere solicited recommendation to the Executive Committee of his firm about a member of his staff seeking a promotion.*

Pleasure; purpose; name; job length	I am happy to answer your inquiry about Jonathon Court. Because Jon has worked for me nearly two years as a member of my staff, I know him well.
Answer to questions	During this time, Jon has been the most effective member of my liaison staff. His monthly reports show a keen grasp of the competitive problems we face in each of our international divisions. He has workable, creative ideas for improving our sales, and he works well with people.
Duties performed	Jon has been involved in the last five advertising campaigns in southern Europe, including Spain and Portugal. His language skills are a plus. He has made it his business to learn several of the languages of the countries in which we work, and thus, knows Spanish and Portuguese. This knowledge will be an asset to him as the Director of Market-

ing in Lisbon. He is acutely aware of the problems of cross-cultural communication and is a sensitive host when nationals from other countries visit our home office.

Personality and character

As to conduct, personal habits, and ability to handle himself, this man has no faults, to my knowledge. He will make a real contribution to our international marketing efforts, and I give him my highest recommendation.

Although a few of these statements seem overstated (and could be revised), this person has written a sincere recommendation supported by specific details.

Recommendations for Candidates with Shortcomings

When you are writing a recommendation for someone with shortcomings, you must decide whether to include or omit the negative material. You may be able to give a recommendation without stating the shortcoming. In any case, mention a weakness only if it meets these conditions:

1. It is relevant to the job (or credit, etc.) for which the candidate has applied.
2. It is *sufficiently serious* to affect the applicant's probable fitness for that responsibility.
3. It is a fact, not hearsay or your own personal prejudice, jealousy, malice, or discrimination and *is supported by the record.*
4. It occurred often enough (and recently enough) to be worth mentioning.
5. It answers a specific question asked or implied, and you mention it in a spirit of goodwill based on the preceding four items.
6. It is possible to state it *discreetly and within legal limits.*

Relevant information, tactfully stated, is advisable in recommendations.

Recommendations are incomplete and misleading as personnel reports if they omit truthful and relevant information. Nevertheless, many employers are reluctant to make any negative statement in writing or orally for fear of a costly lawsuit. Others, however, feel they have a moral duty to state what they honestly believe to be true to the questions asked about a former employee. Basically, you should have no fear of stating the relevant facts prudently.

If you are writing a letter of recommendation for a candidate who, apart from one serious shortcoming, is satisfactory, organize your letter so you establish the applicant's more favorable characteristic before you mention the weakness. In letter 2, for example, the negative fact is embedded; the message ends with candid, positive statements. In the subject line, this writer chose the word

"appraisal" instead of "recommendation." (Four lawyers and an assistant attorney general have declared this letter legally appropriate.)

LETTER 2 *A department manager comments on a former employee who had a serious alcohol problem.*

Full name and brief summary

Confidential Appraisal by Request on Kevin Haynes

Mr. Haynes worked hard for us as a salesperson in the electrical appliances section for about a year. He was such a dependable salesperson that when the section manager resigned to go to the East, we placed Kevin in charge and found him well-qualified for the job. He was with us 22 months-until June this year.

As section manager, Kevin had much responsibility. Besides ordering all merchandise for the section, he was also in charge of the five salespeople working under him. He was well-liked by subordinates and customers. He had a knack of being tactful and thoughtful with every customer. Because of his personality and his knowledge of the stock, he pleased a good many steady patrons and helped increase total sales within his section.

Favorable comment before and after negative

Kevin's work at the store was entirely commendable for about 16 months. Then he developed what he described as an alcohol problem, which noticeably affected his disposition and his attendance. When I talked with him about the change and I suggested a treatment program, he mentioned serious worries. He tried to lick the problem alone and did so for three weeks. But after he had missed at least a day's work every week for six months, I regretfully had to let him go.

Kevin's other personal habits are good. His personality, honesty, and physical appearance are an asset to any company. He takes an active part in outdoor sports and is in fine health, except for the problem I mentioned. He will quite probably successfully recover from his problem during a helpful professional program.

Favorable, job-related appraisal

Kevin is intelligent and well-educated (a marketing graduate of Broadway College). Because he knows the electrical appliance business well and has so many other fine qualities, he can be a top-notch depart-

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ment or section manager, especially in
the electrical field.
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Besides recommendations for job applicants, you may sometimes be asked to recommend people for other reasons. Whether the inquirer is considering a person as a tenant on leased property, for membership in an organization, for credit, or an award, you can adapt the expanded good-news plan for recommendations to help you write favorable recommendations.

Granting Requests for Adjustment

Err on the side of the customer; give him or her the benefit of the doubt.

An *adjustment letter* is the reply to a complaint (called a *claim letter*). In general, the best attitude is to give the customer the benefit of the doubt. Most persons are honest in their claims, and it is usually better to make the desired adjustment than to risk losing a customer.

Even though your firm's adjustment policy may be generous, the ultimate success of your good-news adjustment letters depends not only on *what* you say but also on *how* you say it. Always choose neutral or positive language in referring to a complaint, such as "your experience" or "your letter." One additional caution must be mentioned. When you receive letters from foreign customers, remember that their own cultural conventions may affect the tone of their letters. Some may seem demanding, insist upon immediate satisfaction, and threaten to take their business elsewhere. For example, as Asia—especially China—and Eastern Europe become more capitalistic, they are in a position to be more demanding. Know the cultural background of the country from which the writer is requesting an adjustment. Review some of the cultural principles noted in Chapter 3.

The discussion in this section concerns (1) tone of adjustment messages, (2) organization and content when the seller is at fault, (3) when the buyer or a third party is at fault, and (4) when fault has not yet been determined.

Communication Probe

Research suggests that readers remember most what comes first or last in a message and tend to forget what falls in the middle. Therefore, the strongest arguments, ideas, or new and important information can be most effective if they are at the beginning or the end. Less important points or discussions of objections can be placed in the middle. A writer should not be limited to one organizational pattern, however. The most important consideration is the audience and what that audience knows about the subject and what his or her reactions to the subject might be. There are no rules for effectiveness, only possibilities. You might move from most important to least in a routine message or from least important to most in order to create power and drama.

Selzer, J. (1989). Arranging business prose. In Myra Kogan (ed.), *Writing in the business professions* (pp. 37–54). Urbana IL: National Council of Teachers of English.

Tone in Adjustment-Granting Messages

A considerate and courteous tone is important because the customer may have been irritated or inconvenienced by the situation.

Consideration and courtesy are exceptionally important when you grant an adjustment. Because your reader has been inconvenienced, irritated, and perhaps angered, he or she is especially sensitive to the tone of your message. Even when a letter grants a request, its tone can either maintain or destroy goodwill. Consider the following example, in which the antagonistic expressions are underlined:

Poor: Nevertheless, so that we can keep you as a satisfied customer, we are willing to allow you to exchange these toys. [*The motive sounds selfish; "willing" and "allow you" sound condescending and grudging; sentence lacks you-attitude.*]

Better: Because we want you to be completely pleased, we will gladly exchange the toys for you.

When you are definitely at fault, saying "I'm sorry," "We apologize," or "Please forgive us" is quite disarming. You are more likely to lose face by *not* apologizing than by doing so. One apology, preferably in the explanation section, is enough for most situations.

Organization and Content When Seller Is at Fault

The discussion in this section helps you plan carefully when granting an adjustment if your company is at fault.

Try to create rapport with your reader in the first paragraph.

Opening Paragraph. Begin with whatever you think the reader will consider the best news. If the customer has asked for something specific, such as a refund, exchange, credit memo, or speedier service, grant or promise immediately. However, if the specific problem makes granting something inadvisable, try to create rapport with your reader in another appropriate way. For example, if a customer has found a bug in a jar of prunes and vows never to buy your products again, you cannot very well begin by saying you are sending another jar of prunes to replace the faulty one! Instead, you might express regret for the occurrence and appreciation for the customer's thoughtfulness in writing. In the following examples, the first two grant a request immediately, and the last two open with various statements to create rapport with the reader.

Customer's Request or Complaint	Suggested Opening
1. That you "eliminate the delays" in your merchandise shipments or risk losing business.	You will be glad to hear that we have found a new way to speed deliveries of fresh vegetables to you. From now on, your produce can reach you within two hours

after we receive your order.

2. That you replace immediately five defective copies of a book needed by May 15.

Today five copies of [*book title*] were sent to you by air express, shipping charges prepaid. You should receive them three days before May 15.

3. That you refund to a friend the $30.50 purchase price because of your firm's error. (Your customer bought a birthday gift for a friend. Instead of charging it to your customer's account, your store incorrectly sent the "gift" to the friend c.o.d.)

(*To the customer's friend.*) You have had the unusual experience of paying for your own birthday gift that your friend James L. Tomson had purchased for you from our store. The mix-up is due entirely to our error, for which we extend to you our sincere apologies. (*Note: In this case, the refund check is mentioned only after the explanation.*)

4. That two special toys ordered 4 weeks ago did not arrive in time for Christmas.

Please give us the opportunity to restore the Christmas spirit for your children. We want to do the best we can to make them happy with new toys.

You should generally include an explanation of the problem or mistake.

Explaining What Caused the Mistake. When your firm is at fault, admit it frankly. Do not say that "mistakes are bound to happen" or that because of the size of your firm, there will naturally be frequent errors, and do not promise the error will never happen again. Generally, it is desirable to include some kind of explanation. The following examples—from two adjustment grants—help the reader understand how the error occurred:

1. You guessed correctly. Apparently all the order and shipping papers, including the ones that should have been kept for our use, were sent to you. As a result, we have no record of the ordered paint. We are certainly sorry that you were inconvenienced by our slip-up. We always

try to be careful in processing every customer request accurately and promptly.

2. Our research suggests you are entirely right: the air carrier here in Michigan put an incorrect bar code on our shipment to your office in Helsinki. We know the parts arrived late. We have spoken with the air carrier; they assure us that in our next international shipments they will doubly verify the correct address and bar-code number.

Resale. If the person complaining seems to be losing faith in your firm, resale is desirable. If possible, include concrete evidence of your efficient service, safe and correct shipments, or care in providing or selecting high-quality products. If certain steps have been or will be taken to prevent recurrence of the problem, mention them. Sometimes you can honestly state that a new procedure is developed "on the basis of helpful comments like yours."

Sales promotion is usually desirable in situations involving often-replaced items.

Sales Promotion Material. If a retailer sells only one type of costly product (such as furnaces, home insulation, or roofing), which the average consumer buys only once in a great while, sales promotion material is not necessary. However, if the seller carries a variety of often-replaced items, sales promotion may be desirable. In this case, you want to encourage the customer to continue to buy other goods from you by enclosing coupons or information regarding your products.

Ending Paragraph. For a pleasant close, you may (1) tie suggested action in with sales promotional material, (2) comment on the pleasure the reader will gain from the high-quality new article you have sent, (3) express appreciation that the reader took the time to write, or (4) issue a cordial invitation that the customer continue to come to your firm for top service. Omit negative information, such as an apology (you may have already apologized in your opening) or a reminder of the inconvenience the mistake causes. Do not suggest future trouble or imply that the customer may stop buying from your firm.

Organization and Content When the Buyer or a Third Party Is at Fault

Sometimes it is advisable to grant an adjustment when the buyer or a third party is at fault.

When someone other than the seller is at fault, you may be justified in refusing instead of granting the request. Nevertheless, firms will occasionally grant a buyer's claim even though the buyer or a third party is at fault.

Buyer at Fault. If you decide to grant the adjustment claim although the buyer is at fault, you have two choices for letter organization: (1) Using the direct approach, you begin by granting the request and follow by a tactful explanation that helps the customer understand that mistreatment of the product caused the problem. Your goal is to maintain goodwill so that the customer will continue to make purchases from your firm. (2) If you decide on the indirect ap-

proach, you begin with a neutral statement that creates rapport, such as your appreciation of the customer's promptness in reporting the problem, and follow with a tactful explanation of the mistake. Finally, you grant the claim. The reason for this alternative is that sometimes the psychological effect on the reader is better if you allow the claim *after* you have shown that the buyer, not your firm, is at fault.

Third Party at Fault. Sometimes merchandise is damaged or lost while it is in the warehouse or truck of a third party—distributor, broker, shipper, or someone else. In this case, the third party has the legal responsibility to adjust the claim, and many sellers prefer not to get involved. In shipping materials to foreign customers, the situation is a bit more complex. There are innumerable causes for delay, from the international carrier to customs officials.

However, some wholesalers that sell to small retailers assist them in the claim-filing procedures, or they file the claim directly on behalf of the dealer. In these situations, the direct approach, as described in the section on when the seller is at fault, is usually preferred. You can create not only goodwill but future business if you appear to be helpful to customers and dealers alike.

Organization and Content When the Fault Is Not Yet Determined

When fault is not yet determined, the optimal organization pattern may change.

Sometimes the final adjustment decision cannot be made until the seller determines who is responsible for the mistake. In such cases, letting the buyer know promptly that you are investigating the claim is reassuring, even though you have not yet granted the claim. The best organization is (1) express interest in the problem, (2) assure the customer you are looking into the matter, (3) include brief resale material, if desirable, and (4) courteously state that you will give your reader the facts as soon as they are available.

Approving Credit

When approving credit, follow the good-news plan and include necessary information, resale, sales promotion, and appreciation.

The message telling the customer that you are granting credit often includes all parts of the basic good-news plan—best news first and then terms, resale, sales promotion, and appreciation. Many firms have preset form letters acknowledging credit approval and containing all needed information.

Decision or Shipment in First Paragraph

If the customer has not yet ordered any merchandise on credit, begin with the credit-granting decision and a cordial welcome. If an order was sent with the request for credit, begin with the date and method by which the goods are being shipped (thereby implying credit approval). Make clear the purchase details (name and quantity of goods sent, item prices, freight, and total charge); for more than two or three items, attach an invoice copy. Mention that the shipment has been added to the customer's new account.

Explanation of Credit Terms

In your explanation section, mention briefly the basis on which credit was earned, and clarify the terms. A clear explanation of the credit terms helps re-

duce collection problems later. You must be sure that every new credit customer knows whether your terms are based on invoice date, delivery date, or the end of the month. Consider the following examples:

Vague: Our credit terms are the usual 2/10, net 30.

Better: Under our credit terms of 2/10, net 30, you earn a 2 percent discount if your payment is made in 10 days. [*10 days after what?*]

A clear explanation of credit terms is important to avoid problems later.

Best: Under our credit terms of 2/10, net 30, you earn a 2 percent discount if your payment is made in 10 days, based on invoice date.

If you place the explanation of the credit terms before the resale and sales promotion, you are more certain the reader will notice them. If you place the terms after the resale and sales promotion, you are emphasizing benefits to the reader of the new credit account. Using the word "grant" reflects a we-attitude, while stating that the customer has "earned" credit communicates a you-attitude.

Be tactful in telling the customer when payments are due. Compare, for example, the poor tone in "we expect you to pay" or "you are expected to pay" with the improved tone in "payments are due within 10 days after the billing date." In this sentence, the indirect approach is desirable.

Resales and Sales Promotion

International promotions demand an understanding of the culture of the country to which you send the sales promotion.

The credit-granting message should include resale information about the firm's services, which are customer benefits. Also, it is sometimes desirable to include sales promotion material in the next to last paragraph about such news as forthcoming sales, new seasonal merchandise, or products related to those ordered. Such news encourages the customer to use credit. To keep your letter short, you can enclose a leaflet describing departments and services such as the following:

For the consumer: Free parking, mail and telephone shopping, personalized services for men, home-planning bureau, bridal registry, tearoom, restaurants, child care, gift wrapping, free and frequent deliveries, special discounts or purchase privileges.
For the reader or wholesaler: Nearby warehouses, factory representatives, quantity discounts, free window or counter displays, national advertising, cuts and mats for newspaper and other advertising, repair services, manuals, factory guarantee, prompt and speedy deliveries, research department.
For the international client: Regular quarterly visits by sales personnel, regional distribution office within two hours flight time, two-day courier service from the United States, joint venture agreements with neighboring countries, advisory staff to U.S. home office regarding styles of merchandise, in-place legal firm for legal questions.

Future Service Closing

Close your credit approval letter with statements indicating your desire to serve the customer well in the future or with listings of special services. Inviting readers to a special sale, for example, helps encourage them to use their accounts.

LETTER 3 *A retailer's form letter granting credit to a consumer; applicant's name is in the inside address and salutation.*

Best news, welcome

Welcome to Madson's as our special Regards credit account customer. Your new charge card is enclosed, and we invite you to use it often. This card will identify you at all Madson's stores, so please sign it in ink before putting it into your wallet or purse.

Credit terms

You will receive your statement, soon after the first of each month, showing purchases up to the 23d of the preceding month. Bills on this monthly account are payable by the 10th of each month. (Unpaid bills are subject to a 1½ percent finance charge monthly.)

Resale on store services

As one of our special Regards customers, you will receive announcements of all our sales before they are advertised to the public. You will receive special discounts several times a year as well as coupons for free merchandise. When you wish to shop at home, you can do so conveniently by telephone. Just ask for "personal shopping services," tell your needs to the shopping assistant, and charge your purchases to your account.

Invitation to future use

The enclosed brochure explains the numerous Madson services available for your convenience. Do use them often to save yourself both time and money. We look forward to giving you friendly, courteous service in all our stores for many years to come.

Acknowledging Orders

Acknowledging orders builds goodwill; the acknowledgment must be definite and complete.

An order acknowledgment performs several important functions. It lets the buyer know that the order has been received, is appreciated, and is given attention. It helps build goodwill. Furthermore—and very important—by identifying and accepting the order, the acknowledgment completes a valid contract between buyer and seller. For these reasons, the acknowledgment must be definite and complete.

Orders your firm can fill immediately fall into two categories: first orders and repeat orders. Although acknowledgment for both types should identify the shipment and show appreciation, the message content will be quite different.

Acknowledgment of First Order

The new customer needs to know that the order is being filled promptly and correctly, that it is appreciated, and that because of your products and services, dealings with your firm will be pleasant and profitable.

Include complete information in sending orders; remember the five W's.

Sending the Ordered Items. Usually the best beginning for your first-order acknowledgment is to state what, when, and how you shipped. If possible, state approximately when the shipment should reach its destination. Express appreciation for both the order and the remittance (if you received the latter). If you can fill most of an order promptly and the rest soon thereafter, it is best to begin with what you can ship now or what is already on its way to the customer. Later in the letter explain why and when the remainder of the order will be sent separately. Finally, take care of any needed details about shipping charges and payments.

Resale material on services is appropriate to consumer and retailer; resale material on products is more relevant for the consumer because the retailer is usually familiar with the products.

Specific Resale Material. For the first-order acknowledgment, resale on company *services* is appropriate to both the consumer and the retailer. Resale on *products* ordered is usually more relevant for the consumer than for the retailer because the latter, through sales literature, catalogs, and your sales representative, is usually familiar with your products.

To a consumer, resale material from the manufacturer is sometimes extremely helpful. After placing a large first order with a firm, the consumer may regret having signed the contract, especially when the item purchased is a luxury. The order acknowledgment from headquarters with detailed reader benefits about the product and warranty helps reinforce the buyer's confidence in the purchase.

Include order blanks or information to make the desired action easy.

Looking Forward to Future Orders and Reader Satisfaction. To end the first-order acknowledgment, you can tie suggested action in with resale or sales promotion; enclose order blanks or whatever else is needed for easy action. If you wish, invite the cash customer to fill out and return a credit application form. Avoid suggesting that credit is automatic.

Acknowledgment of Repeat Orders

Provide complete information about terms and delivery date; include expression of appreciation.

Most orders come from repeat customers who know and like a firm's products and services and who do not expect a letter of acknowledgment. Usually the goods can be sent as quickly as an acknowledgment can be mailed. In some cases, standard purchase order forms give complete instructions about terms and delivery date, and they stipulate that the buyer will be notified only if the order cannot be filled as requested. In others, an adequate good-news order acknowledgment is an inexpensive form, a carbon copy of the shipping invoice, or a postcard.

Although most repeat orders are filled with letter acknowledgments, an unusually large order may occasionally warrant a personalized letter. This letter may include appreciation, a statement of how the order is being handled, and perhaps, a few cordial comments about your past relationship and future plans to supply the customer's needs.

Granting Favors and Other Requests

Use the good-news plan: Good news first, relevant comments or explanation next, and a cordial ending.

Whenever you decide to grant a favor, you have a comparatively simple task. Whether the favor is serving on a committee, speaking at a convention, donating money, or lending your firm's equipment without charge, the good-news plan is best to use. Usually all you need is the acceptance first, relevant comments or explanation next, and a cordial ending.

Job Acceptance Letters

Three parts: Accept position and express appreciation; confirm details and ask questions; provide a pleasant closing.

One writing task that will give you pleasure is a letter accepting a job offer. A job acceptance letter is generally short and expresses your enthusiasm for the position offered. It also serves as confirmation of the details of the position, such as your salary and starting date. There are three parts to a job acceptance letter: You accept the position and express your thanks for the offer; you confirm the details and ask any questions that have not been answered; you provide a pleasant closing that expresses your enthusiasm for the opportunity.

LETTER 4 *A job acceptance letter from an M.B.A. student for a summer internship position.*

Good news first

With pleasure I accept your offer to join the Chicago office of McKinsey & Co. as a summer associate. Your hospitality and the time you spent with me have made me eager to begin and excited at the prospect of challenging assignments.

Details of position

According to our telephone conversation, the details of the position include a salary of $10,000 for the period covering May 15 to September 1, with lodging provided by McKinsey & Co. for May 14 through May 18. If there is anything further I need to know before May 15, you can reach me at (313) 555-9876.

Pleasant close

Thank you for your offer. I look forward to joining McKinsey & Co. this summer and the opportunity to make a contribution to the firm.

Goodwill Messages

Nothing wrong with expressing feelings in a goodwill message.

Goodwill messages are different from the usual business documents in that they express feelings rather than information or persuasion, and therefore can be

more difficult to write. Although it may be tempting to send printed cards, it is always more personal and meaningful to the recipients to send a written note of appreciation, congratulations, or sympathy. Goodwill messages are usually short; they should have a sincere tone and should be focused on the reader.

Letters of Appreciation

Thank you notes should be written whenever someone does you a favor or when an action deserves praise. The notes may be written to customers for their orders, to colleagues for their support, and to individuals for any special favors they have done for you or for your company. The two factors to remember in these kinds of letters are (1) the good-news plan is appropriate and (2) reader focus is essential. By beginning with your good news, you immediately focus on your reader. You should continue this reader focus throughout your letter by such strategies as using the reader's name, choosing positive language, and employing a conversational tone.

Letters of Congratulation

Congratulatory notes should be sent for business and personal achievements and milestones. As in letters of appreciation, they should use the good-news organizational plan and focus on the reader. The following short letter is an example.

LETTER 5 *A congratulatory note on a political appointment.*

Good news first

Congratulations, Jennifer, on your recent appointment as assistant chief of staff in the Governor's office! You will bring a great deal of ability, enthusiasm, and sincerity to this position; I was happy to learn of your appointment. Best wishes for your continuing success.

Letters of Condolence

Expressions of sympathy to someone who has experienced grief or misfortune are difficult to write and demand special sensitivity on the part of the writer. The direct approach (in this case, not called the good-news plan) is generally best, and the tone should be subdued and sincere. You should begin with a sensitive reference to the death or other misfortune, and you can include praise for the deceased or reassurance for the person involved. You may offer assistance when appropriate. Although some people type their sympathy notes, most are handwritten on notepaper or personal stationery and most are brief.

LETTER 6 *A sympathy note on the death of a colleague.*

Direct plan

Ruth and I were saddened by the unhappy news of Ralph's death. His contributions to our company, to his work with our youth group, and to our community were consis-

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tently done with his usual skill.  His many
friends here will miss his personality and
his innumerable contributions.

During these sad days, we offer you our un-
derstanding and support.  You have our
deepest sympathy.
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NEUTRAL MESSAGES

The previous section considered messages that are written because someone inquired. This section discusses *unsolicited* messages—specifically, announcements and transmittals.

Announcements

The good-news plan works for most kinds of announcements.

Announcements of good or neutral information should follow the good-news plan. The main idea should come first, followed by an adequate explanation and an ending that is pleasant and positive. Some messages combine an announcement with an invitation, but whether you label them announcements or invitations, you use the same three-part organizational structure.

Included in this section are group and personal announcements about sales and events; procedures, policies, and responsibilities; and honors and activities of people.

Announcing Sales and Events

Whenever you wish to announce a sale or an event (luncheon, conference, celebration, meeting, or other function) about which you need merely to inform your readers, you can use the good-news plan. The opening paragraph should include as many of the five W's as possible—who, what, where, when, why.

An excellent way to build and strengthen goodwill with regular customers is to let them know you appreciate them. For example, Message 1 announces a sale before newspaper publication.

Communication Probe

Routine or common documents tend to follow conventional formats, and these formats are useful in that they are generally efficient in providing the necessary information, and they save time. However, writers should not be completely constrained by the usual forms for messages. Some of the most effective messages break the "rules" in the way they are organized. The effective business writer needs to be aware of the conventions of writing and then decide which to observe and which to ignore.

Driskill, L. (1989). Understanding the writing context in organizations. In Myra Kogan (ed.), *Writing in the business professions* (pp. 125–145). Urbana, IL: National Council of Teachers of English.

MESSAGE 1 *Letter: A store's preannouncement to charge customers about a forthcoming sale (processed form without an inside address; salutation is "Dear Customer," complimentary close is "Sincerely," signature is name of the manager).*

Reason: Best news; five W's

Because you are a regular [*store name*] charge customer, you are invited to a special sale of unusual spring dress values. It is one of Designer Room's greatest dress events. This announcement comes to you now so that you can make your selection during a three-day period before newspaper ads appear.

Displayed for emphasis

PREANNOUNCEMENT SELLING
Wednesday, Thursday, and Friday
February 6, 7, and 8
NEW SPRING DRESSES BY OUR
FOREMOST MAKERS
All priced far below regular

THESE FINE DRESSES such as you will see at much higher prices after this great sale. Every one is a new, just-arrived 199- fashion!

Details

ATTRACTIVE COLORS include whites, pastels, neutrals, and bright shades. You will also find a wide selection of styles-casual and dressy-in various lengths; one-piece and two-piece dresses.

Easy action and motivation

TAKE ADVANTAGE OF THIS OPPORTUNITY FOR FIRST CHOICE AND SUPER SAVINGS! Come in early-February 6, 7, 8-to choose your dress. Prices will return to regular immediately after this outstanding dress event.

Announcing Procedures, Policies, and Responsibilities

Clarity and tone are important factors in messages announcing policies and directives.

Some businesses use "directives" to announce to employees official statements of company policy, procedures, and employee responsibilities. These "directives" are often compiled in loose-leaf policy manuals that can be updated as the need arises. They may cover a wide variety of topics, ranging from assigned parking spaces and office hours to policies about salary increases, retirement benefits, overtime, and treatment of customers.

Two cautions to remember when you write directives are to (1) make your statements absolutely clear to all levels of your employees and (2) avoid an arrogant or threatening tone.

Some announcements must be written in more than one language: English and the language of the foreign customer.

Announcements on policies to foreign customers are often included in booklets. These are either sent to the customer directly or to the legal firm handling policy issues. It is not unusual to present announcements in two languages: English and the language of the foreign customer. Even the military—with its

many foreign locations—has a standard operating procedure (SOP), which is kept up to date,

Some messages about procedures, policies, and responsibilities are not directives. They can be processed announcement letters to customers and others or memos, like Message 2, to employees.

MESSAGE 2 *Memo: Announcement to all employees about enrollment for company insurance plans.*

TO: All Kenmore employees
FROM: Jane L. Wood, Retirement and Insurance Officer
SUBJECT: Open Enrollment Period for Company Insurance Plans
DATE: Sept. 22, 199-

Why, when, for whom, where, what

The annual enrollment period for employee insurance plans will take place between October 4 and 27 at the retirement and insurance office.
During that time, you may

1. Enroll in medical, life, salary-continuation, or accident insurance plans for the first time
2. Transfer from one basic medical plan to another
3. Add previously uninsured dependents to medical insurance plans

Date

Changes and additions made during the open enrollment period will take effect November 1, 199-.

Enclosure instructions

Please refer to the attached individual Insurance Program Summary, which shows the premiums, company contributions, and payroll deductions for plans in which you are currently enrolled. Then read the rest of the attached material, which explains just what to do if you wish to make changes in your coverage.

Offer of more help

Brochures describing the plans and individual counseling services are available at the retirement and insurance office, 4th floor; or phone extension 987 if you wish one mailed to you.

Honors people receive are almost always presented using the good-news organization plan, although the indirect plan can be used when you want to create drama in the announcement.

Announcing Honors and Activities of People

To inform employees and customers about promotions, awards, honors, new appointments, retirements, and other recognition-deserving activities of various persons, it is thoughtful to send announcements.

Communication Probe

Several researchers have studied the various forms of corporate communication documents for employees. Haar and Kossack, citing Courtis's 1987 study of Canadian annual reports, state that the sample of 65 reports studied were not understood by 92 percent of the general adult population and 56 percent of the investor population. When the communication messages are internal, dealing with such issues as procedures, policies, benefits, and directives, the possibility of adverse consequences are great, in some cases, preventing employees from taking advantage of information that could help them.

Harr, J., & Kossack, S. (1990, Spring). Employee benefit packages: How understandable are they? *Journal of Business Communication, 27*(2), 185–200.

The first paragraph, which states the good news, often begins with words such as "We are pleased to announce that . . ." or "With great pleasure we inform you. . . ." The second paragraph gives details about the new officer, award, or whatever pertains to the announced honor or activity. Suggested action may be that all join in congratulating the person or wishing the person success and happiness.

Transmittals

As the name implies, the main purpose of a transmittal is to transmit something, which is usually mentioned in the first paragraph. Transmittals, also called "covering letters," have many uses. They range from short 5- to 10-line notes to lengthy official letters that accompany, explain, or justify documents. In general, they follow the good-news plan.

A transmittal is a letter or memo that simply sends a document to a reader.

For routine business to consumers, employees, or other persons, a cordial, short note is sufficient to transmit one or more items such as a check, policy, passbook, warranty deed, or map. Often processed fill-in forms are used, with various listed items and spaces for checking those that are enclosed. Transmittals that accompany official documents, bids, applications, proposals, or formal reports should be carefully worded letters.

SUMMARY

The good-news plan is effective whenever you answer a request favorably, whether you are giving information, granting adjustments, approving credit, accepting a job, or are involved in any of the other many situations in which you can respond in a way that will please the reader. You may also use the good-news plan for neutral messages, such as announcements about sales and events, procedures and policies, and personal honors and activities. For unsolicited messages, use the good-news plan whenever your message is straightforward and your reader will have a favorable or neutral response. The Capsule Checklists on pages 205–207 briefly summarize the basic plans and various adaptations.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Solicited Recommendation for Carla Smith.*** You are the purchasing manager for Auto-Tech, Mexico, a subsidiary of Auto-Tech International. You have just received a request from the personnel manager of a large manufacturing company located in Mexico City for a recommendation for Carla Rios, who worked in your department for 1 year until leaving because her husband was transferred to Mexico City. Although Carla had many strengths, you were relieved when she left. Carla was sent to work for you by the Mexican president of the company, who was her uncle. She was intelligent and hard-working, and although she did not do a superior job in her responsibilities, she was fairly competent. The problem was that she was overly assertive and caused dissension in the department by her arrogant and domineering manner. She was not a team player, and even though she did not have the authority to do so, she tried to direct the department according to her own agenda. As purchasing manager, you had many problems trying to deal with her tactfully, and the two of you had many conflicts during the year she was with you. Write a letter of recommendation for Carla, choosing the facts you consider to be important. Because your company is a U.S. company, be sure to consider the legal implications involved.

2. ***Product Information.*** Luis St. Jean (LSJ) is a famous leather goods house in France with annual sales of $1 billion in clothing, luggage, and other leather products. As marketing manager for Luis St. Jean, you have received a written request for information regarding your merchandise from the head buyer of Voortman's, an upscale leather goods store located in the Renaissance Center in Detroit. Information requested included types of luggage offered, prices, minimum ordering quantities, and marketing assistance, if any, offered by LSJ. Write a response to the request that includes the necessary information and provides a good promotion of your products.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Good-News Adjustment Letter.*** Evaluate the following adjustment letter from a manufacturer to retailer. What do you like and dislike about it? Suggest specific improvements in the tone, organization, accuracy, and adequacy of explanation and resale.

Thank you for telling us of the problem you have had with the suits you purchased.

Some time ago, a batch of material having bad formulation escaped detection by our quality control people. The line inspectors caught most of the finished suits before they were invoiced. However, some were shipped. Apparently your order was among them.

The situation has since been corrected, and we don't believe you will have this problem with a replacement. Accordingly, a special shipping label is enclosed for returning your defective merchandise to us. It will be promptly exchanged upon receipt. Please let us know if we may be of further service.

4. ***Evaluate the Following Congratulatory Letter.*** What is effective about the letter? What could be improved? Consider tone, organization, and reader versus writer attitude.

Dear George:

On behalf of Tom Pasto and myself, we want to congratulate you on your first anniversary as a Motech dealer. You have done well and your accomplishments have been duly noted.

Your desire to become a Motech Dealer in Savannah, GA, should a position become available, will be given full consideration. Meanwhile, continue the fine performance you have established in Columbus.

In closing, we wish to thank you for your kind words regarding the Jacksonville District and its personnel.

5. ***Evaluate the Following Letter.*** Consider tone, organization, clarity, and completeness.

Hello, John!

This letter is to inform you of I.C.C.'s membership rates. Since Nov. of 1994 the membership rates have increased by $5 to $20. This additional amount goes to the I.C.C.'s endowment fund. Enclosed is a current Renewal Form. If you still want to become a member of I.C.C. you will need to send me an additional $20 or you may receive a refund. Thank you for your interest in I.C.C. and I look forward to your response.

6. ***Compare the Following Three Memos.*** Consider completeness, clarity, tone, and organization.

a. Jack to Bob, 4/23/9-
Booklet Schedule
Johnson now says Saturday sure.

b. TO: RJL
FROM: JS
DATE: April 23, 199-
SUBJECT: HEALTH BOOKLET SCHEDULE

I checked with Johnson and now have a definite promise that the 6000 standard "Your Health" booklets will be delivered Saturday, April 26.

This rescheduling will not affect our production schedules.

c. TO: Dr. Robert Lawson, Vice President
FROM: John Spam, Managing Editor
DATE: April 23, 199-
SUBJECT: Rescheduling of Standard "Your Health" Booklets.

I talked with Thomas Johnson this morning in an effort to reschedule production of 6000 Standard "Your Health" booklets to permit delivery Saturday, April 26.

He indicated at first that such a rescheduling would delay either the "Travel Plans" or the "Vacation Hints" booklets, but after talking with his production manager, he agreed to make the schedule change without delaying our other production.

Thus we can definitely count on delivery of "Your Health" Saturday.

7. ***Evaluate the Following for Organization and Overall Effectiveness.***

Dear Tenants:

We have had some complaints lately about noise, especially at night. The complaints mainly involve the playing of CDs very late and too loud. I know that you like to listen to your music and that you need to relax at the end of your day of classes and homework. Maybe you could put your sound system away from the windows. You might also consider headphones for your listening. It isn't as though this is too serious, but a few people have complained. I just want to keep everybody happy.

8. ***Good News or Bad? Evaluate the Following for Tone and Organization.***

In your letter that accompanied the return of your leather jacket, you claim that the jacket came apart at the seams and that you want to be reim-

bursed for the total cost of the jacket. Please understand, Ms. Appleton, that leather jackets take a great deal of care, and if you give them that care, they will last for many years. The sales tag on the jacket clearly states that it must not be stretched or exposed to high heat or bitter cold. Our alterations team investigated your claim and determined that the seams were indeed not secure and that they would have split apart with little movement. This obviously supports your claim that the damage was caused by a defect in workmanship. Therefore, we are enclosing a check for the complete amount of the jacket.

9. ***Advertisement: What's Wrong with the Following Magazine Advertisement?***

February is SALE MONTH and everything in the store will be from 30%-50% off the regular price. Special inventory of designer coats and suits are priced at 50% off, and evening dresses will be up to 70% of the regular price.

This sale only lasts until February 29, so hurry in today for the best savings of the year!

Capsule Checklists for Good-News and Neutral Messages*

A **Good-News (and Neutral): General Plan**	B **Answering Inquiries for Information about Individuals —Letters of Recommendation**
1. Best news or main idea	1. Best news or main idea a. Applicant's full name and relationship to you, or how you know applicant—job(s) held, tenant, customer, club member, etc. b. Reason for writing (by request)
2. Explanation a. All necessary details b. Resale material c. Educational material d. Sales promotion	2. Explanation a. Answers to questions—direct or implied b. Best psychological order for four-fold responsibility (1) Applicant (2) Person considering applicant (3) Your conscience (4) Civil rights laws c. Specific facts about (1) Applicant's job, duties, conduct (2) Applicant's work or other habits (3) Applicant's personality, etc. d. Honesty and judgment about negatives e. Caution on legal aspects f. Confidentiality g. Offer, phone call
3. Positive, friendly ending a. Appreciation b. CSAD† c. EA‡ and motivation d. Willingness to help further e. DA§ f. RB¶	3. Courteous close a. Candid statement of your personal opinion about applicant's probable fitness for whatever he or she is being considered b. Positive (not negative) attributes at end

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.
†CSAD = clear statement of action desired.
‡EA = easy action.
§DA = dated action, if desirable.
¶RB = reader benefit.

Capsule Checklists for Good-News Messages (*Continued*)*

Granting Requests for Adjustment

C

Seller at Fault (A)

1. Best news
   a. Whatever will please buyer most
   b. Courtesy

2. Explanation
   a. Brief resale with tactful explanation of error (if desirable)
   b. Instructions for buyer action, if needed
   c. Concrete resale on firm, services, or goods, if desirable
   d. Cautions
   e. Sales promotion on replacement of return item(s) or on allied goods

3. Courteous close
   a. Suggested action and expectation of future pleasant use of goods and services.
   b. EA‡
   c. Positive idea; help
   d. RB¶

D

Buyer or Another at Fault (B)

1. Best news
   a. Same as C.1.a
   Get-in-step-with-reader, courteous comment and concern

2. Explanation
   a. Brief resale with tactful explanation of error, showing seller not at fault
   b. If use of 1.b above, best news after explanation
   c. Concrete resale on firm, services, or goods, if desirable
   d. Cautious
   e. Sales promotion on replacement of returned item(s) or on allied goods

3. Courteous close
   a. Suggested action and expectation of future pleasant use of goods and services
   b. EA‡
   c. Positive idea; help
   d. RB¶

E

Approving Credit

1. Best news
   a. Credit approval (if no purchase
   b. Shipment (if goods ordered)
      (1) Description
      (2) Quantity
      (3) Prices, costs
      (4) Method, charges
   c. Courtesy

2. Explanation
   a. Basis for credit; compliment
   b. Credit terms; payments, discounts, limits
   c. Resale on services
      (1) *Consumer:* parking, shopping services, departments, conveniences, deliveries, price benefits
      (2) *Intermediary:* warehouses, discounts, selling aids, advertising, guarantees, repairs, deliveries
   d. Resale on product choices
   e. Sales promotion?

3. Courteous close
   a. Expectation of pleasant service and orders (not greedy)
   b. Suggestion action
   c. EA‡
   d. RB¶
   e. Courtesy; suggestion of further help, if pertinent

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.
†CSAD = clear statement of action desired.
‡EA = easy action.
§DA = dated action, if desirable.
¶RB = reader benefit.

Capsule Checklists for Good-News Messages (*Continued*)*

F **Acknowledging First Orders**	G **Granting Favors**	H **Announcements**	I **Transmittals**
1. Best news a. Shipment details (1) Description (2) Quantity (3) Prices, costs (4) Method, charges b. Thanks for remittance and/or order	1. Best news a. Acceptance of favor, request b. Courtesy	1. Best news; main idea. When appropriate; a. Five W's (all or most); reader in first and all other paragraphs b. Statement of pleasure, compliment, congratulations c. Admission of errors, with good news	1. Best news; main idea a. Transmittal of specific item(s) b. A concise reason c. Courtesy
2. Explanation a. *For credit customer* (1) Basis for credit—compliment (2) Credit terms; payments, discounts, limits b. *For cash or credit* Resale on services same as E.2.c. (1) and (2) Resale on products ordered; highlights on special features—adapted to buyer c. *For cash customer* Perhaps credit application form enclosed, with invitation to return it for consideration.	2. Explanation a. Pertinent comments, and details regarding favor—what is being or will be done, etc. b. Questions, if necessary, pertaining to favor	2. Explanation a. Details to emphasize, reader benefits, if possible *In admission of error* b. Explanation, apology, emphasis on sincere desire to serve well c. Resale on firm, products, or services, as appropriate	2. Explanation, if needed a. Comments b. Instructions
3. Courteous close a. Expectation of pleasant service and orders (not greedy) b. Suggested action c. EA‡ d. RB¶ e. Courtesy, suggestion of further help, if pertinent	3. Courteous close a. Cordial, pertinent comment; perhaps a forward look, good wish, compliment, or request	3. Courteous close a. CSAD† b. EA‡ c. DA§ d. RB¶ and/or offer of further help e. Courtesy	3. Courteous close a. CSAD† b. EA‡ c. DA§ d. Offer of further help or other items or RB¶ about items transmitted

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.
†CSAD = clear statement of action desired.
‡EA = easy action.
§DA = dated action, if desirable.
¶RB = reader benefit.

PART FOUR

Written Communication: Major Plans for Letters and Memos

Chapter 9 Bad-News Messages

Chapter 10 Persuasive Written Messages

Chapter 9

Bad-News Messages

I. The Right Attitude

II. Plans for Bad-News Messages
- A. Indirect Plan
- B. Direct Plan

III. Negative Replies to Requests
- A. Answering Non-Sales-Related Inquiries When the Information Is Undesirable
- B. Refusing Adjustments on Claims and Complaints
- C. Refusing Credit
- D. Acknowledging Orders You Cannot Fill Now or at All
- E. Declining Invitations and Requests for Favors

IV. Unfavorble Unsolicited Messages
- A. Announcing Bad News About Prices or Services
- B. Penalizing for Nonconformity to Rules or Procedures
- C. Conveying Other Bad News

V. Summary

VI. Exercises and Problems

VII. Capsule Checklists for Bad-News Messages

"Difficult," "hard to compose," and "brutal" are a few of the comments often heard in connection with writing bad-news messages. Few persons find pleasure in expressing negative news. But sometime during your career, you will have to send a message that your reader will find disappointing or unfavorable. Composing a statement that creates and maintains goodwill toward you and your organization and at the same time conveys bad news will require a great deal of ingenuity.

In Chapter 8 you learned about the ingredients needed to compose and send a good-news communication. Here you learn the various sections of the negative message. A bad-news message varies from a good-news message in structure, tone, and information. With bad news, there is less tolerance for mistakes in communication.

As with other chapters in this book, we include relevant communication probes. Instead of checklists within the chapter, a detailed checklist for bad-news messages is included at the end. Specific topics relating to bad-news messages focus on the need for a right attitude, suggest plans for bad-news messages, and include various examples of unfavorable replies and unsolicited negative messages.

THE RIGHT ATTITUDE

In negative messages, your tone will help determine your effectiveness.

Everything you learned in preceding chapters about the communication process, consideration, and courtesy toward your reader or listener applies to bad-news messages. In negative messages, it is important that your *tone* be appropriate. Because the right attitude will improve the tone and thus the effectiveness of your message, keep the following suggestions in mind when you write bad-news letters and memos:

1. Put yourself in the reader's place. Your goal is to convince your reader that your decision, although contrary to his or her request, is fair, necessary, reasonable, and possibly even to his or her advantage in the long run.

2. Avoid using company rules or policy with no further explanation, as in such statements as "It is against company policy to do as you have asked." Include, if possible, the *customer-benefits and reasons* that are behind your rules and policies.

3. Assume that the customer wants to do the right thing, even though she or he may be mistaken. The following expressions show confidence in the reader:

   ```
   You have every right to expect high quality in
   . . .
   You are probably wondering how you can . . .
   You understand that . . .
   ```

4. Single people out when you praise them; put them in a group when you criticize. Mention mistakes by using impersonal constructions.

   Single out: `You have made an astute choice, Ms. Edwards.`

As a group: People sometimes misinterpret the terms of the warranty.

Impersonal: Some of these figures need to be rechecked.

5. Be courteous and shield the reader's pride.

Tactless: If you had read the instructions clearly stated on the label, you would have known not to put the garment in hot water.

Tactful: Water will not typically damage the garment. However, hot water will discolor it, as is stated on the label.

6. Talk with, not down to, the reader.

Condescending: We are willing to look into this matter for you.

Agreeable: Thank you for taking the time to tell us about . . . We always appreciate . . .

All the above suggestions apply equally to dealings with international clients. Be especially watchful for words that accuse, point out errors, condemn actions. Chinese businesspeople, and for that matter, many cultures in Asia, will sense a loss of face. An overt condemnation early in a communication will produce resistance to your explanation. Choose your words carefully, and apply the above six suggestions with great care.

PLANS FOR BAD-NEWS MESSAGES

Every bad-news message has an underlying objective: to present the unpleasant facts in such a way that the reader will consider you fair and reasonable and, preferably, remain a friend of the organization you represent. Your choice of message plan is influenced by the circumstances—your purpose, the reader's probable reaction, your relationship to the reader, and the facts in each case. You have two organizational choices: the indirect or the direct.

Indirect Plan

Suppose you have been waiting for a reply to your request for something you want from a business firm—a refund or a loan important to you. How would you react if the reply began with a negative statement similar to these:

Most often, you will use an indirect organizational approach for bad-news messages.

- We regret [we are sorry, wish to state] that we are unable to refund your money on the merchandise you ordered from Scandinavian Outlets, LTD.
- Your application for a loan [refund] has been denied [refused, rejected].

Most people will feel more receptive toward your company—and you—if your reply opens with some kind of agreeable statement. Then insert an explanation followed by the negative news, additional explanations, and a courteous close. Some letters begin with agreeable news, are followed by the negative news, and end with suggestions for the future. Here we consider the first structure.

1. Buffer
2. Explanation and analysis of circumstances
3. Decision, implied or expressed, with resale and/or helpful suggestions
4. Friendly, positive close

- We appreciate your letter telling us about your problems with the merchandise we shipped you six months ago.
- Thank you for giving us the opportunity to consider your loan application for financing your proposed home purchase.

People appreciate hearing some explanation before the bad-news decision, especially if it seriously affects them. A good rule to consider is "Give good news quickly, but take more time with the bad." Thus, while the good-news message often follows the direct approach, the bad-news message usually follows the indirect approach. The bad-news, indirect plan has the following suggested organizational structure:

1. Buffer

Buffers should be neutral in tone; avoid misleading the reader into thinking the news is good.

If possible, begin your message with reader-interest information. Your buffer should be pleasant, relevant, honest, and neutral in tone. Avoid statements that might mislead the reader into thinking you are granting the request; they merely set the reader up for a letdown. Apologies are unwarranted if your firm is not at fault.

The following are ways to begin a bad-news letter:

a. *Agreement.* Agree with your reader on something, if possible (perhaps business conditions, costs, or any other pertinent item).

b. *Appreciation.* Thank the reader (for a check, information, application, request, inquiry, cooperation, or whatever applies).

c. *Assurance.* Assure the reader of your careful consideration and honest explanation of all available facts about the problem.

d. *Compliment.* Try to compliment the reader on something good about his or her past record or request (sincerity, careful listing of facts, or other).

e. *Cooperation.* Show a sincere desire to be as helpful as possible.

f. *Good news.* If you can grant any part of a request, and you think your reader will be pleased, begin with that good news.

g. *Neutral courtesy.* Keep your opening paragraph noncommittal. For instance, if you must announce a price increase or service decrease, use a neutral word such as "change."

h. *Understanding.* Show you understand or sympathize with the reader's problem.

2. Explanation and Analysis

Explanations are often crucial to the effectiveness of a negative message.

Include honest, convincing reasons why the matter must be handled differently from the way the reader wants it. If the matter is routine or obvious (for example, a clerical error), an explanation is unnecessary. We stated earlier that the explanation can be placed *before* the decision, a usual position. You can also place that explanation *after* the negative news. Regardless, remember the following suggestions:

a. Try to convince the reader you are acting in his or her best interests in the long run or according to a policy that is enforced equally for all. Avoid the insincere: "Much as I would like to . . . however. . . ." Also avoid reasons that suggest benefit only to your firm.

b. Explain courteously all relevant facts behind your decision. Mention first the favorable factors, then the less favorable ones.

c. Show that the request has been carefully considered for the reader's benefit as well as your company's.

3. Decision, Implied, or Expressed, with Resale and/or Helpful Suggestions

To make the decision clear, positive, and concise, you have these alternatives:

a. If the reasons are so clear that your reader will conclude you *must* refuse the request, you can omit negatives entirely and make the bad-news decision clear by implication. For example, if you are already scheduled as a luncheon speaker in Sydney on May 6, you do not need to say "Thus, I can't attend your luncheon in Brussels that day."

b. If an implied decision might be misunderstood, express your decision clearly near the end of the explanation. Be careful not to mislead or otherwise cause uncertainty regarding your decision. The best place for a negative decision is in the middle of a paragraph, and never in a paragraph by itself. Avoid "must refuse," "cannot grant," and similar negatives.

c. If you can, offer a constructive suggestion, counterproposal, compromise, or alternative course of action. By emphasizing what *can* be done, you may clearly imply what *cannot* be done without actually using negative language.

d. If desirable, resell the reader on your company's services or policies.

4. Friendly, Positive Close

Endings should be positive, with reader-friendly requests, assurances, and reader benefits.

End on a positive note, with one or more of the following ideas:

a. Offer assurances that you appreciate the reader as a customer (or as an interested inquirer and possible future customer).

b. Invite future patronage, cooperation, suggestions, or compliance with the decision. Include mild, no-pressure sales promotional material if you think the reader would respond favorably.

c. Make clear whatever action is required, when to do it, and how to do it easily if you need the reader's approval or if the reader must take action.

d. Express continued interest, service, and reader benefit, or sincere wishes for the reader's success with alternatives. Do not repeat the bad news. Avoid such statements as "I trust our decision is satisfactory" and "Let us know if you have any further problems."

Direct Plan

Although you can use the indirect bad-news plan for most unfavorable messages, certain situations may warrant the direct approach. Your choice depends on the

Communication Probe

The use of an explanation in a bad-news message in order to maintain goodwill has been addressed in sociolinguistic studies. Much of this research has considered the ways in which people reduce the social threat common in bad news by avoiding personal responsibility and by using face-saving techniques. In a 1990 article by Campbell concerning bad-news messages and speech act theory, five categories of strategies for refusing requests were presented:

1. Deny that an item requested exists.
2. Deny that you are the right person to whom to address the request.
3. Deny that the requested act is a future act.
4. Cite reasons for your inability to grant the request.
5. Cite reasons that the request is not beneficial to the person making the request.

A sixth strategy discussed by Campbell is to cite reasons for your unwillingness (as opposed to your inability) to grant the request. All these strategies attempt to create goodwill and protect the reader's pride. Their effectiveness, however, depends on the reader's perception of them as merely "politeness" tactics.

Campbell, K. S. (1990, Fall). Explanations in negative messages: More insights from speech act theory. *Journal of Business Communication*, 27(4), 357–375.

A direct approach can be used when the message is routine, when the reader is known for preferring directness, or when the message is urgent.

context and on the particular circumstances. The direct approach may be effective if you have one of the following:

- A routine matter on which the reader is likely not to be seriously disappointed or emotionally involved, especially a message between employees of two business firms or within the same firm
- A reader who is known to prefer reading the bad news in the first paragraph
- An urgent message that should be called to the reader's attention forcefully, as in the late stages of a collection procedure

If you use the direct approach, the pattern is the same as the direct good-news plan, except that the opening contains bad instead of good news.

1. Bad-news decision (with or without a brief buffer)
2. Explanation
3. Appropriate, courteous ending

Most examples of bad-news replies and unsolicited messages in this chapter are organized by the *indirect* approach, referred to simply as the bad-news plan. For examples of the messages organized according to the direct approach, look for the words *direct plan* in the title.

Communication Probe

One type of communication message that often concerns bad news is the performance appraisal. These appraisals take both oral and written forms and are used in many companies for the purpose of improving employee performance and increasing productivity. Although companies often provide forms for the written portion of their appraisals, they are not easy to write, and the difficulties have increased over time. The reasons for the problems have to do with attitude and personality evaluation, areas in which a form is little help in describing performance.

The issues involved in writing or orally giving a negative performance evaluation are the same as other bad-news communication issues: how to give the bad news while motivating the worker to improve. In addition, however, the forms used for both written and oral appraisals can impede the process and make the job more difficult. Since performance appraisals are so common, they are worthy of further research to study the unique problems of expressing negative performance aspects in a formal and somewhat artificial format.

Ewald, H. R., & McCallum, V. (1989, September). The performance appraisal: A crucial business process and product. *Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication, 52*(3), 39–47.

NEGATIVE REPLIES TO REQUESTS

This section focuses on negative replies to requests for information about non-sales-related subjects, adjustments, credit, orders, and favors.

Answering Non-Sales-Related Inquiries When the Information Is Undesirable

Honesty, tactfulness, and caution are necessary when responding to a request for a recommendation for a person about whom you have unfavorable information.

Occasionally you may have to write bad-news answers to inquiries about matters not relating to sales. In most cases, your reply may follow the bad-news approach. In some cases, the direct plan or another alternative may be desirable.

When you receive a request for a recommendation regarding a person about whom you have only unfavorable information, you have these alternatives:

1. Call the inquirer on the telephone and discuss the matter. Be careful that what you say is not slanderous.
2. Write a brief refusal note similar to the following:
   On the basis of my experience with Janice Bailey, I am sorry that I do not have sufficient information to recommend her for the position for which you are considering her.
3. Write an honest, frank, confidential, legally appropriate letter using the bad-news plan. Because of libel laws, it is imperative to be cautious and scrupulously accurate. (See also the comments regarding recommendations in Chapter 11, Short Reports, and in the discussion of legal aspects in Appendix C.)

The best overall policy is to be honest, tactful, and aware of your fourfold responsibility—to the applicant, to the addressee, to yourself, and to civil rights laws. Omit any statements you cannot verify in a court of law!

When you are writing to someone in your own organization about a routine matter with which the reader is not emotionally involved, or when you know your reader likes the bad news up front, the *direct* approach is appropriate, as in the following example.

MESSAGE 1 *Memo in direct-plan format for bad news about facilities availability.*

TO: Bill Holmes
FROM: Cynthia Warren
SUBJECT: Need for Alternate Conference Room

Bad news

Today Joe Garbani from the Facilities Department told me that the Conrad Room, which we scheduled for the conference we're hosting next month, will be under construction during the period in question.

Details

As an alternate, Joe suggested using the Mayfair Room, which is bigger and more luxurious than the Conrad. Its less con-

venient location can be handled with clear directional signs.

Action request

If you approve, I'll go ahead and make arrangements. Joe needs to know by next week if we want the Mayfair. Could you give me a call by Wednesday afternoon?

If you write for a nonprofit organization that receives many requests for free information, you may, to cut correspondence costs, devise a bad-news form letter listing the most recurring negative facts. The following letter has a "Dear reader" salutation.

MESSAGE 2 *Form letter to handle a nonprofit organization's multiple inquiries for which many answers may be bad news.*

Buffer: Thanks and reader benefit

Thank you for your recent inquiry. In the interest of replying promptly to the hundreds of requests we receive-and for economy-your request and all others are answered by this form letter.

Facts: Implied decisions

1. The item or information you requested is
   ____ a. Enclosed.
   ____ b. Out of print. Copies are in many libraries.
   ____ c. Not yet available; will be sent later.
2. ____ Your request will be filled as soon as our supply is replenished.
3. ____ The free supply of this report is exhausted. Copies may be purchased from [*name and address*] for _____.

Suggestions for future action

If the check mark for your request is 1.c. or 2, you can depend on us to send the promised material as soon as possible. If your request has other check marks, we wish you success in finding the desired items elsewhere.

[*Signature*]
[*Name and title of writer*]

Refusing Adjustments on Claims and Complaints

When you refuse a request for adjustment, helpful material to include—besides your buffer and explanation—is resale, constructive suggestions, and sales promotion where appropriate.

The following discussion focuses on two kinds of unwarranted customer claims for which you may have to write a refusal: (1) the customer is at fault regarding a product and (2) the customer is mistaken in a complaint about an account or a service.

The Customer Is at Fault Regarding a Product

When the customer is at fault, special tact must be used in rejecting requests.

Often customers who claim free replacement or repair of a malfunctioning product are at fault because they violated instructions for using it. Or a customer might return as "new" an article that cannot be resold because of something the customer did wrong. The next two examples illustrate satisfactory adjustment refusals in such cases.

Misuse of a Product. Notice that in Message 3 the writer calls attention to the user's mistake indirectly and shields the reader's pride. The letter does not say "You violated the instructions" or "You obviously didn't take care of the product." Instead the message includes a logical explanation, an implied but clear refusal, and a constructive suggestion.

MESSAGE 3 *Letter from the customer service manager of Quick Cut Lawn Mower Company refusing to replace free a rusted, malfunctioning lawn mower.*

Buffer: Agreement, appreciation	When you buy a Quick Cut lawn mower, you are right to expect high quality. We appreciate your returning the lawn mower for our inspection so that we can meet our goal-satisfying your needs with quality products.
Resale; assurance of guarantee	Each of the thousands of Quick Cut lawn mowers we sell is guaranteed to give you the service for which it was designed. We provide an instruction booklet with each mower to simplify its use and care.
Reason for breakdown **Implied refusal**	As stated in the instruction booklet, the lawn mower you bought must be stored in a dry place while not in use. Our service department inspected the mower and discovered rust on the motor, which would prevent the mower from running properly, and rust on all the exterior parts. The rust is caused by exposure to the weather over long periods of time. Storing your mower in a dry place, such as a garage or tool shed, will prevent these problems from occurring in the future.
Constructive suggestion	Our repair shop will be happy to remove the rust from your mower and put it in working order. This will cost you approximately $90. If you prefer, you may take the mower to any Quick Cut lawn mower dealer for the repairs. A list of dealers in your area is described in the new instruction booklet we have enclosed.
Easy action; reader benefit	After you have decided which alternative best meets your needs, fill out the en-

closed card and check whether you want our shop to repair your mower and return it or whether you want us to return it to you for your own repairs. Either way, you can have many years of dependable service from your Quick Cut lawn mower.

Unsalability of Return Product. Some products, such as prescription drugs and undergarments, cannot—because of state or national statutes—be accepted for return after they have left the store. In such cases the explanation is easy. However, sometimes a customer may try to return a damaged product or one owned for so long that the store can no longer resell it. In this case, a tactful, detailed letter such as Message 4 may be necessary.

MESSAGE 4 *Letter from the manager of a Hong Kong fabric distributor refusing to accept a returned bolt of silk.*

Buffer: Assurance; thanks

To please our customers is the foremost aim of the Hong Kong Fabric Distributing Company, LTD. Thank you for writing us explaining your wishes about the bolt of silk fabric you purchased two years ago.

Reader benefit; facts about return policy

We want you and all our customers to enjoy the confidence of knowing that any purchase from us is for fabric of outstanding quality and that it is clean, fresh, and new. Bolts of fabric may be returned any time within six months of purchase provided it is in clean, resalable condition.

Findings in this case

To maintain the high standard on the goods we sell, we carefully check returned fabric before it is placed for sale. Our examination of the silk you mailed to us revealed large discolored spots on some sections and mold on others, indicating storage in a damp place.

Implied decision

Because cleaning would render the silk "used" to anyone wishing to purchase it, the bolt of silk is unacceptable for resale.

Helpful suggestion

Our staff can arrange to have your fabric cleaned for a charge, or if you prefer, we will return it to you for your own cleaning arrangements. Although there is no guarantee that spots of this kind can be removed completely, we will do everything possible to help you feel pleased with your fabric.

Easy action

Please check and mail your preference on the enclosed card. Your fabric is an es-

pecially beautiful design, and it should, once cleaned, make a lovely garment or other item.

The Customer Is Mistaken About an Account or a Service

In addition to refusing adjustments on return merchandise, you may also have bad news for customers who make erroneous claims resulting from a variety of intangible grievances. Among them are unwarranted claims about their account balances and unjustified gripes about various aspects of your firm's service. Many firms now handle most of these complaints by telephone whenever possible.

When claims are unjustified, the explanation for the misunderstanding becomes important in order to maintain reader goodwill.

Unwarranted Claims About Account Balances. When customers think you have made an error and you find your records are correct, you must give the customers the bad news that they owe more than they claim. You need to assure them that you have carefully rechecked their records and want to cooperate fully. Be sure to explain each additional charge clearly because your readers may have forgotten that a purchase or late charges were added or that some past checks were returned by the bank for various reasons. If the matter is too complicated for a phone explanation, a letter will be more helpful, with a tabulation of figures or a photostatic copy of the record.

Unjustified Gripes About Company Services. Careful and tactful explanation is necessary to establish your company's accuracy and to resell the reader on its usually high-quality service. For instance, the printer who is wrongly accused of misspelling a name on the customer's stationery may have to send a copy of the customer's original handwritten order showing the identical spelling. Professional cleaners may reduce customer complaints by sending a printed note such as the following, with a cleaned garment or rug that has unremovable stains:

> We've tried and tried, but find that the stains on this [*item name*] cannot be removed without possible injury to the color or fabric. This has been called to your attention so that you will know that it has not been overlooked.

If a customer does complain, a detailed oral or written explanation may have to include specific facts about the extra care and time the experienced workers skilled in modern spot-removal processes took. Likewise, similar procedures are desirable in other types of business to help answer complaints about their services. The message should convince the customer that the firm has earned the fee and must charge for an honest job.

Refusing Credit

Even when refusing a credit application, you should try to keep the reader's goodwill and, perhaps, continued business on a cash basis. A person's credit reputation is important. Thus, a credit manager has responsibilities to make sound, informed decisions concerning credit.

Most refusals use the bad-news organizational plan.

To avoid risk of a lawsuit and unfavorable publicity, a credit manager must be careful about what he or she writes and how reasons are expressed. Refusals

Communication Probe

Studies in giving negative feedback suggest that it is most effective when the grammatical first person or third person is used rather than the second person. An overuse of the pronoun "you" when the reader is at fault or is receiving bad news adds a confrontational tone to the message. Research also suggests that neutral language helps with a reader's acceptance of the message. The tone of a message is very easily influenced by the number of negative words and the number of formal, Latinate words. That's why word choice and sentence construction are powerful tools in designing messages and should be considered carefully when sending bad-news messages.

Brinko, K. T. (1993, Sept./Oct.). The practice of giving feedback to improve teaching. *Journal of Higher Education, 64*(5), 574–593; Hoffman, R., & Kocar, M. (1989, Sept.). Introducing objectivity in evaluating writing assignments. *Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication, 52*(3), 25–26.

of both retail and mercantile credit are usually organized by the bad-news plan, although their contents differ. Some credit departments use the telephone for all refusals. If you work in such a department, you will find you can apply many writing principles in this chapter to your oral refusals.

Retail Credit Refusals

For various reasons, approving credit for some customers may be undesirable. Also, sometimes a customer who currently has credit must be told that further credit purchases will be stopped until the credit balance is reduced or paid in full. Other decisions may involve people new to your city, those involved in divorce actions, young people who have not yet established a credit record, and others.

Opening Paragraph. The refusal usually begins with a buffer that refers to the firm's appreciation or careful consideration of the reader's request for credit or to his or her interest in the store, or to both.

Explanation. Explanations in retail credit refusals vary considerably; here are four ways of handling the reasons for refusal:

1. Reason is omitted entirely (see Example 1).
2. "Insufficient information" is the only reason given (see Example 2).

EXAMPLE 1 *No stated reason. An unhelpful refusal.*

Decision `After careful consideration, we find that at this time it would be better for you to continue your purchases from us on a cash basis.`

EXAMPLE 2 *Insufficient information. A popular retail credit refusal method.*

Explanation

As you know, the usual custom before opening a new account is to get information that will serve as a basis for credit. Such information as we have thus far obtained is insufficient for us to pass favorably on your request at this time. If you feel there are other details that would favorably affect your credit, you are welcome to call on us so that we can consider all the facts.

3. Factors considered in evaluating credit applications are stated without indicating specifically which apply to the reader (see Letter 1).
4. Specific reasons are stated (see Letter 2).

LETTER 1 *List of factors usually considered. A retail credit refusal inviting reapplication and a layaway plan.*

Buffers: Thanks

Thank you, [*reader's name*], for your recent inquiry regarding the status of your credit application.

Explanation: List of factors considered

A number of factors are taken into consideration when reviewing an application. Length of time at one residence and employment are of vital importance-as well as income, assets, and the payment record of current and past obligations.

Implied decision; assurance; invitation

You are assured that all the above available information has been carefully analyzed in your case. Your circumstances may improve in the future, at which time we would be pleased to reconsider your request for credit.

Reader-benefit invitation to purchase; no mention of cash

In the meantime, we invite you to save on your clothing purchases at Forman's regular everyday low prices and frequent sales. Also, of course, you're welcome to use our easy layaway plan for bigger purchases.

LETTER 2 *Specific reasons: inadequate income. Personal-type loan refusal.*

Buffer: Compliment; favorable points

You are to be complimented on your desire to provide the best possible housing for your family. Also, both your loan application and your credit report indicate that you have maintained a steady employment record. This too is commendable.

Explanation: Reasoning from general to specific

```
In mortgage lending, however, extensive
studies have revaled that a certain rela-
tionship between a person's income, fixed
monthly expense, and loan amount should
exist to make a loan advisable.  Our max-
imum loan is 2 1/2 times the annual in-
come, or payments may not exceed 20 per-
cent of the monthly income.  Since your
income at present meets neither of these
requirements, you can understand why we
feel that an additional financial burden
will not serve your best interests.
```

Suggestion

```
If you would like to stop by my office, I
will be happy to go over with you the
minimum requirements for a small loan.
This discussion might help you in setting
and planning for your desired goal for
home ownership.  As time goes on and your
income increases, you will be able to im-
prove your financial position to the
point where we can help you buy a new and
larger home.
```

Future help

```
Feel welcome to come in any day between 9
and 5.  We sincerely want to help you
reach your desired goal.
```

At times, your explanation should not include specific reasons, especially if the reasons suggest that your reader has undesirable characteristics.

The first three approaches can be easily adapted by credit departments that find it necessary to use form letters because of a large number of applications (often over a wide geographic area). Because of similar names among the thousands of individual requests, mix-ups and errors do occur. Thus credit managers for firms that handle numerous requests find it safer to omit specific reasons, especially those that pertain to undesirable character or poor pay habits. From the customer's standpoint, the refusal that omits the reason entirely is the least helpful. The "insufficient information" reason and the list of general reasons are considered by some customers to be unclear or insincere. Nevertheless, methods 2 and 3 are usually acceptable under certain circumstances, provided the constructive suggestion is diplomatic and helpful.

The fourth method of refusing credit—stating specific reasons—is desirable when the following conditions exist:

- The situation requires a personalized, typed reply (as in a request for a large loan).
- The reason is not poor (dishonest, unreliable) personal character.
- The desired relationship between the credit department and the applicant is somewhat personal.
- The applicant cannot come for a personal interview and is likely to be offended with anything but an individual, helpful letter.

Such letters are usually longer and harder to write than the first three types. When they are tactful and accurate, however, they are highly appreciated by the recipient because they indicate what must be done to earn (or restore) a good credit standing.

Some large firms use printed forms with courteous opening paragraphs and then a list of several (perhaps 20) reasons for credit refusals. In front of each reason is a small square with checks in the squares that are applicable to the reader. These forms may also state the applicant's rights according to law.

Try to use positive language when stating an unfavorable decision.

Decision, Resale, Suggestions. When stating your decision, avoid such negatives as "did not approve," "unfavorable," "does not meet," "must decline." Instead of stressing what is wrong, suggest whenever possible how the situation can be improved. You can often combine resale and constructive alternatives with the decision or ending paragraph. Depending on the circumstances, the applicant may be invited to take one or more of these steps:

1. Come to an office to discuss the case if the applicant has questions or thinks an error has been made
2. Apply again later when conditions have improved
3. Contact another lender or credit agency that you name
4. Examine the record at the credit bureau and write any needed corrections
5. Use the layaway plan or another suitable credit plan
6. Continue buying from the company on cash or c.o.d. basis

Ending Paragraph. The suggested action ties in with one of the above suggestions and, if possible, includes a reader benefit. Compare examples 1 and 2 above with the personal Letter 2. (Example 1 suggests buying on a cash basis. Because some customers consider this suggestion obvious, or even offensive, you can avoid referring to cash by wording the last paragraph in a way similar to that in Letter 1.)

Mercantile Credit Refusals

Wholesale or mercantile credit is credit extended by one business firm to another. The preferred organizational pattern for these credit refusals is the bad-news plan.

For the buffer, you have choices similar to those used in retail refusals—appreciation and assurance of careful consideration.

The most noticeable difference between retail and mercantile credit refusals is that the latter are generally more candid regarding the reasons for refusal and are individually word-processed. The decision is based on the firm's financial statement plus other credit ratings. These ratings may be by Dunn and Bradstreet, special rating agencies, creditors, and/or sales agencies of the wholesaler or manufacturer considering the applicant. As with retail credit, the emphasis should be on what is positive rather than on what is wrong now.

A mercantile credit refusal may include one or more reader-benefit suggestions, especially for a reader who is inexperienced in business.

Communication Probe

Many of the concepts covered in books regarding bad-news messages contradict the accepted guidelines for business and managerial writing. Those guidelines, or "rules," state that you should be direct, use simple language, and write short sentences. A bad-news message, however, often comes loaded with context, in which your relationship with the reader, your reader's opinions, and your own position are extremely important. In many of these bad-news situations, you must break the rules of directness and brevity and choose language that cushions your message and softens your tone. You must be tactful without being manipulative, and you must tell the truth. As in all effective messages, a bad-news message must be appropriately reader-oriented.

Fahner, H. (1990, October). The 10 commandments of memo writing. *Sales & Marketing Management*, 85–87; Fielden, J. (1989, April). Clear writing is not enough. *Management Review*, 49–52.

1. Reduction of apparently excessively high inventory by special means
2. Ways to build up customer's volume of sales (and working capital, if pertinent); perhaps offering the assistance of your firm's sales representative
3. Advantages of modest buying, local financing, and cash discounts
4. Cash purchases—smaller, more frequent orders
5. Cash on delivery or cash with orders earning discount privilege
6. Review of the applicant's credit situation at a future time

One good test for any letter is what your reaction would be if *you* received it. Would you feel offended if you were the retailer? Would you buy from the wholesaler? Does the writer of the refusal seem sincere and interested in helping you?

Acknowledging Orders You Cannot Fill Now or at All

If you have good news, state that first before communicating your bad news.

Whenever you get an order that you cannot fill immediately or in the way the customer expects, your acknowledgment will be at least temporarily bad news. This section discusses bad-news acknowledgments regarding incomplete or vague orders, back orders, and substitution orders.

Incomplete or Vague Orders

If a customer omits necessary information on an order, you usually cannot process it. Telephoning or writing to the customer is always better than risking errors and annoyance.

If the order lists some items that you are able to send now, mention them first. If not, begin with a buffer—usually short resale on the product for which the order is incomplete, appreciation for the order, and if a first order from a customer, a welcome. Then, before you request the missing information or payment, state a reader-benefit reason—that you want to be sure to send exactly what the customer wants. Avoid such words as "you forgot" or "you failed to." Include explanatory facts that the customer needs to complete the order, such as sizes or color choice available. If a letter (instead of a phone call) is necessary, include pictures, catalog numbers, sketches, swatches, and other helpful items when appropriate. Make customer action easy, and assure prompt shipment, if possible.

Orders for Out-of-Stock Items to Be Back-Ordered

If your stock of an ordered item is temporarily depleted and you expect a new shipment within a reasonable time (1 or 2 weeks), you can usually back-order and assume the customer would rather wait than cancel the order.

As with the incomplete-order acknowledgment, your main goal in the back-order letter is to keep the customer sold on your product and to serve him or her well. Because of the necessary delay, your message should be organized by the bad-news plan.

Your buffer can be resale on the ordered item (to reinforce the customer's confidence in her or his choice) and appreciation.

Your explanation should focus on the positive aspects of the date the goods will reach the customer. Omit such negatives as "cannot send," "out of stock," "exhausted," "won't have any . . . until." If possible, include a reason for your being out of the item so the customer will not think your firm is inefficient. If such reasons pertain to popularity or exceptional demand, this strengthens your resale and the customer's desire for the item. In your action-getting close, positive suggestion is useful. The best way for the customer to show approval of the back order is to take no action. Thus, back-order acknowledgments often include the positive.

Communication Probe

The language used by an organization communicates an identity that is not always positive. All types of company language, from the name of the company and its products to the wording of its most mundane forms, reflect the attitudes and style of the company's management and those who help create its written communications. A letter to a client or customer reveals much about the attitudes of the company. If you look at one message from a company, you will see that it suggests values in the way it handles tone, sentence constructions, and word choices. All processed messages should ideally show what the organization wants to communicate about itself regarding its values and attitudes.

Morris, K. (1991, Winter). Corporate language: Creating a verbal identity. *Design Management Journal*, 37–41.

Shipment will be made as soon as we receive the new supplies, unless you instruct us to the contrary.

If the wait may be unreasonably long, ask the customer to let you know (perhaps by an easy-action reply card) whether your shipping on the later date is acceptable. Your emphasis whenever possible should be on acceptance, not cancellation. Sometimes a bit of sales promotion material on seasonal or related goods is appropriate, if it is clearly for the reader's benefit.

A short message such as Letter 3 is sufficient for a temporarily out-of-stock item.

LETTER 3 *Acknowledging a customer's order on an item to be back-ordered.*

Buffer	Thank you for your order of the Special Issue of the Gutierrez guitar. At $365, it is an exceptional value.
Resale: Explanation	The demand for this deluxe version of the famous Gutierrez guitar has far exceeded our most optimistic expectations. We have reordered twice from the manufacturer in Barcelona, Spain. The latest shipment will be delivered within 10 days and will be sent out to you immediately.
Decision: Delivery date; reader benefit	You should receive your Gutierrez guitar before May 1 and will be able to enjoy its fine workmanship and beautiful sound. Enclosed for your interest is a catalog of guitar-related products should you ever need any additional items.

Orders for Out-of Stock Items for Which You Suggest a Substitute

When you get an order for a certain model or brand that you cannot supply soon enough by back order or that has been discontinued, you can often suggest a substitute by telephone.

Usually it is safer to ask permission to substitute before you ship, as in Letter 4, especially if the customer must pay a higher price for the newer line. (Unfortunate shippers who have sent large substitute shipments without permission have sometimes had to pay express charges both ways for rejected merchandise returned by a displeased customer.)

LETTER 4 *Suggesting a substitute in place of an ordered, discontinued item.*

Buffer: Brand resale; thanks	Many thanks for your order on April 30 for a Koolco window air conditioner. You can be sure that your decision to buy a Koolco was a decision to buy the best in the industry.

Explanation for new model (substitute)

Last year the Koolco engineers designed a new model window air conditioner. This latest model has several improvements and new features our customers have been asking for. For this reason, we now stock the new model exclusively. Though it's possible that Keller Air Conditioning and Heating may still have the model you ordered, we believe you will want our newest model after you check these improved features:

Reader benefit

- Voice-activated temperature control, allowing you to change the temperature without getting up from your desk or chair
- Quieter motor with heavy-duty soundproofing around the cabinet
- Ability to cool either outside or inside air
- New, smaller size to allow more window space

Easy action

For all these advantages, the new model is inexpensively priced at only $195 installed. To give me your approval for shipment, just call me at (212) 555-4567 any weekday between 8 and 5. I'll have your new Koolco air conditioner on its way to you the same day.

Reader benefit

You may also take advantage of our new no-payments-for-30-days policy. You'll be happy you bought the new Koolco air conditioner.

Notice that the buffer begins with appreciation and general resale information, emphasizing the strongest point of reader appeal that the two products have in common—the Koolco brand.

The explanation and bad-news decision stress what the firm *does* have instead of what it does not carry any longer. After this positive news is announced, the new substitute is introduced with a mention of its merits. Only then is the bad news communicated that the ordered item is unavailable. One good way to do this is to state that you now stock the substitute exclusively (if true), but do not use the word *substitute* because of its negative connotation. If the substitute is a different brand instead of merely another model of the same brand, do not mention the ordered item by brand name more than once. If you mention where the ordered item can be obtained, subordinate that statement in a dependent clause, as in Letter 4. If the price of the substitute is higher, be sure to state adequate selling points to justify the difference. If your substitute is lower in quality but an excellent value because of price or other reasons, stress these benefits.

The ending of the letter should ask for authorization to send the substitute or explain why you have already sent it. Make clear to the reader that the item

comes on trial and subject to the receiver's approval. Sometimes substitution is also made in rush orders for similar, same-price, inexpensive items or when the company absorbs the price difference.

Declining Invitations and Requests for Favors

The bad-news plan is usually the most appropriate for declining invitations and requests for favors.

Customers, noncustomers, and employees may extend invitations or request various privileges or favors that you may have to refuse. Some of these requests are business-related; others are nonbusiness and personal.

Among the numerous business-related favors that customers ask are changing requirements or payment due dates, borrowing your company's equipment or premises, seeing your firm's confidential material, getting special reduced rates, or skipping several payments on a contract. Requests concerning nonbusiness activities may involve donations of your time, money, property, or other assistance.

The bad-news plan is usually the most appropriate in many of these refusals. As always, good judgment is necessary in choosing your buffer, your explanation, helpful suggestions, and friendly close. Message 5 is an example of such a letter refusing a request to speak at a conference.

MESSAGE 5 *Letter: A refusal to speak at a conference.*

Buffer: Appreciation

The International Marketing Association has a great deal to offer business people, and I have enjoyed the annual conference for several years. I appreciate very much your invitation to be the keynote speaker for this year's conference in Helsinki on June 5.

Reason

Implied refusal

The date of the conference is, unfortunately, during a two-week period when I will be in Frankfurt for meetings with my firm's distributors. I did make an effort to reschedule these meetings, but I was unable to do so. I regret not being able to address this important forum and having to miss the conference itself.

Suggestion

May I suggest that you contact Eleanor Forman, our newly elected vice-present in charge of brand-name marketing for Europe? She is eager to become more involved in the IMA and has interesting experiences related to this year's conference theme, "Selling the American Name Abroad." I am enclosing her address and phone number in case you would like to contact her.

Cordial wishes

You have my best wishes for getting the right person. The conference plans look terrific.

Bad news is often communicated in the direct organizational plan whenever the matter is routine between departments of the same firm. The following memo deals with bad news directly:

MESSAGE 6 *Memo—Direct plan: Refusal of a requested specification change in an airplane factory.*

TO: J.R. Lowry DATE: April 30, 199-
FROM: J.S. Thompson
SUBJECT: Food and Beverage Elevator
REFERENCE: RPD-5244-12, dated 2-15 [*year*]

Refusal

As shown on page 5 of the specifications, paneling for elevator walls remains a valid requirement. Thus the referenced request to use paint instead of vinyl paneling is unacceptable.

Explanation

Because of the particular uses for this elevator and the expected altitudes for flights, it is necessary that all walls have the extra protection of the exact vinyl as in the specifications, instead of mere coats of paint.

Request

Will you please, therefore, see that the paneling requirement is met, according to specifications.

Negative replies to requests in situations such as responding to sales inquiries, claims and adjustments, credit requests, orders you cannot fill, or to invitations or favors can effectively use either the direct or the indirect approach. You should always remember to keep the needs of your reader in mind and try to show reader benefits, even when your message is unfavorable.

UNFAVORABLE UNSOLICITED MESSAGES

If the bad news is routine, you may choose to use the direct organizational plan; however, if your readers will be disappointed or angered by the news, use the indirect plan.

You may sometimes have to send bad-news messages that are not in response to inquiries. This section illustrates unfavorable announcements about prices and services, rules and procedures, plus miscellaneous bad news. You are generally wise to use the bad-news plan whenever your readers will be disappointed or angered by your message. However, when you write to employees or other business associates on routine matters, you may use the direct plan.

Announcing Bad News About Prices or Services

When your firm finds it necessary to increase prices or cut services to customers, a buffer opening followed by reasons before stating the negative decision will help break the news gently, as in Message 1.

MESSAGE 1 *Letter from a wholesaler announcing limitations in services.*

Buffer: Neutral courtesy

In reviewing the past year's business and trying to plan for a future in which Appalachiacola Shrimp Brokers, Inc., can continue to give you good service, it has become evident that some modifications must be made.

Reasons

Expenses in the shrimp wholesale business have been constantly increasing without corresponding increases in profit margins. Rather than increase prices, the following changes will become effective on July 15 of this year:

(1) Free delivery will be continued only on orders of at least $350. Orders for a lesser amount will be sent by United Parcel Service, and shipping costs will be added to the invoice.

(2) Collect telephone calls will be accepted only in cases where we have been in error.

Fairness to customers; courteous invitation

A decision on these changes was made after careful analysis of our costs in relation to service. We feel sure you will agree that these changes are fair. If you have any suggestions as to how we may improve our product and service, please let us know.

In contrast to the buffer opening of Message 1 to customers, you can use bad-news, direct-approach openings similar to the following when you announce the same decisions to your employees:

> So that Appalachiacola Shrimp Brokers, Inc. can continue to give good service without a general increase in prices to our customers, the following restrictions in delivery and telephone services will become effective July 15 this year.

Even for employees, however, you should follow the bad-news plan when they are likely to be personally affected or seriously disappointed by your decision. Suppose, for instance, that your company management has decided to close the employee cafeteria food service mornings and evenings and keep it open only during noon hours. To partially offset this decrease and to provide for changing employee food preferences, the snack bar service will be increased. Message 2 illustrates a poor way to announce these changes to employees; Message 3 is a good way. Notice the difference in subject lines.

MESSAGE 2 *Memo—Direct plan: A poor, negative, incomplete bad-news announcement to employees about decreased cafeteria service.*

TO: All employees of XYZ
FROM: Camilla White, Food Services Director
SUBJECT: Closing of Cafeteria for Breakfasts and Suppers

Starting next Monday, March 15, there will be no more breakfasts or suppers served in the cafeteria.

This facility will hereafter be closed every morning and afternoon. Lunches will be served in the cafeteria only between 11 a.m. and 2 p.m.

However, to provide continuing service to our employees, the snack bar will be open from 8 a.m. to 5:45 p.m. and will offer a wider selection of food.

MESSAGE 3 *Memo—Indirect plan: An improved version of the preceding bad-news announcement to employees.*

TO: All employees of XYZ
FROM: Camilla White, Food Services Director
SUBJECT: Changes in Company Snack Bar and Cafeteria Services

Buffer: Reader benefit

To keep food prices at their present level, in spite of rising costs, and to meet your changing needs, the snack bar and cafeteria services will be modified starting Monday, March 15.

Reasons

Changes are necessary because during the past three years fewer employees have been eating breakfasts and suppers in the cafeteria, and the cost of operating it has steadily increased.

Employee benefits

So that you can continue to benefit from both low prices and good-quality food, we are altering the services and believe you'll like them.

Decision: Favorable changes first

Snack Bar Service—The snack bar will be expanded to offer a wider selection of food than ever before. From the semi-self-service counter and the vending machines you can choose:

Packaged cereals	Fruits, juices	Sandwiches
Doughnuts	Soft drinks	Hamburgers
Rolls	Ice cream	Salads
Coffee, tea, milk, hot chocolate	Pies, cake, candy	Soup
		Potato chips

Decision

Cafeteria Service-Each day a lunch special consisting of a hot main course, salad, dessert, and drink will be served, as before, for less than $5. The cafeteria will serve only lunches.

New Hours-Effective March 15:
Snack Bar-8 a.m. to 5:45 p.m.
Cafeteria-11 a.m. to 2:00 p.m.

Employee benefits

In addition, the cafeteria doors will remain open between 8 a.m. and 6 p.m. for those of you wishing a meeting place during work breaks or a place to enjoy food brought from home or the snack bar.

Future look: Invited action

You are invited to use these facilities whenever you can. They are available to you at no extra price on snacks or lunches. If you have any suggestions on the new cafeteria or snack bar services, please jot them on a slip of paper and drop them into the suggestion box at the cafeteria door.

Penalizing for Nonconformity to Rules or Procedures

Announcements about penalties for deviating from required procedures or disregarding previous notices often begin with the bad news. The direct plan should be used especially when the situation is urgent or when the writer wants the reader to be sure to read the main idea, as in Message 4, signed by the editor of a business magazine.

When the message is urgent or of great importance to the reader, use the direct plan.

MESSAGE 4 *Letter—Direct plan: Form letter announcement about a lapsed subscription.*

Main idea

This letter must be my final farewell since your subscription to [*name*] has been suspended.

Explanation

It has been almost half a year since your subscription to [*name*] lapsed. We've continued to mail you issues as a courtesy to a valued Founding Subscriber. But we can no longer continue this courtesy.

Invitation

Reader benefit

You are a valued subscriber. I invite you to return the enclosed renewal notice and continue our relationship. Don't miss out on the valuable information [*name*] brings you-helping you to run a more successful business and be more well-rounded as a professional.

Each issue of [*name*] is packed with useful information on legislative trends, envi-

ronmental ideas, community relations projects new marketing opportunities, and morale building ideas. With [*name*] you're part of something larger than yourself, something that can make a difference in the world. You're part of a vigorous and influential movement of people who are changing the way business does business.

Final request

Easy action

You are needed. To survive and thrive, [*name*] needs the support of our most valuable friends: our Founding Subscribers. Please say you'll stay. Send us the enclosed renewal notice today.

Conveying Other Bad News

You may have to write other bad news or unsolicited or solicited messages. As a rule, you can handle most of them well by the bad-news plan.

When you have made a mistake, it is often best to admit your error in the beginning of your message.

One exception to the usual rule for customer bad-news letters is when you must confess that you made a mistake that is not in the customer's favor. In such cases, it is often better to admit your error in the opening, as in the next example.

MESSAGE 5 *Letter—Direct plan: Announcement of an error in billing.*

Tactful lead to bad news

Giving accurate service to you and all our customers is always our goal. Therefore, we apologize for the mistake in billing on the floor tiles we shipped to you last week.

Details

The correct amount of the shipment of tile was $20 a box for the 10 boxes you ordered, or $200. We billed you for only 8 boxes, or $160. We overlooked the additional two boxes because they were shipped a day later than the other eight.

Request: Easy action; goodwill

May we ask you to send a check for the additional $40? Just slip it into the enclosed stamped envelope and mail it. You can be sure we'll do our best to see that you get accurate service in the future.

Letters of resignation should include a reason, appreciation for people you are leaving, and a cordial ending.

The letter of resignation is another bad-news announcement you may have to write. It should include your reason for resigning (ill health, better position, or whatever), appreciation and pleasant comments about people you are leaving, perhaps a statement of regret, definite effective date for the resignation, and a sincere, cordial ending. Whatever the position from which you are resigning and whatever the reasons, you must consider your readers and your relationship to them before you decide to organize by the direct or the indirect plan.

An opening for the indirect approach might begin like the following:

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During the past four years, I've greatly enjoyed
working with the many fine people of our organiza-
tion.
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If your readers are busy and you think they would prefer reading the main idea in the first paragraph, you may choose the direct plan. This letter might begin with a sentence like the following:

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With reluctance and regret, I must ask to be
released from my position as . . .
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Whatever your organizational plan, you should write a tactful, reader-focused message that is sincere and generates goodwill.

SUMMARY

Whenever you write bad-news messages, whether you are replying to a request or initiating an unsolicited message, you have two choices:

- Indirect organization format 1: Buffer, explanation, decision, positive close
- Indirect organization format 2: Buffer, short explanation, decision, longer explanation, positive close

Communication Probe

One study of annual letters to stockholders indicates that positive words occurred more frequently than negative words even when the financial news was bad. This phenomenon is called the "Pollyanna hypothesis," a universal tendency to state news positively more often than negatively. Another study on annual letters to stockholders confirmed that the news was presented positively even in bad financial years. However, choices in the subjects of sentences and in verb structures gave clues regarding the financial well-being of the company. In bad years, subjects were more often inanimate nominal groups, such as "operating results" and "fiscal 1988," whereas in good years, subjects were more often human, such as "we." Passive constructions were used more often in the bad years than in the good. Altogether, current research suggests that a company's external bad-news messages are created to reflect as positively as possible on the personal accomplishments of its management.

Hildebrandt, H. W., & Snyder, R. D. (1981, Winter). The Pollyanna hypothesis in business writing: Initial results, suggestions for research. *Journal of Business Communication, 18*(1), 5–15; Thomas, J. (1996). Discourse in the marketplace: The making of meaning in annual reports. *Journal of Business Communication.* (Forthcoming)

Either approach is workable. Using the direct plan (decision, explanation, positive close) is governed by your understanding of the cultural situation and the relationship between you and your readers.

Your reader is always the most important factor to consider when constructing your bad-news messages, and you should always try to provide some reader benefits. The tone of your message is also crucial in maintaining your reader's goodwill. Many suggested plans for bad-news messages are in the 13 Capsule Checklists on pages 244–247. These checklists review both organizational approaches; they adapt the indirect plan to eight kinds of bad-news messages and suggest choices of either direct or indirect plan on three kinds of announcements.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Refusing a Claim from an International Customer.*** You are the owner of a small but exclusive leather boutique located on Fifth Avenue in New York City. You have just received a letter from Monsieur Jean LeFevre of Cherbourg, France, asking for a replacement of an expensive leather valise or his money back. Included with the letter is a package containing the valise. According to the letter, the valise was damaged on the flight from New York to Paris. The fine leather was scratched across the front; the leather was not torn through, but the mark was ugly and discolored.

   According to M. LeFevre, the valise was damaged because the leather had not been properly conditioned during production. Because of the high cost ($450), he wants a refund or a replacement.

   You have examined the valise and determined that it was properly conditioned during production and that the scratch was made by a hard metal object. You cannot know for sure that the damage was done by luggage handlers, but it is possible. The scratch could be repaired by reconditioning the leather, but you do not want to do this without M. LeFevre's permission.

   Write a letter to M. LeFevre turning down his request for a refund or a replacement. Explain why you are not liable. Offer to repair the valise, but make sure he understands there is no guarantee of the result.

2. ***Letter to Charge for Mailing a Magazine Overseas.*** For many years, your company has been sending free copies of a glossy magazine, *"Discovery,"* to anyone who requested to be on your mailing list. The cost of this publication is about $3.10 each issue. In an effort to pare expenses, your firm's directors have suggested charging for postage on those magazines sent outside the United States. This number is sizable because you have readers in several European countries, in Hong Kong, and in Africa. Write a pleasant letter explaining the new policy.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Refusing a Claim.*** You are manager of the adjustment and claims department in Apex, a small apparel store with a relatively low volume of busi-

ness. Because of its low volume, it is the store's unwritten policy to grant few refunds and replacements on items returned more than 30 days after purchase.

A customer, Ms. Annette St. John, recently returned a cardigan sweater with which she was dissatisfied. The sweater was blue knit, size 36, and contained a label that indicated that the sweater was "wash and wear but must be washed by hand using a mild detergent." Ms. St. John decided to return the sweater because after she had washed it in her washing machine several times, using the wash-and-wear cycle, the sweater had shrunk. She had no record of when it was purchased because she had misplaced her sales slip. However, she stated that she thought she had bought it about 2 months ago.

The customer argued that the label on the sweater said wash and wear and that the store should be accountable.

Write a letter to Ms. St. John, 4301 Drury Lane, St. Paul MN 55862, refusing the request for a refund or a free replacement on the knit sweater because the instructions said specifically to wash the sweater by hand. You believe the garment was not properly laundered. However, provide some other alternatives in your reply so that Ms. St. John will be inclined to forget about the requested adjustment. You might offer an inducement such as an invitation to a special customer sale or a discount on another purchase.

4. ***Refusing an Adjustment on a Bill.*** You are customer service director for the telephone company in your region. One of the letters you must write today is a refusal to Lars Blint, a student at Central Community College. Here is his letter:

> The enclosed bill from you for $81.90 contains long-distance calls that I won't pay for. Apparently someone in your office got numbers screwed up and charged my account instead of someone else's. I know I made eight of the calls on this bill, but the other two I didn't make. I don't know anyone in those towns, and therefore, I refuse to pay the $20.75 charges on them.
>
> Your bill says I supposedly made those calls on June 18. Well, that day I'm sure I didn't make any long-distance calls because I was busy planning for the celebration party I had that same night. It was a special event. I didn't see anyone using my phone that night either. Anyway, whoever made the calls should have to pay for them, not me.
>
> Enclosed is my check for $61.15, which I think is in full payment of what I owe you.

Your operations staff members have thoroughly investigated this claim. Your highly accurate equipment registers every call, whether it is directly dialed or placed through an operator as a collect call. The two calls Mr. Blint questions were placed at 9:35 P.M. and 10:03 P.M., June 18; each was directly dialed; one was 20 minutes long, $9.60, and the other 25 minutes, $11.15. The number from which these calls originated is definitely that of

Lars Blint. As every phone book states near the front under "long-distance information and rates," any calls dialed must be billed to the number from which the call is made. Thus Lars must pay for the entire bill, including the $20.75 unpaid balance. Can you include one or two helpful suggestions for him? (Perhaps because he knows the date, time, town, length of each call and the cost of each, he could check among his June 18 guests to see who placed the calls.) Your staff even checked all equipment and operations records and found no equipment problems recorded for June 18.

Write Lars Blint, 1852 Seventh Avenue (make up his town and ZIP), a tactful refusal that will keep his goodwill and, you hope, get his full payment before your company has to disconnect his telephone.

5. ***Refusing Credit.*** You are the manager of a clothing store located in a small university town in Minnesota. You offer a very good selection of styles for college students and for young professionals. In addition, you offer such services as a 30-day return policy, a lay-away policy, and an in-house charge account. Because of the difficulties in collecting payments from students, you have a policy of not granting university students charge accounts. They are, however, free to use your lay-away plan and your 30-day return policy. Also, you offer regular discounts and free catalogs of your merchandise.

   You have just received a letter from a student who has been refused a charge account at your store. He is angry about this policy and wants to know why he shouldn't be an exception to your rule. You might consider his request if he were truly an exceptional case, such as a professional who is returning to school for a limited time but who has a regular income. However, he has not included any information that would help you make that decision.

   Write a letter to the student explaining your charge account policy. Decide whether you want to encourage him by asking for some financial information regarding his ability to pay his bills. Be sure to mention the benefits to him offered by your store and try to create goodwill.

6. ***Cutting Off Credit.*** Mr. and Mrs. Kevin Deland have been your credit customers at Brown's department store for the 5 years they have lived in your city. Their account shows that average monthly purchases are about $50, and until 2 years ago, their account was almost always paid on time. During the past 2 years, however, the payments have not been made when due. The account balance is no more than $500, and no payments have been received for 4 months.

   In today's mail was a letter from Mrs. Deland, which said that she had tried to purchase some furniture last week, and the salesclerk told her that the items could not be charged. She left the store in an angry mood, and this letter from her is the result. Among the points mentioned are two that are important: (1) She threatened to take the matter up with the local better business bureau and the local credit bureau, and (2) she said that she would never again purchase anything at your store.

   Write to Mrs. Deland and explain why her recent credit purchase was turned down. Remind her, for example, of the current balance in the account and of the credit terms she agreed to when the account was first opened. Point out that neither the better business bureau nor the credit bu-

reau will take any action because your store has broken no laws. Mention anything else that will support your position. You should not resort to threats, but you should encourage immediate payment of the account so that it can be reopened for her future convenience.

You will also want to include, as best you can, some statement of goodwill or a statement concerning her future as a customer of your store. This is not, of course, the time to try to sell her anything, but you can remind her of the quality of your merchandise, the several convenient locations, the customer announcements that go out before sales are open to the public, and similar points. Tact and firmness are important, but so is your effort to regain the Deland family's goodwill.

7. ***Rejecting a Job Applicant.*** You are the supervisor of the R&D department of a small information technology company. You have received a letter from Jonathon Smart applying for a position with your company. Smart is currently with ABC Computers, for whom you are completing a project. It was Smart's favorable recommendation that got you the contract, and you hope, with Smart's help, to continue to do business with ABC in the future.

   Smart's background is impressive with an education from the University of California at Berkeley and 10 years experience in research and development. He is well-known and favorably regarded.

   Some discreet inquiries reveal why Smart is eager to leave ABC and why you do not want to hire him. He has an abrasive and difficult personality that keeps him from being effective with higher management and generates resentment from those working under him.

   Write Jonathon Smart a letter that firmly closes the door but that, as far as possible, will keep his goodwill.

8. ***Rejection Letters.***

   Letter A:

   Dear Alice:

   I wanted to thank you for interviewing with XYZ and wish you the best for your career. If I can be of any assistance to you, feel free to call.

   Regards,

   Letter B:

   Dear Mr. Janison:

   Thank you for your recent letter expressing your interest in undergraduate summer employment opportunities with UNOX Capital Markets. Unfortunately, at the present time, no summer positions for undergraduate students are available.

Enclosed you will find our brochures describing the programs we offer for full-time employment for your future reference. Once again, thank you for your interest in UNOX.

Good luck in your job search.

Sincerely,

Letter C:

Dear Mr. Horatus:

It was a pleasure to discuss with you your interest in possible employment opportunities with ABC Company.

As promised, we have reviewed your background and your expressed career objectives in view of our current requirements. In addition, we have carefully compared your attributes with those of other candidates interviewed. Based on this comparative assessment, we have regretfully elected not to extend an offer of employment to you.

Although we can no longer consider you further at this time, we hope you will be successful in obtaining a position.

Sincerely,

9. ***Bad-News Announcement.*** You are president of the Central Building Garage, Inc. Your company manages a 400-car garage used by business executives who occupy the Central Building. Because of steadily increasing operating costs (mainly wages), you have found it necessary to increase the monthly parking rates to $106 a month (instead of the former $96). This increase will become effective February 1, 199-.

   For the past 2 years you have been absorbing the increased operating expenses, but you cannot continue to do so any longer. After several conversations with Mr. P. L. Brown, vice president of Commercial Properties, Inc., the Central Building's owners, who lease to the business firms in the building and from whom you lease your garage facilities, you received permission for the rate increase. Now you must write two letters:

   a. To Mr. Brown, telling him your decision about the monthly rate and effective date. Inform him that you will notify all parking customers before a certain date. You might restate briefly the reason for this increase, refer to previous conversations, and show appreciation. Will you organize by the direct or indirect plan? Why?

   b. To all customers who have been renting monthly parking space from your garage. This increase comes to them as a bad-news surprise. Give

them whatever details you think they will appreciate having. Will you organize the same way as for letter a? Why or why not?

10. **Refusal Letter.**

Dear Central City Economic Club:

I must refuse your invitation to be the keynote speaker at your upcoming year-end banquet. My schedule is overcrowded with such events, and I find myself unable to accept any others.

I trust you will understand my refusal.

Sincerely,

11. ***Annual Report Project.*** Review the first paragraphs of the Managers' Messages of four annual reports. Find reports that reflect both good performance years and bad performance years. Study the differences in language in the paragraphs in the good-news years and the bad-news years, noticing the use of personal pronouns, nonhuman grammatical subjects, and length of paragraphs. Present your findings in a short presentation.

Capsule Checklists for Bad-News Messages*

Bad News

A **General Plan (Indirect)**	B **Exception (Direct)**	C **Answering Non-Sales-Related Inquiries When the Information is Unfavorable**
1. Buffer a. Agreement b. Appreciation c. Assurance d. Compliment e. Cooperation f. Good news g. Neutral courtesy h. Understanding	1. Main idea a. Bad-news decision, sometimes with a brief buffer and/or reason	1. Buffer *For unfavorable recommendations* a. Applicant's name; relationship b. Reason for writing; reply by request *For other inquiries* c. Appreciation d. Assurance e. Understanding
2. Explanation a. Necessary details—general to specific b. Favorable, then unfavorable facts c. RB† reasons d. Emphasis on desired goal	2. Explanation a. Necessary details—general to specific b. Emphasis on desired goal	2. Explanation a. Answers to all questions b. Pertinent facts (favorable and unfavorable) c. Caution on legalities d. Confidentiality e. Offer, phone call
3. Decision—implied or expressed—with resale and/or constructive suggestions a. Embedded statement of bad news—with suggestion of what *can* be done b. Helpful counterproposal, plans, alternatives c. Resale d. Sales promotion	3. Decision omitted (already in B.1.a). Resale and suggestions often unnecessary and omitted; sometimes: a. Helpful counterproposal, plans, alternatives	3. Decision—with constructive suggestions *About applicant* a. Honest nonendorsement b. Possibility of changes since you last saw applicant *About other non-sales-related inquiries* c. Same as A.3.a and b
4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close a. Application b. Invitation to future action c. CSAD‡ d. EA§ and motivation e. DA¶ f. Willingness to help further g. RB† h. Good wishes i. Courtesy	4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close. Sometimes: a. Appreciation b. Invitation to future action c. CSAD‡ d. EA§ and motivation e. DA¶ f. Willingness to help further g. RB† h. Good wishes i. Courtesy	4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close a. Ray of hope for improvement b. Willingness to help further c. Good wishes

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.
†CSAD = clear statement of action desired.
‡EA = easy action.
§DA = dated action, if desirable.
¶RB = reader benefit.

Capsule Checklists for Bad-News Messages (*Continued*)*

D
Refusing Adjustments on Claims and Complaints

1. Buffer
   a. Agreement
   b. Appreciation
   c. Assurance
   d. Cooperation
   e. Neutral courtesy
   f. Understanding
   g. If granting a part is good news, opening is on that part
2. Explanation
   a. Logical statement of reasons
   b. General RB† procedure, policy, instructions, guarantee
   c. Resale interwoven
   d. Education on use
   e. Impersonal facts on buyer's mistake
3. Decision—with resale and/or suggestions
   a. Impersonal, expressed or implied, but clear refusal; positive language, perhaps RB†
   b. Clear indication if you are returning product
   c. RB† suggestion(s) for using rejected product and/or another
   d. Resale on product, service, and/or firm
4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close
   a. CSAD (tactful suggestion without urging)‡
   b. EA§ and DA¶
   c. Positive forward look
   d. RB† and satisfaction
   e. Courtesy

Refusing Credit

E
Retail Credit

1. Buffer
   a. Agreeable comment
   b. Appreciation
   c. Assurance
   d. Brief resale on product and/or firm
   e. Incidental reference to the order, if any
2. Explanation
   Choice of
   a. No reason
   b. "Insufficient information" reason
   c. List of all usual reasons
   d. Specific reason(s): with RB† and emphasis on desired goal
3. Decision—with RB† counterproposal and suggestion(s)
   a. Embedded statement of bad news—with suggest of what *can* be done
   b. Suggestions
      (1) Conference
      (2) Other lenders
      (3) Future review
      (4) Other credit plans available
      (5) Layaway
      (6) Cash or c.o.d. buying
4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close
   a. Invitation regarding a suggestion; CSAD‡
   b. Forward look
   c. Resale
   d. RB† and EA§
   e. Courtesy

F
Mercantile Credit

1. Buffer
   a. Agreeable comment
   b. Appreciation
   c. Assurance
   d. Brief resale on product and/or firm
   e. Incidental reference to the order, if any
2. Explanation
   a. Specific reasons
   b. Favorable, then unfavorable, facts
   c. Emphasis on desired goal
3. Decision—with RB† counterproposal and suggestion(s)
   a. Embedded statement of bad news—with suggestion of what *can* be done
   b. Suggestions
      (1) Inventory reduction
      (2) Sales or capital increase
      (3) Local financing
      (4) Cash or c.o.d. buying; smaller, frequent orders
      (5) Help of sales representative
      (6) Future review
4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close
   a. Invitation regarding a suggestion; CSAD‡
   b. Forward look
   c. Resale
   d. RB† and EA§
   e. Courtesy

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.
†CSAD = clear statement of action desired.
‡EA = easy action.
§DA = dated action, if desirable.
¶RB = reader benefit.

Capsule Checklists for Bad-News Messages (*Continued*)*

Acknowledging Orders You Can't Fill Now or at All

G

Incomplete or Vague

1. Good news, if any, and buffer
   a. Shipment details, if sending anything
   b. Buffer: short resale on vaguely described item(s)
   c. Brief order aknowledgment (date, item)
   d. Appreciation
   e. Welcome, if new customer
2. Explanation
   a. RB† reason for requesting missing information
   b. Facts about choices available (sizes, colors, models)
   c. Descriptive enclosures
3. Decision—with resale and/or suggestions
   a. See 2.a, above—implied decision
   b. Perhaps brief resale on the item(s) in general
4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close
   a. CSAD‡
   b. EA§
   c. DA¶
   d. RB (prompt delivery?)†
   e. Courtesy

H

Back Orders

1. Good news, if any, and buffer
   a. Same as G.1.a
   b. Buffer: specific resale or ordered depleted item; no mention of depletion
   c. Brief order acknowledgment (date, item)
   d. Appreciation
   e. Welcome, if new customer
2. Explanation
   a. Approximate date goods expected to reach buyer
   b. Reasons unavailable now (RB?)†
   c. Resale
3. Decision—with resale and/or constructive suggestions
   a. See 2.a above—implied decision
   b. Possibly mild sales promotion on allied item(s) to be shipped with back-ordered item
   c. Perhaps brief resale on back-ordered item
4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close
   a. If shipment in reasonable time: no action; assumption that back order is OK
   b. If longer: CSAD‡; EA†; DA¶
   c. RB†

I

Substitutions

1. Goods news, if any, and buffer
   a. Same as G.1.a
   b. Buffer: broad resale embodies both substitute and ordered item; omits differences
   c. Brief order acknowledgment (date, item)
   d. Appreciation
   e. Welcome, if new customer
2. Explanation
   a. One or two merits of substitute (S) before revealing unavailability of ordered item (O)
   b. Sales point on why we carry S exclusivity
3. Decision—with resale and suggestions
   a. Unavailability of O—in positive terms (exclusively stock S—if true)
   b. Passive statement on where O may be bought
   c. Price and quality justification of substitute; RB†
   d. Sales promotion
4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close
   a. If S is already shipped: assurance of money-back "shipment on approval"; RB†
   b. If S is not yet shipped: CSAD‡; EA§; DA¶; RB†

J

Declining Invitations and Requests for Favors

1. Buffer
   a. Appreciation
   b. Compliment (to reader)
   c. Assurance
   d. Agreeable comment
2. Explanation
   a. Facts and (sometimes personal) reasons leading to refusal
3. Decision—with resale and/or suggestions
   a. Clear, tactful decision, implied or stated; emphasis on the positive aspects (desire to help, etc.)
   b. RB† suggestions—when, how you *can* help
   c. Alternative sources of help to reader
4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close
   a. CSAD‡
   b. EA§
   c. DA¶
   d. Good wishes
   e. RB†
   f. Courtesy

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.
†CSAD = clear statement of action desired.
‡EA = easy action.
§DA = dated action, if desirable.
¶RB = reader benefit.

Capsule Checklists for Bad-News Messages (*Continued*)*

K **Announcing Bad News About Prices and Services**	L **Penalizing for Nonconformity to Rules or Procedures**	M **Conveying Other Bad News**
1. Main idea or buffer a. If routine (or reader not emotionally involved), B.1—(direct plan) b. Otherwise, A.1 buffer (1) Agreeable comment (2) Neutral courtesy (3) Brief resale†	1. Main idea or buffer a. If routine, urgent, or reader not emotionally involved: bad-news decision, sometimes with reason (direct plan, B.1) b. Otherwise, A.1 buffer (1) Agreeable comment (2) Neutral courtesy (3) Compliment on past (4) Hint of urgency or need for change	1. Main idea or buffer a. Same as L.1.a b. Same as L.1.b
2. Explanation a. RB¶ reasons and analysis of increasing costs, etc.	2. Explanation a. Details about the requirements b. Reasons leading to the penalty	2. Explanation a. Details on what is wrong
3. Decision—with resale and suggestions a. Effective date of new plan b. Clear statement and itemizing, if needed c. Enclosures or examples, if helpful d. Resale on your firm products, services, prices	3. Decision—with resale and suggestions a. Clear, tactful statement of what will happen unless reader meets requirements b. Suggestions for eliminating penalty in future c. Forms and deadlines	3. Decision—with suggestions a. What needs to be done b. How to do it
4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close a. Forward look b. Resale c. Invitation to action d. CSAD‡ e. EA§ f. RB¶ g. Courtesy	4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close a. CSAD‡ b. EA§ c. DA¶ d. RB¶ e. Assurance f. Good wishes g. Courtesy	4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close a. CSAd‡ b. EA§ c. Goodwill d. Courtesy

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.
‡CSAD = clear statement of action desired.
§EA = easy action.
¶DA = dated action, if desirable.
†RB = reader benefit.

Chapter 10

Persuasive Written Messages

I. Organization of Persuasive Messages
   A. Direct Request Organization
   B. Indirect Request Organization

II. Persuasive Requests
   A. Requests That Require Time or Personal Contributions
   B. Requests About Products or Services
   C. Requests for Claims (Complaints) and Requests for Adjustments
   D. Requests for Changes in Policy
   E. Requests for Changes in Performance
   F. Requests from Employer to a Reference
   G. Requests from Employee to a Reference

III. Persuasive Sales Letters
   A. Suggestions for Writing Solicited Sales Letters
   B. Suggestions for Writing Unsolicited Sales Letters

IV. Summary

V. Exercises and Problems

VI. Capsule Checklists for Persuasive Requests

Persuasion has one core purpose: Get your reader to support, believe, and act in your favor.

Persuasion played only a minimal role in the issues discussed in preceding chapters, but many situations call for well-thought-out persuasive writing, the focus of this chapter. Many times you want your readers to do something: You wish them to act, to accept a point of view, to follow your wishes, to respond, to change, or to not change. In short, you desire a response from your message receiver.

It makes little difference how persuasive messages are classified. For ease of discussion, here we briefly review two common strategies of organization for persuasive requests, discuss seven kinds of routine persuasive messages, and summarize the persuasion techniques needed in solicited and unsolicited sales letters. The chapter concludes with three detailed checklists: general persuasive requests, favors, and other persuasive requests.

ORGANIZATION OF PERSUASIVE MESSAGES

Direct Request Organization

For the routine, more personal request, use the direct-request format. There is no need to keep the reader in suspense. This direct-request (deductive) approach has three parts:

1. **Main idea**—Your request or question, statement, and reason
2. **Explanation**—Evidence and details needed in order that your reader can respond precisely
3. **Courteous close**—Politely asking for whatever action is desired

Routine personal requests can use immediate, up-front statements of the main idea.

Of the two methods of organization—direct and indirect—the direct approach is easier: You state your request up front, explain why you need a favorable response, and end with a courteous close. Several of the seven routine persuasive examples that follow our indirect request discussion are of the direct request type.

Indirect Request Organization

Situations that are more complex, more difficult, a bit out of the ordinary are not routine; they take more effort. In fact, the favor you ask may precipitate some objection; you will have to supply evidence and data to support your request. Therefore, nonroutine persuasive requests—like the bad-news letter—most often use the indirect approach.

1. **Explanation**—Buffer opening
2. **Main idea**—The core of your request, your concern
3. **Courtesy close**—Polite ending with last request for action

Indirect requests (main message not up front) mean the writer must first get the reader's attention.

Your assumption in using the indirect approach is that if your request were stated directly at the beginning, it would be unwanted or undesirable news to your reader, who then might react unfavorably. Instead, prepare the reader and

offer facts suggesting that your proposal is beneficial or useful. Remember: Your reader often is not expecting your message.

Persuasive letters or memorandums usually have four parts, often referred to as the AIDA formula for sales presentations:

A—Attract the reader's *attention.*
I—Arouse the reader's *interest.*
D—Create *desire* and convince the reader.
A—State clearly the *action* the reader needs to take.

Do not worry about the order of the AIDA structure: It is more important to be aware of the rationale behind the various parts.

Although *attention, interest, desire,* and *action* are listed here as distinct steps, they are usually combined or blended smoothly into your persuasive message. Do not worry so much about the precise order; do focus on giving thought to the principles in each of the sections.

In fact, the persuasive-request plan may also be referred to as the four P's: promise, picture, prove, and push. We also include (within parentheses) other terms for the parts in the following discussion.

1. Attention: First Paragraph (Promise, Start)

Begin by getting reader attention. You are really answering the reader's question of "What's in it for me?" Search for a point that is close to the reader's interests or needs. Avoid speaking of yourself and your organization.

Open with Agreeable Comment or Assertion

To encourage someone to run for office:

```
Few persons realize the need for improved leader-
ship.  Over the years your comments have been read
with interest and support.
```

Communication Probe

Much writing is impersonal and objective. At times such writing is desirable, as in technical manuals or impersonal descriptions on how to operate machinery. But because much business writing is persuasive, it must project a personal "voice." Here the reader must be kept precisely in mind; here he or she must be made to feel that behind the writing is a human being, that a live, interested person is sending the message. Thus in seller/buyer relationships this "voice" seeks to give the buyer a sense of trust. Interestingly, this trust is established, according to one author, through the personal "voice" of the writer/seller in the message.

Corbett, E. (1989). What classical rhetoric has to offer the teacher and the student of business and professional writing. In M. Kogen (ed.), *Writing in the business professions* (pp. 65–72). Urbana, IL: National Council of the Teachers of English.

To ask for a change in grade:

Fairness was a term all of us learned during the last semester. I have tried to practice it daily . . .

Open with Sincere Compliment

To ask someone to speak, without a fee, to a local group:

With pleasure our members read a review of your recent speech before our local Rotary Club. Even that short review raised our desire to have you speak to our [*name of club*].

To ask someone to speak, without a fee, but using a sense of humor:

I know you believe in free speech; how would you like to give one for that amount?

Open with Direct Request for a Favor

To complete a questionnaire:

One Dollar
Yours to Keep

We need your input. Our enclosed questionnaire will take about five minutes of your time. We're sincere in sending along a small sum to cover that time.

To become a member of a task force:

John, we need your advice. You've been a member of this community for over 30 years. With that opening you can guess at my request for your joining us for the [*name*] committee.

Open with a Question

To join an exercise group:

Have you read the company's latest health letter? Did you note the benefits of exercise, even for those under 30? Sixteen of us are getting together three times a week in our fitness room. We'd like to have you join us.

To look at an enclosed folder:

How many people have in place a retirement plan? Do you have such a plan? Studies suggest that less than 25% have consulted a retirement adviser. With our company's average age of 48, there are some of us who feel the enclosed information can be useful.

2. Interest and Desire: Middle Paragraphs (Picture, Chain)

Build upon the theme stated in the attention-getting opening; begin to think about creating interest and desire in the reader. Suggest what your project, product, or service is and what it will do for the reader. Consider doing two things:

- *Describe its physical characteristics*—important features, construction, appearance, performance, beauty, functions.
- *Relate its value or benefits to the reader*—For instance, will your request bring comfort? Entertainment? Safety? Health? Recognition? Financial rewards? Show the reader how your proposal gives one or more benefits such as the following:

Appreciation (by others)
Approval (by others)
Beauty or attractiveness
Cleanliness
Comfort
Convenience
Cooperation
Customer satisfaction
Distinctiveness
Durability
Efficiency
Enjoyment
Entertainment
Extra earnings
Fair treatment
Friendships
Good reputation
Health
Improvement
Love of home, family, others
Money and other valuables
Peace of mind
Pleasure
Popularity
Position of authority
Prestige
Pride
Profits
Protection for family, business, self, or others
Provision for the future
Recognition
Reduced work
Relief from fear
Respect
Safety and security
Satisfaction of helping others (altruism)
Savings
Self-preservation
Solution to a problem
Success
Thrift habit
Usefulness

Evidence is the rational part of persuasion; unsparingly use those supports as part of your persuasive strategy.

Clearly, you need proof, evidence, or data to go along with the benefits noted above. Use examples, quotations, comparisons, statistics, tests, samples, guarantees, or similar information to support your position. Give evidence that your statements are true, reliable, and accepted by others.

Physical Characteristics and Value of Project

To get someone to try a product:

```
For the past two years our foot pedal has been
under review: we placed it in university facili-
ties, local hospitals, and two locations overseas.
Data on those positive results (wear and tear,
maintenance costs, customer satisfaction) are in-
cluded in the following table.  Our most important
```

conclusion is this: 78% of the users rated the product as "very satisfactory." We'd like you to try our new foot pedal over the next 30 days.

To request funds for a summer camp:

Character building, friendship, lifelong friends, and fun are the main values we associated with our summer camp. Over 150 young people join us each summer. Many return for a second year. And as you might expect, the tuition we charge the families of those young people does not cover the costs. We need your help.

Direct and Indirect Reader Benefits

Search out both direct and indirect personal benefits for readers to help your persuasion.

Interest and desire in the reader are generated when you show the direct or indirect benefits of agreeing with your position. Again, it makes little difference whether you call the positive results direct or indirect. What does matter is that you show, as vividly as possible, benefits to your reader.

To show direct benefits (direct impact):

- Company name will be included in the program bulletin.
- Favorable publicity to individual will occur.
- Goodwill for company will result from our working together.
- Improvements will occur in our community.
- Personal benefits will occur to individual directly.
- And many others.

To show indirect benefits (indirect impact):

- Future contacts with members are a possibility.
- Potential is present for additional sales.
- Exposure will help for future political offices.
- Happiness will be brought to other persons.
- Sense of loyalty will be strengthened.
- And many others.

3. Action: Last Paragraph (Push, Hook)

If your presentation thus far has engaged your reader's attention, arousing interest and desire, then now is the time to request action. You need not feel embarassed to ask for your reader's acceptance; most readers know a final request is coming. Make that action clear, easy, and dated, if necessary.

To get someone to send a financial gift:

The AIDA formula may be used when asking for financial assistance.

So what can you do? We hope you'll sit down and send us a check as the year comes to an end. The benefits will be immediate: to the children and to all of us interested in giving guidance to young people.

Communication Probe

Both technical and mechanical changes influence writing. Take for example the rather simple process of storing documents in the vertical file, begun in the latter part of the nineteenth century. Then came carbon copies, multiple copies, and even some suggestions for writing and keeping records. What is the implication? One scholar suggests that our current electronic mail systems affect not only storage of documents, but also their structure, content, and style. She avers that we are already becoming more informal in writing. There may be a trend in business writing toward briefer and less formal communication.

Yates, J. (1985). From press book to pigeonhole to vertical filing: Revolution in storage and access systems for correspondence. In G. Douglas & H. Hildebrandt (eds.), Studies in the history of business writing (pp. 145–163). Urbana, IL: Association for Business Communication.

To renew a subscription to a book club:

```
Because you're a former subscriber, and if you act
within the next three weeks, we'll do this:  offer
you a free book plus send you our classical book-
club selections each quarter.  We sincerely hope
you'll accept our offer.
```

PERSUASIVE REQUESTS

Now that we have discussed the two main organizational patterns for persuasive written messages, let's apply the two organizational patterns to seven more common, routine kinds of persuasive writing. Although there are more than these seven, these illustrations are applicable to other kinds of routine persuasive writing as well.

Requests That Require Time or Personal Contributions

When you approach an individual to do something or contribute funds, you are asking that they give up some of their time or money, or both. And the basis for your request is that your receivers do possess knowledge of certain topics or are capable of giving both mental and physical effort to your cause. Here are two examples.

MESSAGE 1 *Letter of invitation for speaker to address convocation.*

Direct request (attention)

```
By unanimous vote, the Directors have
asked that I write you to be our convoca-
tion speaker on May 7, 199-.  That convo-
cation is for our 800 students who have
```

achieved high distinction in their studies at our university.

Background Two young students, who sit on our planning committee, placed your name in nomination with full support of the university's student council. Thus you were our only nominee to be the convocation speaker on May 7, 199-.

Persuasive details (interest desire) We are fully aware of your busy schedule. However, your recent book on the issue of urban environmental problems could serve as the basis for a timely statement on our campus. As you vividly state in your book, you feel the concerns of the environment will have to be carried forward by the young people of the future. Our convocation and dinner that evening of young people and university faculty would provide both a formal and informal setting for your remarks.

Details We are prepared to cover all travel and hotel costs while on campus. I personally will pick you up at the airport.

Easy action (action) Please let us know by February 1, 199-, your decision on giving the convocation lecture. I will then be in contact with you concerning other details.

With sincerity we look forward to your positive response.

MESSAGE 2 *Letter asking for donation of money or other tangible valuables.*

Many people are relucant to part with material goods. Thus, all that you have learned about persuasion, data and evidence, and reader benefits must be brought to bear when requesting financial help. Note the various appeals and the AIDA plan used by the company vice president addressed to all members of the corporation.

TO: All employees of Starbright
FROM: Carol Schmidt, VP Human Resources
SUBJECT: Yearly appeal for the local United Fund
DATE: September 25, 199-

Attention Our recent newspaper articles leave little doubt about the needs of our community. In fact, volunteer organizations, along with our churches and synagogues, are already making their own contributions of time and money.

Interest Because we are one of the larger employers in this community, more is expected of us. We

Desire did well last year: we made our goal of 100% of the employees contributing to the UF. Each of us sets the figure our conscience dictates, but I sincerely hope that you could increase your contribution this year. Our company goal is $134,000.

Action Please return the enclosed pledge card indicating the amount of your contribution for this year. Your support is needed this year more than ever. I personally thank you in advance for your gift and wish you well in your daily work in our company.

Requests About Products or Services

Products or services are among the most common forms of persuasive requests.

As a consumer or as a business or professional person, you will have occasions to seek a response from your reader. As a seller you are interested in promoting your product or services; as a consumer you are interested in making sure those products and services meet basic requirements.

Persuasively Requesting Purchase of Product

Notes to customers who have not used your services or brought your product for a period of time can also be organized in the direct request pattern. These notes are called miss-you messages.

Catalog firms, especially, send reminders to customers who have not ordered their merchandise for a long time. So do book clubs. Even auto dealers send reminders that it is time for a car tune-up or perhaps time to consider a new vehicle.

REQUEST 1 *Miss-you letter from a catalog firm.*

Attention Our order department has not heard from you for a long time.

Desire And that troubles us. We know many other catalogs also come to your home. But as you know, for over 10 years you have been a desirable customer. We appreciate the trust you've put in us.

Easy action If there is anything about our products or services you are dissatisfied with, we would like to know. Please drop us a note-why not write directly on the order form which is in the enclosed catalogue-and let us know how to serve you better.

When writing persuasive notes to employees, be aware of the legal implications of your message. Choose your words carefully.

Persuasively Requesting Information from Seller

All receivers of a request for further business or some kind of involvement should be eager to reply. Strange as it may seem, some sellers are late in re-

sponding or do not respond at all. Such a request—even via the Internet—can be simple. "Please send me your most recent catalog so that I can place an order." "I'm considering attending the evening program of your school; please send me your undergraduate catalogue." Here is a more detailed request:

REQUEST 2 *Reaction to a news story in a local newspaper.*

Direct request

My family and I have searched for an exercise bike for my invalid mother. The story in the Mind and Body section of [*local newspaper, date, and page*] suggests your product might work well for us. All we saw was a picture of your Exercise Bike. Therefore, we need a little more information.

1. Which institutions now use your bike?
2. Can a partial invalid get on and off the bike alone?
3. Does the bike come assembled?
4. What guarantee do you offer?
5. What is the cost of the product?

Easy action

Probably some of the above questions are answered in a brochure; I would be pleased to receive your responses within the next two weeks.

Persuasively Requesting Internal Employee Action

Because "quality management" is extensively used today, companies are deeply concerned about how to improve their relationships with employees and customers. Persuasion is needed to convince the reader that the information requested is necessary and worthwhile.

REQUEST 3 *Memo seeking feedback on computer hardware.*

TO: All employees
FROM: Manager, Systems Division
SUBJECT: Request for your views concerning computer hardware

Background

For the past two months a committee has researched, tested, and evaluated various computers. Our single goal was to arrive at a recommendation as to which product would benefit all of us the most.

Easy action

We now need your input. Attached is a list of the five computers we have evaluated: the attached sheet lists both their strengths and weaknesses. In order to get a tally of your preferences, we ask that you complete the brief evaluation form and return it, anonymously, to your supervisor by September 17, 199-.

Requests for Claims (Complaints) and Requests for Adjustments

All agree: Never write a letter in the heat of anger.

Unhappy customers—those dissatisfied with a product, service, or policy—are often quick to request a correction. Often such communication is written in the heat of anger. But we recommend a more temperate approach. Remember, most companies wish to please customers.

Persuasively Requesting an Adjustment

REQUEST 4 *A customer approaches a local savings and loan requesting a financial adjustment.*

Attention

Thirty-six years. That's the amount of time I have enjoyed a working relationship with your organization. In fact, both of my children also have accounts with you. We've been pleased over the years. But something happened last month that I'd like to call to your attention.

Supporting data

On November 16, 199-, I called your loan office and asked what the final payment on my loan would be if I were to pay it off entirely. Ms. Hicks said it would take an hour or so to arrive at the precise figure and would call me back.

[*Here would appear a two-paragraph summary on the financial data such as interest charges, administrative help, and other matters Ms. Hicks orally reported previously.*]

Supporting data

On November 18, 199-, I sent you the amount requested to completely pay off my loan. On December 8, 199-, I received a statement that indicated I still owed $27 for interest charges.

My intention is not to pay those charges inasmuch as the final figure given me on November 16, 199-, was carefully examined by Ms. Hicks; she assured me her figures were correct.

Easy action

I would appreciate a response to this note and an interpretation for those additional charges of $27.

REQUEST 5 *Request for a refund or an exchange.*

Attention

For the last 12 years we have purchased many of our Christmas clothing gifts from your catalogue. They have been reliable, have worn well, and have consistently met our standards for excellence.

Communication Probe

One of the classic theories of communication was developed by Stephen Toulmin. It later developed into analytical measures applicable to managerial communication. Toulmin's theory—expressed in his model—suggests that claims (also called declarations, assertions, positions, resolutions, propositions, affirmations) are of three types: fact, value, or policy. Oversimplified, he suggests that (1) message senders begin with a claim. In turn this claim is supported with (2) data (evidence such as examples, statistics, credible sources, comparisons, and so forth). Last, he proposes that message senders use (3) a warrant, explanations that imply a relationship between the data and the claim via general beliefs expressed in phrases as "because of" or "since" or "given that." A result of such a process, suggests Toulmin, is that message receivers can be persuaded. Application of this model to managerial persuasion suggests that business messages can be evaluated for their potential effectiveness.

Rogers, P. (1994). Analytic measures for evaluating managerial writing. *The Journal of Business and Technical Writing*, 8(4), 380–407; Toulmin, S. (1958). *The uses of argument*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Details Over the phone, on November 6, 199-, I placed an order for your traditional calf-high hunting boots. There were in green in size 9. The size I received on December 1, 199-, was size 8.

Easy action Within this express package I have enclosed the wrong-size boots. Please send me the correct size 9 as I requested, in the same color and with the same soles. If this is not possible within two weeks, I request a refund of $56.

Persuasively Requesting Credit

Money matters often demand your exposing some personal and confidential information.

Many credit applications are handled routinely. However, on some occasions you may seek a special credit privilege requiring you to persuade the lending institution for variances from their regular pattern. You will need to convince the financial institution that you are dependable and reliable.

Sometimes applicants' requests for credit are turned down. If you are one of those persons, you would like to know why.

REQUEST 6 *A request for credit after an initial turndown.*

Attention My mailbox continues to be filled with letters from organizations that wish me to use their credit card. In fact, that is the way I received your initial invitation to use your card and services.

Aim

However, your form letter of March 7, 199-, refused me a Revolving Credit account. Certainly I was unhappy with that decision and request a further explanation.

To assist you in coming to a positive conclusion I have included additional information.

Supporting details

[*Information about employer, years of service, salary.*]
[*Assets and liabilities as printed on computer form.*]
[*Names of references who could be contacted.*]

Easy action

Be assured that my payments would occur promptly. That is the method I use with my other credit card. Your card allows me to use it abroad, where I spend several months of the year. With pleasure, I look forward to a favorable decision.

Requests for Changes in Policy

Effecting change in a policy can take considerable time. Be prepared with logical and organized evidence.

Besides requesting nonroutine adjustments for credit, at times you may need to persuade a company to make other exceptions to its usual policy. Or you may wish to persuade individuals to change their actions, or to give employees a pep talk, hoping to improve their future performance.

Here you request a change from an established pattern; you try to seek a variation from an established policy.

REQUEST 7 *An employee's persuasive request to allow more choices for retirement funds.*

Direct request

For many years our company has successfully allowed its employees to invest in two funds: the Strategic Bond and the Strategic Stock Funds. I feel it is time to allow us more options.

Organized data

First, three other companies in the area now allow investments in Fidelity, The China Fund, the Europe Fund, and others. A comparison of the rate of return from those funds surpasses what we have received this past year.

Second, we have grown considerably in the number of employees from when the plan was first started. There is no doubt in my mind that the company would increase morale if employees were given another investment choice.

Recommendation

In the interest of continuing our cordial relations between management and employee, I respectfully suggest action al-

lowing us more investment options for our retirement funds.

REQUEST 8 *A traveler's request to a hotel for a lower prepayment.*

Attention

For 18 years I have stayed at your hotel during my visits to Vienna. And during that time your location on the Ringstrasse allowed me the privilege of either walking or taking the street car to the Opera or the outdoor concerts in Staatpark. In short, you can see that I was pleased with my visits to your hotel.

Aim

I would like to continue doing so. But your policy of demanding a prepayment of $500 in advance seems excessive and unnecessary.

Organized details

First, I have certainly established a reputation for paying my bills on time. At no time was I in arrears or late in my payments.

Second, my company has been approached by another nearby Vienna hotel with a tempting offer that does not include the prepayment feature.

You have in the past explained your policy to me, and I understand that. But I can assure you-and for all the other persons with whom I work in my company-that they prefer your hotel. The one hindrance is your requirement of the rather large prepayment amount.

Courteous close

I sincerely hope you can make an adjustment in your policy.

Requests for Changes in Performance

In personal matters, it is a positive idea to follow an oral discussion with a written summary of that discussion.

Persuasion is needed when you need to convince individuals to change their performance. Requested changes could include personal appearance, habits annoying to others, or even business practices. Elaborate monitoring scales and measures of individual performance are increasingly common. But following most oral evaluations, a written letter or memorandum summarizes the situation and also creates a paper trail. When writing such a note, Checklist 10.1 will help you avoid some common faults.

REQUEST 9 *A summary statement sent to an employee after a formal oral evaluation.*

Common agreement

Our visit of a week ago cleared up, I think, some of the misunderstandings re-

Checklist 10.1 Avoiding Negative Words in a Performance Letter

1. Watch overuse of negative terms: "disturbed," "agitated," "stupid," "misinformed," "horrified," "senseless," "punishing," "destroying," and others.
2. Avoid overuse of "I" and "we."
3. Go slowly and avoid a domineering attitude.
4. Omit threats to the message receiver.

garding your work effort. As you and I both agreed, we will meet with more regularity to avoid future misunderstandings.

Summary and details

Let me summarize our agreements, open to your amendments after receiving this note:

--To limit the number of personal phone calls per day to two
--To avoid bypassing the supervisors in the shipping section
--To begin evening business classes at our local school

These three items appear to be where major improvements must occur. Please let me know whether the above three points parallel your understanding or whether they are unclear.

Courteous close

I look forward to an improved working relationship.

Requests from Employer to a Reference

Employers desire feedback, often in written form, from individuals who know something about a prospective employee. Keep in mind that the receiver of your message may have no desire to respond. You must persuade your reader to react. A series of questions often can be the basis for your request to a reference.

1. Be specific. It is better to include too much information in your request than a general, incomplete inquiry.
2. Word your questions in a neutral way; avoid influencing the answer.
3. Number your questions and use a separate paragraph for each one.

4. Phrase the question to go beyond a simple "yes" or "no" response. If you have a questionnaire, it is acceptable to include "yes" or "no" responses.
5. Use a rating scale if you ask for an evaluation of a person, product, or service.

You can also enclose, as do many schools and universities, specific criteria to which the reference gives a numerical value, as in the following:

Please check (1 to 5, high to low) each of the following criteria. If you feel you have no opinion, please use DK (don't know).

	1	2	3	4	5
Gets along with others					
Oral communication ability					
Written communication ability					
Ability to solve problems					
Thorough in his or her work					

REFERENCE *Employer personal request concerning a job applicant.*

EXAMPLE 1 [*In this example and others, we have omitted the introductory parts of the letter.*]

Your name was given to me by Ms. Sadie Barron, who is applying for the position of Account Manager in our firm.

We are looking for a young person to handle our European accounts who has a good command of English as well as a working knowledge of at least one foreign language, preferably German. To arrive at a final decision for the position, I would appreciate your responses to the following questions:

1. How long was she in your employ, and for what reason did she leave?
2. How was she received by other members of her work group?
3. Is her German competence adequate for either speaking or writing?
4. Are there any problems you foresee if she is asked to spend considerable time in Germany?

Please include any other information you feel is needed in our evaluation of Ms. Barron.

```
Your response will be treated confidentially. Our
selection committee would appreciate a response
within the next two weeks.
```

Requests from Employee to a Reference

Your teachers are prime candidates for writing reference letters; your authors as teachers firmly suggest: Give them background information.

Who are desirable references? To whom would you, as an employee or a student, turn for an evaluation letter? Most likely your teacher(s) would be your first choice, followed by supervisors in your current position, professional friends, religious leaders, and many others who you feel can evaluate you successfully. Some persons may not want to write a letter on your behalf; your task is to persuade them to do so.

Assume you will ask a former or current teacher for a letter of recommendation. First check to see if the teacher (or other reference for that matter) is willing to provide information. Then—either in person or in writing—do the following:

1. State why you are communicating and what the recommendation is for.
2. Include some summary information about yourself; you need to refresh the referent's memory. For example:
   - **a.** Courses studied; class with the teacher
   - **b.** Grades in major and minor area
   - **c.** Positions held and companies worked for
   - **d.** Examples of leadership qualities

Communication Probe

There exist many kinds of writing genres; some are audience-specific, others applicable to just about anybody. Much business writing is persuasive and specific. Indeed, in many business messages persuasion is the core purpose. Thus a primary difference between business and some other writing genres is the preeminent importance of adapting the message to the reader. It is the reader, the member of the audience, who determines the format, the content, the organization, and the tone. Assessing the audience of a business message, whether internal or external, demands great skill and sensitivity on the part of the writer. The result is that persuasive writing is demanding, especially when asking someone to do something for you. A business writer must know the basic fundamentals of writing and have experience in writing those business messages. Both components assist business writers in feeling comfortable about writing in the business genre.

Corbett, E. (1989). What classical rhetoric has to offer the teacher and the student of business and professional writing. In M. Kogen (ed.), *Writing in the business professions* (pp. 65–72). Urbana, IL: National Council of the Teachers of English.

e. Activities outside the workplace
f. Goals and objectives for your future

Your closing should state to whom the letter or form is to be sent, along with the due date. Many organizations often include preprinted envelopes and ask for the referent's signature directly over the flap of the envelope. Above all, be courteous in your request to a reference; he or she must be persuaded to write a letter of support on your behalf.

REFERENCE EXAMPLE 2

405 N. State St.
[City, State, Zip]
November 29, 199-

Professor Carl Renny
3260 Rumley Hall
State University
[City, State, Zip]

Dear Professor Renny:

Introduction

In the final weeks of the term, you said you would be pleased to write a letter of support for your students. This note thus asks for a letter of recommendation to the Rapid Motor Company, where I am applying for the position of Buyer.

Body (background)

Three years ago you were management professor for the course LHC 560. My grade in that course was a low B. Since completing that course and my other college work, I have worked as a Purchasing Agent for the Technical Supply Co. There I handled all the accounts that had yearly business with us of at least $1 million. My supervisor was pleased with my work. In fact, he is writing a letter on my behalf to the Rapid Motor Company.

My reason for leaving the Technical Supply Company is that advancement opportunities at the moment are limited. Thus I have submitted my application for a senior Buyer position at Rapid Motor Company.

Action request

Enclosed with this note is a formal evaluation form, along with an envelope addressed to the Senior Buyer. Professor Renny, I value your comments. Would you please complete the brief enclosed form

along with a brief reference letter. I appreciate your sending that information before the deadline of December 19, 199-.

Sincerely,

Randy Gutfleish

Enclosure

PERSUASIVE SALES LETTERS

The two kinds of sales letters are *solicited* (the organization is invited to respond to sales messages) and *unsolicited* (the organization sends out an uninvited message to sell a product or service). Here we focus briefly on the former and in depth on the latter.

Suggestions for Writing Solicited Sales Letters

Responses to solicited sales letters begin, if possible, with good news.

With solicited letters, the organization has one central goal: to get responses quickly to someone's request for information. Checklist 10.2 is a basic format for the solicited letter; also see the capsule checklists at the end of the chapter.

EXAMPLE 1 *A solicited response letter from a foreign subsidiary.*

Positive opening

With pleasure we received your letter. And it is with further pleasure that we are able to open a foreign account with our Singapore bank. All the necessary forms to initiate that account are included with this letter.

Response to questions

You requested further information concerning our ability to purchase stocks for your account, arrange international loans, and oversee the handling of your payroll. All these activities can be handled through our international banking section. Unfortunately, we are unable at this time to purchase local stocks; that can only be done through your account executive in the States. As you know, the large share offering of Singapore Telecom stock for foreign investors was handled in this manner. Often a foreign investor must also pay a premium above the local stock offering price.

Benefit to reader

Please accept this note as an initial response to your letter. You will be interested to know that our bank already has over 130 American firms doing business with us. It would be our pleasure

Easy action

Checklist 10.2 Responding to Solicited Letters

1. Opening paragraph [Use the good-news approach.]
   a. Answer the inquirer's questions favorably.
   b. Indicate that the requested material will be sent.

2. Body
   a. Answer additional questions.
   b. Provide educational, resale, or sales promotion information.
   c. Be truthful about negative information.
   d. Arrange your answers so your positive responses are at the beginning and the end; embed (put in the middle) your weaker or negative comments.

3. Action ending
   a. Make the action easy.
   b. Suggest benefits to reader.
   c. Focus on the positive.

```
to work with you as well. When you have
completed the enclosed forms, please re-
turn them and we will begin establishing
your account. If you have further ques-
tions, our fax number is 82 123456 or you
can call me directly at 82 567890.
```

Suggestions for Writing Unsolicited Sales Letters

Composing unsolicited sales letters is often a team effort of several different functioning areas within an organization.

"Cold turkey," "over the transom," or "prospecting" are terms connected to letters initiated by the seller and sent to potential customers. Your mailbox is filled with these kinds of letters. Resistance is often strong. Thus writing unsolicited letters demands superior writing skills. Often you will work in conjunction with a marketing department or even an ad agency; they will make recommendations about the mailing lists, the timing, the core theme, and the visual presentation of brochures and accompanying material.

Your task—even before beginning to write—is to be firmly in control of the following issues:

- Know the central selling point: Decide if the purpose is to (1) make a direct sale, (2) stimulate a future sale, or (3) win back lost customers.
- Understand whether the audience is general (thousands) or a small niche (specifically selected).
- Know every detail about your product or service.
- Be aware of the enclosures and timing.
- Give thought to the length of your letter.

The basic guide for the organization of your sales letter is the AIDA formula: *attention, interest, desire, action.* Although the following discussion focuses separately on each part of the AIDA plan, the parts need not always be in sequence, nor need all parts be in every letter. Creativity—foremost in the eyes of marketing departments—should govern the direction of your letter.

Attract Your Prospect's Attention

Realize this: You have only a few seconds to catch your reader's attention. Consequently, one principle shouts loudly: Keep the opening short. Short paragraphs look easy to read and might encourage the reader to continue. Here are possible beginnings:

Opening Techniques	Illustration
Comparison or story	Your neighbor may already own one. No wonder she's getting all those favorable comments. [*appeal to women considering buying a new small car*]
Event in reader's life	A graduate! Congratulations! Your success automatically permits a low-cost insurance rate. [*appeal to recent college graduate*]
Rhetorical question	What's the main characteristic of leaders today? [*appeal to reader's ego and sale of leadership seminar*]
Enclosed gift	It's a screen saver! [*appeal to complete a questionnaire and establish a mailing list*]
Product fact	More than 12,000 subscribers. One of the largest in the U.S. [*appeal to reader to subscribe to periodical*]
Surprise question	New landscaping! How does a year to pay sound? [*appeal to landscape a yard at favorable payment terms*]
Challenge statement	Alaska! Hawaii! Tokyo! Yours, when you return the enclosed lottery number. [*appeal to join a travel group*]

Clichés are a turnoff; avoid them.

Of course, there are many other ways to get attention. But avoid time-worn and cliché openings, keep away from exaggerations unsupported by truth, and certainly avoid any falsehoods for which you could be legally liable.

Arouse Your Reader's Interest and Desire

Now you "picture" your product and tell the readers what your product or service will do for them. You develop your central theme, your core selling point. You place great emphasis on the reader and what your product will do for him or her. At the same time, you are interested in creating a desire, pointing out the positive features of the product or service.

EXAMPLE 2 *Stating benefits of early landscape planning.*

Two or our customers last year were the top two winners in our local "Outstanding Yard" contest. In addition, they also gained special care in root fertilizing of trees and spring pruning. You too could enjoy those benefits.

Our offer for new customers is this: We'll omit all charges for root feeding and pruning for one year. All you need do is work with us in designing a new look for your yard . . .

EXAMPLE 3 *Interweaving benefits with a physical description.*

Sixteen holiday scenes for use with your PC. At this time of the year your computer screen can be as colorful as the decorations in other parts of your home. These winter scenes not only give you a pleasant visual effect, but save your computer screen.

All you need is Windows 3.1 or later, and 4 MB of memory.

Return the enclosed card and the Holiday Scenes will be yours by return mail.

EXAMPLE 4 *Convincing readers through others' satisifed experience.*

Thirty-two names appear on the attached sheet. Each one was willing to let us use their name as a satisfied customer.

As you go through the list note that they come from all sections of our town . . .

EXAMPLE 5 *Persuading readers through noting experts, authoritative agencies.*

Seals of approval have come from such diverse groups as the Academy of Family Physicians, the American Medical Association, and the Association for Better Health. Such support is not given lightly, nor readily.

Receiving their support is an early guarantee that our medical services to you will be ethical, honest, and caring.

EXAMPLE 6 *Convincing readers through free trial.*

You've got two weeks to use these clip-on sun glasses. Try them while walking, jogging, driving, and the other things you do. At our risk.

```
If for some reason-any reason-you're not satisfied,
send them back within 10 days.  What could be fairer?
```

EXAMPLE 7 *Convincing readers through a guarantee.*

```
Your money back in three weeks if you're not satisfied!

To be honest, only 4 percent of our customers have
returned our product.  That enviable record tells
you we're here to serve you-and thousands of others.
```

The preceding examples are some of the more common methods of interesting and convincing the reader; here is an additional list of persuasive approaches:

- Develop central selling point and list of benefits.
- Include testimonials of satisfied users.
- Include samples of the product.
- Make payments simple to do and understand.
- Suggest how features affect your readers' time, money, health, family.

Induce Reader Action

Action endings should be clear; placing benefits at the end is acceptable.

Leave your specific action request until the end. Surely your readers will know your intent—they are not dense—but it is still up to you to make the final action easy. Remember these five points:

- State clearly the action you desire.
- Make the action easy.
- Date the action (when desirable).
- Offer inducements to act by a specific time (when desirable).
- End with one final reader-benefit plug (when appropriate).

To induce the reader to act within a certain time, you can use one or more of the following methods.

Communication Probe

A thoughtful statement on preparing written material for readers appears in a journal directed toward insurance practitioners. Therein the anonymous author asks whether our documentation of data, in support of a product or service, should be changed. The argument is made that we must review how we now transfer information, perhaps turning to this concept: Humans most efficiently absorb information via pictures, sound, organization, color, and intuition. Should the written word be used less in transmitting information? The author's response is that we give more effort to interactive video and oral presentation. This concept is worth thinking about.

(1995, February). Technology is changing . . . shouldn't documentation change too? *Insurance & Technology*, 30–31.

Communication Probe

This probe is different from previous probes used in this text: It is a collection of pithy statements that capture thoughts relevant to persuasion; they are well worth remembering when persuading:

- My idea of an agreeable person is one who agrees with me. *Samuel Johnson.*
- A soft answer turns away wrath. *Proverbs 15:1.*
- Think as wise men do, but speak as the common people do. *Aristotle.*
- The more you say, the less people remember. *Anatole France.*
- Men govern with words. *Benjamin Disraeli.*
- The greatest problem in communication is the illusion that it has been accomplished. *George Bernard Shaw.*
- Getting the facts is only half the job; the other half is to use them intelligently. *Unknown author.*
- Nothing astonishes persons so much as common sense and plain dealing. *Ralph Waldo Emerson.*
- The worse the news, the more effort should go into communicating it. *Andrew S. Grove.*
- Many a good idea has been smothered to death by words. *Unknown author.*
- If I had eight hours to chop down a tree, I'd spend six sharpening my ax. *Abraham Lincoln.*
- One of the best ways to persuade others is by listening to them. *Dean Rusk.*

EXAMPLE 8 *Credit cards.*

For the moment don't send any money. We know your credit card has been approved. Just sign the enclosed order form and we'll bill your credit card directly. Please fill in completely your credit card number and expiration date.

EXAMPLE 9 *Easy payments.*

Your family can enjoy filtered air in time for the holidays. Here's our deal: Send us a down payment of $50 and we'll arrange for monthly payments of $10. No hassles, no fuss.

EXAMPLE 10 *Gift.*

Our gift is already enclosed: a suncatcher to attach to your window. Send your order in and we'll send you another one. Free.

It is brutal, but the success of a letter can be seen by the number of responses it generates.

Here are some other ways to end with action:

- Free trial of the product.
- No obligation to buy.
- Higher earnings.
- Special price for a limited time.
- Join with others who already are satisfied.
- No salesperson will call.
- Names will not be sold to other firms.

In sum, writing effective and persuasive sales letters is difficult. Some letters may take weeks to perfect. But financial returns can be great. Good selling presents the benefits and the proposition in such a way that the readers become convinced and "sell themselves." Achieving your goal requires careful editing and rewriting, but the results can well be worth the effort.

SUMMARY

Much business writing is routine; such writing occurs daily and is often in the direct-request format: deductive, up front—direct in stating a request. That organizational format is used more with more personal, routine requests for action.

Indirect organization is often used when the persuasive situation is more complex. Here the structure is similar to a bad-news message, giving more effort to the beginning of a message prior to asking for an action.

There are numerous kinds of persuasive requests, each using either the direct or indirect structure. Such structures are applicable to requests requiring time or personal contributions; requests about products or services; requests on claims and requests for adjustment; requests for changes in policy and performance; and requests from employer to a reference and employee to a reference.

Persuasive sales letters take time to compose and write. Of the two main types—solicited (the organization responds to a request) and unsolicited (the organization sends an uninvited request to buy a product or service)—the latter is more demanding to write. Using the AIDA formula (attention, interest, desire, action) is applicable here.

Useful checklists for all the above topics are found throughout this chapter.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises of an International Nature

1. ***Request.*** You are vice president of Kalends Consulting, Inc. You are planning a seminar to be held in New York City on May 1, 199-. The title of the seminar is Swimming in Strange Waters: Dealing with National Environmental Legislation in International Business. You want to invite Silvio Berlusconi, former Prime Minister of Italy, to be your keynote speaker. If he cannot do it, you intend to invite Werner Watchke, vice president of Mercedes Benz. You are acquainted with both men through work you have done for their companies in the United States. Write to each of these men. Write the *first paragraph only* of your message. How will you begin? What

organizational pattern will you choose for each of them? What kind of tone will you use?

2. ***Problem for Discussion.*** Kevin Thompson is vice president of research and development for a small computer software firm, CompWare, Inc., headquartered in Phoenix, Arizona. He has traveled to Mexico City to negotiate a deal with a small Mexican firm, Inez CC LTD, that makes computer chips. Because CompWare wants to buy part of the Mexican company, the negotiations will take tact and finesse.

   Kevin has done his homework on the Mexican company and knows that decisions are made more slowly than in the States and that the work pace is more leisurely. Meetings do not usually begin at the appointed hour, and long lunches and social outings are common in doing company business. Therefore, Kevin has planned a 2-week stay and has investigated some good restaurants where he might entertain company officials. For his first meeting with the vice president of development of Inez CC, Kevin thoughtfully arrives a half hour late.

   Unfortunately, Guillermo Sepúlveda, the vice president of development for Inez, has also done his homework. So far, all the Americans he has done business with have been extremely time-conscious and wanted decisions made quickly. Therefore, he has already obtained authority from the president to discuss terms and to make the final decision for the deal in the first meeting. He has also, with some inconvenience, arrived at his office on time and has been waiting for Thompson for half an hour. He is somewhat annoyed because his expectations have not been met, and he is confused about why this American is so late.

   Discuss the issues of miscommunication in this situation and how they affect the persuasion involved. Which party has the greater burden of persuasion? How should Kevin Thompson handle the situation?

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Persuasive Beginnings.*** Write the *first sentence only* of a message in the following situations:

   a. To invite someone to chair a committee

   b. To ask a publisher to consider a manuscript

   c. To ask someone to complete a survey

   d. To ask someone to renew a subscription to a magazine

   e. To ask a French retailer to send you a catalog

4. ***Request for a Policy Change.*** Discuss the persuasive strategies you would use in the following situations:

   a. To send a message to the *vice president of facilities* asking for a policy change in company parking to allow part-time workers to use the company parking lot

b. To ask *company employees* to use another parking lot for 2 weeks in November because of a workshop being given at your place of business

5. ***Request to Improve Performance.*** At a friend's urging, you hired a young man, Darryl Jenkins, to be your secretary even though he did not have much experience and no recommendations. He has been with you a month, and unfortunately, he is not doing a very good job. He is consistently late for work in the morning and disappears for long periods during the day. The letters he has typed for you are full of errors. He does not seem to be comfortable with the computer, even though most of your company's internal communication is handled by E-mail. And finally, and most frustrating, he has never returned a project you have given him by the deadline. You have spoken with him about these problems, but they still persist. Write a letter to Darryl with the objective of motivating him to change his work habits.

6. ***Request for Adjustment.*** Several months ago, you bought a Brown-Rite toaster from a local retailer. After a month, the toaster stopped working properly, not browning the bread without toasting it several times. You returned the toaster but were told that you could only exchange it for another of the same kind. Therefore, you took a new toaster of the same kind and hoped for the best. Unfortunately, this toaster worked for only 3 weeks. You returned it again and asked for a refund, or at least an exchange for a different brand. You were told that you could only get another of the same kind. You took a third toaster home and tried it again. After a month, you had the same problem with this third toaster. By this time, you are frustrated and angry. The manager of the retail store will not give you a refund because of "policy," and neither will he let you exchange it for another brand. Write a letter to the president of this large department store asking for a full refund and anything else you think is appropriate for your inconvenience.

7. ***Evaluate the Opening Paragraphs in the Following Claims Letters for Effectiveness.***

a. In line with your policy on consumer satisfaction published in your recent catalog, I am requesting a cash refund of $45.38 for a toaster I purchased 2 weeks ago for cash. The reason I have directed this request to your office is that your department manager said such a refund would not be possible. [*Written to the adjustment department manager.*]

b. In the past year I have ordered nearly $200 in goods from your store, by mail. Two weeks ago I came there in person and bought a gray overcoat. As I was heavily loaded with packages, I asked the clerk to send the garment to me by store delivery. When the overcoat arrived, I was busy and so I didn't open the package until 2 days ago.

c. Never in my life have I been treated so rudely as I was the other day in your store, by two jerks you call employees. I tell you, the way I was in-

sulted gave me a good indication of what kind of people you're hiring these days. I'm so mad-I will never go back to your store again.

8. ***Evaluate the Following Letters for Tone, Organization, Clarity, Accuracy, and Effectiveness.***

   a. *From a business firm in Detroit to an airfreight corporation in Pittsburgh:*

   Re your airbill #54663, we orginally shipped this same amount of mdse. to Cincinnati UPS (United Parcel Service), got overnight delivery, and it cost only $15. Now, your shipment from Cincinnati to us took over 15 days to get to us, and you want $48.36. Now, if you want to rebill and charge ICC surface rates, we will pay you, but if you think 15-day delivery is air express . . . better check the rubber bands on your airplanes or start feeding those pigeons better.

   b. *From a landlord to apartment tenants:*

   It seems some of your typing late at night disturbs some tenants. Perhaps when all is quiet, it is easier to hear.

   I was wondering if you type on the nook table-as that is bad because the table is fastened to the building. A felt pad will help if you do not already have one. The university bookstore has them just for that purpose.

   I know your typing is very important to your schoolwork; however, I would like to keep everyone happy.

9. ***Letter—Incorrect Billing by Fast Freight Corp.*** You are the accounting department manager of Hanson's Flowers, a reputable florist. Today, April 5, you received a $106.50 bill from Fast Freight Corporation, 947 Columbus Building, Indianapolis, IN 46288-3344. The bill shows two deliveries—airbills #18694 and #25479—unpaid since January 20 and February 9, respectively. You have canceled checks and invoices showing that both these shipments were paid when delivery was made. In fact, your firm always pays freight when it arrives. You resent the computerized statement across the bottom of today's bill: "THIS IS OUR FINAL REQUEST BEFORE REFERRING THIS TO A COLLECTION AGENCY. REMIT NOW." This is the first billing you have received. Your firm's general manager has decided that as of today he is switching to another airfreight company that is more careful in their bookeeping. He says that any company this careless in keeping records probably is just as careless in handling freight. Write the general manager of Fast Freight Corporation after you have determined your purpose and what evidence you need to enclose with your message. Remember to use good judgment in the tone, organization, and content of your letter.

Capsule Checklists for Persuasive Requests*

A
Persuasive Requests—General Plan

1. Attention (*promise; start*)
   a. Introduction of relevant reader-benefit or reader-interest theme—centered on reader, not on writer's organization
   b. Envelopes and letterheads sometimes specially designed for the message

2. Interest (*picture; chain*)
   a. Introduction of project, product, service, or problem; description; central selling point
   b. Appeals—direct or indirect reader benefits: appreciation, approval, beauty, cleanliness, comfort, convenience, cooperation, customer satisfaction, distinctiveness, durability, efficiency, enjoyment, entertainment, extra earnings, fair treatment, friendships, good reputation, health, improvement, love of home and others, money and other valuables, peace of mind, pleasure, popularity, position, profits, recognition, relief from fear, safety, satisfaction of helping others, savings, self-preservation, and others

3. Desire (*prove; chain*)
   a. Development of description, benefits, central selling point, request, appeals; perhaps with an enclosure
   b. Appropriate handling of possible objections
   c. Conviction
      (1) "Outside" proof; perhaps with enclosures
      (2) Price and terms when needed and appropriate; perhaps in enclosure

B
Persuasive Requests for Favors

1. Attention
   a. Sincere compliment
   b. Questions
   c. Agreeable comment or assertion
   d. Basic problem
   e. What has been done about a problem
   f. Frank admission of a favor

2. Interest
3. Desire
   a. Necessary physical description of project
   b. Facts, figures, and reader benefits to convince reader that his or her contribution will be enjoyable, easy, important, beneficial—directly or indirectly
      (1) In request for speaker: date, day, hour; place; function; topic; talk length; audience size, interests; honorarium; expenses; special attractions; appeals
      (2) In requests for donation: problem; needs; past, present methods of meeting needs; costs; reader contribution; benefits; appeals
      (3) In request for cooperation: problem; facts, suggestions, committee, etc., to help meet goal; reader's part; benefits; appeals
   c. Positive handling of negatives and probable objections for favors that:
      (1) Require time, knowledge, or effort
      (2) Ask donations of money or other valuables
      (3) Urge cooperation on goals and projects
   d. Enclosures (brochures)

C
Other Persuasive Requests for Adjustment, Credit, or Changes

1. Attention
   a. Preferably an agreeable assertion or a principle used as major premise
   b. Sincere compliment
   c. Question
   d. Basic problem
   e. Frank admission of a favor

2. Interest
3. Desire
   a. All necessary facts and details pertaining to request for adjustment, credit, or changes in policy or performance—interwoven with reader benefits and appeals (as in A.2.b)
   b. Description as needed by the reader to see that his or her firm is responsible (if applicable) and that the request is factual, logical, and reasonable

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.

Capsule Checklists for Persuasive Requests (*Continued*)*

A	B	C
Persuasive Requests—General Plan	**Persuasive Requests for Favors**	**Other Persuasive Requests for Adjustment, Credit, or Changes**
4. Action (*push, hook*) a. CSAD† b. EA‡ c. DA when desirable§ d. Special inducement when desirable e. RB¶ (often tied in with opening statement)	4. Action a. CSAD† b. EA‡ c. DA when desirable§ d. Special inducement when desirable e. RB¶ (often tied in with opening statement)	4. Action a. Logical conclusion based on the major premise and the clearly stated facts; then same as B.4

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.
†CSAD = clear statement of action desired.
‡EA = easy action.
§DA = dated action, if desirable.
¶RB = reader benefit.

PART FIVE

Written Communication: Reports

Chapter 11 Short Reports

Chapter 12 Long (Formal) Reports

Chapter 13 Proposals

Chapter 11

Short Reports

I. Suggestions for Short Reports
   A. Developing the Main Sections
   B. Outlining the Major Sections
   C. Including Other Desirable Sections

II. Informational Memorandum Reports
   A. Conference Reports
   B. Progress Reports
   C. Periodic Reports

III. Analytical Memorandum Reports
   A. Steps in Preparing an Analytical Personnel Report
   B. Recommendation-Justification Reports

IV. Letter Reports—Informational and Analytical
   A. Informational Letter Reports
   B. Analytical Letter Reports

V. Summary

VI. Exercises and Problems

Short reports are both a bane and a blessing: Busy executives dislike the number of short reports, yet they like them because they are *short.* Even President Lincoln asked members of his cabinet to give him short written reports; then he could review their remarks—and weigh the options.

Short reports, then, inform and analyze; they are often presented in memorandum form. A short report is concise, accurate, unbiased, all inferences depending on supporting evidence to help readers make an informed decision. Chapter 6 is a general guide for planning and organizing effective business messages, regardless of their length. Short reports need less detailed introductions, numerous transitions, abundant visuals (see Appendix A), elaborate headings, involved appendixes, micro subdivisions, and excessive formality. Short reports therefore are often used in business communication; some are even sent via E-mail.

This chapter begins with basic suggestions for short reports: *developing* and *outlining* the main sections and noting other possible *inclusions.* Next is a discussion of the memorandum format for *informational* and *analytical* reports. The chapter ends with suggestions for the informative and analytical *letter report.*

SUGGESTIONS FOR SHORT REPORTS

Developing the Main Sections

As with oral communication, the short report includes an introduction, body (or discussion, or text), and terminal section (summary, conclusions, recommendations). Checklist 11.1 is an overview of those three sections.

Outlining the Major Sections

Report outlines may be the basis for headings within the report.

After you decide what the major sections of your report will be, devote time to your headings and subheadings. (Our comments here are also applicable to long reports, as explained in the following chapter.) Of course your outline will help you see the relationship between topics, enable you to compare proportions and headings, and let you check for loopholes and logical order. In organizing your outline, you must determine the types of headings, the degrees of headings, and the parallelism in the headings you will use.

Types of Headings

You can choose from *topic, complete sentence, imperative sentence,* or *variant* headings. Topic headings are the most commonly used.

Topic Headings	Alternative	
History	History of the Problem	(*Use nouns or short phrases.*)
Background	Background Issues	

Checklist 11.1 Developing the Main Sections of Short Reports

1. Introduction
   a. Some of these elements (defined in Chapter 6) may be included if desirable: purpose or aim (always), authorization, sources, scope, definitions, background, limits, brief mention of results, list of topics (layout) to be discussed.
   b. If a report's introductory elements are stated in one or two short paragraphs at the beginning, the title "Introduction" is usually omitted.

2. Body (discussion, text)
   a. *Present all relevant facts accurately and impartially.* Do not let your personal feelings and prejudices affect the facts.
   b. *Organize* your report by the inductive plan or the deductive plan; western businesspeople prefer the deductive method.
   c. *Emphasize important ideas* by showing details, placing them in prominent positions (with the highest degrees of headings that are appropriate), and using stylistic means such as capitalization, underscoring, boldface, italics, more space, and repetition.
   d. *Include visual aids*—graphs, tables, pictures—whenever they will help clarify information for your readers (or listeners).
   e. *Use headings* to guide the reader through the report, but write your sentences and paragraphs so they can stand alone—as if the headings did not exist. In short reports use no more than two or three degrees (levels) of headings.
   f. *Use topic sentences* for most paragraphs, and *use an introductory paragraph at the beginning of a major section* that contains two or more subdivisions.
   g. *Apply the seven-C writing principles.* Throughout, make your writing easy to read. Use understandable words, sentences averaging 16 to 20 words in length, concrete nouns, few adverbs, few adjectives, and paragraphs whose average length is about seven typewritten lines.

3. Terminal section (summary, conclusions, recommendations)
   a. Remember that *a summary condenses the text, conclusions evaluate and infer from the text, and recommendations offer specific courses of action.*
   b. *Do not include any new material* in the terminal section of the report.
   c. Usually *list summary points in the same order as topics are discussed* in the text.

Complete Sentence Heading	Alternative	
Preparation Is Essential When Outlining	Writers Should Take Time When Preparing for Outlining	(*Include a subject and verb.*)

Imperative Sentence Heading	Alternative	
Take Time to Outline	Prepare Ideas Before Writing	(*Begin with a verb; subject can be omitted because "you" is understood.*)

Variant Heading	Alternative	
Taking Time to Outline	Preparing Before Outlining	(*Could begin with a participle.*)

Formats of Outlines

After you determine the wording for your headings, next choose a way to show the degrees of importance for your ideas. Three options are available.

Numerals and letters are popular in U.S. reports.

Numeral-letter combination is popular in businesses and schools. Less popular in U.S. businesses is the *decimal system,* occasionally favored by foreign companies and used in scientific and technical reports. The *letter-numerical combination* is used by those who prefer letters before main headings and do not need in their reports the additional degree that is possible with Roman numerals. Figure 11.1 shows three common ways to number heading degrees.

Some writers place their first-degree headings in the middle of the page: in capital letters, in boldface type. Others use different options. Your authors, for example, used a similar format when preparing the manuscript for this text:

First-Degree Headings
(*Capital letters, placed at left margin*)

Second-Degree Headings
(*Bold, left margin, with prose beneath beginning at left margin*)

Third-Degree Headings
(*Indented, with prose beneath beginning at left margin*)

Be consistent in heading format throughout the report.

Fourth-Degree Headings
(*Indented and underlined, with prose beneath beginning on same line as fourth-degree heading*)

Fifth-Degree Headings
(*Indented, with prose beginning on same line as fifth-degree heading*)

	Degree of Heading	Numeral-Letter Combination	Decimal System	Letter-Numeral Combination
Introduction	1st	I.	1.0	A.
	2d	A.	1.1	1.
	2d	B.	1.2	2.
	1st	II.	2.0	B.
	2d	A.	2.1	1.
	3d	1.	2.11	a.
	3d	2.	2.12	b.
	2d	B.	2.2	2.
	3d	1.	2.21	a.
	3d	2.	2.22	b.
	4th	a.	2.221	(1)
	4th	b.	2.222	(2)
	5th	(1)	2.2221	(a)
	5th	(2)	2.2222	(b)
	1st	III.	3.0	C.
	2d	A.	3.1	1.
	3d	1.	3.11	a.
Text/ Discussion	3d	2.	3.12	b.
	2d	B.	3.2	2.
	3d	1.	3.21	a.
	3d	2.	3.22	b.
	1st	IV.	4.0	D.
	2d	A.	4.1	1.
	3d	1.	4.11	a.
	3d	2.	4.12	b.
	2d	B.	4.2	2.
	3d	1.	4.21	a.
	3d	2.	4.22	b.
Summary/ Conclusions/ Recommendations	1st	V.	5.0	E.
	2d	A.	5.1	1.
	2d	B.	5.2	2.

Figure 11.1 Three ways to indicate heading degrees in report outlines.

There is little magic in using the above scheme. What *is* important, however, is consistency. Once you select a scheme to indicate levels of topic importance, stay with that format throughout your report. (See Checklist 11.2.)

Parallelism in Headings

For parallel—and consistent—construction, all headings of the same degree within any part of an outline should be parallel to one another. That is, they should have the same grammatical form: all nouns, all phrases, or all clauses or sentences.

Checklist 11.2 Five Cautions Regarding Headings and Subheadings

1. Place the most important ideas in the highest degree of headings.
2. Try to balance the sections regarding the number of headings. For instance, if one section had nine subsections and another section had none, the proportion would be lopsided.
3. Have at least two subheadings if you divide any topic; for example, if you have A.1, you need A.2, never A.1 alone.
4. Use about three to seven main points in a report. Too many or too few could be annoying to the reader.
5. Avoid using the report title as a section heading.

Parallel (All Topic Headings—Phrases)	Parallel (All Imperative Sentence Headings)	Not Parallel (Topic, Variant, and Sentence Headings)
Kinds of headings	Choose heading types	Heading types
Formats of outlines	Select outline formats	Selecting outline formats
Purposes of report	Maintain current reports	Reports must be current

Including Other Desirable Sections

Many short reports are in memorandum format, the most-used form in internal business communication.

Often the short report is in memorandum form. Other forms may be a letter or a shortened form of a long report. Memorandum and letter reports often use a subject line, often restated in the introduction, before moving to the body of the report. A shortened formal report may have prefatory and supplementary parts as well. Visuals may also be used (see Appendix A), but too many may add unnecessary length to a short report.

Subject Line

Short, precise, subject lines often include a verb to give immediate sense of direction to the reader.

For directional clarity, consider adding a verb in the subject line. In so doing, you give the reader an immediate up-front sense of direction for the deductive, direct report. Some companies have a preprinted form for memorandums, in which little space is left for a subject line; they may therefore prefer a brief subject line, permitting the idea to be developed in the document. Contrast the following examples:

Brief Subject Line	More Complete Subject Line
Recent changes	Retirement age changes in Brazil's labor code [*inform*]
Intellectual property	Suggestions for informing Brazil's courts on matters of intellectual property rights [*inform and analysis*]

Communication Probe

Courses in report writing—rated highly by business graduates—are similar to, yet in some respects different from, the report writing requirements of other professionals. Let's face it: Not all business students enter the world of business; some will be professionals in other areas of work. One such area growing across the country is social work. Here is a "business" geared to helping people—a working environment aimed at improving the lives of others. Social workers, for instance, write many reports. Yet, the kind of reports demanded in their world of work is similar to the types discussed in this chapter: observational reports, interview reports, and summary projects. One researcher has concluded that three cautions are applicable to social workers: Avoid judgmental tone; decrease use of the passive; and use more parallelism. All these suggestions are also applicable to the report writer in the world of business.

Reep, D. C. (1989, March). Report writing for social workers: Special needs in the business communication course. *The Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication, 52*(1), 29–31.

Brief Subject Line	More Complete Subject Line
LEXIS services	Recommended changes in our using company's subscription to LEXIS services [*analysis and persuasion*]
Attrition	Report on employee turnover [*inform*]

Prefatory and Supplemental Parts

Including some visual elements of a long report can improve the visual persuasion of a short report.

In some situations a short, comprehensive, important memo report or letter report is more impressive if it has some of the prominent features of a long report. If your report is, for example, five or six single-spaced typewritten pages long and has several attachments, consider using a title page, a transmittal letter or memo, the report body (typed in single or double space), plus an appendix for the attachments. In the appendix put material that belongs in the report but would clutter the text and is not vital to its development or presentation.

Using Visuals

Often, the longer the report, the more visuals. However, if you have extensive statistics in a short report, some of that data may be clarified by using the traditional three types of charts: pie, bar, and line. (See Appendix A for a discussion of visuals and examples that illustrate their use in either written or oral communication.) Our suggestion is this: In a short report, use visuals sparingly. If you do use them, it is your choice whether to include them in the text proper or as supplementary material.

INFORMATIONAL MEMORANDUM REPORTS

The central purpose of informational reports is to inform and to summarize information, similar to the speech to inform (Chapter 15). Obviously, these reports vary widely in content, depending on type of business, purpose, topics discussed, and readers' needs. Although there are many kinds of informational reports, the following examples illustrate three general kinds often used in organizations: conference reports, progress reports, and periodic reports.

Conference Reports

Topics for conference reports range from summaries of personal sales call conferences to write-ups of meetings attended by hundreds of persons. For example, an advertising account executive may write a conference report (contact report) after every meeting or phone call between the ad agency and a client. Its purpose is to record all decisions and discussions. A credit or collection manager or account executive may make similar reports after conferences with clients. Likewise, many other employees as well as executives may be responsible for writing reports after any significant conferences with individuals or committees. *The text of such reports is usually organized by topics discussed or presented simply in a chronological progression.* Some firms have standardized headings for the often-written reports to ensure that the same information or main topics are recorded in all of them.

How you organize your material is closely related to your content; try to link content and form.

In Report 1, which follows, assistant sales manager arranges *by order of time.* This report—to the sales manager—uses first-, second-, and third-degree headings.

Communication Probe

Although this text focuses on three macro divisions of report writing (conference reports, progress reports, and periodic reports), it is still the memorandum and letter that carry the burden of written business communication. One study concluded that those two forms were the most used in on-the-job writing, followed by step-by-step instructions, general instructions, forms to be filled out, and proposals. Another study supports the memorandum-letter dominance, but suggests that reports within a bank, for instance, were of this nature: reports of telephone calls, memos requesting services or information, reports of investigations, reports about a prospective client, and others. We infer that the memorandum is heavily used as the major format for shorter reports.

Anderson, P. (1985). What survey research tells us about writing at work. In L. Odell & D. Goswami (eds.), *Writing in nonacademic settings* (pp. 3–83). New York: Guilford Press. Redish, J. (1989); Writing in organizations. In M. Kogen (ed.), *Writing in the business professions* (pp. 97–124). Urbana, IL: National Council of Teachers of English.

MEMO REPORT 1 *Assistant sales manager's report on regional conference organized by topics.*

TO: Martha Cook
FROM: Andrew Weichman
DATE: April 10, 199-
SUBJECT: Report on Open Houses and XL Promotion Programs

The following is a report on the items we discussed during our April 10 meeting in [*city*] regarding our XL product. Topics pertain to the scheduled open houses and our promotional programs. The names of those who were asked and agreed to be responsible for the various parts of these plans are listed in the right-hand column below.

EVENTS AND PROGRESS

Open House

Here is the tentative schedule that was established for three events.

Employees' Meeting-Thursday, July 30. Families will be invited and sandwiches and refreshments provided. — Ruth Aprill

Ribbon-Cutting Ceremony-Friday, July 31. Dignitaries to be invited need to be agreed upon. We generally agreed that this occasion presents an exceptional opportunity to publicize the growth of new and nonpolluting industry in our state. . . — Jack Donaldson

Promotional Programs

The discussion regarding our Promotional Programs focused on two brochures, an advertising and direct-mail campaign, and identification signs.

The XL Product Brochure. After we reviewed this product brochure, relatively minor changes were agreed upon. Another draft will be sent to Bill Campbell for approval before setting type. — Bill Campbell

Introduction Brochure. We agreed that a brochure to familiarize our customers with the operation of the XL will be desirable. We agreed that the — Erick Brown

procedure used formerly in materials, showing photographs of the various personnel, will be a good approach. . .

SUMMARY

The following open houses have been tentatively scheduled for these dates: July 30-Employees' Meeting; July 31-Ribbon-Cutting Ceremony; and August 1-Distributor Event.

The promotional program is to include: a slightly changed XL product brochure, an introduction brochure, expanded advertising and direct mail, and special signs for XL products plus buildings and property. . .

c: Aprill, Brown, Campbell, Donaldson

MEMO REPORT 2 *A conference report organized by sources.*

TO: Dan Johns Date: October 16, 199-
FROM: Roy Weber
SUBJECT: Summary of Singapore Training Planning Conference

My attendance at the Singapore Training Conference took place over two days, September 12 and 13, at the Park View Hotel. Our format included presentations by each of the regional training directors followed by discussions. The following report summarizes the comments of the regional training directors.

Ms. Olive Reardon's Opening Statement

Ms. Reardon opened the conference, introduced the regional directors, and set the following goals for the meeting:

1. Determine the needs assessments of employees from each of the regions produced.

2. List suggestions for which new courses now on the market would meet those needs.

3. Get information from the United States as to which of their courses might fit into our Asian culture and our individual subsidiaries.

Mr. T.K. Lam's Report

Representing Korea, Mr. Lam handed out a printed report of his employee needs assessment. . . . He concluded with suggestions for new courses to meet the needs expressed by employees in his country.

[Additional statistical data presented along with course listings.]

Ms. Charlotte Lim's Report

Ms. Lim indicated that she has previously sent her report concerning Hong Kong in advance and thus had only new course suggestions to make.

[*A listing of the three new courses followed.*]

Ms. Olive Reardon

After discussions, Ms. Reardon concluded the sessions with a plan of action which could be followed for the next six months:

[*Included was a listing of six suggestions.*]

Progress Reports

Most progress reports move inductively, via the organizational structure of what is topical or chronological.

As the name implies, progress reports show "progress," accomplishments, or activity over time or at a given stage of a major assignment. The organizational plan is usually inductive, including topics similar to these:

- Introduction (purpose, nature of project)
- Description of accomplishments during the reporting period
- Unanticipated problems (if any)
- Plans for the next reporting period
- Summary (overall appraisal of progress to date)

Following is a report submitted on behalf of the chairperson of a governmental committee asked to investigate what the position of the United States should be regarding high-definition television (HDTV). The committee simply supplies information and concludes without offering a recommendation. In short, the report is informative, using second-, third-, and fourth-degree headings.

MEMO REPORT 3 *An inductive report [shortened example].*

Date: 16 July 199-

TO: Carl Fornell, Vice President
FROM: Shirley Adams, Chairperson
SUBJECT: Progress report on options that the U.S. government might consider for HDTV (high-definition television)

On behalf of the HDTV committee we present this progress report on the question: What should the U.S. policy be regarding the future of HDTV?

Background and History

Development of HDTV began in Japan over 20 years ago as a joint effort between NHK (Japan Broadcast Corporation), Sony, Panasonic, and Ikegami. Their intent was to increase the number of lines of reso-

lution to 1,125, a system incompatible with the U.S. system. . .

Europe sought to improve transmission using existing TV systems and decided to develop HDTV over time. Their approach was to use the Multiplex Analog Converter (MAC) compatible with existing television sets. . .

Possible Influence of HDTV on the U.S. Economy

The issue of U.S. participation in the HDTV market has attracted the attention of U.S. policy makers, broadcasters, and electronic companies for two reasons:

Technological issues

1. HDTV-related integrated circuits
   [*details and statistics*]

2. Large picture displays
   [*details and statisics*]

3. New manufacturing technologies
   [*details and statistics*]

4. Broadband switching technologies
   [*details and statistics*]

Commercial and trade issues

Options Available to the United States

United States policy makers have a high-tech dilemma on their hands. Many electronic industry analysts think HDTV will be to the nineties what computers were to the eighties. Thus, a central question is, which system should the States use and begin developing?

Foreign standards

1. The Japanese system . . .
2. The European system . . .

U.S. standards

Evaluation of U.S. Options

1. Develop its own American-based technology via a consortium

Considering many criteria, one of the options available to the United States is to develop a

consortium of companies that already produce high-quality electronic products. Such a "helping hand" allows a pooling of money and resources. . .

2. Adopt foreign standards

To not develop a system in the States will allow foreign nations to determine the future direction of HDTV, and therby to remove jobs from the United States. To accept a foreign pattern would increase the speed of development in the United States. The decision involves viewing either the Japanese or European models . . .

3. Do nothing

According to researchers, HDTV will revolutionize the electronic industry. And following this pattern will decrease the amount of up-front funds needed for research and development. . .

Summary

Our report began with viewing the history and background of HDTV. Out of that history arose implications for U.S. industries and their effect on four commercial areas. Of course the question to be answered is this: Which of several transmission systems should the United States adopt? We viewed the major foreign standards and considered standards suggested by the Americans, the Japanese, and the Europeans. . . . We conclude our task by noting that we have simply informed; the ultimate direction for U.S. participation in HDTV is left up to the policy committee.

Periodic Reports

Periodic reports are as numerous as there are business organizations; it is more important to know what they do rather than what they are called.

Some periodic reports are written to correspond to the company's fiscal year. Others may be written weekly, monthly, quarterly, or annually, or in other regular recurring periods.

When a memorandum report is written each month about the same department and to the same readers, an introduction and terminal section are unnecessary. Many business firms use printed forms and standardized headings for the text section of such reports.

One company's chief executive officer—who shall remain nameless—insisted that all foreign subsidiaries reporting to the home office in the States limit their quarterly report to *one page.* In fact, the report could be done in half a page if the news was favorable; if unfavorable, one page. And then writers were to include only the reasons for the unfavorable situation and the way it was being handled.

Most organizations—business, government, religious, athletic, and even business schools—write annual reports to summarize activities and financial af-

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A key word today in writing is the term *collaborative.* Even though no definition is accepted unanimously, the process may involve planning the document and peer review before and during the construction of a manuscript. The end product should result in a document produced by a group of individuals. Although much of one's writing is solo, suggestions for producing reports—and the kind of reports—apply as well to work produced collaboratively. Research suggests that as many as 74 percent of technical and professional writers worked collaboratively, and as many as 87 percent of writers in a workplace concluded that they sometimes wrote collaboratively. Therefore, collaborative writing plays a role in producing a report.

Faigley, L., & Miller, T.P. (1982). What we learn from writing on the job. *College English, 44,* 557–569. Ede, L., & Lunsford, A. (1986). Collaborative learning: Lessons from the world of work. *Journal of the Council of Writing Program Administrators, 9,* 3, 20.

fairs. For some small concerns the report is exceptionally short, consisting of perhaps a brief transmitted letter with one or two pages of financial statements. For other organizations, especially corporations that must report to their stockholders, the annual report may begin with a top official's letter report. Sometimes the letter is the entire report (perhaps eight or more pages). If not, then the report body discusses operations and activities. Checklist 11.3 gives general guidelines for preparing informational reports.

Checklist 11.3 Informational Reports

1. Be aware of the purpose: Determine whether the person requesting your report wants to make the decision or a recommendation from you.
   - **a.** You offer no recommendation.
   - **b.** You offer a recommendation.

2. Know how to conclude: Ask yourself: Will I simply summarize (a review of what was covered), or will I end with judgments, conclusions (inferences from the presented data)?
   - **a.** You summarize.
   - **b.** You conclude.

3. Use neutral, unbiased language: Is your language nonjudgmental, or does it betray a firm point of view?
   - **a.** You are neutral in word choice.
   - **b.** You choose persuasive words, sentences.

ANALYTICAL MEMORANDUM REPORTS

A pure analytical report has one central purpose: To analyze a situation or issue.

Informational memorandum reports search out and make known to the reader data and evidence. Those reports clarify; they try to omit a recommendation. An analytical memorandum report, now to be discussed, seeks to analyze a situation or problem; it may end with or without a specific recommendation. Our following detailed discussion suggests a step-by-step analysis of a personnel situation, ending with a conclusion without a recommendation. Thereafter, three ways of organizing a recommendation-justification report are illustrated.

Steps in Preparing an Analytical Personnel Report

The Helen True case is illustrative of the genre of most analytical reports: Analyze, analyze, analyze. Then know the wishes of the report requester: Does he or she desire a recommendation or not?

Assume that Gene Mohr, manager of your bank's head office savings department, has asked you (assistant manager of the personnel department) to help find a replacement for a teller who is quitting work and moving to another city. Fifteen people applied for the job. Ultimately, you narrowed your list to the five best applicants. Then you wrote to their references for recommendations. After receiving the replies, you chose the three best-qualified candidates. Your task now is to evaluate each of the three in a memo report to Mr. Mohr. He likes you to analyze the facts for him—and rank the applicants—but he wants to make his own recommendations and decision. Here are the facts about the three applicants:

Helen True: One year of business college; high school graduate with a 3.0 (out of a possible 4.0) grade-point average; completed in high school an office machines course with a grade of B; typing, 60 words per minute; arithmetic aptitude, excellent; neatly groomed for business appearance; excellent references—"highly dependable, courteous, and honest"; excellent health; 11 years of business experience—all with one company.

James Mace: High school graduate with a 2.6 GPA; completed in high school an office machines course with a grade of C; typing, 50 wpm; arithmetic aptitude, good; fairly neat and well-groomed; good references—"dependable, tactful"; good health; 6 years of business experience with two different firms; two years' military service.

Beth Astor: One year at the local four-year university, with a 3.1 GPA; high school graduate with a 3.2 GPA; completed in high school an office machines course with a grade of A; typing, 65 wpm; arithmetic aptitude, excellent; very neat, well-groomed; references—"good worker but has difficulty getting along with others"; fair health; 3 years' business experience with three different firms; attendance irregular in 2.

With all these figures facing you, where do you begin? One way is to group these facts under headings representing the *criteria* (Chapter 10) you will be using to measure the three people's qualifications. Notice that if you merely group them by their names as in the above list, comparisons are difficult. After some juggling, you decide that all the data fall under the headings of "Education and Skills," "Personal Qualifications," or "Probable Permanency with Bank." (Many times, when organizing, you have material that could fit under more than

Communication Probe

As an adjunct to justification, persuasive writing, it is interesting to note that when asked to defend their positions orally, men displayed a more argumentative attitude than women. That is, based on gender, females were less prone to advocate positions on controversial issues or verbally attack others. Furthermore, in a related study (Infante and Gorden, 1985), this same predisposition toward argumentativeness was perceived favorably by both superiors and subordinates: the perceived credibility of the individual in the workplace increased.

Darus, H. J. (1994, June). Argumentativeness in the workplace: A trait by situation study. *Communication Research Reports, 11*(1), 99–106. See also Infante, D. A., & Gorden, W. I. (1985). Superiors' argumentativeness and verbal argumentativeness and verbal aggressiveness as predictors of subordinates' satisfaction. *Human Communication Research, 12,* 117–125.

one heading: Health is an example. So you organize such material the best way you can; in this report it can fit under "Personal Qualifications" or "Probable Permanency with Firm.") You can now arrange the backgrounds of the three applicants in a working table like the following, in rough-draft form:

	True	Mace	Astor
	Education and Skills		
Education	High school graduate 1 year business college	High school graduate	High school graduate 1 year at university
Grade point	3.0	2.6	3.2 in high school 3.1 at university
Arithmetic aptitude	Excellent	Good	Excellent
Typing	60 wpm	50 wpm	65 wpm
High school grade in machines	Grade B	Grade C	Grade A
	Personal Qualifications		
Appearance	Neat and well-groomed	Fairly neat; well-groomed	Very neat and well-groomed
Dependability	Excellent	Good	Fair; but good worker
Compatibility	Excellent	Good	Fair; difficulty working with others

Probable Permanency with Bank

Number of jobs	1	2	3
Years of work	11	6 plus 2 military	3
Health	Excellent	Good	Fair
Attendance record	Excellent	Good	Fair (irregular in two firms)

Now you can begin to analyze and interpret the material. Suppose your interpretation results in the following ranks and points for these candidates (assuming you decide to assign 6 points for first place, 4 points for second place, and 2 points for third place):

	True		Mace		Astor	
Criterion	Rank	Points	Rank	Points	Rank	Points
Education and skills	2	4	3	2	1	6
Personal qualifications	1	6	2	4	3	2
Probable permanency	1	6	2	4	3	2
Total score		16		10		10

From this analysis Helen True wins first place, and although Mace and Astor are tied for second place in scores, it is obvious that Mace is ahead of Astor in two of three criteria. Thus he wins second place, and Astor third.

Your next step will be to write the report, in rough draft. Then you will edit it and revise wherever desirable. You will use the inductive organizational plan because Mr. Mohr told you he preferred that plan for all memo reports.

With that groundwork completed, you begin to write—first the *subject line*, which should contain no more than five to seven words, preferably. You decide on "Evaluation of Three Teller Applicants." Then you write the introduction, next the major divisions of the text, and finally the terminal section.

Introduction

The following list of introductory elements could be included in this particular report:

Element	Comment
Authorization	Mr. Mohr asked you to assume the assignment.
Purpose	To evaluate the three applicants' qualifications for one opening as teller.
Background	From 15 applicants you selected 3.
Methodology sources	You used application blanks, test scores, your own interview notes, and recommendations from references.
Plan of presentation	You will develop the text according to the three criteria for a teller.

Brief statement of your decision	Optional. You may tell Mr. Mohr that Ms. True ranks highest of the three candidates, or wait to tell this in the terminal section. Your choice will depend on what you think Mr. Mohr prefers.

When you put these five elements into words and sentences, you might have an introductory paragraph such as one of the following:

> On July 25 you asked that I prepare an evaluation of candidates for the position of your retiring teller. That analysis is complete, and the following report is my response. On the basis of four criteria (company test scores, screening of initial applications, personal interview with each applicant, and recommendations from references), 3 candidates have been chosen from the 15 who applied. In evaluating the candidates, I have placed major emphasis on (1) education and skills, (2) personal qualifications, and (3) probable permanency. In view of my analysis, Ms. True ranks high for consideration.

[*For the reader who will resist your deductively stated decision, you may wish to move inductively, as in the following:*]

> Following these opening comments is the report you requested on July 25 concerning the evaluation of candidates for a teller as a replacement for the employee who is resigning. Four criteria were used in selecting the final candidates: company test scores, screening of initial applicants, personal interview with each candidate, and recommendations from references. Three of the fifteen applicants met these criteria: Ms. Helen True, Mr. James Mace, and Miss Beth Astor. Additionally, on the basis of their education and skills, personal qualifications, and probable permanency, these names come to you for consideration as probable employees with our bank.

Main Divisions of the Body or Text

You will use three main sections for your text—one for each criterion. You will study the working table and analyze the facts. If your reader wants all the details, you will include each table section or a variation of it within the text. Assume that you now decide to change the sequence of the sections within the table. "Probable Permanency" will be placed first; "Education and Skills," second; "Personal Qualifications," third.

The following discussion concentrates on the section labeled "Probable Permanency." Your procedure for the other two sections will of course be similar. What are the most important facts you can pull from the table? Avoid saying in sentence form before or after a table everything that is already in the table; repe-

tition wastes time and is monotonous. After careful thought you might write a paragraph such as this to place before the table:

> Ms. Helen True's experience and her previous job responsibilities show a background and future potential for a greater degree of permanence with our organization than either Mr. Mace or Ms. Astor. The following table shows that both Mr. Mace and Ms. Astor might have a greater tendency to leave, since they have less stable past employment records and they do not possess the excellent health that is preferable for the teller work.

After the table you might include such comments as:

> Mr. Mace rates as a second choice. His two jobs in 6 years and good health are a better record than that for Ms. Astor. Also in his favor is the fact that he plans to make a career of working with people.

Terminal (Closing) Section

Clearly, you now face the decision of whether to choose a summary (condensation of information) or conclusions (evaluation and inferences). Adhere to Mr. Mohr's preference! Remember, he asked you to present your evaluation, but he clearly wants to make his own decision. Therefore, your terminal section should include conclusions, not merely a summary. Omit the recommendations.

The following illustration (Memo Report 4) shows one of several ways this completed report may be worded. It is presented on your bank's memo stationery, addressed to Mr. Gene Mohr, without his title as manager of the head office savings department. This title could, however, be included if company policy so dictates or when the organization is large enough to justify a title for clarification.

MEMO REPORT 4 *A personnel department officer's analytical report (with conclusions only) to a savings department director.*

MEMORANDUM [*bank name*]

TO: Mr. Gene Mohr DATE: March 15, 19--

FROM: [*your name*]

SUBJECT: Evaluation of Three Teller Applicants

Here is the report you requested concerning the choice of a replacement for your teller who is resigning. On the basis of information obtained from applications, test scores, personal interviews, and recommendations from references, I have selected 3 out of 15 applicants for your final consideration. Of these 3, I feel that Ms. Helen True best meets the job requirements of permanency, education and skills, and basic personal qualifications, as discussed below.

Probable Permanency

Ms. Helen True's background of experience and previous job responsibilities indicate potential for a greater degree of permanence with our organization than either Mr. Mace or Ms. Astor. The following table shows that both Mr. Mace and Ms. Astor have less stable past employment records and that they do not possess the excellent health that is preferable for the teller work.

Criterion	Helen True	James Mace	Beth Astor
Experience	11 years	6 years	3 years
Previous jobs	1 firm	2 firms	3 firms
Health	Excellent	Good	Fair
Attendance record	Excellent	Good	Fair (irregular in 2 firms)

Mr. Mace rates as second choice. His two jobs in 6 years and good health are a much better record than that for Ms. Astor. Also in his favor is the fact that he plans to make a career of working with people.

Education and Skills

On the basis of education and skills, Ms. Astor is an outstanding applicant. The table below provides facts in which Ms. Astor ranks consistently higher than the other two in education, grades, and skills.

Criterion	Helen True	James Mace	Beth Astor
Education	H.S. graduate; 1 year business college	H.S. graduate	H.S. graduate; 1 year university
Grade-point average	3.0 H.S.	2.6 H.S.	3.2 H.S.; 3.1 university
Arithmetic aptitude	Excellent	Good	Excellent
Typing	60 wpm	50 wpm	65 wpm
H.S. grade in machines	Grade B	Grade C	Grade A

Although Ms. True's results are not as high as those of Ms. Astor, she shows a more-than-adequate

proficiency in her skills. She should prove just as efficient and capable as Ms. Astor in a teller's position.

Personal Qualifications

Mainly on the basis of references from past employers, Ms. True has the personality that best fits the performance and image of the position. As the following table shows, she is the only applicant of the three who has excellent references with no additional qualifying statements by those references.

Criterion	Helen True	James Mace	Beth Astor
Dependability	Excellent	Good	Fair, but good worker
Compatibility	Excellent	Good	Fair; difficulty working with others
Appearance	Neat and well-groomed	Fairly neat; well-groomed	Very neat; well-groomed

The references of Ms. Astor are somewhat disturbing because of former employers' comments about her ability to get along with her coworkers.

Conclusions

1. Ms. Helen True is the best-qualified to fill your teller vacancy. She rates highest in degree of expected permanence and in personal qualifications for the job. Although her professional ability does not rank highest of the three applicants, she ranks second and indicates a more-than-adequate proficiency.

2. Mr. James Mace rates as a good second choice, mainly on the basis of his expected permanence and his compatibility. Although he does not rank as high on skill and grades as either of the other two applicants, his education and scores indicate that he can perform the job adequately.

3. Because of the questions raised in her references, I feel Ms. Beth Astor is definitely in third place among these three candidates for this position. Other less desirable factors are her "fair" health and the uncertainty of her permanency with our organization. Her outstanding professional ability is too greatly outweighed by these two factors.

While the above memorandum report does not specifically recommend that Ms. True be hired, Mr. Mohr could infer that recommendation. It is now his decision—in light of the presented analysis—to take final action.

Recommendation-Justification Reports

Persuasion is central to recommendation reports.

Many of your analytical reports will have a special purpose: to recommend a change or remain with the status quo (policy), support the idea that something is desirable or undesirable (value), or defend the accuracy of information (fact). Your report may be in response to a specific request, or it may be voluntary.

Consider the following four items when preparing sections of a problem-solution or recommendation report.

Introduction

Give thought to an opening line (somewhat like standing on a porch before entering a house); be precise as to the aim or purpose—this could be a restatement of the subject line—along with a brief authorization; and end with a brief statement on the report's organization (layout or road map of what you will cover) of included material. In a real sense you are laying the foundation for the report, getting started, holding attention.

Body (Text, Discussion)

Interestingly, not everyone will agree that a problem truly exists. Your task—even in the informative material in the body—is to suggest that there is a problem.

Do not move too quickly toward a solution or recommendation. First, analyze the situation or problem. Second, do not presume that everyone agrees that a problem truly exists. Thus your opening information may include evidence on the current situation, along with undesirable effects. Only after you have proved the existence of a problem can you move toward a recommendation. Headings such as the following are popular in text sections:

- Current state of the problem
- Effects and causes of the problem
- Possible options to remove the problem
- Criteria in evaluating a solution
- Recommended solution (*if requester of report desires this*)

Terminal Section (Conclusion, Recommendation)

Be brief in this section. Include a short summary of major points and the recommendations, usually numbered consecutively.

Organizational Plans

Know the wishes of your report requester: Does he or she want the recommendation up front or near the end? Most prefer up front.

Recommendation-justification reports may be organized in one of two ways. In the following examples, Memo Report 5 (deductive) and Memo Report 6 (inductive) can be used if the reader may react negatively toward a recommendation; in that case, present your facts first, then the recommendation.

The discussion section in any of these reports usually is 50 to 75 percent of the entire body.

MEMO REPORT 5 *A deductive plan; note up-front recommendation.*

TO: Board of Directors, [*company name*]
FROM: Dave Allen, Senior Vice President-Tobacco Products
SUBJECT: Recommended expansion of [*name*] into Western Samoa
DATE: June 5, 199-

RECOMMENDATION

PURCHASE THE EXISTING CIGARETTE FACTORY ON WESTERN SAMOA AS PART OF OUR PACIFIC RIM EXPANSION PLAN

INTRODUCTION

The company produces and internationally markets tobacco products, packaged food, and distilled and brewed beverages. Last year [*name*] made $1.209 billion on $15.766 billion in sales.

Today's proposal is part of our overall plan to dominate Pacific Rim tobacco markets within 5 years.

PROPOSAL

Fact: Negotiations are currently in progress that will allow U.S. tobacco companies limited access to the Chinese market within 1 to 2 years.

Fact: 50% of Chinese males smoke-a market of 439 million customers, or almost twice the population of the United States.

Strategy: Develop a tobacco industry in the Pacific Islands that will foster indigenous consumption while developing sufficient capacity to supply the Chinese market.

Criteria:
1. Find a stable political and ecological climate.
2. Ensure a consistent supply of quality leaf.
3. Locate near major trade routes.
4. Develop a model easily adaptable to other islands.

THE ISLAND OF WESTERN SAMOA MEETS THE ABOVE CRITERIA

BACKGROUND

[Included here is data on the country]

SATISFYING THE CRITERIA

1. Politically and ecologically stable . . .
2. Some leaf is already grown on Western Samoa . . .
3. Western Samoa is near several major shipping lanes . . .

RATIONALE FOR PURCHASE OF FACTORY

1. An existing factory and work force are already in place.
2. Small scale will allow for experimentation in the model.
3. Greater tobacco plants will stabilize economy.
4. Greater value of tobacco will provide more taxes.

The Company should enter into negotiations with the government of Western Samoa to purchase its cigarette factory. Using the Samoan model that we will build, [*company*] can island-hop to develop a strong tobacco trade in the Pacific Islands.

MEMO REPORT 6 *Recommendation for change in communication procedure (inductive plan).*

November 10, 199-

TO: David Bank, Unit Manager
FROM: Marianne Clauw
SUBJECT: Inefficient Communication Between Data Processing and Consulting Departments

As you requested on October 1, I have investigated the state of communication between the Consulting Department and the Data Processing (D.P.) Department. Six months ago our company formed an internal consulting department to interface between the D.P. Department and the departments that use data processing services.

Current Situation

Since the formation of the Consulting Department, the consultants have complained that their communication with D.P. personnel is inadequate. The recent relocation of the D.P. Department to Flint aggravated the problem since the consultants remain

in our Detroit office. The following are some problems that resulted.

Problems

1. The interoffice mail turnaround is approximately 3 days, which makes it inappropriate for urgent messages.
2. D.P. personnel are difficult to reach by phone because they are frequently away from their desks.
3. There is no message-taking procedure in the D.P. Department.
4. D.P. personnel state that they are unable to service user needs efficiently because the needs are not communicated in a timely fashion.

Conclusion and Recommendations

To provide efficient service to the user departments, timely communications between the consultants and the D.P. personnel are necessary. Implementing the following recommendations will facilitate quick and efficient communication between the departments.

1. Assign a receptionist to the D.P. Department to answer the phone, sort interoffice mail, and page persons who are called.
2. Strongly encourage all personnel to acknowledge phone messages and return phone calls the same day.
3. Institute special daily facsimile services to handle written communications between the D.P. Department and the Consulting Department. Also use facsimile machines daily to transmit documents between the Detroit consultants and the Flint D.P. personnel.

Guidelines for writing analytical memorandum reports are cited in Checklist 11.4 on the following page.

In summary, informational memorandum reports seek to inform; recommendation or analytical reports intend to either recommend or analyze.

LETTER REPORTS—INFORMATIONAL AND ANALYTICAL

Letter report formats are similar to traditional business letters, more often sent to persons outside the organization.

A letter report is simply a report in letter form; it is often used when sending information to a reader outside your organization. It includes:

- Date
- Inside address

Checklist 11.4 Analytical Memorandum Reports

1. Introduction
   a. Determine whether you are to recommend a solution or simply analyze a series of alternatives.
   b. Determine whether your reader desires the deductive (recommendation first) or the inductive (recommendation last) approach to reports.

2. Body (Text, Discussion)
   a. Use the suggestions for the seven-C principles discussed in Chapter 2.
   b. Use sentences about 16 to 20 words in length; sentences should consist of concrete nouns, few adjectives and adverbs. Paragraphs should be about seven typed lines in length.
   c. Use a structure similar to the traditional problem-solution format.

3. Terminal (Closing) Section
   a. If you are asked for more than one conclusion or recommendation, number them.
   b. If your evidence is well thought out, your conclusions should logically follow from that evidence.
   c. If you know or do not know the receivers of your report, end with courtesy: You would be willing to meet for further oral discussions.

- Salutation
- Body (the heart of the report)
- Complimentary close
- Signature
- Reference section

Often the letter report has a subject line, usually placed a line or two below the salutation. Its length may range from two to five (seldom more) pages. And it may have two purposes: informational or analytical.

We said that the general format of the letter report is like that of a letter. Its body (text, discussion) requires some special qualities.

1. *The first paragraph* may include some of the following elements found in an introduction:

   Pleasant greeting and authorization (*mention date and name of person making request*).
   Purpose, aim (*always*)
   Problem, issues (*if problem exists*)
   Conclusions, statement of results (*optional*)
   Layout, road map, plan of presentation (*depends on length of report*)

Communication Probe

Certainly visuals can add to the clarity of complex statistics. Additionally, there is the question of style. And regardless of the form of writing—from succinct E-mail statements to short or long reports, style can impact the finished product. Disabuse yourself of the idea that the formats and rules of writing for clarity are new. They're not. You, and your authors, who write and communicate orally in the business world and elsewhere have a historical debt to the ancient Greeks and Romans. Although their world was primarily oral, we can learn the lessons of clarity, for reports and other forms of communication, directly from them. A significant source is *Essays on Classical Rhetoric and Modern Discourse.*

See two significant statements on the impact of rhetoric. Lunsford, A. (1976, October). Classical rhetoric and technical writing. *College Composition and Communication, 27,* 289–291; Halloran, S. M., & Bradford, A. M. (1984). Figures of speech in the rhetoric of science and technology. In R. J. Connors, L. S. Ede, & A. A. Lunsford (eds.), *Essays on classical rhetoric and modern discourse* (pp. 179–192). Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press.

Examples

a. This note responds to your request of January 25 that I collect information on the plans of the German chemical company BASF expanding into Austria.

b. In response to the Executive Board's request, our committee discovered six causes for high employee turnover in our foreign subsidiaries. Likewise, we considered four options to decrease the problem. One of those options is recommended for the board's consideration.

c. Thanks for your recent fax; it was good to receive your greeting. We'll be happy to summarize our new advertising campaign-just approved-for this next fiscal year. That information is included in the following several pages.

Regardless of your reader, end politely, show a willingness to respond to further questions or to meet if that is desirable.

2. *The middle paragraphs* of the text should present objectively, without emotional appeals, all pertinent facts—both favorable and unfavorable. Sources and methods should be mentioned along with emphasis on findings or results. Headings, visual aids, and transitional sentences are also included wherever desirable.

3. *The last paragraph* brings the letter report to a pleasant, friendly close, as for letters. If you need to conclude or recommend, do so just before

the last paragraph. If appropriate, offer to discuss further or to come to the reader's office.

Informational Letter Reports

LETTER REPORT 1 *A staff report to the chief financial officer regarding issues concerning personnel turnover in the engineering department of a foreign subsidiary.*

Dear Mr. Powell:

You asked an ad hoc personnel committee here in New Zealand to address the question of how the high turnover rate in the engineering department is affecting our quality rating with the local chemical companies. Our committee has finished its review and submits the following report for your consideration.

Causes for Turnover

After four consecutive years of 20% turnover in the engineering department, we have determined that the main cause of the excessive turnover lies with compensation. . .

The following comparative table summarizes the major findings:

Salary Costs for Engineers, June 19--

Company	Low	High	Width	Average Wage	Turnover
X	$24,000	$35,000	40%	$30,000	20%
Y	$25,000	$38,000	52%	$31,500	10%
Z	$26,000	$40,000	60%	$32,500	7%
Market	$25,333	$39,333	55%	$32,333	8%

Solving Issue of Engineer Turnover

A two-step method for reducing turnover may be considered. The first is to increase the average salaries engineers receive. Considering your goal for producing a quality product, we should offer a salary to the engineers above the market rate.

These alternative levels are: 3% above market, 5% above market, or 8% above market.

[*Further details presented.*]

A possible second step is to increase the average range of the salaries for the engineers. We suggest raising it from the current $25,000-$35,000 to a new level of $30,000-$43,000. This new range maximum will allow for salary increases to the four existing engineers who have reached their current range maximum.

Benefits of Accepting the Proposal

1. Save funds needed in recruiting, training, and overtime costs. [*Statistics included*]
2. Stabilize turnover in the engineering department.
3. Place our company in a position to allow it to achieve higher-quality ratings with the local chemical companies.
4. Allow us to more actively recruit qualified personnel for the engineering department.

Conclusion

Two options are presented for your consideration: (1) increase the engineering salaries from a current range of $25,000-$35,000 to $30,000-$43,000; (2) increase the average salary of the current engineers.

[*One final paragraph concludes the letter, including courtesy comments and a willingness to respond to further questions.*]

Analytical Letter Reports

Short reports from overseas are frequently in the form of a letter report, either as hard copy or E-mail.

Often used in letter reports is the problem-solution format. For example, an outside consultant to a company is asked to investigate an issue or a perceived problem. That final report may be submitted in letter-report form. You may also represent your company on an outside board and would write that group an analytical letter report in response to a specific request. One example of an analytical letter report (deductive in format) from an American overseas follows.

LETTER REPORT 2 *An American expatriate's analytical letter on problems faced in* Germany; *the salutation is* "Dear Ted."

You asked us in your fax of April 10 to tell you what problems the eight of us faced in adapting to

Communication Probe

It is clear that when ending (inductive) or beginning (deductive) a report with a precise recommendation, persuasion is involved. Analytical reports often involve a discussion of a problem, a review of options—or alternatives—and a recommendation. Alternatives can be used persuasively. For instance, writers intending to persuade, in a report or other persuasive document, can pose two alternatives, either of which is acceptable to the writer. The receiver, says one study, is likely to choose one of those two alternatives. Clearly, the receiver may also choose the unwritten option; that is, he or she may not like either alternative. Likewise, when laying out alternatives, it is useful to consider one highly positive alternative and several nonpositive, the writer giving more positive effort to the recommendation or alternative.

Gilsdorf, J. W. (1991, March). Write me your best case for . . . *The Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication, 53*(1), 7–12.

work in Germany and to give you suggested changes in preparing Americans for an overseas assignment.

[*Present here the core* recommendation(s). *Present* problems *if those are not known.*]

Benefits

All of us feel that our productivity would improve if the preceding recommendations are accepted. Our families would more quickly become involved. We would know issues early. We would not be as surprised.

Ted, you asked for our brief statement on better preparing us as Americans to work in Europe. Although I wrote the letter, the ideas represent the thinking of the eight of us and our spouses. We look forward to your reaction and response.

SUMMARY

Short reports are basically of two types: informational and analytical. Although there may be overlapping between the two types, the former is more neutral, more unbiased; the latter is more analytical, more persuasive. Both types may be short, and both can be sent via the mails, faxes, or even E-mail. Regardless of the medium chosen, they possess a classical organization of introduction, body or text, and a terminal section. Just as their contents can vary widely, so too can their format and the visual appearance and placement of their headings. All depend on purpose, audience, problems, complexity of the subject matter, and other significant concerns.

Communication Probe

Both scholarly and trade publications are increasingly pointing out the merits of software packages in collecting data, organizing data, and reporting of that data, in reports. As companies downsize, there is a growing realization that software packages can do much of the data analysis prior to submitting a report. Professionals who are testing the various packages often come away awarding those packages high marks, often in human resource areas and financial data collection. There is little doubt that in long reports the use of the computer will become increasingly more prominent.

Hemmerick, S. (1995, May). Rave review for software. *Pensions and Investments, 23,* 30; Santosus, M. (1995, May). Personnel matters. *CIO, 8,* 44–52; The, L. (1995, May). On line analytical processing (ONLAP). *Datamation, 41,* 65–67.

A letter report carries its own meaning: a report sent in the format of a letter. Often this form is used when writers are outside the company, as in a foreign location. Increasingly, the letter report is used within companies.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Short Informative Report Sent Back to the Home Office.*** Assume for the moment that you are stationed in a foreign country; you choose the country. Your vice president (more clearly than most) of International Marketing in the United States makes this request:

   ```
   Please send me pertinent information concerning the
   economic state, the political situation, the com-
   petitive environment, and the labor market of coun-
   try X.  I need just a brief introductory report be-
   fore we go into more detail.  I would appreciate
   receiving that information within the next couple
   of days.
   ```

   Using the above as a request, compose a brief report that responds to her questions. Additionally, your report should include the three basic parts of a report: introduction, body or text, and a terminal section.

2. ***A Recommendation-Justification Report Sent Back to the Home Office.*** You can, for this assignment, use the same country for assignment 1 above or select another country of your choice. Here are the requirements for this assignment:

   Subject: Presenting a recommendation-justification memorandum concerning a foreign country investment

Goal of assignment:

1. To recommend whether a company (of your choice) should establish a subsidiary in a foreign country
2. To give evidence in your report of individual research and secondary information that clearly supports your final recommendation
3. To present copies of your memorandum to all members of the class

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Review of the Opening Letter of an Annual Report.*** Select an annual report of your choice. You will note that in large corporations either the CEO or president—sometimes both—sign the opening statement within that annual report. It is written for stockholders and others interested in the corporation. Let's be honest: Some of those opening letters are the work of outside public relations firms, each trying to capture the intent of the executives signing the letter. Yet, the executives are responsible for both content and style.

   Your task in an informative memorandum report is to do the following:

   a. Analyze the introduction; set your own criteria as to whether the opening statement captures the attention or interest of the reader.
   b. Determine whether there is a clear specific purpose.
   c. Is there a road map, an agenda, a layout included in either the letter or the complete annual report?
   d. Are there clearly organized sections in the body of the report?
   e. What kind of ending is given to the letter? Is there a summary, or is there an overt attempt to end with persuasion?

4. ***Analytical Memorandum Report on Promotion of Colleague.*** In the academic world of colleges and universities, several persons are asked to write short letters or memorandums evaluating persons within their own school or for persons outside. Even in the business world requests may come to you—as a member of the Human Resources (HR) Department—to write such an analysis. In fact, one of your authors has written several assessments of individuals in companies for which he has consulted, with the intent of offering an opinion on specific criteria. Those criteria vary from company to company. But the result is the same: Give an analysis of that individual's performance as measured against several criteria.

   Your manager would like you to write a confidential analysis of an individual within your company. In some companies the criteria are vivid, in others not. Therefore, select your own criteria and submit an analytical memoran-

dum that ends with specific recommendations. In addition to your own criteria, you may wish to consider some of the following:

- Ability to perform his or her current job
- Capacity to get along well with superiors, peers, and subordinates
- Support for his or her communication abilities
- Willingness to perform high-quality work
- Control over time
- Evidence of creativity in solving problems
- Desire to continue working with the company

5. ***Rewrite of Savings Association Letter Report.*** The following letter report (answering an inquiry) is quite good. Your job is to make it even better. Assume the customer asked about all the topics mentioned; thus, keep all the ideas but improve the report in these five ways:

   a. Insert headings—second- and third-degree or third- and fourth-degree headings.
   b. Show more you-attitude.
   c. Change at least five passive verbs to active voice (and of course make whatever subject changes are necessary).
   d. Tabulate some listed details—for easier reading.
   e. Make any other minor changes desirable for good business writing.

Thank you for your request for information relating to INSURED savings accounts in this association. This reply includes facts concerning types of savings plans, security of savings, withdrawal of funds, and necessary forms for opening an account. I am also enclosing a copy of our latest financial statement and several pamphlets of general information that give you essential facts you desire about us and the savings accounts we issue.

We have two types of savings plans available-a passbook savings account and a 6-month savings certificate.

Briefly, an insured passbook savings account may be opened for any amount at any time. Upon receipt of your remittance, we issue to you our savings passbook with the amount credited inside. Additional sums may be added in any amount and at any time you desire. Interest earnings are credited to passbook savings accounts on March 31, June 30, September 30, and December 31 of each year. This is done automatically on these dates whether you send in your passbook or not. Gold Bond stamps are given as a bonus to passbook savers, as outlined on the enclosed card.

The current rate of dividend on passbook savings is 5 1/2% per year, compounded daily.

In addition to our savings passbooks, we also issue insured 6-month savings certificates. Designed to offer larger, longer-term investors the maximum rate for insured savings, these certificates are issued for a minimum of $1,000, with larger amounts in multiples of $100. They differ from passbook accounts in several respects. Earnings on certificates begin on the day of purchase and are paid at the end of each 6 months on maturity dates. The certificates are in certificate form, and checks are mailed to the certificate holders every 6 months from the date of issue, instead of being automatically credited to the account as is done on passbook accounts. Of course, if you have a passbook savings account with State Federal, the dividends on your savings certificate may be automatically credited to your passbook account upon your request. For your convenience, savings certificates are automatically renewed on the maturity dates for an additional 6 months unless you are notified at least 30 days prior to a maturity date. The current interest rate on 6-month savings certificates is 8 1/4% per year.

Savings in this association are INSURED up to $100,000 by the Federal Savings and Loan Insurance Corporation, Washington, D.C. We are also members of the Federal Home Loan Bank System, a reserve credit system for associations. We lend our funds upon the security of selected monthly reducing first mortgages on homes. So, you will see, there is really exceptional security for savings placed with us.

You will probably wish some information concerning withdrawal of your funds. It has always been the policy of this association to pay withdrawals IN PART OR IN FULL without notice. We have followed this policy ever since organization in 1926. However, a savings and loan association may require notice of withdrawal if necessary. If the country should again experience an economic emergency such as prevailed in 1932-1933, it is possible that we would require notice. Under such circumstances it is quite likely that every financial institution would necessarily restrict withdrawals. This provision in the savings and loan laws is a wise one for the protection of the customers.

For your convenience I am enclosing a signature card that may be used for either an individual or a joint account. If you desire to open an

acount in your own name alone, you should use Form 100. If, however, you wish to open an account in your name jointly with some other person, probably another member of your family, you should use Form 200, on the reverse side of the card. If you desire a 6-month savings certificate, the same signature card may be used.

We also have trust accounts, frequently used by parents in carrying savings accounts for children, or by persons who desire to hold funds in trusts for another. Signature card forms for this type of account will be mailed to you upon request.

I thank you kindly for your inquiry and extend to you a cordial invitation to use the facilities of this association

6. ***Rewrite of Annual Letter Report, with Tables and Other Improvements.*** Following is a report to shareholders. Assume this message appears on one side of an 8½ by 11 inch sheet and the annual statement of condition appears on the opposite side. Rewrite it so that the information is easier to read. For example, can you put in table form some or all the figures given in the first three paragraphs? And can you list the names and titles in the last two paragraphs? Also, add an appropriate rounding-out last paragraph.

Report to the Shareholders

We ended our 61st year May 3, 199-, which proved to be a very good year. Our assets totaled almost $12,000,000 being $11,997,728.90, representing an increase of $430,315.75, which was due principally to the increase in home loans of $538,622.30.

Savings accounts reflected a total of $11,013,974.26, representing a gain for the year of $385,321.70, which was substantially greater than the gain in the previous year. During the year the association repaid $265,000 to the Federal Home Loan Bank and had no notes payable May 3, 199-. Net operating income, after expenses, amounted to $558,293.40, reflecting an increase of $32,423.01 over the previous year. The operating ratio of the association for the fiscal year was 17.87% of gross operating income, which was substantially lower than the national average, which is in excess of 27%.

During the year, $42,000 was added to reserves, $495,810.52 was distributed as earning on savings accounts, and $20,482.88 was added to undivided profit. Total reserves were $514,000 and undivided profit $87,505.03, making a total of $601,505.03, representing over 5% of total liabilities. Our reserves and undivided profit place us in a rather

enviable position and leave no question, in my opinion, of our ability to continue at our present rate of return to our savings accounts.

At our shareholders' meeting held Monday, April 5, the following were elected to serve as directors for the ensuing year: William E. Brady, Robert E. Becker, Stephen G. Mills, Mary A. Aitken, Daniel A. Roberts, Lisa L. Gifford, and Louise G. Bulett.

At the directors' reorganization meeting, immediately following the shareholders' meeting, the following officers were elected: Chairperson of the Board of Directors and President, William E. Brady; Vice Chairperson, Robert E. Becker; Executive Vice President, Secretary and Treasurer, Stephen G. Mills; Vice President and Assistant Secretary and Treasurer, Louise G. Hulett, and Assistant Secretary, William A. Dugger. Sylvia Reddie was reappointed Savings Officer, and Bonnie Whittemore was appointed Head Bookkeeper. Fred L. Sharp was reappointed attorney.

7. ***Collection of Sample Periodic Reports.*** Although this chapter noted the presence of periodic reports in businesses, there is little consistency as to the kinds of periodic reports required within organizations. Our focus is on business. Yet, many other organizations—not directly business-related—also produce periodic reports, some of which may be similar to business organizations. Go to the offices of one or two of the following organizations and ask for copies of what they consider to be periodic reports. If they will not release the complete report, you could simply list the headings used within those reports. Locate similarities, determine whether some of the contents and headings might be of use to businesses.

Local church or synagogue	YMCA or YWCA
United Fund	Admissions office within your school
City Council	Local thrift shop
Clothing store	Post office
Local newspaper	Head office of your school

8. ***Short Report on a Business Book.*** Locate a book review of a business book. Such a review can be found in a publication such as the *New York Times* or in a periodical that briefly discusses new books. Your task is to write a one-page report on a business book of your choice. What you choose for headings in that report is your decision. Your review, for example, might include topics such as these:

Author's qualifications
Theme or purpose of the book
Implications for students entering business
Major idea gained from the book
Areas where the book could be improved
Other topics of your choice

Chapter 12

Long (Formal) Reports

I. Prefatory Sections
- A. Cover and External Title
- B. Title Fly and Internal Title
- C. Letter or Memorandum of Transmittal
- D. Table of Contents
- E. Executive Summary, Abstract, Synopsis

II. Supplemental Sections
- A. Bibliography
- B. Footnotes and Endnotes (Citations)
- C. Appendix
- D. Glossary
- E. Index

III. Presentation of the Long Report
- A. Writing the First Draft
- B. Editing and Revising the Rough Drafts
- C. Typing the Final Document

IV. Examples of Pages from a Long Analytical Report

V. Summary

VI. Exercises and Problems

A long report is simply an expansion of a shorter report. Major differences in the long report involve greater length and depth of discussion of more complex problems. Some long reports extend from a few pages to several hundred—even into several volumes of information.

- A report to a U.S. nuclear regulatory commission was 180 pages long.
- A report to a utility company on building a new power generating system included eight volumes.
- A report to the home-country manager of an Asian oil company recommending expansion into India was in excess of 200 pages.
- A report to a U.S. motor company recommending automobiles be built in Mexico was in excess of 300 pages.

A formal report does not mean more formal language; it means the report is more detailed, more complex in structure.

Consequently, long reports demand more preliminary collecting, sorting, interpreting, writing, and editing and creation of visuals (see Appendix A) than short reports. Long reports are a mix of informative and persuasive information.

A long report may also be called "formal," but not formal in the sense of language usage. In fact, the principles of the seven C's in Chapter 2 may also be applied here. We label a report *formal* when it includes more detail, more prefatory information, more visuals, and more supplementary forms of support. Topics are often involved and complex.

This chapter presents additional information you need to know regarding writing long reports: prefatory sections, supplementary sections, presentation of the long report, and a shortened example of a long report.

PREFATORY SECTIONS

Assume that someone within your organization requests that you investigate a problem. Thus you receive a charge—someone requests information. The request may be simple, often oral:

"Look into the issue of salary levels among our personnel in Europe."

"Give me a report on changes in retirement benefits."

"Submit to the Board some options on computer hardware."

Or, you may receive a detailed statement that precisely spells out the issues to investigate. This letter or *memorandum of request* (some companies call it an *MOR*) may run several pages, even including a budget for completing the report.

In any event, you will have to do preliminary work, perhaps even meet with the individual or committee requesting a report from you. Checklist 12.1 summarizes what you need to know and do first.

Writing in one's second language is considerably more difficult than writing in one's native language.

As companies globalize and subsidiaries are located worldwide, the need to work in two languages adds to the complexity of completing a report. Often the required report is first written in the native language of the foreign subsidiary and then translated into English. Thus, you must request—if that fact is not already established—that the final document be in English. (On occasion a foreign subsidiary will submit two reports: one in the native language—for example,

Checklist 12.1 What to Do First When Asked to Complete a Report

1. Recognize clearly what is expected of you: issues, problems, purpose, scope.
2. Realize who your audience of readers will be.
3. Get an idea of sources to which you may turn.
4. Understand when the report is to be completed.
5. Be sure of financial and time constraints: costs, travel, release from work.
6. Ask if the authorizer wants progress reports.

Spanish—and one in English. That way—the Spanish-speaking manager would argue—managers in the subsidiary's home office can have their own translators review the Spanish-to-English version or read the report in Spanish.)

After you understand your specific charge and complete your preliminary investigation, it is time to consider the distinguishing features of the long report: cover and external title, title fly and internal title, letter or memo of transmittal, table of contents, and executive summary.

Cover and External Title

Even large companies have reports printed with special, visually appealing covers.

Many reports combine the cover page and title page as the first page. You can even purchase professionally produced covers that have space for a title. Or—as are some reports submitted to the President of the United States—the cover may be leather with the title embossed directly on the cover. However, most reports have a simple hard cover, with the title typed on a gummed label. (On occasion, a foreign subsidiary will submit two cover pages: one in the native language and one in English.)

A report title should indicate briefly and clearly what the report covers. Here are five suggestions.

1. Remember the five W's: *who, what, when, where, why.* As an example, suppose your report discusses a strategy for a company called LifePlus that markets exercise bicycles in Canada. You could use this analysis:

Who:	LifePlus	*Where:*	Canada
What:	Marketing strategy	*Why:*	To increase sales
When:	199-		

Possible titles could be:

```
Recommendations for Increasing LifePlus' Sales
  in Canada
A New Marketing Emphasis for 199- Canadian Sales
Canadian Sales:  Ways to Improve our Market
```

Communication Probe

Writing a report in one's own language is considerably easier than writing in a second language. Yet, foreign subsidiary report writers often must write in their second language. And too often the typical U.S. manager's reaction to that report is "that report just doesn't read right,"—or worse! A real scenario is the following pattern as traced by one of your authors some time ago:

Request for a proposal arrives at foreign country regional office. (*English*)
Request sent to German subsidiary. German country manager has request translated into German for distribution to his staff. (*English-German*)
Staff discusses request. (*German*)
Initial report written in German. (*German*)
Staff discusses report and finally approves. (*German*)
Report translated into English. (*German-English*)
Report sent to German country manager. (*German-English*)
Report sent on to regional office and on to parent company in the United States. (*English*)

Hildebrandt, H. W. (1974). Technical written reports from Germany. *The Journal of Technical Writing and Communication, 4*(4), 291–303.

2. Keep title short. Eight to ten words is desirable. Try to omit articles—*the, a,* and *an*—whenever possible.

3. Consider a subtitle, often indicated with a colon. For instance:

Your readers get an initial impression in the title: Give careful thought to being concise and clear.

```
Argentina:  Recommendations for
  Establishing a Joint Venture
Industrial Water Pollution:  What Strategy
  Should Our Company Follow?
Drug Use in the Workplace:  Options for
  Decreasing the Problem
```

4. Avoid titles that are vague, extremely short:

Unclear	Better
Root Causes	Core Issues Affecting Decline in Profits
Drugs	Marijuana and Its Abuse in the Workplace
Company Plans	A Strategic Financial Plan: 1998–2000

5. Eliminate judgment terms:

```
Errors in Accounting Procedures in the Past Two
  Years
Why Overseas Personnel Do Badly
Issues That Hinder Our Acceptance in Jakarta
```

Title Fly and Internal Title

By definition the title fly is simply the sheet of paper between the cover and the internal title page. Immediately following that page is the internal title page, which has four parts: the title as stated on the exterior cover, the recipient of the report, the preparer, and the date.

Example 1

[*title*] Peru: Recommendations for Establishing a Joint Venture

[*for whom*] Prepared for [*company*] Board of Directors

[*by whom*] Prepared by the International Strategic Review Committee

[*date*] January 25, 199-

Example 2

[*title*] INDUSTRIAL WATER POLLUTION: WHAT STRATEGY SHOULD OUR COMPANY FOLLOW?

Title, for whom, by whom, and date are the four parts of a title page.

[*for whom*] For the Environmental Committee

[*by whom*] Prepared by
Olga Lotz
Russ Winoski
Elaine Zimmer, Chairperson

[*date*] September 5, 199-

Note that each example illustrates the four parts of the title page. Position each part symmetrically on the page for an initial positive impression.

Letter or Memorandum of Transmittal

A cover letter or cover memorandum are names for the first prose document of a report. Regardless of the formality of the report, it is conventional to address the receiver of the report—as if you're writing a letter—as "Dear." Before looking at the five parts of a transmittal message, review the probe on the next page; it is an enlightening review of how a Middle East country handles a salutation in a cover letter.

Most transmittal messages have five parts.

1. Authorization

Include the name of the group or individual who requested the report.

Unless your report is self-initiated, someone has asked you to produce a report. Hence, your opening words in the transmittal document refer to that request. Include the date. Remember that much time may have passed (some reports

Communication Probe

Turkish letters and cover letters begin with a salutation. Two different "Dears" exist: *Sevgili* is used in informal contexts while *Sayin* is more formal, used when writing to an older person or a superior. Salutations in either kind of context end with a comma, not a colon. When submitting a report to a government official in Turkey, you begin with a specific salutation such as "To the Attorney General, Istanbul." Salutations also include the name of the city where the office is located. Additionally, there are expressions relevant to the positions of the writer and reader. If the person to whom the letter or cover letter is sent is a subordinate, you request; if the person is a superior, you present. Western readers of foreign letters need to be aware of differences in letter formats, beginning with the salutation.

Kaleli, O. (1993). Writing in Turkish and English compared. Unpublished manuscript.

take several months to complete) since the initial request and that even the requester may have forgotten the details. Some report writers include in the appendix the actual report request as supplementary information.

2. Transmittal Details

Simply put, your transmittal message says, "Here's the report you requested." But politeness demands more. Use conversational language (with first- and second-person pronouns as "I," "you," "me") as you would if you were handing the report to the recipient in person. A formal, distinguished group—such as a top government official or department—might use more formal language. Also, you may combine both the authorization and the transmittal details within the same paragraph.

3. Background, Methodology

One could call this information "throat clearing." You briefly suggest the research methods you employed, giving the reader some feel for the breadth (also known as the scope or limits of the report) of your investigation. This also gives you the opportunity to build your credibility as senior author of the report: who you are and what your qualifications are as well as those of your committee members. In short, you forestall the inevitable questions of how conscientious you and your associates were in gathering information.

As in short reports, here too consider whether your reader is favorably disposed to your recommendation. If yes, put the recommendation up front.

4. Highlights

You should include information that briefly mentions your conclusions. Here you must make a judgment: If your reader is friendly, potentially inclined to accept your conclusions, you could be precise as to the recommendations; if your reader is less inclined, consider being a bit more general.

5. Courteous Ending

Think about doing any of the following in your ending statement:

- Acknowledging those who assisted
- Indicating, if necessary, that later reports will be forthcoming
- Verifying that the effort in completing the report was worthwhile
- Suggesting a personal willingness to respond to further questions or complete further research if that is necessary
- Including—if you are distant from the report readers—where you can be reached personally or via electronic means

Precision as to your electronic address is often included in the final line.

EXAMPLE 3

Dear Ms. Hammel:

Authorization and transmittal

Attached is the report you requested on April 10, 199- on the issue of Drugs in the Workplace. We have tried to meet your requests as stated in your letter of that date and hope the report is useful to you and your office.

Methodology

Our approach to the issue involved work in three areas: meetings with local health and medical personnel; interviews with persons who have publicly indicated a problem with durgs; and meetings with other companies in the area. Three months of effort were devoted to the above investigations. After that initial data collection we also met with each of our vice presidents to get their reaction to our preliminary data.

Highlights

Three recommended solutions are supported by the committee; those recommendations are detailed in the executive summary. Consensus also appeared for the three criteria we used for evaluation: fairness, workability, and cost effectiveness.

Courteous ending

We hope the report is acceptable to the committee. As a group we found the investigation interesting, challenging, and most of all, hopefully rewarding in decreasing and eventually solving the problem of drugs in the workplace.

Cordially,

[*Signature*]
[*Typed name and title*]

A foreign language title page—with translation—is not unusual.

As with the title page, some foreign subsidiaries include the cover letter or memorandum both in the native language and in English. Such actions are a mark of respect and not an attempt to demean the English readers of the letter.

Table of Contents

Contents of the Report

Suggestion: Prepare the table of contents last—after you have assigned the headings and final page numbers. Place the table of contents just before the report body, being sure that all headings parallel those in the text. You need not include all headings in the body of the report. Usually you show no more than two degrees (first, second, and only occasionally the third). Going beyond that level results in micro, unnecessary detail.

Table of Tables

A long report will include illustrations, statistical data, clarifying end notes, visuals, even bibliographic citations, as we have in this textbook. What you choose to include depends on the kind of formal visuals shown throughout the body of the report. Your visual layout may be similar to the following:

Table of Tables

Table		Page
1	(Title).....	7
2	(Title).....	24
3	(Title).....	34

Visuals or Figures

Visuals may be included in the body of the report or included as a section in the appendix.

Detailed figures or drawings, especially in highly technical reports, are frequently placed in the appendix. Such visuals are there for the reader's use: to see more micro and detailed graphics, as supplements to the prose discussion. Likewise, explicit visual aids may also be given their own section of a report, particularly when those visuals supplemented the oral presentation as support for the report. (See Appendix A.)

Executive Summary, Abstract, Synopsis

Executive summaries are often the most read page in a report.

Companies differ where the "executive summary," "abstract," "synopsis," "précis," "digest" should be placed. Some boards and chairpersons desire it right after the transmittal letter or memorandum. Regardless of its position within a report, it is often the most read piece—occasionally torn out—of a report. Busy managers, and even those tangentially interested, can determine whether they wish to read the entire report simply by reading the executive summary.

This prefatory part may be organized deductively (recommendation or conclusions section up front, then introduction and body) or inductively (introduction, body, and recommendation near the end). Either way, there is little agree-

Checklist 12.2 Prefatory Sections of a Long Report

1. Title of Report—Use the five W's:
   - *Who* wishes the report?
   - *What* is to be investigated?
   - *When* should the report be finished?
   - *Where* is the central issue of the report?
   - *Why* is the report requested?

2. Letter or Memorandum of Transmittal—Include the following information:
   - State who authorized the report.
   - Be informal in submitting the report.
   - Make some effort to explain the procedure in completing the report.
   - Include some highlights.
   - End with courtesy.

3. Table of Contents
   - Let your headings for major sections parallel those used in the body of the report.
   - Include a supplementary table or list of visuals if you use many statistics and figures.

ment as to which headings should be used in an executive summary. Dominant headings include

purpose	problem analysis
scope	results
background	solution criteria
data analysis	conclusions
methods of research	possible solutions/recommendations
current issues	recommendations
causes	benefits
effects	time-frame analysis

Checklist 12.3 gives guidelines for an effective executive summary.

Besides being a useful prefatory part of a long, formal report, informative executive summaries also serve other important functions. Some firms circulate to all their management personnel only executive summaries of reports. Then it is up to the managers to decide whether they need to see the complete document.

A well-written executive summary, or abstract, communicates essential information to many people. Some of the best examples of abstracted articles, for

Checklist 12.3 An Executive Summary

Try to make this short, one-page document as clear as possible; persons often unconnected with the report may read the summary purely for information. One proposition should be controlling: The executive summary should be able to stand alone.

1. Check that you have given a brief background statement.
2. Ask yourself: Have I analyzed the data carefully?
3. Be sure that the causes you attribute to the issue are established.
4. Give thought to including criteria that solutions should meet.
5. Know if your reader desires recommendations up-front or in the terminal section.
6. Include, if desirable, budget and time-frame implications.

instance, occur in the various electronic databases. Note in the following example the specific information for the common ABI/INFORM on-line system:

Copyright © 1993 by University Microfilms, Inc.
All rights reserved.

Access No.	00934500 ProQuest ABI/INFORM ® Global
Title	Multimedia: An emerging communications technique
Authors	Held, Gilbert
Journal	Information Strategy: The Executive's Journal [IFS] ISSN: 0743-8613 Vol: 11 Iss: 2 Date: Winter 1995 p: 41-46 Illus: Charts
Reprint	Contact UMI for article reprint (order no. 14374.00). Restrictions may apply.
Subjects	Multimedia computer applications; Trends; Communications; Customer services; Training
Geo Places	US
Codes	5240 (Software & systems); 9190 (United States)
Abstract	An emerging method of increasing the efficiency and effectiveness of communication in organizations is the use of multimedia. The term multimedia represents the merging of voice, data, and video into a computer-based application. To enhance customer service, multimedia kiosks can be placed in stores to display items that are not normally carried by a branch store and that many customers may have previously ordered based on limited information. . .

Although the abstract length varies somewhat in proportion to the report length, it should be confined to fewer than 500 words (preferably on one page). To show you how abstracts vary, here are two additional examples:

EXAMPLE 1 *A short abstract on a 75-page published report.*

Purpose, scope, method, sources, major facts and figures

To determine the basic vocabulary of written business communications, a computer count was made of 2,504 letters, memorandums, and business reports, submitted by 1,411 companies representative of the population of industries nationwide. A total of 606,496 running words and 15,522 different words were identified, with the 100 most frequently occurring words accounting for half of all word occurrences. Major differences between this list and previous lists were noted. A separate analysis of 500 letters, 300 memorandums, and 200 reports was made to identify the physical format, sentence structure, and readability levels of the documents.

EXAMPLE 2 *Executive summary of international consultant recommendation.*

Background

You requested advice on the possibilities of increasing the consumption of cold cereals in Japan. The specific question was this: What must be done to increase the consumption of cold cereals in Japan from the current 0.150 kilograms to 1.5 kilograms?

Data analysis

We collected data from the Japanese Institute for Social and Economic Affairs as well as other Japanese and US organizations. Data analysis showed that Japanese consumers spend 180 yen per serving to make their traditional breakfast of fish, rice, vegetables, and green tea. Cold cereal costs 240 yen per serving, or an increase of 25%. . .

Causes

The higher cost for the cold cereal breakfast is due to research and development costs, advertising efforts, and sales promotion efforts. Additionally, Americans drink more milk, often on their cereal. Finally, the aging population of Japan also mitigates against cold cereal: older persons resist changing from their traditional breakfast . . .

Possible options

1. Conduct an education program targeting the younger Japanese consumer, those less than age 25. Emphasis could be placed on cereal's nutritional benefits. . .

2. Increase media advertising, emphasizing the nutritional elements of cold cereal. . .

3. Develop more cereals made from rice. . .

Conclusions

We conclude that any of the above three options would help increase the consumption of cold cereals in Japan. Particularly important is the concept that our marketing efforts should be directed toward those age 25 and younger.

SUPPLEMENTAL SECTIONS

Long reports have numerous headings and sections; they are more detailed; they include more visuals, more evidence, and involve more collaboration than a short report.

Furthermore, a long report may also include various kinds of supplementary information. That material is for readers who desire additional details related to, but not required within, the report itself. Such supplementary material may include a bibliography, a collection of endnotes (or footnotes), appendixes, a glossary, an index, and even visual aids.

Communication Probe

It is clear that when ending (inductive) or beginning (deductive) a report with a precise recommendation, persuasion is involved. Analytical reports often involve a discussion of a problem, a review of options—or alternatives—and a recommendation. Alternatives can be used persuasively. For instance, writers intending to persuade—in a report or other persuasive documents—can pose two alternatives, either of which are acceptable to the writer. The receiver, says one study, is likely to choose one of those two alternatives. Clearly, the receiver may also choose the unwritten option; that is, he or she may not like either alternative. Likewise, when laying out alternatives, it is useful to consider one highly positive alternative and several nonpositive, the writer giving more positive effort to his or her desired recommendation or alternative.

Gilsdorf, J. W. (1991, March). Write me your best case for . . . *The Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication, 53*(1), 7–12.

Bibliography

Bibliographies are often not a part of business reports. Know whether your company desires them.

From basic writing courses you learned that a bibliography is a list of sources you cited as documentation for relevant content in your report. These sources range from articles to electronic databases. Such precision is more characteristic of scholarly writing but may on occasion be included in a formal business report. Business reports use citations (endnotes or footnotes) sparingly. In fact, many business reports omit both full-citation footnotes and bibliography. On the other hand, some do include a general bibliography but without any footnote source citations. Here we summarize appropriate ways to insert bibliographic information. Checklist 12.4 on p. 332 is an overview of bibliographic citation.

Placement

Bibliographic information is usually included at the end of the document. It is for additional reading, additional sources to which the reader may wish to turn. Some reports include bibliographic information at the end of each section or chapter. The choice is yours. In this book, for example, bibliographic information is combined with reference notes and placed at the end of each chapter.

Bibliographic Format

Modern Language Association formats are often used in qualitative statements.

You have two main choices for bibliographic form: the Modern Language Association (MLA) format *(MLA Handbook for Writers of Research Papers)* or the American Psychological Association (APA) *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association.* (Another format is Kate Turabian's *A Manual for Writers of Term Papers, Theses and Dissertations,* but this style is used more often for the purposes noted in the title.) Your choice may depend on which form your company prefers. Or lacking any guidance, choose one with which you feel most comfortable. Regardless, be consistent throughout your report. For instance, this book uses a modified APA format, combining brevity and clarity.

The American Psychological Association is also frequently used in numerous publications.

Once you decide on your format, you can present bibliographic entries in a single alphabetic list or under various headings. One could, for instance, arrange sources within broad groups such as books, periodicals, newspapers, government reports, or any other major categories of your choosing. A sample bibliography (also variously called *sources, references, works cited, selected bibliography, works consulted)* follows, using the format of the widely accepted American Psychological Association. Full details for the many, many variations of bibliographic citations are noted in the complete book of the APA, third edition.

Books

Baldwin, C. W. (1959). Medieval rhetoric and poetic. Gloucester MA: Peter Smith. (Original work published 1928).
[*citation for a republished text*]

Kristeller, P. O. (1979). Renaissance thought and its sources. (M. Mooney, ed.). New York: Columbia University Press. (Original works published 1944-1975).
[*citation for edited book, and republished book*]

Murphy, H. A., & Hildebrandt, H. W. (1991). Effective business communications (6th ed.). New York: McGraw-Hill.
[*simple two-author text*]

Quintilian. (1943). Institutio oratoria. (H. E. Butler, Trans.). Cambridge MA: Harvard University Press.
[*citation for a translated text*]

Periodicals and Newspaper

Chen, K. (1996, January 4). Chinese are going to town as growth of cities takes off. The Wall Street Journal, pp. A1, A12.
[*citation for newspaper article with one author*]

Hertling, J. (1966, January 5). China embraces the English language. The Chronicle of Higher Education, pp. A49, A51.
[*citation for periodical with one author*]

Hildebrandt, H. W. (1988). A Chinese managerial view of business communication, Management Communication Quarterly 2, (2), 217-234.
[*citation for scholarly article with volume, issue number, and pages)*

Government Publications, Reports

United States Environmental Protection Agency. (1995). Implementation for the clean air act amendments of 1990. Washington, D.C.: Office of Air and Radiation.
[*citation from a government report*]

Footnotes and Endnotes (Citations)

Kinds of Footnotes and Endnotes

Footnotes and endnotes are of two main types: those that explain *content* and those that *identify* sources of content, or citations.

1. Footnotes and Endnotes That Explain

Footnotes may appear at the rear of a report or at the bottom of a page.

An explanatory endnote or footnote[1] should provide additional information, discuss, or explain the content within the text. For example,

> *The term* footnote *is somewhat confusing. It can mean the inclusion of a superscript number in the text that refers the reader to an explanatory statement or a source citation. In this book we use superscript numbers for both purposes, including the explanation or source at the end of each chapter.*

Many books position the above explanatory material at the bottom of the page, at the end of the chapter, or at the end of the book. Its position is up to you; however, it should relate to an idea in your report that is incidental, or that is too long, too complicated, or too technical to include in the text discussion, or that should not interrupt the flow of thought.

To refer your reader to explanatory footnotes or endnotes and to number them, you may use superscript numerals, easily inserted with today's word pro-

cessing systems. Superscripts are small Arabic numbers placed slightly above the line. You can number these superscripts consecutively throughout a report or begin a new series with each chapter [*as we do in this book*].

2. *Footnotes and Endnotes That Identify Source*

Unhesitatingly give credit to sources that supplied you with needed information.

Some footnotes or endnotes give credit to sources you used. Any quotations and important factual information that is not common knowledge or that is based on your experience must be supported by a reference to your sources. Citing sources does three things: It improves your own credibility as a writer, it helps convince your readers that your data are trustworthy, and it gives readers an opportunity to examine your sources.

A modified version of the APA format of identifying sources is used in this book.

Indicating to the reader that you have cited a source—to which he or she may wish to turn—can be done with a superscript numeral, similar to the explanatory footnote discussed above (as we have done in this book), or you may use the widely accepted APA format, in which a citation is placed in parentheses within the running text itself, including the author's surname and date of publication. Here we look at a few examples:

EXAMPLE 1 *Two authors—cited within the text.*

```
While traditional literature in strategy and orga-
nization theory suggests that organizational per-
formance is a result of organizational adaptation
to industry or market requirements (Hill, 1988;
Porter, 1980, 1985), recent research highlights the
importance of organizationally "distinctive compe-
tencies" . . .
```

Note that two sources are cited: We know the authors, we know the dates of all statements. Turning to the bibliography (or sources, references, works cited, selected bibliography, works consulted), you simply look in an alphabetical list for Hill, 1988, and Porter, 1980 and 1985, for a complete bibliographic citation:

```
Hill, C. (1988). Differentiation versus low cost
  or differentiation and low cost: Contingency
  framework. Academy of Management Review, 13(3),
  401-421.
Porter, M. (1980). Competitive strategy. New
  York: Free Press.
Porter, M. (1985). Competitive advantage. New
  York: Free Press.
```

EXAMPLE 2 *Multiple authors—cited within the text.*

```
Compared to the United States, labour mobility be-
tween and within European countries is much lower
(Bayoumi and Eichengreen, 1993; de Grauwe and Van-
haverbeke, 1933), wage flexibility is lower (Abra-
ham, 1994; Blanchard and Katz, 1992; Decressin and
Fatas, 1994) . . .
```

Again, we know the authors and the dates for their statements from reading the citations within the text. We do not know the source of their statements. That

Checklist 12.4 Bibliographic Citations

1. Determine which format is used within your company (you can choose from MLA (Modern Language Association), APA (American Psychological Association), and Turabian.

2. Know these facts about the book, periodical, or newspaper regardless of the format:
   - Author(s) names
   - Author capacity: editor, translator, compiler
   - Date of publication
   - Title of article or book
   - Edition
   - Page numbers
   - Volume number
   - Publisher

information can be found by referring to the bibliography. Just two citations are illustrated:

> Bayoumi, T., & Eichengreen, B. (1993). Shocking aspects of European monetary integration. In F. Torres and F. Giavazzi (Eds.). Adjustment and growth in the European monetary union (pp. 193-229). Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
>
> Blanchard, O., & Katz, L. (1992). Regional evolutions. Brookings Papers on Economic Activity 1, (pp. 1-61). Washington D.C. Brookings.

EXAMPLE 3 *Government report—cited within the text.*

> Most Chinese managers working in research and development (R&D) studied in areas as the following: engineering (45.4%); natural science (23.5%); medicine (20.3%); agricultural (7.7%); and other areas (2.9%) (China Stat, 1988: 814-832).

In the bibliography the citation to the *China Stat* document would appear as follows:

> Statistical yearbook of China, 1987 (1988) (China Stat). Hong Kong: Economic Information and Agency.

Instead of providing a complete bibliography at the end of the book, this book uses a modified version of the APA bibliographic style, with superscripts to refer you to the Reference section at the end of the chapter rather than paren-

thetical in-text citations. We also included complete citations within the boxed Communication Probes. This system works well because it avoids footnotes at the bottom of the page, does not break up the text for a citation, and yet maintains the ease-of-reference style of inverted authors' names.

But it is your decision as to which citation format you wish to follow. The differences between the various forms are slight. We recommend you use the format accepted in your company. But keep in mind that many long company reports do not use any citations.

Appendix

You put materials into the appendix when you need to include them somewhere in the report but they are not essential in developing any part of the text. The appendix lets you avoid cluttering the body (discussion, text) with exhibits, copies of questionnaires, or pamphlets that are unnecessary for understanding the report but that may be useful for reference or as supporting information.

With short reports, you merely add the appendix sheets directly to the report. But for a formal report, you place a sheet of paper (the appendix title page) between the last page of the body and the first page of the appendix. If you have enough material in the appendix to justify a separate table of contents, show the contents below the title on the appendix dividing sheet.

Each separate entry (sample forms, detailed data for reference, tables, pictures, questionnaires, charts, maps, graphic representations, blueprints) in the appendix naturally requires an identifying title. As a rule, you should refer the reader to every entry in the appendix in the report body (within the discussion itself or in a footnote).

The last page of the appendix is the ideal place for any table or illustration the reader will need to refer to throughout the report. You can set up this table on a pull-out sheet and tell the reader about the sheet in the letter of transmittal or introduction.

Glossary

When your report includes any terms that have several possible interpretations, definitions should be inserted—in one of three places. If you have many definitions (for instance, in a technical report), a glossary at the end is preferable. Mention in your introduction that the report includes a glossary, which will be useful to readers who wish to check on some meanings even though the terms are not essential for understanding the report.

Index

The index lists topics alphabetically and guides the reader to various places that discuss certain subject matter in the report. Only in very long reports will you need an index.

PRESENTATION OF THE LONG REPORT

Presume for the moment that you have completed all your preliminary work: You have defined the problem, collected all needed material, sorted and inter-

preted data, organized the final outline, and prepared visual aids. Now your steps are writing, editing, revising, and typing the report.

Writing the First Draft

Accept no criticism for beginning to write with the easiest section; it helps you feel comfortable.

You may like to begin with a section you consider easiest. Nothing wrong with that. Feel comfortable with the job facing you. Use your outline and get your ideas into your word processor without stopping to correct every spelling, punctuation, or grammar error. Some people initially overwrite, later finding it easier to delete material than to locate additional and new information.

Introduction

You can begin with the introduction, or leave it until last. Either way is acceptable. Be sure to include opening statements that orient the reader to the rest of the report. For a 15- to 25-page, double-spaced, typewritten report, the introduction should be no more than 1½ or 2 pages.

Body or Text

Three or four main divisions are appropriate for a report that is 15 to 25 pages in length. If your report is longer than that, look critically at your outline to determine whether you can regroup sections or combine sections. Of course, a report consisting of one-hundred or several hundred pages will have proportionately more main divisions; in fact, the report may contain "chapters," with each chapter having its own main divisions.

Conclusion, Summary (Terminal Section)

As we noted in the preceding chapter, you may label the terminal section "Summary," "Conclusions," or "Conclusions and Recommendations."

Editing and rewriting can be exhilarating; they force you to review your prose for added clarity.

Besides completing a first draft of the report body, you should also write a draft of the executive summary, letter or memo of transmittal, and bibliography or endnotes list, if you will have one. You can also set up the table of contents and the table of tables (if any) in rough draft, but only after the final typing is finished can you know correct page numbers for these tables.

Editing and Revising the Rough Drafts

After you have finished the first draft, lay it aside for at least 1 day. Doing so will help you look objectively at the material and see more clearly the weaknesses in the draft. Editing requires objective self-criticism. What seemed right in the first writing may seem seriously out of place upon second reading. Remember too that the best writers revise and rewrite several times.

Text editing and revising functions are easily accomplished on a word processor. As you know, a few keystrokes permit condensing, changing or adding words, rearranging paragraphs, adjusting margins, detecting spelling errors, and a host of other functions unimaginable several years ago.

Typing the Final Document

Be consistent. This statement suggests that when selecting one of the many ways of physically putting together a report, you should be in harmony with the style others have used to prepare reports for your company. Several items should be considered.

Overall Appearance

Laser printers, various type fonts, and different sizes of type allow reports to be highly attractive. Spacing, margins, and pagination all contribute to a favorable impression of a report.

Spacing

Reports may be typewritten with double or single spacing. Those who prefer double spacing feel it is easy to read. Single-spaced reports have become popular in recent years not only because they save paper but also—with fewer pages for the same amount of report data—because they save (1) typing time, (2) filing space, (3) expense of both duplicating time and materials when multiple copies of a report are needed, and (4) reading time when turning fewer pages.

If you double-space the report, the first word of each paragraph should be indented (usually five spaces). In a single-spaced report, paragraphs may be indented or begin at the left margin. However, always double-space between paragraphs and both before and after long quotations, visual aids, and footnotes.

Regardless of whether the report is typed in double or single spacing, the following parts should be single-spaced:

1. Transmittal document—typed on company letterhead if you are writing it as an employee of the firm. And, of course, the letter should be centered attractively on the page.
2. Quotations and examples—of three or more typewritten lines. If this material consists of two or more paragraphs, double-space (leave a blank line) between them. Also, indent margins of the quote five spaces to the right and left of the double- or single-spaced text material. Use ellipses (. . .) to indicate omissions if you are quoting only parts of an author's paragraph. In long quotations you can show lengthy omissions by either a full line of periods or by four periods at the end of the paragraph.
3. A list of items you want to set off or emphasize.
4. Footnotes (but double-space between them).
5. Some tables and other visuals aids.

Margins

Mechanical details are easily handled via word processors.

In addition to the following suggested margins, you need to add ½ inch for binding on each page. The report is usually bound on the left-hand side. Acceptable margins are as follows:

Communication Probe

Consistently your authors have moved on this principle: Computers or PCs or word processors are central to report writing or for that matter to any business writing. Although some people may still wish to use an upright typewriter, computers for composing in English are core to Western business communication. Indeed, in writing a report or an analysis, it is easy to connect with persons throughout the world, to download information as precise as a bibliography on your topic, to get on line persons whose voice on the topic was only at the margins. If your report is done collaboratively, it is easy to E-mail your colleagues and get their input into that report. As computer technology moves ahead relentlessly, construction of information becomes more of a collaborative process, a social construction of knowledge.

Moran, C. (1992, February). Computers and English: What do we make of each other? *College English, 54*(2), 193–198. See also Handa, C. (ed.). (1990). *Computers and community.* Portsmouth NH: Heinemann; Holdstein, D. H., & Selfe, C. L. (eds.). (1990). *Computers and writing: Theory, research, practice.* New York: Modern Language Association; Masdon, R., & Kaye, A. (eds.). (1989). *Mindweaver.* New York: Pergamon.

First page of each prefatory part (preface or letter of transmittal, table of contents, table of tables, abstract), *body,* and *supplemental parts* (appendix, bibliography or endnotes, index): top margin of 1½ or 2 inches.

All other pages: Top, bottom, and side margins are 1 or 1½ inches (plus the ½-inch allowance for binding at either left side or top).

Pagination

Every page in the report—except the cover and title fly—should have a number, but not all numbers are actually typed on each page. For the prefatory sheets use small Roman numerals; for the body and supplemental sheets use Arabic numbers, according to these guidelines:

1. *Prefatory parts page numbers* are centered and placed ½ inch below the imaginary line that frames the bottom of the typewritten material. Count and number the prefatory pages as shown below:

Cover and title fly	Do not count or number.
Title page	Count (i) but do not insert number.
Transmittal document	Count, but usually do not insert number. A one-page letter is page ii at the bottom; a second page of the transmittal is page iii.
Table of contents	Count and number each page.
Table of tables	Count and number.
Executive summary	Count and number.

2. *Body and supplemental parts page numbers.*

   a. If your report is bound at the left, page numbers are usually placed near the upper-right corner of the page, aligned with the right margin and ½ inch (or a double space) above the top imaginary line that frames the typewritten material. The exception is that the numbers for first pages of parts are either omitted (though counted) or placed ½ inch (or double space) below the imaginary line that frames the bottom of the typed material. They are centered with the typing on the page (as for prefatory parts pages).

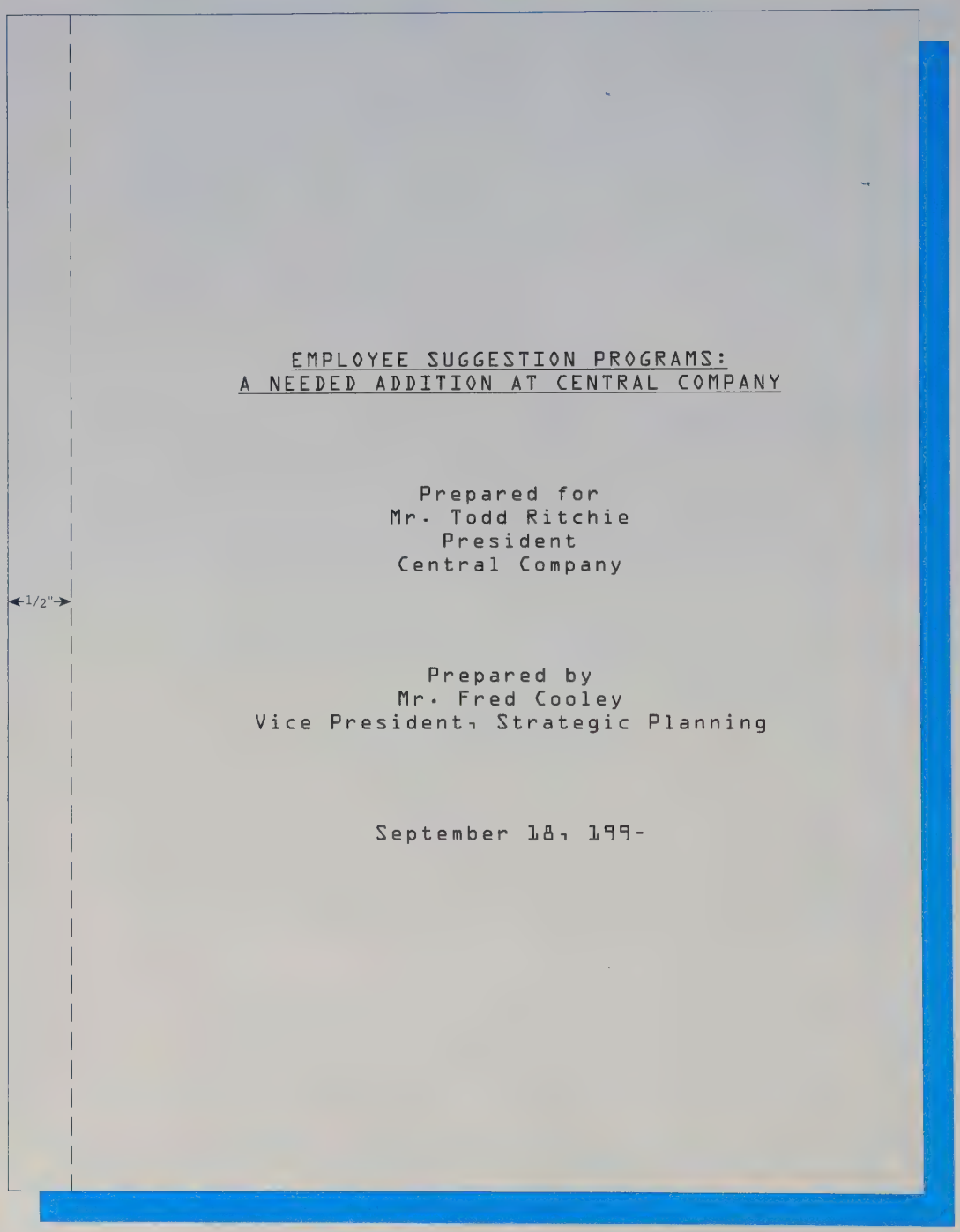
   b. If your report is bound at the top, page numbers are usually placed in the center at the bottom of the page, ½ inch, or a double space, below the imaginary line that frames the bottom of the typewritten text.

EXAMPLES OF PAGES FROM A LONG ANALYTICAL REPORT

What follows on pp. 338 to 346 is a shortened version of a long report submitted to a company that had no employee suggestion program. One of the board members recommended to the president that he consider such a program and requested that a report with recommendations come before the board of directors. The president of Central Company (not the real name) then requested, in writing, that such a report be completed by the vice president of Strategic Planning. Included from that report are these sections:

- Title page
- Transmittal memorandum
- Table of contents
- Executive summary
- Selected pages from the report
- Sample attachment—appendix

Title Page


EMPLOYEE SUGGESTION PROGRAMS:
A NEEDED ADDITION AT CENTRAL COMPANY
Prepared for
Mr. Todd Ritchie
President
Central Company
1/2"
Prepared by
Mr. Fred Cooley
Vice President, Strategic Planning
September 18, 199-

Transmittal Memorandum

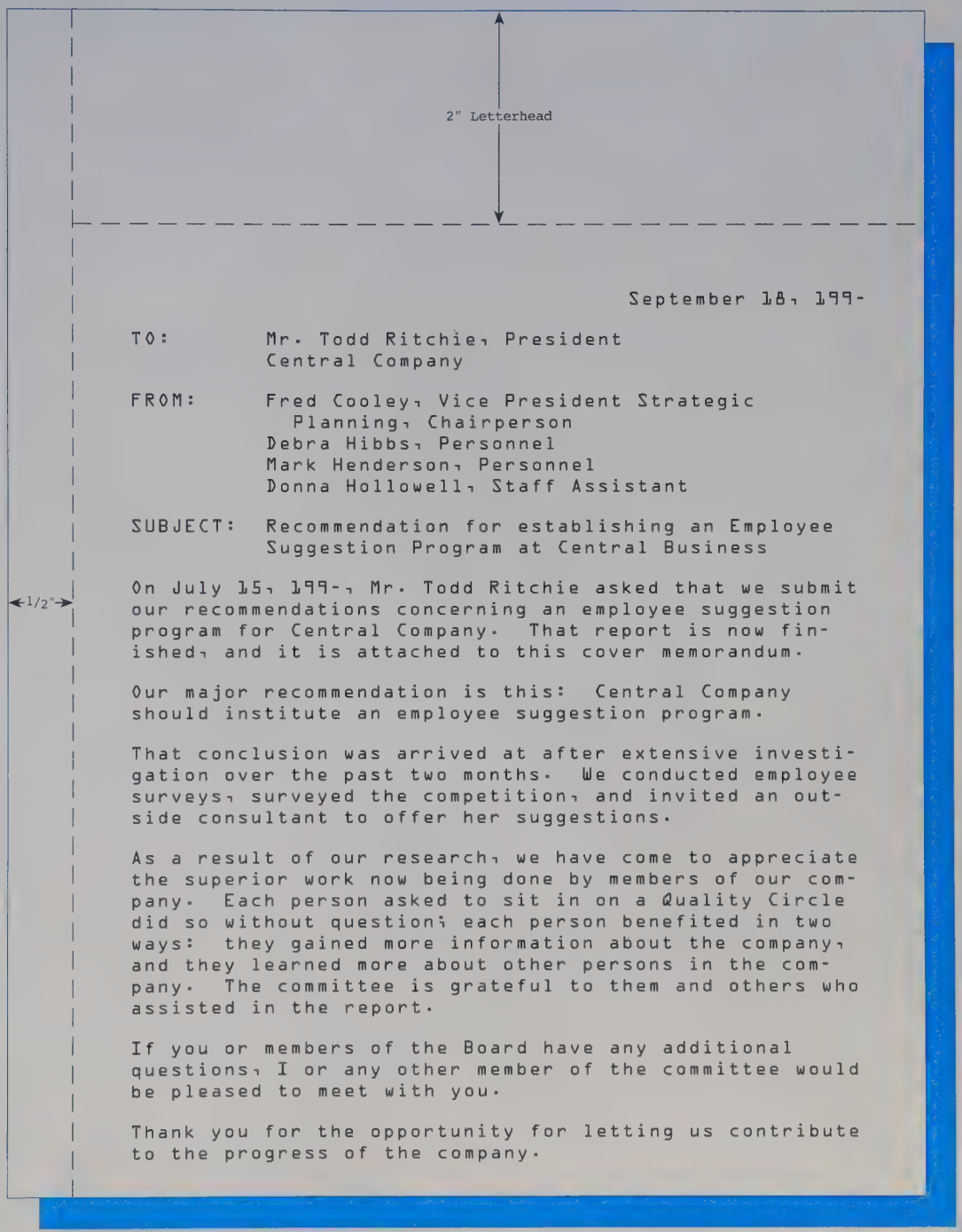
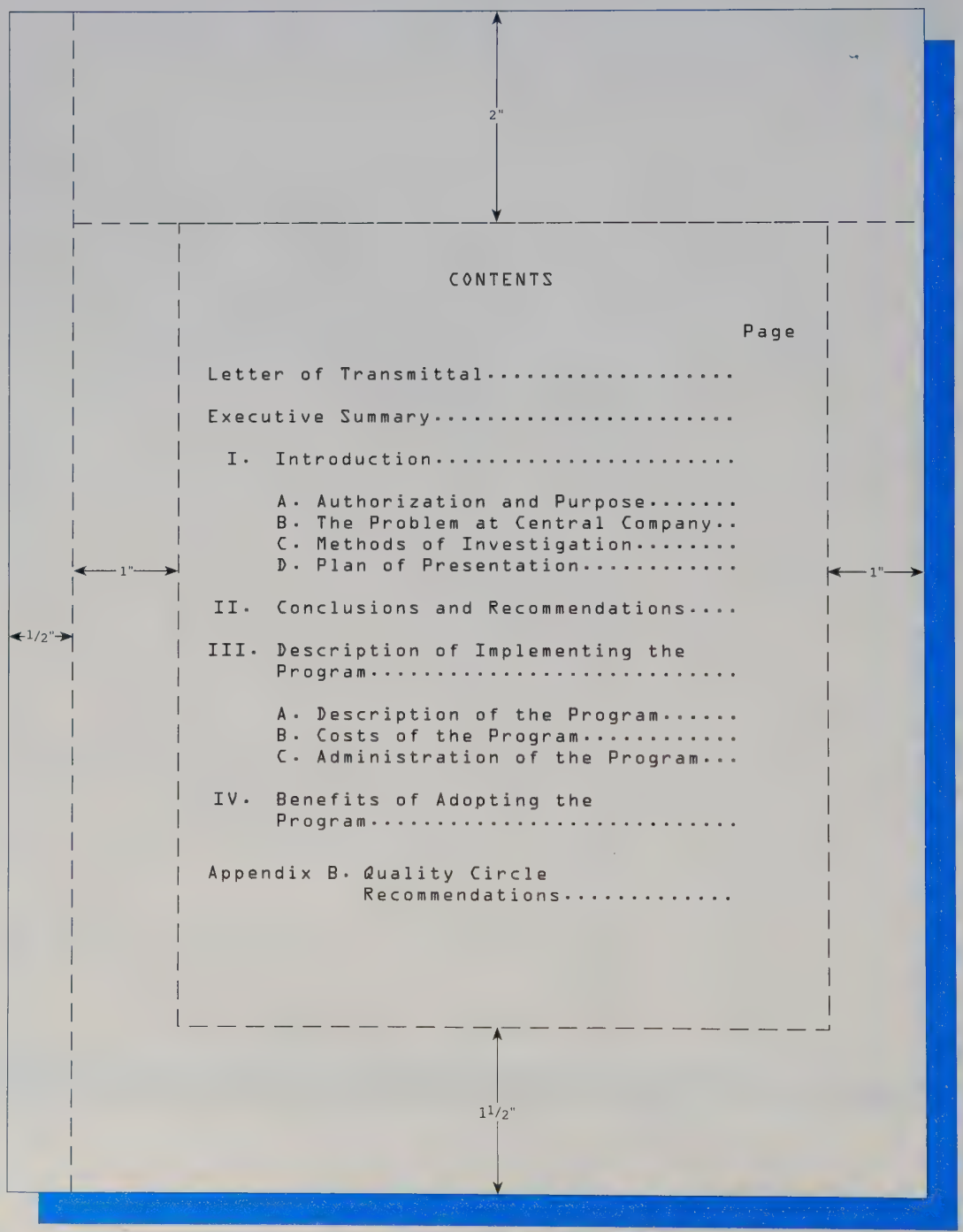


Table of Contents



Executive Summary

Title

Employee Suggestion Programs:
A Needed Addition at Central Company

Authorization recommendation

This report responds to the request of the president, Mr. Todd Ritchie, that a committee look into the issue of whether Central Business should adopt an employee suggestion program. The committee unanimously recommends that such a program be implemented.

Process of review, methodology

Data for that recommendation comes from the committee as based on our investigations over the past two months. We worked with employees of the company in Quality Circles, hired an outside consultant for a period of time, and had contact with our competitors. All eagerly gave their advice.

Problems

A central concern of the employees was their unwillingness to submit suggestions without receiving some kind of financial reward. They felt if they took the time to search out suggestions for improvements, they alone should receive a financial benefit. Such an approach would definitely impact the finances of the company. The committee weighed those consequences and still feel the positive benefits to the company outweigh the negative consequences.

Time frame

Finally, if the recommendation is accepted, the program could be put into effect within three months.

Sample Prose from Body of Report

Employee Suggestion Programs:
A Needed Addition at Central Company

I. INTRODUCTION

Central company, for many years, has been a major community leader. We mean that our firm continues to employ workers from the area and, in turn, contributes to the community as a whole. We have consistently been good citizens. With such a perspective of looking outward, it seemed only logical that we look inward. That mission, we are told, was behind the charge that a committee look into the possibility of establishing an employee suggestion program at Central Company.

Authorization and Purpose

This report, authorized on July 15, 199-, by Mr. Todd Ritchie, is intended to review whether Central Company should establish an employee suggestion program. We realize the need for such a program and have given every effort to find an acceptable set of procedures to put such a program in place . . .

The Problem at Central Company

Central Company must approach the current situation from two points of view: Would establishing an employee suggestion program be beneficial to the company, and would such a program be beneficial to the employees? . . .

Methods of Investigation

Our committee followed a three-step review process:

-Held six Quality Circle sessions with employees wherein we sought answers to this general question: What could the company do to make them feel more a part of the company?

-Visited with the personnel directors of seven competitors and related industries to get their assessments on employee suggestion programs.

-Hired an outside consultant in human resource management to get her feedback on company policies throughout the United States . . .

Employee Suggestion Programs:
A Needed Addition at Central Company

Plan of Presentation

With the above as background, our report will proceed on laying out the specific recommendations, describe how we will implement the program, and conclude with benefits of adopting the program . . .

II. CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

A. That Central Company offer cash awards to employees for their accepted suggestions under the Employee Suggestion Program (ESP)
B. That an ongoing committee be formed to review ESP suggestions
C. That an employee form for ESP suggestions be created and made available to all employees
D. That the final decision of a financial award, and the amount, be reviewed by the chief financial officer

III. DESCRIPTION OF IMPLEMENTING THE PROGRAM

Before describing the program, we wish to comment on the results obtained through the investigations noted earlier in this report. Appendix B shows the statistical results of the Quality Circle group meetings. A look at that visual suggests that the highest percentage of employees (45%) feel there should be a formal method of presenting ideas to management. Such a formal procedure, they feel, could well be an employee suggestion program . . .

Finally, as additional sources of data, we then took the six areas as determined by the Quality Circles and had 200 of our 300 employees rank the areas as to their desired involvement. Their percentage of support for the ESP program was supported at 48% . . .

Description of the Program

The program will offer a cash award to the employee whose suggestion is accepted. Final computation of the award amount will vary, based on whether the suggestion results in a positive financial impact for the company. Awards will be based on the percentage of savings to the company over a 12-month period. Such awards will be limited to a

maximum of $10,000. Awards for suggestions that do not have a financial impact, if accepted, will be $100 . . .

All employees, both full- and part-time, will be eligible to participate . . .

Employee Suggestion Programs:
A Needed Addition at Central Company

Any suggestions that would benefit the company may be submitted into the following areas: operations, new product, product improvement, quality, training, community relations, employee morale, and other.

Costs of the Program

Awards for suggestions with a financial impact will be computed as a percentage of the savings to the company. We recommended that such awards be 5% of the savings realized during the first 12 months after implementation of the suggestion. We also recommend that the maximum award be $10,000 . . .

Costs necessary for implementation may be approximately $2,500. Implementation costs will include training and publicity. Administration costs for a year would be approximately $2,500 and would include labor, training, printing, and supplies.

If no awards are granted, the most the company will lose will be the $2,500 implementation costs and annual costs of $2,500 for administration. The total amount at risk for a one-year period would be $5,000 . . .

Administration of the Program

We have developed a four-part form that employees can use to submit suggestions. As we indicated earlier, these suggestions would fall into one of eight categories (see Appendix A). Such a form allows employees to record the current method within Central Company, the proposed new method, and the advantages expected.

Personnel coordinators in each of the 12 major departments will be assigned the duties of coordinating ESP in their areas. They will attend some of the one-hour training sessions other employees attend. Coordinators also will attend three-hour sessions addressing these issues: logistics, including tracking and processing; reviewer selection; and employee awareness campaigns.

Our main goal is to ensure that employees receive credit for their suggestions, following a pattern of review as the following:

-Employee completes form, attaches separate breakdown on savings expected, and submits material to supervisor.

-Supervisor signs, acknowledges awareness of the idea, and returns signed form to employee.

-Employee signs, tears off pink copy, and forwards form to ESP coordinator.

-Coordinator signs, tears off pink copy, and forwards to chairperson of the ESP review committee.

-Chairperson of ESP committee meets with review committee: They accept or reject suggestion, and return decision to ESP coordinator, who gives decision to employee's department head.

-ESP coordinates or determines whether suggestion has financial impact.

IV. BENEFITS OF ADOPTING THE PROGRAM

1. Central Company will increase revenues

Suggestions for new products and improvements to existing products have the potential for increasing marketing share and sales. Last year Far East Company increased revenues by $1.2 million. Of that total 20% can be attributed to its employee suggestion program . . .

2. Central Company will decrease costs

Research conducted by Management Associations and by our outside consultant reports that no one knows how to streamline operations and increase efficiency better than employees. Surveys (on file in the chairperson's office) conducted in 199- show that costs were reduced by 1.2% through employee suggestions. . . .

3. Central Company will enhance its product line

In the training sessions, suggestions for improvements to current products and development of new products will be encouraged. Central employees, as consumers, have ideas for new products that could widen our product lines . . .

4. Central Company's morale will be enhanced

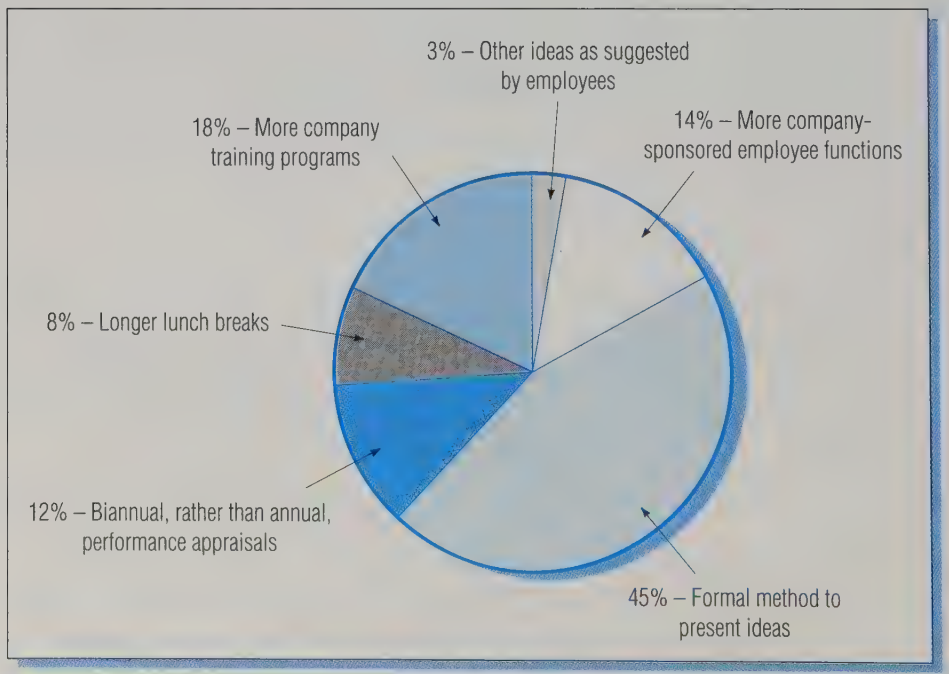
Results from a survey conducted by the American Institute of Human Resources listed "employee inclusions in the decision-making process" as a major factor in improving employee morale. As a corollary to an improved morale, we expect employee turnover to decrease. One former employee who left our employ for a competitor, for example, contributed an idea within his first six months of service that resulted in a new product. Had he remained with us, we would have benefited from that suggestion . . .

5. Central Company will improve its community relations

Appendix B
Quality Circle Recommendations

We conducted seven Quality Circle meetings wherein this question was asked: What could the company do to make you feel more a part of the company? As a result of these meetings-led by our outside consultant-six areas of concern were discovered.

Results of this second investigation produced the following results:



Communication Probe

A significant portion of any report is its recommendation. There may be one; there may be several. Many of these recommendations demand a process or procedure for implementing the recommendations. Actions desired or instructions to implement must be clear to the reader. High-impact writing, say two researchers (clear purpose, layout of direction, short paragraphs, simple sentences, subject and verb close together, active verbs, and others), as applied to compliance instructions, made instructions clearer. Additionally, high-impact style may also elicit more timely responses than other styles of writing. Finally, using the deductive structure of organization (recommendation, conclusion first) is also effective in bringing about a higher rate of compliance and understanding.

Rogers, H. G., & Brown, F. W. (1993). The impact of writing style on compliance instructions. *The Journal of Technical Writing and Communication*, 23(1), 53–71.

In sections of the report just illustrated, the writers decided not to include outside sources or a bibliography. Most of their work was done internally; most data came from internal personnel and outside competitors and related groups. To include the names of competitors—as part of the outside groups consulted—is not appropriate in a report of this type.

SUMMARY

Throughout this chapter we connected the term *formal* with the term *long* report. The formal business report is formal because of its many parts, not because it uses formal language. A long report generally covers more complex issues and is considerably longer than the short reports discussed in Chapter 11. In addition to the body (text, discussion) of the report—where details are fleshed out—prefatory parts include the cover and external title, title fly and internal title, letter or memorandum of transmittal, table of contents, and an executive summary.

Supplementary parts of a long report include (if needed) a bibliography, footnotes or endnotes (citations), if they are necessary; appendixes; a glossary, if needed; and an index, if the report is especially long.

Documentation within the report is of two types: explaining (referring to content) or citing the sources of your information. Important here is your decision as to the format of your citations. Make a decision early to establish a consistent style, perhaps following the format of the Modern Language Association (MLA) or that of the American Psychological Association (APA). Be aware, however, that many business reports have few or no citations.

Finally, effective presentation of your long report is easier today with word processors. When using a word processor, writing, editing, revising, and typing the report is your final task. Also, be sure to apply the seven C's (Chapter 2) to your writing.

Communication Probe

Some companies make an inordinate effort to put together a detailed document that summarizes its corporate and mission statement: to guide behavior, to express an organizational culture, and to inspire commitment. Such reports may be short or long. Regardless of length, determining the company philosophy from the written document demands several things: a compelling philosophical statement, an effective communication and implementation process, and a process for ongoing affirmation and renewal. One company, Eaton, involves employees in an annual affirmation program, giving life to words earlier incorporated into a written statement.

Ledford, G., Wendenhof, J., & Strahley, J. (1995, Winter). Realizing a corporate philosophy. *Organizational Dynamics, 23,* 4–19.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Creating an External and Internal Title to a Foreign Company Report.*** Internal titles to your report should mirror exactly the title on the outside cover of the report. However, committees or report writers often consider several options before arriving at the final title. To achieve such a list of options, complete the following assignment: (1) read the chairperson's letter in an annual report to stockholders of a foreign company or (2) select any statement that an investment house has made about a foreign company. Then write out three different versions of a possible title page for that report. Let the class determine which of the three options comes closest to the content of the original report.

2. ***Outline of Report for Training Programs in an Aircraft Company Expanding into China.*** Read the following case and then offer an outline (down to two levels) on topics you would include in preparing a report on a training program for U.S. Flight Company.

U.S. Flight Company is to add three new support offices in China: in Sichuan province, Hunan province, and in the autonomous region of Xinjiang Uygur. These additional offices will support the expanding service commitments in China.

Those offices will be staffed by special field-service representatives of U.S. Flight who will assist the 12 airlines in China using U.S. Flight equipment. Currently, more than 200 U.S. Flight aircraft are in service, and they expect to add 150 aircraft in 1997.

```
Some joint venture training programs are already in
place.  It is the goal of the expanded training
centers to train more than 1,500 personnel each
year.
```

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Topic Outline.*** If you need practice in organizing topics under meaningful headings, try this assignment. Assume the sales manager of ABC New Car Agency in your city has asked you, a management consultant, to review and evaluate the agency's sales system. The internal control seems to be weak, and something is causing problems.

   The main purpose of your study is to determine the strength of the internal control and its effect on the financial papers for new-car sales.

   You have just finished both secondary and primary research. Two new accounting books (make up names) substantiate your concept for internal control. In your primary research you interviewed 4 middle managers and 15 or 20 employees. You studied the personality of the sales staff and the viewpoints of other personnel. You observed the personnel performing their duties and their interactions. Up to now you have information under the following topics, jumbled and in no useful order:

   ```
   File clerk's job
   Keypunch operator's responsibility
   Dealership's environment
   Title clerk's functions
   Salesperson's personality
   Internal control by buyers' orders
   Personnel system's internal control
   Dealership's history
   Sequence of signatures in sale of a car
   Accounting clerks' duties
   Control system's procedure
   Title clerk's work
   Sales staff's functions
   Flowchart of new-vehicle sales system [you have drawn
     this on seven pages]
   Dealership's new-vehicle sales system
   Introduction
   Conclusions
   Sales manager's part
   Bibliography
   ```

   Choose main headings for the text of this report (3 or 4 should be sufficient). Then organize; place these 19 topics under the headings wherever they belong, in a complete outline of the well-planned formal report.

4. ***Long Formal Report.*** Your assignment is to write a formal informational or analytical report whose body is approximately 15 to 25 double-spaced pages. Choose a topic that is broad enough to justify the length. Yet beware of a topic so broad that it would require volumes. If possible, consider a subject that you know something about or one that especially interests you.

   Try to find a topic that involves a business problem. (For example, you

might know there is too great a turnover of employees in a certain department.) From the problem, and with some thought on your part, you can determine the purpose of your report. Other ideas that you can use as a springboard for a topic are listed below, pertaining to problems involved in:

Accounting, credits, collections

The accountant's role in cost reduction and analysis

Computer programming and errors in monthly statements

Problems and progress of accounting in X Company

Accounting contributions to the effective management of X Company

Problems involved in a bank's converting to a computerized operation

Policy or procedure and degree of communications used by X Company in collecting retail accounts

General management and/or labor

The functioning and problems of your campus student-body governing organization; accomplishments and recommendations for greater effectiveness

A profit-sharing plan for X Company

Hiring handicapped workers: whether it would be charity or good business for X Company

A program for achieving optimum discipline in X Company

Business outlook for Y industry or X Company

Proposed plan for hiring and training minority groups in X Company

Development of a profitable ski area on a certain mountain

Suggestions for X Company's response to Z Union's attempt to organize workers

Recommendations for a formal salary scale for X Company

Personnel administration

Development of a personnel testing program for X Company

Analysis of the merit rating system of X Company

A safety program for X Company

The performance of women in top executive positions

Survey, interpretation, and recommendation—after a study on attitudes toward certain recent troublesome problems:

- Opinion of X Company's employees regarding wages, working hours, parking, food services, promotion plan
- Opinion of students in your school regarding grading, credit hours for certain courses, student parking, housing

Marketing

A promotional program for introduction of X product

A new plan for X Company to offer incentives to sales personnel
Where X Company should locate its next supermarket
How X company can measure effectiveness in its advertising
How downtown merchants can cope with suburban shopping centers

After you have clearly determined the purpose of your report, state it in one sentence. Continue your preliminary preparation. Then submit to your professor (or anyone he or she suggests) a memo report of your working plan. Be sure to include in this memo at least the following: problem, purpose, methodology, readers (both primary and secondary), and suggested outline. In this outline show the order for the introduction, major divisions of the text, subheadings for each major division, and the type of terminal section.

After you have approval of your working plan, you can begin to collect your data; then organize this material and interpret it. With the completion of this last stage—interpretation—you can draw conclusions and make recommendations. Naturally, if you're writing an informational report, you will skip interpretation of material and merely summarize. Also at this time you should prepare (at least in rough-draft form) your tables and any other necessary visual aids. If your professor requests it, submit the final outline that you will follow in writing your report—the one that will become your table of contents.

Now you should be ready to write. Choose the right time and place and follow the rules outlined in the chapter—for both the first draft and the revisions. After your final revision, you can type (or have typed) the body of the report in final draft, or you can first write the necessary prefatory and supplemental parts. In this report assignment include at least the following: cover, title page, letter of transmittal (or preface), and table of contents. Also, you will need to include other parts—especially appendix and bibliography—if your report requires them. If the transmittal may affect part of what is included in the body, you should at least plan the transmittal before the final typing of the body.

Although the content and presentation of the material are most important, also remember the role that mechanics play. Be sure you have nothing that distracts your reader from concentrating on what you want to tell. Thus, be sure the spelling, grammar, punctuation, and appearance are acceptable.

5. ***Information Available or On-Line or Optical Disks.*** Go to either your library or your computer center where on-line databases or disks are located. Report to the class—with actual printouts—the various kinds of data available under common headings such as the following:

General business information
Company financial information
Statistical data
Industry-specific information

Your goal is to offer information as to the many kinds of electronic business data that are available. Sample printouts will permit your classmates to examine your collected information.

6. ***Bibliography Styles of MLA and APA.*** Obtain from your library or local bookstore the *MLA Handbook for Writers of Research Papers* or *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association* and give the class examples of the citation style in a bibliography from either of the two works for each of the following references:

   A one-author source; a two-author source
   A computer software source
   A doctoral dissertation
   Two books by the same person in a bibliography

7. ***Report on Software Packages for Visual Aids.*** As companies become more electronically versatile, some boards of directors insist on consistency in the use of visual aids: within reports and as overheads or slides to accompany an oral presentation. Complete a report to a board of directors that responds to the following charge:

   The Board requests that you act as chairperson, along with a committee of Todd Jones, Roberta Stein, and Alanzo Pina, to complete a report on which software package our company should use within reports. We wish you to review some of the popular programs available, such as Harvard Graphics, Chart, Powerpoint, and MacPaint. There may be others you may wish to investigate. We are interested in knowing what our suppliers are using, a review of the complete costs for instituting a consistent program across the company, and a time frame for implementation. We would like your report, along with recommendation, within two months. The Secretary of the Board, Ms. Joetta Shriver, will respond to questions and review expenses in connection with your investigation.

8. ***Comparative Interview of Two Writers.*** Interview (1) a writer at a local newspaper or school paper and (2) a manager or administrator in your school. Determine the steps the newspaper writer goes through in preparing a report for his or her organization. Questions you may wish to ask both persons could include the following:

   - In what form (oral or written) is the charge given you for your writing assignment?
   - Do you do your initial outline of the topic alone, or do you depend on the help of others?
   - What differences do you see between preparing your work and that of a company manager and a newspaper writer? And vice versa.
   - Do you give your first draft to another person for review?
   - Which guidelines do you feel are the most important when preparing your final draft?
   - Are there suggestions you would give to potential writers?

Chapter 13

Proposals

I. Purposes of Proposals

II. Kinds of Proposals
- A. Research Proposals
- B. Business Proposals

III. Parts of Proposals
- A. Title Page
- B. Executive Summary, Abstract, Synopsis
- C. Draft Contract
- D. Table of Contents
- E. Introduction
- F. Background
- G. Procedures
- H. Equipment and Facilities
- I. Personnel
- J. Budget
- K. Appendixes

IV. Short Proposals

V. Long Formal Proposals
- A. Request for Proposal (RFP)
- B. Chronology of Procedures for Solicited Major Proposals
- C. U.S. Government Proposals
- D. Sample Sections of Long Proposals

VI. Writing Style and Appearance

VII. Summary

VIII. Exercises and Problems

Persuasion lies at the heart of proposal writing. You seek to get your reader to do something, to accept your written plan for completing a task. It matters little whether your proposal is a memo or a full document. What does matter is the structure you apply to writing good proposals. You may write internal proposals, suggesting that your department can do a good job of completing a project or accomplishing a task for another department. You and your company may also go outside, submitting a "bid" that you are qualified to do something for someone else—for a fee.

Proposals may be written to departments within your own company or to outside requesters.

Thus professors submit proposals to companies stating that they can help solve problems within a company; defense contractors submit proposals to the federal government that they can build something for the Department of Defense; advertising agencies bid on being the "agency of record" in publicizing a product or an idea for a client; companies submit proposals to foreign governments that they can build everything from bridges to skyscrapers—the list is endless.

This chapter discusses purposes, kinds, and parts of proposals; short and long proposals; and writing style and appearance of proposals.

PURPOSES OF PROPOSALS

The federal government is one of the largest requesters for proposals.

Numerous groups solicit proposals; the U.S. government is one of the foremost requesters. These requests may appear in trade publications or newspapers, or on occasion a Request for Proposal (RFP) is directed toward a company with specific expertise. Proposal topics are varied, as the following examples illustrate:

Communication Probe

Many universities in the United States have offices devoted solely to keeping track of proposal requests offered to the public and assisting others in writing responses to those proposals. Personnel and various booklets in those offices often tell why proposals writers fail—what gets in the way of being successful. Likewise, the federal government—and often chiefs of staff of members of Congress—make a sincere effort to help contractors obtain grants and success when approaching federal or state government offices. The Chief of Staff for Senator Dodd of Connecticut once pinpointed the central problems that block effective proposal writing: unclear purpose, inability to be concise, failure to follow the formalities as stated in the request for bid, unqualified individual or company, and lack of supporting data. Interestingly, only one of these drawbacks does not relate to writing.

Powell, M. C. (1996, February). [Interview with Michael C. Powell, Chief of Staff to Senator Christopher Dodd, Connecticut]. Washington, D.C.

- To sell property, such as airplanes, machines, buildings
- To construct parking structures, buildings, bridges, water systems, complete power plants, highways
- To survey water areas for possible oil fields
- To plan and construct airport baggage conveyor systems
- To clean up the ground soil at military airports

Although the above topics are large in scope, smaller projects are also made known to individuals and corporations:

- Improving engineering and just-in-time (JIT) performance within a company
- Communicating strategic issues throughout the company
- Preparing international managers for work in Asia
- Planning and basic research before developing an automobile factory in Mexico
- Constructing—as a subcontractor—buildings as part of a large project

Thus the purpose of a proposal is similar to that of a recommendation-justification report, discussed in Chapter 11. Both aim to solve a problem, alter a procedure, find answers to questions, offer advice and training, or conduct research on a topic of interest to both parties.

Outside reviewers may also read your proposal submitted to a requester.

In some instances proposals submitted to a requesting agency or a company are also sent to outside readers or a review committee. These experts evaluate and can make recommendations concerning the credibility of the proposer, the legitimacy of the proposed benefits of the proposed services, the worthiness of previously produced products, and other relevant topics. Basically a requester is concerned with one question: Will the proposal as stated meet our needs? Money is the main medium of exchange, but some firms also barter (offer their services or product for another's services or product).

KINDS OF PROPOSALS

Research Proposals

Proposals are sales presentations, easily classified into research proposals and business proposals. Simply put, a research proposal is usually academic in nature. Professors, or the school for which they work, desire to obtain a grant in response to a request or an announcement from the government or other agency. A proposal may even appear in a foreign language.

EXAMPLE 1 [*From government's Commerce Business Daily.*]

```
[In Japanese] Hiroyuld Ito, Director-General, Ad-
ministration Bureau, Nagoya University, Furo-Cho,
Chikusa-Ku, Nagoya 464-01, Japan. . . .  Agency's
Public notice for this tender no 510.  Opening date
15:00, Oct. 31, 1996.  Open tender no: product:
```

multidisplay information system for campus communication . . .
[*Then follows the details needed and further information and office to contact.*]

EXAMPLE 2 [*From U.S. Information Agency (USIA).*]

Professors and school or university departments often submit requests for research proposals.

USIA's Office of Academic Programs seeks proposals to the College and University Development Program in Business Management for Croatia and Macedonia. . . . The purpose of the exchange program is to develop curricula and teaching methodologies for foreign faculties in the field of business management. . . . Courses developed may include, but are not limited to, marketing, production management, economics, industrial relations, finance, accounting, international business, and business communications.
[*Then follows information on contacts for submitting the proposal.*]

Academic institutions submit most research proposals. Companies also want to become involved. That way they make contact with and become involved in the agency requesting the proposal. But most business employees will submit business proposals, our focus in the following discussion.

Business Proposals

In length, proposals may be similar to other reports—short or long and formal. Also, like reports, proposals may be *solicited* or *unsolicited.* An organization often knows in advance those individuals and corporations that are qualified to bid on a job or help solve a problem. So requests may come via the mails (as illustrated later in this chapter), or in the case of the government via the daily published *Commerce Business Daily,* in which between 500 and 1,000 notices are announced.

When you write a solicited business proposal, remember that you most likely will have many competitors also bidding for that contract (and the remuneration). Follow meticulously the proposal requirements of the solicitor, regarding problem, needed solution, specific work to be done or equipment to be installed, even the format of the proposal, number of copies desired, deadlines, and so forth. Whenever possible, use the outline and same words the agency has in its literature or guidelines. Do not use jargon that only you and your assistants can understand.

Likewise, when you write an *un*solicited proposal, you need to convince the reader or review committee that you understand the organization's problem and that your firm or you are qualified to solve it successfully.

PARTS OF PROPOSALS

The parts of a proposal, listed below, may be used in major business proposals on sales of your company's services, expertise, equipment, or extensive installation

facilities. Or they may be adapted for a research study within your own firm or for another company outside your firm. Of course, only long, comprehensive proposals require most of or all these parts. Smaller projects may use only a few. Information required for a $100 million grant or sales contract will surely be longer and more profound than for a $500 research allowance. Therefore, *consider carefully which parts are desirable for your specific proposal outline.*

Title Page

Title pages of proposals are similar to either short or long reports.

Most organizations specify the information to be included in the title page, some even providing special forms that summarize basic administrative and fiscal data. As a minimum, the title page should include the title, the name of the person or company to whom the proposal is submitted, the person submitting the proposal, and the date. When in doubt, follow the suggestions in Chapter 12 concerning the title page for a report.

Executive Summary, Abstract, Synopsis

Even brief proposals should have an executive summary. Because you will be competing with others for the same opportunity, some evaluators will initially read only the executive summary, seeking to gain a quick overview. In fact, the executive summary should speak for the complete proposal, it should be able to stand alone, and it should summarize how objectives will be met and what procedures will be followed. Budget figures are frequently omitted because proposal abstracts may receive wide distribution.

Some proposal readers feel that the executive summary is one of the most important parts of a proposal; give it careful time and effort.

Draft Contract

A draft contract allows the receiver to offer a counteroffer.

In long proposals—and if the reader is nonhostile—a draft contract may be inserted after an executive summary. Such an early presentation (deductive) gives an immediate overview, including financial information.

Table of Contents

Brief proposals usually do not require a table of contents. Long proposals do require one, as well as a list of tables, figures, and illustrations.

Introduction

Purpose

Do not take for granted that the reader of your proposal will be the same person who sent you a request for a proposal. Staff members often give the proposal an initial reading, actually doing some screening before sending the proposal along, which is why you should write the introduction as if you were approaching a nonspecialist. Your purpose is often stated in infinitive form, as for example:

- To recommend a format for Board of Director Reports
- To bid on supplying 40 aircraft engines to Aviation Supplies Corporation
- To be the printer for the biannual Defense Contract Audit Manuals
- To supply the engineering data needed to retrofit Company Y's nuclear generating plant

Problem

In a business proposal, show clearly that you understand the problem or problems. Does your reader need a complex remodeling and construction job or extensive equipment replacement? If pertinent, mention difficulties that may be encountered and consider how you propose to overcome them. If your proposal concerns a research study, is it a community problem, for the local area or a general area?

Scope

Be precise about the scope of a project when dealing with a foreign country or company.

If your proposal is for service or equipment you are selling, in what areas will it serve the prospective buyer? Define the boundaries of your project. If you are proposing a research study, will you study one area of a community, company, department, or severe problem? What boundaries are you setting to accomplish your objectives?

Project Team

Even in short reports some proposals include a listing of the individuals who will work on the project, including the project director. In long proposals such information is a must, including a brief vita on each individual.

Communication Probe

Clarity in Stating the Problem and Purpose Statement

We are tempted to say "that it goes without saying" that a good report, a good proposal includes basic information. Thus most requests for proposals (RFPs) are a public cry for help: to solve a problem, to find an answer, to complete a project. We recommend that when writing a proposal, the problem be stated clearly: It is the core issue, the main theme, the heart of what your proposal will address. Without a clear understanding of the problem, your recommendation is meaningless. The problem statement is distinctly different from the *purpose statement*, a term referring to the precise end (stated preferably in an infinitive form) of the entire report.

Wayne, F. S., & Scriven, J. D. (1991, March). Problems and purpose statements: Are they synonymous terms in writing reports for business? *The Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication, 54*(1), 30–37.

Background

If your proposal is short, the background may be omitted; in a longer proposal, information such as the following is usually included:

- Previous work completed on identical or related projects
- Possibly, literature reviews on the subject, particularly your evaluation of them
- Statements showing how your proposal will build on the already completed projects and research

Procedures

Here you briefly state, without exaggeration, how you will meet the requirements of your reader. A good way to review your proposals—they will be different in each situation—is to follow the suggestions in Checklist 13.1.

Equipment and Facilities

Show that you have thought deeply enough to realize what facilities will be needed. If your proposal is for your company's bid on an enormous construction job, probably several departments will cooperate with you in presenting needed facts and figures.

For a research project, state what equipment and facilities you already have for use, and assure that you can get the rest. Depending on the type of project, you might, for example, need everything from an electronic blackboard to a small airplane.

Personnel

If you did not include brief information on the individuals involved in the project in the introduction, a longer section is appropriate here. Two topics should be addressed: the personnel arrangements and the company areas involved, and their individual qualifications, expressed in complete biographic form. Include also the percentages of time that personnel will devote to the project.

Checklist 13.1 Basic Preparation for Writing a Proposal

1. Be realistic as to what you can accomplish. Avoid overextending your capabilities and those of your company.
2. Be specific as to method of meeting all goals.
3. Be precise with the time schedule.
4. Be clear as to how you will evaluate your work, production, or product.
5. Be exact as to the scope: What you will do and what you will not do.

Budget

Sponsors or organizations requesting proposals frequently specify how the budget should be presented. Read such specifications carefully. Not all groups allow the same costs.

While some budget sections may be in tabular or even a form of visual aid, it is customary to include a "budget justification" section, stating in paragraph form a further rationale for your financial figures.

Figure 13.1 is a sample tabular 12-month budget. "Sponsor" is the government office or organization for which the work will be done; "Company" is the firm that requests the funding.

TWELVE-MONTH BUDGET

	Sponsor	Company	Total
PERSONNEL			
Project director, quarter-time	$ ...	$ ...	$ ...
Project associate, 10%	...	...	...
Research assistant, half-time	...	...	...
Clerk-typist, half-time	...	...	...
Subtotal	$ ...	$ ...	$ ...
Staff benefits (21% of salaries and wages)	$ ...	$ ...	$ ...
Subtotal	$ ...	$ ...	$ ...
CONSULTANTS	$ ...	$ ...	$ ...
MATERIALS AND SUPPLIES			
Miscellaneous office supplies	$ ...	$ ...	$ ...
Glassware	...	...	...
Chemicals	...	...	...
Subtotal	$ ...	$ ...	$ ...
TRAVEL			
Project director consultation with sponsor, Washington, D.C., and return. 1 person, 2 days:	$ ...	$ ...	$ ...
Air fare	...	...	...
Per diem @ $100/day	...	...	...
Local transportation	$ ...	$ ...	$ ...
Subtotal			
TOTAL DIRECT COSTS	$ ...	$ ...	$ ...
INDIRECT COSTS (60% of modified total direct costs)	$ ...	$ ...	$ ...
GRAND TOTAL	**$45,064**	**$7,909**	**$52,973**

Figure 13.1 Sample budget.

Appendixes

Some reviewers of proposals leave reading of appendixes to the last, if they read them at all. Additional bulk may to the reader represent additional padding, and could produce a negative reaction. Certainly, visuals (maps or graphs) and some pertinent letters of support and endorsement can be added. But when in doubt, leave out.

SHORT PROPOSALS

Following are sections of a proposal submitted to a utility company to complete two units of their power substation, part of a much larger project:

- Letter of transmittal
- Executive summary
- Body of proposal with information on: project team, scope of services, construction contract packages, computerized engineering system

Letter of Transmittal

Engineering Company
[*address*]
[*City, State, Zip*]

September 22, 199-

Mr. Thurston Blair
[*usual internal address*]

Dear Mr. Blair:

With pleasure we respond to your Request for Proposal sent to us on August 20, 199-. We at Engineering Company are happy to be included in your list of companies qualified to construct two units

Communication Probe

The term *fact book* accompanies some proposals: various collections of evidence to accompany the prose discussion. Additionally, proposals to either the federal government or to outside agencies now include computer graphics technology. Thus, it is now possible, with the ever-increasing numbers of software packages, to use color graphics and photographs in the proposals. Good prose, plus high-technology graphics, can lead to successful proposal presentation.

Barr, S. (1995, Winter). Proposal production: Full color and fast! *Economic Development Review, 13,* 37–40; Weddle, R. (1995, winter). Preparing tailored fact books and prospect proposals. *Economic Development Review, 13,* 32–36.

of your power plant, completely with all internal controls.

Since receiving your letter we have appointed a special internal committee to respond to the questions and procedures outlined in your earlier note. The attached report is structured to correspond to the numbered sections of your letter.

You will note that your requirements are highlighted in italics with our repsonses following in normal-type style. On occasion we have also included some editorial comments where we feel we are especially strong in meeting your requirements.

Throughout, we have quoted figures that we feel respond favorably to your request that we keep our budget figures at a minimum. Indeed, we feel our figures will be highly competitive inasmuch as we completed a similar project for another utility in Australia. References from that company and many others with whom we have worked in the past are available for your inspection and review.

If after reading the enclosed proposal you have questions or desire additional information, please give me a call at (313) 555-4567. If I do not hear from you, the committee and I look forward to meeting you and your review committee on October 9, 199-, at 9:00 A.M. in our offices.

JR<sub>9:hhh

Sincerely,

Henry Holt
Vice President, General Manager

Executive Summary

Engineering Company is capable of constructing Units 1 and 2 of Utility Company power plant project, with a common control room between the two units, for a total cost of $6 million.

To meet the above responsibilities we have moved forward on the following assumptions:

- No provisions have been made for additional units on the site.
- The project will be completed within one year after signing of the final contract.
- Optional labor-hours beyond the contract will be billed at the rate of $25 plus 15%.
- The control units will be air-insulated.
- The soil conditions presume that foundations can be supported on undisturbed earth.

- The water source will be the Fox River.
- No auxiliary boilers will be required.

All pretesting of the site confirms that we can complete the project within one year, as stated in your Request for Proposal letter of September 22, 199-.

Seven individuals will be assigned to completing the project: an executive representative, a project manager, two project engineers, a project construction manager, a lead construction manager, and a lead procurement representative. The lead construction manager will be on site through the completion of the project.

Body of Proposal

[*The proposal follows the main sections of your Request for Proposal: The Project Team; Scope of Services; Draft Contracts; Financial Details; and Similar Project Labor-Hour Comparisons.*]

Project Team

Henry Holt, P.E.
Executive Representative-Responsible executive in overall charge of the operation
Vice President and General Manager
Publications information
Vita information

John McCabe, P.E.
Proposed project manager
Publication information
Vita information

W. Theofile Cooley
Proposed project engineer
Publication information
Vita information (and a list of five other names)

Scope of Services

I. Scope of Services

The services are delineated below (subject to addition or deletion as the Owner may determine). [*Sections have been omitted.*]

A. A Project Design Manual will be prepared within 180 days of the contract award outlining all project parameters for the re-

view and approval of the Owner. Included in the manual will be eight areas:

-General description of the units
-Organizational charts of the Owner and Engineering Company
-Administrative procedures
-Engineering criteria
-Description of contract packages (both equipment and construction)
-List of studies to be performed
-Project economic criteria
-Testing and start-up procedures

. . .

H. Provide a scale model program coordinated with various equipment suppliers. That model will yield sufficient detailed information to be used as a design verification and training tool.

We will prepare a 3/8-inch scale model of the units. Structural members, equipment, ducts, and control panels will be included. The model will be shipped to the site to be used during construction. Two hundred hours will be required to complete the model.

. . .

L. Procurement and related services

1. Will recommend a list of qualified bidders for both equipment and supplies. Visit the bidder facilities and prequalify bidders or to verify qualifications.

2. Assist the Owner in procedures for purchasing and procurement recommendations on equipment and materials with long lead times.

3. Contract specifications will be prepared in accordance with all government regulations.

II. Proposal Construction Contract Packages

Title	Explanation of Scope
General Services	Site mobilization, security services, maintenance, fur-

	nish and install temporary construction power.
Site Preparation	Site clearing, rough grading, excavation and fill; furnish and install storm drainage, erosion control systems and site fencing. Construction sedimentation control ponds, roads, and parking facility subgrades. Furnish and install all temporary buildings for engineering work.
Material Testing	Perform all site material testing.
Main Foundations	Construct base slab for the two units. Place concrete. Furnish and install underslab and embedded piping, grounding, and conduit for electrical units.
Unit Enclosures	Furnish and install main building enclosures for the two requested units complete with elevated concrete floors and floor metal deck, siding, roof deck, doors, sash, louvers and masonry. Furnish and install complete interior partitions and architectural work for main units including plumbing and plumbing fixtures.

[*Thereafter follow several pages of additional detail.*]

III. Computerized Engineering System

For years Engineering Company has been in the foreground of using computer-assisted engineering techniques. Our 15,000-square-foot planning and design building houses all the conceivable forms of computing hardware and software. Additionally, we have on staff three computer programmers, two technical experts, and an office dedicated to working with individuals directly involved in the project.

A software package developed in-house will be used throughout the project. That software currently contains over 100 standard report formats. And with the Report Writer insert in our program, our reports can readily be modified to meet the Owner's needs and ours.

Copies of several of our report forms are included in the appendix to this report.

Foremost, our system will be set up following authorization with the overall architect for your project. Initially, the installation will be in our [*city*] office with a CRT and plotter in our on-site office. Before construction begins, a minicomputer will be moved to the job site.

As a summary of our capabilities, the following software subsystems will be used throughout the project:

- -Command processing
- -Planning and scheduling
- -Estimating
- -Cost and performance measurement
- -Property records
- -Data management
- -Report writer capable of handling reports as the following:
  - ⇒ Time Scheduling
  - ⇒ Target Scheduling
  - ⇒ Estimating
  - ⇒ Accounting
  - ⇒ Cost Controls
  - ⇒ Graphics

Realize that in working with some foreign governments, a contract as a result of an accepted proposal means bargaining will still occur.

It has been your authors' experience that over the years more detail, more precision is being included in proposals. You will note in the above example that much detailed information is included. Such detail avoids misunderstandings,

Communication Probe

Visual displays are often a part of each proposal. Even are used in completing a project. In our opinion one of the best books on the subject is Tufte's *The Visual Display of Quantitative Information,* a true masterpiece of prose and visual examples. Therein Tufte notes five principles for graphic excellence that can be used in proposals and other kinds of business writing:

1. Interesting data is a mixture of substance, statistics, and design.
2. Clarify, precision, and efficiency are needed to communicate complex ideas.
3. Giving the greatest number of ideas in the shortest time is a mark of visual excellence.
4. Multivariate visuals distinguishes it from average visuals.
5. Truth, as an ethical precept, is core to good graphic design.

Tufte, E. (1983). *The visual display of quantitative information.* Cheshire, CT: Graphics Press.

avoids lawsuits, and hastens completion of a project. On the international level such proposal detail is even more necessary. Add the additional impediment of several languages, and the problems of interpretation can multiply. Too often it is said of foreign companies and governments, "once the proposal is signed, the real bargaining begins." If you agree on the details early, you avoid the miscalculations that can slow or even stop a project until the clarification is complete.

LONG FORMAL PROPOSALS

Large projects require proposals with elaborate detail; some may be bound into several volumes when the dollar figure is in millions or even billions of dollars. Excerpts relating to information connected to long formal proposals follow:

Interest groups from throughout the United States have offices in Washington, D.C., to keep tabs on current and upcoming requests for proposals.

- Request for Proposal (RFP)
- Chronology of procedures for solicited major proposals
- Submitting proposals to the federal government
- Samples of sections from long proposals

Request for Proposal (RFP)

A government, a company, an agency, an individual may send an RFP to outside vendors who they feel are qualified to complete a given project.

Requester	Possible Vendors
Department of Defense (airplanes, ships)	Vendors have to possess basic qualifications or on occasion have produced products for the government; thus qualified, large vendors receive requests to submit bids for specific airplanes, submarines, warships, and numerous other items used by the federal government
Electric utility (plant modification)	Design and construction companies: to either modify, for instance, present nuclear facilities to coal-fired facilities
Auto company (foreign auto plant expansion)	Professors at major universities with expertise in the country in which the auto company desires to expand
Foreign government (Singapore airport expansion)	Construction companies in Japan, Indonesia, and the United States
Foreign government (high-speed train service from Beijing to Shanghai)	Foreign governments and railroad engineering firms in Germany, Japan, and France
Survey of consumer attitudes (social research)	Schools of business that have expertise in assessing consumer attitudes throughout the country

Thus, for any of these projects the agency could submit an RFP to an outside vendor who they feel qualifies to bid on the request. Each vendor—and there may be several—receives the identical preliminary information.

"Short lists" consists of persons or groups who are the final candidates for winning the proposal.

Such a common approach helps the soliciting group. It can now compare data, determine who will be asked to submit a more detailed proposal. (Being asked to submit a second proposal is called making the "short list.") In brief, the soliciting group for large contracts, for instance in excess of $100 million, (1) sends a preliminary request to possible interested parties and (2) eliminates through this initial screening some companies. It is the "short list" of vendors who are asked for more detailed information, again in competition with others on that "short list."

Excerpt from Request for Proposal (RFP) Letter

The following letter is from a large automotive company in the United States interested in building a completely new facility to produce automobiles. This preliminary letter sought to determine which construction companies had some interest in the project before requesting more detailed information.

Letterhead of Requester

Gentlemen:

Our company as you know has for over 80 years been involved in the designing, engineering, and assembling of automobiles throughout the United States. We would like to discuss your firm's capabilities, resources, experience, philosophy, and innovative approaches to assist our internal team in the design and construction of an entirely new auto assembly facility.

If your response is favorable, we will provide a complete conceptual package containing master specifications, building sections and elevations, a construction budget, scope of services, etc. Your organization, if ultimately selected, will perform complete engineering services to general construction bid documents. These services will be rendered on a lump-sum basis.

If your firm is interested in being a partner in this endeavor, we would like to hear from you and arrange for a discussion in your facilities within the next month. In line with our company's approach, we have attached certain preliminary information and will present further details related to the project upon our visit. To make arrangements, please call . . .

Sincerely,

[*Name*]

Checklist 13.2 Request for Proposal (RFP) Communication

1. Leave no doubt as to the product or service for which you desire bids.
2. Give the precise name of the person and address—even the phone number—to whom your proposal should be sent.
3. Be precise as to what bidders must include: This makes initial screening easier in locating qualified candidates.
4. Indicate the time by which the proposal should arrive.

Attached to this cover letter were four pages requesting preliminary information, divided into four major categories and subpoints. Note the detail; note the importance given to company philosophy in addition to construction data.

Company's philosophy and mission

Corporate philosophy

People philosophy

Mission

General description of possible facilities

Administration and support facilities

Ancillary facilities

General assembly facility

Body shop facility

Manufacturing facility

Paint shop facility

Powerhouse-cogeneration facility

Powertrain facility

Site work

Stamping facility

Water-wastewater facility

Tentative Company engineering schedule

General Company technical requirements

Chronology of Procedures for Solicited Major Proposals

A complete chronology of the entire process for a major proposal could go through eight steps:

1. The soliciting company publicly announces a project in professional publications, newspapers, and newsletters or writes to certain companies asking if they are interested in bidding on the project. (See the cover letter on p. 368 as an example of such an initial request.)
2. Contacted companies, and others reacting to the public announcement, submit preliminary proposals based on initial request information.
3. The soliciting company reviews all submitted documents, eliminates some companies on the basis of this preliminary review, and establishes a "short list" of finalists.
4. The soliciting company (a) asks each of the finalists bidding for the contract to submit a highly detailed proposal and (b) sets deadlines for receiving the proposal.

The oral statement offered in defense of the proposal—often when making the short list—must be well-prepared, well-rehearsed.

5. Finalist (the "short list" candidates) companies select their written and oral presentation teams; writing of their proposal proceeds through several editions; oral rehearsals of statements based on the proposal occur.
6. Finalist companies submit proposals to the soliciting group; dates are established for the oral presentation to the soliciting group.
7. Finalist companies make their presentations.
8. Finalist companies wait for response—from one month to as long as half a year, or longer.

U.S. Government Proposals

The preceding eight-step process is common in business proposals, and the federal government—one of the largest receivers of proposals—has a similar review process. There, however, the soliciting agency will hold its own internal review, but may also involve outside experts, frequently including representatives, for instance, from the Defense Contract Audit Agency.

When one is writing a proposal for the government, it is necessary to meet strictly each agency's proposal requirements, learned through contacting a contracting officer or requesting proposal specifications as announced in the *Commerce Business Daily.* Such a request for a proposal follows:

U.S. Department of Labor, Office of Procurement Services Room S-5220, 200 Constitution Ave., N.W. Washington, D.C. 20210

Government proposals save space and time by extensive use of abbreviations; a key for those abbreviations often precedes the request.

70-PERSONAL LIBRARY SOFTWARE & CENTRAL SITE MAINTENANCE SOL RFP L/A 94-38 DUE 091694 POC Raymond J. Vanzego, Contract Negotiator (202) 555-6445. The Department of Labor intends to enter into sole source negotiations with Personal Librarian Software, of 2400 Research Boulevard, Suite 350, Rockville, Maryland 20850, for Personal Library Software. 25 current users on 300 enterprise network and add-on software including "P/L Batch"

and "Replica" as needed. Also, Central Site Maintenance Plan that will include future upgrades as released. This notice is for information purposes only. No solicitation document is available. Interested persons may identify their interest and capability to respond to the requirement or submit proposals. All responses to this notice must be received within fifteen (15) days of the date of publication of this notice, and must cite RFP L/A 94-38. (0244)

After reading the above solicitation, you could contact the person named first in the proposal. He would give you additional information and send appropriate forms.

The Washington, D.C., area and its environs are crowded with offices of special-interest groups seeking to obtain contracts from the government. Many of those offices maintain personal contacts with many government offices and know of impending RFPs. Additionally, these offices include samples of successful proposals they have used in the past. Fair warning: The competition is keen; proposals must be well-written and -researched.

Sample Sections of Long Proposals

So important are proposals for some firms that they have spent thousands of dollars to equip their own company libraries with individual study rooms and up-to-date research facilities plus a staff of typists, designers, photographers, editors, and computer experts. Their main purpose is to help their marketing representatives turn out top-quality, winning proposals—solicited and unsolicited.

Checklist 13.3 Submitting Proposals to the Government

Most government Requests for Proposals are sufficiently detailed. Thus in your reading of the *Commerce Business Daily* you will receive sufficient precise information. Nevertheless, we recommend that you speak with the person or office listed in the announcement, for two reasons: Doing so will answer your questions and will indicate your deep interest in the proposal. In that phone call:

1. Ask if they are willing to send you sample successful proposals from the past.
2. Ask if the proposal is a new one.
3. Ask if there is in place a contractor whose contract has expired (*by law the government must request open bids on the expiration of certain contracts*).
4. Ask if there is anything not listed in the request that you should be concerned with in writing the proposal.

Often thousands of dollars are spent on preparing the visual appearance of a proposal.

Nor is visual persuasion on the written proposal neglected. Company logos are often on each page and name card. Color is used extensively. All visual aids may be bound in a separate booklet or be on various pages of the proposal. For example, one marketing executive's successful unsolicited major proposal has on its colorful cover an accurate sketch of the prospective customer's buildings. The proposal—32 pages, single-spaced—is attractively bound and protected by a plastic cover. Inside are also five appropriate full-page pictures. Here is that proposal's considerate transmittal letter (with changed names); it was typed on the company's letterhead and bound in the proposal:

Dear Mr. Johnson:

Purpose: review of RASC needs

Thank you for the opportunity to review the communication needs of the Region Administrative Services Center.

Problem areas and solutions to be discussed

In the past few years this administrative center has grown rapidly in both staff and services to the community. Because your communications system has not kept pace with your growth, a number of communication-related problems have developed.

Your department heads, receptionists, and employees have been most cooperative during our discussions to determine major communication problem areas. The problems uncovered and the solutions to them are discussed in the following pages.

RASC benefits from two proposed systems

Metrodynamic Communications looks forward to providing a telecommunications system that will grow and expand as your Center expands. To meet that goal, we recommend a Direction PBX. The Direction PBX features stored program control combined with time division switching, which provides exceptional versatility for today's needs and is easily adaptable to future requirements.

As an alternative, Centrex II will also respond to your needs, with capabilities somewhat different from the Direction system.

Benefits now and in future

Either system will provide the Regional Administrative Services Center with an efficient, flexible, versatile system for today and tomorrow. I am looking forward to working with you on a continuing basis.

Sincerely,

Communication Probe

Fifteen academic researchers were interviewed to probe some of the complex relationships between them and outside funding agencies. It was found that some of the problems of academics also pertain to other proposal writers. A major conclusion was this: Proposal writing and the funding process is a highly political, multi-institutional enterprise. Those two situational factors, and others, mitigated against successful funding of proposals. As with interpersonal communication, all felt the need for more communication between researchers and potential funding agencies.

Mehlenbacher, B. (1994, September). The rhetorical nature of academic research funding. *IEEE Transactions on Professional Communication, 37,* 157–162.

This proposal's table of contents includes six major parts. Each part is preceded by a title listing its topics, some with subheads and pertinent pictures. The body of the proposal is neatly typed with helpful headings (second-, third-, and fourth-degree). Colorful illustrations and pictures help emphasize that the proposed system is "efficient, economical, flexible." Important figures, rates, charges, and other details are shown in tables both within the text and in the appendix.

The following are sample headings found in longer formal proposals for (1) a general proposal, (2) a construction management proposal for several million dollars, and (3) a research proposal.

PROPOSAL 1 *A general formal proposal.*

1. *Prefatory parts*
   Title page
   Letter of transmittal
   Table of contents
   List of tables and/or figures (if any)
   Executive summary or abstract

2. *Body of proposal*
   Introduction
      Problem
      Need
      Background
      Objectives or purpose
   Procedures (discussion section)
      Methods and sources
      Plan of attack
      Sequence of activities
      Equipment, facilities, products
      Personnel qualifications

Evaluation and benefits of project
Budget of costs, prices, total bid

3. *Supplementary parts*
Agency forms
Budget justification
References
Tables, maps, or graphs (if any)

PROPOSAL 2 *A construction management proposal.*

1. *Prefatory parts*
Cover, with title
Inside title page
Table of contents
Request for proposal letter (owner's solicitation letter)
Response to proposal letter (company's cover letter)
Description of owner's requirements
Scope of services
Description of facilities
Working relationship
Contracts
Schedule for selecting architect or engineer
Phase 1, qualifying firms
Phase 2, interviews
Phase 3, negotiations of fees and notice to proceed

2. *Body of proposal*
General format
Approach to delivery of services
Capabilities of firm
Demonstration of management system
Personnel in delivery of services
Contract terms and conditions
Firm information
Fee

3. *Supplementary parts*
Master project schedule
Vendor surveillance
Projected fuel analysis
Table defining direct costs, overhead fees

PROPOSAL 3 *A research proposal.*

1. *Prefatory parts*
Title
Abstract
Table of contents
Introduction (including statement of problem, purpose of research, and significance of research)

2. *Body of proposal*
   Background (including literature survey)
   Description of proposed research (including method or approach)
   Description of relevant institutional resources
   List of references
   Personnel
   Budget

WRITING STYLE AND APPEARANCE

All the rules of writing, including the seven C's, pertain to proposal writing.

You will be wise to apply all business communication principles and report-writing techniques when writing the proposal—whether it is for a research grant or for a million-dollar sales contract by your company. Remember also that appearance throughout your proposal makes important nonverbal impressions.

In its digest on proposal writing, the Washington State Office of Economic Opportunity includes the following excellent advice:

> First impressions are very critical. None is more so than that first impression your proposal gives to the reader when submitted to an agency or foundation for consideration. Many proposals are lost at the first look by the reader. He [or she] appraises the proposal immediately in terms of:
>
> 1. General appearance
> 2. Neatness
> 3. Specific appearance of:
>   a. Table of contents
>   b. List of figures
>   c. Title page
>   d. Maps
>   e. Graphs
>   f. Charts
> 4. Consistency of style
> 5. Title—is it grandiose or does it properly describe the project?
> 6. Completeness
> 7. Professionalism
>
> Therefore, you cannot afford to skimp on the time you spend in "polishing" your proposal. Each item must be checked and rechecked. Since you have spent many hours developing the proposal idea, and further hours researching and writing before your first draft, why risk your investment over poor typing, proofing, graphics, etc.? Some of the most important time spent working on the proposal will be that spent on the final draft.
>
> If you are not an artist, it might be advisable to employ one to prepare the cover, charts, graphs, etc. The cost is minimal when you consider the potential return.
>
> Be sure you and your typist are familiar with an appropriate typing style. Learn it well and be sure to follow it consistently. . . . Select one which best fits your needs and adopt it for all your proposals.
>
> Don't accept or be satisfied with sloppy typing or artwork. Make sure it is reworked until satisfactory. You want all the final copy to be neat and clean prior to submission.

The preceding suggestions on proposal outline, format, writing style and appearance can be adapted to all kinds of proposals. If, instead of seeking funds for a comprehensive research study, you are writing a proposal that is your company's bid on a $5 million sales or construction contract, the basic characteristics of the formal proposal are similar.

SUMMARY

Proposal writing is primarily persuasive writing.

Writing proposals is persuasive writing: You seek a response, wanting the reader to accept your recommendation—you wish acceptance. That is true whether writing a research proposal (more often written by professors individually or on behalf of schools or universities) or a business proposal where you hope to receive a financial return.

Requesters of proposals govern the majority of the content. The soliciting group or individual often lays out the requirements of what must be included, similar to the following 11 sections: title page, executive summary, draft contract, table of contents, introduction, background, procedures, equipment and facilities, personnel, budget, and appendixes. Most of these are similar to the inclusions in a long report.

Short proposals do not have as much detail, and are often for smaller sums of money. Here the emphasis is heavily on the qualifications of the vendor.

Long formal proposals—which often include sections similar to the above 11 parts of a proposal—are detailed and complex; they bid for huge sums of money. At this level, it is not unusual for the soliciting group to write a Request for Proposal (RFP) to already identified candidates. A "short list" of qualified vendors is formed with later requests to that small group to submit detailed proposals. Our U.S. government often operates in this manner.

Finally, writing style is no different from other short or long reports. Clarity, above all—especially in the executive summary—is needed for instant and clear communication.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Preparing a Proposal for an Announced Request for Bid.*** Read the following invitation to bid (a request for proposal) that appeared in a foreign newspaper. Then do two things: (1) write a letter to the company requesting further information, and (2) assume you have received that information and write your response along lines suggested in this chapter:

```
        INVITATION TO BID-FOREIGN COUNTRY AIRLINE

Interested buyers are invited to a sealed bidding
for the sale of the following:

a. Ten BAC aircraft in 109 seat configuration with
   two engines each
b. One rediffusion flight simulator
c. Eleven spare Rolls Royce Spey 512-14DW engines
d. Large inventory of rotator spares, expendables

Interested parties should please contact G.L. Hong
at Foreign Country Airline, Raffles Place, Singa-
pore.
```

2. ***Writing an RFP (Request for Proposal) Letter.*** It is well known that one of the main entrances to doing business in China is via Hong Kong. There, many worldwide accounting firms have offices for working with international companies. Write an RFP letter to a U.S. company indicating that you have services to help a company establish contacts with mainland China. In writing such a proposal letter do these things:

   a. Try to use an area of business that is your specialty, e.g., accounting, finance, marketing, human resources

   b. Select a company in the United States that you know something about.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Proposal to Development Foundation Regarding Research Project.*** Your instructor may on occasion submit a proposal either to begin or to finish a research project. Assume that he or she has asked you to join in applying to a foundation to begin a research project on the general topic of the formal preparation needed for today's executives.

   Assume further that you have investigated the various private foundations in the United States and located one which has in the past funded educational research. In writing to the Development Foundation, you discover that it has specific requirements.

   a. An initial summary page should be limited to the following information:
   Institution
   Principal investigators
   Brief title
   Descriptive title
   Time period for the investigation
   Budget

   b. The contents of the proposal should use the following headings:
   Request
   Purpose of research
   Procedure
   Intended results
   Time schedule
   Budget (first, second year)
   Investigators

   Your responsibility is to (1) create a title page for the proposal and (2) develop an outline of the ideas to be included under the Development Foundation's major headings.

4. ***Proposal to Another Firm to Distribute Your Firm's Products.*** Assume you are marketing manager in a manufacturing firm whose products are now successfully marketed by distributors in 15 states. Assume products with which you are somewhat familiar or on which you can get specific information. They may be furniture items, building construction materials,

electronic office equipment, or others. After careful research by your staff members, you have found that a certain five-state region in the United States is expanding rapidly for various reasons (make up the reasons).

You have never before marketed your products in that region, and in the past 2 months you—with your assistant manager—have visited the area in person. Also, you have conversed with the vice president and purchasing manager of a large firm that distributes other products related in general to those your firm manufactures. However, neither that distributor nor any dealer in the area has products similar to yours. You feel sure that dealers, business firms, builders, and individual customers need and should have your products. Being without them could cause problems.

In this assignment you are to write a convincing proposal to the distributing firm's purchasing manager. Your purpose is to persuade him that the area needs the products you are selling. State the problem, purpose and benefits, scope (area in which your products will help the distributor's business), your marketing procedure, quality and prices of your products, and any other pertinent information.

5. ***Report on a Proposal's Process from Initial Request to Winning Bid.*** Some local companies (engineering firms, ad agencies, and others) attempt to win contracts through submitting proposals. Your task in this exercise is to interview someone who is or was involved in preparing a proposal in one of those firms. Your goal is to trace the proposal's process: from initial request for a proposal to final selection of the winning bidder. Not all firms use identical procedures or formats; thus, you and your classmates will each learn different formats for the respective firms in your area. (1) Present a brief written report on the results of your investigation, and (2) on the option of your instructor offer a brief oral report based on the written statement.

   Some interview questions helpful for your report might include the following:

   a. How were you or your firm contacted? How did you find out about the opportunity for submitting a proposal?

   b. Who determined the team to work on the proposal? What were the central goals of the proposal?

   c. Was a project leader or chairperson of the project appointed? What were his or her responsibilities?

   d. What were the major headings or parts of the proposal?

   e. Which modern technological approaches were used to supplement the oral presentation?

   f. If the company was denied the proposal, were any reasons given for denial?

6. ***Proposal to a Chosen Organization or Agency.*** Choose a problem that you can solve by experimentation, survey, observation, or any combination of these, and write your proposal to the organization that is concerned with the problem. Or (if more appropriate) assume your proposal goes to a fund-

ing agency whose philosophy is in keeping with the problem you propose to research. Here are suggestions for topics—but feel free to choose your own.

a. Try to solve a problem related to a firm's product development; plant expansion; improvement of a sales, accounting, or purchasing system; or curtailment of shoplifting.

b. Analyze a problem in your community—crime in a certain area, a traffic snarl situation, poor citizen involvement in local issues, need for attracting new industry or keeping young, educated persons in the community.

c. Undertake a project in one of your college classes—or survey a sample of the student body regarding an important campus problem.

Follow thoughtfully the suggestion in this chapter regarding proposal writing. Organize your topics under appropriate headings, and write a proposal that meets all requirements as to content, format, and writing style. Then submit your complete proposal to (a) your instructor and/or (b) your class in an oral presentation. Be prepared to defend your proposal and to have the class critique it.

7. ***Proposals for Sponsored Research to the Government, Foundations, or Inside School Groups.*** Some schools and universities follow a basic format when submitting proposals for sponsored research, either to the government, to private foundations, or even to inside school groups. If your school has an office that helps with preparing such proposals, speak with a member of that office and determine (1) the recommended inclusions in an academic research proposal and (2) some reasons for acceptance or rejection of a proposal. Present to the class, in an oral report complete with some visual aids, the results of your findings.

8. ***Report on a Sample Instructor Proposal.*** If your school does not have an office assisting in developing proposals for either internal or external sponsored research, speak with a professor or teacher who has submitted a proposal. Determine (1) what the purpose of the proposal was, (2) what major points were covered in the proposal, and (3) what he or she felt helped the proposal to be accepted or rejected. Here too you could orally present to the class the results of your investigation, along with a visual aid that summarizes your main points.

9. ***Noting Problems in Proposal Writing.*** Most schools have certain people or even entire offices that assist instructors—even students—in writing and submitting proposals. Interview an administrator in such an office, or if there is no office, perhaps an instructor who has submitted a proposal. He or she will have some ideas as to what should or should not be done in writing a proposal. In parallel form summarize the positive and negative elements they personally feel should be avoided or included in a proposal. This report could be in the form of an executive summary or in a short report format.

PART SIX

Strategies for Oral Communication

Chapter 14 Strategies for Successful Speaking and Successful Listening

Chapter 15 Strategies for Successful Informative and Persuasive Speaking

Chapter 16 Strategies for Successful Interpersonal Communication

Chapter 17 Strategies for Successful Business and Group Meetings

Chapter 14

Strategies for Successful Speaking and Successful Listening

I. Strategies for Improving Oral Presentations
   A. Steps for Preparing Effective Oral Presentations
   B. Kinds of Oral Presentations
   C. Ways of Delivering the Oral Message
   D. Strategies for an Effective Oral Delivery
   E. Strategies for an Effective Nonverbal Delivery

II. Strategies for Reducing Stage Fright
   A. Signs of Discomfort
   B. Strategies for Decreasing Speaking Fears

III. Strategies for Improving Listening Skills
   A. Faults in Listening
   B. Purposes for Listening
   C. Results of Good Listening

IV. Summary

V. Exercises and Problems

In the ancient world, writers such as Aristotle, Cicero, and Quintilian—names unfamiliar to many people—were some of the Greek and Roman practitioners of the art of rhetoric or persuasion. Its roots are deep. Its heritage is oral.

Oral communication has an ancient foundation; its roots go back to the time of the Greeks and Romans—and earlier.

Our statement suggests that orally moving a message from sender to receiver is not new. Throughout each day, in your personal life and in the world of business, you orally communicate with customers, colleagues, associates, supervisors, employees, employers, and others.

This chapter introduces you to successful strategies needed to be effective in oral communication:

- Strategies for improving oral presentations
- Strategies for reducing stagefright
- Strategies for improving listening

In a sense this chapter is macro, providing an overview of oral communication, rather than micro. Later chapters are more specific: informative and persuasive speaking, interpersonal communication, and business and group meetings. We begin with viewing basic strategies.

STRATEGIES FOR IMPROVING ORAL PRESENTATIONS

During your career in the business world, you will give various kinds of oral presentations. Indeed, how your capabilities are measured will initially occur based on your oral words. You need a strategy.

Oral presentations need a strategy: To reflect favorably upon you.

This section takes you through the steps needed to be effective in oral communication:

- Steps for preparing effective oral presentations
- Kinds of oral presentations
- Ways of delivering the oral message
- Strategies for using an effective oral delivery
- Strategies for effective nonverbal delivery

Steps for Preparing Effective Oral Presentations

Seven steps are essential for successful oral statements, short or long. The more up-front preparation you do, the more confidence you will have before a group.

1. Determine the purpose.
2. Analyze the audience and occasion.
3. Select the main ideas for the message.
4. Research the topic.
5. Organize the data and write the draft.
6. Create visual aids.
7. Rehearse the talk.

Communication Probe

A recent study sought to determine which modes of communication were used during a business day. Out of the eight modes frequently cited, oral comunication dominated, with face-to-face communication the most common (81.4% U.S.; 77.5% Asian; and 94.4% Chinese) and use of the telephone next (81.4% U.S.; 90% Asian; and 87.6% Chinese). The following table suggests that within three cultures—even where written communication is extensively used—businesspersons still prefer to interact on the personal, oral level. It will be interesting to see what occurs over the years if more intensive use of electronic communication decreases the need for interpersonal contact.

Modes of communication used by selected U.S. executives and Asian and Chinese managers

Modes	U.S. Executives*	Asian Managers‡	Chinese Managers
Face to face	81.4%	77.5%	94.4%
Telephone	81.4	90.0	87.6
Written	69.9	55.0	87.1
Mail	NA†	NA	69.0
Teleconference	12.9	5.0	11.5
Telex	NA†	NA	15.6
Fax	NA†	NA	9.5
Computers	10.7	30.0	20.5

*Executives are defined as chief executive officers, presidents, and vice presidents.
†Not available in the U.S. Executive and Asian Manager database.
‡Includes Singapore, Malaysia, and Hong Kong managers.

Hildebrandt, H. W., & Liu, J. (1991). Communication through foreign languages: An economic force in Chinese enterprises. *Journal of Asian Pacific Communication*, 2(1) 45–67.

Determine the Purpose

We communicate to produce a result. We wish something to occur as a result of our words. On the macro level these overall goals are: to inform, to persuade, to entertain.

Three basic types of oral communication are found in business speaking: informing, persuading, and entertaining.

1. To Inform or Instruct. Here your core goal is to clarify, secure understanding, explain a process. Your teacher, most often, is making a speech *to inform.* So are your authors as we write about the process of oral communication. In brief, at the conclusion of your message you hope listeners have a better comprehension of an issue, an idea, a process, a procedure.

2. To Persuade. Gaining willing acceptance of an idea is core to persuasion. Note that the key word here is *willing.* Your goal is that after you have finished your presentation, listeners will accept your proposal, your claim, your thesis;

you hope they will do as you ask them to do. Advertisements also desire a positive result. But their tools of persuasion may include the oral plus many other kinds of persuasive devices.

3. To Entertain. This speaking genre may include not only humorous statements you will make—of which there will probably be few—but also the numerous ceremonial, introductory, or stimulating statements. Social occasions such as promotion parties, retirement, or anniversaries are characteristic of this kind of speaking.

Analyze the Audience and Occasion

Whether one writes or speaks, the message must be adapted to the audience. If your talk is within your organization, you will have some idea about who and how many people will be in the audience.

As in writing, a knowledge of the audience is significant for comunicating effectively.

Less information is available when speaking to outside groups. Then, seek out information such as the size of the group, age range, interests, goals, occupations, and other tidbits which could be incorporated into your remarks. Some of that information may be obtained from the person who asked you to speak and from other members of the group. If all audience members have the same occupation, such as purchasing agents or computer salespersons, you can use more technical expressions and illustrations.

Select the Main Ideas for the Message

Selecting your main theme or your core ideas should be done first. Then gathering additional information will be in support of those core ideas. Your first list of core ideas may be disorganized, haphazard, which is fine. Later you can select those ideas that are workable and offer a unified theme. Some speakers begin with filling a complete page with single words or incomplete sentences. And onto this list they impose a form of organization. Do not rush this stage of preparation; do not presume this initial structure will be your final version.

Research the Topic

It is obvious that you will not possess all information relating to your central theme. Thus, as in writing, you need to collect facts, data, information. Your research may cause you to drop some of your initial ideas and add new ones. One has only to read newspaper accounts of the President's speech to realize it was still under revision until the last moment. New facts, new views are constantly appearing.

Organize the Data and Write the Draft

Assume that you have completed gathering your information. Then it is time to force some order on your information, usually in the form of an initial outline. As

Communication Probe

Research on communication issues was fervent during the 1970s. Two such studies during that period suggest that the credibility of the speaker is a major predictor of success in persuasion. On the other hand if a speaker feels he or she is lacking in credibility as perceived by an audience, he or she can refer to experiences with the topic. Or, the speaker can connect him or herself with others who are competent on the topic. Therefore, one conclusion is to search out evidence that supports your message in a credible, hopefully uncontestable manner.

Lashbrook, V. (1971). Source credibility: A summary of experimental research. Paper presented at the Speech Communication Association convention, San Francisco; McCroskey, J. C. (1969). A summary of experimental research on the effects of evidence in persuasive communication. *Quarterly Journal of Speech*, 55, 169–176.

you do this, remember that a good speech has three parts: an introduction, a body (or text, discussion), and a conclusion or summary.

Remembering the PAL is an easy way to recall the major three parts of an introduction: Porch, aim, layout.

1. Introduction. Traditionally an introduction seeks to do several things: Get attention, include an aim or purpose, and lay out the direction of the speech. Think of these three elements as a *PAL*:

*P*orch	Your opening remarks. It is your throat-clearing statement, your preamble, your preface, your greeting. Additionally you may begin with a quotation, a question, a startling statement, a reference to the occasion, a reference to the past, a humorous story. Use these choices to get started.
*A*im	Your purpose. Why you are giving the talk. Here you clearly state the aim for your remarks; you make clear your intent.
*L*ayout	Your agenda. Cicero long ago suggested such a "layout" was the *divisio* of one's remarks. Telling the audience your main parts, often by number, gives them a precise understanding of the major points you will cover; it's the roadmap for what follows.

The body is the heart of your talk; here you explain and support the main purpose of your presentation.

2. Body (Text, Discussion). Some people refer to the heart of the message as the text or discussion. Here you include evidence, data for your central theme; here you organize the supports for your central purpose. Organizing the body of the talk is similar to developing the text or discussion of a major paper. However, in speaking there is often a time constraint; such a constraint demands that most talks be limited to two or three main points.

Summaries review what has been said; conclusions draw inferences from data.

3. Summary or Conclusion. A summary reminds the audience of the main ideas covered in the body of the talk, whereas a conclusion draws inferences

from the data. Regardless of your intent, there must be an ending or a "closing" to your remarks.

Create Visual Aids

Some presentations do not require visuals. It would be odd to include an overhead of the major dates in the career of a retiree. On the other hand, it would be odd not to include a visual when speaking about the structure of an organization. But most important is answering this question: Would a visual add to understanding and support of your message? A discussion of different kinds of visuals is included in Appendix A.

Rehearse the Talk

Two purposes underlie rehearsals: You will become more comfortable with your material and you can still revise where necessary. When rehearsing, stand and deliver your talk out loud.

Three rehearsals are recommended. If you rehearse too much, the statement sounds memorized.

How many times should you rehearse? Three times is about the right number. Nevertheless, a company president presenting a holiday greeting rehearsed four times; a vice president before a congressional committee went through his talk three times; a President of the United States rehearsed once. The final decision is up to you.

Keep in mind the following issues:

- Always imagine the audience in front of you.
- Use transitional phrases and sentences to show your listeners the relationships between sections of your report. Avoid long sentences and unusual words.
- Take each of the main points one at a time and learn to present each with its supporting material as a unit.
- Include the visual aids you'll use—and in the margin, note where each aid should be used.
- Anticipate questions from the audience. Jot them on paper and consider thoughtful answers.
- Stop at the allotted time. Then cut and revise the speech accordingly until you can deliver it within the time limit, allowing also for a question-and-answer period.

Kinds of Oral Presentations

Basically, all oral communication lies betwen informative speaking on one end of a continuum and persuasion at the other end. For most purposes the statements are therefore some variation of inform, persuade, or entertain. Additionally, one could add such variations as motivate, inspire, and eulogize. But these are simply relatives of the three basic forms, discussed earlier in this chapter.

Short talks may range from 1 to 10 minutes in length. You may simply introduce someone, present an award to a retiree, give a briefing to visitors to your company, or offer an opening statement in a group meeting. You could also represent the company outside your office: accepting an award, showing your sup-

Checklist 14.1 Preparing Effective Oral Messages

1. Know the precise purpose of your presentation: Will you inform, persuade, or entertain?
2. Identify your audience and the situation. What are their approximate ages, their occupations, their interests, their biases, their reasons for being present?
3. Select the main ideas, the core concepts you wish to discuss.
4. Research your topic thoroughly.
5. Organize your information and prepare a first draft.
6. Create some visual aids, if necessary (Appendix A).
7. Rehearse your talk at least three times.

port for a local cause, offering greetings at a community banquet. And so on and on.

The longer the presentation, the higher the risk of losing an audience's attention.

Longer statements may vary from 10 minutes to 1 hour. It is not unusual in Asia, for instance, to have speeches 2 hours long. But with the increasing emphasis on brevity, some corporations limit statements to 20 or 30 minutes, knowing that attention spans decrease the longer the statement.

Ways of Delivering the Oral Message

You have four options for speaking: extemporaneous, reading, memorization, and impromptu delivery.

1. Extemporaneous

Extemporaneous delivery is preferred by both audiences and speakers; it allows more eye contact and more verbal and nonverbal involvement with the audience.

This method—most preferred by audiences and speakers—allows a speaker to use notes or an outline. He or she usually may use 3 by 5-inch cards or a full sheet of paper as notes for the remarks.

Use this method whenever possible: It allows more eye contact with an audience, permits you to establish rapport, and enables you to move with ease.

2. Reading

Major political figures and others who do not want to make a mistake read a manuscript. If they will be filmed or have their statement appear on the evening news, ad-libbing could lead to problems. A familiar story runs like this. A speaker once read his remarks and got this reaction from a listener: "I didn't like your reading your speech; I didn't think you read it well; and I didn't think what you read was worth reading!"

Today speakers on television often "read" from a teleprompter, a device allowing them to read their words directly from a script passing in front of the camera lens. Recent presidents of the United States have favored this method.

When constructing a manuscript for reading, some speakers use a page style similar to a TV script, leaving a left margin of about one-third of the page. In that wide margin are pronunciation aids or suggestions as to where to look in an audience.

3. Memorization

A risk of memorization is forgetting your precise words; groping for words in front of an audience decreases your credibility.

Few speakers today memorize complete speeches. Nor should they. Often the first few words of a statement can be memorized, but the time needed to recall a long speech is prohibitive.

4. Impromptu

Many of us are called upon at the last moment to offer comments. When you speak "off the cuff," without preparation, without a forewarning that you will speak, you are speaking impromptu.

How can you prepare? Winston Churchill, the energetic British prime minister during the Second World War, "rehearsed" his impromptu remarks at home; later, in the House of Commons, he gave the impression that his remarks were spur of the moment. A vice president doodled through a discussion: In reality he was also jotting down notes for later use in his "impromptu" remarks.

Strategies for an Effective Oral Delivery

One of your personal signatures is your voice; varying pitch, rate, and volume gives it more interest and appeal.

As writing has its criteria to move ideas clearly across a page, so too does the speaker in an oral situation. In addition to completing the seven steps for preparing an oral message and choosing the methods of delivering it, you need to focus on decreasing stage fright and the desirable elements of oral and nonverbal delivery.

Your voice is your trademark; it is that part of yourself that adds the human element to your words. Writing does not have that immediacy because the words are static on a page. You can give extra life to your delivery in five traditional ways.

Communication Probe

One of your authors, early on, investigated this hypothesis: Does the mode of presentation—that is, extemporaneous or manuscript delivery—affect an audience's recall of information? Results suggest that the mode of communication employed makes no difference: Audiences recall information about equally well when speakers use either method. However, audiences—beyond question—desired the extemporaneous mode of delivery. They simply liked it more. Fortunately, in the business world most presentations are of the extemporaneous type.

Hildebrandt H. W., & Stevens, W. (1963). Manuscript and extemporaneous delivery in communicating information. *Speech Monographs, 30,* 369–382.

1. Pitch

At its simplest level *pitch* is the highness or lowness of your voice. In speaking, this pitch should be varied. Traditional problems in using pitch are monotone, high or low voice, and same word value.

Monotone. "He's a monotone" is no compliment. This critical statement implies that the speaker has little or no variation in pitch. An oscilloscope would show a rather flat line.

Lack of pitch variation may result in being called a monotone.

High or Low Voice. Often monotones are voices that rarely rise out of a lower register. On the other hand, excited people frequent the upper ranges.

Same Word Value. In writing we emphasize a word visually by underlining it, marking it boldface, or using italics. When each word in speaking, regardless of its importance in a thought group, is the same, the speaker does not distinguish with vocal stress between important and unimportant words. Cantonese, for instance, is an accented language. Much pitch variation occurs.

The above problems are decreased through pitch changes, through glides—from a higher to a lower level, abruptly. Say this sentence: "Mary, don't do that!"

On which word did you raise your voice? Here are the possibilities:

Mary, don't do that!	Mary, don't *do* that!
Mary, *don't* do that!	Mary, don't do *that*!

When emphasizing an entire sentence, usually the strong declarative thoughts end with a downward pitch change, giving the feeling of finality, of determination. A rising inflection is more appropriate to asking questions or suggesting indecision.

2. Rate

Take a guess: How many words do you use per minute as you speak? Most communication experts suggest the range for public speakers lies between 80 to 160 words per minute. In more casual conversation some people may range from 80 to 250 words per minute.

Variation in rate is better than speaking at the same speed.

What the above statement suggests is that the rate of speech varies from individual to individual. A speaker may be considered dull if he or she is slow or unvarying, even though the speaker's content may be superior. Conversely, the fast speaker also causes discomfort: We hope the rapid-fire speaker will slow down in order for us to digest the thoughts.

A key word related to rate is *pause.* We call pauses between major thought groups "oral white space," similar to the white space between paragraphs in a written document. As in writing, a pause in speaking lets your receiver reflect on the message and helps break the flow of thought. A pause lets you, the speaker, collect your thoughts, take time to move to a visual, or rest your voice.

3. Volume

Unless you as a speaker are heard, many of your words will be lost. It takes real courage for a listener to stand at the rear of a room and shout "Speak up, please!" Volume is the loudness or softness of your voice. How do you improve it?

Contrast in Emphasis. Contrast in emphasis involves using a louder or softer volume on certain words, certain ideas, certain parts of your talk, even certain syllables. For instance, how would you orally deliver the following statement?

> And with that we conclude our remarks. Personally, I look forward to working with you and the other members of your project team. I can't forget that at one time I was asked to join your firm. Now I'm on the other side, offering a proposal that I hope you'll accept. Regardless of your final decision, we wish you to know that we enjoyed this morning with you.

When in doubt as to your volume level, ask a colleague about her or his impressions from the back or side of a room.

In the above instance—heard by one of the authors—the speaker lowered his voice and made the statement a moving personal appeal at the conclusion of a rigorous 3-hour team presentation.

Controlled Breathing. Too frequently speakers breathe in shallow gasps. You must—as does a singer—have lungs filled with air in order to produce a higher pressure level to propel the air forcefully past your vocal folds. Breathe deeply. In fact, slow, deep breathing prior to speaking helps to decrease stage fright symptoms.

Certainly you must adapt your volume level to the size of the audience and room. Speaking to 100 people in a room without an amplification aid would surely demand more volume than in a small room of 5 people.

4. Vocal Quality

One's voice is hard to describe; we often turn to metaphors to describe voice quality.

Before reading the next several lines, pause and see how many words you can think of that describe the human voice. Did you choose any of the following: *husky, throaty, deep, loud, vibrant, dynamic, mellow, moving, weak, strong, harsh, shrill, effeminate, masculine, gentle, squeaky, muffled, falsetto, silvery, ravishing, clear, ringing, effortless, secure, flexible, serene, pliable, vibrant, colorful, furry rug*? Many of the preceding are metaphors, implying a comparison of the voice with another known quantity. Regardless of your voice's quality, it is the indefinable something that distinguishes your voice from others.

There is some debate about whether anything can be done about changing voice quality. Your mouth, tongue, lips, teeth, vocal folds, sinuses, hard and soft palate, and nose all affect that quality. If you are unhappy with your voice, see a competent speech therapist for professional help. Some experts also suggest relaxing the throat, thereby allowing an unrestricted sound to enter the resonating chambers of the mouth, throat, and nasal cavities.

5. Pronunciation

We more easily forgive pronunciation errors in foreign speakers than in native speakers. You are expected to be correct in the business world. In fact, we sub-

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A lighthearted spoof—quite serious, really—of jargon and its consequences in the business world recently appeared. The author's observation is that consultants entering a company to improve communication come loaded with their own vocabularies, their own font of words. Thus with some difficulty the company must learn about *empowerment, paradigms, vision congruencies, short-term disabilities, cultural interventions,* and a host of others. Soon, however, the company is mouthing these same terms, or in the author's terms "psychobabble." Underneath the satire the message is clear: Do not neglect the simplicity of the English language; do not give up clarity for jargon.

Theibert, T. (1994, August 1). Eschew that paradigm! Drop the jargon. *Wall Street Journal,* 18A.

consciously react negatively when any word is mispronounced—relative to our concept of how it should be pronounced. (*Danger:* we may be wrong, the speaker right.)

Additional pronunciation problems need to be mentioned.

Speech therapists can help with pronunciation concerns, particularly with nonnative speakers.

Jargon. Within your organization you will learn jargon pronunciations, often for abbreviations. Thus cam used within one group will mean "contract audit manual," but to outsiders could mean a part that forces a roller to move. A danger clearly lies in using these in-group pronunciations outside your group, with inevitable quizzical nonverbal reactions from your listeners.

Varied Regional Accents. For many words, southern pronunciation and accents, for example, differ from those in Chicago or Boston. For most of these words, however, there is a common standard throughout the states, as there must be for us to understand quickly.

Added or Omitted Sounds. Speakers should, of course, be careful not to add such sounds as *uh, hm, y'know, er, OK* between words or sentences. If one has many of these interjections (one speaker had 24, another 42, another 147), they break up the flow or words for the listener. The result is similar to the negative impression that writing errors leave with a reader. Some speakers literally don't hear their interjections until they hear them played back on a videotape.

Other bad habits of adding and omitting may also affect pronunciation. In the following examples, the preferred pronunciation is second:

A videotape recording is superior in reflecting your pronunciation. It captures you as others hear you.

Adding		Omitting	
idear	idea	gonna	going to
athalete	athlete	watcha say	what did you say
arthuritis	arthritis	meetn	meeting
hunerd	hundred	dija	did you

Checklist 14.2 Striving for Oral Vocal Variety

All the following suggestions move on one main assumption: You must have variety and enthusiasm in each of the vocal characteristics.

1. Try repeating thought groups in your speech in different ways. Ask yourself: Which way sounds more effective through varying pitch (highness/lowness of the voice); rate (fastness/slowness of speech); volume (loudness/softness).
2. Think of adding oral white space: Insert silence (pauses) between major points of your talk.
3. Be sure you have the correct pronunciation of words. This suggestion is most appropriate for persons using English as a second language. When in doubt, ask a native speaker or check the dictionary for the preferred pronunciation.

Suggestions for improving pronunciation are:

Listen to the Educated and Cultured People of Your Community. You can usually assume that their standard is correct and acceptable for their region of the country. A respected businessperson's speech is also a good guide.

Consult a Recent Dictionary. More options on pronunciations of words are included in recent editions. When in doubt, get a consensus from your class members or your instructors.

Strategies for an Effective Nonverbal Delivery

How much do you nonverbally communicate about yourself when speaking? How close do you stand to someone in polite conversation? How important is your attire when speaking? These are questions often raised when thinking of nonverbal communication. Your posture, movement, gesture, facial expression, and attire all convey external nonverbal cues. Many nonverbal cultural habits are discussed in Chapter 3.

1. Posture

Posture, how you stand, even sit, communicates something about you as a communicator.

Many of you have seen the film *Patton,* in which the actor George C. Scott plays the role of General Patton. In one scene Scott delivers a ringing motivational statement: He delivers it erect, straight, and unbending. The entire scene suggests confidence, rapport with his audience of soliders. One senses the poise and confidence of the speaker.

Thus, when you stand straight and balance your weight on both feet, you give the impression of complete control, of poise. Your outward appearance mirrors your inner mood.

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Although extensive communication research was conducted in the sixties and seventies, Professor Roger D. Masters has continued that investigation specifically as it applies to political leaders. But some of his conclusions have applicability beyond the political arena. In fact, all audiences dislike speakers who exhibit fear: looking down, hesitating, jerky in movement, or seeming to freeze. People react positively when candidates smile warmly, tilt their head, and establish eye contact with their audience. "If you think about it," he says, "politics is about getting people to look at you. Our studies show that effective leaders are attention-binding."

McDonald, K. (1996, January 5). The body language of leadership. *The Chronicle of Higher Education,* A6–A9; Masters, R. (1993). *Beyond relativism: Science and human values.* Hanover, NH: University Press of New England; Masters, R. (1989). *The nature of politics.* New Haven, CT: Yale University Press.

Conversely, when draped over a podium with your shoulders sagging, you give the feeling of depression, of lack of control. However, a casual posture may also be adapted to the audience. When speaking to a business conference of, say, 10 people, you might sit on the edge of a table or even address them from a chair. Certainly a formal talk to 200 people would demand more formality in posture.

Women should be especially concerned about posture, sometimes choosing shorter-heeled shoes when speaking. Too high a heel causes some female speakers to rock from side to side. Choose a comfortable set of shoes to avoid conveying a negative, ill-at-ease impression.

2. Movement

Lecterns are movement-inhibiting. If you must use a lectern, try moving slightly from one edge to the other.

Taking a few steps during a presentation helps hold attention, as does any moving object. There are times, however, when a lectern precludes extensive movement other than short steps to its side. Yet, move if possible, for the following reasons:

Move to Hold Attention. At large sessions, lecterns restrict your movement. In business meetings the audience may be smaller, thus permitting you to stand behind a desk or table. Move more often from side to side rather than back and forth. But do not move continuously, like a caged lion!

Move to Get Rid of Nervousness. A way of decreasing stage fright is to move about, especially in the beginning of your talk. Even the manner in which you approach the lectern tells something about you nonverbally. Are you slow and plodding, or do you move with assurance, determination, enthusiasm? The latter approach gives a confident feeling while decreasing some of your initial nervousness.

Move to Suggest Transitions. Cues for transitions in writing include headings, words, and numerical hints such as (1), (2), (3) or (a), (b), (c). In your talk, you

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One of the earliest researchers into nonverbal communication (Birdwhistle) suggested that words alone do not carry meaning in communication. He argued that no more than 30 to 35 percent of meaning is carried entirely by words. Nonverbal communication adds, subtracts, and amends the messages we send. Nonverbal symbols, in conjunction with oral symbols, say much about who we are, how we feel, and even how we feel about others. Hence, the oral communication context involves both verbal and nonverbal symbols, each hopefully getting listeners to understand us and do what we wish them to do. Sending the right symbols demands knowing the audience's receptivity to those symbols.

Birdwhistle, R. (1970). *Kinesics and context.* Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press; Knapp, M. L. (1990). Nonverbal comunication. In G. L. Dahnke & G. W. Clatterbuck (Eds.), *Human communication: Theory and Research* (pp. 50–69). Belmont, CA: Wadsworth.

visually supplement the oral words of transition by physically moving when making a direction shift. The audience follows you more easily.

Move to Increase Emphasis. In writing we use exclamation points following emphatic statements. In speaking, a movement toward the audience, accompanied by a gesture, can imply you are stressing a point. Emphasis through movement suggests idea importance and holds group attention.

3. Gestures

At a simplistic level any movement of the hands, arms, head, shoulders are termed *gestures.* At a more micro level there is an entire science of body movements called *kinesics,* of which gestures are a part:

Emblems. Behavior that has a direct verbal counterpart such as the thumb upward for hitchhiking; the arm wave for hello or goodbye.

Illustrators. Here belong the gestures, usually the arm used to describe a circle, or the finger pointing to emphasize a point. As emblems had direct verbal counterpart, illustrators do not.

Affect Displays. Speakers may use any of the primary emotional states usually via facial expression: happiness, sadness, anger, fear, surprise, disgust, contempt, and interest.

Regulators. Speakers use body movements of their audience to search out responses to their message. Thus listeners may nod their heads, maintain eye contact, shift their postures, incline their heads to hear better.

Be aware—as noted in Chapter 3—that acceptable gestures in your native country might prove unacceptable in other countries.

Adapters. These are often the unintentional movements to a physical or psychological state: scratching a nose, twisting a pencil, smoothing one's hair.

Hand and arm gestures are used for several reasons:

To Emphasize. For example, the clenched fist emphasizes a point by either hitting the palm of the hand or shaking it upright before an audience.

To Point. The index finger calls attention, indicating either locations or directions.

To Reject. A sample phrase accompanying this gesture would be "I can't believe the actions of our competitors." Here the hand may go to the side in an act of rejection.

To Describe. Clearly, though your hands cannot give the precise picture of the idea or thing you are speaking about, even an approximation of size is worthwhile.

As with the voice, varying gestures also help to hold the attention of an audience.

Finally, some suggestions regarding gestures are in order:

Vary Gestures. Using the same action repetitiously is boring to the audience and suggests lack of creativity on your part.

Avoid Continuous Gestures. Visually the audience needs a rest from the speaker's frequent gestures. Overuse can weaken the emphasis.

Watch Timing. The gesture should accompany the oral thought, not precede or follow it.

Adapt Gestures. Seated at a table is not the time for broad, all-inclusive gestures. On the other hand, a large audience would not see a small gesture. Adapt to the size of the group.

4. Facial Expressions

Earlier we suggested that one's facial expressions could convey primary gestures. Thus a smile or a laugh suggests that your topic interests you. A frown or

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Two tests over the years (Rosenthal, 1979, and Buck, 1984) have attempted to answer this question: Which gender is most perceptive in sending and receiving nonverbal messages? Rosenthal's Profile of Nonverbal Sensitivity (PONS) test and Buck's Communication of Affect-Receiving Ability Test (CARAT) lead to some interesting conclusions. Through viewing slides and film, with emphasis on the face, the body, and the voice, women seem to do better in sending and receiving nonverbal messages.

Rosenthal, R. (ed.). (1979). *Skill in nonverbal communication: Individual differences.* Cambridge, MA: Oelgeschlager, Gunn, & Hain; Hall, J. A. (1984). *Nonverbal sex differences: Communication accuracy and expressive style.* Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press.

Checklist 14.3 Enhancing Your Nonverbal Communication

1. Stand erect. It is better to err on the side of more formality than casualness in speaking .
2. Move! To hold attention, to get rid of nervousness, to suggest transitions, to increase emphasis.
3. Gestures add emphasis to your oral words. Use them to emphasize a point, to suggest rejection of an idea, to describe size. Using your arms helps hold attention.
4. Facial expressions suggest enthusiasm for your topic. A mobile face is an interesting face. Look at the audience: Give them the feeling of high interest in them and your topic.
5. Your attire is determined by the culture of your group. When in doubt, be more formal than informal.

glare may convey nonverbal impressions that you are worried, angry, or perhaps ill at ease. You must not only feel but show interest in your ideas. Sincerity is important.

Facial expression includes eye contact. Speakers who bury their head in their notes or who speak to the screen behind them lose a sense of directness with the audience. Eye contact with your listeners suggests respect and goodwill, adding to a favorable impression of you as a speaker.

5. Appearance

Western attire is accepted throughout the world. Conversely, western businesspersons must recognize that other nations may have different dress codes.

Local newspapers often include questions about and answers to what to wear to interviews, sales meetings, social gatherings. How you look and what you wear affect listeners. Thus some companies are more casual in dress, others less so. Learning the company culture includes learning its dress code.

Most western companies encourage males to wear the traditional shirt, tie, and suit and females to wear a white blouse with a dark skirt and jacket. But those "rules" are consistently changing. Terms as *smart casual* or *business casual* are symbols for appearance; it is important that you know what they mean in your particular environment.

STRATEGIES FOR REDUCING STAGE FRIGHT

Being at ease, or simply giving the *impression* of being at ease, is difficult for most people. Few people can approach an audience without some feeling of discomfort. In traditional rankings, speaking before an audience is rated the most fearful thing some people do.

Pick up any newspaper, read what persons have to say about situations demanding a performance in front of people: Many resist and fear the idea. Barbara Streisand avoided public performances for years out of stage fright; Van

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Because speech anxiety is so widespread, numerous studies and approaches to meeting that anxiety have appeared over the years. Without getting into extensive detail, those anxiety-reducing techniques involved skills based on cognitive and affective approaches. A study that combined all three methods resulted in some interesting conclusions. Performance visualization is effective in reducing communication anxiety. Relaxation techniques were encouraged and imagining ability (reading a script of a successful speech and viewing a speech) was the type of performance visualization employed. "People who have the ability to imagine situations vividly receive more benefit from performance visualization than do others."

Ayers, J., Hopf, T., & Ayers, D. M. (1984). An examination of whether imagining ability enhances the effectiveness of an intervention designed to reduce speech anxiety. *Communication Education, 43*, 252–258.

Cliburn said, "Those who know me best know that when I walk out on a stage, I'm nervous, always nervous"; Luciano Pavarotti, the superb tenor, said, "I would not want even an enemy to suffer those terrible moments"; Steve Carlton, a recent inductee into the Baseball Hall of Fame, put it this way: "This is a wonderful thing . . . once the speech is over." And the list of similar comments is endless.

Signs of Discomfort

Signs of discomfort are universally experienced: The heart rate increases, blood pressure and body temperature rise, and some say their mouths feel dry. Look carefully at each of the preceding: All are internal, none are visible to the audience. What you feel internally is not obvious to listeners. Surely you will also feel as if your voice is trembling and your palms are sweaty. Again, you may be aware of these things, but they are not obvious to the audience.

Strategies for Decreasing Speaking Fears

Regardless of culture, stage fright is universal. Following our eight suggestions helps decrease the intensity of that fear.

In a true sense it is mind over matter, confidence above all, feeling that you know the subject better than anyone else, the feeling that you are in charge. If it makes you feel any better, musicians, football players, and singers have similar feelings before a performance or contest. Checklist 14.4 offers eight helpful ways to decrease your discomfort.

STRATEGIES FOR IMPROVING LISTENING SKILLS

Listening is a neglected study in school and colleges even though managers from around the world consider it a significant part of one's communication skills. Our review here concerns common faults of listening, purposes for listening, and results of good listening.

Checklist 14.4 Decreasing Stage Fright

1. Know your subject well. Prepare with the attitude that you want to know the subject, on that day, better than anyone else.
2. Rehearse your talk several times. If possible, rehearse in the same room where you'll speak. This can easily be done within your company. But if your speech will be outside your company, try to arrive at the place early and take a look around.
3. Request—in advance—a lectern. It helps to hold not only your notes but also, occasionally, a trembling hand.
4. Precheck any equipment you'll need—projector, screen, extension cord—and know which electric outlet is nearest the podium or lectern.
5. Take an object with you—a pen, your notes, a marking pencil. Of course one should not play with the object, but using it as a pointer and as something to touch has helped calm some speakers.
6. Breathe deeply and slowly before speaking. Try moving a little in your chair: cross and uncross your legs.
7. Move during the speech. Some movement holds audience attention and releases nervous energy. Even behind a lectern one can move slightly or use a lavalier mike and, thereby, increase the possible range of movement. If you're seated, shift positions in your chair or gesture a bit more with your arms.
8. Approach the lectern with assurance and enthusiasm.

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An interesting study in Finland viewed these hypotheses: In front of the same audience, an individual's heart rate is significantly higher in a public speaking context than in a small group context. Further, an individual heart rate level is significantly higher in a small group context in front of an audience than in a dyadic context without any audience. Public speaking was the most stressful as measured via increases in heart rate, rising to 144 beats above the baseline rate of 83. Speaking in small groups caused the heart rate to reach 117 beats per minute. The authors conclude that the heart does reflect the nature and demands of the communicative situation.

Porhola, M., & Isotalus, P. (1993, June). Communication-elicited arousal in public speaking, small group and dyadic contexts: Comparisons of change in heart rate. *Communication Research Reports, 10*(1), 29–37.

Faults in Listening

Listening is as important as the other three components of communication, namely, speaking, reading, and writing.

Much information that you send orally is lost because of listeners' poor listening habits. In fact, studies agree that listening efficiency is no better than 25 to 30 percent. Why? Some causes follow.

Prejudice Against the Speaker. Perhaps you have heard this quotation. "Who is saying it shouts so loudly that what is said is easily forgotten." We are distracted because who the speaker is conflicts with our attitudes. For example, can you maintain attention when the speaker's position, attitude, or belief is entirely contrary to your own?

External Distractions. The preceding fault was more of an internal distraction. Some nonverbal cues are strong external distractions. Does the speaker stammer? Wear loud clothing? Dress sloppily? Walk or gesture excessively? Reek of perfume or cologne? All these and more cause persons to tune out on speakers.

Actually, the entire physical environment affects listening. Among the negative factors are noisy fans, poor or glaring lights, distracting background music, overheated or cold or oddly shaped or gaudily decorated rooms, excessive draft from a window or register, and so on. Also, sitting near disturbing individuals in the audience might distract a listener's attention from the speaker's message.

Thinking Speed. Most of us speak between 80 and 160 words per minute. Yet people have the capacity to think at the phenomenal rate of up to 800 words per minute. That leaves time on the listener's hands (or in his or her head). What do you do during all the time when you are not actually processing the speaker's words? Do you go off on tangents, focus your attention elsewhere, begin to daydream, shift your attention? Soon you can be off, far away from the words of the speaker—missing some important points.

We have time on our hands while listening to a speech. Our thinking speed outpaces the speaker's rate of speech.

Premature Evaluation. How many times have you interrupted persons before they completed their thought? Finished their sentence? Stated *their* conclusions? Directly as a result of our rapid thinking speed, we race ahead to what we feel is the conclusion. We anticipate. We arrive at the concluding thought quickly—although often one that is quite different from that the speaker intended.

Semantic Stereotypes. As certain kinds of people bother us, so too do their words. An interesting class interchange occurs when discussing this question: What is your favorite word, and why? Opposite that question is, What words bother you, and why?

Internal reaction words vary from person to person, each list influenced by feelings, attitudes, prejudices, and biases we carry inside ourselves. (See the communication model in Chapter 1.) Hence, some words cause negative reactions. We tune out the speaker because the word annoys us; it shouts so loudly in our brain that effective listening is impaired.

Delivery. A monotone can readily put listeners to sleep—or cause them to lose interest. Sadly, some teachers speak in monotones. So do significant people in government or business. How a speaker delivers his or her message does annoy

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Listening research had its heyday during the sixties and seventies. Little has been added to change the conclusions of some classical studies on the topic. It is estimated that we spend nearly 45 percent of our verbal communication day in listening. That is not surprising in a world given increasingly to the visual medium. Additional support is given the thesis that more business communication should be devoted to improving listening. Data, for example, from a sample of Hong Kong utility managers suggest that communication courses should include emphasis upon the following forms of communication:

Writing	32.7%
Speaking	31.4
Listening	19.3
Reading	17.0

In other words, the traditional forms of business communication in one Asian country—similarly mirrored in the United States and elsewhere—still focus on the two main media. Yet, listening as part of the "big four" ranks third as a desirable addition to communication improvement.

Hildebrandt, H. W. (1996). Chinese utility executives. Unpublished raw data; See also studies reviewed by Wolvin, A., & Coakley, C. (1982). *Listening.* Dubuque, IA: Brown.

some people—and they become bored, uninterested, and critical of the message. "He's a bore" is more a critique of delivery than an assessment of a speaker's mental abilities.

Purposes for Listening

It should be no surprise that poor listening is not entirely the fault of the speaker.

A speaker alone gets an audience to listen. Wrong. All of us have had the experience of reading to the end of a page and not knowing what we have read. Similarly, it is possible to hear someone without being able to summarize what the person has said. The fault is not entirely that of the sender. Why listen? There are four good reasons:

1. To Gain New Information and Ideas

Throughout our lifetimes there are kernels of information that become a part of us through the spoken word. Lectures in class, for example, can supplement and clarify a textbook; informative indoctrinations give new employees background to a company; persuasive statements to clients give both information and reasons for buying. New ideas are received daily, via the oral medium, if one listens. In

other words, speakers must select reliable evidence. A goal is to arrive at a conclusion that is true, workable, and acceptable to many people.

2. To Question and Test Evidence and Assumptions

When a speaker presents a message, much of what is said consists of facts (verifiable data) or opinions (inferences). Good listeners test those facts and opinions against assumptions and then question the speaker. Additional information and the selection of acceptable evidence and data are discussed in the following three chapters.

3. To Be Inspired

Martin Luther King's "I Have a Dream" speech inspired, as did Patton in the film of the same name. Keynoters are selected to set the tone, the mood, the outline of where a group should go. Sales meetings are known for their rousing kickoffs, their enthusiastic openings—occasionally with bands, vocalists, even stage shows, all seeking to motivate, to inspire the audience favorably.

4. To Improve Your Own Communication

Role models and mentors are valuable to young people entering the business world. If your role model is also an effective communicator, you are lucky. However, if your mentor lacks some communication skills, and thus cannot serve as a resource, other excellent ways exist to study communicators: attending meetings, hearing speeches, or even observing famous officials speaking on television. Choose the best techniques; listen for and adopt those that are done well. Add them to your list of desirable speaking attributes. Omit undesirable habits that you see and hear.

Results of Good Listening

In summary, the following six benefits will occur if you listen purposefully and positively because such attentive listening

1. Leads to helpful, positive attitudes—by understanding the hindrances that lie in the way of good listening.
2. Permits the speaker and listeners to improve communication because each side is more aware of and receptive to the other's viewpoint.
3. Indicates by feedback to the speaker that listeners are interested; in turn, the speaker tries harder to give his or her best presentation.
4. Helps listeners obtain useful information on which they can make accurate decisions.
5. Creates better understanding of others and thus helps listeners work with others.

Checklist 14.5 How to Improve Your Listening Skills

1. *Be prepared.* For a class, this means completing your reading and assignment responsibilities. For an outside speaker, you can learn something about the speaker, the topic, the audience, the situation even before attending.
2. *Accent the positive.* "If you have to do it, do it with a positive attitude" is a centerpiece of life.
3. *Listen to understand, not refute.* Respect the viewpoint of those with whom you disagree. Try to understand the points they emphasize and why they have such feelings (training, background, etc.). Don't allow your personal biases and attitudes regarding the speakers or their views to influence your listening to their message.
4. *Focus your attention.* Construct a mental outline of where the speaker is going. Listen for transitions and the progression of ideas.
5. *Concentrate on context.* Construct a mental outline of where the speaker is going. Listen for transitions and the progression of ideas.
6. *Take notes.* Jot down ideas. Even incomplete sentences or single words will later be a memory jogger of what was said.
7. *Curb the impulse to interrupt.* This suggestion applies to interviews, conferences, job instructions, and meetings. Listen attentively until the speaker invites questions.
8. *Summarize and evaluate.* Restate—in your own words—just what you think was said. You should also question evidence used and mentally test the validity of evidence in support of a proposition.

6. Helps the speaker (especially in an interview) in talking out a problem; a person needs to receive, as well as give, help

SUMMARY

One strategy for improving oral communication is to follow seven steps: (1) determine your purpose; (2) know the audience and occasion; (3) select your main ideas; (4) collect data; (5) organize your material; (6) plan visuals, if needed; and (7) rehearse about three times.

Then determine whether your talk is to inform (make something clear), persuade (get willing acceptance), or entertain (some form of celebratory statement). Once that is determined, most likely you will present the talk extemporaneously, from notes in an outline form.

Enthusiasm is a key word in giving variety to the two main parts of delivery. *Oral communication* involves variety in pitch, rate, volume, and pause. *Nonverbal communication* pertains to posture, movement, gesture, and eye contact.

Communication Probe

Current pragmatic articles still lament the poor listening abilities of businesspersons. No profession is immune from that indictment: Internal auditors are concerned, pharmaceutical companies, and innumerable other areas of business. Recognizing the fact that people listen at an efficient rate of about 25 percent or less, suggestions for improving that listening efficiency are similar to suggestions made in this chapter: Listen for key concepts and ideas, anticipate what the speaker is going to say, review key points occasionally, look for unspoken messages, and provide feedback.

Flagg, J., Kerr, D., & Smith, L. (1995, Winter). Conducting effective interviews. *Internal Auditing, 10,* 41–45; Lamons, B. (1995, September 11). Good listeners are good communicators. *Marketing News, 29,* 13; (1995, September). Home-grown training at Fannie Mae. *Management Review, 84,* SS3.

Strategic listening means being positive, purposeful when listening to someone. Eight actions should be taken: Be prepared; accept the positive; listen to understand, not refute; focus attention; concentrate on context; take notes; curb impulse to interrupt; and summarize and evaluate.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Nonverbal Characteristics of Other Cultures.*** Books, journals, and periodicals frequently have articles relevant to nonverbal communication habits of different countries. Search out an article or a chapter in a book (ABI Inform is a good source under the term *intercultural*), and then do two things after reading your material: (1) summarize some of the nonverbal habits of the country under discussion and (2) suggest how some of those same nonverbal habits are used or not used in the United States.

2. ***Oral Characteristics of Other Cultures.*** Interview an international student either in class or in your school. Ask him or her to summarize some of the difficulties experienced in using English. What oral habits of U.S. students are found to be different? Are there specific sounds in the English language that are especially difficult to master? It is interesting to collect a series of statements from different foreign students in order for you—as future businesspersons—to better understand the difficulties faced by others speaking in their second language.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Analysis of Public Presentation.*** Attend a public presentation offered by a business person. Using the following format, write brief statements on some of the principles learned in this chapter:

CRITIQUE OF ORAL AND NONVERBAL SECTIONS OF A PRESENTATION

To what extent did the speaker have variety in the following characteristics of voice?

Pitch:
Rate:
Volume:
Pause:

To what extent did the speaker use nonverbal communication in his or her presentation?

Posture:
Movement:
Gesture:
Pause:

4. ***Oral Presentation Based on Resume.*** The way of decreasing your nervousness in speaking is to talk about a well known topic—yourself. Prepare an assignment that (1) presents a brief oral statement in support of a specific job, backed up by (2) your resume prepared as a transparency. *Suggestions:* Be organized, think of the main sections of your resume (e.g., goals, education, work experience) that you will use as the basis for your support for a specific job.

5. ***Nonverbal Communication Log.*** Test the assertion that people consciously or unconsciously communicate nonverbally during oral communication. Note any situations you wish, but you should have at least three examples per day for a week.

   a. Divide your log into two parts: On the left side of a page put the heading "Situation;" on the right side, "Example" or "Conclusions."
   b. Defend in class the conclusions you drew from the nonverbal cues noted in your left-hand column.

6. ***Short Informative Talk to Introduce Speaker or Award Winner.*** For this assignment each student will give a short (3- to 5-minute) talk to introduce a member of the class as either a speaker or an award winner. First, choose a classmate (by any method your instructor suggests). Then exchange resumes with that person. Confer with each other to get acquainted. (Your classmate needs information to introduce you, too.)

   You may each assume that your classmate is a speaker about a certain topic at a meeting of a business, professional, campus, or other club of which you are both members. You have been chosen to introduce him or her. If you prefer, instead of introducing your classmate as a speaker, you may assume you were asked to present him or her with an award.

   Whichever specific purpose you choose for your talk, select from your classmate's resume at least four pertinent facts—with his or her approval.

All statements in your talk should be true—except of course the assumption that this classmate is a speaker or an award winner. To support either of these assumptions you may need to add a few made-up incidents. For instance, if you will present an award, be sure to mention clearly a (made-up) noteworthy achievement—on the job or in scholarship or in community activities, sports, music, or whatever. Organize your talk well, and present it enthusiastically to your audience.

7. ***Listening to Newscasts for Repetitions.*** Even though TV newscasts are not a pure form of public speaking, newscasters use some of the same features you will use in more formal presentations. Listen to several things in newscaster statements: their introduction to the newscast, transitions between stories, and their concluding remarks at the end of the newscast. Questions you may ask as you watch may include the following:

   - Is there consistency in the way the newscaster opens the newscast over a period of several days?
   - Are the same words used to move from one point to another in the newscast?
   - Are signoffs the same after each newscast?
   - Is there a time connection between the kinds of news report? For instance, are serious and tragic stories given less or more time than humorous incidents?
   - And other questions of your choice.

   Then, write a brief report on your findings, including specific examples of the kinds of repetitions (or varied) beginnings, transitions, and endings used.

8. ***Listening for Evolving Slang in Speaking.*** Slang (specialized vocabulary and idioms used by an "in" group) is always with us. No organization, no college class, no group of students, no classroom can avoid terms that are added and omitted over one's lifetime. Three people are needed for this assignment: a student who has worked for several years prior to returning to school, a student who has never had a permanent job prior to coming to school, and a minority student. Each should prepare a list of slang terms they have heard in their daily contacts with friends, in the classroom, or in their work environment.

   After the class members have their own list, they should form a group and combine their slang terms into one list. Bring that list to class and let the members of the class guess the meaning of the slang terms, affirm whether they use the terms, and decide whether the terms are now out of date.

Chapter 15

Strategies for Successful Informative and Persuasive Speaking

I. Purposes of Informative and Persuasive Speaking
   A. Informative Specific Purposes
   B. Persuasive Specific Purposes

II. Kinds of Informative and Persuasive Speaking
   A. Informative Speaking
   B. Persuasive Speaking

III. Audience Analysis for Informative and Persuasive Speaking
   A. Degrees of Interest and Attitudes
   B. Occasion
   C. Location

IV. Organization for Informative and Persuasive Speaking
   A. The Introduction
   B. The Body (Text, Discussion)
   C. The Summary or Conclusion

V. Supports for Informative and Persuasive Speaking
   A. Six Forms of Support (Evidence, Data)
   B. Questions on Forms of Support

VI. Summary

VII. Exercises and Problems

VIII. Reference

Oral communication is our most used mode of communication. It may involve only one other person. It means speaking within a meeting, conversing in the hall, announcing over a PA system, using the telephone, speaking to 100 people, or whispering words of love.

But here, as in the preceding chapter, we mean speaking to a group of people. We mean giving a speech: to a small group or a large audience. And to be effective in the business world requires knowing something about informative and persuasive speaking. The former focuses on making an idea clear, the latter on gaining willing acceptance for your proposal.

For both types of speaking we review the following:

- Purposes of informative and persuasive speaking
- Kinds of informative and persuasive speaking
- Audience analysis for informative and persuasive speaking
- Organization for informative and persuasive speaking
- Support (evidence, data) for informative and persuasive speaking

PURPOSES OF INFORMATIVE AND PERSUASIVE SPEAKING

Making an idea clear is central to the purpose of informative speaking.

Oral communication consistently has two purposes: a general, or macro, purpose (to inform or persuade), and a specific, or micro, purpose (precise objective to be communicated). When thinking of the specific purpose, we suggest phrasing that purpose as an infinitive.

Informative Specific Purposes

Vague Specific Purpose	Better Specific Purpose
Olympic games	To compare information, using the criterion of modern technology, as to which country should host the year 2000 Olympic games.
Health care	To review the various funding options for a national health care program.

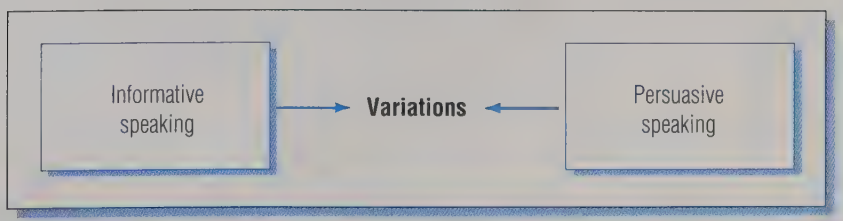

Figure 15.1 Informative-persuasive continuum.

Exchange rates	To trace the exchange rates over 15 years of the Thai baht and the U.S. dollar.

After having drafted your specific purpose, you can link three things: the title of the talk, the general purpose, and the specific purpose.

Search for unity between the title and the specific purpose of your talk.

Title:	An International Barrier: Language
General purpose:	To inform
Specific purpose:	To note three barriers of speaking in a second language: Definite articles, tenses, and prepositions

Process as Purpose

How does something work? What are the steps we follow to complete an act? These and similar questions suggest that you will explain the steps involved in a process. A study of *process* is knowing the systematic steps needed to bring about a desired result. Thus you might speak about how a machine works, how to construct a good audit report, how to enroll in the company's health program, or how to use a word processing program. Two organizational formats are frequently used: chronological and topical.

Chronological Organization. Many oral statements relating to a process move chronologically, that is, from a beginning to an ending. The following example is organized chronologically.

Title:		Our Employees Overseas
General purpose:		To inform
Specific purpose:		To suggest the procedures in preparing for overseas work
Main points:	I.	Contact with personnel office
	II.	Visit to overseas location
	III.	Debriefing with previous personnel in overseas location

Topical organization lets you determine the major headings for your speech.

Topical Organization. If a process is complex and does not readily fit into a chronological pattern, you may wish to select headings that give only the main points of that process. It is your judgment as to what those headings might be. A good example of a topical approach to explaining a topic are the self-learning exercises for software programs. Often the process discussion begins with general headings and then along come the smaller segments. Microsoft *Word* has such an approach.

Title:	Learning Microsoft Word
General purpose:	To inform
Specific purpose:	To introduce users to the basic process of learning Microsoft Word

Main points:	I.	Word disks
	II.	Microsoft Word manual
	III.	Word Pocket Guide
	IV.	Fast Results: A Sampler
	V.	Quick Help

You should think of the kinds of visuals you will use to supplement your process presentation. These may be self-created or taken—with proper citation, of course—from materials already available on your topic.

For instance, a human resources manager might wish to use his or her "Main Points" headings on the visual aids, as taken from the following example:

Title:		How to Develop an Employee Attitude Survey
General purpose:		To inform
Specific purpose:		To discuss phases of an employee survey
Main points:	I.	Decisions on survey and questions
	II.	Distribution and collection of questionnaires
	III.	Tabulation and analysis of data
	IV.	Implementation and follow-up

A detailed outline for development of an employee attitude survey might be similar to that in Figure 15.2, adapted from suggested plans by Léland G. Verheyen.[1]

Policy as Purpose

New employees often have a series of get-acquainted sessions wherein company policies are clarified. The topics can describe a process but can also clarify company policies or concepts. You therefore may inform groups on a new policy, a current policy, or changes to existing company policy.

In some ways policy speeches are more difficult to give than those explaining the steps in a process or the functioning of a machine. With policies or directives you deal with ideas more than with things that you can touch and feel or see. Visual aids, then, become valuable additions to your speeches on policy matters.

Title:		Drugs in the Workplace
General purpose:		To inform
Specific purpose:		To clarify company policy on use of drugs in the workplace
Main points:	I.	Company definitions of what drugs are
	II.	Company policy on administered drug tests
	III.	Company evaluation of results and employee rights
	IV.	Company rehabilitation policy

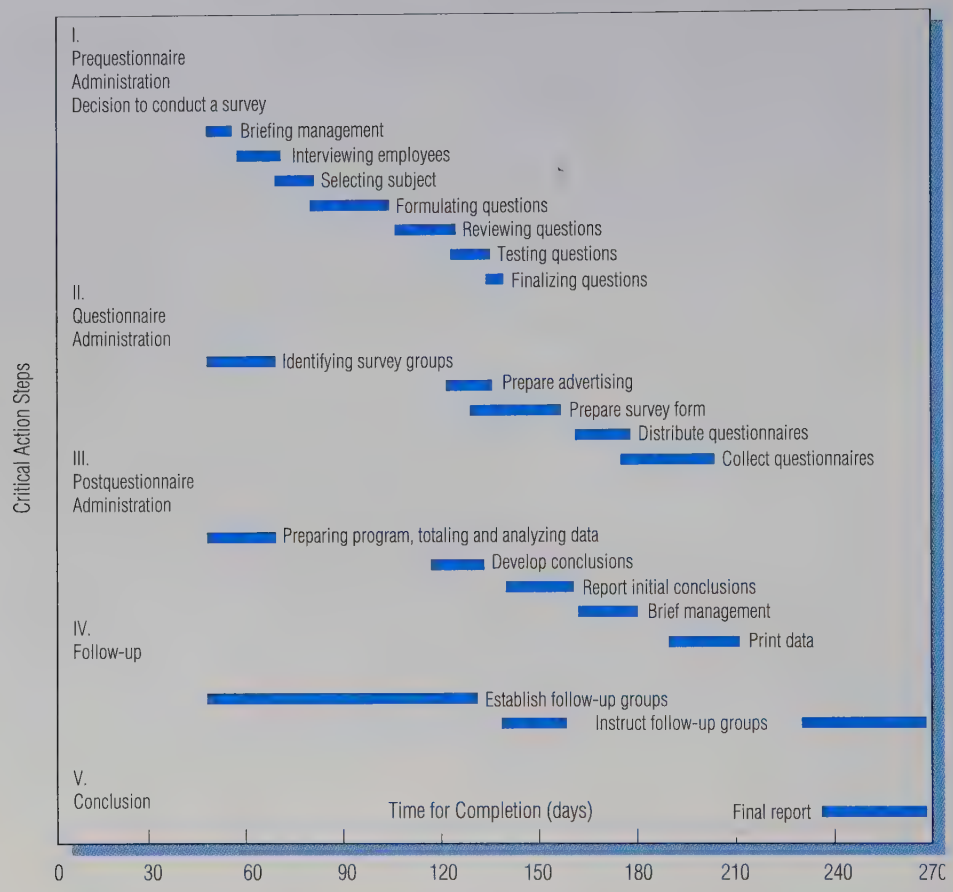

Figure 15.2 Development of employee attitude survey.

Title:		Creation of Trust Fund for Republic of Peru
General purpose:		To inform
Specific purpose:		To inform the Peruvian Government on additional options to consider in preserving its natural resources
Main points:	I.	History of the "Fondo Nacional para Areas Protegidas por el Estado" (FONANPE)
	II.	Management of the Peruvian Trust Fund
	III.	Options for further preservation of Peru's natural resources

Persuasive Specific Purposes

Witness the advertisements that daily bombard us with appeals: Buy this object, try this product, take this trip, fly this airline. We are inundated with persuasion.

As informative speaking focuses on the information end of the communication continuum, persuasion represents the other end.

Gaining willing acceptance of your central thesis is a core purpose of persuasive speaking.

Using the same format as for informative speaking, persuasive statements also have a general and a specific purpose. Phrasing your specific purpose in infinitive form channels your thinking into a precise goal statement.

Vague Specific Purpose	Better Specific Purpose
Health care	To recommend that the American Academy of Family Physicians consistently be asked for input.
M.B.A.s	To suggest that at the M.B.A. level there be mandatory requirements for a second language.
Language problems	To suggest that acronyms used by the federal government lead to unnecessary misunderstandings.
Taiwan investments	To argue that Taiwan's capital investments in China were greater than in other sections of the world.

Phrasing your specific purpose in an infinitive phrase makes your goal clearer both to yourself and your audience.

When you have determined your general purpose (to persuade) and selected an interesting title that gets attention, you then state the precise response you wish to get from your audience.

Persuasion is difficult. The more thoughtful you are and the more time you take in preparing carefully—as in the informative speeches—the better chance for later success. It is a good idea to write out the specific purpose. The purpose becomes the central theme around which you build your speech to achieve the desired response. Note in the following three examples how the titles get attention. The general purpose reminds you of the overall goal; and the specific purpose, in an infinitive phrase, is exact.

Title:	Seven Days of Reporting
General purpose:	To persuade
Specific purpose:	To convince listeners that four changes have to be made in the weekly sales reports

Title:	Decreasing Telephone Expenses
General purpose:	To persuade
Specific purpose:	To recommend three options for company consideration and select "Call Lock" as the preferred method

```
Title:                  Promoting Public Acceptance of
                        Japan's Nuclear Policy
General purpose:        To persuade
Specific purpose:       To recommend four actions to be
                        taken in implementing a public
                        awareness program
```

KINDS OF INFORMATIVE AND PERSUASIVE SPEAKING

Informative Speaking

Commonly, there are four types of informative situations in business communication: reports, goodwill, briefings, and instruction.

Reports

High on the list of dislikes about a job is the weekly or monthly meeting. Frequently the response to that ritual is "I don't like the reports"; "they're too long"; "meetings drag on endlessly"; and so forth. Sadly, many report sessions do fall into those categories. Why? Because some speakers do little to make their statements interesting or work on clarity of organization.

The following list summarizes the most common forms of oral informative business reports:

Oral informative statements often build on written material.

- Periodic department reports
- Progress reports on sales or ongoing committee activities
- Statements on area or division responsibilities
- Reports on manufacturing problems in the plant
- Reports on competitive operations
- Reports on problems with vendors
- Monthly personnel reports
- Abstract of contact reports for month

Checklist 15.1 Deciding Whether to Inform or Persuade

1. To inform:
   - **a.** Are you seeking to clarify an idea, a process, a procedure?
   - **b.** Do you wish to explain how something works?
   - **c.** Will the audience leave knowing both sides of an issue?

2. To persuade:
   - **a.** Are you going to support a point of view?
   - **b.** Do you wish action as a result of your speech?
   - **c.** Will you be clear as to which side of an issue you will support?

A weekly staff meeting, a monthly board of directors' meeting, a yearly stockholders' meeting, or even a yearly visit overseas to hear reports from functional units of a large multinational corporation can be the setting for making something clear to listeners.

Goodwill

Utility companies particularly—and early on—recognized the value of remaining in contact with the community. Their goal, and that of similar organizations today, is to leave a positive company image in the community. Although written flyers often dominate in releasing information to the public, oral speech is often used.

Thus many companies have speakers' bureaus. Company employees—top-level executives—speak in a variety of public settings, often on topics about which the speakers have considerable knowledge. Announcements in local papers occasionally name topics on which employees will speak to local civic, church, or other community groups. Even agencies of the federal or state government present informative statements to the public. A phone call to a company's speaker's bureau or to a government public relations office or consumer affairs office could bring a speaker on topics as varied as the following:

- A History of Solar Energy. Its Prospects for the Future
- Nuclear Power: Safe for the Country of France
- Plans for the New Substation
- Proposed DNR Changes for Refuse Disposal

In the above real instances the speakers brought along a company-produced film to supplement their oral remarks. Clearly, only the better speakers are selected to represent the company to the public.

Less frequent, but also important, are the various other short goodwill statements. Long before you are a top-level executive, you may be asked to welcome visitors, offer a tour and explanation of the company, introduce speakers, confer awards, speak at dedication ceremonies, or host a retirement party. All seek to bring about goodwill for your company.

Briefings

Short, problem-solving sessions in the military are called *briefings*. The term has a similar meaning in the business world. Usually, speakers offer background information, current situation, options to meet the situation, pro and con sides of an argument—all presented to management that they can make an informed decision. You, as a staff person, will make concise presentations on the above or similar topics. After that, management will review your comments and make a decision.

Briefings often lay out information on both sides of an issue.

For instance, a utility preparing for an increase in utility rates (a rate case) had numerous brief staff meetings to decide on which strategies to follow. A chronology of topics in preparation for its rate case followed this pattern:

1. Selection of rate case manager.
2. Selection of potential witnesses.
3. Meeting of all team members to select initial strategy.
4. Writing and redrafting of case.
5. Assembly of final case of direct testimony.
6. Rehearsal of witnesses: Work with manager.
7. Filing of case.
8. Rehearsal in preparation for cross-examination before public service commissioners.

Hence, there are many meetings, occasionally several a week, to hear oral informative statements and to make decisions. Much informative speaking precedes any final decision in the world of business.

Instruction

A common belief is that the longer you are with a firm, the more instruction you will give to younger employees, to others who can benefit from your experience. Your responsibility may be to instruct either several people or on some occasions an entire class of recruits new to the firm. The central goal, again, is to make clear a process, policy, or even the philosophy of the company.

Your goal as an instructor is to have listeners follow your explanations, learn from your instruction, and then apply this knowledge within the organization. Examples of topics offered in an organization are:

When informing, you are often acting as a teacher.

- Using our word processor—an introduction
- Completing the sickness and accident forms
- Setting up a retirement plan
- Using recent tax law changes in auditing
- Conserving energy

Communication Probe

Informative communication may be part of a process, making informative material the initial step toward problem solving. Informing may be a form of inquiry, providing background data, background content that contributes to an eventual solution. Thus out of inquiry, out of informative communication may arise a position or thesis or claim. Persuasion, then, depends heavily upon background material, or on what the authors of your text refer to as informative communication.

Batteiger, R. P. (1994). Taking positions and marking choices—An overview of argument. In R. P. Batteiger, *Writing and reading arguments* (pp. 1–13). Boston: Allyn and Bacon.

Speaking in such situations as reporting, community goodwill, and briefings gives you less freedom than when instructing. Here you have more room for individual creativity: choice of subtopics, arrangement of material, structure of the classroom.

That there is a need to teach employees to instruct more effectively has not gone unnoticed. Some universities offer in their management or education programs, for example, seminars on training the trainer, training in the organization, and instructional development workshops. All these seminars focus on one core idea: preparing employees to do a better job of managing, and then preparing them to instruct others.

Persuasive Speaking

Opportunities to persuade are endless; however, persuasion as a whole may be classified into four major categories: policy, procedure, value, or fact.

Policy

Policy refers to a course of action to be taken or not to be taken. A policy, a method of proceeding would occur in response to questions as the following:

- What policy should we follow regarding investment in South Africa?
- Should we establish a statement about adding Martin Luther King's birthday to the list of elective vacation days?
- Which changes in policy does the board recommend in health care?
- Which guidelines should we remain firm on in dealing with the former Soviet Union?
- What is the University's policy regarding electronic linkage from the school to the home of instructors?

Try answering the above questions. Some of you will immediately seize upon a single solution, while others will let several choices or answers run through your mind. Your goal in answering a policy question is to arrive at a decision and then recommend that decision to another person or group. To do that requires persuasion, supplying reasons for accepting your recommendation.

A sample outline for the last topic might look like this:

Advocating a change from the status quo involves asking for a change in policy.

```
Title:                  Electronic Linkage: Desirable
                        or Undesirable

General purpose:        To persuade
Specific purpose:       To recommend the University
                        allow electronic linkages with
                        instructors' homes


Main points:     I.     Policies at peer schools
                 II.    Concerns with linkage
                 III.   Benefits from establishing
                        linkage
```

Procedure

Questions such as the following suggest a procedure is requested: How will the policy be policed? What steps should be followed in implementing the policy?

What steps should be carried out? What is the scenario of how we will prepare for the court case? Questions and statements of procedure parallel those seen in the discussion of process relating to informative speeches. There the intent was to make a process clear; in persuasive speaking the speaker persuades that one procedure or process is more desirable than another.

- What is the quickest way to install a floppy?
- In formulating a PR strategy for the next year, which steps should we follow with our ad agency?
- In rewriting the company bylaws, where should items on the foreign subsidiaries be placed?
- Crises may hit our company. Which persons and offices should handle crisis communication?
- The agenda for the directors' meeting should have six major categories.
- Let's add the electrical harness for the automobile at step 12.

Not all persons agree on procedures; persuasion is required to support your personal position on how to proceed.

One has only to speak to employees in a manufacturing facility to learn that there are other ways of doing things. Company manuals, standard operating procedures (SOPs), and traditions play forceful roles in how things are carried out. When you propose changes to established procedures, you really have two tasks: You must first show why the previous system is inadequate and you must persuade that your new proposal is better, more cost-efficient, and more effective. An initial outline for a speech about a change in procedure may look like the following (taken from an actual study by a review committee):

```
Title:                  Proposals: A Needed Change
General purpose:        To persuade
Specific purpose:       To recommend a change in pro-
                        posal preparation for contracts
                        over $1 million

Main points:     I.     Current preparation procedure
                 II.    Problems with current method
                        A. To us as the proposers
                        B. To proposal requesters
                 III.   Recommend changes to procedure
                 IV.    Anticipated positive results of
                        accepting proposed changes
```

Visual aids often accompany requests for change from the current position. (See Appendix A.) The proposal review committee in the above example used visual supports such as (1) cost figures, based on hours worked, for the several departments compiling the internal data; (2) memorandums which showed that several departments were working on the identical background information; (3) pages from the proposal, showing errors of fact and costing, poor grammar and spelling.

Value

The following questions and statements imply a value judgment. Select the value words that suggest how the statement differs from questions and statements of policy and procedure.

- What benefits did we derive from supporting the Olympics?
- Give me three reasons why our bottom line will improve if we invest in Poland.
- Give me a list of the better speakers in the organization.
- It's unwise to compete with the cottage industries of Asia.
- That's the poorest memorandum I've seen in a long time.

Value terms demand clarification; value speeches require using definitions.

A value judgment is needed to answer the questions above and react to the assertions. While you can still turn to facts to support you view, it is quite difficult, for instance, to find many facts in support of the term *better.* All of us carry around in our heads a concept of "better"; and therein lies the problem: We must persuade others that our interpretation of the term *better* is the one to accept.

Words and their opposites, as in the following list, imply some kind of value judgment:

Fair/unfair	Honest/dishonest
Good/bad	Valuable/valueless
Interesting/uninteresting	Brave/cowardly
Beautiful/ugly	Advantageous/disadvantageous
Sincere/insincere	Modern/outdated
Leader/follower	Progressive/nonprogressive
Creative/noncreative	Traditional/modern

You may ask "How does one handle value terms?" Try a definition—later discussed as a means to clarity in informative and persuasive speaking. That way you put all receivers on the same level of meaning you attach to the value term. For instance, the following is an adaptation of a statement made in an actual persuasive speech:

> I know that we will consider the matter closely, for that's the policy of this company. But I have one favor to ask. Keep in mind what I mean by "acceptable." For me it means that no worker will be displaced because of the changes; no parachute will be opened for employees here less than 15 years; no retirement benefits will be impacted in any way.

What the speaker did was laudatory: She defined and made public her criteria for her use of the term *acceptable.* This definition, in part, clarified her judgment term and permitted at least a crude form of measurement. It would be ludicrous to try to define each evaluative term we use. To define the statement "It's a nice day" or "That's a good memo" each time it's used goes beyond common sense, a quality needed in handling value situations. A value speech outline could look like this:

```
Title:                  Benefits of Investing in New
                        Zealand
General purpose:        To persuade
Specific purpose:       To recommend to the board that
                        advantages outweigh the disad-
                        vantages of investing in New
                        Zealand
```

```
Main points:    I.   Background information on the
                     country
                     A. Geography
                     B. Government
                     C. Economic climate
                II.  Opportunities for growth in New
                     Zealand
               III.  Favorable government policies
                     on foreign investment
                IV.  Ease of doing business
                     A. Language is English
                     B. Politics appear stable
                     C. Tourism on the upswing
```

Fact (Present or Past)

One would think that matters of fact should raise few questions as to what is true. But not surprising, there are questions as to what happened, when something occurred, or who did what? You are seeking answers to what is true and verifiable. You may be alone as to what you believe is true. In turn, you may have to persuade or inform others.

Not everyone agrees as to what is a fact. Extensive research may be required to prove the validity of your facts.

Business questions and statements requiring a factual answer are represented in the following:

- What is the expenditure of Macau in U.S. dollars for their new airport?
- What did our letter of August 3, 199-, promise those who responded within two weeks?
- Travel costs are way out of line; I want a report on last month's expenditures.
- Our 10-K report was misquoted by the financial services.
- Your department has the highest absenteeism in 199-.

Communication Probe

Using statistics or numbers as forms of persuasive support is old hat. Numbers are both praised and condemned. Regardless of your position, numerical support is used to buttress persuasive statements with audiences, either written or oral. One researcher suggests that "[statistics] and other numerical data are simply one of several ways of viewing a situation." Her research suggests that newsy magazines such as *Business Week* use numbers as a kind of shorthand. On the other hand, writers depending on more sophisticated idea development use minimal statistics and other forms of support. Conclusion: Use statistics, but be sure of their credibility and conclusions drawn from them.

Butler, M. S. (1991, March). The persuasive use of numerical data in influential business periodicals. *The Bulletin of the Association for Business Communications, 54*(1), 13–16.

On the surface, answers to questions of fact may appear clear—perhaps to only one person. Under close examination, some supposed facts may be totally in error, owing to a misreading of data, a misunderstanding of data entered into the computer, or a host of other reasons. Witness a court of law where 12 jurors try to decide the "facts" of a case; there is rarely 100 percent agreement, and in some cases so divergent are interpretations of facts that no decision is reached.

Fact (Future)

An area for business management is called *strategic planning*, laying out long-term goals for an entire company or for departments within that company. In stating goals, many internal and external impediments must be considered. Since future planning is based on projections from the past, there is much guesswork involved. The speaker recommending future company directions will therefore face inaccuracies in data; he or she will have to predict future facts.

This book makes no attempt to analyze the various statistical methods and probabilities regarding future data. Predicting the future, inevitably, is risky. Yet, few people can avoid offering interpretations of data, of facts that may impact a company's future. Some companies lay out their sales projections for an entire year and adjust them every several months in view of changes affecting the original projections. All you can do is try to be as correct as possible, building on past facts as the foundation for future projections.

Title:		Environmental Pollution in Country X
General purpose:		To persuade
Specific purpose:		To offer facts that Country X continues to have a high level of pollution
Main points:	I.	Background to the problem
	II.	Survey of country's inhabitants concerning pollution
		A. Drinking water
		B. Soil
		C. Air
	III.	Impact of farming on country pollution
	IV.	Proposed governmental action as a result of gathered information

AUDIENCE ANALYSIS FOR INFORMATIVE AND PERSUASIVE SPEAKING

Knowing as much about your audience as you can decreases your chances of making either content or attitudinal errors.

Surely a group to whom you consistently speak needs less analysis than a new audience. It is this latter group that demands more of your time. Learn something of your audience's up-front interests and attitudes, the occasion, and the location where the speech will be given.

Degrees of Interest and Attitudes

Informative Speaking

Look at Figure 15.3; its structure is similar to a forced-choice questionnaire. That is, questions are worded so that audience responses range from "very interested" to "very uninterested." You should be able to answer the following three questions:

1. How much do my listeners know about the topic?
2. What is their level of comprehension?
3. What percentage of the group is well informed? What percentage of the group is uninformed?

If your assessment shows an audience is "very familiar" with the topic, you would omit the obvious, the simple, the elementary. You would go on to a more advanced explanation. Such an approach is more characteristic of the informative presentation.

Persuasive Speaking

Using a similar five-point scale allows you to know where your audience falls on the agree-disagree continuum (Figure 15.4). Certainly you will not know precisely where an audience lies on the continuum, but early soundings can give you a general sense of an audience's position on your topic. Yet one factor even more relevant for persuasion is the attitude of being for (pro) or against (con) your position.

Your assessment focuses on what you think the attitude of your audience is toward accepting your proposal. If they strongly agree with you, your task is easier; if they strongly disagree, your task is more difficult.

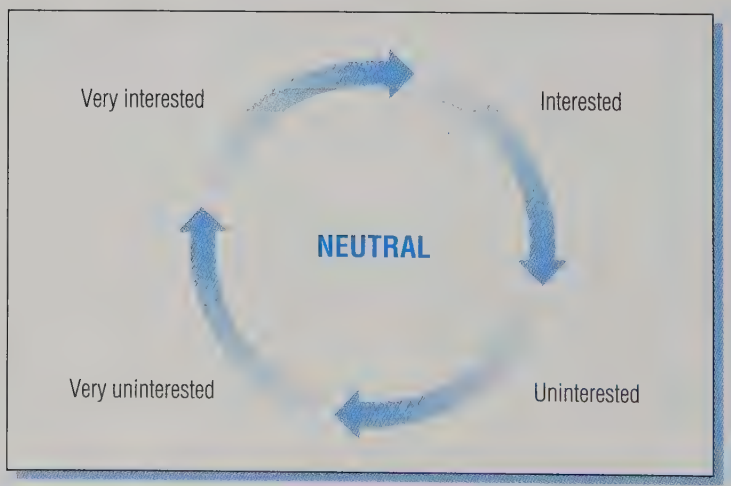

Figure 15.3 Degrees of interest.

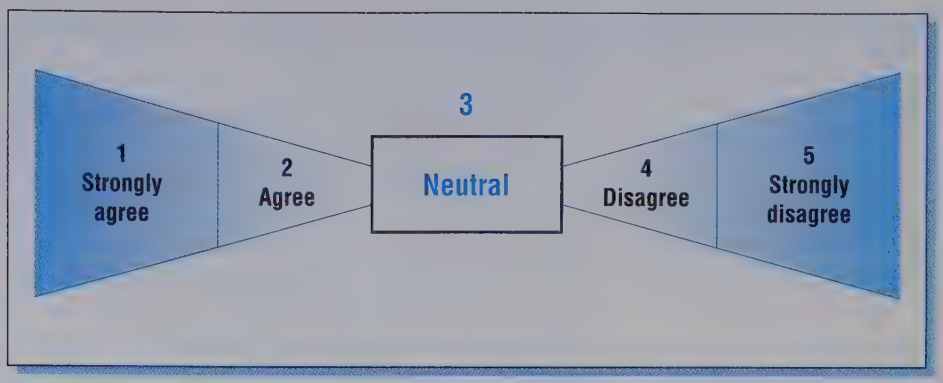

Figure 15.4 Degrees of agreement.

How can you face the hostile, prejudiced audience? Among various ways you may possibly choose these two: search for commonality, and compare agreements with disagreements.

Begin with areas of agreement when speaking before hostile groups.

Search for Common Ground. Speakers facing a hostile audience usually begin with familiar, commonly accepted topics before moving to areas of disagreement. You can begin inductively, using examples, illustrations, and goodwill comments that produce little disagreement. You can use four approaches in your opening remarks:

1. Insert praise for the organization and its members.
2. Mention names of colleagues or friends within the organization with whom you have worked in the past.
3. Make use of patriotism, loyalty, cooperation.
4. Be polite—even poke fun at yourself.

Not all the above commonalities will work all the time in the United States, and in foreign countries perhaps less so. Abroad, you must be aware of differing cultural standards, as discussed in Chapter 3.

Compare Agreements and Disagreements. A second method to consider in breaking down attitudinal hindrances to your position is to review areas of agreement and disagreement—for yourself—prior to giving the speech. Depend heavily upon facts here, use value judgments sparingly. Your goal is to force yourself to see the areas of difference before offering your main position. Labor negotiators and lobbyists often use the parallel-column, agree-disagree approach as an initial review of positions. In some companies the day care issue, for example, may have two points of view:

Communication Probe

Ask yourself these questions: How alike are you to your friends—in their beliefs, their attitudes? Do the similarities outweigh the dissimilarities? Are you a likable person? Communicators who give the feeling of being likable to their audiences are in turn liked by their audience. In fact, we spend more time communicating with persons with likable characteristics. Cheerful speakers, for instance, are more likely to hold attention. A speaker who shows little concern for or interest in an audience finds it more difficult to hold the interest of an audience.

Burgoon, J. K., & Miller, M. D. (1990). In G. L. Dahnke & G. W. Clatterbuck (eds.), *Human communication: Theory and research* (pp. 227–258). Belmont, CA: Wadsworth.

Point of View I— Agreement with Your Position	Point of View II— Disagreement with Your Position
On-site day care permits a single mother to work.	Mothers, regardless of their situation, belong in the home.
Six percent of industry today offers day care for younger children.	Day care costs incurred by the company decrease earnings for everyone.
Children in workplace day care are close to one of the parents.	Single persons feel slighted; they support day care even though they have no children.
Women with children desire to work for a company with day care.	Day care is an unacceptable criterion for choosing a place of work.

Although the above two methods—the search for common ground and the comparison of viewpoints—cannot solve all problems with a potentially hostile group, they do force you to review possible audience attitudes toward your topic. Clearly, a group strongly opposed to your idea will force a change in your approach; a more neutral group offers fewer problems.

Occasion

Most of your speaking will occur inside your company, either to members of your own group or to other functional areas. At daily, weekly, or monthly staff meetings you will most likely review the progress of the company; you will inform—extensively, and often.

You will also persuade within your own company. "Good luck on entering the lion's den" carries a meaning quite clear to business speakers: You are giving a speech on your home ground, perhaps in front of colleagues who are opposed

Checklist 15.2 Suggestions for Approaching a Hostile Group

1. Offer a greeting to gain goodwill.
   - "We have differences in philosophy, yet I bring you greetings from many friends of yours whom I have met during this past year."
   - "I've spoken to many groups over the years; each has given me a hearing. I bring you greetings from your colleagues in . . ."
2. Make use of the fairness concept.
   - "All of us in this room have a degree of freedom not experienced anywhere else in the world; I'm using that freedom to bring a different point of view."
   - "This group is known for its many representatives of fairness; I trust you'll consider my remarks fair."
3. Appeal to a sense of human weakness.
   - "Well, I've made mistakes in my days; may I tell you about one I made in my first appearance before this group."
4. Quote from a supporter of the audience's views.
   - "One of the directors of your association strongly supported the concept of brotherhood. I'll begin with a quotation he uttered last year."
   - "Your newsletter has this heading: 'Unity as based on truth.' I like that, and believe I can pass that test."

to your position. Thus your analysis is not as difficult as when speaking to persons outside the organization. Your own work group is relatively constant, many of the same people—with their prejudices and attitudes already in place—being present from session to session. Thus, when either informing or persuading, it is easier to speak when the audience is known and familiar.

When speaking to outside groups, you must devote more thought to the occasion. Are you the main speaker? Are you first or last on the program? How much time will be given to you? These questions apply either to informing or persuading.

Additional concerns arise when persuading an outside audience. There it is more difficult to summarize group attitudes, know their point of view, determine their precise position. Indeed, there may not be a group attitude unless you are, for example, a supporter of nuclear power speaking to an antinuclear group. You may be asked to participate in a public debate, supporting your company's position in contrast to an outside opposing group; there you would know the format in advance and could bring in material strongly founded on logical supports. Here too you must know—particularly when addressing government groups on behalf of the company—whether your proposal is being given a first reading or whether a decision will be made later. Knowledge of political parties and their position to our company's proposal is a must before attending a city government meeting.

Location

This obvious characteristic needs minimal discussion. It is sufficient to say that each location for your presentation has its own peculiar physical environment. Members of company speakers' bureaus have spoken in church basements, large auditoriums, oppressively small conference rooms, and even in lounges of local bars. Know the physical arrangements, find out whether you will have a podium or a table. Will you have a public address system? Surely the physical size of the room is important, but underlying all these factors is the attitudinal influence of the room on you, the speaker. Checklist 15.3 gives suggestions for analyzing your audience and the locales of your speech.

ORGANIZATION FOR INFORMATION AND PERSUASIVE SPEAKING

Your basic preparation is over. You have determined whether you will inform or persuade; you have stated your specific purpose and analyzed your audience. You also have begun collecting data. Now it's time to organize the data into a logical pattern. To give you suggestions, we employ the structure suggested since ancient times: introduction, body or discussion, summary or conclusion.

The Introduction

Give effort to the introduction; here you set the tone and pattern for the rest of your talk.

In the preceding chapter we suggested that introductions are composed of three parts: (1) the porch, (2) the aim, or purpose, and (3) the layout. This system we call the PAL approach to public speaking. Let's view those sections with reference to either the speech to inform or persuade.

The Porch (P)

This is the opening statement, the beginning, through using five different approaches.

1. ***Tell an anecdote, appropriate joke, or good-natured story relating to your subject.***

   "Funny things happen to people between 40 and 60; here's one incident that's common to that group."

Checklist 15.3 Analysis of Audience and Locale

1. Know their interests, likes, and dislikes.
2. Determine their degree of knowledge of the topic.
3. Know whether there is hostility toward the topic or toward you.
4. Be aware of the gender of the group and approximate ages.
5. Find out about the physical setting for the speech.

Communication Probe

Patterns of arrangement are as diverse as the writers who expose them. While forms of organization are oftentimes appropriate for given topics, writers—and speakers—must also focus on the content. A series of questions is suggested: Can one group similar matters together? Do some ideas appear to be subordinate? Can one move from the general to the specific or the specific to the general? Does the content presuppose certain approaches to arrangement? Are there logical reasons for the specific arrangement? Once these questions have been answered, there is the continuing issue of the audience in arrangement strategies.

Selzer, J. (1989). Arranging business prose. In Myra Kogen (ed.), *Writing in the business professions* (pp. 37–54). Urbana, IL: National Council of Teachers of English, Association for Business Communication.

"An interesting communciation story is of a speaker mistaking a restroom in a London airport. I'll begin there."

"Merit pay increase may have two definitions: the company's and mine. You'll like mine better."

2. ***Use a quotation that gives some background or inspiration to your speech.***

"As Oliver Wendell Holmes wrote, 'A great thing in this world is not so much where we stand as in what direction we are moving.' That's my theme: In which direction are we headed?"

" 'No man is an island,' John Donne said. That's the basic idea we promote in this company."

" 'The shadows are lengthening for me. The twilight is here.' The words of General MacArthur in 1962 are not a drumroll for ending: They were the beginning of a new resolve for the rest of us."

3. ***Greet your audience sincerely.***

"Two places I especially enjoy coming to are home and your community. It's good to be with you."

"The sound of your applause is indeed a warm greeting; I thank you. It's good to be here."

4. ***Make a startling statement.***

"By the end of my talk, over 2,000 new babies will have been born: Over 1,800 people will have died."

"Last year we had the lowest turnover rate in the industry: 6 percent."

"One of you has just won dinner for two. A look on page 27 of the workbook, with my signature, indicates the lucky winner."

5. ***Ask questions that make audiences start to think.***

"Let me begin by asking some general questions: What's the average age of a company president? Which area of study do managers say is the most important in reaching the top?"

"Three questions are foremost: What are the architectural plans for the company condominiums?—Who gets first claim on applying for entrance?—How much will they cost?"

The Aim (A)

Briefly, the *aim* is simply stating—clearly and precisely—the *purpose* of your presentation. Examples such as the following have been used:

"One reason brings me here today: to chat with you about the changes in our retirement policy." (*We know the central purpose immediately.*)

"Let me state up front that our monthly meeting has one purpose: to summarize our positive operating results for the last period." (*There is little question as to the core idea for the speech.*)

"I'm here to ask for your support as a candidate for the office of state senator." (*Either pro or con, the audience knows the speaker's main thrust.*)

"My point is this: We must change our policy regarding the promotion of persons from within the company." (*Using the word policy immediately sets the purpose of the talk.*)

Therefore, be precise, be exact, be concise regarding the reason you are before an audience. That way you avoid the embarrassing statement one occasionally hears from an audience member at the end of a confusing talk, "I haven't the slightest idea what that was all about."

The Layout (L)

By layout we mean giving an *overview,* setting the *agenda,* laying out the *roadmap* of where your speech will proceed. According to an old quotation, "It's tellin' 'em what yur gonna cover." It's giving a foretaste of the major points to be covered in the body of the talk. Some examples follow.

"I'm here to discuss three major costs connected with product liability." (*The audience immediately knows you'll cover three points.*)

"Today I'll concentrate on the cultural problems abroad regarding different concepts of keeping time." (*The audience knows there will be several—precise number unknown—issues to be discussed.*)

"One of the reasons I'm here is to support the idea of establishing a subsidiary in the Philippines, for the following four reasons." (*The audience know four reasons will be presented.*)

Occasionally speakers also state what the three, or four points will be, thus making the layout even clearer, as in the following examples:

"To help you understand why we believe Venezuela provides Wright Oil with attractive investment opportunities, I will discuss Venezuela's economic, financial, investment, and political situation." (*Listeners know the four areas to be discussed later in the body of the talk.*)

"Based on my analysis, the marketing research department recommends [*aim*] that Happy Inn expand into the Danish market with several moderately priced 300-room hotels. My criteria for this recommendation are the following: favorable business and investment trends in Denmark, increases in the Danish tourist market, and Happy Inn's strength in northern Europe." (*Three criteria serve as the core arguments to be supported in the body of the presentation.*)

Regardless of which approach you use in the layout—simply giving the number of points to be covered or precisely listing the points—audiences tend to remember your major points when the layout is clearly done. Sample introductions using the complete PAL technique are illustrated below.

EXAMPLE 1 *Informative.*

Porch (P) "Here's a game I'd like to play; it's a variation of Trivial Pursuit.

Aim (A) What I'd like to do is use this approach to describe some of the characteristics of top-level executives in the United States.

Layout (L) Our categories for analysis will include career patterns, education, and personal background."

EXAMPLE 2 *Persuasive.*

Porch (P) "How many of you know the word Macau? Do any of you even know it's a country? Have any idea where it is?

Aim (A) I'll tell you. But I'll also make clear that on behalf of the research committee we recommend establishing a pharmaceutical joint venture with a company in that region of the world.

Layout (L) Our committee reviewed four criteria; these will serve as the basis for our recommendation and reasons for requesting your acceptance: positive government attitude, improved infrastructure, positive investment climate, and a positive market for our products.

The Body (Text, Discussion)

Informative Speaking

The body or discussion of your topic is where your ideas are developed in detail.

Known variously as the *body*, the *discussion*, the *text*, or the *main section*, this part of your speech supports your aim, or specific purpose. Here also appear the

major sections you announced in your layout. In informative speaking you can choose from several ways to make your ideas clear.

1. By Topical Organization. This means you organize topics into natural divisions or into some kind of general classification. No two people organize a topic in an identical matter; each would be correct according to his or her own purpose. A speech on "The Automobile as a People Mover" could be variously organized:

I. The electrical system
II. The lubrication system
III. The cooling system

I. Rubber and its use in an automobile
II. Plastics as a major portion of the automobile
III. Steel's contribution to an automobile

You decide on the major sections in the body of your speech. Then, to make those sections clear, determine the supports (as discussed later in this chapter).

2. By Chronological Organization. Listeners like to follow material according to the order in which events or happenings take place: past, present, and future. That's chronological. If a sequence is obvious, has a beginning and an ending, has a definite sequential motion, has a prescribed order of events, use the chronological order.

An informational speech on "Rights of Students in the Business School Concerning Grade Issues" could have the following major headings:

I. Individual meetings with the instructor [*earliest*]
II. Consultation with the department chairperson [*later*]
III. Consultation with the dean of the school [*later*]
IV. Final review by academic committee [*latest*]

Instructing a group of middle managers on "Preparing for Meetings" could include:

I. Decisions before the meeting
II. Notification of members
III. Arrangements for the meeting
IV. The leader's role
V. The participants' role
VI. Evaluating the meeting

Even though the headings in the above example are chronological—from before the meeting to after the meeting—you may use your own subheadings within the chronological pattern.

3. By Cause to Effect. We know that certain pressures and stimuli cause other things to happen: Pressing down on the accelerator makes a car go faster;

opening a refrigerator door lets cool air escape; investing money in a bond results in dividend payments; advertising a sale should bring in more customers.

In the preceding examples there is a high chance that the causes produced the stated effects. If the causes were not there, no effect would have occurred. But three caveats are noteworthy in considering causal reasoning.

a. Avoid assuming that a single cause produces a precise result.

Effect	Questionable Cause
Low earnings per share	are not solely the result of decreased sales.
Spelling errors	may or may not be due to a faulty spell-checker.
Takeovers and mergers	are not entirely due to the actions of greedy people.
Your low raise	is not wholly due to your boss's not liking you.
A low grade on an assignment	does not necessarily mean the instructor dislikes you.

b. Avoid assuming a false connection, that is, presuming that because one event occurred after another, the two are linked. In the following examples, ask yourself if there is a precise, infallible connection between the cause and the effect.

Effect	False Linking Causes
Sales were up in 199-	after new management took over.
The consulting area of the Big Eight has grown	since deregulation.
She's been a problem	since she's been here.
Unemployment is up,	and stocks are down.
I got an A;	I changed instructors.

c. Realize there may be multiple causes, some major, some minor. Not all causes are of equal value. A speaker who states that a minor cause is major is open to challenge. Such is often the basis of argument—discussed in the next chapter—as two different teams or individuals try to determine causes for a problem and try to correct it.

Persuasive Speaking

Synonyms are numerous for the term *thesis;* each, however, carries the idea of a specific declaration followed by credible supporting material.

As the informative speech has options for organizing the body of the speech, so does the persuasive statement. In place of informing, you now use the body to persuade, to get the audience to accept your position, to believe your evidence. What you are doing is gaining acceptance of your aim, often expressed as a claim, assertion, thesis, generalization, proposition, resolution, or even a formal legal statement.

Position:	That one month of foreign travel be required of all students studying for a business degree.
Claim:	I maintain that the *Economist* is one of the most widely read business journals.
Assertion:	One often hears this assertion, which I happen to accept: There is a high correlation between a favorable home life and one's job satisfaction.
Resolution:	Whereas, lack of exercise among utility executives is a concern of health officials, and Whereas, high correlations exist between exercise and decreases in stress, now therefore Be it resolved: That our corporation support the construction of a physical fitness and wellness center, and that it be available to all employees.
Legal proposition:	Article XII, Section IC, of the code suggests that four members of the financial staff be endorsed by the chief financial officer. Therefore, an amendment through addition should be inserted into Article XII, Section IC, as follows, "That all . . ."

All the terms in the left-hand column assert that something should be done, accepted, or believed. Each demands proof before listeners will willingly go along with you.

Remember this: Persuasive speaking may use the same kinds of organization discussed earlier (topical, chronological, and cause-to-effect). But most persuasive business speaking uses the problem-solution format, proposing a change from the status quo or recommending that things remain as they are.

Problem-Solution—For Change

Often used in the business world is the problem-solution-benefit organizational structure for persuasive speaking.

Frequently your intent will be to argue that something is wrong and that a change is in order; you are unhappy with the status quo. For this reason you must convince listeners that a problem exists and that you have a solution to remedy the problem. You begin with proving the existence of a problem.

The Problem. Central to your thinking is the idea that something is wrong; there is dissatisfaction; flaws exist in the way things are going; failures far outnumber successes; costs are outrunning profits; negatives exceed the positives; the situation is so bad that something must be done; difficulties are many; there is a need for change; things are a mess. Remember, not all your listeners may feel there is a problem, so your first step is proving that one exists. Two brief examples of the problem section in the body follow:

Problem:

```
Our preparation for a rate case hearing be-
fore the Indiana Utility Regulatory Commis-
sion can be improved.
1. Neglecting contacts with advocacy groups
2. Preparing case with insufficient evidence
```

Problem: There is need for improving communication between upper and lower management.
1. Lower management feels they are being talked down to
2. Downward communication is often without explanation
3. Personal interaction is minimal between the two levels

By presenting your problem analysis you have met half your responsibilities. You now must present the solution for solving the problem.

The Solution, or Recommendation. Politely state your solution and then give your reasons. Several questions may run through your listeners' minds:

- Do we really need to change from what we're now doing?
- Will the proposal really solve the problem?
- Can one be sure that the solution will work? Be practical? Be effective? Be cost-effective?
- Will the benefits of the solution outweigh the negatives?
- Will the proposal create a host of entirely new problems?

Having answered what debaters call these "stock issues," you are ready to amplify your solution. Two examples of organizing solutions or recommendations follow:

Recommend we improve our preparation for rate hearings through the following steps.
1. Inform the Indiana Utility Regulatory Commission as to the motivation behind the proposed rate increase.
2. Focus on local consumer organizations.
3. Inform company employees.
4. Write numerous news releases for the public media.

Recommendations for opening lines of communication between upper and lower management.
1. Publish monthly newsletters; inform all levels of the organization.
2. Institute a "Good Idea Program" to encourage employee involvement at all levels.
3. Promote visits between levels of management.

Overview of forms of cooperation.
1. Restricted investment.
2. Technology licenses.
3. Customer and supplier.
4. Joint venture.

Your solution is a mixture of laying out your recommendation and showing how it will remove the problems you cited earlier. One more step needs to be

taken in the body of the speech advocating change: Show the benefits of adopting your solution and the disadvantages of not accepting the solution.

The Benefits from the Solution Briefly, you can insert in your talk positive results if your solution is adopted. You're trying to heighten desire for acceptance, summarizing future desirable effects. Your answers would be "yes" to the questions raised on page 433. Yes, we really do need to change; yes, my proposal would solve the problems, along with producing the following benefits; yes, my proposal would work, would be practical, would be effective, would be cost-effective; yes, by accepting my proposal the benefits would outweigh the negatives; yes, my solution implies that a change is needed and would not create a series of new problems.

Do not hesitate to show the negative consequences if your proposal will not be accepted.

The Disadvantages of Not Accepting the Solution. Conversely, you may also use a negative approach. A typical method is to suggest that if your recommendation or solution is not accepted, undesirable consequences will occur. You project into the future, suggesting that the current situation will continue (the status quo will be maintained); current problems, as you have defined them, will continue; undesirable consequences, such as costs, work force issues, or examples relevant to your topic, will not be removed. An example of two negatives is seen in the following:

Negative:

Neglecting to improve our preparatory steps for a rate case hearing will result in continued poor preparation.

1. The Commission will sense we are unprepared to defend our requested rate increase.
2. The public will be up in arms unless we get publicity out into the community.
3. The leading consumer groups of the city will feel neglected if they are not kept informed, resulting in less support of our position.

Negative:

Not adopting an open-line communication system will permit the current problem to continue.

1. Team spirit will not increase.
2. Vested interests will continue in strength.

Thus the problem-solution-benefit form of organizing the body of the persuasive speech first proves the existence of a problem, supplies a remedy to that problem, and then projects positive benefits if the solution is adopted or negative consequences if the recommendation is not accepted.

Problem-Solution—For No Change

Arguing that no problem exists is as common as arguing that a problem does exist.

Any hint at changing a procedure or accepting a different idea within an organization is to some people a red flag. Indeed, most people like things to remain as they are. We all have heard statements such as "What's wrong with the way we're

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Immunity. That term is usually associated with the medical world. Yet, used metaphorically, it has applicability to the world of business as well. There "immunity" can be a shield, a hindrance, an impediment, an obstacle to individuals receiving a message. In brief, some persons consciously edit out unwanted information, screening out much information formed by public relations people. One answer is to select a strategy that is in tune with the audiences selected to hear the message, with the intent of influencing their behavior. How to achieve this, one expert suggests, is via communication strategy, creativity, message building, delivery, and evaluation.

Obrien, T. (1995, May). Business must overcome "message immunity." *Communication World, 12,* 32.

now doing it?" "Why should we tamper with success?" "There's no problem; why can't we leave things alone?" "That recommendation is worse than what we've got now." "Over my dead body will that solution be adopted," and so forth through a series of statements reflecting resistance to change.

The Problem. If you feel the current situation is acceptable as is, you are in favor of the status quo. Such an attitude may be as legitimate as that of those who wish a change, except that you must prove that no problem or need to change exists. All your subheads in support of the proposition must leave one impression: There is no problem; things are fine.

If you are in favor, for example, of keeping your training program in your company as now structured, you might formulate the following generic main headings, which may be adapted to other topics as well:

Problem:

```
Current situation for training managers
1. In-house programs
2. Use of outside consultants and trainers
3. Release time for on-site programs
```

The Solution. Debaters on the negative side of an issue—those opposed to change and in favor of the status quo—would argue that no new solution is needed, things are currently acceptable. By analogy, a political party out of power contends that so many problems exist that a change in the administration shold be made; the group in power argues that to continue success, the current party must remain.

```
Recommendation that we remain with the current sys-
tem
1. Continue in-house programs along with release
   time
2. Continue use of outside expert consultants and
   trainers
```

The Summary or Conclusion

Earlier we stated that a summary pulls together the main points of your talk. Now you tell an audience what you have told them—similar to the summaries at the end of each chapter in this book. If your talk has symmetry, the summary will closely mirror the purpose and layout as expressed in your introduction, as for example:

Introduction

In January 199-, MCA announced that it had agreed with Nippon Steel Corporation of Japan to explore various types of joint opportunities in the entertainment and leisure field. You asked that I investigate some of those possibilities and provide both positive and negative views on various options and then come in with a recommendation.

Summary

In summary, current successes of theme parks in Japan offer great opportunities for our company. My review of several options, both pluses and minuses, leads to one recommendation: MCA and Nippon Steel should establish a joint venture tour and entertainment facility in Tokyo.

Although the summary may closely follow the introduction, using a visual aid—perhaps the same one used in the beginning of the speech—is a good way to add visual emphasis and provide a frame for the entire speech (see Appendix A).

Summaries reiterate what was covered; conclusions are inferences from data.

Conclusions draw inferences, conclusions, judgments—as based on your material. Here you make one last call to action, one final appeal that your proposal be accepted. You imply that your evidence was sufficient to support your position and now request audience acceptance.

"And so our conclusion is inescapable: We must approve the four steps recommended for improving our preparation for rate case hearings."

"To review, I sincerely ask for your support in trying different methods of opening lines of communication between upper and lower management: through newsletters, through a 'Good Idea Program,' and through personal visits between management levels."

SUPPORTS FOR INFORMATIVE AND PERSUASIVE SPEAKING

Since the time of Aristotle, Cicero, and Quintilian—writers on oral communication in the ancient world—speakers have been told that good oral communication rests upon three bases: *ethos*, *pathos*, and *logos*. These Greek terms are perhaps not part of your vocabulary, yet you have used what they mean in your writing and will do so in your speaking.

Consistently, personal credibility is rated highly if you are to persuade successfully.

Ethos concerns your credibility as a speaker, what you do that suggests good sense or a high moral character. You give your listeners the impression that you are a believable person. You do that by knowing your subject, giving the feeling that you are fairly presenting your information via a delivery that is enthusiastic and believable. In other words, both you as a person and the contents of your speech must give an image of high credibility and believability.

Pathos is using emotion to support your ideas. Few of us would admit—especially in the business world—that we are moved to action on the basis of our emotions. Our advertising and marketing friends have been capitalizing on emotions for years. But few speeches in staff meetings or before company groups depend on the emotional impact left on listeners. Surely, we are influenced by appeals to fear, to self-preservation, to physical well-being, to self-esteem, and to a host of other needs, but they do not often find a prominent place in internal business communication.

It is *logos*, the third part of ancient rhetorical principles, that receives major emphasis in both written and oral persuasion. *Logos* involves using evidence and reasoning, organizing supports into logical patterns of argument. All of us hope that rational thinking governs our actions. And to a great extent speaking to your peers within a company is based on rational thinking.

Now we focus on facts and opinions and then on the seven kinds of evidence that are used to support persuasive positions.

Six Forms of Support (Evidence, Data)

Regardless of what you consider a valid number of forms of support—and there is disagreement on this subject—we suggest that the raw material for supporting your speaking aim be found through using six different supports. Clearly, the core of your supports has to be founded on facts, verifiable data. Opinions are also used, but using opinions demands selecting a credible source. After we have looked at how facts and opinions are used in six different kinds of support, we will suggest ways of testing their reliability.

Communication Probe

Most of us accept the norm that rational arguments help us accept ideas, support propositions, believe others. Surely data, evidence, and supports assist us in making a decision, but humans are inconsistent in accepting changes in belief. Using evidence is helpful, but not a 100% guarantee of success in changing others' views. However, some early studies suggest that careful use of evidence is effective; it does have some influence on the receivers of a message, particularly if it is new and relevant to the assertion or claim.

Reynolds, R. A., & Burgoon, M. (1983). Belief processing, reasoning, and evidence. In R. Bostrom (ed.). *Communication yearbook* 7 (pp. 49–82). Beverly Hills: Sage. McCroskey, J. C. (1972). In T. D. Beisecker & D. W. Parson (eds.), *The process of social influence* (pp. 318–324). Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall.

Examples

You will use this form of evidence more than any other. It is a short, pithy item, representative of a group. An example also helps clarify in addition to acting as a form of support.

> "For example, some companies in foreign countries turn off their fax machines at night in order to conserve energy. What that means is that senders in distant time zones cannot make contact."
>
> "Here's an example: It took K-mart three news releases to clarify the situation concerning the possible sale of certain subsidiaries."

Then you can draw conclusions from the example, offer judgments based on the presented information.

Illustrations

Illustrations are elongated examples; they lay out in detail a specific situation, suggesting, for example, that your proposed solution has worked successfully elsewhere.

> "TV teaching was used in this manner by X company in successfully preparing employees for overseas work. They began with a film on intercultural problems, followed that with a written analysis of what participants felt was the problem, and ended with a discussion with people who had spent time in that country. The whole process took place over three weeks."

Statistics

Many of the statistics (numbers) you use in persuasion in the business world are self-generated. They are therefore dependent on your method of collection and the inferences you draw from them. You should know what statistical measures to use to prove the validity of your data.

You will also use statistics from sources other than yourself. If statistics come from members of your own staff, you are in a good position to gauge the reliability of the data. On the other hand, turning to secondary sources outside your immediate area demands knowing the credibility of that source and the secondary source in which the information may have been reported.

> "According to the World Tourism Organization, more international tourists are arriving in Vietnam. It is estimated that Vietnam's share of tourists (including businesspersons) from Southeast Asia, Japan, Europe, North America, and Australia should increase from 2.7% in 1989 (187,573) to 8.4% (1,596,264) in 2005."

Quoting credible sources also improves the speaker's credibility.

Quotations, Testimony

Using credible sources beyond yourself adds to your credibility. That linkage adds to improved acceptance of your ideas. A *literal* quotation is using the words

of a well-established, accepted expert, an individual, or a book genuinely informed on the topic. You will use this kind of citation often in your business presentations.

> "A recent story in the *Bangkok Post* stated that 'Thailand launched a campaign to retain the 1998 Asian games.' "
>
> "Samart chairman Mr. Peter Sutch said that profits for the next fiscal year should equal or even surpass the 5.4% increase over last year."

When speakers use a *literary* quotation, they are evoking the words of a source primarily for its emotional or philosophical support. You would probably not use this kind of quotation in the business world, but rather in nonbusiness affiliations. Thus a quotation from Shakespeare, Browning, Abraham Lincoln, Confucius, or the Bible could be used for its possible emotion-getting reaction from the audience.

> "Even the Bible (Matthew 25:20) suggests we use what has been given us: 'And so he that had received five talents came and brought other five talents, saying, Lord, thou deliveredst unto me five talents: behold I have gained beside them five talents more.' "
>
> "One of the great business stories involving accounting principles, mistrust, and usury is in Shakespeare's *Merchant of Venice*; let me offer a few quotations from Portia's speech. . . ."

Comparisons (Analogies)

Comparisons demand similarities between two subjects; those similarities should outweigh the dissimilarities.

Comparisons estimate similarities and differences between at least two different items. Thus investors wish to know the earnings per share from quarter to quarter, rates of exchange between nations, comparisons that help clarify complex procedures, differences in salaries from company to company, or recommendations as to which business communication book is best on the market. Again, once the comparison is stated, you can draw conclusions from that information. Be careful. Not all persons will draw the same conclusions as you!

> "Note the differences in earnings per share in 1996 with 199-; there is a 2% increase. That success should continue."
>
> "Think of the human heart as a pump. As the water pump in an automobile moves water through the system, so the human heart pumps blood through our human system."

Definitions

Keep in mind that definitions are not exactly supports. Yet, using them helps both speaker and audience to be at the same level of understanding. In either informative or persuasive speeches, words have denotative (dictionary) meanings

or meanings that you personally link to your ideas. Use either form to clarify your thought.

> "Asian Dragons? Let me clarify. It means the four countries of Korea, Hong Kong, Thailand, and Singapore, each offering the rest of the world increased competition."
>
> "*Engineer* refers to our authorized representative for purchasing; he or she will be the final authority in administering the contract."

Questions on Forms of Support

Recall what was said earlier: All listeners and readers come with their own biases and prejudices on topics. So do we as speakers; we too select—edit out—opinions, even facts that do not conform to our way of thinking. In collecting evidence we must be careful about the accuracy and neutrality of our sources. One way an audience counters your arguments is to raise questions such as those offered in Checklist 15.4—all of which you should consider in selecting your evidence.

Do the facts agree with other facts? If there is confict between two sets of facts, both may be wrong. If the facts you use are supported by others, the data are more valid.

Are the opinions you use or depend on reliable? Just because a person is a respected member of the community does not make him or her an expert on every subject. Search for expert, rather than lay, opinions.

Answering these and other questions better prepares you for responding to

Checklist 15.4 Selecting Evidence for Your Speech

1. Is the source reliable? Is the material taken from data considered valid by common standards of honesty and integrity?
2. Does the person whom you are quoting have a reputation for credibility? For fairness? For careful research?
3. Is your information true? Valid? Is it accurate or taken out of context?
4. What is the recency of your data? How old is the information? Is it out of date? Are more recent statements available on the same topic?
5. Are your statistics valid? Have you used commonly accepted means of determining reliability?
6. Have you indicated how you obtained your evidence? Do you make it clear when you are moving from your opinion to what is considered fact?
7. How wide is your scope? How many others agree with your evidence?
8. Is your evidence ambiguous? Do you go through it with generalities, rather than specifics?

Communication Probe

Self-esteem does play a role in persuasion. Possessing this trait cuts two ways: When you're exposed to appeals from others and in turn expressing your own opinions and arguments. Persons with high self-esteem have confidence in themselves, are comfortable with their own opinions when persuading others. Moreover, these same high self-esteem persons are also more confident in challenging the opinions of others. An inevitable conclusion is that when addressing an audience possessing high self-esteem, there is need for careful selection of and credible supports for evidence selected.

Cox, D. F., & Bauer, R. A. (1964). Self confidence and persuasability in women. *Public Opinion Quarterly, 28,* 453–466; Gelfand, D. M. (1962). The influence of self-esteem on the rate of verbal conditioning and social matching behavior. *Journal of Abnormal and Social Psychology, 65,* 259–265; Gollow, J. G., & Dittes, J. E. (1965). Different effects of manipulated self-esteem on persuasibility depending on the threat and complexity of the communication. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 2,* 195–201.

possible objections and at the same time gives you confidence that your choice of evidence is acceptable and valid.

SUMMARY

In our view, the general purposes of oral communication lie on a continuum: On one end is the process of informing (through reports, goodwill statements, briefings, and instruction), and on the other is the process of persuasion (on issues of policy, procedure, value, and fact). Blending does occur between the two, informative communication frequently providing the background for persuasion. In the former you seek to clarify, make an idea or process clear; in the latter you seek willing acceptance of your ideas.

Central to either informing or persuading is knowing your audience, which means tuning in to their degrees of interest in your topic and their attitudes toward you or the subject. Both the occasion for your talk and the location details should also be known.

Your ideas may be organized in the traditional introduction, body, and conclusion format. In the introduction consider using the PAL (porch, aim, layout); in the body or discussion you have many choices: from topical, chronological, or cause to effect in informative speaking, and the more traditional problem-solution outline in persuasive speaking. A summary to your remarks reviews your major points, whereas a conclusion draws inferences from data presented.

Supports—also known as evidence or data—include using examples, statistics, quotations, comparisons, and definitions. All these need validity in order to establish your credibility with the audience.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Presentation of a Talk in a Foreign Language.*** This assignment requires that one or two persons competent in a foreign language present a 2- or 3-minute speech in a foreign language. Class members listening to this foreign speech then seek answers to the following questions:
   - Was the presentation to inform or persuade?
   - Could you determine whether the tone was serious or lighthearted?
   - Were there any words recognizable to you?
   - Was there a sense of sincerity in his or her remarks?

2. ***Determining the Clarity of a Foreign Visual Aid.*** Again this assignment works better if the student completing the assignment knows a foreign language. Have that student go to the library or some other resource and locate a visual aid in a foreign language. Clearly that visual is being used as a form of support or as evidence to accompany the written statement. Make a transparency of that foreign visual. Then do the following:
   - Project the foreign visual—as a transparency—on a screen.
   - Have members of the class draw *inferences* as to what the visual is trying to communicate or trying to support.
   - Let the student who understands the visual then interpret it.
   - Assess whether the visual meets the requirements of clarity and a form of support.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Informative Speech to Peers.*** Prepare an informative speech on any topic of your choice. Your goal is to make clear an idea to an audience of peers. As you prepare the talk, be sure to do the following: Use clear organization, support your specific purpose with a variety of support forms, and deliver with desirable pitch, rate, and volume. For a 3- to 5-minute talk, use the following format:

```
Title: _____
General purpose: to inform

                    Introduction
 I. Specific purpose _____
II.

                       Body
III.
 IV.
  V.

                     Summary
 VI.
VII.
```

4. ***Persuasive Speech on a Controversial Topic.*** Prepare a 5-minute oral statement on a controversial topic that you wish to defend before the class. You will make but one main point. Clearly, you will have to present evidence so the group will accept your proposition. Your support (evidence) should come from reliable outside sources and individual investigation. Prepare an outline similar to the following:

```
Title of one-point proposition: _____
General purpose: To persuade
Specific purpose: _____
Specific main point: _____
  First support: _____
  Second support: _____
  Third support: _____
```

The following are sample one-point assertions:

- Reprimands to employees should begin with an oral statement followed with a written summary.
- Concepts of time are different in Asia than in the United States.
- Recommendation: English should be the universal language of business throughout the world.
- Nonverbal communication is as effective as oral communication.
- There should be mandatory retirement at age 62.

5. ***Revision of General Purposes into Specific Phrases.*** Rewrite the following vague phrases into an infinitive phrase for a speech to persuade.

   Health care in the United States
   Term limits for members of Congress
   Government bonds
   E-mail
   Nonverbal communication
   Asian communication
   European right of free speech
   Dress and the listener

6. ***Informative Speech to Clarify an Idea or Explain a Purpose.*** Prepare an informative presentation that makes an idea clear or explains a process. This speech should be about 4 to 6 minutes in length. Criteria are organizational clarity, a good delivery, and content that supports your ideas. Try also to use visual aids. You may choose from these topics or others:

   The steps involved in buying stock
   What is meant by the "invisible hand" in business
   Characteristics of rejection letters
   How a word processor works
   What is meant by "first-in, last-out" in the accounting field

7. ***Assessing Periodicals for Credibility.*** After reading this chapter, you should be more attuned to the credibility of sources used for your facts and opinions. Daily you are bombarded with visual and auditory stimuli. And it

is from some of these stimuli that you collect forms of support for your speeches, or papers.

Divide a paper into two parts, as follows:

NAME OF PERIODICAL	ASSESSMENT
1.	1.
2.	2.

On the left side name a periodical (daily paper, magazine), on the right side assess the credibility of that publication as a source for financial news. Number one could be your selection as the most credible source; your last number in that column—at least five—could be your lowest-ranking source. Give reasons—support why one periodical has higher credibility than another.

8. ***Oral Presentation of Long Formal Report.*** Assume you have been asked to present your long, formal report orally at an informal conference attended by 10 managers in your company. Their work is closely concerned with the subject matter of your report. Prepare your report presentation thoughtfully. Usually a mere "summary" of the report is not the best method because it may be too general to be meaningful to your listeners. In addition, if appropriate, select specific highlights about the problem and its solution. Choose the ideas that are most likely to be of interest and importance to your audience. For example, you might introduce to them the three or four most important factors you considered in the report. Be well informed about the overall highlights of your report, and be prepared to defend your findings in a question-and-answer session (with your class members) immediately after you have presented your report. (In your presentation, you will of course *not* read many parts of the report to the audience.) Make your talk businesslike, with the right tone; it may be 20 or more minutes in length.

9. ***Persuasive Speech to Support Keeping Things As They Are.*** Occasionally you may make a speech opposing change; you like things the way they are. Prepare a 5-minute statement wherein you are opposed to change. Some possible topics include the following:
   - Insider trading rules are adequate.
   - Keep the present political party in power.
   - There is no need for a foreign language requirement for business students.
   - Keep our present requirements for receiving a degree.
   - The current tax laws are adequate.

10. ***Noting Comparison Between an Informative Talk and a Stockholder Letter.*** Go to your library and locate three different annual reports. These could be in similar product categories (all chemical or all automotive or all fast-food, for example). Read only the letter to the stockholders, usually

signed by the president or CEO (chief executive officer). Your task will be to determine answers to the following questions:

a. Is the structure similar to that of an informative speech? Does it have an introduction, body, and conclusion?
b. What is the specific purpose of the letter?
c. Is the letter informative or persuasive? Why?
d. What forms of evidence are used in the letter?
e. Was the letter effective?

11. ***Critical Analysis of a Paragraph.*** The statement that follows is attributed to no particular speaker. However, it does illustrate some flaws in critical thinking. It could have been spoken at a sales meeting or in another persuasive situation.

Analyze the statement at each of the numbered points in the statement. Each one is a location for potential critical thinking errors. You might think of content, reasoning, language, and sources for the information.

> "There is no doubt [*1*] that every [2] home in the United States needs [3] a microwave oven. Most [*4*] homes have it [5] already. In fact, statistics suggest [*6*] that microwave ovens are the fastest growing item added to every [*7*] new home. Years ago [*8*] the outdated [*9*] woodstove, the bane [*10*] of every farm woman [*11*], was the center of the family. While the microwave oven cannot match that emotional and desirable bond, it can add the same speed and efficiency enjoyed by others." [*12*]

REFERENCE

1. L. G. Verheyen. (1988, August). *Training and Development Journal,* 72–76.

Chapter 16

Strategies for Successful Interpersonal Communication

I. Dyadic Communication
   A. Self-Perceptions
   B. Dyadic Communication Relationships

II. Interviewing
   A. Interview Purposes
   B. Interviewee's Responsibilities
   C. Interviewer's Responsibilities

III. Telephoning

IV. Dictating
   A. Suggestions for Dictating
   B. Example of Dictation

V. Summary

VI. Exercises and Problems

VII. Reference

Thus far this book has focused on the more formal aspects of business communication: writing and speaking in formal business settings. But there is another side: more informal, more casual, more given to informal interactions between people. Such interaction may be called *interpersonal*; it is primarily face-to-face communication between two or more people with the opportunity for immediate feedback. Hence both sender and receiver affect one another; the feedback loop involves oral and nonverbal responses and is immediate rather than delayed, as in written communication.

Face-to-face communication is the most common form of communication within organizations.

Many of your communications will be with one other person. Such interaction is called *dyadic*. And this 1:1 relationship is the foundation for group and committee work, discussed in the next chapter. Here, however, we focus on some principles relating to dyadic communication and then offer suggestions on handling three common forms of interpersonal communication: interviewing, telephoning, and dictating.

DYADIC COMMUNICATION

Your self-perceptions can be tested through honest feedback from an intimate friend.

We define a *dyad* as two persons seeking to exchange information. Of course that may occur within a meeting, but here we focus on personal 1:1 interactions. And because two persons interact, we begin with a look at self-perceptions: how each of us sees the self.

Communication Probe

Four types of communication pervade the business world. Sometimes called the Big Four, their percentage of use has not varied much over the years—speaking, writing, listening, and reading are cornerstones of business communication. Note that two of the four relate to oral communication, some of that being interpersonal in nature. Thus writing and reading pertain to the written word. Without detailing the many studies that have investigated their percentage of usage, look at the following percentages of use by some recent Asian and Egyptian managers:

PERCENTAGE OF DAY DEVOTED TO THE FOLLOWING TYPES OF COMMUNICATION

	Egyptian	Asian
Speaking	27.3	28.7
Listening	21.8	25.3
Writing	28.6	24.4
Reading	25.1	21.4

Hildebrandt, H. W., & Edington, D. (1987). *A managerial profile: The Asian manager.* Ann Arbor: Division of Research, University of Michigan Business School, University of Michigan; Hildebrandt, W. W. (1996). [Questionnaire data from Egypt. Unpublished raw data.]

Self-Perceptions

Setting us apart from animals is our ability to look at ourselves. We can, objectively or subjectively, consider who we are. Surely most of those perceptions will be private, but on occasion we do make them public. Others' perceptions of us may be different. Take a look at the following characteristics of one man:

Tall	Married
Has a beard	Drives a four-wheel drive truck
Wears jeans to class	Smokes
Has holes in the jeans	Wears horn-rimmed glasses
Wears cap on backward	Wears no socks
Friendly	Consistently late

Although the above is an incomplete picture of the person, he nevertheless exists. What inferences do you draw from the above cues? What is your perception of this person? Would you invite him to your home? When asked to write a description of this man, one person wrote:

> He is someone from a broken home who rarely had guidance in preparing for the outside world. His home was probably disorganized. His habits were influenced by members of his family, one of whom smoked. Clearly, he likes the out-of-doors.

Would you agree? It is virtually impossible to arrive at conclusions based solely on visible, nonverbal characteristics. Actually, the description of the person is that of a college professor; he has written over 40 articles, has appeared on national forums, and currently is a leading university lecturer. His self-perception is positive; he gets along well with his peers, and he is a diabetic type I. His teaching awards have been numerous.

In short, over time we accept some personal verbal and nonverbal habits of others that are out of sync with our own. We often are inaccurate in our perception of others, and we may have a distorted view of even ourselves. A cyclical action may occur, as seen in Figure 16.1.

Jumping to conclusions about an individual can be done too quickly: Be cautious in drawing conclusions about others.

Thus, misjudging a person because of idiosyncratic behavior can lead to serious misunderstandings. Your personal biases may shout so loudly that you do not even hear what the other person says. You may have thought a lot, but not very correctly; you may have spoken a lot, but not very precisely. In short, both your self-perception and the perceptions of others can influence transactions in communication.

Dyadic Communication Relationships

It is virtually impossible *not* to communicate in reaction to another person.

Earlier we said that dyadic communication involves two people seeking to exchange information. Consequently, communication that is unidirectional lacks feedback.

Look at Figure 16.2. Speaker A sends a message to receiver B and receives little feedback from Receiver B. Receiver B, in turn, sends that same message to listener C, again with little feedback. The cycle continues. That is not good inter-

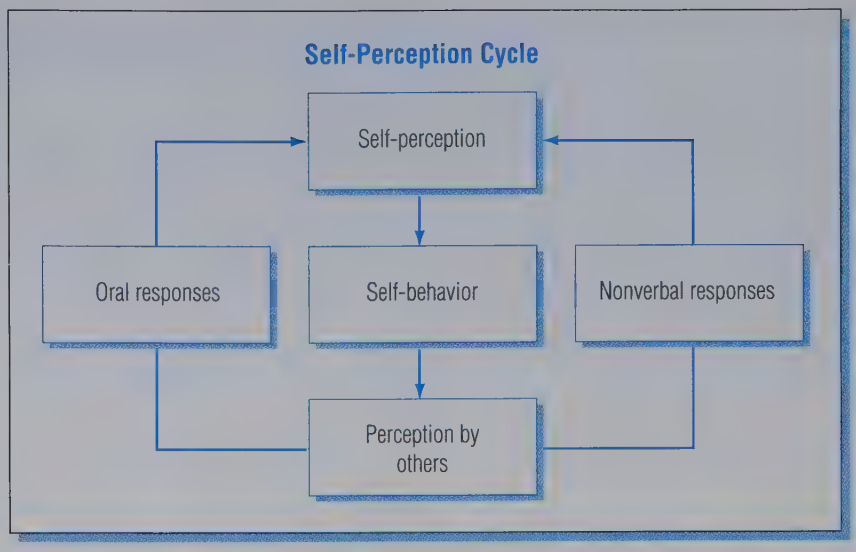

Figure 16.1 The cylical nature of self-perception.

personal communication. Some argue that it is impossible *not* to communicate. Even averting one's eyes or turning away from a speaker is a form of response. Figure 16.3 is a more purposeful dyadic exchange.

Answer this question: What are the most frequent two-person communication interactions occurring during a business day? If you guessed face-to-face communication, you are correct. We can classify two-person conversations two ways—by function and type.

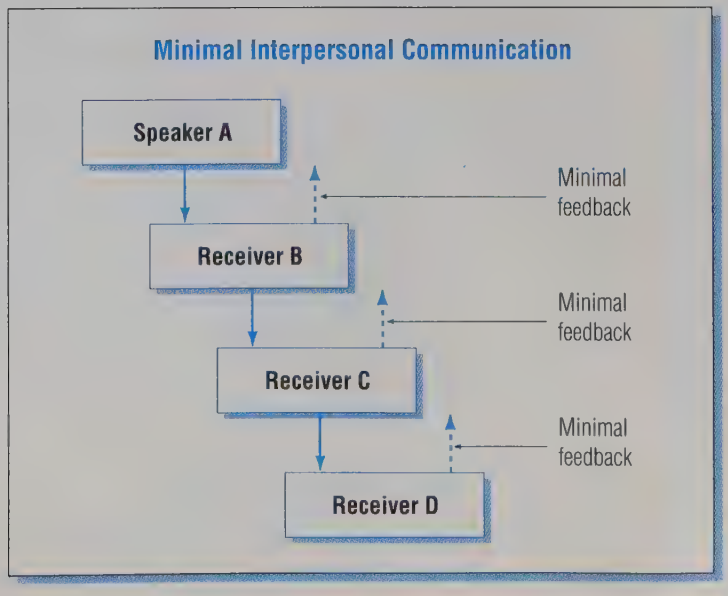

Figure 16.2 Minimal interpersonal communication.

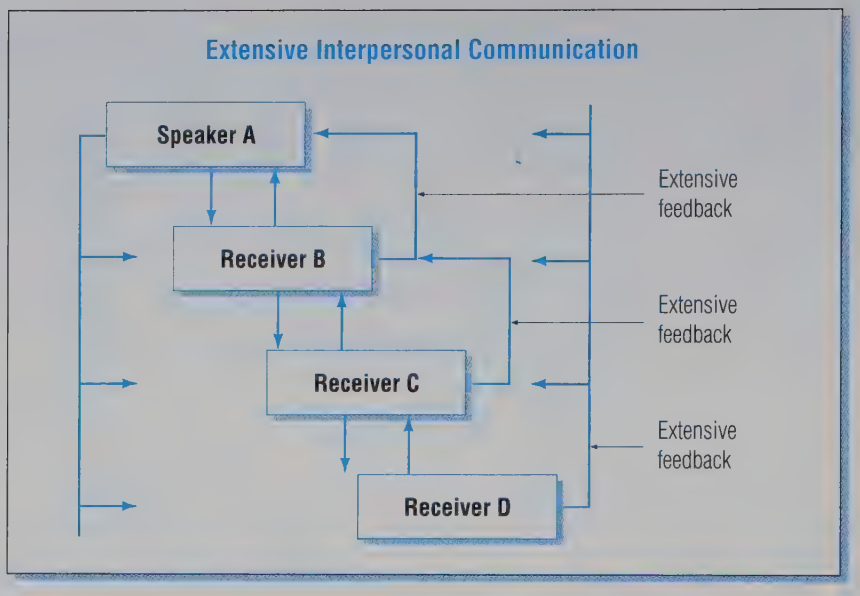

Figure 16.3 Extensive interpersonal communication.

Functional Relationships

Both informal (unplanned meetings) and formal (planned) interactions between two people are part of a communication day.

A purposeful meeting may involve two people meeting for a common purpose. Here the glue holding them together is tighter than the hall conversation or the quick hello on the street. The following are functionally related interactions:

- Interviewing for a position (*qualifications of a candidate are evaluated*).
- Instructional interview (*new employee finds out about the specific duties for a new position*).
- Telephone exchange (*clarification of issues, informing on topics, hopes for closing a deal*).
- Grade review (*session to clarify grades on a recent examination, between student and instructor*).
- Job termination (*exit interview seeking to get departing employee's reasons for leaving a position*).

And there are many others. Note that all the above examples have one common aim: to achieve something, to assist, to guide, to explain, to review. The meeting is not haphazard, but in most instances planned by one of the parties in the exchange.

Types of Relationships

A second way of viewing dyadic communication is to think about the levels at which you relate to people. On a continuum of intimate to nonintimate, where do the following persons lie?

Communication Probe

It does not take much insight to guess which form of communication is most often used in business settings: face-to-face communication. That informal mode of speaking with others is characteristic everywhere—among U.S. managers and Asian managers. In fact, with Asian managers the telephone is the most preferred means for interaction with another person. Tie that statement in with face-to-face communication, and you realize the importance given to the value of interpersonal communication. Asian statistics follow:

Modes of Communication	Percentage of Respondents Listing Modes of Communication as 1 of 4 Modes of Communication
Telephone	90
Face-to-face	77.5
Memorandum	55
Computer mail	30
Letter	29
Electronic blackboard	5
Teleconferencing	5
Videoconferencing	5

Hildebrandt, H. W., & Edington, D. (1987). *A managerial profile: The Asian manager.* Ann Arbor: Division of Research, University of Michigan Business School.

Your family	Your secretary
Your boss	Your teacher
Your coworkers	Your president
Your fellow students	Your roommate
Your spouse	Your significant other

Clearly, we desire to communicate more often, and intimately, with those with whom we feel comfortable and trust.

Each of the above categories falls somewhere on the continuum, as seen in Figure 16.4. A follow-up question to the above is what will cause your relationship to end with any of the above persons? It is safe to say that most of our relationships with others are more nonintimate: quick to flourish, quick to die.

The words exchanged between persons in an intimate relationship (spouses, significant others, dates, partners) are clearly at a different level of exposure and intimacy than the other relationship categories. Although some intimate relationships do exist in a work setting, your communication will more likely avoid the kinds of topics and intimacy reserved for your family and those close to you.

Most of your interpersonal communication at work will be at the "friend" and "acquaintances" levels. It will be more formal, with the topics heavily business-related. At meetings you may see people you do not know; they are strangers and completely nonintimate.

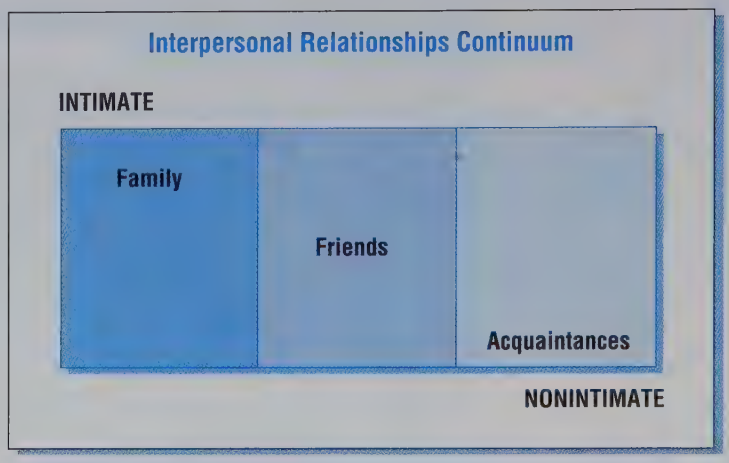

Figure 16.4 Interpersonal relationships continuum.

Reflect for a moment. What sort of oral or nonverbal greeting did you receive from complete strangers today? Were you greeted orally or given some form of recognition as a stranger passed you? Was eye contact avoided?

As your intimacy with another person increases, the kinds of communication you exchange and kinds of things you talk about also change. Thus, speaking about the weather is a safe, nonthreatening oral greeting; or a slight nod, or a hesitant wave to a stranger is usually acceptable. Rare is the person who launches into controversy immediately on meeting a stranger. Only after some sharing of pleasantries do both persons begin to open up and make public their

Communication Probe

No test is exact enough to determine whether your perceptions about another person are correct. Yet, you must interact, you must communicate with other people. You, to a large extent, may prefer certain of those people. How? Our degrees of positive feelings for another are as varied as the research on the topic. Propinquity (proximity of physical closeness) is a cause; so are similarities in attitudes. Demographic characteristics such as age, gender, education, cultural or ethnic identity, and socioeconomic status also play a role, as do similarity in beliefs, opinions, and values. When two people believe, and sense, the presence of these characteristics, they are on the way to becoming close interpersonal communicators.

Byme, D. (1969). Attitudes and attraction. In L. Berkowit (ed.), *Advances in experimental social psychology,* Vol. 4. New York: Academic Press; Byrne, D. (1971). *The attraction paradigm.* New York: Academic Press; McCroskey, J. C., Richmond, V. P., & Daly, J. A. (1975). The development of a measure of perceived homophily in interpersonal communication. *Human Communication Research, 1,* 323–332.

Communication Probe

A recent theory on determining linkages between one's self-perception of his or her communication abilities and that of others is the Competing Values Communication Model. Here you first self-assess your oral or written skills. Then other people (peers, subordinates, or superiors) are asked to do the same about you. Through statistical calculations applied to 12 criteria, it is possible to create a visual picture of where you feel you are *now* and where you would *like to be.* Similar calculations are done for others' evaluations. A sample of a completed visual of one person's self-assessment is depicted in Figure 16.5.

Rogers, P. S. & Hildebrandt, H. W. (1993). Competing values instruments for analyzing written and spoken management messages. *Human Resource Management,* 32(1), 121–142; Quinn, R. E., Hildebrandt, H. W., Rogers, P. S., & Thompson, M. (1991). A competing values framework for analyzing presentational communication in management contexts. *The Journal of Business Communication,* 28(3), 213–232.

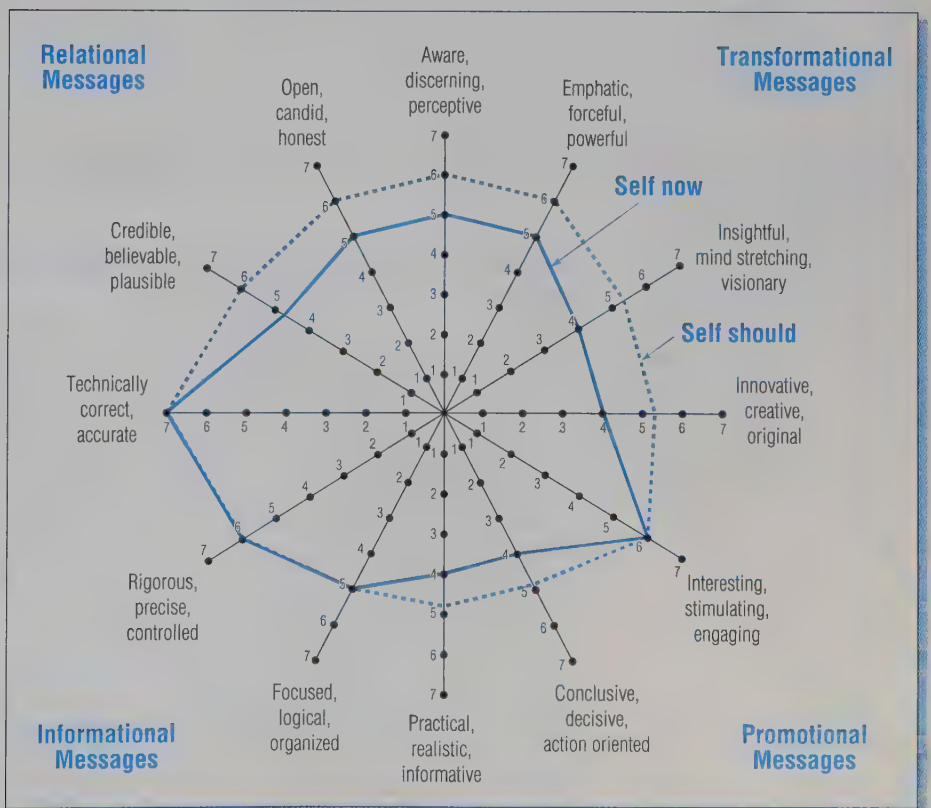

Figure 16.5 One person's self-assessment.

Checklist 16.1 Interpersonal Disclosures in Interpersonal Communication

1. Recognize that interpersonal relationships take time. Ask: Am I comfortable with certain people? What can I do to improve my relationship with them?
2. Recognize that some persons do not offer self-disclosure statements. Ask: If you want a closer relationship with others, have you—over time—attempted to make public more of your personal thoughts?
3. Recognize that relationships end; this is not unusual. Ask: Have you personally made an effort to continue or discontinue that relationship? Can you assess why the relationship ended?

views on issues. Time generally raises the level of intimacy. Some forms of address may become more familiar; first names replace last names. Checklist 16.1 describes interpersonal relationships more fully.

INTERVIEWING

A job interview may be the most intense dyadic communication you will ever encounter.

Some colleges and universities have an Office of Career Development. Among its purposes is to prepare you to do a better job when interviewing for a position.

Communication Probe

Dyad research suggests that when there is agreement on the process when working through an issue, there is an increased degree of success for that project. Likewise, business organizations are realizing the importance of "gatekeepers," or persons who control access to another person or office. Thus, establishing a rapport with a gatekeeper increases the success of a company in improving its informal external communication. Although the research is preliminary among information technology professionals, it is a start at determining that self-reporting information dissemination behavior can be used to identify gatekeepers among individuals with diverse information-gathering behaviors.

Watson, W., Ponthieu, L., & Critelli, J. (1995, September). Team interpersonal process effectiveness in venture partnerships and its connection to perceived success. *Journal of Business Venturing, 10,* 393–411; Kolobas, J., & McGill, T. (1955, September). Identification of technological gatekeepers in the information technology profession. *Journal of the American Society for Information Science, 46,* 581–589.

In fact, an interview—there are many types—may be one of your most important dyadic communications. Here the dyadic interaction may place you in a session with a complete stranger or with someone known in your work environment. Regardless, you need preparation.

This section reviews seven common interview objectives, presents three checklists that you as interviewee can use as a guide for successful interviews, and discusses the responsibilities of the interviewer.

Interview Purposes

We stated above that interpersonal communication is purposeful. Such is the case in the following interview situations:

Use	Procedure	Example
Seeking position	Candidates speak with company representative.	Recruiter meets with graduating students or job seekers.
Informing on job	Job requirements are stated as based on job description or job experience.	Senior member or boss meets with new employee early in job experience.
Solving problem	Facts are collected, options reviewed, decision is made.	Employer talks with successful employee who is abrasive.
Supporting solution	Information is collected and arguments are planned to persuade.	Manager persuades employee who is opposed to recommendation.
Counseling employee	Facts are used to support contention that employee needs help.	Employee, accused of drug abuse on the job, is presented with treatment options.
Evaluating employee	Job performance review form is discussed.	Supervisor makes yearly review of employee.
Gathering information	Data are gathered on why employees leave; emphasis is on events and not personalities.	Manager conducts exit interview.

Interviewee's Responsibilities

Considerable literature—articles, books, videotapes—is readily available for a detailed discussion of the role you play in the process of seeking a job. Our suggestions are in the form of three checklists, each of which acts as a summary of a stage of the interview process (see Checklists 16.2, 16.3, and 16.4). Most job interviews in the past have been those in which the candidate appears in person

Checklist 16.2 Preparation Before the Job Interview

Thorough preparation is essential. Go through the following five steps to ensure success at the interview:

1. Understand yourself (*a rational self-assessment of your strengths and weaknesses is a must*).
2. Know details about available position (*review how your skills relate to the open position*).
3. Do homework on company (*analyze the firm; read the Wall Street Journal on the day of the interview for possible firm references*).
4. Rehearse possible questions (*brainstorm issues, questions*).
5. Speak with insiders (*learn from alumni, from others familiar with the company*).

for evaluation. However, a growing format for interviewing candidates for positions is the interview via your personal computer.

Computer Interviews

The personal, on-campus interview still dominates. Yet, as costs increase to meet candidates face to face or in videoconferencing techniques, some initial effort is being given to computer conferencing. Basic technological aids needed include a high-speed telephone line and on each end a computer, a small camera, a micro-

Checklist 16.3 Procedures During the Job Interview

1. Give positive first impression; offer a warm handshake; show a pleasant smile.
2. State your understanding of the interview (usually the interviewer gives this statement).
3. Organize your answers; think of stating a thesis or claim and then supporting that position with data or evidence, as you do in writing or formal speaking.
4. Listen. That task is difficult because you may desire to do most of the talking. Avoid confrontation.
5. Ask thoughtful questions: about the company, about the position.
6. Offer a conclusion at the end of the session: who, what, when, where, and possibly why. Obtain agreement on those conclusions.

Checklist 16.4 Follow-Up After the Job Interview

1. If there were specific actions to be accomplished, do so promptly.
2. If you are to provide additional information, gather than information and offer it to the interviewer.
3. If a thank-you note is required, send it within a day or so.

phone, and some software. Both the candidate and the interviewer sit at their computers and via a split screen can speak to each other and even pinpoint sections of the resume. Your school, and even some companies, may be in the process of signing up for this interactive system.

Suggestions for the Computer Interview

Stephen Miller[1] offers seven suggestions for a computer interview:

- Try out the equipment beforehand.
- Avoid excessive movement.
- Use an audio and visual check before beginning.
- Dress as if the interview were live: person to person.
- Operate on the assumption that everything you say will be heard.
- Avoid high-contrast clothing; small cameras have difficulty with contrast.
- Try to relax.

Interviewer's Responsibilities

Recruiters to schools are often recent graduates of those schools. They know the school; they know the caliber of the students. You too may be in that position—someday. For your preparation, and knowing how the interviewer prepares, we look at objectives of the patterned interview, a checklist of an interviewer's preparation, the procedures during the interview, and an evaluation of the conclusion.

Objectives of the Patterned Interview

Sophisticated measures are being used for initial screening of job applicants. The job interview thus becomes highly important.

In a patterned interview, the interviewer controls the direction of the conversation. He or she may actually follow an agreed-upon evaluation form used by all company recruiters. Remember, they have read your resume, and they will know more about you than you will know about them. In fact, some schools publish complete resumes of all their graduates—with standardized resume forms. All resumes may also be included on a CD-ROM disk and available to companies for a fee.

Recruiters often have four goals:

- Evaluate job qualifications that resumes cannot provide.
- Determine the oral communication ability of the interviewee; can the interviewee think off the cuff in a cogent and logical manner?

- Give the applicant essential facts about the job and company.
- Establish goodwill on behalf of the company.

Interviewer's Preparation Before Interview

Warm-Up Period of the Interview. Earlier we considered how we communicate with strangers, trying to avoid controversial topics as both persons search for a common ground. Nonverbally, greet the candidate with a firm handshake and a warm smile. Orally, suggest a degree of enthusiasm in your greeting; be sincere and friendly. It is up to the interviewer to set the interviewee at ease, perhaps building on some current topic as suggested in the resume. A candidate's hobbies are a nice, noncontroversial beginning to an interview.

Main Content of the Interview. After the brief warm-up, you make clear the purpose of the interview and the topics you plan to cover. You encourage the applicant to do most of the talking, but you control the interview and see that it does not wander aimlessly. You ask appropriate planned questions, use desirable methods throughout the interview, and avoid pitfalls.

Asking appropriate questions. You might begin by letting the applicant describe his or her education, and then move to the work history and off-the-job activities. Focus on relevant information that cannot be obtained as well from other sources.

Open-ended questions and statements are usually preferred because the applicant can give you more information—both verbal and nonverbal. Among useful open-ended questions you might ask are those that begin with "what," "which," "why," "how," or "tell me."

> Which courses were the most useful in your degree program? Why?
>
> Which courses did you like best? Least? Why?
>
> Please describe yourself in comparison with other members of your class.

Checklist 16.5 Interviewer Preparation Before Interview

1. Read each applicant's resume prior to the meeting.
2. Focus on core information desired: for instance, character, personality, work experience, training, motivation, interests.
3. Be aware of national and state regulations regarding fair employment practices.
4. Plan your questions. Know if your questions are within the laws concerning marital status, age, race, sex, religion, and other matters. (*Some schools have oversight committees to be sure all questions and the behavior of the interviewers are appropriate.*)
5. Omit personal bias from your prepared questions.

Outside of school what are your interests?

What experiences in your previous jobs have helped you prepare for the job you are now seeking?

Describe the kind of manager for whom you would like to work.

Why are you leaving your present job? [*If the applicant mentions "problems with my supervisor" or other vague reasons, you may tactfully probe for clarification.*]

Dead-end questions (also called *closed questions*) usually ask for only "yes" or "no" or other one-word answers.

How many people graduated in your class?

Can you give me the percentage of foreign graduates who majored in Accounting? Marketing? Finance?

How many accounting courses did you have in college? Did you enjoy college? Which course was most difficult?

Questions similar to these elicit quick responses that are easy to tabulate. But the information is often less helpful than that from open-ended questions—unless you probe for an explanation or reasons for the answers.

Know the interview "rules" of the school and which questions can be asked in an interview.

Using effective methods. Tense applicants do not give positive impressions. In part, that may be due to unfair, leading, negative questions. Avoid such self-betraying questions, value-judgment questions, and any questions that the respondent may be reluctant to answer.

One of the things that I've supported for years is . . . ; what's your opinion on that?

[*School*] is known for its lousy school attitude; would you agree with me?

What's your reaction to the favorable (unfavorable) ruling of the Supreme Court on the issue of . . . ?

Tell me, why are so many of you so tense in this school?

Questions should be neutral. Embarrassing the interviewee—even in a planned confrontational interview—adds few benefits.

Evaluation After the Interview

Your authors follow one basic rule after an interview: They immediately write notes on all interviewed candidates. Memories are variable; written notes help keep a paper trail of important recollections. In your evaluation of the interview, the cues in the following Communication Probe should prove useful in determining a macro impression of the candidate.

Interview formats are as diverse as the companies doing the interviewing.

It is your choice as to the form of your notes following the interview. Some persons simply write a paragraph on each interviewee; others complete a checklist evaluation form. The form is unimportant. More important are your topic inclusions such as education and training, work experience, current off-the-the-job life, personal characteristics, and an overall summary. Such a form might look

Communication Probe

POSITIVE AND NEGATIVE IMPRESSIONS FOLLOWING AN INTERVIEW

Positive Cues	Negative Cues
Behavioral and Psychological Cues	
Early arrival	Late arrival
Alert, responsive attitude	Inattentive
Emphatic attitude	Condescending or withdrawn
Relaxed manner	Tense, fidgety
Smiling	Frowning
Clear voice	Mumbling, timid
Verbal Cues	
Sticking to main point	Changes the subject
Incisiveness	Generalizes, excessive detail
Relevant responses	Irrelevant responses
Organized presentation	Disorganized
Appropriate use of humor	Uncalled-for levity
Spontaneous replies	Long pauses
Speaks well of people	Criticizes others
Candor	Rationalizes, evasive

like the following interview assessment guide, which is taken from the University of Michigan's Office of Career Development; it is one example of an actual form used in campus interviews.

Campus Interview Appraisal Guide

Name of Student _____ **Name of Recruiter** _____

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Rate the candidate on each dimension using the following scale (circle your rating).

   4 = outstanding 2 = good 0 = did not observe

   3 = superior 1 = unacceptable

2. List what you see as the candidate's primary strengths and weaknesses.

3. Make your final recommendation.

LEADERSHIP STYLE AND INFLUENCE. Asserting ideas and opinions effectively and gaining impact without relying on authority or position.

4	3	2	1
+ Consistently in a leadership role among group of friends or classmates. + Takes charge of ambiguous situations, establishing structure and direction toward objectives. + Controls conflict directly.		– No school-related leadership experience. – Past experience demonstrates authoritarian or extreme task orientation when leading.	

TECHNICAL/PROFESSIONAL KNOWLEDGE. Possessing technical knowledge and understanding of discipline fundamentals through past training and experience.

4	3	2	1
+ Special awards, recognition for academic excellence + Closely related job experience. + Able to apply knowledge in practical business settings.		– Limited previous experience in required area. – Difficulty communicating concepts and theories. – Little reading of industry publications to keep skills up to date.	

COMMUNICATION. Presenting material orally and in writing in an interesting, persuasive, organized, articulate, and concise manner.

4	3	2	1
+ Speaks clearly and articulately. + Extensive vocabulary-used descriptively and precisely. + Makes points concisely.		– Mumbles, rambles, digresses, interrupts. – Flat, monotonic. – Mechanical gestures, nervous mannerisms	

INTERPERSONAL RELATIONS. Developing and maintaining smooth, cooperative working relations with others.

4	3	2	1
+ Socially active in school, participator, committed member. + Demonstrates an understanding of other's needs and concerns. + Interpersonally poised, gains impact in business and social situations.		– Prefers to interact only with persons like themselves. – Blunt, insensitive, critical. – Makes poor initial impression on others.	

INITIATIVE AND DRIVE. Actively attempting to influence events and to originate actions to achieve goals.

4	3	2	1
+ Successfully juggles range of academic, social and part/fulltime work demands. + Surpasses established performance standards by effort. + Overcomes significant obstacles to get results.		– Works only toward goals others have set. – Uncomfortable on own, quickly looks for aid of others. – Fast to start and slow to finish—has trouble sustaining energy.	

TELEPHONING

All of us have grown up using the telephone. It is basic to business communication and is used extensively even in international communication. Rather than give a detailed discussion of its usage or the types of telephone capabilities, we offer Checklists 16.6, 16.7, and 16.8 for you to review.

DICTATING

Most international hotels and their business centers have dictation facilities for immediate transcriptions to one's central office.

Dyadic communication is direct communication between two persons. Dictation is oral communication between two people but with a twist. You speak to someone either directly or via some electronic device. Your goal, often, is to have someone else type a communication that will be sent to an addressee. Shorthand is falling by the wayside; in its place is the spoken word recorded on the many kinds of electronic devices for transcription later.

Suggestions for Dictating

Your approach will vary little from preparing for a telephone call. Here too you collect information, plan for your specific purpose, organize ideas clearly, and speak in a firm, clear voice. What you do additionally is give more instructions to the stenographer transcribing your words unto paper. We offer seven suggestions.

1. Give the precise name, address of the individual(s) to whom the message is to be sent.
2. Speak clearly. Be careful with plurals. It's also better to repeat when using numbers. Sounds such as "p" and "b," "f" and "v," and "t" and "d" can be misunderstood.
3. Spell unusual words or names when using them for the first time, as in the following list:

Checklist 16.6 Points to Consider in International Telephoning

1. Be aware of time zones. Western Europe is between 6 and 7 hours ahead of the eastern United States. Asia is 13 or 14 hours ahead. Few businesspersons want to get phone calls in the middle of the night.
2. Speak more clearly. Often your message receiver is foreign and is using English as a second language. Overarticulate in place of mumbling.
3. Restate and summarize more often. Memories are prone to error.
4. Follow up the conversation with a letter or fax. That way you and the message receiver have a statement that summarizes the major points covered.

Checklist 16.7 Sender's Preparation Prior to a Phone Call

1. Know your specific purpose; have some questions in mind. It is better to have one central purpose than many rambling thoughts. Introduce yourself if much time has elapsed between calls.
2. Know the precise person you are calling, and the best time to call.
3. Give thought to your opening statement. As noted earlier in this text, even a PAL (porch, aim, layout) introduction can focus direction for the conversation.
4. Take notes. Have before you pertinent papers of previous correspondence or summaries of previous discussions.

accept, except
addition, edition
affect, effect
assistance, assistants
brake, break
cease, seize
coarse, course
compliment, complement
council, consul, counsel
formally, formerly
its, it's
latter, ladder
ordinance, ordnance
practical, practicable
principal, principle
residence, residents
right, rite, write
sight, site, cite
stationary, stationery
straight, strait
their, there, they're
to, too, two
waive, wave
weather, whether
who's, whose

4. Suggest punctuation. Clearly, this suggestion depends on the amount of time you have spent with a secretary. But in many instances a secretar-

Checklist 16.8 Message Receiver's Guidelines

1. Be patient. Giving the feeling that the phone call is an intrusion gets the conversation off to a negative start.
2. Listen. Interruptions break up both your and your partner's train of thought.
3. Restate. Be sure you understand and that your partner agrees.
4. End politely. Suggest, if your partner does not, that you would be happy to supply a summary of the conversation.

ial pool transcribes your words. When in doubt, insert your suggestions as to paragraphs and specific punctuation, if you feel it is needed.

Of all dictation suggestions, this one is foremost: Speak more slowly and distinctly than usual.

5. Avoid side comments. These "off the cuff" comments (intended merely as your personal opinions) confuse more than clarify.
6. Dictate at a slower rate of speech. Too rapid a rate may slur some words; too slow—with too many interruptions caused by holding the pause button on the recording machine—will confuse the stenographer.
7. End with a suggestion regarding the time you will need the recorded information and state where you can be reached.

Example of Dictation

The following opening and closing sections from a good-news reply to a phoned request for product information simulate how an orally dictated letter might "sound" to the transcriber. If you dictate to the secretary face to face, most of the words below in italics will be omitted. If, however, you use a voice-recording instrument, your instructions to the transcriber may be similar to those in italics below. Of course, voice inflection conveys additional (unspoken) instructions—for instance at the end of each sentence.

> "Good morning, operator. This is Robert Bridges in the consumer service department. Extension 507. Please transcribe this letter addressed to Mr. Phillip P-h-i-double l-i-p Jones, Department four two, Harrington H-a-double r-i-n-g-t-o-n Corporation, one six zero zero Avenue of the Americas plural. New York, New York, one zero zero three eight. Dear Mr. Jones.
>
> "Thank you for your inquiry about our, *operator, next two words all caps* ELECTRO *hyphen* SPEED, *operator, cap M as in Mary* Model 28, *operator, cap T* Typewriter. Yes, *comma* indeed *comma* this model has proved very popular in such applications as yours in which, *operator, one word* downtime must be minimized. *Paragraph.*"

[*Middle paragraphs dictated in similar fashion.*]

> "Our sales representative in the *cap E* Eastern *cap T* Territory *comma* Tanya *T-a-n-y-a* Brickler *B-r-i-c-k-l-e-r comma* will call you next week to set up a meeting to discuss your needs more specifically *semicolon* she will then be able to inventory your needs and give you a price quotation. To help you investigate our product line more thoroughly *comma* I have enclosed six colorful brochures *period, parenthesis.* Note the blue leaflet that describes the automatic *quote, initial cap N* Never *hyphen, initial cap F* Forget *end quote* one zero zero *hyphen* character memory system *period, close parenthesis, paragraph.*
>
> Please call me at five five five *hyphen* double nine eight seven if we can answer additional inquiries about our typewriters. Cordially yours, Robert Bridges, Customer Service Representative. Enclosures, six.

A shortened version of the same material—providing your secretary knows your style—might proceed in this manner.

"Joanne, I'll give you the business cards for all the next couple of letters when I return. Just omit the inside address. This is letter one.

"Dear Mr. Jones. Thanks for your inquiry about our ELECTRO-SPEED Model 28 Typewriter. Yes, this model has proved very popular in such applications as yours in which downtime must be minimized. *Next Paragraph . . .*"

Joanne would know, from previous letters dictated by her boss, which words to capitalize, where the dictator wishes abbreviations, and even when the preferred ending should be.

SUMMARY

A dyad is defined as two persons seeking to exchange information. Communication in that situation is two-way. Feedback is immediate. In that interchange both persons have a perception of themselves, either accurate or erroneous. Regardless of those perceptions, we are most open with those closest to us, and less so with our partners in a business environment.

An interview is one of the more common forms of dyadic communication, which is often 1:1. You and your partner seek to solve a problem, inform, and even persuade. These general purposes are found in situations such as seeking a position, informing about job requirements, solving a company problem, counseling an employee, and evaluating an employee.

Face-to-face communication and the telephone are the most used modes of communication. At the international level additional problems arise, primarily language issues and problems of time. One should prepare as carefully for a phone conversation as for a longer oral statement.

Dictation is oral communication to an intermediary who transcribes the spoken words into a written message. Desirable dictation practices include clear pronunciation, spelling of unusual words (where appropriate), and adequate instructions to the transcriber. With today's word processing systems, several drafts can easily be prepared before a final one is approved.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Hindrances to Interpersonal Communication in an International Setting.*** It does not take much effort to recognize that communication problems occur when speaking with someone who is highly conversant in your own language. Problems are compounded when you add another variable: someone who uses English as a second language. Even though you may not have visited a foreign country (or if you have, so much the better), simply make a list of hindrances that you think might occur when holding a 1:1 conversation with a person using English as a second language. Chapter 3 should give you a start on compiling your own list.

2. ***Mock Interview of International Student or Nonnative Speaker.*** This assignment requires one nonnative member of the class to provide two

things: A resume as prepared in that international student's own country (it will be different from those prepared in the United States) and his or her willingness to be interviewed by members of the class. Specific goals: (a) Have the international student explain some differences between her or his resume and those in the United States; (b) have the international student suggest which questions in an interview would be acceptable; and (c) have the international student describe the differences between interviews conducted in her or his own country and those in the United States.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Oral Report After an Interview.*** This project involves an interview (for information-gathering purposes) and an oral presentation (for information-dissemination purposes). Your first task is to identify and interview a person who has a type of job or career that you hope to enter upon graduation. The purpose of the interview is to determine what kinds of communication activities that person must engage in during a typical week. You should not only cover the types of written messages sent and received but also determine the volume or frequency, the job title for the originator of the incoming messages, and the disposition of the messages (what your interviewee does upon receiving each type of message). Do not forget to cover oral communication messages (verbal orders or directives, telephone requests, etc.). For outgoing written or oral messages, find out to whom (title of person) the messages are directed. Unless the interviewee keeps a log of such activities, you will have to depend on the interviewee's estimates for some of the information.

   The second part of this assignment requires you to make a formal oral report of your findings in class. A 3- to 5-minute time limit should be sufficient; however, your instructor may wish to establish other limits.

4. ***Exit Interview Planned to Gather Useful Information.*** For efficiently handling a situation in which your oral communication skills are important to a company, you must do some preliminary planning and practice.

   Assume that you work for a firm with high employee turnover. Your responsibility is to gather information that will be useful to management in determining why so many employees leave. This information will be gathered in an exit interview procedure used by your company and conducted with every employee who leaves. You are to establish specific objectives to be followed during the interview, set up strategies that can be followed, and develop a specific list of questions that you will ask during the interview.

   Try these questions out in an interview setting in class, using another member of the class as the employee who is leaving the company. In your interview, you should first express appreciation to the employee for his or her service. (This should be done in order to set the tone for a positive and relaxed interview.) You should then emphasize to the employee that in no way will the information gathered be used against the employee when seeking employment elsewhere. Stress the fact that the information will be used to help management improve working conditions in the company and per-

haps help cut down on employee turnover. Use any technique that you believe will ensure a nonthreatening situation.

Your primary functions during the interview are to solicit the information your company needs and to provide information that will be helpful to the employee.

5. ***Oral Instructive Explanation About a Particular Job.*** Present to the class a 5-minute instructive explanation on how to perform the duties of a particular job you are familiar with. After you finish, call on a class member to tell as well as possible what she or he learned. (This procedure tests not only your instructional clarity but also the listener's attentiveness.)

6. ***Oral Improvements on Three Telephone Responses to Customers.*** The following replies are similar to some that employees have given to customers when answering telephone calls. What impressions do you think they make? Write your suggestions for improving each. Then be prepared to share your ideas orally in class.

   a. "Hello. Yeah, it's Jake. Huh? What kinda TV do ya have? I dunno if we have a part to fit it. I can't tell ya; I have ta know the model number of your TV. Wait a sec. I'll look. Woops. Got a customer here just now. Call again. Bye." [*Click*]

   b. "Hi, nope. This is not Mr. Brown. Wow! I'm not sure if he's out or just not taking calls. Maybe he's still out to lunch. What was your name? Hang on."

   c. "Hello. XY repair service. Gosh, we're so far behind today. Have a stack of cars here. No way we could getcha in today. Well, maybe. Don't call until after tomorrow."

7. ***A Difficult Job Interview Question for Class Discussion.*** As a class exercise you are asked to bring in one question that you consider difficult to answer in an interview. The question may be one actually asked in a job interview or a potential question about which you feel uncomfortable in answering. Because each of your classmates will also bring a question to read in class, you will all hear a variety of questions. Some class members may then try responding to them—tactfully, truthfully, and as specifically as possible.

8. ***Oral Report on Interviews Via Computers.*** Electronic innovations are occurring daily. It would be useful to contact three groups now working on or using the computer as an interview tool. ViewNet, of Madison, Wisconsin, has been in the market for 8 years, marketing a PC-based program. Schools trying the program include Brown, the Georgia Institute of Technology, Vanderbilt, the University of Michigan, and others. Companies participating include Boeing, Chase Bank, Procter and Gamble, and others. Choose topical headings for an oral report to the class, after contacting some

of the above participants. Describe in some detail the emerging process and evaluate the strengths and weaknesses of the system as you see it.

REFERENCE

1. Miller, S. (1996, January 7). Lights! Camera! Telephone? It's the long-distance interview. *The New York Times* (Education Life Suppl.), p. 13.

Chapter 17

Strategies for Successful Business and Group Meetings

I. Background Information on Groups
- A. Definition of a Group Meeting
- B. Formation of Groups

II. Purposes and Kinds of Meetings
- A. Informational Meetings
- B. Suggested Solution Meetings
- C. Problem-Solving Meetings

III. Solving Problems in Meetings or Groups
- A. Authorization for a Committee
- B. Methods of Solving Problems in Meetings

IV. Leadership Responsibilities in Meetings
- A. Kinds of Leadership
- B. Planning Steps Before the Meeting
- C. Procedures During the Meeting
- D. Follow-Up After the Meeting

V. Participant Responsibilities in Meetings
- A. Preparation for Meetings
- B. Effective Participant Roles in Meetings

IV. Summary

VII. Exercises and Problems

VIII. References

You know the familiar definition of a meeting: a group of people wasting time on topics of unimportance. Perhaps true. But it need not be that way. Each day—no matter the country or the company—meetings are held to conduct business more efficiently and for more profit. Sadly, if there is one activity in the business world that disturbs people, it is the meeting—for any number of negative reasons.

Poorly run meetings need not occur. Thus, this chapter offers some background information on groups, reviews the purposes and kinds of meetings occurring in business, lays out the various ways to solve problems in meetings, and summarizes the responsibilities of both the group leader and participants.

BACKGROUND INFORMATION ON GROUPS

Definition of a Group Meeting

Purposive discourse between two or more people is a common definition of a group meeting.

Definitions for meetings are legendary: "They keep minutes and spend hours"; "they sow but do not reap"; "a camel is a horse designed by a committee"; and so on. But let's be positive: A meeting is a gathering of two or more people where purposive discourse occurs. Of course these purposes will vary.

In the preceding chapter we suggested that dyadic communication is primarily an interchange between two people. A group is larger: at least 3 people and perhaps as many as 15 or more. Additionally, a group often meets face to face with a common purpose in mind. Such a group may also be informal (unplanned, free-flowing discourse) or formal (clear, planned purpose).

Informal Group

Informal or casual meetings also make up *groups*. Such meetings build rapport between people and can be the basis for later formal meetings.

Casual or informal group meetings are common. Here you casually chat over coffee, meet after work, or get together for purely social occasions. You and your friends meet to socialize, to interact—often spontaneously, without plan. Your business day is filled with such informal group meetings. Ironically, out of the need for frequent casual meetings may develop the need for more formal and directed meetings.

Formal Group

Often called task-oriented groups, *formal groups* often search for answers to problems, look for a course of action, make recommendations to a higher authority. This means that you and others may meet to change a policy, make decisions on how a specific problem should be solved, and decide on the beginning steps to implement a solution.

Our focus in this chapter is more on this formal group: a gathering where the participants and leader know the specific reason for getting together. Would you call the following meeting announcement specific?

```
TO:       The Staff
FROM:     Personnel
SUBJECT:  Vacations

Hope you can make the meeting on November 10.
We've got to talk about vacations for everyone.
```

Communication Probe

There are many reasons why people join a group, foremost of which is interpersonal attraction. Additionally, there are such factors as proximity, even physical attributes, similar and perceived abilities in others. Others suggest that similarity in attitudes strengthen interpersonal attraction, as well as similarity in personalities. From the above it is easy to add other shared characteristics one searches for in working within groups: similarity in economic status, gender, and race. In brief, interpersonal attraction is a major cause for joining, for working and meeting with others interested in a common purpose.

Festinger, L., Schachter, S., & Black, K. W. (1950). *Social pressure in informal groups.* New York: Harper; Maissonneuve, J., Palmade, G., & Fourment, C. (1952). Selective choices and propinquity. *Sociometry, 15,* 135–140; Byme, D., & Nelson, D. (1964). Attraction as a function of attitude similarity-dissimilarity: The effect of topic importance. *Psychonomic Science, I,* 93–94; and many others.

Hopefully you said "no," for the purpose of the above meeting announcement is vague, incomplete, imprecise. We make suggestions for clarifying meeting announcements later.

Formation of Groups

As with other encounters, people go through an interpersonal ritual before beginning movement toward solving a problem.

How are groups formed? Surely informal or casual group meetings arise out of a common liking for the other persons. You just enjoy being with them. In fact, strong interpersonal attraction, as discussed in Chapter 16, is the glue holding persons together for a common, even casual, purpose. One researcher[1] suggests that most groups go through four formative stages in becoming a group.

Forming	Here the group tries to get started. It is the orientation phase for group members.
Storming	Members begin to stake out their positions; they begin to have conflicts and arguments.
Norming	Progress begins here. Members work to solve conflicts and recognize acceptable kinds of conduct.
Performing	Here the group begins to achieve its goals.

Most likely when joining an organization, you will join the group at step four, *performing*; it would be rare for you as a company newcomer to try to get a group started. More likely you would join a mature group, one under way for some time.

Once you are part of a group seeking to solve a problem, one other thing occurs: The group begins to follow certain phases in solving the problem.

Checklist 17.1 Guidelines for Starting a Group

1. *Ask:* Do the other members of your proposed group agree on what the purpose of the group should be?
2. *Ask:* Do the initial members of the group get along well; is there personal compatibility?
3. *Ask:* Do the similarities—in such areas as abilities, personalities, economic status, physical attributes—outweigh the dissimilarities?
4. *Ask:* Do you wish to proceed in an informal or a formal manner, or are meetings to be spontaneous?

Orientation Here discussion is free-flowing, people orally wander about, each trying to focus on asking questions. Here too, questions are numerous: Members try to inform, ask further questions. Here members' convictions are tentative and somewhat ambiguous.

Conflict After the preliminary sparring is over, members begin to offer opinions, evidence in support of their position. At this phase initial conflicts occur. There may even be resistance to the agreed-upon task.

It's normal to have conflict as divergent views begin to appear in a discussion.

Emergence Open exchanges continue; members begin to search for ways of truly solving the problem. Compromises occur, and there is a decrease in conflict and sincere movement toward decreasing differences in opinion.

Solutions A positive attitude exists at this phase. Options have been discussed, and criteria for measuring those options have been viewed. Now is the time to complete the task and agree upon a solution.[2]

PURPOSES AND KINDS OF MEETINGS

We noted that meetings have two core purposes: to present information and to help solve problems. Obviously both purposes occur in all meetings. Three kinds of meetings help achieve these objectives.

Informational Meetings

Informational meetings seek only to clarify, to make something clear, to give information.

Review the following list: all were actual meeting topics in various companies.

- Changes in reporting procedures in the purchasing department
- Report on the company's strategic plans for the next fiscal year
- Announcement of the new mission statement

Communication Probe

Group satisfaction with meetings has been researched extensively. A major finding is that the quality of group decisions increases as members exchange facts and reasons, and it decreases as members stick to their positions. A recent study applied the Myers-Briggs Personality Type Indicator to the group process, making use of an electronically supported meeting. The result: All participants contributed more original solutions in the group decision support system than in a face-to-face environment, and made more comments than in the traditional environment. As can be expected, extroverts participated extensively in any environment.

Innami, I. (1994, December). The quality of group decisions group verbal behavior, and intervention. *Organizational Behavior & Human Decision Processes, 60,* 409–430; Yellen, R., Winniford, M. A., & Sanford, C. (1995, January). Extraversion and introversion in electronically supported meetings. *Information and Management, 28,* 63–74.

- Retirement planning for those over age 50
- Cultural differences between British and Finnish organizations
- Documents needed for working relationships with Thailand's National Energy Policy Committee

At each of these meetings the members learned, asked questions, sought to understand. No problems were solved; no recommendations for change occurred. In each case there was an opening statement by the caller of the meeting and then a discussion. Participants came to the meeting with one pivotal purpose: to be informed, to understand the information.

Suggested Solution Meetings

Visualize this situation. A manager desires to receive input from her staff on an issue; she desires to review preliminary recommendations before solving the issue. The complete scenario may run something like this:

1. A supervisor senses a problem and desires a meeting to review options on addressing the problem. The goal: purely exploratory.
2. A memo or E-mail message is sent to all staffers asking for possible options on removing the problem.
3. Suggestions are tabulated and distributed to all respondents.
4. A meeting is called to discuss all possible options.

The manager and the review committee review all recommendations. Comments on the options occur at the meeting. Often no decision is made. The

meeting is exploratory and informational. Then a final recommendation is prepared either for higher approval or group consensus.

Problem-Solving Meetings

No group proceeds identically in trying to solve a problem; most often variations of problem, solution, benefit, action steps occur.

Problem, solution, benefit, action. These four steps trace the most common process in solving problems typical of the business world. Often (1) the major problem is presented early in the meeting, (2) participants suggest solutions, discussing and evaluating them, and (3) participants arrive at a decision for further action. All the steps involved in this process are discussed in the following section.

SOLVING PROBLEMS IN MEETINGS OR GROUPS

Because the problem-solving meeting requires the most careful planning and supervision by the leader and rational discussion by the participants, the remainder of this chapter focuses on the problem-solution meeting. You can, of course, use most of the suggestions for all types of meetings.

Authorization for a Committee

You may be asked to form a committee to solve a specific problem. That letter or memorandum of authorization—similar to the letter of authorization or charge noted in Chapter 11—may come from your superior, or even at the level of the secretary of the board. Regardless of the source, that note should include who, what, when, where, and why as good cornerstone questions to answer. Two examples of memos for authorizing a committee follow:

EXAMPLE 1: *Committee authorization.*

Charges to committees must be vividly clear; the precise problem to be solved must be unambiguous.

TO: ER Nursing staff of [*name of hospital*]
FROM: Nancy Glover, Chairperson
Economic and General Welfare
SUBJECT: Establishing a committee to investigate continuing education requirements for re-licensure

Our Chief of Staff requested that I convene a committee of staff nurses to review what steps the hospital should take to ensure nurse re-licensure in our various specialties. May I set the first meeting of this ad hoc group for Monday, November 14, 199-, in the ER Conference Room at 4:00 p.m.? Our task is to consider the following issues.

1. How to encourage individual nurses to achieve certification.
2. What is the possibility of on-site programs?

3. What is the approximate off-from-work time needed to meet continuing education requirements?
4. Who will collaborate with the Board of Nursing to ensure that all requirements for re-licensure have been met?

I look forward to working with you on these important issues.

EXAMPLE 2: *Committee authorization.*

TO: International Review Committee
FROM: Judy Ho, Manager, Marketing Development
Chairperson, International Review Committee
SUBJECT: Need for recommendations concerning expansion into Eastern Europe

As you know, our International Review Committee has been in place for the past two years. During that time we have made recommendations as to whether we should or should not establish advertising branches in Eastern Europe.

Last year, as you know, we had success in penetrating the markets of Bulgaria, Poland, and Austria. Profits from those countries increased by 10%. As a result of this favorable increase, our CEO has asked that we identify new market opportunities in other parts of Europe. I have been asked to convene all members of the International Review Committee to get their views on establishing a branch advertising office in Eastern Europe.

Would you therefore please meet in Room 3255B on March 9, 199-, at 11:00 a.m. through lunch. At that initial meeting I'd like to establish some criteria for possible expansion and assign responsibilities for gathering additional information.

Please E-mail me if you cannot be present on March 9.

Illustrated above is *who* requested the meeting, the specific *purpose* of the meeting, who is to be *present,* and the *time* and *location* for the meeting. A detailed analysis on how to work on problem-solving issues in a meeting will now be discussed.

Methods of Solving Problems in Meetings

Just how do you solve a problem in a group? Some of you may use intuition (rapid insight into a problem), rationalization (justification of solution over time), or scientific, reflective thinking (logical progression) to arrive at an answer. We

Communication Probe

The usual structure for a problem-solution meeting moves from initial awareness of an issue to its eventual resolution. But the process to follow in getting there varies from study to study, from person to person. In a major statement relating to what CEOs desire from problem-solving meetings, a researcher discovered that they desire answers to four questions.

- What is the plan?
- Why is the plan recommended?
- What are the goals?
- How much will it cost to implement the plan?

Answer these questions, says the author, and meeting participants will get a decision from the superior.

Lovett, Paul D. (1988, November–December). Meetings that work: Plans bosses can approve. *Harvard Business Review,* 38–44.

favor this last approach, the one used most often in business. Four steps are involved in problem-solving meetings: background analysis, solution discovery, solution evaluation, and choice of action.

Background Analysis

You sense a problem; you feel something is wrong; you hear contradictory stories; you know something is not going well. Welcome to frustration. You now can solve the problem alone, or you can assemble a group. We recommend three steps.

State problems in the affirmative. Negative wordings create apprehensions and could imply a preliminary judgment.

1. State the Problem or Question in an Affirmative Tone. Affirmatively stating the central issue is more effective than stating the issue in the negative.

Negative Wording	Preferred Affirmative Wording
How not to handle personnel dismissal?	What should be our procedure in dismissing personnel from their positions?
Which kinds of related businesses should we avoid?	In which related businesses should we consider expansion?
How can the negative consequences of foreign maids be decreased in Asia?	Which steps should be taken to improve treatment of foreign maids in Asia?

2. Define and Limit the Problem. Each of the above affirmative questions require some definitions. This information is usually included in the authorization memorandum or in the initial stages of a group meeting.

> By personnel we mean only those employees in job classifications 12-17. By related businesses we mean only core competencies, i.e., those that have at least a 50% relationship to our manufacturing process. By foreign maids we mean only those women from the Philippines who have been in Asia since 1990.

3. Collect Facts on the History of the Problem. Several questions, and others, relate to gathering initial data.

- How long has the problem existed?
- Describe the symptoms of the problem.
- What is the extent of the problem?
- Can we tentatively guess at the possible causes and effects of the problem?
- How do other companies handle the problem?

Your thoughtful examination of background material will have helped to prepare you for the role of discussant or leader of the meeting. And, if you have prepared written background material for the group, it will serve as backup information to prepare for the next stage: solution discovery.

Solution Discovery

Stating definite criteria for a solution places everyone on the same page.

1. Establish Criteria. Ask yourself: What are some of the frequently used criteria applied in problem-solution meetings? If you answered *fairness, workability, acceptability, positive consequences, favorable costs, number of people impacted,* and *return on investment,* you would be among the majority.

Apply some of the above criteria to the following issue: "In view of our high energy costs, what should be the policy of our company regarding alternative sources of energy?" Your group might set up criteria for assessing solutions to the issue as follows:

- The solution must be *acceptable* to the Environmental Protection Agency and the company.
- The solution should have little *impact* on the earnings per share.
- The supply of energy must be *adequate* (favorable) to cover energy needs into the next century.

Unless there is consistency in applying criteria, each participant will assess solutions using their own criteria. But note: Some criteria may change during a meeting and attach different weights to those criteria.

2. List Possible Solutions

Brainstorming is a positive way of getting all solution variations on the table.

During a meeting you as a new graduate may offer a solution that you feel has been logically thought out, based on time and research, and then firmly insist that the problem can be solved only in this way. It is a rude introduction to the business world when others suggest that your solution has little merit. Hence, the thoughtful chairperson and participants should consider several alternative solutions, perhaps ranging from the practical to the highly innovative.

A good technique at this point in the problem-solving process is simply to list alternatives. *Brainstorming*—the process of listing as many ideas as possible without judgment from any group member—is a favored method. Here persons, interested in solving a problem, offer ideas in a freewheeling atmosphere. No criticisms are allowed, even for off-the-wall solutions.

After everyone has had a chance to voice suggestions, the list is shortened, usually in light of stated criteria. Several good ideas may thus arise, and later serve as a list from which may come the final solution.

What list of solutions, for example, would you propose to the question "What should be the company policy on drugs in the workplace?" A shortened list of possible solutions from one company looked like this:

```
-During recruitment let candidates sign release
 forms for drug testing.

-Managers should orally and in writing communicate
 this message:  Employees will be fired if caught
 using drugs on the job.

-External drug rehabilitation programs will be used
 for those using drugs.

-"No Drugs in the Workplace" should be posted
 throughout the company.

-An employee assistance program (EAP) is the cen-
 tral goal in the war against drugs.

-Drug testing must be used in conjunction with
 other means of employee assistance.
```

Solution Evaluation

The preceding step was simply formulating a list of *tentative* suggestions on solving a problem. Now you must evaluate all suggestions in light of your stated criteria. In other words, you begin testing, locating pro and con reasons about a solution, answering whether a preferred solution truly will solve a problem or create new ones. As you work through the process in a discussion, you may end with selecting one of your tentative proposals, create an entirely new solution, or combine parts of several solutions. Your responsibility is this: You should arrive at a solution during this evaluation phase.

A series of questions can serve as hints to what you could be asking, for example, on this problem: "What health programs will best meet the needs of our workers?"

What will be the consequences of adopting one of the tentative solutions?

Will any of the solutions introduce new dangers or new problems?

Will all the causes of the problem be removed?

How does each of the solutions meet the criteria established for judgment of the solutions?

What are the advantages and disadvantages of each solution?

What effect will the solution have on the future?

Has the solution proved workable at another company or in a similar situation?

Is there a professional organization or a person held in high regard in support of one of the options?

In each of us are hidden reasons why we support or do not support a proposed solution. Rational persons try to apply a reasoned approach to problem-solving meetings. Consensus, or formal vote, then determines the solution to be accepted.

With the solution accepted, you still have one more thing to decide.

Choice of Action

A favorite question of senior management receiving a recommendation from a committee is this: What costs are involved? That question, along with a time schedule, is basic to any group recommendation.

The following example was part of an action marketing plan for placing ads into catalogs sent to consumers in their homes:

Financial data is a needed part of a final action plan.

Marketing Budget for First Year

Our marketing recommendation for the new product Diet Lite has been prepared for introduction on September 1, 199-

Annual marketing plan	$360,000.
Packaging	$25,000
Revised product sheets	35,000
Advertisement design	35,000
Co-op advertising plan	60,000
Media planning and placement	205,000

Personnel involved

Media Director
Graphic Arts Department
Administration

The document was signed by the vice president for Media Relations.

Thus, problem solving will be the major reason for business group meetings. And while some meetings will not precisely follow the three main divisions noted above, all do begin with some kind of opening analysis, spend considerable time reviewing options, and end with a recommendation for action. Getting to the

final stage is sometimes messy, but it is better to live in a democracy where we listen to the view of others than in a totalitarian society where decisions are often made with little input. How to be a good leader and a good participant using the above problem-solving structure is the topic to which we now turn.

LEADERSHIP RESPONSIBILITIES IN MEETINGS

"She's a bore"; "He only needs our committee to help him in delaying a decision"; "He leads a committee that should have been buried long ago." These are negative evaluations of chairpersons; many are worse. In brief, when you are appointed chairperson, you have major responsibilities; it is up to you to lead a group through the intricate process of resolving an issue. You should know about the three different kinds of leadership and its functions—before, during, and after the meeting—to be effective.

Kinds of Leadership

Look at Figure 17.1. We suggest that styles of leadership are on a continuum from authoritarian through democratic to leaderless; here we elaborate on this premise.

Authoritarian

Avoid the following characteristics typical of an authoritarian leader: shows contempt for some members, dominates the discussion, praises those who agree

Communication Probe

Research on leadership is worldwide. Indeed, throughout business history people have been interested in what makes an effective leader. Numerous comparative studies sought to determine the differences in leadership styles across cultures, with similarities in style dominant. Although some of this leadership research is somewhat macro, some of the ingredients for leadership have a carryover to leadership of smaller groups. Regardless of culture, differences in leadership style may result from beliefs, values, needs, risk taking, cognitive styles, and personal factors. Indeed, one's personal value style may influence managerial leadership—how one

- Perceives and defines a situation
- Defines and tackles problems and decisions
- Approaches interpersonal relations
- Interprets ethical behavior
- Responds to organizational pressures

Ronen, S. (1986). *Comparative and multinational management* (pp. 197–220). New York: Wiley. England, G. W., & Lee, R. The relationship between managerial values and managerial success in the United States, Japan, India, and Australia. *The Journal of Applied Psychology,* 59(4), 411–419; Westwood, R. I., & Chan, A. (1992). Headship and leadership. In R. I. Westwood (ed.), *Organizational behavior* (pp. 118–143). Hong Kong: Longmans.

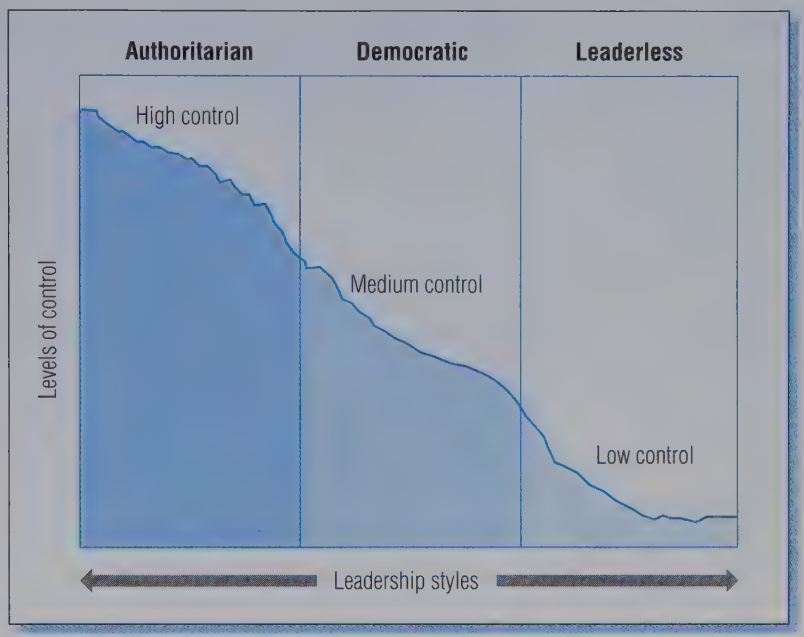

Figure 17.1 Styles of leadership.

with his or her position, speaks often and loudly, issues orders and commands, suggests that higher authority supports his or her position. Such leadership characteristics do not belong in our current system of group meetings.

Leaderless

This is almost as bad as the authoritarian style, but here the leader delegates all direction and decision-making steps to others. This person believes in shared leadership, allowing high-ability people to run the meeting. While sometimes successful, there is need for someone to offer some guidance, some positive feedback to the group that something has been achieved.

Democratic, Participative

You live in a democracy; you know that all points of view have the right to be heard. You also know that in such an environment the group has the final authority, that groups will vary in their ability to make decisions. Your major goal is to help the group make the best decision possible rather than force them into it; you facilitate productive group discussion, invite minority opinions, evaluate unsupported generalizations, and clarify vague statements. To achieve such a lofty profile is possible—with work.

Realize that business discussions take time, are frequently disorganized, are in need of good guidance before, during, and after a meeting.

Planning Steps Before the Meeting

It seems obvious that you as a group leader should know the precise purpose of your upcoming meeting. In your preparation, take the following steps:

Communication Probe

Leadership is difficult to define. One way of defining it is to say that a leader is a person who is capable, through communication, of assisting a group in achieving specific goals. How? A series of studies suggests that some persons desire to be leaders: They seek that position. Likewise, a person who actively uses communication skills, oral and nonverbal, in a meeting is likely to emerge as a leader. Why? Others have the opportunity of hearing and viewing this person's views on issues and can make judgments about them. Although quantity of contributions is important, so is the quality of those contributions as measured by their relevancy, helpfulness, and reinforcement to group members. Communication, early and of high quality, contributes to desirable leadership.

Shaw, M. E., & Gourd, D. S. (1990). Group dynamics and communication. In G. L. Dahnke & G. W. Clatterbuck (eds.), *Human Communication: Theory and research* (pp. 123–155). Belmont CA: Wadsworth; Stogdill, R. M. *Handbook of leadership*. New York: Free Press; and many others.

1. Review the Problem and Determine the Precise Purpose

As with formulating an informative or persuasive speech, take some time to write out what you think is the central purpose of the meeting. Such a statement works well if put in infinitive form.

Of all people, the chairperson must know precisely the purpose of a meeting.

- To determine what percentage of our profits should be contributed to charities during the year.
- To decide whether the regional office—now located in London—should be returned to Detroit.
- To ask: What steps should we take in reprimanding the employee who falsified accounting records over the past year?

In brief, by phrasing the question in infinitive form, you already are answering this question: Do we really need a meeting or can a decision be made via telephone, memos, letters, video- or teleconferencing, or E-mail? It is the chairperson's call as to the medium selected.

2. Decide Who Should Participate

In regularly scheduled meetings the cast will be similar; who will be there is predetermined. Specialists might also be called in for their expertise or a facilitator to assist in the deliberations. But when a special ad hoc (temporary committee), is formed, it is desirable to have persons representative of the group as a whole. Usual criteria include gender, age, diversity of view, ethnic groups, and others.

Ideally, a smaller group (3 to 5 members) is more harmonious than a larger group. Often a small group may draft some preliminary information and lay out some options before going to a larger group. In the following Communication Probe some further research observations were observed.

Communication Probe

It appears quite obvious that in smaller groups more speaking occurs because of the diversity of talents, interest in the issue, and ease of interrelationships. Additionally, as the group increases in size, coordination difficulties increase, irrelevant inputs occur, and individuals are inhibited to speak. Some other negatives occur as group size increases: Some members may dominate the discussion, responsibilities are shifted to key members, and greater stress is placed on the leader. Conversely, in smaller groups research suggests that its members are better satisfied and record more positive evaluations of their group. Finally, it is clear that consensus is far more difficult to achieve in larger groups.

Bales, R. F., Strodtbeck, F. L., Mills, T. M., & Rosenborough, M. E. (1951). Channels of communication in small groups. *American Sociological Review, 16I,* 461–468; Poole, M. S., McPhee, R. D., & Seibold, D. R. (1982). A comparison of normative and interactional explanations of group decision-making: Social decision schemas versus valence distributions. *Speech Monographs, 49,* 1–19; Hemphill, J. K. (1950). Relations between the size of the group and the behavior of "superior" leaders. *Journal of Social Psychology, 32,* 11–22; and many others.

3. Arrange for Meeting Date, Time, Place

- Be exact as to time and date. E-mailing a reminder to participants works well.
- Avoid Friday afternoon. Generally Tuesday through Thursday are desirable.
- Be precise as to location. A room change from a consistent location demands both oral and E-mail follow-up.

4. Create an Agenda

It is desirable for the chairperson to send out the agenda in advance of a meeting.

Three core questions are the basis for meetings: Fact (is something true or not); value (whether something is desirable or undesirable); and policy (should something be done or not be done).

You, as chair, have the responsibility to set the agenda. An agenda is the roadmap of what will be covered in the meeting. That information can be sent in advance (desirable) or distributed at the meeting. Busy managers and executives tend to follow the latter.

We have repeatedly emphasized the importance of the *wording* of the problem question. Be clear when putting that information in the agenda; know that your agenda can word that problem as a question of fact, value, and policy.[3]

Fact questions are concerned with what is true. You try to answer the question, what are the facts of the matter? For example,

- Who is the leading builder of luxury boats in the world? Is that company a competitor with our size boats?
- What are the constraints on TV advertising in Germany?
- China is developing rules for joint ventures in their country; which Hong Kong legal firm has the largest client list on international joint ventures?

Value questions depend on words implying appraisal and judgment of the goodness or badness, rightness or wrongness, acceptability or unaccceptability, and merits or demerits of a person, place, or thing.

- What assurance do you have that the government will be *fair* to minority firms from the West?
- Is there a *value* to our sending three people to the executive program on human resource development?
- Is *it worthwhile* for our company to continue its program of sales awards to persons whose gross sales are above $75,000 a month?

Policy or *procedure* questions will occupy most of your meetings: What should be done? What action should we take? Who should carry out the decision?

- Which actions should we take to cover future maintenance of our physical plant?
- We build numerous products for medical care; to what extent should we ourselves make the component parts or have them built by others?
- To what extent should we do three things: Invest time and money in creating new markets in Asia or Europe; align ourselves with a firm already in place in those parts of the world; or piggyback with another firm interested in our overall objectives?

It makes little difference which of the three question formats you choose. What does make a difference is clarity in wording. The wording should be short, clear, unbiased, as in the following sample agenda and later announcements for the meeting.

Agenda for Marketing Staff Meeting
November 15, 199-

1. Review of progress on actions approved at meeting of October 6, 199-. [*Informative*]

2. Problems with our ad clients since last meeting. [*Informative*]

3. Action item: What theme should we pursue in our new TV ad campaign for Client X? [*Policy question*]

4. Action item: Who should be asked to coordinate the written and oral proposal in response to the request that we bid for the agency of record for potential Client Y? [*Policy question*]

5. Other issues to come before the group.

5. Distribute the Announcement for the Meeting

If you have decided on the main questions for discussion, laid out the agenda for the meeting, and decided on who, what, when, and where, you're ready to send out the announcement for the meeting. Some announcements are simple and brief; others may be detailed. In fact, most of the items in the agenda can serve as a major portion of the call to the meeting.

October 7, 199-

	TO: Warehouse salespeople
	FROM: Chris
Title of topic	SUBJECT: Potential computer market for home use
Importance	Electronic Topics suggests in its October issue that a potential market exists for increased sales of computers in the home.
Topic question	Will each of you please give thought to this question: How can we increase sales
Responsibilities	of our personal computer hardware and software in our immediate area? This will be the first meeting on the issue; we'll assign more responsibilities at the meeting.
Date, time, place	We'll meet two weeks from now, Tuesday, October 21, 199-, in my office, at 9:00 a.m.

In addition to the five ingredients listed above and "importance" of the topic, you may also—when desirable—include suggested reference materials, as sent with this announcement:

May 22, 199-

	TO: Product Planning Committee
	FROM: RNS, President
Date, time, place	SUBJECT: Monthly meeting, Wednesday, June 6, 10:00 a.m., Rm. 816
Responsibility	Two questions are to be discussed in our monthly meeting:
Specific topic questions	1. What other uses can you suggest for our disposable tubing? 2. What policy should we follow about producing intravenous suckers that use internal wiring for support?
Individual responsibilities	Beyond these two questions we will have a review of progress on our redesigned mod-

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ules-by Mike S. and Tom G.-and the usual
monthly review of our ongoing new-product
items, by all of you.
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Responsibilities of group

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My staff has prepared the background and
history of the two questions above.  I
ask you to come prepared to recommend op-
tions.  Suggested reference material is
enclosed with this announcement for the
meeting.
```

6. Check on Physical Arrangements

- Select the seating pattern.
- Determine what kind of materials are needed in the room.
- Have available the usual electronic visual aids.

Leadership procedures before the meeting are summarized in Checklist 17.2.

Procedures During the Meeting

Here's a hint. Learn from other group leaders; note those actions and procedures that you feel make them effective group leaders. On the other hand, avoid those leadership characteristics that you feel produce a negative effect.

1. Begin with an Opening Statement

A neutral, free-from-bias, opening statement from the chairperson can get the sessions off on a positive note.

Be sure to prepare your introductory remarks before the meetings. Checklist 17.3 has guidelines for beginning the problem-solving meeting effectively.

2. Stimulate Discussion

Involving all members in a discussion is central to a leader's responsibilities.

Remember, you as the leader primarily encourage all to participate, which means getting all views on the table. For instance, to assist discussion of a topic, you might write on a board or chart the criteria the solution should meet. List on

Checklist 17.2 Leadership Procedures Before the Meeting

1. Understand the central problem for discussion; know your precise purpose in calling the meeting.
2. Decide who should participate.
3. Be precise as to date, time, and place for the meeting.
4. Prepare an agenda in advance of the meeting.
5. Distribute an announcement for the meeting.
6. Check on physical arrangements.

Checklist 17.3 How to Begin a Problem-Solving Meeting

1. State the problem.
   "We're here today for an analysis of this question: 'Which divisions are not meeting the financial goals set last January?' "
2. Indicate importance of problem.
   "At no time in the history of this company have we faced more serious problems. Without exaggeration, I suggest that we must come up with a firm answer to the question I put on the agenda: 'What should be our position on expanding our overseas data processing operations?' "
3. Suggest issues.
   "It appears that three issues relate to our question of overseas expansion: (1) What is the political base of those countries in which we wish to expand, (2) what is the economic base, and (3) under what conditions should we consider moving more production to foreign countries?
4. Use a quotation.
   "*Jobber News*'s editorial has this comment: 'Revising a ruling last year by an administrative judge, the Federal Trade Commission has ordered Tenselo, Inc., to sell off its Martoe Equipment Co. unit.' That opening comment is a good springboard to our meeting today: Which units in our organization are possible targets for court action?"
5. State cause for discussion.
   "The Citizens' Lobby in the House is prepared to offer two bills on the issue of regulating content and sale of dread-disease insurance policies. They were kind to send us copies of those two possible options, and wish our suggestions for change. Before we begin our discussion, I suggest we examine both versions, then move into our discussion."

another surface the possible solutions. Then discuss. Ask questions to keep the discussion moving, and keep participants on the main path. Get conferees to analyze their own thinking and that of others.

Above all keep an atmosphere of goodwill and cooperation. If the situation becomes tense or hostile, keep calm. Ask for restatements, request courtesy in place of acrimony. Even taking a recess diffuses tensions.

3. Understand the Roles of the Participants

There are many classifications, many names given to participants in meetings. Benne and Sheats' classification[4] of the National Training Laboratory in Group Development is our favorite:

Communication Probe

Your job within the business world often determines your group memberships. Such a philosophy weakens substantially in a volunteer group where you remain by choice. But in both kinds of groups there is need for cohesiveness; certain forces act upon you to keep you a member. It follows, therefore, that cohesive groups will be more successful, will possess similar attitudes, exhibit a willingness to work together, will actually influence others within a group. A danger, of course, is that such cohesiveness can lead to *groupthink* (too much thinking alike, loss of discrimination) and to intolerance of opinions different from the norm. Regardless, cohesiveness as a characteristic of groups is desirable.

Terborg, J. R., Castore, C., & DeNinno, J. A. (1976). A longitudinal field investigation of the impact of group composition on group performance and cohesion. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 34,* 782–790; Blanchard, F. A., Weigel, R. H. & Cook, S. W. (1975). The effect of relative competence of group members upon interpersonal attraction in cooperating interracial groups. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 32,* 519–530; Shaw, M. E., & Shaw, L. M. (1962). Some effects of sociometric grouping upon learning in a second grade classroom. *Journal of Social Psychology, 57,* 453–458.

Group Task Roles. Anyone may play these roles, even the chairperson.

- Initiator-contributor
- Information seeking
- Opinion seeker
- Information giver
- Opinion giver
- Elaborator
- Coordinator
- Orienter
- Evaluator-critic
- Energizer
- Procedural technician
- Recorder

Group Building and Maintenance Roles. Keeping the goals of the group in mind through group-centered attitudes characterizes these roles.

- Encourager
- Harmonizer
- Standard setter
- Gatekeeper (opens channels of communication)
- Group observer
- Compromiser
- Follower

"Individual" Roles. The emphasis here is self-oriented roles, often at odds with group building and maintenance roles.

- Aggressor
- Blocker
- Playboy
- Help seeker
- Recognition seeker
- Self-confessor
- Dominator
- Special interest pleader

Problem participants demand special attention. Consider our suggestions for five common problem participants.

The Reticent, Nonparticipating Member. First ask this person a question he can answer by a simple "yes" or "no." Then whenever possible, ask this member to give the conferees some information that he is sure to know because of job, training, or experience. Thank and praise the person as much as you can; he may then be more likely to enter the discussion confidently.

The "Know-It-All." This person may be asked to justify every statement she makes. Whenever possible, ask other conferees for their opinions of these statements. Sometimes, if necessary and you feel the majority are annoyed by this person's arrogance, you may tactfully quiet the person by asking for a show of hands from the group, which strongly outvotes the know-it-all's suggestions.

If the negative member still insists on knowing all the answers, a private, outside-the-meeting session can bring the group's concern to the person. This one-on-one meeting in a nonthreatening atmosphere may produce more positive results.

The Long-Winded Speaker. Thank this excessive talker when he is at the end of a sentence, and then recognize someone else. Or you might move the discussion to another highly important point, perhaps with a statement like "Well, we have two more points to consider before we wind up this meeting, so let's move along to the next topic."

The Erroneous Member. If the other members—out of respect—are reluctant to correct this person, an especially tactful comment by you, the leader, may be required. As with any bad-news message, avoid direct criticism, sarcasm, or ridicule. Shield the person's pride. "When praising people, single them out; when criticizing them, put them in a group." Perhaps analyze a similar case, without referring to the speaker personally.

The Conferee Who Shows Personal Animosity. Although rare, sometimes an angry member shouts hateful, tactless comments toward another member or members. You can show an attitude of calm understanding and turn her off by directing a question to another conferee.

4. Interpret Data for Solution Evaluation

After all options are before the group, it's time to evaluate. Encourage consideration of advantages and disadvantages. As a leader—at this stage—avoid imposing your opinions on the group. Or, if you wish to participate, ask another member to chair the meeting.

Chairpersons should summarize and ensure that all members know their responsibilities as a result of the meeting.

5. State the Major Conclusions and Plan of Action

In earlier chapters we suggested that written analytical reports, for example, end with a clear call to action, a clear indication of what you wish readers to accept. It is no less in concluding a meeting.

Checklist 17.4 How to Be a Good Leader During and After the Meeting

1. Prepare your opening statement in advance.
2. Involve all members in the discussion, if possible.
3. Encourage participant comments to be positive: from sincerely trying to solve a problem to encouraging others into more helpful roles.
4. Encourage members to evaluate all options before making a decision.
5. Be precise in stating the conclusions and final action plan.
6. Write out minutes of the meeting; send members that record along with individual responsibilities agreed to in the meeting.

- Summarize (list major conclusions of the discussion).
- State individuals responsible for specific actions.
- Indicate by which time a task is to be completed.
- Extend thanks to the members for attending and completing the task.

Follow-Up After the Meeting

Secretaries take minutes; chairpersons check for accuracy.

A leader has two final responsibilities: distributing the minutes of the meeting and seeing that responsible committees, departments, or individuals are appointed to complete decided upon actions. Good minutes will include who and when a task is to be completed. Briefly, minutes should include the following:

- Name of the organization, department, or group
- Date, time, place of meeting
- Names of members present, including who chaired the meeting
- Signature of the secretary who recorded the minutes

It is also the responsibility of the secretary (or chairperson) to keep a permanent file—a paper trail—of all material viewed or distributed at the meeting.

PARTICIPANT RESPONSIBILITIES IN MEETINGS

Not all of you can be leaders; the law of averages works against you. Accordingly, you most often will be a participant. You too have responsibilities.

Preparation for Meetings

Personal preparation adds to meeting effectiveness. Do your homework, collect information, check your data, confirm your conclusions. In other words, the phrase "I don't know" in response to a manager's question is harmful to your career—to put it mildly. Be overprepared.

Effective Participant Roles in Meetings

Professors William M. Sattler, now deceased, and N. Edd Miller[5] wrote a classic text on discussion and meeting procedure; they recommend nine roles for you to play to succeed as a good participant during a meeting.

1. Organizer

Some persons do not like clutter—even in meetings. Some are natural organizers. They dislike disorganization. Meetings, as you know, often move without direction, from either the inability of the leader to give direction or because members wander off the path. When you are an organizer, you give procedural suggestions, you steer the group back to main, central issues.

> "I feel we're wandering from the topic. I suggest we return to the main subject, which in my estimation is, what criteria should we consider for any foreign expansion?"
>
> "Let me pause a moment and reflect on what I think are our central concerns: What will be the reaction of our shareholders and what will be the potential reaction of the market?"
>
> "Mr. Chairman, I suggest we consider moving to item two on our agenda; that issue requires a decision from us by next month."

2. Clarifier

Chairpersons may misinterpret questions and issues; participants can act as clarifiers when issues become unclear.

A clarifier points out misunderstandings, attempts to make clear unclear expressions or foggy ideas.

> "It's useful that we begin with a consistent definition of the term *strategic*; let's see if we can set a common understanding of the timeframe."
>
> Let me add this comment: Some of you are using exchange rate figures for the German Mark from two months ago, some from last week, others from today. As you know, even a decimal point shift will affect our budget. I suggest we use today's figure for consistent analysis."

3. Questioner

Many questions need clarification. You wish to fill in your knowledge gap for yourself and others. Be careful: Know the difference between a vital or an inconsequential question. But when in doubt ask your question; others may have had the same question but were afraid to voice their concern.

4. Factual Contributor

Valuable is the participant who brings valid, credible data to a meeting.

Any time you add substantive (factual, accepted opinions) information to a discussion, you are making a worthwhile contribution. Watch your tone. Presenting factual information in an arrogant or overbearing manner will create negative reactions. Be positive.

"You make an interesting point; I like it. May I add some data from a study appearing in the fall issue of the *Journal of Business Communication*?"

"If you read the *Wall Street Journal* this morning, their information is slightly different. Here's what the article said . . ."

"We seem to be guessing on what our chairman wished us to do. Let me take a minute and read from his letter to this committee . . ."

5. Energizer

Groups can also feel "down": Energizers pursue ways of keeping persons interested and motivated.

Football coaches often typify this role; so do group members desiring to keep the discussion moving, stimulating members to reach their goal. Gloom is a part of meetings; so is frustration. An energizer suggests there is light at the end of the tunnel.

"Hang in there, we're almost there. If we can make it another half hour, I'm sure we'll reach some kind of concensus."

"Madam chairperson, perhaps a recess is in order. That would give us a little time to reflect and get a cup of coffee. Then let's come back and finish this task before the end of the hour."

6. Idea Creator

So needed is this kind of contributor. The creator risks ideas that may be new, different, even unusual. If you are an idea creator, you are willing to test an idea in the open forum of the meeting.

"Let me try this idea . . ."

"Wait a second, there may be third option . . ."

"Before coming here I made several phone calls for others' ideas. They mentioned three possibilities; here they are . . ."

"*The Nation,* one of Thailand's newspapers, recently had an in-depth analysis of hotel expansions in Bangkok. May I summarize three issues which could help us get started?"

And so on. Creativity in offering options, different points of view is needed in group meetings. If you play such a role, you will become one of the more valuable members of any group.

7. Critical Tester

Tact is required when testing opinions of others. Focus on the content rather than on who is making the statement.

Every meeting needs a person willing to challenge, tactfully, the validity and reasonableness of contributions. Note that the stress is on what is said rather than on who is saying it. Focus on the idea, the content, the evidence, the reasoning, leaving out all references to the person. All persons have the right to do so whenever a misleading or inaccurate statement is made. The following are questions to keep in mind:

- Were a sufficient number of facts given on which to build a conclusion?
- Is the information consistent, or do some contradictions get in the way of accepting the information?
- Are the facts—and the language—clear?
- Are the sources of information and the statistics reliable?
- Is the information recent; can one see the source and verify the evidence given?
- Was the cause sufficiently powerful to produce the alleged effect?
- Have some data been omitted in leading to the conclusion?

You should not hesitate to challenge an unsupported conclusion, an out-of-date source, a biased piece of information, an incomplete recital of facts, an unclear cause producing even more unclear effects, an unclear referent or source—and other illogical matters that potentially can negatively influence the discussion. Not to do so is to omit good participant responsibility when reading a report or participating in a discussion.

8. Conciliator

Deadlocks are not uncommon in meetings. Both sides refuse to budge; violent disagreements do occur. What often happens is that persons become so polarized that not losing face is as important as not losing the argument. You as a conciliator attempt to find a middle ground, seek to find a compromise.

"Let me try this suggestion: Instead of offering a two-year appointment, could we consider a one-year appointment with a review after the first six months? If our review is favorable, we could then move toward a three-year appointment."

"Well, we're at an impasse as to what the final recommendation should be. I suggest four people—two from both sides—hammer out a draft and then come to the whole body for our review."

"O.K., we're still far apart; it seems we're not going to reach agreement this evening. We can either call in an outside facilitator, have an outsider chair the meeting, or we continue in deadlock. I recommend we get a neutral facilitator to help us to closure on the issue."

9. Helper of Others

A chairperson should invite full participation. If the chairperson ignores anyone, participants can invite the silent member to participate.

A final role you can play is to invite other participants to join in. You do not wish to embarrass others, but try to help those who may feel inadequate or who are simply hesitant to speak up in the forum. Tact, sensitivity, and cooperativeness with the chairperson characterize this role.

"Most of us have had a chance to participate. I'd like to hear what Jane has to say on the topic." (*invitation to participate*)

"Mr. Chairman, there appears to be a slight misunderstanding. I think what Kellie was saying is this . . ." (*clarification and further support*)

"Superior thought, Donna. Let me make a comment and then invite others to make observations." (*praise of member*)

Checklist 17.5 How to Be a Good Participant During a Meeting

1. Bring the group back to the central topic if the group wanders away.
2. Clarify, ask a question, if the issue is unclear.
3. Give substantive—accepted facts and opinions—statements to add credible information to the discussion. Risk giving ideas that could transform (bring about a different perspective) the group.
4. Be a cheerleader, energize the group, if it seems to lapse into negativism.
5. Test ideas; tactfully suggest correct information.
6. Search for a middle ground; suggest possible compromises.
7. Help others; invite participation; ask for contributions from those more silent.

"We all were a little harsh on your first point. Could you take a little time and explain your second concern." (*support of member*)

No one expects you to use all of the preceding nine roles. But be aware of them. Adopt an appropriate role whenever you feel it is necessary. Using one or two of them during a meeting will add to the quality of the meeting and let you make a significant contribution to the discussion.

SUMMARY

Of all the chapters in this book, this chapter brought together the many elements of good business writing and oral communication. Many meetings and discussions within those meetings depend heavily upon written documents, most often to arrive at a solution to a problem.

Thus, business groups are formed, or are already in place, primarily to resolve problems. These are formal groups, moving from an initial awareness of a problem to its eventual resolution. Some call these steps problem, solution, benefits, action. Regardless of titles of the steps, a problem-solving meeting should result in action.

Both the chairperson of a problem-solving meeting and its participants require skills. For the leader, this means primarily being a democratic leader, guiding, encouraging, compromising. The participant must focus on two things: contributing content of value via positive participant roles and suggesting procedural steps to improve both the harmony of the group and the flow of the discussion. In short, a good meeting requires cooperation between the leader and its participants.

Keep in mind the two other purposes for meetings: informational (giving of information to individuals) and suggested solution meetings. This latter form is in the form of a hearing, a bringing together of various preliminary views prior to the final recommendation.

Communication Probe

Electronic brainstorming is a term coming into vogue in connection with electronic discussions. One researcher argues that although groups meet to generate ideas, share information, and initiate action, in face-to-face meetings, members of the group may worry about the way others will perceive their ideas. Thus, some members hold back ideas; they can be apprehensive, literally uncomfortable with proposing an idea. In contrast, electronic brainstorming allows persons to anonymously type in their ideas, which, in turn, are passed on to other participants electronically and synchronously. Thus more ideas are displayed before the entire group, without the proposer being known.

Kay, G. (1994/1994, Winter). Effective meetings through electronic brainstorming. *Management Quarterly, 35,* 15–26.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Differences Between Western and Asian Leadership Styles.*** Much has been written on the differences between western (primarily U.S.) leadership and Asian leadership styles. Knowing what some of those differences are will help us understand what occurs during meetings where westerners and Asians interact. Look up the following terms in some leadership texts; give a brief definition of each and their possible implications in group meetings:

   - Headship
   - Individualism
   - Independence
   - Paternalism
   - Transformational

   Suggested sources for some of the above terms include:

   Westwood, R. I. and Chan. A. (1992). Headship and leadership. In R. I. Westwood (ed.), *Organizational behaviour* (pp. 118–143). Hong Kong: Longmans Group; Dahnke, G. L. and Clatterbuck, G. W. (eds.) (1990). *Human Communication: Theory and Research.* Belmont, CA: Wadsworth; Hildebrandt, H. W. (1988). International/intercultural communication: A comparative study of Asian and U.S. managers. *World Communciation, 17,* 49–68.

2. ***Interview with Second-Language Student.*** One of your classmates may be from a foreign country and speaks English as a second language. Presumably this student has participated in or is aware of meeting procedures in his or her native land. Differences do exist. Search out some of those differences in an interview with a foreign student or friend from a foreign country. Then prepare a written and oral report to the class on your find-

ings. You may wish to use some of the following questions to supplement your own:

- Describe how the leader begins the meeting.
- To what extent do the members participate in the discussion?
- Are the members critical of ideas presented? What is their approach to testing evidence?
- How does the meeting end: Does the leader announce the decision, or does it evolve naturally from the discussion?

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Report on a Meeting, Chairperson, and Participants.*** Attend a meeting on your campus or in your community; report back on the following questions:
   - **a.** Was the purpose of the meeting clear?
   - **b.** What were some of the chairperson's actions?
     - How was the meeting begun?
     - Was the chairperson democratic, or were other kinds of leadership exhibited?
     - What was done to move the group along toward a decision?
     - How was the decision regarding a problem announced?
   - **c.** What roles did the participants play?
     - Did some members exhibit negative characteristics? If so, what were those characteristics?
     - What kinds of support did members bring to the discussion? How did they support their ideas?
     - Describe the most useful member in the group; what made that person effective?

4. ***Evaluations of Questions for Problem-Solving Discussion.*** The following questions were posed by other students as they considered topics for a discussion. Their goal was to have a problem-solving discussion before the class. Evaluate these questions: Which are satisfactory and which are not?
   - **a.** New products for next year?
   - **b.** What is the problem with our new administration and education building?
   - **c.** Is our economy getting better or worse?
   - **d.** What should the government's policy be on allowing banks to sell securities?
   - **e.** Oral communication in business—what makes it effective?
   - **f.** What steps can business take to improve business relations with Third World countries?
   - **g.** Should B.B.A. students go on in school and obtain their M.B.A. degree?
   - **h.** Which of the Big Eight accounting firms is the most respected in our state?

5. ***Evaluation of Participants' Contributions During a Public Meeting.*** Attend a public meeting of a local school board, a city council, or a student organization. Use the following evaluation form to determine the number and kinds of contributions the participants made. Bring the form to class for a report on the roles participants played in the meeting.

PARTICIPATION FORM

Discussion group: _____

Date: _____

Check in the appropriate category the type of contribution made by each of the participants. (See the discussion of participant roles in this chapter.)

Type of contribution	*Participant*						
	#1	*#2*	*#3*	*#4*	*#5*	*#6*	*#7*
Organizer							
Clarifier							
Questioner							
Factual contributor							
Energizer							
Idea creator							
Critical tester							
Conciliator							
Helper of others							

Which type of contribution was made most often? Why? _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

6. ***Oral-Written Group Work Using Scientific, Reflective Method.*** The following information summarizes the basic requirements of this oral written assignment involving extensive group work on using the scientific, reflective method.
   a. Each member of the class will be assigned to a group.
   b. Each group will select its own chairperson, set its own meetings outside

of class, meet the deadlines imposed, select its own problem for the assignment.

c. Each group will present to the class and instructor the following information:

(1) On the day before the background-analysis presentation, distribute to the class—or announce—the topic to be discussed in the following class period.

(2) On the day of the informative, background-analysis presentation about the group problem:

(a) The group distributes the agenda for the meeting.

(b) The chairperson introduces group members, sets out the direction for the meeting.

(c) Each member in the group orally presents one part of the background, location, recognition, description of the problem chosen by the group.

- Definitions needed to understand discussion
- History of problem
- Effects of problem
- Causes of problem
- Importance of problem
- Evolution of problem (early period; late period)
- Comparison of problem

(d) The chairperson concludes the presentation and allows questions and discussion with members of the class.

(e) A secretary can take minutes on the presentations of group members.

(f) The meeting is adjourned.

(3) On the day of the persuasive solution presentations about the group problem:

(a) The minutes of the preceding meeting may be presented to the class for approval.

(b) The chairperson of the group summarizes the preceding background presentation of the group.

(c) Each member in the group orally offers his or her own solution to the group problem.

- Criteria for evaluating alternatives to solving the problem
- Overview or range or listing of solutions available to solve the problem
- Solution A
- Solution B
- Solution C
- Solution A/B
- Solution C/D

(d) The chairperson concludes the presentation by summarizing the alternative solutions presented and allows questions and discussion with group members.

(e) A secretary may record the presentations of the group members.

(f) The class or group may or may not decide on a single solution.

7. ***Review the Decision Process on a Published Issue:*** Review in a local newspaper, a campus paper, or a national business journal an issue that ultimately was solved, by vote of a governing body. Such an issue may have consumed several months of deliberations and may be a business issue, a school issue, or a governmental issue. Your task is to review the process of arriving at the final decision, through doing the following:

   a. State the problem as you perceive it as a question of fact, value, or policy.
   b. List the various options that were considered.
   c. State whether criteria were announced before or during any discussion.
   d. Summarize, briefly, the final solution or recommendation voted on or approved by the approval body.

   Having presented that outline, offer an analysis as to where you think the major problems lie in arriving at the final decision.

8. ***Review of Governmental Discussions.*** Newspaper and TV reporters are not participants in actual governmental discussions. Yet, the average reader or viewer must often depend on these sources for information about the results of an issue. Such an issue was the budget discussion at the end of 1995 and the beginning of 1996: Both the President and Congress held innumerable discussions.

   Although we do not know what actually occurred during these budget discussions, there are adequate records of those protracted discussions. Bring in a written report that does the following:

   - Gives examples of various newspaper headings that summarized the proceedings
   - Summarizes some of the arguments issued on both sides of the budget issue
   - Reviews several newspaper editorials, and the inferences those editorials drew from the budget battle

   Then draw some inferences from your collected data, answering questions similar to the following: What outside influences (political) enter into decisions made by government officials? What suggestions do you have to speed up decision making within the government on strong contentious issues? Is the communication received from the various newspaper accounts unbiased? And other questions of your choice.

9. ***Assessing a Student Group Meeting.*** Inevitably you will be a participant in a student group assignment. Often those meetings are a disaster; at other times they are quite successful. Therefore, monitoring and evaluating those student meetings can lead to improvements in the future. At the end of a meeting, apply the following KSS evaluation method to a meeting. [Tripman, J. (1996). *Making Meetings Work.* Thousand Oaks: Sage Publications.]

On a sheet of paper write three questions and then report the results to the class:

- What during this meeting went well and should be KEPT?
- What during this meeting did not go well and should be STOPPED?
- What did not happen during this meeting and should be STARTED?

A variation on this assignment is to have several groups complete it and then have each group report their answers. The results can point up interesting similarities and differences.

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PART SEVEN

The Job Application Process

Chapter 18 The Job Application Process—The Written Job Presentation

Chapter 19 The Job Application Process—Interviews and Follow-Up

Chapter 18

The Job Application Process—The Written Job Presentation

I. Self-Assessment
- A. Know Your Skills
- B. Know Your Accomplishments
- C. Know Your Interests
- D. Know Your Personal Values

II. Market Assessment
- A. Written Sources of Career and Job Information
- B. Helpful Persons Regarding Employers and Jobs

III. Resume (Vita, Qualifications Brief)
- A. Opening Section
- B. Education
- C. Work Experience
- D. Achievements, Awards, Service Activities
- E. Personal Data (Optional)
- F. References
- G. Sample Resumes

IV. Cover Letter to Resume
- A. Opening—For Favorable Attention
- B. Middle Paragraphs—For Data, Details
- C. Last Paragraph—For Easy Action
- D. Sample Letters of Application

V. Summary

VI. Exercises and Problems

Throughout this brochure we've presented an overview of who we are, where we came from, how we approach our business, and most importantly, what we promise . . . to you!

This brochure introduces you to career opportunities available at [*company*]. We've organized the information into answers to big questions—the kind you probably have as you face critical decisions about your career and future.

Companies market themselves to potential employees via handsome brochures that summarize their missions, products, and services.

These representative statements from company recruiting brochures lead to several conclusions: Companies are widening their search for promising job applicants, companies are marketing themselves, companies are aware of the significant decisions you make when searching for a job.

The next task is yours: How should you decide whether you are interested and qualified to approach a particular company for a job? Times have changed. Japan, for instance, had lifelong job security; that is changing. So, too, certain positions in the United States seemed to be guaranteed for life; that is also changing. Reengineering of corporations, restructuring of entire companies, and takeovers all guarantee that few positions will be for life. You, as a new graduate or currently employed worker, can expect to hold several jobs over your lifetime.

This chapter—and the following—take you through the steps necessary to prepare you for doing a good self- and company assessment in landing a job. Here we focus on self- and market assessment and recommend vital inclusions in a well-formed resume and cover letter.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

Who are you? This is not a simple question. A cursory answer is that you already know who you are. But beyond your surface awareness lie deeper qualities, which when evaluated, prepare you for landing a job: your skills, achievements, interests, and even personal values. Being aware of these qualities allows you to better sell your product—yourself!

Communication Probe

Historically, three approaches to career assessment have been discussed in books and articles: individual career assessment, group session assessment, and books and tapes for self-assessment. Recently, an additional approach was suggested: a three-step long-distance support model. This approach involves the following steps: A professional counselor meets with client employees; several questionnaires are completed at home or during the workshop; the counselor scores and interprets the questionnaires; a personal report for each of the employees is prepared. The result was that employees felt better about themselves, felt they knew themselves better, and felt renewed.

Godkewitsch, M. (1989–1990). Exploring the long-distance career support model. *Optimum, 20,* 65–69.

Know Your Skills

Verbs suggest action; using them to describe your skills gives the impression that you are a dynamic person.

Verbs are core in relating to your reader what you have accomplished and where your skills lie. But before choosing these action verbs, you have to assess your interest in and support for ideas that follow those verbs. For example, you might write a list of skills under each of the following verbs:

- Enjoy *analyzing* financial data
- *Administered* a program of 10 students working with minority businesses
- Prepared *consulting* proposals in response to tender offers
- Involved in student *planning* for the admissions office
- Helped prepare the *evaluating* document for core courses in our school
- *Coordinated* off-campus internships
- Discovered that I like to *negotiate,* preparing the written document and the oral defense as based on that document
- Noted that I worked well in *mediating* differences between student group members
- *Created* three new products for our small company from initial idea to product manufacture and assembly
- Delighted to *speak* before groups—both in school and to outside groups

Of course, these 10 statements are illustrative. Yet they show that *beginning* with a verb—and including more later—forces you to focus on a specific skill following that verb. Take time in compiling such a personal list.

Know Your Accomplishments

Record accomplishments. What may be trivial to you may be important to someone else.

No matter how young—or old—you are, you have already accomplished something. Again, stating those accomplishments following a verb is a good way to profile your accomplishments; show the *result* of your specific achievement, as for instance in these categories:

Communication Probe

Knowing the skills sought in students was the focus of a recent Darden study. In short, what were some selection criteria when making decisions relevant to hiring people? To answer that question, close to 40 firms recruiting persons nationwide were interviewed. Seven top attributes sought in graduating M.B.A.s in their final round interviews were these: communication skills (verbal and nonverbal), 85%; interpersonal skills, 69%; self-motivation/initiative (self-monitoring and independence), 67%; professional presence/initial impact (ability to interact), 62%; leadership, 56%; analysis/problem solving, 54%; and academic achievement, 51%.

Dowd, K. O., & Liedtka, J. M. (1994). A study of management characteristics sought by recruiters today. *The Career Forum, 14*(1), 21–23.

- Winning the scholarship award allowed me to travel to Europe [*education*]
- Reducing the labor-hours required for product changeover resulted in a savings of 5% [*work-related projects*]
- Obtaining the Combat Infantry Badge resulted in a promotion to Master Sergeant [*success in military service*]
- Joining the church group ended with my being elected chairperson [*extracurricular activities*]
- Winning the outstanding student investor award allowed me to invest new capital into the market [*awards, honors*]
- Traveling resulted in a major paper and proposal for entering the east European market [*intercultural exposure*]
- Starting my own business taught me practical experience and introduced me to basic fundamentals of entrepreneurial business [*business ventures*]
- Speaking French and Spanish allowed me to head a student study group to Europe [*knowledge of foreign languages*]

Know Your Interests

Analyzing your interests, preferences, and attitudes can help you determine in what type of job you can use your skills.

Which jobs have I enjoyed the most? Why?
Do I prefer to work with figures, machines, people, or ideas?
What do I like to do with my free time?
Which things have brought me high satisfaction?
Which hobbies do I enjoy the most?
And many other self analysis questions . . .

Know Your Personal Values

Earlier, Chapter 4 discussed various situations involving ethical environments; often your decision is based on your own value judgments. Values can also be applied to jobs and what you seek to get from them. Look at the following descriptions; each has a value attached to them; check those statements that apply to you:

1. _____ A desire to help people, a desire to work with them in a personal manner. A concern to make the world a better place in which to live.

2. _____ A position of major responsibility. You would also receive a sizable salary and high recognition.

3. _____ A wish to face risk. You would have to be willing to travel and be concerned with exciting tasks.
4. _____ An ideal place in which to work; people would know one another. The atmosphere would be friendly and warm.
5. _____ A desire to accomplish much on your own. A keen interest in being your own boss.
6. _____ A wish to control events and people. While concensus would be desirable, you would make many decisions alone.
7. _____ A wanderlust. You tire easily of monotonous routines.
8. _____ A dislike for a desk; you would rather be involved in outdoor or physical activity.
9. _____ A dollar sign floats before your eyes. When asked to draw a picture of your interests, that same sign appears.

Values are difficult to measure. Each person carries in his or her own head those things considered of prime importance.

Respectively, the order of the values connected with the above descriptions are altruism, prestige, adventure, association, independence, power, variety, physical activity, and money. You can add to the above list for other values you feel are important.

These four self-assessment categories outlined are for your own use. You will not mail them to anyone. But such a start at self-analysis allows you to see patterns that can give you preliminary ideas as to the kind of work you would like to do.

Checklist 18.1 Self-Assessment

1. Skills
   —My strongest skills are in this area: _____
   —I must work further on this skill: _____
2. Accomplishments
   Rank from 1 (high) to 9 (low) your accomplishments in the following areas: education, work-related projects, military service, extracurricular activities, awards, honors, travel, business ventures, international cultural awareness, or others.
3. Interests
   - I most enjoy _____
   - I least enjoy _____
4. Values
   Rank from 1 (high) to 9 (low) your values in the following areas: altruism, adventure, association, independence, power, variety, physical activity, and money.

Communication Probe

Self-assessment is not limited only to obtaining a job. Self-assessment can occur while even holding a present position. Some companies have an ongoing self-assessment program for the good of the individual and for the good of the company. Often such assessment involves the popular Myer-Briggs Type Indicator, but often companies create their own assessment programs, often called career enrichment programs. Chevron Corporation includes these components: complete self-assessment; joint planning between employee and employer; review of the plan by a group of supervisors; implementation of the plan; and an end-of-cycle review.

(1995, September). Chevron changes focus from career development to career enrichment. *Business Credit, 97,* 24.

MARKET ASSESSMENT

You now have to ask these questions. Which jobs and employers need what I have to offer? In which business market (company) would I like to work? This section includes suggestions to help you in your job-related research.

Written Sources of Career and Job Information

Trade publications, libraries, placement offices are principal places to locate information on possible functional job areas.

Innumerable sources exist. Your school library, local library, and even the career or placement center at your school have countless articles and books on careers and job information. We included here just a few classic, representative samples.

Self-Assessment and Career Planning

- Harr, G. (1995). Career guide: Road maps to meaning in the world of work. Pacific Grove, CA: Brooks/Cole Publishing.
- Herriot, P. (1992). The career management challenge: Balancing individual and organizational; needs. Newbury Park CA: Sage Publications.
- Pollock, D. (1995). Life beyond school: A career guide for college graduates. Kaaawa HI: Jungle Press.

Resume and Cover Letter Preparation

- Kaplan, R. (1994). Sure-hire cover letters. New York: AMACOM.
- Karsen, A. (1991). Ready, aim, hired: Developing your brand name resume. Homewood IL: Business One Irwin.
- Wilson, R. (1994). Conquer resume objections. New York: Wiley.

Interviewing Strategies

- Curzon, S. (1995). Managing the interview: A how-to-do-it manual for hiring. New York: Neal-Schuman.

- Yate, M. J. (1993). Knock 'em dead: With greater answers to tough interview questions. Holbrook MA: Bob Adams.

Internships

- (1995) Internships: A directory for career-finders. New York: Macmillan. Smith, C. (Ed.).
- (1990). Great careers: The Fourth of July resource guide for the promotion of careers, in public, community, and international service. Garrett Park MD: Garrett Park Press.

International Careers

- Cantrell, W. (1992). International internships and volunteer programs . . . Oakton VA: Worldwise Books.
- The student's guide to international internships. (1993). Washington, DC: National Internships.

Additionally, many company directories and employment guides, industry directories, books relating to geographic job searches, cost-of-living directories, and search firms are available. CD-ROM and ABI-Inform databases, job fairs, and the College Placement Council are additional sources for career ideas. For the most up-to-date information concerning a company, consult its annual report, 10-K reports, and recruiting booklets.

Helpful Persons Regarding Employers and Jobs

Networking (remaining in contact with individuals or groups) allows you to make known your job wishes. Or, your network lets you know of potential job positions.

Networking is the current buzzword for linking your interests with a position or company through the help of another person or group. In all parts of the world, the family often nourishes those connections, from generation to generation. If you do not possess such familial network relationships, you must turn to other people, such as those listed below, to help you assess job opportunities.

- *Alumni.* Obtain a list of your university alumni from around the world.
- *Business friends.* Ask for an informational interview with local business persons for advice and even a reference.
- *Counselors.* Your school or placement office staff people who are tuned into the latest areas where jobs and opportunities are growing.
- *Employment Agencies.* Make an appointment with a search firm; get on their list; ask for a review of opportunities in your area of expertise.
- *Former employers and coworkers.*
- *Friends, relatives, acquaintances.*
- *Labor unions.*

RESUME (VITA, QUALIFICATIONS BRIEF)

Phrases or incomplete sentences are acceptable in a resume.

Having completed your self-analysis and market analysis, you must now focus on writing your resume. Briefly, a resume is a summary of your qualifications and intended career path. Some schools require all student resumes to be consistent

Communication Probe

Interesting but similar conclusions were gleaned from a cross-cultural study between job selection approaches in the United States and Japan. Both countries are industrialized and both have a formalized recruitment process, two factors considered in the study. Comparative data from over 600 U.S. male employees and over 500 Japanese male employees were examined. Major variables included country of the firm, size of the firm, educational level of the employees, and age. Dependent variables were direct contact in the employees' employment process; source of the job information; and influence of personal ties in the job selection. *In both countries, most employees heard of job openings from personal sources.* Not unexpectedly, the size of the firm influenced both availability of job information and final selection practices.

Marx, J. (1988, August). Organizational recruitment as a two-stage process: A comparative analysis of Detroit and Yokohama. *Work and Occupations, 15,* 276–293.

in form. Such consistency allows companies using a school resume book to quickly review many graduates and, on that basis, invite some to a personal interview.

Content and layout of resumes vary; there is no best type. Present your information under headings in phrases instead of full sentences. Focus on your job-related achievements. Push the positive—but be honest.

Here we discuss the possible contents of a resume. Choose those parts that best fit your background, and then arrange them in any desirable order. After the opening discussion, we will present examples of complete resumes.

Opening Section

Heading

Information in the heading tells the reader where you can be contacted.

John Sweetland
405 N. State St.
Waseca, MN 56093
Phone 507 555-3237

Although the above is customary, some students, and particularly persons currently in a job position, also include their E-mail-Internet and fax number:

Lyoung@mus.umich.edu and FAX 313 555-4567

Such an insertion quickly suggests you are in control of recent technological means of communication.

Communication Probe

Consistently, writers and researchers suggest similar inclusions in a resume. The information below is based on a recent survey of steps. Note the similarity in the following list with those suggested in this book:

- Preparation is essential.
- Identification of self- and company interests.
- Work experience.
- Professional objectives.
- Education qualifications.
- Achievements.
- Personal information.
- References.

Hornsby, J., & Smith, B. (1995, Winter). Resume content: What should be included and excluded. *SAM Advanced Management Journal, 60,* 4–9.

Job or Career Objective

Based on your self-assessment and an analysis of the job market, you should try for a single-sentence statement of your goal. Such a statement may be general or specific: General, if you know your functional area of interest; specific, if you desire more precision, combining the functional area with an industry.

General goal statement

1. An entry-level sales position
2. An assistant in a brand management area
3. An entry-level position in institutional lending

Specific goal statement

1. An entry-level sales position in automotive parts
2. An assistant in brand management in the food industry
3. An entry-level position in the lending section of the savings and loan industry

Some resumes at this point include a brief statement of your basic qualifications. Such a statement is a mini summary of what you can offer to the job. It is your decision; some persons opt to include such information in the cover letter accompanying the resume.

People tend to remember "first" things; therefore, after the heading select your most important selling point.

You now face another decision: Which area should be in second position in the resume? A general rule is put the most important qualification immediately after the heading. If you have superior job experience, put that next; if education—the category most often in the second position—is important, position it next.

Education

Here are some recommendations regarding what to include under the heading Education.

1. Include school names, locations, dates attended, and degrees of certificates earned. High schools are usually not included. But if you did something outstanding there, such information may be added.
2. Insert abbreviations for your degrees; most employers or their human resources department are familiar with major degree citations.
3. Decide whether to include your grade-point average. Certainly if it is high, it should be included. If your grade-point average is low, omit it. Later in your resume you may indicate, for example, that you worked full-time to finance your education and still managed to earn a degree.
4. Determine whether to include specific courses completed. In a detailed resume, such information may be unnecessary; companies today know the basic required courses for most degrees.
5. Note honors and scholarships.

Work Experience

The third section of a resume is usually devoted to work experience. Here you include information that helps employers evaluate whether you have the necessary background for a current position. Clearly, work experience similar to that for which you are applying indicates you like the type of work in question.

List your jobs in reverse chronological order; put the present or most recent one first. Keep in mind the following points:

1. Give the name, location, and dates of employment for each company.
2. Insert your position and title, if any, beside each company.
3. Use verbs that show your major accomplishments while working for each company; be precise as to the results of your work experiences. The list of action verbs on the facing page is helpful.

Arrange the facts for each job in the best "selling" order. Put the most important fact first following your opening verb.

Follow the rules of parallelism, making two or more elements in a series similar in grammatical word structure. *Manager, representative, salesperson, accountant* are all parallel because each is a job title and a noun. *Managing*, a kind of work, would not be parallel to the preceding titles. Duties, as *filing, word processing planning* are parallel. Most often the verbs, as in the long list, are in the past tense when describing activities performed for a previous company.

Achievements, Awards, Service Activities

Try to limit your resume to one page. If you have received few noteworthy awards, this information may be omitted or included in sections on education and

accomplished	delegated	interpreted	published
achieved	demonstrated	interviewed	questioned
adapted	designed	introduced	realized
administered	developed	invented	recommended
adopted	devised	investigated	reduced
advanced	directed	judged	researched
advised	disposed	juried	restated
allocated	drafted	justified	reviewed
analyzed	edited	led	revised
appraised	employed	listened	saved
approved	enlisted	maintained	scheduled
assessed	established	managed	secured
assisted	executed	marketed	selected
audited	expanded	matched	sold
broadened	expedited	measured	sponsored
brought	explained	monitored	staffed
calculated	extrapolated	negotiated	suggested
clarified	facilitated	obtained	summarized
communicated	forecasted	offered	supervised
compiled	formed	operated	taught
completed	formulated	optimized	trained
conceived	furnished	organized	transferred
conciliated	generated	originated	transformed
conducted	guided	performed	undertook
constructed	handled	persuaded	used
consulted	headed	planned	validated
contacted	implemented	prepared	verified
contracted	improved	presented	weighed
controlled	increased	prioritized	widened
coordinated	influenced	produced	won
created	initiated	programmed	worked
decided	inspected	projected	wrote
decreased	instructed	promoted	
defined	integrated	proposed	

work experience. Regardless, this is not the time to be humble. Receiving any award deserves mention in a resume. Additional items often include offices held, athletic accomplishments, published materials, fluency in foreign languages, speaking awards (debate, extemporaneous contests), professional fraternities, student organizations, and community services that involve working with people.

Personal Data (Optional)

Including personal information is now entirely optional. Civil rights laws clearly prohibit discrimination in hiring on the basis of race, age, religion, sex, marital status, or national origin. Exceptions include occupational restrictions that are reasonably necessary to the normal operation of particular businesses, enterprises, or occupations. For example, some jobs, such as playing professional football, may reasonably require certain physical attributes.

Although no law forbids you from volunteering personal information, you must be careful about including information that could accuse you of being discriminatory. Bias and prejudice still exist; *omit any information that might be considered negatively!* Common inclusions under personal data include health, hobbies, physical skills, travel, and, if not included elsewhere, Peace Corps, Americorps, military service details, or other national service organizations.

References

Employers today often ask prior to or just after an interview for a list of references. Including a long list of individuals in a resume is becoming less usual. Potential employers know you will select persons who will evaluate you positively. Often the phrase "references available on request" is the last statement at the end of a resume. However, your school may suggest including references. If that is the case, consider the following:

Checklist 18.2 Review of Major Sections of a Resume

1. Opening Section
   - **a.** Your name, address (school and/or home), telephone numbers, fax number, or E-mail address
   - **b.** Your job or career objective
   - **c.** Your basic qualifications (optional)

2. Education
   - **a.** Schooling beyond high school: names and locations, dates attended, degrees and certificates
   - **b.** Major, significant pertinent courses; academic honors; grade-point average [if high]; special skills; significant achievements
   - **c.** Positions, such as assistant to an instructor, grader, or research assistant

3. Work Experience
   - **a.** Employer names, dates, location; titles and positions held; specific accomplishments preceded by a verb
   - **b.** Volunteer work

4. Achievements, Awards, Service Activities
   - **a.** School and community achievements, honors, offices, publications
   - **b.** Travel, languages, self-support, other facts

5. Personal Data (Optional)
   - **a.** Date of availability
   - **b.** Health, military service, hobbies

6. References (Optional)

- Limit your list to three individuals, complete with information about where they may be reached via phone, fax, letter, or E-mail.
- Avoid including relatives as references.
- Choose individuals such as former work supervisors, professors, teachers, colleagues, or business friends.
- Be sure you have the permission of the individual whose name you use as a reference.

Sample Resumes

In the preceding sections we discussed the six major parts of a resume: opening section, education, work experience, achievements, personal data, and references. Review the following four examples, which illustrate all the sections. A description of each resume is included at the bottom of the example.

All the above guides for completing a resume are just as applicable to creating your material for electronic resume transmission. There, however, your material can be read by many readers, particularly on line resume service organizations hired by human resource departments of corporations. Remember: Electronic screening is efficient for large corporations that may use sorting systems, scanners, or on-line data pools. Your resume, particularly your goal or objective statement, will be more general rather than directed at a specific company, for a specific position.

COVER LETTER TO RESUME

Also called the "cold contact" letter or the job application letter, the resume cover letter has one purpose: to attract the interest of your prospective employer to give you a job interview. A resume could be called the shotgun approach—it covers much material; a resume cover letter could be called the rifle approach—it focuses on precise points.

You have only about 30 seconds to capture the attention of your reader in the cover letter.

Try to write a one-page job application letter composed of the following points: opening, middle paragraphs, and last paragraph, as noted below. This tripartite approach should also continue to be reader-centered and should include evidence (data) to support your claims.

Communication Probe

Obviously, the nonverbal appearance of the resume must catch the eye of the prospective employer. Thus neatness, accurate spelling, and acceptable grammar are givens in a resume. And only after reading the resume—along with the cover letter—can an employer make a decision whether to interview the candidate. Four factors in the content of a resume, says one researcher, work against its success: candidate had too many lateral job moves; candidate did not include a cover letter; candidate held too many jobs in a short period of time; and the candidate lacked related experience.

Macdougall, N. (1990, September). An employer rates resumes. *CMA magazine, 64,* 35.

ELLEN RAAB

Campus Address
[Street]
[City, State, ZIP]
[Telephone; Fax; E-mail]

Permanent Address
[Street]
[City, State, ZIP]
[Telephone; Fax]

Goal A position in marketing or advertising.

Education

School of Business Administration
College *[Name, City, State]*

B.B.A. degree candidate. May 1997. Concentration in marketing with interest in advertising. Member of Marketing Club. Active on advertising and product management committees. GPA = 3.25.

Community College *[Name, City, State]*

A.A.–Associate in Arts degree, June 1995. Member of Phi Theta Kappa, honorary fraternity. Received *[Name]* Scholarship for Outstanding Community College Student. GPA = 3.6.

Experience

[Company Name] *[City, State]*

Intern. Summer 1996. Worked directly with buyers, assistant buyers, store management, sales associate, and senior merchandise management. As assistant department manager, responsibilities included trend analysis, implementation of merchandise concepts, communication with buyers, promotion preparation, and motivation of sales force. Distributed information to sales managers.

Trassel Advertising *[City, State]*

Intern. Summer 1995. Gained experience in sales promotion, public relations, media placement, agency presentations, client relations, copy writing, and commercial production.

Commerce Weekly *[City, State]*

Advertising display staff. January-April 1994. Created layout, ads, and guided ads through the areas of artwork, typesetting, and billing.

Lawn Maintenance *[City, State]*

Owner and partner. Summers 1991-1993. Marketed services to new and already established areas of our working community. Increased customers yearly.

Activities Research assistant for professor of marketing. Leader of "Sunbank Products" marketing term project; organized advertising agency presentation of new marketing strategy for Sunbank baby food. Member Zeta Beta Tau fraternity. Active on fundraising committees. Team member in intramural softball and football. Participant in Dean's Seminar Program.

Available Sept. 1, 1997. References furnished upon request.

Figure 18.1 One-page resume with main headings in left margin; right-hand margin justified (vertically straight); "Activities" in place of terms "Achievements, Awards, Service, Activities."

Henry Zse
2030 Welch Ct.
[City, State, Zip]
[Telephone; Fax; E-mail]

OBJECTIVE: A management position in accounting

EDUCATION:

The University of *[Name]* *[City, State]*
School of Business Administration
MBA candidate for May 1999.
– Active member, Accounting Club–Special Events Coordinator
– Active member, Black Business Students' Association

The University of *[Name]* *[City, State]*
BBS degree, December 1997
– Graduated magna cum laude (GPA 3.59/4.0)
– Honors: National Dean's list; Scholastic All-American
– Elected President, School of Business and Industry Forum

EXPERIENCE

1994-1996 *[Company Name]* *[City, State]*
General Accountant
– Reviewed with re-engineering of the payment process and systems; ensured uniformity across the organization
– Assisted with re-engineering of the payment process for contract services; resulted in 3-5% rate reduction in services provided
– Coordinated two cross-functional teams to review contract services
– Promoted to Senior General Accountant in June, 1996
– Prepared month-end journal vouchers in accordance with corporate guidelines

College Graduate in Training
– Managed Dealer Incentive Programs for *[Name]* motor division
– Analyzed and recommended changes in indirect costs associated with specialty vehicles
– Resolved 100% of outstanding items on five supplier accounts

1993 *[Company Name]* *[City, State]*
Winter Intern
– Analyzed district performance for various products distributed to suppliers around the country
– Evaluated physician assistants' responsibilities to determine viability as a potential target market

ADDITIONAL
– Volunteer tutor, Project STEP tutorial program
– 1994 campaign manager, local Friends of Scouting
– One and one-half years retail sales experience

Figure 18.2 One-page resume with traditional main headings and dates in left margin.

Opening—For Favorable Attention

In Chapters 14 and 15 we stressed the importance of the *aim*, making clear—up front—your central purpose. Be businesslike—indicate you're applying for a job. Four possible opening styles are recommended: summary, name, question, and news item openings.

RESUME OF WINNIE NG

[Address, City, State, Zip]
[Telephone; Fax; E-mail]

Professional Objective: Business education teaching position in a *[State]* Class A secondary school.

EDUCATION FOR BUSINESS AND TEACHING

[Name] **University,** *[City, State],* September 1994 to June 1997

Major: Business education, secondary school emphasis
Courses in accounting; business communication; business law; computer programming; data processing; graphic arts; marketing; office practice; secretarial procedures; teaching accounting, shorthand; machine operations

Minor: Economics Courses in European and American economic history, international economics, macroeconomics, microeconomics

Grade Point Average: 3.9 (out of possible 4.0)
Degree: M.B.A. (master of business administration)

University of *[Name, City, State],* September 1990-1994

Grade Point Average: 3.8 (out of possible 4.0)
Degree: B.A. (bachelor of arts), with emphasis on business courses.

EMPLOYMENT EXPERIENCE

Student Teacher:	Broadway High, *[City, State],* September to December 1991
Supervisor:	Ms. Jayne Hamilton
Courses taught:	Shorthand 2, Word Processor Typesetting, Secretarial Procedures, Computer Operations: MS DOS; Windows
Responsibilities:	Planned and supervised three complete units for each class, ranging from 20-30 students, with approval of Ms. Hamilton and Mr. Thomas Jones.
Bookkeeper and Secretary:	Baron Ford Motor, 850 Fifth Avenue, *[City, State]* January 1986 to December 1990 (part time during school; full time, summer): Mr. David Lowns, Office Manager
Responsibilities:	Varied over the two years. Operated switchboard, recorded accounts payable ledger, prepared reports, typed letters, assisted office manager as secretary and file clerk.

Figure 18.3 Resume (on two pages), with centered and side headings.

Summary Opening

An effective opening is a summary of your two or three outstanding qualifications related to the job you seek. For instance:

1. Orion Pictures, Slavic Pictures. Both these companies gave me the opportunity to apply the financial skills learned in school. For two years I also worked for Turner Broadcasting;

RESUME OF WINNIE NG
Page 2

EMPLOYMENT EXPERIENCE *(continued)*

Assistant Claims Adjuster:	Central Administrator, 360 Main Street, [City, State] summer 1985
Supervisor:	Mr. Walter Arnold
Responsibilities:	Processed claims for health insurance, maintained all billing files on customer accounts, and sent reminders for premium payments

Part-time jobs before 1985:
Waitress in Jolly Home Restaurant, grocery store sales clerk, library assistant

HONORARIES, CLUBS, ACTIVITIES

College
Phi Beta Kappa, academic national scholarship honorary
Beta Gamma Sigma, national scholastic honorary in business administration
Recording secretary, Business Student's Association
Vice president, Beta Beta sorority
Recipient of two academic scholarships: from Lions Club and XYZ Business Association

High School
National Honor Society and Torch Club–three years; secretary one year
President, Business Education Club
Editor, Annual
Outstanding Graduate 1986, chosen by Alumni Association

SKILLS AND HOBBIES

Write and speak the French language.
Office skills include operating computers (IBM, Apple, Zenith), copying machines, electronic calculators; writing shorthand 125 wpm, and typing 60 wpm.

Hobbies include hiking, working with people, swimming, professional enrichment.

REFERENCES

Available with credentials at Placement Center,
[Name, Address] University

Figure 18.3 (continued)

there I headed an international marketing team searching for broadcast opportunities in southern Europe. [*extensive work experience*]

2. Classical music has for years been an interest of mine. Thus my CD collection, membership in the school symphony orchestra, and work as an usher at classical concerts suggest an awareness of the classical stage. Your published job description for a continuity writer for your station suggests that my background includes the qualifications you desire. [*no work experience*]

RESUME

PERSONAL PARTICULARS

NAME:	Zhong Bei Baolin
ADDRESS:	12f, Block 24 Crossway Gardens Lam Tin, Kowloon
TELEPHONE:	2431 0014 (home) 2829 7470 (office) 1228128 pager 5609
SEX:	Male
DATE AND PLACE OF BIRTH:	January 25, 1962, Hong Kong
H.K.I.D. No:	G259643(A)
MARITAL STATUS:	Married

EDUCATION

1994-1996	Master of Science in Mechanical Engineering *Hong Kong University of Science and Technology*
1990-1993	Professional Diploma in Informational Technology *Hong Kong Polytechnic University*
1985-1987	Bachelor of Science in Mechanical Engineering *University of Hong Kong*
1982-1985	High Diploma in Mechanical Engineering *Hong Kong Polytechnic University*
1975-1982	Lung Cheung Government Technical School

PC KNOWLEDGE

Lotus, Database, AutoCad, Multimate, MS Word, Word Star, Harvard Graphics, MS Windows, DOS

INTERESTS

Badminton, Squash, Reading

WORK EXPERIENCE

Feb.' 96-present	Senior Engineer *[Company]* Hong Kong Limited – Project management and design of E&M works in the construction and maintenance of Service Stations in Hong Kong and China – Provide preliminary design and estimates for potential projects – Handle regular maintenance work for service station facilities – Prepare tenders for E&M work for service stations

Foreign resumes include more personal information than do those of the United States; it is your option as to what personal information you include.

Figure 18.4 This two-page resume suggests that different cultures, different schools in foreign lands prepare resumes differently. Note especially the opening Personal Particulars section. Asian students have no distaste for or interest in hiding any of what western students would consider highly personal information. Then too, the United States has rules that prohibit that information from being made public, either on a resume or during a personal interview. Similar comments on "private" information can be made for European students, some of whom even include the names of their parents and the occupation of their father.

Interestingly, the above resume—names and details changed—omits mention of the fact that he knows English well: In Asia much of the information western students place in resumes is discussed orally during the interview. Also, note that the resume writer chooses to place his work experience last.

There is no objective or goal statement. We were told that when he received his current position, only those who felt they met the stipulated job requirements applied; hence, his goal statement is absent.

Sept.' 90-Jan.' 91 Engineer
[Company] Motor Bus (1993) Co. Ltd.
– Design of depot facilities, commissioning of equipment in bus depot
– Supervision of workforce and the repair and maintenance of bus and depot facilities
– Liaison with vehicle parts manufacturers
– Liaison with bus drivers to solve engineering and operational problems

Oct.' 88-Sept.' 90 Engineering Graduate
[Company] Motor Bus (1993) Co. Ltd.
– A two-year training program included workshop practice, supervision, management, and design works in bus-maintenance field.

3. Your international expansion plans have been cited in many major business publications. Your desire to expand into India caught my attention. I am of Indian descent. I have visited India with my parents extensively and have interned with an international oil exploration firm. My background suggests I can be a worthy candidate for your expansion plans. [*has cultural awareness knowledge*]

Name Opening

To use this kind of cover letter opening requires *networking*, learning about opportunities from another person or group. If a networking reference, or anyone

Name cards—kept on file—are constant reminders of persons on whom you might call for future references in cover letters.

well known to you, has suggested you apply for a position, you can use that person's name in the opening—unless he or she has asked you to keep it confidential. Many job opportunities with the federal government, if you are interested in that kind of work, are carried via the Washington "network."

1. Professor Joseph Haan, my major professor in Operations Management at [*university*] told me of a possible opening in your area. Work with him over the past two years as a research assistant suggests I have some of the basic requirements for your open position.

2. Your ad in the employment section of the International Herald Tribune, on Friday, January 27, 19--, suggested the need for someone interested in working on investment opportunities in China. As a student who has visited China on several occasions, and one who owns some "B" shares of stock in that country, I would like to apply for the position of investment trainee in your company.

3. Your name comes to me via a mutual friend, Mr. Richard Sarns. He recommended that I send you my resume for your open position of assistant product manager.

Question Opening

A bit more difficult to write, but just as effective, is the question that shows understanding of a company problem or significant need. You as an applicant desire to help.

Geht es auf Deutsch? Are you in need of a German translator? Who answers the questions of your foreign guests at your Cape Cod guest house? German is one of my foreign languages, as is French and a little Italian. These language skills, and work in the Holiday Inn chain, lead me to approach you for the position of General Manager.

Read publications not only for content, but for future job opportunities.

News Item Opening

Any young person or seasoned businessperson should frequently read business publications. Not to do so may cost you a job opportunity. A planned expansion, a newly released product, a refinancing program, a new account—all are possible motivators for sending a job application letter. Often you send such a letter without a specific job in mind; you are interested in letting your readers know you have qualifications that tie in with their future plans.

1. Mexico, NAFTA were the headlines in the [*name of journal, date*]. And a significant portion of that article summarized your expansion plans into Mexico. My minor at [*name of school*] was Spanish,

with a second minor in Civil Engineering. Because of those two reasons, and others as noted in the accompanying resume, I'd like to apply for a job that makes use of my talents.

2. Congratulations on being voted in [*name of magazine, date*] as the most innovative Michigan company in creative information systems. For two years I have been linked with "open systems theory," applying that information to my current position of senior systems analyst. My academic concentration and my practical experience will enable me to perform well as a potential member of your staff.

Middle Paragraphs—For Data, Details

Support your claims; use truthful data, evidence, supports that both clarify and sustain your conclusions.

Two or at most three paragraphs is all the space you have to persuade your reader you have the necessary job qualifications.

- Avoid repetition of facts in the resume.
- Ask yourself: Which two points effectively show a potential employer that I have the necessary qualifications?
- Conclude each statement with this question: So what?
- Include brief, valid, startling data (evidence) in support of your job qualifications.
- Put your strongest argument first.

Education

Many of you will consider education your most important qualification, especially if you are applying for a first job. But avoid the impression that a college degree (entrepreneur and chairman of Microsoft Bill Gates does not have a college degree) overshadows all achievements.

- Emphasize how your *overall* education prepared you for the work or area you seek.
- Show that you have both a broad background in business (and arts and sciences) and depth in certain major courses.
- Explain how additional electives supplemented your major.

1. My training in production control at [*name*] enables me to analyze, study, and recommend methods of work simplification in your factory projects. Additionally, my seven-week internship-as part of our M.B.A. requirement-allowed me to work on the floor of [*name*] motor company where pragmatic experience added to my classroom work.

2. Many executives have made this assertion: "Seek multifunctional employees." My degree in music theory, with a minor in accounting principles, has given me understanding in two areas needed for your position as Assistant Business Manager.

Work Experience

Full- or part-time job responsibilities add valuable data to your resume cover letter. Suggest that in your responsibilities in previous jobs you

- Gained practical experience to accompany your education
- Adapted to different work environments
- Supervised other people with positive results
- Administered large expendable funds honestly and correctly
- Negotiated major tender offers with foreign suppliers

1. My internship with you during the past two summers made my decision easy: I'd like to be considered as a permanent employee of your product design area. As a result of that prior effort, I know CAD-CAM and all its derivatives, as well as detail work with the production people who manufacture the product.

2. Two summers at Raffles Place in Singapore-at the [*name of bank*]-honed my international financial skills. There we worked on bringing to market the Singapore Telecom stock and were in the process of planning a forthcoming sale of another major country utility. Such work experience is superb background for joining your international banking division.

Personal Attitudes, Interests, Activities, Qualities

Simply listing your abilities is not enough; show how those abilities relate to the position for which you are applying.

Relating your personal attitudes, interests, activities, or personal qualities to the job requirements may also be included, as illustrated in the following examples.

Your Ability to Work with People

- Used good judgment in working with senior people.
- Known to be a conscientious listener to new members of the firm.
- Led student groups of various nationalities and cultural interests.
- Won applause for using good judgment with incomplete information.

Your Attitude Toward Employment

- Long have held an interest in [*functional area*].
- Even in spare time I have devoted effort to furthering my interest in [*functional area*] as seen in the following examples.
- For a long time I have shown enthusiasm for this field; my intent is to make it my full-time occupation.

Checklist 18.3 Cover Letter to Resume

1. Obtain favorable attention
   - **a.** Summary—Select two or three outstanding qualifications.
   - **b.** Name—Choose a known individual with whom the reader is familiar or the publication in which the reader's notice appeared.
   - **c.** Question—State one or two questions that suggest you are familiar with the company.
   - **d.** News item—Relate your opening comment to an item that appeared in the national press.

2. Give effort to data, details in the middle paragraphs
   - **a.** Education—Be truthful as to degrees, majors, and minors.
   - **b.** Work experience—Be precise about how previous experience trained you for the current position.
   - **c.** Personal attitudes, interests, activities, qualities: Relate, show how your qualities can improve your performance with the announced job.

3. Focus on easy action in the last paragraph
   - **a.** State when you are available on the phone or in person.
   - **b.** Ask if a local representative is in the area whom you could contact if the home office is extremely distant.

- All my school teachers will quickly support my thesis that my readings, my papers, my outside interests have been devoted to [*functional area*].

Your Personal Qualities

- My schooling was funded through scholarships and my own outside-of-school work [*determination*].
- Each day was tightly planned in order to meet all commitments for the day [*organized, time control*].
- Winning the undergraduate school investment award taught me the value of in-depth research before making a decision [*analytical mind*].
- Two suggestions that led to completed projects were under my supervision [*initiative*].

Last Paragraph—For Easy Action

In the final paragraph you ask for action; here, more than in other parts of your job application letter, use the first person singular "I." Some suggestions:

John Bitar

1247 Golden Rd., Apt. #3
Middleburg, VA 22117
May 15, 199-

Dr. John Hollowell, Superintendent
[City] High School Employment Services
[City, State, Zip]

Dear Dr. Hollowell:

In September, will one of your grade schools need a physical education instructor who can make learning realistic and interesting for students? If so, please consider me for the position. My qualifications include a degree in physical education and a minor in business subjects.

On June 10 this year I shall graduate from *[School]*, where I did several things: played on the varsity basketball team, majored in physical education, and minored in business subjects. Several students and I also headed a three-week workshop on drug abuse; during that time we had outside speakers and two all-school convocations. If you are thinking about adding a special program on drug abuse, I will gladly give you my ideas about setting up such a program.

Three years of summer work have given me insights into the growing need for the kind of education needed by young people. My work with Opportunity Inc., Freedom Toys, and Mershon Investing added to my course work in physical education. Each of the above companies–after my work with them during the summer–contributed financially to the drug abuse seminar I mentioned above. Furthermore, my respective different positions in the above companies–handicap student assistant, product design assistant, and health care analysis assistant–developed my qualities of concern for young people

My student evaluations–summarized in the enclosed resume–suggest I have done well in teaching. So well that I have decided that grade school teaching will be my chosen career.

To discuss further your requirements and my qualifications, will you please grant me an interview? You can reach me during the evening hours at *[Telephone]* or during the day at *[Fax]*. Because your school district is within one day's driving distance, I could visit you at your convenience.

Sincerely,

John Bitar

Enclosure: Resume

Figure 18.5 A "cold call" job application letter to a school superintendent; this letter includes necessary information for a first-job application.

- Make the action easy.
- Be precise as to times you can be reached by phone.
- Include phone number, if you have an answering machine, and whether you are available by fax or E-mail.
- Suggest that it is possible for you to come to the employer's office.
- Ask for a local representative's name if the central office is extremely distant.

2039 Alhambra
Mt. Morris, MN 56099
January 29, 199-

Ms. Pauline Kwong, Senior Product Manager
Beverage Division
General Foods USA
250 North St.
White Plains, NY 10625

Dear Pauline:

Delightful is the way to describe our meeting of last week during our Finance Club mock interviews. Not only were your remarks to the club useful, but I personally got to speak with you about summer internship possibilities. Our discussion convinced me more than ever of my desire to pursue a career in product management.

As we discussed, my work with Wolverine Products (as an interim financial analyst) and at Stroh Brewery would allow me to make an immediate contribution. At Stroh's two other people and I were given the task of decreasing delivery costs over a four-state area. We were successful, decreasing costs by 2.8%.

Our school calendar suggests representatives from General Foods USA will be on campus in February. But because all places on your interview schedule have already been assigned via computer, I request inclusion on your closed interview list. At that time it would be a pleasure to meet your company's representative to go over my resume and to answer additional questions.

Please contact me if you need additional information. You can reach me at 507 123-4567 in the evenings, central time. I look forward to hearing from you soon.

Sincerely,

Michi Yamada

Figure 18.6 Sample of a job application letter written after an earlier contact was made. Letter is full block style.

Sample Letters of Application

The three application letters illustrated in Figures 18.5 through 18.7 apply suggestions made in this chapter. A description of each application letter is included below each figure.

SUMMARY

The first thing you should do in the job application process is pursue a self-assessment—that means knowing yourself. Take time to list your skills, accomplishments, and personal values as you and others see them.

Arnaud Desbans
Mühlacker Weg 2
6918 Neckarsteinach
Germany
12 April, 199-

Mr. Fritz Feuerstein, Senior Partner
Anderson Consulting
Am Seiteralle 6
4038 Frankfurt, Germany

Dear Mr. Feuerstein,

Are you looking for someone flexible enough to go from bartering chickens in a rural area of Borneo to conducting a market survey of Bulgaria for a leading Asian insurance company? If your response is yes, please consider adding me to your team of consultants helping to restructure industries in Eastern Europe.

Three years of developing and restructuring income generating products in Malaysia increased both my resourcefulness and perseverance. My largest hurdle was helping project participants understand both problems and solutions. Once that was understood, we were able to bring about change. While my world of work is in Asia, the problems facing former East block countries are more complex. Yet the dynamics of change are universal.

Consulting in Eastern Europe is the obvious career choice given my educational background, work experience, and personal interests. My degree will come from a top business school; my study in two languages (Chinese, German) will be used extensively; and my pioneering work in Malaysia will allow even more adaptability in the future.

Please refer to the accompanying documents for further details on my background. Please let me call you or contact you via Internet or fax during the week of April 22-26, 199-. If you desire to contact me prior to that time–in German or English–telephone (7-hour time difference) me evenings at 49 2345 678, fax 49 2134 456, or E-mail ades@neck.edu..

I look forward to your response.

Cordially,

Arnaud Desbans

Figure 18.7 A "cold call letter" in which the writer sought out the specific name of the foreign employer. Note the few uses of the first personal singular *I*, and the European accepted use of the "," after the salutation. He also is considering a career change.

Thousands of companies and functional areas of work make up the world's workplace. Your school career counseling center or placement office is the place to start. Then move to reviewing some of the many written sources on careers and job information. Do not neglect to contact persons already in the field or persons who can likewise be helpful in landing a job.

Communication Probe

Casual studies abound as to what to include or exclude from resumes and cover letters to resumes. With the job market narrowing, what one includes in those two documents influences every employer, who according to some estimates, spends no more than 30 seconds on submitted documents. A recent summary of points to consider in the area of management accounting are the following: Apply to more than one company, use many avenues to search for job opportunity, lay out a strategy for your search, *give inordinate time to the resume and cover letter to make them error-free,* investigate the company thoroughly, establish rapport with a follow-up communication, search beyond the limits of your work experience, be flexible, and leave an interview with a positive and upbeat attitude.

Half, R. (1993, October). Managing your career. *Management Accounting, 75,* 12.

Edit, rewrite, review; have other persons look at the centerpiece of who you are: your resume. No agreed-upon organization for a resume and its content is forthcoming. Notwithstanding that comment, we recommend focusing on three central topics: a goal statement, education experience, and work experience.

Finally, this chapter focused on a second most important document: the cover letter to accompany your resume. Here too, edit, rewrite, review, and have other persons look at this piece of persuasive writing that seeks to obtain an interview for you. Likewise, give thought to three steps: the opening paragraph for getting favorable attention, the middle paragraphs for supply data and evidence, and the last paragraph for suggesting easy action.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Resume Comparisons.*** This assignment demands contacting foreign students who are members of your classes. Its purpose is to suggest that there is no consistent way in which different cultures construct a resume—or what information is included. Before asking your foreign friends specific questions, have them review with you a traditional U.S. resume from your school. Then with several foreign students discuss and illustrate in writing answers to these questions:
   - Which information is included in resumes representative of their country?
   - What are the main headings of their resumes?
   - How important is personal information in those resumes?

2. ***Cover Letter Comparisons.*** As with the preceding assignment, this one too demands contact with several foreign students in your classes. Apply the

same three questions above to their cover letters to resumes. Again, bring in written examples for class discussion.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Self-Assessment.*** This assignment helps you structure your ideas for preparing both a resume and a cover letter to that resume. It forces thought on those qualities that make up your job search, similar to the topics noted in this chapter. (1) List your accomplishments under the headings of skills, accomplishments, interests, and personal values. (2) Insert a verb in front of each statement to give a high sense of action. For instance, "*Worked* toward meeting a B+ average in school classes in order to have a respectable average for college entrance."

4. ***Market Assessment.*** This question seeks to have you analyze your potential interests in the job market. Use a similar structure to question 1, namely, headings of (1) functional areas in which you have a potential interest and (2) names or kinds of people who would be helpful to you in locating a job.

5. ***Resume Preparation.*** As an outgrowth of the two preceding questions, it is time to prepare a resume. Choose one of the organizational patterns discussed in this chapter in Figures 18.1 to 18.4. Your instructor may request that at least four different patterns occur for a comparison between them to be made. After the four patterns have been presented, which of the four do you find most persuasive and workable?

6. ***Cover Letter Preparation.*** Prepare the actual letter you would send to a prospective employer as based on the above resume. Assume that you will soon graduate; address is to the firm of your choice.

7. ***Cover Letter Evaluations.*** Following are two cover letters to go along with a resume. Explain orally in class which one is acceptable and would most likely get an interview. Which one is totally unacceptable?

   Letter a. Application for a teaching job in history.

   I'm graduating soon from college, where I majored in history. I like history and find that my career goals are in place to pursue that vocation.

   I've learned that your school district is looking for history teachers, especially those students who majored in ancient history. I did. I enjoy it. I like the ancient world because some of the lessons from that day apply here as well.

   My work experience is hard to relate to history, but I did spend my summers working in the school

library. There I catalogued books and worked at the sign-out desk. All that information is included on the enclosed resume.

I hope to hear from you soon. I know that my interests lie in the area of history and would fit into your school system. Please write me.

Letter b. Application for a product manager position.

Exercise bicycle. Step Master. Those two physical exercise machines were part of my last two summer's work here in [*city*]. Add that practical experience to my major in kineseology and I feel I possess the qualifications you seek for an entry position in your company.

Your company reports suggest a continuing interest in and support for exercise equipment as a form of rehabilitative therapy. Both of the two machines above are currently extensively used in nursing homes and hospital exercise therapy units. And what makes the above statement more important is the fact that I demonstrated the exercise bicycle and Step Master at numerous health facilities. My resume suggests that physical exercise and overall well-being are a major part of my life-and will continue to be so.

Finally, my personal habits of meeting assignments on time while working outside of class can be verified by my teachers; they willingly would write letters on my behalf.

After you've reviewed this note and my enclosed resume, I would like to call you for an initial appointment during the week of October 21-25, 199-. Or, you could call me during the evenings at (313) 555-4567. My school has a fax in their placement department if you wish to send such a message: (313) 555-6789.

8. ***Cold Call Letter.*** Any cold call, verbally or in writing, is difficult. You have just a few seconds to capture the attention of your receiver. Go to your school library and locate an annual report of a company or one of their brochures, which may be in your placement office. Write a "cold call" letter inquiring about a possible job position.

Chapter 19

The Job Application Process—Interviews and Follow-Up

I. Successful Preparation for the Job Interview
   A. Prior to the Interview
   B. Chronology of the Interview
   C. Activity During the Interview
   D. Answering or Asking Questions During the Interview

II. Successful Follow-Up Messages After the Interview
   A. Candidate to Employer (Eleven Sample Letters)
   B. Employer to Candidate (Seven Sample Letters)

III. Successful Negotiating
   A. Basic Preparation for Negotiating the Job Offer
   B. Basic Issues in Negotiating the Job Offer

IV. Summary

V. Exercises and Problems

VI. References

When Bonnie Dun, 20 years old, tried out for a teller's job at Great Western Bank in Chatsworth, California, she faced a lineup of big jerks.

One young woman sputtered contradictory instructions about depositing a check, then blew her top when the transaction wasn't handled fast enough. Another customer had an even shorter fuse. "You people are unbelievably slow," she said.

Both tough customers appeared on a computer screen, as part of a 20-minute job interview.[1]

Some entry job positions are conducted electronically. Computers, some people argue, are not judgmental.

A computer interview? Yes, for some entry-level positions. Companies such as Nieman Marcus, Marriott, Corning, Foley's, American Express, and Walt Disney Company are among early users. Their argument: Computers are not judgmental; applicants are more honest with computers.

Need you as a graduate be fearful that your next interview will be conducted by a computer? We think not. At the managerial level there is less evidence that such electronic screening is extensively used. However, at the managerial level an electronic network of job announcements and job leads is growing nationally. Members of the three largest networks share information via an electronic mail system and published newsletters. Only after a contact is made with the listing company does the possibility of a face-to-face interview occur.[2]

This chapter discusses preparation before and behavior during an interview, follow-up messages to an interview from either the interviewee or interviewer, and preparation needed to successfully negotiate a job offer.

SUCCESSFUL PREPARATION FOR THE JOB INTERVIEW

Congratulations! Getting on the interview list of either an on-campus interviewer or at the company is an important first step. Your cover letter as a "sales" approach and your resume achieved their purpose. Now what?

Prior to the Interview

The following ideas from a New York Life Insurance Company booklet capture oft-repeated ideas on the significance of the interview.

> The 20-30 minutes spent with an interviewer may determine the future course of one's life. Indeed, it is one of the most important events in the average person's experience. Strangely, some persons drift into interviews with scant preparation and only with the vaguest idea of what they are going to say. Too often the oral and nonverbal communication is "well, here I am."
>
> Two other extremes also are present. On the one hand are those who are seemingly indifferent, casual, nonchalant, apathetic, detached, cool. Or, some are overprepared, overrehearsed, overnervous, overstimulated. Both may respond in a monotone, with monosyllables.

These marks of inexperience can destroy a promising interview. Some simple preparatory steps are in order.

Checklist 19.1 suggests 10 crucial points that can act as an initial guide to your prior-to-the interview preparation.

Chronology of the Interview

As with most communication instances, an interview also has an introductory period, a middle assessment period, and a concluding period.

There is no consistent pattern for job interviews; the following is typical. Also realize that many first interviews are just that: interviews to screen candidates for a possible second interview.

Checklist 19.1 Interview Preparation

1. *Know yourself.* Review the self-assessment document you created based on your skills, accomplishments, interests, and personal values.
2. *Know your resume.* Take at least two copies of your resume with you; know its contents cold.
3. *Know the company.* Review current CD-ROM databases, check either electronic or hard copy issues of the *Wall Street Journal,* The *New York Times,* The *Asian Wall Street Journal,* or other periodicals. What do you look for? Earnings, products, expansions, management changes, events—even problems.
4. *Know the position.* Prepare with your strongest qualifications if the job position is known. If the position is general, come with your personal qualifications well-rehearsed and known.
5. *Know some questions and answers.* Prepare some of your questions in advance. Try to anticipate some of your interviewer's questions—and your answers. A series of often-asked questions is on pages 536 and 537.
6. *Know that your nonverbal appearance communicates loudly.* This statement is not an overlooked mixed metaphor; it suggests that your clothing, your shoes, your jewelry, your lotion, your color choice, your grooming—all say something about you. When in doubt, be conservative in dress.
7. *Know that your oral delivery also communicates.* A monotone rarely holds attention. Oral variety in pitch, rate, and volume will help, as recommended in Chapter 14.
8. *Know the meeting place, time, and other details.* Arrive early; know the name of your interviewer.
9. *Know some basic salary ranges.* Avoid locked-in-stone positions on salary; initial interviews are not the place for negotiation sessions. But knowing possible salary ranges is advisable.
10. *Know that you must rehearse.* Mock interviews—with video playback—are recommended. Take advantage of your placement office's opportunity to rehearse, perhaps two times: for ideas, for oral and nonverbal appearance, for the first few minutes of the interview.

Communication Probe

One may make the best preparation possible for an interview. Yet, there are companies that search specifically for an employer-employee fit, that decision being made toward the end of the interview process—often at the end of the second interview. What interviewees must know, however, is that some search firms advise their clients to first consider internal candidates for job positions; that lowers the risk of a bad hire. The argument is made that all job candidates try to show themselves in a positive light; a company just knows more about an internal candidate than an outside one.

Adkins, C. L., Russell, C. J., & James, D. (1994, Autumn). Judgments of fit in the selection process: The role of work value congruence. *Personnel Psychology,* 47, 605–623; Overman, S. (1994, September). Hiring: The inside track. *HR Magazine,* 39, 54–57.

Introduction (about 2 to 5 minutes)

- Interviewer seeks to put candidate at ease: chitchat, casual talk about personal information on resume.
- Candidate tries to make positive up-front impression: smile, handshake, sense of enthusiasm.

Company Information (about 5 to 10 minutes)

- Interviewer may indicate type of positions available, some information about the company.
- Candidate suggests a high degree of interest in the company, in the position.

Candidate Assessment (about 10 to 20 minutes)

- Interviewer tries to assess the qualifications of the candidate: What are his or her strengths and weaknesses?
- Candidate employs data, evidence: via goals, skills, accomplishments, interests, and personal values. Relates these data to skills learned in school and the world of work.
- Questions: during this period a variety of questions, challenges, testing of the candidate occurs. Possible questions are on pages 536 and 537 of this chapter.

Conclusion (about 1 or 2 minutes)

- Interviewer determines ending to interview: suggests when an answer will be forthcoming.
- Candidate tries to: summarize his or her qualifications, reaffirm interest in the company and position, and express appreciation for the interview.

Activity During the Interview

Both oral and nonverbal cues are important in the early part of an interview.

Some points in the above chronology apply here. Significantly, the first few moments are critical. Make eye contact immediately, begin courteously, show en-

Checklist 19.2 Positive and Negative Behavior During an Interview

Positive, Desirable Behavior

1. *Show enthusiasm, vitality, interest.* You can do so by the alert way you sit and look, by facial expressions, by the questions you ask, and by the answers you give.
2. *Be honest.* State your data clearly, without exaggeration.
3. *Listen attentively, concentrate.* Do not interrupt. Let the interviewer finish. Then try to link your achievements with your answer.
4. *Keep answers brief.* The more answers you provide, the more varied the information you can give about yourself.
5. *Show interest in the company.* Here, too, tactfully relate your achievements to your future employer's needs.
6. *Show analytical skills.* Organize your answers, take time to comment on both pros and cons, short- and long-term benefits.

Negative Factors to Avoid

1. *Discourtesy.* Avoid first names, doodling, disinterest.
2. *Jargon, slang.* This is not the time to project an image that you are hip, cool, or tuned in to the jargon of youth.
3. *Overaggressive or cynical attitude.* Avoid the superiority complex and "know-it-all" attitude.
4. *Unfavorable comments.* Focus on the positive. Omit criticisms of former professors, colleagues, other employers.
5. *Disregard for positive factors.* If you put the words "failure to" before each of the six suggestions for positive behavior, you will have a total of 11 in this list of negatives to avoid.

thusiasm, give a firm handshake. To make the best impression—verbal and nonverbal—be aware of some commonsense positive and negative behavior as noted in Checklist 19.2.

Answering or Asking Questions During the Interview

It is hard to predict which questions will occur in your interview or even the time of day for your meeting. Each interviewer has a set of favorite questions, and the time of day may be set by the school or according to the convenience of the company. Time periods are as variable as the kinds of questions asked. Our list of 25 favorite questions and statements is a composite from many sources:

1. Where do you expect to be in 5 years?
2. Give me a list of your strengths and weaknesses.

Communication Probe

Interviewees should feel encouraged: In a study of over 800 employee performance interviews, there was no correlation between the time of day for the applications and the ratings of those applicants. Likert scales, used in the study, verified the conclusion noted above. And as other studies have noted, preparation on the part of the interviewee, regardless of the time of the day, is more important. For instance, one researcher suggests that financial management people will face these five tough questions: How can the candidate help the organization and increase its revenue? Which goals did the candidate set in the last job and how were they achieved? What opinion does the candidate have of a vice president who requests more money for employees? In which area is personal improvement still needed? How is the candidate preparing for impending reform in the industry?

Willihnganz, M. A., & Myers, L. S. (1993, Winter). Effects of time or day on interview performance. *Public Personnel Management,* 22(4), 545–550; Reticker, P. (1993, September). The five toughest interview questions. *Healthcare Financial Management,* 47(9), 82–84.

3. When have you successfully motivated others over whom you had no authority or power?
4. What do you think it takes to be successful in this position?
5. Why should we hire you rather than someone else?
6. Tell me about your work experience. What did you accomplish?
7. What typical role did you play in your school groups? What evidence do you have for that statement?
8. Give me three reasons why you are interested in our company.
9. How well do you work with teams and other people; what evidence do you have that you were successful in a group?
10. How is the job search going? Who else have you spoken with?
11. Which course did you like best? Least? Why?
12. If you were starting your schooling over, which courses would you add to your program?
13. Describe the kind of boss you prefer.
14. What personal characteristics are necessary for success in your field?
15. Give me an example of a situation which upset you in either your school or your place of work.
16. What do you know about our company?

17. Do you prefer working alone or with others?
18. Which of your college years was the most difficult?
19. Can you get recommendations from all your previous employers?
20. Do you like routine work?
21. Define cooperation for me.
22. Give me an example of an analytical mind.
23. What was the last book you read?
24. What is your major weakness?
25. What are the disadvantages of your chosen field?

Regardless of your preparation, there will be some unexpected questions. Pause, try to organize your answer, and then offer it with a high degree of confidence. You could also refer to your resume, using it as support for your oral comments.

"Bridging" Confrontational and Unfair Preemployment Questions

Be careful in handling questions that you feel border on being discriminatory or confrontational.

Most interviews—both the initial screening interview and a later follow-up with more people—will be direct. The questions will sincerely seek information related to the job. Occasionally, to test your poise under pressure, you may receive a confrontational question; you also may be asked an unfair preemployment inquiry that may be illegal if used for discrimination.

Confrontational Questions

Some interviewees have returned from interviews wilted. They allege that the interviews were confrontational, that the interviewers were abusive, abrupt, and discourteous. However, the interviewers may have been testing the applicants' confidence under pressure, how they handled a tense situation. Tough questions should not necessarily be considered a personal attack.

Preparing for some tough interview questions is similar to preparing for a TV interview. Leading executives spend considerable time and effort preparing for potentially hostile questions, using some of the same techniques you can use in your interview. Try to rehearse or hold a short mock interview for potentially negative questions. Try to bridge to a response that keeps you in control. The key word here is "bridge," using terms such as the following to move from a confrontational question to a more positive response:

- "There may be some truth in that statement [*bridge*], but my data and information lead to a different conclusion."
- "Certainly others have the right to their opinion [*bridge*]. My opinion is this . . ."
- "That's an interesting comment [*bridge*]. A more complete analysis would include information discovered in my investigations."

In each case, you bridge to information you wish to speak about, avoiding a direct confrontation with a potentially negative and hostile question. Here are a few other questions that require tactful, honest answers:

Question	Answer
"How come your grades are lower than average?"	"What the grades do not reflect are the nonclassroom leadership positions I held on several committees. Also, to help pay college expenses I worked on part-time jobs—as shown in my resume."
"Some people feel M.B.A.s are arrogant and only concerned with the buck."	"That attitude, I know, is held by some people, including the press. In my opinion we cannot put all M.B.A. degree candidates into the same mold. . . ."
"What's your greatest weakness?"	"I approach everything I do with a great deal of enthusiasm. But out of my love for work comes a bit of impatience. May I give you a complete incident . . . ?"

Even with the negative, risky question about your weakness, you can focus on the positive—determination to improve your strong qualities further—or perhaps mention a non-job-related trait that needs improvement. It is desirable for you to try to turn a potentially negative situation into a positive one.

Unfair Preemployment Questions

Laws in the United States prohibit employment questions that discriminate on the basis of race, color, religion, sex, handicaps, and national origins. (Appendix C is a discussion of fair and unfair preemployment questions relating to 19 topics.) Nevertheless, if you are asked an "unfair preemployment question," you

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As you have prepared for the interview, including both friendly and unfriendly questions, so too has your interviewer. Some interviewers come with a prepared list of questions. Some do the following: (1) They search for qualifiers, such as "knowledge of"; (2) they try not to read more into a resume than is there; and (3) they search for signs of self-reliance and initiative. Additionally, some interviewers actually write in advance the kind of answer to be expected from their questions; the authors call this an additional test of the candidate.

Hackney, M., & Kleiner, B. (1994, November). Conducting an effective selection interview. *Work Study, 43,* 8–13.

may answer it if doing so will not be disadvantageous to you. If your reply could hurt your chances of getting a job, tactfully decline answering.

Questioning the Interviewer

Preparing a few of your own questions in advance is a sure sign to the interviewer that you are organized and interested in the position.

A sure sign that the interview is coming to a close is when the interviewer asks if you have any questions. We recommend preparing several in advance. But it's your call what those specfic questions might be, as for example:

- What kind of person fits in with your company?
- Give me a little information about why the last person in the position left.
- For a person who works effectively in this job, what is the next step in the advancement process?

And so on. One final comment. If you do not get a job offer, do not discuss salary or fringes. However, if you are offered a position on the spot, that is the time to discuss salary and fringes. We discuss the issue of negotiating beginning on page 552.

SUCCESSFUL FOLLOW-UP MESSAGES AFTER THE INTERVIEW

Following any interview, immediately jot down some notes of the meeting, for instance, in reference to some of the following:

- What were some significant facts you learned about the company?
- Which questions did you have trouble answering?
- Which of your own selling points did you leave out?
- How well do you feel you did in the interview?

Candidate to Employer (Eleven Sample Letters)

To improve your chances for securing the job for which you interviewed, we recommend you contact the interviewer in person, by letter, by phone, or E-mail. Of the three approaches, the letter is the most effective because employers analyze applicants' qualifications at their convenience. A well-written letter—if done successfully—can strengthen your chances of obtaining the position.

The Initial Follow-Up to an Interview

Regardless of how the interview went, it is courteous and in your interest to write the interviewer a note of thanks.

Remember that your interviewer may have spoken with many people; your task is to keep yourself, although out of sight, not out of mind. Within 2 to 5 days after the interview, send a thank-you note. Such a thank-you note is short, probably no longer than four paragraphs. See Checklist 19.3 for a summary of major points.

After reading the checklist, review the following two examples. Note the brevity of each, the careful attention to courtesy and politeness.

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An interesting ethical/legal issue arises when an interviewee desires to see some of the resumes of current employees. He or she may allege they have nothing but honorable intentions: to seek additional sources in order to make an informed decision as to whether to join a firm or not. Survey data suggest that one-half of the current managers had no problem with exposing their resumes to job seekers; others objected because they felt it was an invasion of their privacy. The researchers conclude that viewing resumes might give the job seekers a stronger negotiating position and help them decide on their job choice.

Pesek, J. G., & Fulmer, W. E. (1991, Summer). The flip side of recruitment, allow job candidates to view current employees' resumes. *Journal of Applied Business Research, 7*, (3), 1–7.

MESSAGE 1 Sample of a foreign student's response. *Note the subtle style (extreme courtesy) differences in this letter from western letters.*

Dear Mr. Salaam,

Attention opening

Informative, enjoyable exciting. Those words capture the pleasure I had yesterday in interviewing for the position of Construction Management Assistant in [*company name*]. Thank you for your personal courtesies.

Review of related job exerience

My enthusiasm for the position and the company continues, today more than ever. As I reviewed your future strategic plan, there is no doubt that exploration for new deposits in Latin America will continue. That pleases me because my previous work in Indonesia-as you know for a gold mining firm-has parallels in difficulty and opportunities. My work background in my former field has prepared me well for work in your emerging and growing field.

Review of academic training

As my resume indicates, I went to college in the U.K. That preparation exposed me to the English language which I had to learn for six years in my grade school. I mention that because learning languages has been comfortable for me. Thus, learning Spanish seems like a small hurdle on the way to beginning a successful Construction Manager. With eagerness I would immediately begin my study of Spanish.

Checklist 19.3 Initial Follow-Up After an Interview

1. *Opening paragraph:* Express appreciation and gratitude for having been granted the interview.

2. *Middle paragraphs:* Any or all of the following ideas can be incorporated into the middle of the note.
   - **a.** State how you now feel about the position.
   - **b.** Add new material that may have been omitted or left out.
   - **c.** Include some new facts if you sensed the interviewer's concern about certain of your qualifications.
   - **d.** Mention your favorable reaction to some points mentioned in the interview.
   - **e.** Highlight the qualifications discussed in the interview.

3. *Last paragraph:*
   - **a.** Offer to send any additional information.
   - **b.** Suggest that you are willing to come to a second interview.
   - **c.** Indicate that you feel your qualifications fit the job requirements.
   - **d.** Mention you're looking forward to a favorable decision.

Courteous close

Mr. Salaam, you will find, I believe, that I can develop into one of your senior Construction Managers. That is my personal goal. With eagerness I would welcome that opportunity.

Yours Faithfully,

MESSAGE 2

A sample BBA letter after an interview. *The position here is for the position of a hospital's Senior Gift Coordinator.*

Dear Ms. Lawson:

Polite, direct opening

Your interview with me on February 2 regarding the position of Small Gifts Coordinator was appreciated. You also requested that I get two persons from my university to send a letter of support. I therefore have asked Professor Wayne Stume of our Accounting Department and Ms. Timmie Mead of the University's Donor's Office to send you a note within

Communication Probe

As U.S. colleges and universities more carefully prepare their students for more global interactions, there are more opportunities for those students to interview for jobs with foreign companies. Indeed, several years ago (1990) the U.S. Department of Labor estimated that foreign companies employed more than 4.7 million people in the United States. Thus, whether one will work for that foreign company abroad or in the United States requires—according to one researcher—raising issues such as the following: the company's motivations, the extent of travel, the goals of the foreign company in the United States. One of the best ways to determine the foreign company's motivations is to speak with Americans already working within that company.

Ellis, N. (1993, Fall). The American, an alien in a foreign country? *Baylor Business Review, 11,* 30–31.

the next few days. Both were eager to do so.

Addition of new facts

Omitted in our discussion was the fact that I also ushered at university fund-raising events. These occasions brought me into contact with many donors who have contributed to our various schools and colleges. There I learned from senior fund-raisers about organization, tact, politeness, all ingredients needed in your position of Small Gifts Coordinator.

Review of personal capabilities

With pleasure I noted that you mentioned the position demanded close contacts with the city. My Rotary Scholarship and my local church scholarship both demanded reports to several groups within the city. Both groups spoke highly of my presentations and both offered me financial support. My resume also indicates that I was born in this city; that fact along with my family's long ties here suggest my deep commitment to remaining in this area.

Polite, easy action ending

I look forward to your favorable decision. You will, I assure you, be pleased with my work.

Letters do get lost in the mails; feel free to inquire if you did not receive a response to your cover letter and resume.

The Inquiry About a Cover Letter and Resume

You are justified in sending a follow-up note if after 3 weeks you have received no response to a request or cold job application letter. Such a letter may have been lost, or it may be the intent of the receiver not to respond—as in some Pa-

cific Rim countries, where a forthright negative response is avoided. Regardless of the motivation, you have the right to inquire.

Such an inquiry letter is short. You simply ask, "Did you receive my letter and resume?" Of course you could include identification of the job, the date of your cover letter and accompanying resume, your continuing interest in the position, highlights of the previous letter, and your address, telephone, fax number, or E-mail. Both the following letters move deductively, the core idea occurring up front.

MESSAGE 3 Short inquiry about previously sent cover letter and resume. *This example identifies and reviews date of earlier communication.*

Dear Mr. Tong,

Direct request

My notes tell me that I sent you a letter and resume for the position of Account Executive on October 21, 199-. My interest in the position still remains strong. My inquiry is whether you received this material.

Willingness to send more data

If you do not have any of my material in your file, I will be pleased to send you additional and updated information. Certainly I could come in for an interview whenever you suggest.

MESSAGE 4 Short inquiry letter about earlier sent cover letter and resume. *This example reviews date of earlier communication and goes further by summarizing the qualifications of the applicant.*

Dear Ms. Steffie:

Opening gives precise dates

Things have a way of getting lost in the mails; perhaps that's what happened to my cover letter and resume sent you on July 25, 199-. My notes were in response to the vacancy of Executive Secretary posted in the *Tribune* of July 20, 199-.

In those materials I noted these points:

Summary of earlier note

-Knowledge of Word Perfect, Windows, and Multimate software packages.
-Work in several offices with several kinds of PCs.
-Employment as a staff secretary for a vice president at a local electric utility.
-Arranger of many private and public functions for executive officers and the Board of Directors.

Polite close

With those qualifications and others mentioned in my resume, I know I could fulfill the position of executive secretary. If you wish further information, I would be pleased to respond.

Other Follow-Up Messages from Applicant to Employer

MESSAGE 5 Request to keep information on file. *Such a note is usually sent when you are told there is no current vacancy for the position you seek.*

Dear Mr. Wilson:

Polite request for future opportunity

Thank you for reviewing my credentials for the position of Food and Beverage Manager.

Please do this: keep my records on file. While I know there is currently no open position, there may be that opportunity in the future. At that time I would like to be considered.

Thank you for your courtesy.

MESSAGE 6 Reply to letter requesting additional information. *This example concerns a request for information about school records, especially the low grades in certain courses.*

Dear Ms. Lim:

Here is my response to your request as to why certain grades were lower than average in my courses in voice theory and music theory.

Responses for variances

Enclosed with my explanation is a letter from my voice theory professor. She points out-as you will see in reading the letter-that only in one area of theory did I have a weakness, and that was corrected during a special make-up class during the summer.

Truthful

To be honest, I just blew the exam question when it was given. I knew that, and made quick arrangements for the special summer class.

Additional explanation

The class in music theory is another story. With honesty I must say that the semester in which I took the course, I came down with a severe case of mono. That sounds like a trivial excuse, but the illness took me out of school for two

weeks, with lingering effects for several weeks thereafter. Fortunately, other courses that followed that course, and that depended on music theory, were much improved.

In brief, in both instances I was aware of needed improvements-and took steps to achieve them. Such determination, I assure you, would continue in my desire to work in the music program of your school system.

MESSAGE 7 Follow-up letter if no reply occurs after inteview. *Give an adequate amount of time (perhaps two weeks) for a response. But if you do not receive a response by a promised date, you can write.*

Polite reminder

Two-and-a-half weeks have passed since my interview with you about the position of Small Business Loan Officer. At that time you said you'd notify me of your decision by [*date*].

Continued interest

Sadly, I have not heard from you. In the meantime another savings institution has expressed deep interest in my joining their firm. Before giving them a response, I would like to know whether you have reached a decision on my candidacy for your position.

Continued interest

My personal desire is to work for your savings institution. And I'd like a reply before [*date*]. You can reach me during the daytime at [*number*] and in the evenings at [*number*].

MESSAGE 8 Request to delay a decision. *Occasionally you need more time to accept or reject a job offer; be forthright in requesting a delay.*

Positive opening

I'm honored that you have extended a job offer to me. Such a positive response has put excitement in my life, and certainly in our family.

Appeal to fairness

Your request that I arrive at a job decision within the next two weeks is difficult for me. Forthrightly, I must say that promises to two other firms-made at the same time I agreed to meet with you-to interview with them makes it impossible to respond within your time frame. It would be unfair to all parties if my word cannot be trusted.

Precise action desired

I ask for an extention of two weeks from your requested date. Please let me know if that extension of time is possible. I would be grateful for a positive response to my request.

MESSAGE 9 Acceptance of job offer. *Although this is an easy letter to write, keep in mind that certain details need to be mentioned: Identify the job you're accepting; give details about moving, about reporting to work; request any forms required for salary and benefits; end with a statement of pleasure in working for the firm. A follow-up phone call also verifies what is mentioned in the letter.*

Immediate decision statement

With pleasure I accept the position of Sales Trainee in your [*name*] Department.

Details

Since I graduate on June 6, 199-, my spouse and I plan to be in your city one month later, July 6, 199-. We plan to take a two-week vacation and to locate living accommodations in [*city*]. I will report to work on Monday, July 7. This note simply confirms what we discussed orally when I accepted your offer.

Agreement statement

May I also confirm that our agreed-upon year's salary was $[*amount*] and that additional health and insurance forms will be sent me at my address noted above.

Polite close

With sincere pleasure I look forward to joining your company. Such a challenge is accepted with enthusiasm.

MESSAGE 10 Message of resignation from present position. *Ideally, your current employer would have been contacted prior to your sending any resignation letter. It is recommended to date the resignation letter at least two weeks before your departure.*

Early statement of decision

This note confirms that I will be accepting the position of Assistant Engineer in International Products in [*city*]. My reporting date to that firm will be on September 4. Please consider my resignation to be effective as of August 16.

Positive details

Certainly you can count on me to assist my successor in every way. And even after leaving the company, should there be any additional questions, I will be happy to reply.

Positive ending

Personally, as I have told you, my wife and I have been pleased with [*name of*

company]. We have spent six fruitful years here; we leave with mixed feelings for our many friends. Thank you for your concern and interest over the years.

MESSAGE 11 Rejection of job offer. *Usually the organization of a rejection-of-job letter is buffer, explanation, refusal, and a positive ending. In the following example note the tactful tone, sincerity, positive approach, and genuine compliment to the firm.*

Dear Ms. Ong:

Buffer

You have been consistently helpful to me during the last series of interviews with your company. For that I'm personally grateful.

Buffer plus details

As you know, I've been speaking with other firms over the past couple of months. Fortunately, both you and another firm have offered me a job. Because my qualifications, interest, and background fit in more closely with the other job, I have sent them my acceptance.

Positive ending

In no way does my decision reflect a negative impression of you or your company. You took time to meet with me, and you were gracious in answering all my questions. I'll consistently think of you as a company where management is concerned with people.

Thank you for your consideration.

Employer to Candidate (Seven Sample Letters)

Employers or interviewers face similar decisions: What kind of communication to send the candidate after an interview.

There may be a time when you will be on the other side of the interviewing process: You will have to communicate with the interviewee. Several instances of such communication are now noted.

MESSAGE 1 Invitation to interviewee to visit company. *A major intent, clearly, of a request to interview is to make the reader feel he or she is desired for a personal interview.*

Dear Mr. Harris:

Clearly opening request

This note confirms my telephone call of Thursday, April 6, inviting you to visit

with us in our company facilities at our head office on April 15.

Details In order for us to make arrangements for your visit and plans for meeting several other persons on the staff, we ask that you return the enclosed card or fax us a response at (313) 555-8824.

Details Certainly you will receive reimbursement for all air travel to [*city*] and return, as well as for all incidental expenses. If you have questions, you can call my secretary (Ms. Jody Hannecker) at (313) 555-1277.

Courteous close We sincerely look forward to your visit on April 15.

MESSAGE 2 Invitation for a company visit after initial campus interview. *In the popular language of campuses, these second requests for attending an interview are referred to as "fly backs."*

Dear Arlene:

As you know, other members of my office and I were on your campus Thursday and Friday of last week.

Up-front request With pleasure we invite you to visit with us at our company headquarters in [*city*] on Tuesday, June 16, to continue our discussions. Our initial plans would have you beginning your visit at 9:00 a.m. in my office to set out the agenda for the day.

Details Such a plan means you would have to arrive by the evening of June 15. Therefore, we have reservations for you at the Park Plaza Hotel; all airport cabs know the location of that hotel.

Details It's your decision whether you wish to return to your hometown after our meetings on June 16. Our plan is to conclude our meetings around 4:00 p.m. on that day.

We look forward to meeting with you.

These two letters illustrate the kinds of messages sent to candidates to visit the company, but there are five other kinds of notes you might write after an interview. As the candidate is polite in his or her notes, so too you must be polite in

requesting further information, offering a position, granting a time extension, rejecting a candidate, and replying to a candidate's acceptance.

MESSAGE 3 Request for further information. *Even though cover letters have been sent and resumes completed, additional questions may arise out of that printed information.*

Dear Marilyn:

Warm, courteous opening

Your resume was quite complete and we enjoyed the brief phone conversation. Still, there are a few questions to which we'd like some answers.

You can respond to the following two questions, either via fax or a brief note:

Precise listing of issues

-Tell us more about your summer visits to Argentina. Were these visits school-related? Work-related? Casual visits?
-We'd like to know some of the major topics discussed in your English Language Institute Training sessions. Were you the instructor or a member of the class?

We thank you for your continuing interest in [*name of firm*]; we look forward to hearing from you within the next week.

MESSAGE 4 Offer of a job. *Clearly, this is a comfortable letter to write: It brings good news. In the opening paragraph identify the job and state the salary. In later paragraphs, you might try to anticipate any questions the candidate might have. Also, you could leave the door open for the candidate to ask further questions (usuaully via phone) before making a decision. Be precise by when you need an answer.*

Dear Mr. Lipnick:

Positive first news

With pleasure we offer you the position of assistant legal counsel in our firm at a yearly starting salary of $[*amount*], that position to begin November 1, 199-.

Elaboration of details

We will pay all moving expenses associated with your move, and a member of our Human Resorces Department will assist you in locating housing.

Thank you for the interest you already have shown in our company. We hope you

will decide to make your career with us. If you or members of your family have questions concerning our offer or other questions, please call Ms. Dee Rant in our personnel office at (123) 555-4586. She, or a member of her staff, will respond to any further questions.

We sincerely hope you will join us for a rewarding career.

MESSAGE 5 Grant of a time extension. *Sound reasons are valid for you to consider in extending more time to consider an offer. Often such discussions are held over the phone. However, if you write a note, grant the request in the first paragraph, suggest the cutoff date, express interest in the candidate, and end on a friendly note.*

Dear Pauline:

Early statement granting request

As you asked, we will grant you additional time to decide whether you want to accept our previous offer to work with us. We wish you to know, however, that you continue to be our most desired person to fulfill the position of Purchasing Manager.

Precision on date

We need to know your decision as soon as possible. To be precise, we would like your response by June 15, just about three weeks from now.

Warm ending

Again, you are well qualified for our open position. Our management staff eagerly looks forward to your positive response.

Please call me at (123) 555-7899 if you have additional questions.

MESSAGE 6 Message conveying decision not to hire. *Here the tone of your refusal is important, for you do not wish the candidate to leave with a negative impression of the company. All candidates desire factual, straightforward answers; this is not the time for falsehoods or discourteous statements. Your organization is that of a bad-news letter. Begin with a buffer, suggest an explanation, state the refusal, and end with a wish for the candidate's success.*

Dear Mr. Slovack:

Buffer

Thank you for spending time with us at the on-campus interview and here at our company.

Buffer plus explanation

Your credentials are impressive, your educational background is first-rate, and your aptitude scores were high, along with the other candidates we interviewed. Our staff feels one of the other candidates' qualifications would more closely fit in with our requirements.

Positive comment

That preceding statement is not a negative. It simply suggests you have admirable qualifications, but at this time we need a closer fit between previous experience and the open position.

Courteous close

Please accept our gratitude for the time you spent with us. We sincerely wish you success in your chosen field.

MESSAGE 7 Reply to candidate's acceptance. *This is an easy note to write: It is all good news, it is all positive, it is short. It is a brief statement that allows for a paper trail, a legal recognition that you have received the candidate's acceptance letter.*

Dear Ulga:

Positive opening

Vielen Dank! All of us are pleased that you have agreed to join us in Rüsselsheim at the [*name of foreign company*].

Additional good news

One additional surprise: We have agreed to pay for a visit to Germany for you and your spouse in order that both of you can begin a housing search in this area. Ms. Helga Brewer-Special Assistant to our Aufsichtsrat-will contact you by phone to make all those special arrangements.

We look forward to your joining us.

SUCCESSFUL NEGOTIATING

Being personally satisfied, being at ease with a compromise is a valuable lesson in negotiation.

As the following probe suggests, take time to review the salary and benefits package of comparable positions before you begin an interview. Most often on a college campus no financial details are confirmed in an initial meeting; that comes later, usually after a second interview and if you receive a job offer.

Most likely the individual who was the lead interviewer of the human resource manager will first make an oral offer. Remember, this is only the first step. Usually such a verbal (oral) offer mentions the starting salary, a signing bonus (if any), the job title, basic benefits, and possibly the person to whom you will report and a suggested starting date. The person making this initial verbal offer then has the responsibility of sending a formal, written description of the offer.

Communication Probe

As with preparing the cover letter, the resume, and the interview, similar effort must also go into the job negotiation process. To come in cold into an interview—with little preconception of salary or benefits—is to risk losing a position. Lawyers and law firms are especially adept at negotiation; they realize the value of research, facts, and investigation in order to prove and justify any decision. Such preparation is needed by everyone in the negotiation process. Several suggestions are recommended: Let the interviewer mention the salary issue first, be aware that a lower salary offer implies negotiation is in order, realize that benefits are a part of the salary package, and establish a firm date for resolving the salary issue. Furthermore, candidates should approach negotiation with a win-win attitude; they will have a better chance of success.

Estrin, C. (1992, May/June). Negotiating salaries: the undeclared war. *Legal Assistant Today, 9,* 136–139.

Basic Preparation for Negotiating the Job Offer

Spend time in gathering comparative financial and benefit information in order to present your most forceful arguments for your position.

The more data you possess prior to negotiating, the better equipped you will be for arriving at a package desirable to you—and acceptable to your new employer. Sources for your information will vary. We believe it is easier to locate information about job salaries in the United States than in other parts of the world where salary information is highly confidential. Word of mouth and frank talk with human resource personnel overseas can dislodge some hidden comparative salary and benefit information for Asia and Europe.

Regardless of your location, collect as much valid (not hearsay) information as possible before making a final decision. Sources to which you might turn include the following:

1. Alumni, fellow classmates. Be sure you have true evidence. Have a clear idea as to ranges for various positions.
2. Placement reports. Most large business schools publish employment data from the previous year's class. The following is simply a listing of major headings used in the University of Michigan's Business School Office of Career Development; headings are identical for a section on full-time positions and a section on internship positions:

The University of Michigan Business School 199- Overview

199- Michigan MBA Profile and Review

Acceptances by Industry (13 major service and manufacturing categories)

Service	*Median Salary ($ for each category)*	*Salary Range ($ ranges for each category)*

Manufacturing	*Median Salary (\$ for each category)*	*Salary Range (\$ ranges for each category)*

Acceptances by Function (21 major categories)

Median Salary	*Salary Range*

Acceptances by Geographic Region (8 national/international locations)

Median Salary	*Salary Range*

Acceptances by Undergraduate Degree (7 major degree categories)

Median Salary	*Salary Range*

Companies Hiring 3 or more MBA Students

3. Your own resume. Be prepared to cite your own credentials for the position: Review your related work experience, your academic achievements relevant to the position, your special skills.

The *National Business Employment Weekly* is a "must read" document prior to beginning a negotiating session.

4. *National Business Employment Weekly.* Go to your library or your placement office and ask to see printed data for various sections of the country. Therein you will see headings as cost-of-living comparisons between various U.S. cities; city-by-city index of costs; local and state tax burdens; estimated major taxes for a family of four; and sources of articles relating to salaries in various functional areas.

Basic Issues in Negotiating the Job Offer

Unless some of the following issues were discussed in the interviews, you have every right to be clear on issues such as the following, depending on the level at which you enter the company:

1. Your total compensation package
   - **a.** Cash issues
     Starting base pay and salary range of position
     Bonus for signing (if any) and how paid
     Stock options (if any) or profit sharing or other payments
     Salary review schedule
     Percent of salary matched by the firm
   - **b.** Fringe or other benefits issues
     Vacation payments, length of vacations
     Car, auto expenses
     Club memberships
     Health care issues: long-term disability, accident insurance, dental plan, death benefits, sick leave, health insurance, and persons covered by insurance
     Discounts on purchase of employer products
     Life insurance
     Recreation programs

2. Your position
   Extent of your authority, members of your staff
   Statement of your precise responsibilities
   Individual to whom you will report
   Range of your budget
   Title of the position

3. Your work environment
   What is the precise location of my job?
   What are the expected hours of work during the day and week?
   What are the resources, supplies, facilities?
   What is the work culture of the company?
   What is the business language of the company? (More an issue if the company is located overseas)

4. Your beginning/ending work benefits
   Starting date of the new position
   Housing assistance: disposal of former residence and acquiring another
   Relocating assistance from current to new location: travel, moving charges (highly important when working with an employer overseas)

If at all possible, carry out negotiations orally. Submitting something in writing is fine, but your oral and nonverbal behavior is also persuasive.

It is more desirable to carry out your negotiations orally rather than in writing. Doing so gives you the power of both oral and nonverbal persuasion to accompany your credentials. Some people would have you believe there is a set formula for negotiating success, but it is not that simple. Be fair; listen to the other side; come prepared with arguments for your position. Have your facts straight; know in advance your top or bottom final position.

Checklist 19.4 Successfully Negotiating a Job Offer

1. *Prepare carefully:* Gather information from alumni, friends, placement reports, your own resume, and national publications as The *National Business Employment Weekly.*

2. *Know specific data:* Collect reliable information about the median and range of salaries in your functional area, your industry, and even your geographic area of the country.

3. *Organize negotiating plan into four parts:*
   a. Compensation issues as cash and fringe benefits
   b. Position within the company
   c. Environment of the company
   d. Beginning and ending of work benefits

If you feel you are being hurried into a decision, negotiate immediately for an extension of time. It is better to delay a decision rather than to rush into one that you later will regret. Once a decision is made on the final offer, send your acceptance immediately.

SUMMARY

Of all the things you will experience in life, few surpass the importance of the job interview; a successful one can literally position you on a career path for the rest of your life. Remember these 10 points: Know yourself, your resume, the company, the job position, some questions and answers, the importance of both oral and nonverbal communication, the meeting details, basic salary ranges, and the need to rehearse.

After the interview, it is good policy to write a thank-you note. Later, if you have not had any response as based on the interview, you have every right to send a follow-up letter. Additionally, the chapter offered basic letters for reference: requesting a company to keep information on file, replying to questions for additional information, sending follow-up notes if there was no reply after an interview, asking for a delay in a job decision, accepting an offer, resigning from one's present position, and rejecting a job offer.

Employers also need to send follow-up messages to job candidates. These include invitations to visit a company for an initial interview, requests to visit the company on a "fly back" after a campus interview, inquiries to candidates for additional information, suggestions for the basic salary package along with the job, responses to a request for additional time in making a decision, agreements to a time extension, words that gracefully convey a decision not to hire someone, and replies to a candidate's acceptance.

If all your preparations for landing a job were successful, one final stage has to be realized: negotiating your final compensation package. Here—as in preparing your cover letter, writing your resume, or interviewing—prepare carefully. Know salary ranges, medians, benefits for your functional area, your industry, and your geographic area. Your data must be accurate when taken from alumni, placement reports, your own qualifications, and national publications.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***International Interview Comparisons.*** Question 1, Chapter 18, suggested interviewing foreign students from your classes to determine differences in resume preparation. Question 1 here asks you to do something similar: Review with foreign students the process of interviewing as followed in the United States and then ask for their responses to the following questions:

   - How are job candidates requested to come for an interview in the foreign students' homeland? Is this done by letter, a phone call, or the human resources office?
   - What are some of the questions raised in the interview?

- Who conducts the interview?
- How are they informed about the results of the interview?

2. ***Follow-Up Messages Comparison.*** Western multinational companies in other parts of the world follow a similar interview and follow-up message pattern as in their home country. Search out a foreign student who interviewed with a nonwestern multinational company. Then ask him or her the following:

   - What differences did they see in format, style, or substance in the kind of communication they received as compared with that in the United States?
   - Do the similarities outweigh the differences between the U.S. method of replying with their home country?

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Research into International or Local U.S. Firm Before Interview.*** Choose a company with which you would like to interview. Then study as much material as you can about that company—from sources suggested in this chapter. Your goal is to be able to respond to many of the questions as cited on pages 536 and 537.

4. ***Inquiry in Response to the Following Job Posting.*** Here are the precise qualifications for the position of part-time editor at a local company. Write a cover letter to go with your resume as you apply for the position, which requires these qualifications:

   - Extensive writing and editing experience
   - Demonstrated ability to write for professional and lay audiences
   - Knowledge of business issues and vocabulary
   - Knowledge of the local library system
   - Ability to work with little supervision

5. ***Conducting a Mock Interview.*** To do this assignment successfully requires two persons conducting research on the same company. Select a teammate; study as much information about a company as possible; hold a mock interview before the class with one student acting as the interviewer and the other the interviewee. Have the class critique the interview on criteria such as the following: courtesy toward one another, oral and nonverbal skills of each person, knowledge of the company, appropriateness of the questions, and other incidents noteworthy of comment.

6. ***Follow-Up Letter(s) After an Interview.*** Assume you were interviewed by a national company on your college campus. All went well—at least from your point of view. During the interview you discussed your qualifications, your interviewer mentioned the company's basic policies, the range of salaries for the open position, and other relevant information. Write a follow-up note for one (or each) of the following outcomes:

   a. At the end of the interview she told you she would notify you of her decision.

b. At the end of the interview she said you should put down in writing the reasons why you feel you are qualified for the position.

c. At the end of the interview she said that your work experience gave her the impression you were overqualified for the position. Write her a note indicating how you would handle this negative observation.

7. ***Inquiry About Application Letter and Resume.*** Assume you mailed a response to the above job posting several weeks ago but have received no response. Send an inquiry to the company.

8. ***Your Acceptance and Refusal Letters.*** Assume you received two job offers for a career job.

   a. Write the acceptance message to the firm of your choice.

   b. Write the refusal letter to the other firm.

9. ***Rejection Letter from Employer to Candidate.*** You have made the decision to hire another person for the position of internal auditor. Five persons applied for the position; three have already been notified of their unacceptability based on lack of experience. One has been notified that she will be hired. You have a last letter to write; you do so based on the following brief notes taken during the interview:

   - Friendly and personable young man
   - Courteous, polite, well-groomed
   - Superior in oral communication skills
   - May not wish to move to [*city*].
   - Perhaps does not wish to continue in accounting work
   - Not quite clear as to his future

10. ***Negotiating a Job Offer.*** Assume you have received a written offer for a position for which you applied. The offer made to you was $5,000 less than you had expected. In order to write an effective negotiation letter back to the company you must first (1) choose the city where the company is located; (2) choose the functional area in which you desire to work; (3) choose the industry in which your functional area is found. Then assemble as much information as the following in stating your cause in the form of a follow-up letter:

    - Median or average salary for persons of your experience
    - Median or average salary for the geographical area you have selected
    - Cost of living for the geographical area you have selected
    - Median or average salary for your selected industry
    - Median or average salary for your selected functional area.

11. ***Listing of Benefits to Consider When Negotiating a Position.*** This chapter gave you an initial idea as to various benefits possibly available with many job positions. Review the list of possible benefits on pages 554 and 555, and compile a rank-order list from 1 (high) to 10 (low) of those benefits you consider the most important. Defend your rankings before the class or compare how others have done for this exercise.

REFERENCES

1. Bulkeley, W. M. (1994, August 22). Replaced by technology: Job interviews. *Wall Street Journal,* pp. B1, B4.

2. Three large networks currently have the most members seeking new jobs: Exec-U-Net of Norwalk CT; the Search Bulletin of Great Falls VA; and NetShare of Novato CA. By subscribing to these networks you receive mailings from the service, which has several hundred job listings. Information included is job title, job description, salary, benefits, and other details. When in doubt about the listing, a potential respondent may call the job-search service to verify specific contact information. [See Lancaster, H. (1995, February 7). Managing your career.] When taking a tip from a job network, proceed with caution. *Wall Street Journal,* p. B4.

Appendixes

A. Visual Aids in Business Communication

B. Grammar, Punctuation, and Style

C. Business Communication and Legal Issues

Appendix A

Visual Aids in Business Communication

I. Graphics for Quantitative and Other Data
   A. Equipment
   B. Graphics Packages for Visual Aids

II. Sample Graphics for Quantitative and Other Data
   A. Outline Charts
   B. Tables
   C. Bar Graphs
   D. Pie Charts
   E. Line Graphs
   F. Area Graphs
   G. Pictograms
   H. Other Visual Aids

III. Checklist for Effective Visual Presentations

Visuals are a graphic representation of abstractions of reality, or symbols, as seen in words and figures. This comment suggests that visuals are applicable to both written and oral communication. Hence, this appendix is applicable to both.

To help improve the readability of your reports—or the illustrations you use in conjunction with an oral presentation—good communicators increasingly use more visuals. A steadfast charge given one of your authors by the chairperson of a board of directors was this: "We want consistency in all visuals brought to the board; we want the same consistency in the written reports that accompany those presentations." In brief, they wanted visuals of similar format, even color.

Modern graphic packages for use on computers make creating visuals relatively simple, and easily amendable. It is uncomplicated to create handouts, 35mm slides, overheads, enlargements for flip charts, insertions in reports, desktop presentations, in color or in traditional black and white. Consequently, the following discussion is dominated by visuals, created on computers, under three headings: graphics for quantitative and other data, sample graphics for quantitative and other data, and a checklist for effective visuals.

GRAPHICS FOR QUANTITATIVE AND OTHER DATA

Equipment

It is not our task to recommend software packages for constructing graphic aids (also called *visual aids,* or *illustrations*) or any particular computer to drive that software. Some of the popular packages include *Harvard Graphics, Microsoft Powerpoint,* Claris *McPaint,* or a host of other options. Each system has its own variables for graphic display. Only your budget and current equipment are hindrances in selecting the equipment and software you desire. Additionally, we recommend the periodical *The Office;* it can keep you up to date on all the office equipment capable of handling the latest microcomputer graphic packages.

Communication Probe

Throughout this book, whether for written or oral communication, up-front preparation is mandatory—especially for visuals with oral presentations. Rehearsals with visuals are a must. A high-tech multimedia presentation may work well in your home office, but on the road inevitable glitches can occur. Foremost, says one author, discuss in advance with your client, prospect, or contact your needed equipment, plus the local technical support persons who will work with and for you.

Stella, P. (1995, June). The road to presentational hell: Tips for traveling presenters. *Presentations, 9,* 10–11.

Graphics Packages for Visual Aids

Get used to learning new jargon when you open the books associated with graphic packages. In *MacPaint* you will use such tools as *rectangle* (selects a rectangular portion of a picture), *lasso* (selects irregular shapes in a picture), *grabber* (permits scrolling within a picture), *paint bucket* (fills in patterns), *spray can* (applies spots of paint or continuously paints a pattern), *paintbrush* (determines the paint strokes within a current paint pattern), and numerous other variations.

A representative sample of what software packages can do to enhance your presentations is seen in the following list of *MacPaint's* options:

- Draw straight lines and round circles and create precise shapes and intricate patterns.
- Add patterns to your pictures by "painting" with several sizes and shapes of brushes.
- Select any part of a picture and move, duplicate, rotate, flip, stretch, shrink, or invert it.
- Add text to a picture in a variety of fonts, font sizes, and font styles.
- Move in for close-up views of a picture—as if you had a magnifying glass—so you can do detail work.
- Enjoy the freedom to experiment, try new effects, undo what you do not like, create several versions of an idea, combine images from several different sources, and finally, put your work on paper.
- Create or edit pictures that you can "paste" into documents created with word processing or page-layout programs.
- Open up to nine documents at a time.
- Zoom in to magnify a picture 200, 400, or 800 percent.
- Draw ovals, circles, rectangles, and rounded rectangles from the center outward or from corner to corner.
- Take a snapshop of a picture, permitting later changes to that snapshot.

Communication Probe

One writer suggests that even the background color to one's visual is integral to the message. Single-color backgrounds do little to hold audience's attention. A main suggestion is to use gradient color. People's eyes are attracted to areas of highest contrast where foreground and background colors are high in contrast. Even the visual texture of a background should be considered, implying that one should wish to touch the surface of the visual. Moreover, western visuals read from left to right, or up and down. Adding the additional visual element of three dimensions further enhances attention of the reader or listener.

Meilach, D. (1955, June). Putting a new slant on visuals. *Training, 32,* 108; Cagle, K. (1995, June). Get in the mood with creative visuals. *Presentations, 9,* 56–60.

SAMPLE GRAPHICS FOR QUANTITATIVE AND OTHER DATA

Following are illustrations and brief explanations of the popular graphic forms that can enhance your written and oral presentations; each is capable of being created using a graphics package for your computer.

Outline Charts

Variously called *presentation outline,* or *speaker's notes,* or *outline of main points,* this format is perhaps the easiest to complete. Some packages suggest you begin with the title, then the body text, and then the conclusion. (See Figures A.1 and A.2.)

Some strengths and weaknesses are the following.

Strengths	Weaknesses
Readers, listeners can see outline of major points	Little deviation, little shifting from prepared outline
Writers, speakers must be highly organized in advance	Does not allow for up-to-date data or information
Authors can use regular outline format of Roman numerals, capitals, numbers	Too brief, incomplete; reader/listener must be present to follow ideas
Creators can use bullets or other visuals to separate ideas	Has a hint of the formal Too many lines of prose can be dull, uninteresting

Tables

In order of simplicity, tables follow outline formats. A table is a numbered list; here quantitative information or words, or a combination of the two, are pre-

Managing Cultural Diversity in a Multinational Company

I. Power Distance
- **A.** Extent to which group accepts power distribution
- **B.** Various cultures vary in acceptance of power distance

II. Uncertainty Avoidance
- **A.** The lack of tolerance for ambiguity and uncertainty
- **B.** Various cultures vary in acceptance of uncertainty avoidance. . .

Based on Hofstede, G. (1994, January). Management Scientists are human. *Management Science, 40,* 4.

Figure A.1 Portion of outline chart.

Public Policies to Decrease Greenhouse Effect

I. Definition of Greenhouse Effect
- **A.** What is the greenhouse effect?
- **B.** What actions taken to decrease greenhouse effect?

II. Three Kinds of Public Policies
- **A.** Traffic policies
  - **1.** Japan
  - **2.** Germany
- **B.** Energy policies
  - **1.** Use of solar batteries
  - **2.** Cost of solar batteries
- **C.** Waste disposal policies

III. Conclusions and Recommendations

Figure A.2 Outline chart to three levels.

sented in rows and columns. Titles of the rows (horizontal lines) are usually called *stubs,* and the titles of the columns (vertical lines, sometimes called *variables*), are *captions.* (See Figure A.3.) Some strengths and weaknesses of tables are:

Strengths	Weaknesses
Permit precise figures to be used	Do not visually show differences in data
Make complete decimal detail possible	May be too detailed; with too many items, values may distract reader
Allow numeric data to be combined with nonnumeric information	Are more useful in written than in oral presentations
Allow reader to return for in-depth review	May be visually dull

Bar Graphs

Bar graphs, or bar charts, are among the most common and adaptable type of graphic presentations. Basically, you create individual cells that create columns (vertical, y axis) and rows (horizontal, x axis) of comparative data. Frequently the columns represent units of measure such as dollars, number of units, or population. The x axis generally explains the data classification or unit or dates being used. Four kinds of bar graphs are illustrated in the following figures, but we look first at a comparison of the strengths and weaknesses of bar graphs in general.

Acquired and Insured Properties

Captions

Stubs: Mortgagor's net effective monthly income	1996 Properties acquired (%)	1996 Total insured (%)	1997 Properties acquired (%)	1997 Total insured (%)
Less than $300	2.7	2.4	1.3	1.8
$300 to 399	25.8	19.2	23.7	16.9
400 to 499	33.3	28.8	34.5	21.9
500 to 599	20.5	21.8	21.4	25.3
600 to 699	10.5	13.5	10.8	16.2
700 to 799	2.5	7.4	4.3	9.4
800 to 899	3.7	3.6	2.0	4.5
900 to 999	0.2	1.5	1.5	1.9
1,000 to 1,999	0.4	1.2	0.5	1.4
2,000 or more	0.4	0.6	--	0.7
Total	**100.0**	**100.0**	**100.0**	**100.0**

Table 3 percentages of properties acquired and insured, 1996 and 1997

Figure A.3 Illustration of a numbered table.

Strengths

- Comparisons or trends easily shown
- Main titles and subtitles for data easily added
- Oral presentations possible, if simple in form
- Color and cross-hatching add to visual appeal

Weaknesses

- Inclusion of too much detail may require lettering too small to read
- Precise distinctions between variables harder to see
- Not all headings consistent between graphs on x and y axes
- Visual impact may overwhelm content

Vertical Bar Graphs. When a time factor is considered, vertical bars are especially useful (see Figure A.4).

Stacked Vertical Bar Graphs. When two or more items or parts of a subject are being compared for the same year, a stacked vertical bar graph is helpful. Each item on a bar has different color or cross-hatching (Figure A.5).

Three-Dimensional, Stacked, Vertical Bar Graphs. With a software package for a microcomputer, labeling of variables and alteration of legends can be easily done. In fact, *Cricket Graph, MacDraw II, MacPaint,* and others permit

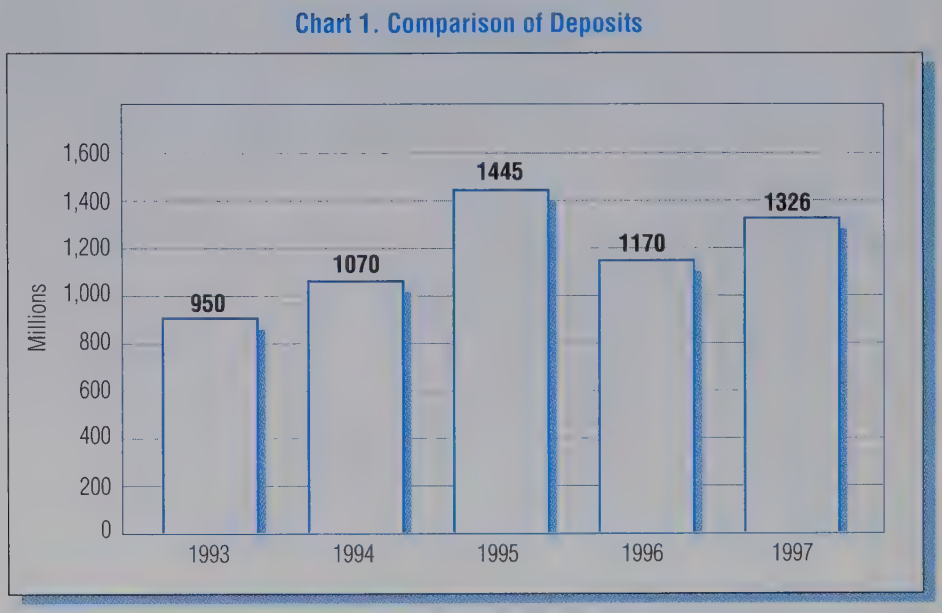

Figure A.4 A vertical bar graph.

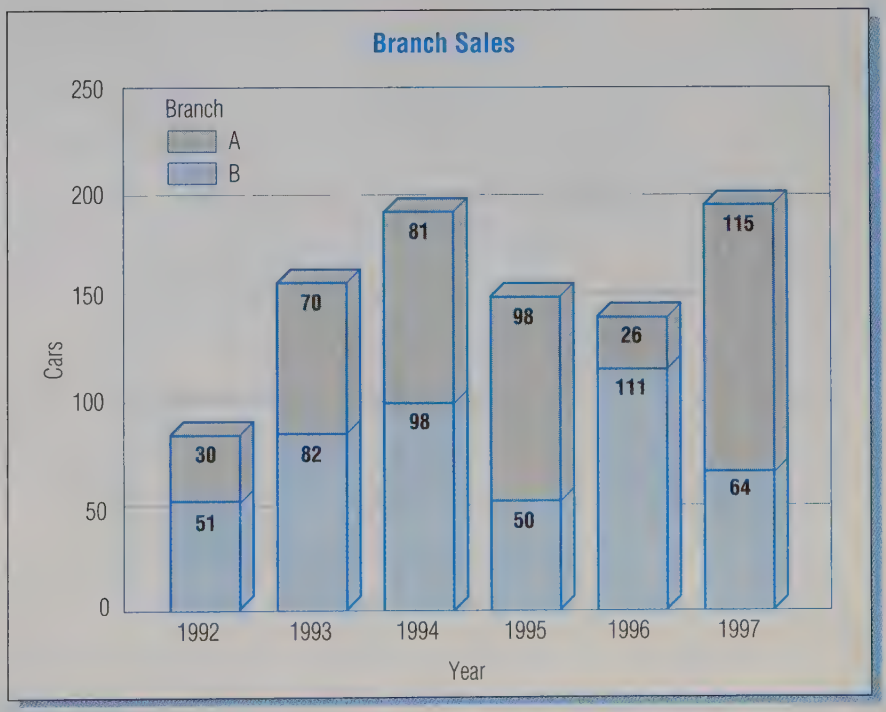

Figure A.5 A stacked vertical bar graph.

numerous variations to be added to the basic bar or column graph, including changing text, font, size, style, and orientation. Additionally, a graph can be redrawn in a three-dimensional stacked appearance, illustrated in Figure A.6. Adding depth further enhances the visual appearance of the bar graph and, for that matter, many other visuals.

Horizontal Bar Graphs. The information presented in a vertical bar graph may also be presented horizontally. Visual variations—to hold the attention of the reader—add interest to the presentation. Figure A.7 is an example of a three-dimensional horizontal bar graph that adds a "stacked" value.

Unlimited is a good term to describe the variations possible when using horizontal bar graphs. Suppose, for example, a report focuses on comparing the number of six- and eight-cyclinder engines assembled over 7 years; you can use either the vertical version of that data (Figure A.6) or the horizontal version (Figure A.7). These are only two variations; many other options are also available. For example, for a different business, Figure A.8 illustrates a simple horizontal multiple bar graph comparing percent of associations that issue plastic cards for six different uses during two years. Notice that the categories (uses) are at the left, percentages are across the bottom of the bars, and the years are identified in the key. The *Wall Street Journal* frequently uses this format.

Pie Charts

When you wish to show relative sizes of various categories and the percent that each category adds to the whole, pie charts are the most popular and helpful. To make a comparison of facts easier, the pie segments (pieces) may be shown with percentages—all placed *consistently* either within a slice or outside but near it, as in Figure A.9.

Strengths and weaknesses of pie charts are as follows:

Strengths	Weaknesses
Segment of pie may be lifted out for visual emphasis	Precise distinctions are not as visible when decimal distinctions are needed
Parts of a whole may be shown	Use of too many parts and values may blur distinctions
Values, headings, legends may be placed below, inside, or aside data	Distortions may occur if similar patterns are next to each other
Both oral and written presentations can use pie charts	

As with bar graphs, you can "explode" or "drag out" a piece of the pie, thereby emphasizing that category. You can also add a three-dimensional variation, as seen in Figure A.9.

Typically, the legend contains the major category names for the pieces in the pie; preferably there should not be more than six. The names may be listed in a key, or inside each slice if space allows, or outside the pie near the percentages. The third method is shown in Figure A.9.

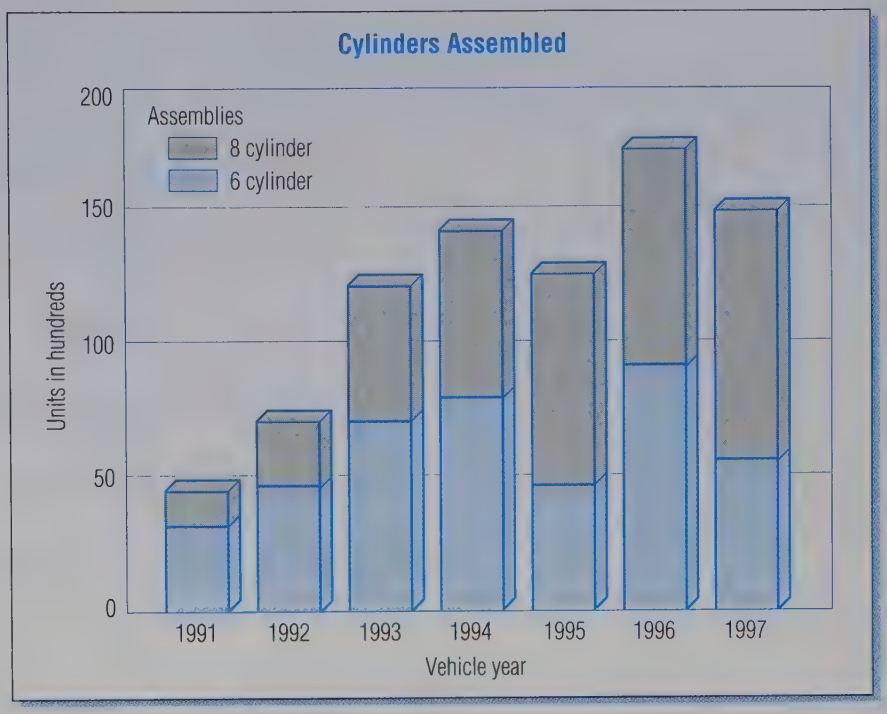

Figure A.6 Three-dimensional stacked vertical bar graph.

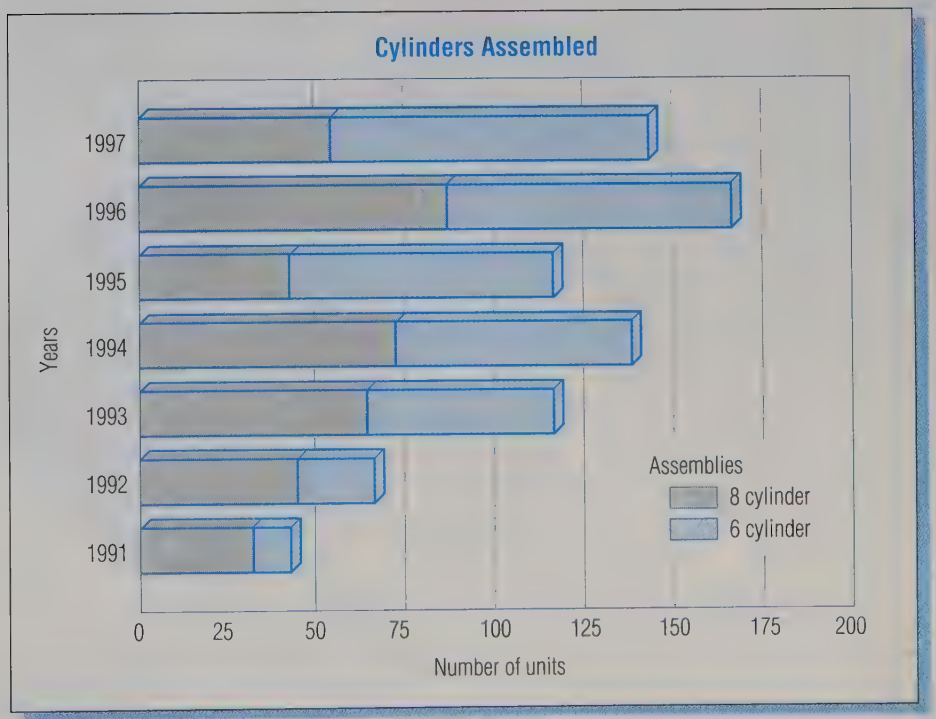

Figure A.7 Three-dimensional stacked horizontal bar graph.

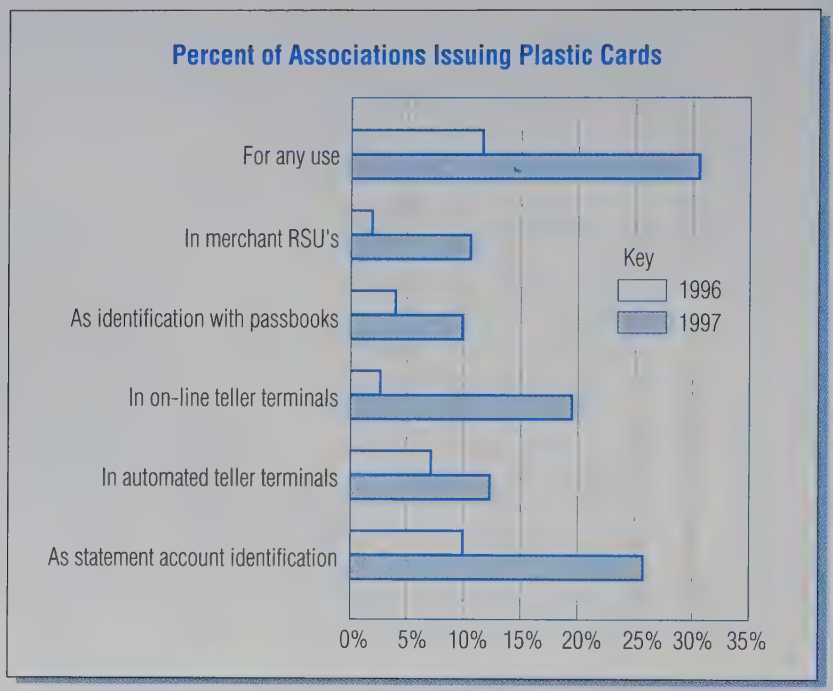

Figure A.8 A horizontal multiple-bar graph.

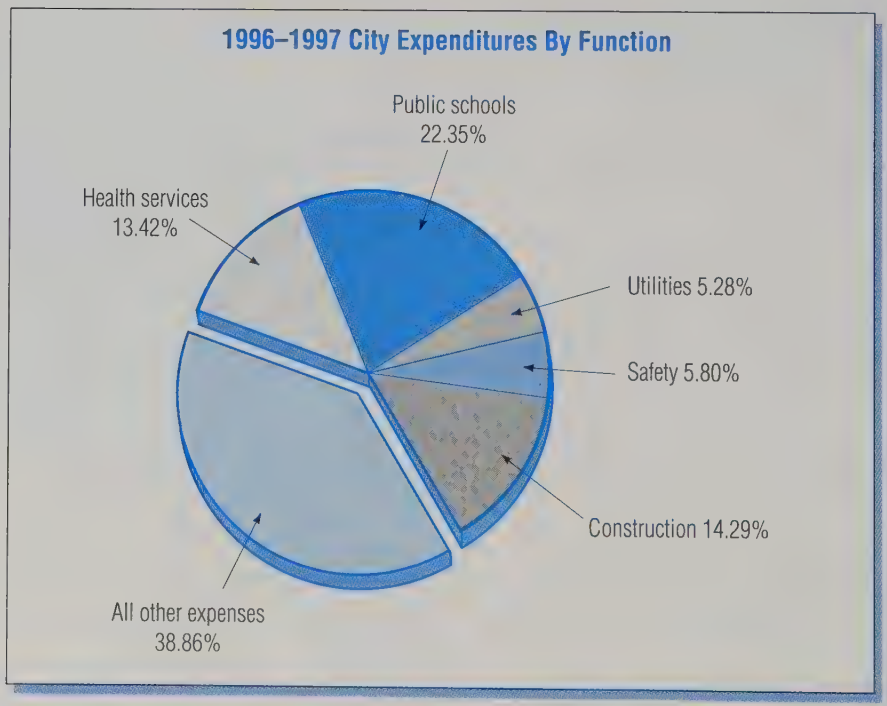

Figure A.9 Three-dimensional pie chart with exploded section, total of a whole, or 100%.

Line Graphs

Indicating trends over time is a central purpose for the line graph. So too is the wish to compare the distribution of one variable with another, over time. As in our preceding discussions, the line graph may be constructed using a computer software package or drawn with the aid of a drawing board. Several types of graphs involving lines, to indicate changes over time, are available in various software packages: Line and area graphs are some of the most common. Line graphs have the following strengths and weaknesses:

Strengths	Weaknesses
Trends over time, for several variables, permit comparisons	Too many variables and too many dates clutter information
Tick marks indicate increments between values	Fine, precise distinctions are difficult to determine
Symbols on lines aid clarity	Inconsistency for heading on x and y axes may confuse the reader, viewer

In a line graph the time increments are usually along the bottom, or x axis, and the magnitudes are along the side, or y axis. Some software packages, for instance, *Cricket Graph*, accept only figures along the y axis.

One feature of a line graph is that the various date points along the lines may each be marked with a small circle or square, and with figures that show totals, as in Figure A.10.

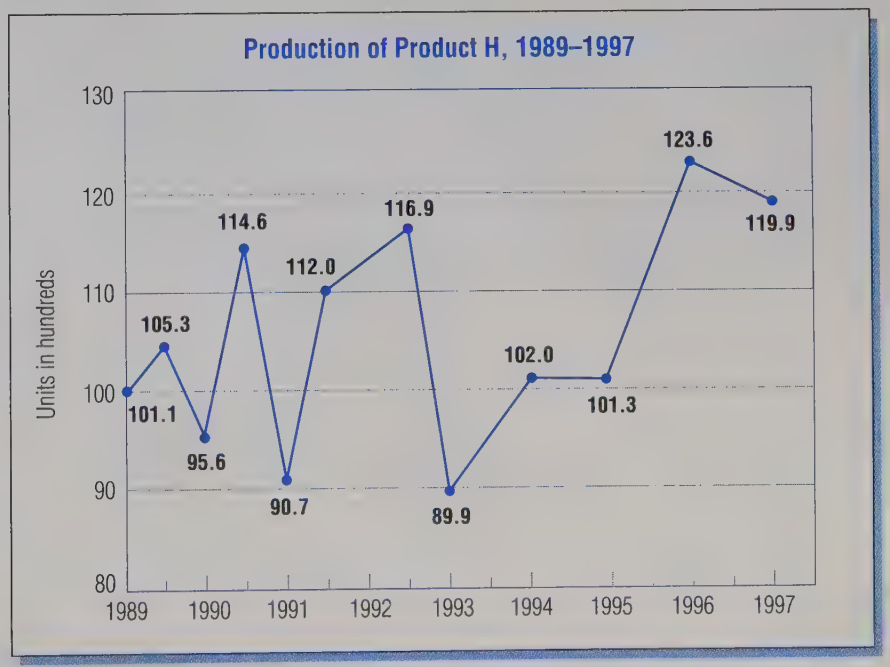

Figure A.10 A single-line graph with marked peaks and valleys.

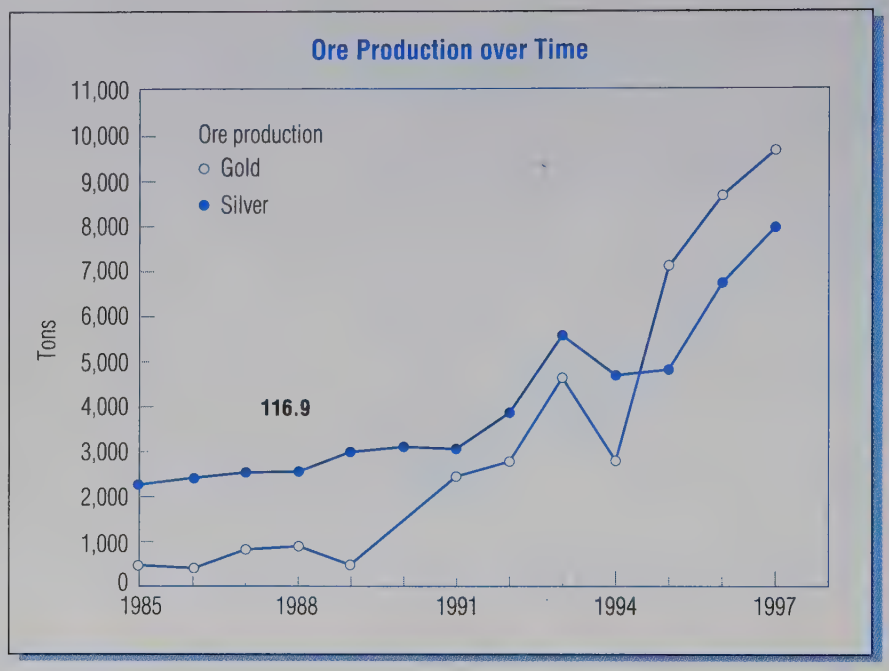

Figure A.11 Line graph with two variables.

In Figure A.11 the line graph compares two categories. To distinguish them from each other, one has small squares; the other, circles. Some graphs may use a different color for each line.

Area Graphs

You will see that there is a high similarity between a line graph and an area graph. The major difference in an area graph is that the space or area under the line is filled in. When additional categories are entered the graph shows, through colors, hues, and other variations, the differences between the categories. Figure A.12 illustrates how such a graph might look with two variables. It is easily constructed with a graphic software package. Area graphs have the following strengths and weaknesses:

Strengths	Weaknesses
Simple, one-variable changes in volume emphasis aid clarity	Small changes in data may be concealed
Multiple sets of data, in different configurations, can be instantly visible	Dramatic shifts in data are not handled well

Pictograms

Data may also be presented in the form of small pictures (pictograms, or icons). They may be arranged in various ways. When used on vertical or horizontal bar

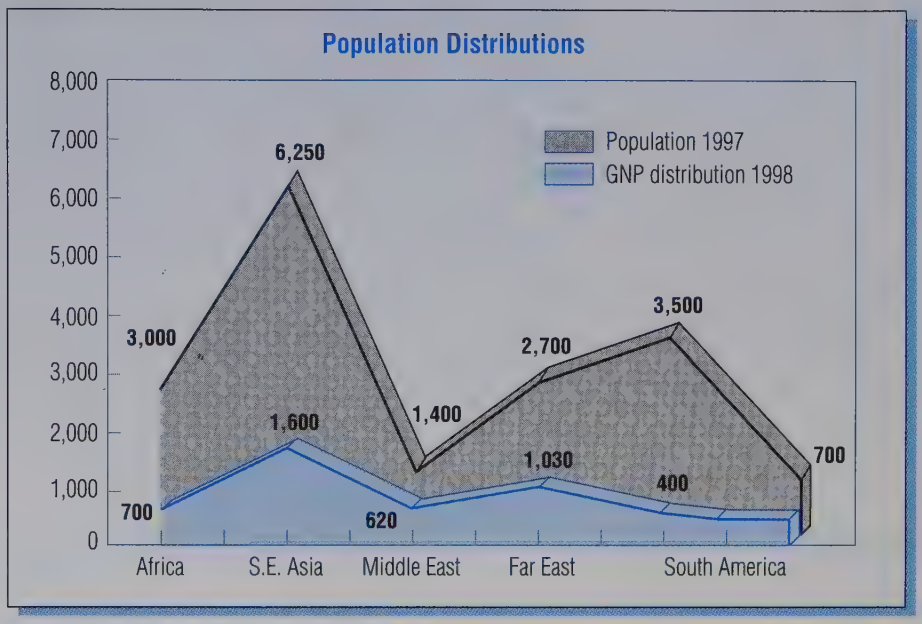

Figure A.12 Area graph.

graphs, the small pictures—instead of lines—can form the bar rectangles. Depending on your subject matter, these miniature pictures may be created from scratch on a drafting table, taken from a bank of software designs, or formed freehand on a computer. While formal business reports may not make extensive use of pictograms, reports to the general public in annual reports to stockholders, company advertising booklets, and desktop publishing may include numerous inventive pictograms such as people, houses, and cars:

All the preceding visual aids may be created on software programs on microcomputers, or if you have the patience, by using drafting materials. Slides and overhead transparencies of any of the preceding visuals can also be rapidly produced.

Other Visual Aids

A wide variety of additional visual aids can be used to help enliven the appearance of a report or an oral presentation. Among them are maps, cutaway drawings (like those showing parts of a machine), organizational charts, flowcharts, polar graphs, scattergrams, photographs, and various design sketches.

Maps help reveal geographic facts and comparisons. They can show locations of natural resources—as in Figure A.13—or company offices, transportation routes, environmental or weather patterns, quantities of products sold in certain areas, and various other data. To mark locations of pertinent data, you can use small squares, triangles, crosses, circles, cross-hatching, colors, designs,

Communication Probe

Full-scale presentations, both written and oral, are the norm for informative or persuasive presentations in the business world. Research suggests that not enough effort is given to the visual delivery of the message. One criterion for a good visual is consistency—noted in our later visual presentation checklist—along with the following summary suggestions: choose a consistent format, invest in slide production software, give thought to a graphic artist, make use of the corporate logo, use larger fonts, blend text in with graphics, employ photographs to hold attention, take slides with you, position projector carefully, give effort to all advance logistics, and use a versatile background—or template—that could be used in future presentations.

Martin, L. (1995, Spring). The fate of business often comes down to the quality of the presentation. *Public Relations Quarterly, 40,* 44–47; O'Meara, F. (1995, May). The trouble with transparencies. *Training, 32,* 36–41.l

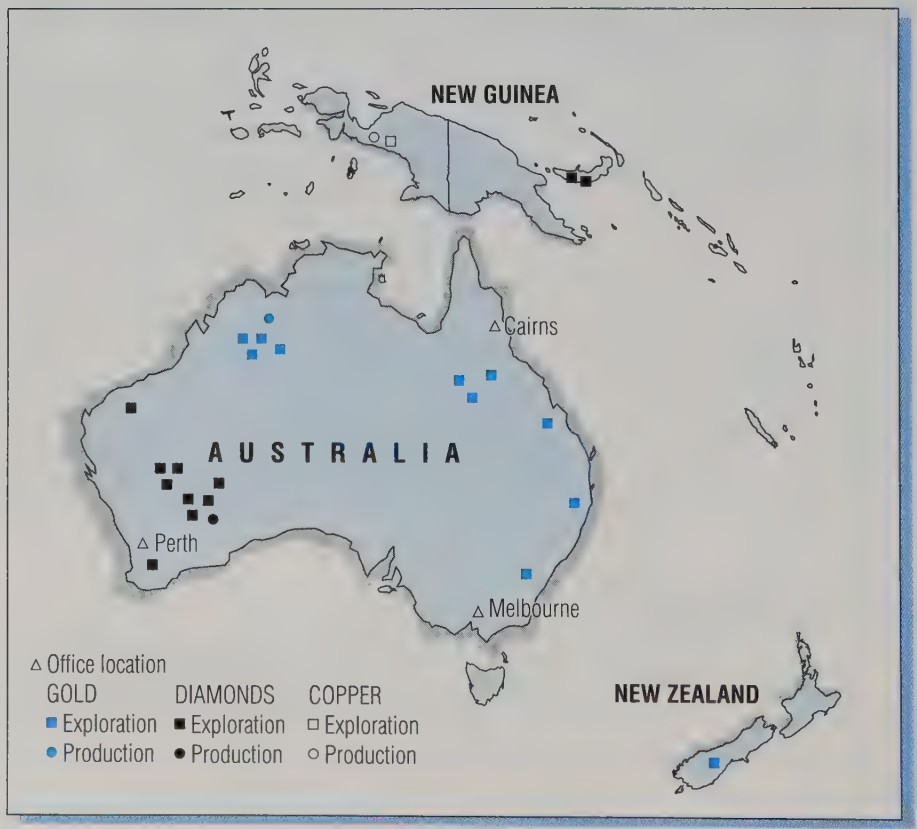

Figure A.13 A map showing locations of gold, diamond, and copper resources.

numbers, sketches, or small pictures. Gold mining companies, for example, find these maps useful.

Drawings of maps can be easily made into transparencies or pages in reports. If you work in a highly technical industry, software packages permit drawings of machines and processes, thus helping to clarify an idea or process.

CHECKLIST FOR EFFECTIVE VISUAL PRESENTATIONS

Throughout this appendix we included many suggestions for improving visual aids, including pragmatic citations in the three Communication Probes. Literally hundreds of additional sources can be cited. It is extremely important, however, that you become familiar with the software book accompanying your graphic package. For the most part, many of the comments there parallel the suggestions summarized in Checklist A.1.

Checklist A.1 Guidelines for Effective Visuals

1. *Placement.* When completing a written report, put the visual as close to the paragraph in which the subject is discussed. In like manner, introduce the visual at the related thought in an oral presentation.
2. *Introduction and interpretation.* Introducing the visual is usually brief, unless you wish to build a little suspense by withholding the visual for another page or later in your speech.
3. *Simplicity.* Avoid more than eight lines on an outline chart, six to eight categories in a bar chart and pie chart, and three to four lines on a line graph. Limit the use of terms and titles within the visual.
4. *Emphasis.* Graphic packages allow an unlimited variety of visual techniques; use them sparingly, but with planned effect. Select consistency in colors, scales, patterns, and titles or logos for all your visuals.
5. *Humor.* Clip art also enhances visuals. Select with reference to the formality or informality of the reader/listener. Creative merging of content and the visual will help hold the attention of the reader or audience.
6. *Expression of figures.* Round off figures. Percentages as values is a common way of noting differences in variations.
7. *Graphic choices.* Outlines give prose overviews; bar charts compare two or more variables; pie charts often view a single category broken down into various parts, often totaling 100%; line graphs show changes over time.
8. *Size.* Visuals should be large enough to be read anywhere in the room.

Appendix B

Grammar, Punctuation, and Style

I. Grammar
- A. Dangling Modifiers
- B. Coherence
- C. Parallel Structure

II. Punctuation
- A. Period
- B. Comma
- C. Semicolon
- D. Colon
- E. Dash
- F. Hyphen
- G. Exclamation Mark
- H. Question Mark
- I. Quotation Marks
- J. Ellipsis
- K. Apostrophe
- L. Slash

III. Style
- A. Abbreviations
- B. Numbers as Numerals or Words
- C. Word Choice

Appendix B focuses on a few of the common types of mechanical mistakes and areas in which care must be taken to maintain appropriate business communications. Grammatical issues include dangling modifiers, document coherence, and parallel structure. Punctuation is also covered as well as style details, such as abbreviations, numbers, and word choice.

GRAMMAR

Questions of grammar include items to do with the structure of sentences and clauses. The Seven C's of Effective Communication in Chapter 2 deals with specific grammatical constructions and recommended usage for business documents.

Dangling Modifiers

Any modifier, which is a word that qualifies in some way another word in the sentence, must clearly relate to the word it modifies. A modifier that is separated from the word it relates to is called a *dangling modifier.* Modifiers can dangle at the beginning of the sentence, within the sentence as a subordinate clause in which some elements are not expressed, or at the end of the sentence. Note the following examples.

At the beginning of a sentence:

Unclear: Expecting an important E-mail message, my computer stayed on all afternoon.

Clear: Expecting an important E-mail message, I checked my mail often during the afternoon.

Explanation: The first example suggests that the computer was expecting the message. Changing the subject of the main clause to "I" removes the dangling modifier.

Unclear: Upset by the team's performance, the arena began to empty.

Clear: Upset by the team's performance, the fans began to leave the arena.

Explanation: The first example suggests the arena was upset by the team's performance. Changing the subject of the main clause to "the fans" corrects the error.

Within the sentence:

Unclear: When only five, my mother taught me how to read.

Clear: When I was only five, my mother taught me how to read.

Explanation: The missing words in the first example (a dangling elliptical clause) make the sentence confusing. The simplest way to correct a dangling elliptical clause is to supply the missing words.

At the end of a sentence:

Unclear: Every member of the project team worked conscientiously, thus producing a project overwhelmingly approved of by the board of directors.

Clear: Because every member of the project team worked conscientiously, we produced a project overwhelmingly approved of by the board of directors.

Explanation: A modifier following the main clause should refer to a definite noun or noun phrase, not to the general idea expressed by the clause.

Coherence

Certain words and phrases help tie sentences together and help make the document coherent. The following chart provides categories and examples of these connecting words and phrases:

Category	Examples
Addition (and)	Also, furthermore, in addition, additionally
Contrast, concession, dismissal, replacement (but)	However, nevertheless, in contrast, conversely, on the other hand, though, even so, still/yet, in spite of, despite, regardless of this, in any case
Reason (for)	For this reason, because of, in view of, with this in mind
Result, effect (so)	Therefore, thus, as a result, consequently, as a consequence, in consequence, hence, accordingly
Consequence	Then, if so, if not, in that case, in that event, under these circumstances, otherwise
Illustration	For example, for instance, namely, in particular, for one thing, as an illustration
Similarity	Similarly, likewise, in the same way, by the same token

Clarification, identification	In other words, to put it another way, specifically, namely, that is to say
Sequence	First, first of all, at first, firstly, to begin with, second, secondly, next, then, subsequently, afterward, later, meanwhile, to conclude, finally, eventually, at last, lastly, in the end, last but not least
Summation	In conclusion, in sum, to summarize, in short, briefly, to be brief, in a word
Review	As was previously mentioned/stated/pointed out, as I have said
Generalization	In general, overall, on the whole, all in all
Changing the subject	By the way, incidentally, to change the subject
Returning to the subject	Anyway, at any rate, to return to the point

Parallel Structure

Parallel structure is the use of the same grammatical form or structure for equal ideas in a list or comparison. The balance of equal elements in a sentence helps show the relationship between ideas. Often the equal elements repeat words or sounds.

Parallel The instructor carefully explained how to start the engine and how to shift gears.

Not parallel The instructor carefully explained how to start the engine and shifting gears.

Parallel Joseph liked reading, writing, and driving his car.

Not parallel Joseph liked reading, writing, and to drive his car.

The following structures call for parallelism:

both . . . and . . . Both *by the way she dressed* and *by her casual attitude,* it was clear that she was a relaxed person.

either . . . or . . .
neither . . . nor . . .
not only . . . but also . . .
whether . . . or . . .

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According to most linguists, the words in the above chart are more related to cohesion than to *coherence.* Cohesion refers to the actual links in the text between one word or phrase and another. Coherence, on the other hand, is the quality that makes a text comprehensible and includes issues of semantics and the overall worldview of the communicators. If you have clear lexical and grammatical links in your written document, it is generally coherent, but not always. To illustrate the larger issues involved in coherence, consider this example:

> *I'm wearing a green hat. In addition, "hats off" means to salute a person or thing. However, things aren't always as they seem. But you have things to do.*

Even though the above statements have grammatically correct linking words, the passage makes no sense. Something else is needed for coherence. Sometimes a message is coherent even without overt linking words, as in the following example:

> *Two-minute warning. The quarterback races the ball down the field. Twenty-five yards to go. Field goal? Offense lines up. No! Touchdown! The crowd roars approval.*

The second passage, choppy though it is, makes perfect sense to those who know American football. Keep in mind that coherence is more complex than simply using connective words.

Enkvist, N. E. (1990). Seven problems in the study of coherence and interpretability. In *Coherence in writing: Research and pedagogical perspectives* (pp. 11–15). Connor, U., & John, A. (eds.). Alexandria, VA: Teachers of English to Speakers of Other Languages.

PUNCTUATION

A change in punctuation can change the meaning of a sentence. The following punctuation forms are reviewed: period, comma, semicolon, colon, dash, hyphen, exclamation mark, question mark, quotation marks, ellipsis, and apostrophe.

Period

Periods signal the end point of a statement. Periods were formerly called "stops" to signal the end of the idea expressed. Many Asians call a period a "full stop." Use a period in the following cases:

1. To end a complete sentence.

```
The company operates several divisions through-
out the world.
```

2. To indicate abbreviations. (However, omit the period after acronyms for organizations or government agencies and some companies.)

   Dr., Mr., Ms., a.m., p.m., H. M. Murphy, NATO, AT&T

3. For decimal signs and after tabulated numbers.

   15.2%, $45.75, 1. 2. 3. (only one space after the period in listed numbers)

Comma

Use a comma in the following situations:

1. To separate items in a series.

   The police chief said the explosion could have been caused by defective wiring, misplaced chemicals, a careless match, or spontaneous combustion.

   When the last item in a series is connected by a coordinating conjunction (and, or, but, not, for, yet, so), the comma can be omitted before that conjunction if the meaning is clear without it. In this book we are consistent: We use a comma after the last conjunction in a series of three or more.

2. To separate two independent clauses connected by a coordinating conjunction, as long as these clauses don't contain much internal punctuation.

   Five divisions of XYZ Corporation were sold yesterday, and rumor has it that more will be on the block soon.

   An independent clause can stand alone as a complete sentence. A sentence with two or more verbs that serve the same subject (compound predicate) does not need a comma because it is part of the same clause.

   Jon Simms performed an audit of XYZ Corporation and reported that everything looked in order.

   If both independent clauses are short, you can sometimes drop the comma.

3. To set off long introductory clauses and phrases and some shorter clauses and phrases that would be confusing without the comma.

   Just as Cheryl Davis entered the building, the fire alarm went off.
   Each day, many people visit the Eiffel Tower.
   To Dick Johnson, Addison Ford is a mentor.

4. To set off nonrestrictive (nonessential) clauses, phrases, and modifiers from the rest of the sentence.

   a. *Restrictive (essential).* These clauses and phrases are integral to the meaning of the sentence and must not be set off.

   ```
   An elderly couple who sought refuge in a small
   shed died when the tornado slammed into the
   building.
   ```

   (The subordinate clause "who sought . . ." limits the meaning of the sentence.)

   b. *Nonrestrictive (nonessential).* These clauses and phrases do need commas because they are nonessential, or incidental, to the sentence.

   ```
   Claudio Venturini, who won the gold medal for
   downhill skiing at the 1994 Olympics, recently
   toured several U.S. ski resorts.
   ```

5. To separate descriptive modifiers of equal rank.

   When a noun is preceded by several adjectives, if you can use the adjectives interchangeably and can insert the conjunction *and* between them, they are coordinate and require a comma.

   ```
   Metereologists predicted another cold, dreary
   Michigan winter.
   ```

   But no comma is appropriate in:

   ```
   Meteorologists predicted another cold Michigan
   winter.
   ```

6. To set off parenthetical expressions or when you address the reader directly.

   ```
   At the last meeting, you may recall, we decided
   to implement the new plan.
   Please let me know, Ms. Hardy, when you will be
   arriving.
   ```

7. In dates and places.

   ```
   On September 16, 199-, John Harris started to
   work for XYZ corporation.
   Chicago, Illinois, is called the Windy City.
   ```

8. To set off participial phrases that modify some part of the independent clause.

   ```
   Having seen the article in question, I knew what
   you were referring to.
   The Senate adjourned today, having passed a num-
   ber of controversial bills.
   ```

9. When two verbs come together; when two numbers come together.

   ```
   Whatever will be, will be.
   ```

In 1997, 200 people from the company will be eligible for retirement.

10. When a sentence contains a quotation.

"Mr. Jonas," he said, "has been chosen department manager."

11. When the absence of a comma would cause confusion or misreading.

Ever since, we have looked forward to visiting your country.

12. To separate two independent clauses that are not joined by a coordinating conjunction. Violating this rule results in a run-on sentence or comma splice as in:

Inflation rates stayed steady employment rates rose.

Do not use a comma in the following situations:

- *To introduce a subordinate clause.* Using a comma before *because* is one of the biggest offenders. The conjunction *because* introduces a dependent clause. It is not a coordinating conjunction and does not join clauses of equal rank.

The mayor decided to visit the plant site because she needed to speak to the company management.

- *To separate a noun or pronoun from its reflexive.* A reflexive is any one of the "self" pronouns used to accent the noun or pronoun preceding it.

The CEO himself gave the opening address.

- *To precede a partial quotation.*

The candidate for Congress charged that the incumbent was "not listening to her constituency."

Semicolon

More formal than the comma, the semicolon is a half comma, half period. It has three main uses:

1. To join independent clauses not connected by a coordinating conjunction.

Howard launched a shot from the field goal area for a three-point play; it brushed the backboard and fell through the net just as the buzzer sounded.

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In early books printed in England, the only punctuation marks found are the slash (/), the colon (:), and the period, called a full stop (.). By the mid-sixteenth century, the comma began to replace the slash. Additional punctuation marks appeared as written English developed as a system rather than as a mere representation of spoken English. The colon changed from representing a pause of medium length to a mark of announcement. Semicolons developed to fill the gap left by the original colons.

Question marks and exclamation points did not become common until the seventeenth century. Apostrophes were originally phonetic, marking the omission of a sound. Only later did they become markers for the possessive case. The latter usage became obligatory by the eighteenth century.

Gorlach, M. (1991). *Introduction to Early Modern English* (pp. 58–60). Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Note: Words such as *however, moreover, nevertheless,* and *therefore* are conjunctive adverbs, not coordinating conjunctions. When one of them separates two independent clauses, a semicolon is required.

```
This budget is tentative; however, I believe
that it should be accepted immediately.
```

2. To separate internally punctuated independent clauses joined by a coordinating conjunction.

```
The group, known as the Environmental Caretak-
ers, visited three toxic waste sites; but they
were not able to gather the evidence they
wanted.
```

3. To set off parts of a series that also contain commas.

```
Attending the conference were Aaron Smithson,
professor of corporate strategy at the Univer-
sity of Utah; Janet Jones, consultant for GOE
Industries; and Marjorie Jesson, professor of
communication at the University of Michigan.
```

Colon

Colons announce. They may announce complete sentences, lists, quotations or dialogue. They are used in the following situations:

1. To introduce a lengthy quotation, list, or table after such words as *the following, as follows, as these, this.*

```
Several things were found in the victim's purse:
a comb, wallet, pen, checkbook, and credit
cards.
```

2. To separate hours and minutes.

```
5:30 a.m.          3:15 p.m.
```

3. To introduce quotations longer than one sentence and to end paragraphs that introduce quotations in the next paragraph.

```
Here is the text of Congressman Evans' speech:
"Good evening, my fellow Americans . . ."
```

4. After the salutation in U.S. business letters. Numerous foreign writers, particularly in Asia, use a comma after an individual's name.

```
Dear Ms. Addison:
Dear Mr. Son, (Asia and other parts of the
world)
```

Dash

Dashes emphasize a word or phrase within the sentence or set off a series within the sentence.

1. To emphasize.

```
Congress today voted in a bill to decrease gov-
ernment spending-a bill with dramatic conse-
quences for many programs.
```

2. To set off a series within the sentence.

```
Several people-Jon Smithson, Sue Beacon, and
Fred Tipple, among others-have asked to go on
the trip.
```

Hyphen

The dash sets words apart; the hyphen brings them together. Use the hyphen in the following ways:

1. To join compound modifiers that precede a noun unless the modifier is preceded by *very* or an *-ly* adverb.

```
a good-natured person
a slowly moving object (not slowly-moving ob-
ject)
```

2. For certain prefix and suffix words. Prefixes that usually take a hyphen include *all-*, *ex-*, *non-*, and *pro.* There are exceptions; check a dictionary or stylebook to be sure.

```
extra-attentive, ex-president, re-cover (cover
again)
```

3. In numbers 21 through 99 when spelled out.

```
sixty-six, eighty-seven, one hundred seventy-
five
```

4. To break a word at the end of a line.

```
sub-                    con-
  stantial                sideration
```

Exclamation Mark

To indicate strong emotion, use an exclamation mark.

```
How terrible! What a problem!
```

Question Mark

Use to:

1. Ask a direct question.

   ```
   Have you researched the problem?
   ```

2. Show doubt.

   ```
   In 199- (?), the company sold two divisions.
   ```

Quotation Marks

Use them in the following situations:

1. Around a direct quotation.
2. Around unusual, substandard, or inexact terms.
3. Around titles of magazines articles and book chapters (but not titles of magazines, books, and pamphlets).
4. Around words to be set off.

   ```
   The "please" in a request serves to . . .
   ```

Punctuation within quotation marks should follow these guidelines:

- All periods and commas go inside the quotation marks.
- Semicolons and colons go outside the quotation marks.
- Question marks, exclamation marks, and dashes
  1. go outside the quotes when they punctuate the entire sentence.
  2. go inside the quotes when they punctuate only the quoted matter.

Ellipsis

Use the ellipsis mark (. . .) to alert the reader that something has been removed from the quoted material, that the speaker has hesitated, or that there is more material than is cited.

```
"There are many good sports, such as racquetball,
swimming, jogging, . . . that help your cardiovas-
cular system.
```

Apostrophe

Three main uses for the apostrophe:

1. To show possession.

   ```
   woman's, man's, Kevin's, someone else's
   ```

2. To show omission of a letter or number.

   ```
   We'll, don't, can't, o'clock, it's, earthquake
   of '95
   ```

3. To show plurals of numbers, letters, or words used as words.

   ```
   How many 10's do you have?
   Watch your p's and q's.
   You have used too many "the's" in this paper.
   ```

Slash

Also known as virgule or slant line, the slash is often used to separate words or to show omission. Along with the period, the slash is the oldest of punctuation marks, historically indicating a short stop (/) or a longer stop (//). The period indicated a full stop. The slash is used more often in informal writing than in formal. Three main uses for the slash today are the following:

1. To separate words.

   ```
   Ms. Jennifer Tyler/2256 Rosemary Ct./Nashville,
   TN
   ```

2. To show omission.

   ```
   c/o for "in care of"
   days/week for "days per week"
   ```

3. To indicate numbers.

   ```
   3/4 indicating fractions
   10/2/99 indicating dates (informal)
   ```

STYLE

Several chapters in this book include suggestions on style, especially the chapter that covers the seven C's (Chapter 2). This section reviews additional style questions, including abbreviations, numbers as figures or words, and word choice.

Abbreviations

In business letters and reports, abbreviations are appropriate for the following:

1. *Titles:* Mr., Mrs., Ms., Dr., Messrs. (as for a law firm of Messrs. Berry, Moorman, King, & Hudson).
2. *Descriptors:* Jr., Sr., Mt. (Mount), St. (Saint), Inc., Ltd., D.C. (District of Columbia, NW (Northwest).
3. *Professional degrees:* B.B.A., Ph.D., M.D., C.P.A.

The following words should usually be spelled out: *president, superintendent, honorable, reverend, professor, building, association, department.* City names should be spelled out. A good rule is "When in doubt, spell it out." The U.S. Postal Service has its own rules for abbreviations. The following chart shows the recommended abbreviations for states and for other words used in addresses.

Standard State Abbreviations

AL..... Alabama	KY..... Kentucky	OH .... Ohio
AK..... Alaska	LA..... Louisiana	OK..... Oklahoma
AZ..... Arizona	ME .... Maine	OR..... Oregon
AR..... Arkansas	MD.... Maryland	PA ..... Pennsylvania
CA..... Californa	MA .... Massachusetts	PR ..... Puerto Rico
CO..... Colorado	MI..... Michigan	RI..... Rhode Island
CT..... Connecticut	MN .... Minnesota	SC ..... South Carolina
DE..... Delaware	MS..... Mississippi	SD..... South Dakota
DC..... District of Columbia	MO .... Missouri	TN..... Tennessee
	MT .... Montana	TX..... Texas
FL..... Florida	NE..... Nebraska	UT..... Utah
GA..... Georgia	NV..... Nevada	VT ..... Vermont
HI ..... Hawaii	NH .... New Hampshire	VA ..... Virginia
ID ..... Idaho	NJ ..... New Jersey	WA..... Washington
IL..... Illinois	NM .... New Mexico	WV .... West Virginia
IN ..... Indiana	NY..... New York	WI..... Wisconsin
IA..... Iowa	NC..... North Carolina	WY..... Wyoming
KA..... Kansas	ND .... North Dakota	

General Abbreviations

Apt..... Apartment	Ln..... Lane	Rm..... Room
Ave..... Avenue	N..... North	S. ..... South
Cir..... Circle	Pl..... Place	Ste. .... Suite
Dr..... Drive	Rd..... Road	W..... West
E..... East		

Numbers as Numerals or Words

In general, use the numeral instead of the word because it's easier to understand, especially for those whose first language is not English. In letters and reports,

use the rule of 10: spell out numbers 1 to 9; use numerals for numbers 10 or higher) except for amounts of money and for certain situations as the following:

1. If a sentence begins with a number, express the number in words. If the number standing first in the sentence is followed by another number, express both in words.

   Seventy or seventy-five should be enough.

2. When a sentence contains one series of numbers, express all units of the series in numerals unless they are all below 10.

   Last month, we entertained 15 applicants from Michigan, 25 from New York, and 8 from California.

3. When a sentence contains two series of numbers, express one series in words and the other in numerals. Following this rule will avoid confusion because of too many sets of numbers.

   Four members received $100 each, nine received $25, and twenty got $10.

4. When one number immediately precedes another number of different context, express one in words and the other in numerals.

   I wish to place an order for fifteen 4-inch paintbrushes.

5. When a numerical quantity contains more than three digits, each group of three digits should be set off by a comma, starting at the right. This rule does not apply to dates, street numbers, serial numbers, or page numbers.

   3,400,627 50,000 200,000

6. Express amounts of money in numerals. When the money is dollars and cents, always express the amount in numerals. The dollar sign precedes the amount, unless in a tabulated column.

   Your total cost is only $395.95.

   If the amount is only in dollars, you can omit the double zero unless you are listing amounts in a column that includes both dollars and cents.

   I owe you $125.

   If the amount is only in cents, you can use any of the following:

   $.25 25¢ 25 cents

7. Express the following numbers in numerals unless otherwise indicated:

   a. Dates January 10, 1998

   b. House or room numbers, except number one: 13112 White Street

c. Numerical names of streets *(over 10):* East 73rd Street

(under 10): 324 Fifth Street

d. Numbered items such as pages, chapters, tables, charts, telephone numbers:

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e. Decimals: 4.25 5.75

f. Dimensions and age: 15' X 23' 25 years old

g. Time: 6 a.m. or six in the morning or six o'clock

h. Percentage: 40% 25% or six percent

i. Fractions: 1/3 4/5 or three-fifths

Word Choice

Trends in business writing continue to move in the direction of less rather than more formal word choices and sentence constructions. Formerly, you might see many legal words and phrases; however, even the language of the law has simplified to some extent. The following phrases are not currently used in the most effective business messages, and when used, create a stilted tone:

attached please find
enclosed please find
party (when you mean person)
we transmit herewith
assuring you of our prompt attention, we remain
in reply I wish to state
attached hereto
kindly (when you mean *please)*
please be advised that
this writer (when referring to yourself)

Although many textbooks give lists of words considered "incorrect," most of the words chosen have a long history of usage. Language changes continually, and English itself has a rich word hoard that can be used with pleasure to create meaning. There are, however, a few pairs of words that are sometimes confusing. A quick reference to some of these follows:

accept	*approve, receive*
except	*exclude, make exception to*
advice	*guidance (noun)*
advise	*to counsel (verb)*

affect	*to influence (verb)*
effect	*result (usually a noun)*
eminent	*distinguished*
imminent	*about to happen*
lay	*to set down a thing*
lie	*to recline (yourself)*
precede	*to go ahead of*
proceed	*to go forward*
principal	*main*
principle	*truth, tenet*
stationary	*in a fixed position*
stationery	*writing paper*

Communication Probe

Many textbook writers disapprove of certain words for business purposes, even though the words in question are used by many people. One such word is *prioritize,* which means "to give priority to" or "to establish priorities." It's first use was by T. H. White in his 1972 book *The Making of the President.* University of Michigan English langauge expert Richard W. Bailey calls it "A word that at present sits uneasily in the language." However, many business people use it often and effectively.

Another word often questioned is *input* used as a verb. Language purists accept this word as a noun but not as a verb. However, *input,* meaning "to put in" has been used since the sixteenth century; its present sense "to feed in data" has been in the language since the mid-1940s. Since language is continually developing and changing, it's probably more productive to think of words as choices rather than constraints.

Simpson, J. A., & Weiner, E. S. C. (eds.). (1989). *Oxford English dictionary* (2d ed.) Oxford: Clarendon Press.

Appendix C

Business Communication and Legal Issues

I. Defamation
   A. Publication
   B. Privilege
   C. Defamatory Terms

II. Invasion of Privacy
   A. An Employee's Personal Disabilities
   B. An Employee's Personal Identity and Private Facts
   C. An Employee's Records, Reports, Letters, and Electronic Data

III. Misrepresentation and Fraud
   A. Innocent Misrepresentation
   B. Fraudulent Misrepresentation
   C. Sales Warranties
   D. Frauds

IV. Laws Regarding Employment, Credit, and Collections
   A. Employment—and Preemployment Inquiries
   B. Credit and Collections

V. Other Areas of Caution in Business Communication
   A. Copyrights
   B. Computer Data Security

Business communication is affected by terms emanating from both federal and state courts of law; each term is both a warning flag and a potential communication issue: E-mail privacy, hackers, electronic monitoring, copyrights, discrimination, Civil Rights Act, disability testing, reasonable accommodation, fraud, libel, falsehoods, warranties, defamation, access, and a host of others. In short, simply sending a letter, a memorandum, a fax, or an Internet message, or making a cellular phone call demands your vigilance. Because of our litigious society, we must be more careful than ever to avoid being taken to court.

Up front we make this assertion: No single appendix or chapter is able to review the thousands of situations covering the legal interpretations applied to business communication. Our central goal is to heighten your awareness of the risks and complications in communicating information (making information public) that may be considered private. Ignorance of the law excuses no one. Thus, for specific questions you should consult an attorney in your organization. Our statement here is introductory only; no guarantee is made for its completeness.

This chapter focuses on several areas of concern affecting both your communication within and outside an organization:

Defamation
Invasion of privacy
Misrepresentation and fraud
Laws regarding employment, credit, and collections
Other areas of caution in business communication

DEFAMATION

There exists a patchwork of opinions and interpretations as to the boundaries of defamation. Simply stated, defamation is a communication made public that

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U.S. companies—as they grow—consistently hire in-house attorneys to complete the necessary legal work. This appendix is thus limited to legal views applicable to the United States. And, those in-house attorneys are governed by the same ethical and disciplinary rules applicable to other attorneys. However, companies with increased globalization or people working with some European companies, for instance, will find that European Community (EC) attorneys operate under a different set of guidelines. In Europe, attorneys are not members of the bar, and attorney-client privileges do not exist. A caution: In dealing with EC attorneys, be alert to differences that could impact communication between the U.S. and EC companies.

Hill, A. (1995, Winter). A problem of privilege: In-house counsel and the attorney-client privilege in the United States and the European Community. *Case Western Reserve Journal of International Law, 2,* 7145–194.

tends to be false or harmful to an individual's character, reputation, or fame. Oral defamation is *slander.* Written defamation is *libel.* Quite often a company "defames" an individual by making public to another organization a job applicant's background and references. Four suggestions are in order:

- Establish a company policy for handling information regarding both present and former employees.
- Resist making public any information unless it is required by public policy.
- Keep a "paper trail," a record of released information.
- Avoid making any subjective statements in the released material.

Note that a key element in defamation is making certain information public. That statement leads to understanding two legal terms: *publication* and *privilege.* We discuss these two terms and conclude this section noting some defamatory terms.

Publication

To "publish" defamatory material about a person is to make public that information to a third party. Any means of communication (fax, letter, memo, circular, picture, newspaper, radio, television, E-mail, and others) by which a third party learns of alleged defamatory material makes that material public.

A private one-to-one discussion wherein you tell an employee that he is incompetent, lazy, disorganized, unreliable is within your rights. Only you and the other person have heard those statements. But as soon as you make that information available to another person or to others who are not "privileged" (defined later), you risk serious consequences. Note that the derogatory qualities that make a statement defamatory are the same for both libel (written) and slander (oral). However, because the libel statement is more permanent, different levels of proof are required.

Be careful even in sending a sealed letter wherein you accuse the recipient. Should the letter be read by a third person (a secretary for instance), you may be liable for "publishing" defamatory material. Some suggestions:

- Seal the envelope.
- Mark the envelope personal and confidential.
- Wrap the enclosed message with opaque material to further screen the material from possible readers.

The preceding suggestions also apply to unfavorable information about a person or organization and collection messages about past-due payments.

Accidental communications to third-party persons (unauthorized readers, eavesdroppers, casual room attendants) are not actionable unless you knew or should have foreseen such possibilities. Conversely, most authorities consider dictating defamatory material to a secretary a form of publication.

Communication Probe

A study sought to determine the willingness of businesses to respond to requests for information about previous employees. That is, the underlying assumption was that failure to control responses could increase the number of suits alleging defamation of character. Conclusions from the study suggested that smaller firms—fewer than 100 employees—generally did not employ human resource managers to oversee responses to outside requests for preemployment information. In contrast, firms with over 100 employees often had human resource managers to monitor and oversee released former employee information. A major suggestion was this: Appoint one person to handle all employee references; this person would be aware of the potential defamation allegations.

Fenton, J. W., Jr., & Lawrimore, K. W. (1992, October). Employment reference checking, firm size, and defamation liability. *Journal of Small Business Management, 30*(4), 88–95.

Privilege

There are times when defamatory information may be made public.

Absolute Privilege

Absolute privilege is possible in three circumstances: judicial proceedings, legislative proceedings, and the actions of important government officials.

Courts of law are places where defamatory statements may be made. Thus juries, attorneys, witnesses, and other participants in judicial or quasi-judicial proceedings are *absolutely privileged* to make defamatory statements, either orally or in writing. However, if you—as a potential member of a legal investigation—make public accusatory or defamatory statements outside the judicial proceedings, you are liable for those statements.

Similarly, government officials are *absolutely privileged* to make defamatory statements in the performance of their duties.

Finally, newspapers—or for that matter employee newsletters—continually run the risk of being accused of libel statements concerning public persons. But a Supreme Court decision in 1964 concerning the *New York Times*—pertaining to public persons—lessened the risk of liability for criticism. Under the *Times* ruling, public officials cannot recover libel damages unless actual malice is proved. Criticism or comment about the public conduct or fitness for office of public officials and statements about the public conduct of other voluntary public officials are privileged. A significant caveat is this: Even erroneous material—unless there was actual knowledge of falsity or reckless disregard as to whether the material was true or false—is considered privileged.

Communication Probe

Overt intent to defame another person is difficult to prove. And as courts consider the concept of "libel by impression," there is a court tendency not to award damages to persons who feel that a conscious attempt was made to defame them. Thus, a plaintiff must prove that even judges and police officers intended to libel them—again, a difficult task to achieve. And in the process of reporting there is also the possibility of hyperbole, exaggerating via language certain things about a person or a group. Here too courts have resisted awards to individuals who feel they were defamed. Additionally, inadvertent disclosure, via electronic means, appears to be increasing exponentially. The caution is obvious: Handle confidential information with care.

Joffe, M., & Rice, E., Jr. (1995, July). Oops! Can I take that back? *Defense Counsel Journal, 62,* 450–452; Stein, M. L. (1992, November). Rhetorical hyperbole is OK; defamation is not. *Editor and Publisher, 125*(46), 37; McDonald, M. P. (1991, June). "We never intended to suggest . . .": the press, the courts, and libel by impression. *Communications and the Law, 13*(2), 17–42.

Conditional (Qualified) Privilege

Fear of lawsuits should not hamper communicating in good faith. Thus, at times within business when the writer may have *conditional privileges* during business communications. Defamatory statements made in ordinary commercial activity are *qualifiedly privileged,* whether those statements are made within the company or without—as long as the recipient has a lawful interest in the topic of discussion.

Of the business situations allowing *conditional privileged* communication, two actions should be foremost in your mind: responding to requests for information concerning a former or current employee and requesting recommendations from others.

Responding to Requests for Information. You as a manager and others outside an organization most likely will be asked to write a recommendation letter. Within the business world you may also be asked about the credit record of a customer. *Avoid malice or deceit;* this is the strongest admonition we can give.

Thus, whenever you reply to an inquirer (potential employer, credit reference, or the U.S. government, for instance, who might suffer a loss if an unworthy applicant is employed), reply in good faith, tell the truth, and include no malice. If you carelessly or intentionally mislead the inquirer who seeks information about another person, you could be sued for damages. Your reply should not mislead the recipient into hiring or lending to an unworthy applicant. Conversely, you should not maliciously prevent a worthy applicant from being considered fairly for employment or credit. Several suggestions:

- Appoint one individual to respond to all requests for information concerning individuals within your company.
- Demand that reference requests be submitted in writing.
- Accept, if possible, a release from the former employee absolving the company from future liability.
- Double-check that all statements about former employees are true and precise.

Avoid the belief that all conversations concerning former employees are "off the record."

Requesting Recommendations. On numerous evaluation forms given to professors or other references, students and others have the opportunity to check a box indicating that they desire to not see the recommendation. Additionally, the requester often promises to hold the response in confidence. Thus, more safeguards are being put in place to protect the reference writer. And as is more and more the case, phone calls to former employers and other references are occurring to replace the written response.

What the preceding paragraph suggests is that when you request information from another person about a former student or employee, be clear in showing that you will protect the received information and keep it confidential. Bear in mind that more and more employees are filing defamation claims against current or former employers, particularly in the following areas:

- Publication of unfavorable evaluations
- Publication of disciplinary action
- Publication of unfavorable references
- Publication of reasons for termination

Communication Probe

Consistently the courts have held that disseminating truthful and accurate information to those with a legitimate interest in knowing it is valid. While that principle refers to reference letters, it also applies to exposing credit information. Federal antitrust laws do not discriminate against exchanging historical credit information concerning a person, with a legitimate third party. In short, and as noted in the prose section of this chapter, disseminating accurate and truthful credit information is recognized by law. On the other hand, disseminating false information or disseminating such credit information to persons with no legitimate interest in knowing it can be the basis for malice, in which case the privilege to communicate defamatory information is lost.

Panaro, G. (1993, November–December). Avoiding business credit reporting pitfalls. *Business Credit*, 95(10), 38–39.

Remember one suggestion we made earlier: Have one person check the comments made in a reference letter—probably a member of the human resources department. Likewise, this same office could be solely responsible for asking others to send the company a reference letter about a current employee or an outside candidate for an open position.

Defamatory Terms

Before reading the following list of terms judged libelous, jot down a few terms you feel are objectionable to you. Then compare your list with the one that follows. Of course the following sample is just that: an incomplete series of words that should be either avoided or used with caution when referring to a person or organization.

adultery
agnostic
alcoholic
altered records
atheist
bad moral character
bankrupt
blackmailer
cheats
communist
corrupt
crook
deadbeat
dishonest
disreputable
drug addict
faker
falsified
forger
fraud (fraudulent)
gay
gouged money
grafter
hypocrite
illegitimate
incompetent
inferior
infidel
informer
insolvent
intolerance
Jekyll-Hyde personality
kept woman
kickbacks
lovemate
mental illness
misappropriation
misconduct
misrepresention
perjurer
plagiarist
price cutter
profiteer
quack
racketeer
rascal
scandalmonger
sharp dealing
shyster
simpleton
slacker
sneak
subversive
swindler
thief
unchaste
unethical
unmarried mother
unprofessional
unreliable
unworthy of credit
villain
worthless

Entirely unacceptable are words that suggest an individual has

- An undesirable disease
- A conviction for committing a crime, or words falsely charging arrest, or an indictment for or confession of a crime
- An anti-Semitic attitude or other prejudices based on race, creed, color, or sexual orientation
- A tendency to lie
- A life of squalor or poverty
- An unwillingness or refusal to pay a debt or evasion of payment of a debt

Truth is usually a defense in a libel suit in which there is no conditional privilege, especially if there is no evidence of malice. Traditionally, legal malice has meant spite, ill will, or a desire to do harm for harm's sake. A quotation from a

Supreme Court decision of Alabama, 1989, captures its desire of what the plaintiff must establish:

> "Plaintiff must prove to your satisfaction from the evidence the following things: . . . that the employee of the [*name of company*] who made the defamatory statement knew at the time said statement was made that it was false and that it was defamatory."
>
> Supreme Court of Alabama, 1989 Ala.; June 16, 1989.

INVASION OF PRIVACY

Each worker has the expectation that one's personal work area is free from invasion by others. When there is an unconsented, unprivileged, or unreasonable intrusion into the private life of an individual, it is called *invasion of privacy.* Note that in this definition, privacy can be violated although no publication to a third party occurs. In fact, the concept of privacy is analogous to that of trespass, which gives one the right to keep unwarranted intruders off one's land.

This section discusses an employee's personal disabilities, personal identity and private facts, and personal records, reports, letters, and electronic data.

An Employee's Personal Disabilities

With the increase in drug use, companies are uncomfortable in acting under the guidelines of the Americans with Disbilities Act. Many sections of that act have yet to be clarified. Thus, some employees object to drug tests because they allege that such a test is an invasion of their privacy. Court cases suggest (*Third Circuit US Court of Appeals in Borse v. Piece Goods Shop*) that the plaintiff must prove that the tests or searches are highly offensive to the reasonable person.

In the case above, the court relied on the legal precedent that drug testing could constitute an invasion of privacy in two ways: If the methods of use fail to give due regard to the privacy of the employee and if the results disclose private facts of an employee, such as an illness.

Anytime you as an employee must deal with private health matters, you must keep that information private, measuring the health issues against the job requirements. Opinions and decisions on this complex health issue are undergoing change; we suggest that any communications in this area be reviewed by your company's human resource department, in addition to keeping up with decisions in the *Employee Relations Law Journal.*

An Employee's Personal Identity and Private Facts

You cannot use a person's name, photograph, or other identification for commercial benefit without permission. Awards have been given for publishing x rays, medical pictures, or even records of delinquent debt.

Furthermore, the personal information customers give when applying for credit (insurance, medical care, jobs) should be kept confidential. Unfortunately,

Communication Probe

Shrill have been the cries against employers who leniently interpret privacy laws. Indeed, as electronic communication increases and as demands for more investigation of the health of employees increases, states have devoted much time to those issues. California, for instance, insists that the company establish a compelling reason for testing of any sort; however, a recent decision by the California Supreme Court in *Hill v. the National Collegiate Athletic Association* (1994) was a watershed decision that lowered the legal protection afforded to the right of privacy; here the court held that the plaintiff has the burden of proof to establish three things:

- A legally protected privacy interest
- A reasonable expectation of privacy
- A serious invasion of privacy

Such a decision shifts to the defendant the burden of establishing a competing interest to justify the privacy intrusion.

Meyers, J. F. (1994, Summer). *Hill v. NCAA:* California adopts a new standard for invasion of privacy. *Employee Relations Law Journal, 20*(1), 73–84.

in some cases the customer's permission has not been obtained; lawsuits have resulted. Keep credit application material confidential.

An Employee's Records, Reports, Letters, and Electronic Data

An employee's right to privacy will be violated if private records, reports, letters, and, more recently, electronic mail are read by persons not entitled to examine them.

Two recent court decisions add emphasis to the above statement:

"(The historical judgment which the Fourth Amendment accepts, is that unreviewed executive discretion may yield too readily to pressures to obtain incriminating evidence and overlook potential invasions of privacy and protected speech.) Petitioners would have been forced to articulate their exact reasons for the search and to specify the items in Dr. [*name*] office they sought, which would have prevented the general rummaging through the doctor's office, desk, and file cabinets."

Supreme Court of the United States, 480 U.S. 709; 107 S. Ct 1492; 1987 U.S.; 94 L. Ed.2d 714; 55 U.S. L. W. 4405; 42 Empl. Prac. Dec. (CCH), P36,891; 1 BNA IER CAS 1617, March 31, 1987.

"However, the federal courts have not yet recognized such a 'principle,' and we fear the potential effect . . . on the long accepted, and vitally important, axiom that the sender of a letter retains an expectation of *privacy* protected by the fourth amendment in the contents of the letter after it is sent."

United States Court of Appeals for the Eighth Circuit, 853 F. 2d 1479; 1988 U.S. App.; August 12, 1988.

Communication Probe

Results of a recent survey concerning eavesdropping in over 300 businesses:

- One out of five companies eavesdrops on its employees.
- Seventy percent use some form of electronic eavesdropping.

In other words, as the electronic world proliferates in business, the question of employee privacy will be tested even more. In question, say the researchers, is the legal minefield of disciplinary action as a result of determining an employee's sexual orientation, marital status, or social life. In short, they feel that regulations for legitimate monitoring and illegal snooping must be more clearly established. Invasion of privacy issues demand that both the employer and the employee be alert to this fast-changing area of internal communication.

Webster, G. (1995, May). Internal-communication issues. *Association Management, 47,* 150–153; Jacobs, D. L. (1994, February). The perils of policing employees. *Small Business Reports, 19*(2), 22–26.

Yet to be finalized are the rights of the employee regarding privacy of personal electronic mail. Those guidelines are still being formed, but indications suggest that one's E-mail is also considered an issue of privacy.

MISREPRESENTATION AND FRAUD

Innocent Misrepresentation

Innocent representation is a "communication not in accordance with the facts, but which the communicator thought or merely assumed to be true." To be legally significant the misrepresentation must be relied upon by the person to whom it is made.

Fraudulent Misrepresentation

A *fraudulent misrepresentation (or fraud)* occurs when the communicator knows the representation is not true and the person to whom it was made relies on it to his or her disadvantge.

Sales Warranties

In most *sales contracts,* the seller undertakes certain obligations concerning the nature, title, and quality of the goods or services being sold. When these obligations are expressly stated or implied and when they actually induce the sale, the obligations are called *warranties.* Warranties are of two types.

Express Warranties

Express warranties are created by a seller's specific statements about a product: its characteristics, or its performance, which affect the buyer's decision to buy. (Some consumer surveys suggest that only 10 percent of consumers say a warranty has a bearing on their decision to buy.) Regardless, to achieve a sale the seller may include a description, grade labeling, use a sample or model, or include statements or pictures in advertisements. Such a promise becomes the basis for a contract even though the term *warranty* or *guarantee* is not used. Be careful in your communication: The buyer can sue a company or you to recover damages for certain kinds of injuries arising out of the express warranty.

Implied Warranties

Implied warranties of the Uniform Commercial Code (UCC) apply only to the sale of goods; it means the warranties are part of the bargain even though the parties themselves say nothing about them. Consumers have four years from the time the good or services were delivered to take legal action, if they feel a contract has been breached. In cases where a service has been provided, the claimant must show negligence.

Frauds

Fraud occurs when one party acts on the basis of a material presentation and consequently suffers as a result of that representation. Be aware of these communication possibilities:

- A deceitful silence
- A desire to actively conceal
- A misrepresentation via a third party
- A misrepresentation of intentions

An organization called the National Fraud Information Center (NFIC) receives hundreds of calls daily from victims of phone, voice mail, or mail fraud. So too does the U.S. Postmaster General. Avoid involving yourself in schemes with fake contests, false charity appeals, missing-heir schemes, false business opportunities, worthless medical cures, and others.

Computer fraud is also on the increase via computer hackers who have managed to infiltrate private databases. Often the approach is this: One or more persons devise a deceptive scheme, the deceptive scheme injures another, and there is direct intention to defraud.

The following sample quotations from court cases illustrate judicial use of the terms misrepresentation and fraud:

> "The investor/plaintiffs allege the FDIC acquired their notes with actual knowledge of the fraudulent misrepresentations and omissions and without good faith. Specifically, the investor/plaintiffs allege the FDIC had full knowledge of the financial con-

dition of the bank and of the material misstatements made to the plaintiffs by FPD officers and employees."

United States District Court for the Eastern District of Louisiana, 661F. Supp. 163; 1987 U.S. Dist.: February 27, 1987.

"The sales contract, which was negotiated in the United States, England, and Germany, signed in Austria, and closed in Switzerland, contained express *warranties* by petitioner that the trademarks were unencumbered and a clause providing that 'any controversy or claim [that] shall arise out of this agreement or the breach thereof' would be referred to arbitration before the international Chamber of Commerce in Paris, France, . . ."

United States District Court for the District of New Jersey, 713 F. Supp. 737; 1989 U.S. Dist.; May 11, 1989.

LAWS REGARDING EMPLOYMENT, CREDIT, AND COLLECTIONS

Employment—and Preemployment Inquiries

Chapters 18 and 19 alluded to some of the concerns both the interviewer and interviewee must address in a job search. Here we add a few more legal issues.

Title VII of the Civil Rights Act of 1964 prohibits discrimination in employment as to hiring, firing, compensation, termination, and conditions of privileges of employment on the basis of race, color, religion, sex, or national origin. The above law forbids discrimination, not the asking of certain questions. However, some questions may be unfair or risky to ask because they may appear discriminatory and may serve as the basis for later legal action.

A representative checklist is in order. Note that the following preemployment questions in Checklist C.1 are in line with the Uniform Guidelines on Employee Selection Procedures. Some states, as well as cities and counties—even universities—may have stricter regulations regarding a few of the preemployment questions. Thus, it is advisable to check your own local and state laws or consult a member of your human resources staff.

Credit and Collections

Many federal and state laws are in place to protect the consumer. And because state statutes vary, you will need to investigate those in your state. We note just some of the more important statutes.

1. Equal Credit Opportunity Act—Requires financial institutions and others engaged in credit extension to make credit equally available to all creditworthy customers without regard to sex, marital status, race, color, religion, national origin, or age. In turn, some lenders are turning to a credit scoring system to protect themselves from lawsuit.
2. Fair Credit Billing Act—Aims to protect the consumer against inaccurate and unfair credit card practices.

Checklist C.1 Preemployment Inquiries

Subject	Fair Preemployment Inquiries	Unfair Preemployment Inquiries
Age	Inquiries as to birthdate are permitted in some states; in others, only whether applicant is of legal age.	Any inquiry that implies discrimination (without job-related justification).
Arrests (see also Convictions)	None. (Law enforcement agencies are exempt from this rule.)	All inquiries relating to arrests.
Citizenship	Whether applicant is prevented from lawfully becoming employed in this country because of visa or immigration status. Whether applicant can provide proof of citizenship, visa, or alien registration number after being hired.	Whether applicant is citizen. Requirement before hiring to present birth certificate, naturalization papers, or baptismal record. Any inquiry that would divulge lineage, ancestry, national origin, descent, or birthplace.
Convictions (see also Arrests)	Inquiries concerning specified convictions that relate reasonably to fitness to perform particular job being applied for, provided that such inquiries be limited to convictions for which date of conviction or of prison release is within seven years of job application date. All general conviction inquiries must be accompanied by a disclaimer informing the applicant that a conviction record will not necessarily bar him or her from employment.	Any inquiry that does not meet the requirements for fair preemployment inquiries.
Family	Whether applicant can meet specified work schedules or has activities, commitments, or responsibilities that may prevent meeting work attendance requirements.	Specific inquiries concerning spouse, spouse's employment or salary, children, child care arrangements, or dependents.
Handicap	Whether applicant has certain specified sensory, mental, or physical handicaps that relate reasonably to fitness to perform particular job. Whether applicant has any handicaps or health problems that may affect work performance or that employer should take into account in determining job placement.	Overly general inquiries (e.g., "Do you have any handicaps?") that would tend to divulge handicaps or health conditions that do not relate reasonably to fitness to perform the job.
Height and weight	Inquiries as to ability to perform actual job requirements. Being of a certain height or weight will not be considered to be a job requirement unless the employer can show that no employee with the ineligible height or weight could do the work.	Any inquiry that is not based on actual job requirements.
Marital status (see also Name and Family)	None.	Whether applicant is married, single, divorced, separated, engaged, widowed, etc.; whether Mr., Mrs., Miss, Ms.

Checklist C.1 Preemployment Inquiries (*Continued*)

Subject	Fair Preemployment Inquiries	Unfair Preemployment Inquiries
Military	Inquiries concerning education, training, or work experience in the armed forces of the United States.	Type of condition of military discharge. Experience in other than U.S. armed forces. Request for discharge papers.
Name	Whether applicant worked for this firm or a competitor under a different name; if so, what name. Name under which applicant is known to references if different from present name.	Inquiry into original name and whether it has been changed by court order or marriage. Inquiries about name that would divulge marital status, lineage, ancestry, national origin, or descent.
National origin	Inquiries into applicant's ability to read, write, and speak foreign languages, when such inquiries are based on job requirements.	Inquiries into applicant's lineage, ancestry, national origin, descent, birthplace, or mother tongue. National origin of parents or spouse.
Organizations	Inquiry into organization memberships, excluding any organization the name or character of which indicates race, color, creed, sex, marital status, religion, or national origin or ancestry of its members.	Requirement that applicant list all organizations, club, societies, and lodges to which he or she belongs.
Photographs	May be requested *after* hiring, for identification purposes.	Request that applicant submit photo, mandatorily or optionally, before hiring.
Pregnancy (see also Handicap)	Inquiries as to duration of stay on job or anticipated absences that are made to males and females alike.	All questions as to pregnancy, and medical history concerning pregnancy and related matters.
Race or color	None.	Any inquiry concerning race or color of skin, hair, eyes, etc.
Relatives	Names of relatives already employed by this company or by any competitor.	Name and addresses of any relative other than those listed as proper.
Religion or creed	None.	Inquiries about applicant's religious denominator or affiliations, church, pastor, parish, religious holidays.
Residence	Inquiries about address to the extent needed to facilitate contacting the applicant.	Names or relationship of persons with whom applicant resides. Whether applicant owns or rents home.
Sex	None.	Any inquiry.

3. Fair Credit Reporting Act—Demands that consumer reporting agencies (credit bureaus; investigative, detective, and collection agencies; computerized information-reporting firms; lenders' exchanges) should make a firm offer of credit to each consumer whose name appears on a final prescreening list. Additionally, the institution will only use the information to extend a credit offer. The basic intent of the law is to protect consumers from erroneous information that could ruin their credit rating.

4. Fair Debt Collection Practices Act—Addresses abuses of consumers by unethical debt collectors. The bill basically states what bill collectors (other than creditors and attorneys) can and cannot do.
5. Federal Truth in Lending Act—Concerns meaningful disclosure of interest rates so that consumers may compare more readily the charges different credit sources make. Recent widespread errors in the calculation and disclosure of interest rates under adjustable rate mortgage loans (ARMS) have increased the number of lawsuits.
6. False Claims Act—Seeks to protect the federal government from fraudulent claims.
7. Uniform Commercial Code—Set up guidelines concerning, among many other things, product specifications and untruthful statements about a product or service.

OTHER AREAS OF CAUTION IN BUSINESS COMMUNICATION

Copyrights

Electronic transmission of documents is on the rise. And with this increase everyone from publishers to document suppliers to end users is concerned with protecting private interests. Basic copyright law applies: You cannot copy copyrighted material without permission of the copyright owner. Exceptions include "fair use" privileges and single copies made for noncommercial purposes. There are strict conditions with which designated libraries must comply.

As you can see, multimedia products stress content over technology. Such content—with which you will work in business—includes text, sound, artwork, animation, photography, film clips, and other forms of copyrighted material. When in doubt, *ask for legal advice* before using copyrighted material.

Computer Data Security

Each of us is concerned about privacy—as is the organization for which you work or will work—because of the increasing dependence on electronic data storage and transmission. Can a company or can you maintain privacy over private materials? Legislative proposals are in the works to address the privacy issue. Regardless of whether another employer intrudes into your private database or not, a core question must be answered: Does an employer monitor a worker's electronic files to gather private information about the employee, or is the information gathered to improve production within the organization? There exists a fine line between what is considered private and workforce production information. Such were the concerns—in addition to national security—surrounding the Clipper Chip (embedding in all computers a chip that would allow only federal security agencies, after securing legal permission, to access certain computers). At the moment such a suggestion has been withdrawn.

Communication Probe

Workplace electronic control systems are generally used for three purposes: to measure performance, prevent internal theft, and enforce laws and workplace rules. To support those purposes, and others, the federal government enacted The Federal Electronic Communication Privacy Act of 1986 to protect all electronic communication systems from outside intruders and protect the privacy of certain messages in transmission over public service E-mail systems. A study of one company with 151 employees found that feedback sign, feedback frequency, and supervisor consideration were positively related to computer-monitoring satisfaction. Procedural fairness was central to employer satisfaction with a workplace electronic control system.

Kidwell, R. E., Jr., & Bennett, N. (1994, June). Employee reactions to electronic control systems: The role or procedural fairness. *Group & Organization Management, 19*(2), 203–218; Shannon, J. H., & Rosenthal, D. A. (1993, Winter/Spring). Electronic mail and privacy: Can the conflicts be resolved? *Business Forum, 18*(1,2), 31–34.

Surfing the electronic Internet and the cellular network is becoming serious business. Scanners already can be adapted to monitor cellular conversations, and the Internet is an ever-evolving frontier. Both these areas are protected from outside infringement, but invasions of those communication systems continue. You, as an employee, must be alert to possible intrusions into your private business communication.

Communication Probe

Long reports (Chapter 12) and proposals (Chapter 13) may include as an appendix a contract. Companies and private persons use the Internet to send contracts, along with a report, along with a signature. Inevitably this kind of electronic communication will increase, and it is being used extensively. Thus the question: What are the current legal principles governing the sending of a contract via the Internet or E-mail? Answers are not clear. What is clear is that three additional legal-communication questions must be answered: When is a deal really a deal? If a deal actually exists, when and where is it made? And which jurisdiction's laws should govern, especially when parties in different jurisdictions use third-party network services? Again, there is need for awareness when sending a contract as a form of electronic communication.

Woolford, D., & Chester, S. (1995, April). When is a deal really a deal? *International Corporate Law,* 18–22.

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